

The Vanguard Codex

The Holy Bible

Volume III

Ketuvim

Soli Deo Gloria

2026

Contents

Ruth	1
Psalms	9
Job	237
Proverbs	323
Ecclesiastes	417
Song of Songs	437
Lamentations	455
Daniel	477
Esther	511
Ezra	527
Nehemiah	551
1 Chronicles	585
2 Chronicles	657

Ruth

1

Elimelech Moves His Family to Moab



IN the days when the judges ruled in Israel, a severe famine came upon the land. So a man from Bethlehem in Judah left his home and went to live in the country of Moab, taking his wife and two sons with him. ²The man's name was Elimelech, and his wife was Naomi. Their two sons were Mahlon and Kilion. They were Ephrathites from Bethlehem in the land of Judah. And when they reached Moab, they settled there.

³Then Elimelech died, and Naomi was left with her two sons. ⁴The two sons married Moabite women. One married a woman named Orpah, and the other a woman named Ruth. But about ten years later, ⁵both Mahlon and Kilion died. This left Naomi alone, without her two sons or her husband.

Naomi and Ruth Return

⁶Then Naomi heard in Moab that the Lord had blessed his people in Judah by giving them good crops again. So Naomi and her daughters-in-law got ready to leave Moab to return to her homeland. ⁷With her two daughters-in-law she set out from the place where she had been living, and they took the road that would lead them back to Judah.

⁸But on the way, Naomi said to her two daughters-in-law, “Go back to your mothers’ homes. And may the Lord reward you for your kindness to your husbands and to me. ⁹May the Lord bless you with the security of another marriage.” Then she kissed them good-bye, and they all broke down and wept.

¹⁰“No,” they said. “We want to go with you to your people.”

¹¹But Naomi replied, “Why should you go on with me? Can I still give birth to other sons who could grow up to be your husbands?

¹²No, my daughters, return to your parents’ homes, for I am too old to marry again. And even if it were possible, and I were to get married tonight and bear sons, then what? ¹³Would you wait for them to grow up and refuse to marry someone else? No, of course not, my daughters! Things are far more bitter for me than for you, because the Lord himself has raised his fist against me.”

¹⁴And again they wept together, and Orpah kissed her mother-in-law good-bye. But Ruth clung tightly to Naomi. ¹⁵“Look,” Naomi said to her, “your sister-in-law has gone back to her people and to her gods. You should do the same.”

¹⁶But Ruth replied, “Don’t ask me to leave you and turn back. Wherever you go, I will go; wherever you live, I will live. Your people will be my people, and your God will be my God. ¹⁷Wherever you die, I will die, and there I will be buried. May the Lord punish me severely if I allow anything but death to separate us!” ¹⁸When Naomi saw that Ruth was determined to go with her, she said nothing more.

¹⁹So the two of them continued on their journey. When they came to Bethlehem, the entire town was excited by their arrival. “Is it really Naomi?” the women asked.

²⁰“Don’t call me Naomi,” she responded. “Instead, call me Mara, for the Almighty has made life very bitter for me. ²¹I went away full, but the Lord has brought me home empty. Why call me Naomi when the Lord has caused me to suffer and the Almighty has sent such tragedy upon me?”

²²So Naomi returned from Moab, accompanied by her daughter-in-law Ruth, the young Moabite woman. They arrived in Bethlehem in late spring, at the beginning of the barley harvest.

2

Ruth Works in Boaz's Field



Now there was a wealthy and influential man in Bethlehem named Boaz, who was a relative of Naomi's husband, Elimelech.

²One day Ruth the Moabite said to Naomi, "Let me go out into the harvest fields to pick up the stalks of grain left behind by anyone who is kind enough to let me do it."

Naomi replied, "All right, my daughter, go ahead." ³So Ruth went out to gather grain behind the harvesters. And as it happened, she found herself working in a field that belonged to Boaz, the relative of her father-in-law, Elimelech.

⁴While she was there, Boaz arrived from Bethlehem and greeted the harvesters. "The Lord be with you!" he said.

"The Lord bless you!" the harvesters replied.

⁵Then Boaz asked his foreman, "Who is that young woman over there? Who does she belong to?"

⁶And the foreman replied, "She is the young woman from Moab who came back with Naomi. ⁷She asked me this morning if she could gather grain behind the harvesters. She has been hard at work ever since, except for a few minutes' rest in the shelter."

⁸Boaz went over and said to Ruth, "Listen, my daughter. Stay right here with us when you gather grain; don't go to any other fields. Stay right behind the young women working in my field. ⁹See which part of the field they are harvesting, and then follow them. I have warned the young men not to treat you roughly. And when you are thirsty, help yourself to the water they have drawn from the well."

¹⁰Ruth fell at his feet and thanked him warmly. “What have I done to deserve such kindness?” she asked. “I am only a foreigner.”

¹¹“Yes, I know,” Boaz replied. “But I also know about everything you have done for your mother-in-law since the death of your husband. I have heard how you left your father and mother and your own land to live here among complete strangers. ¹²May the Lord, the God of Israel, under whose wings you have come to take refuge, reward you fully for what you have done.”

¹³“I hope I continue to please you, sir,” she replied. “You have comforted me by speaking so kindly to me, even though I am not one of your workers.”

¹⁴At mealtime Boaz called to her, “Come over here, and help yourself to some food. You can dip your bread in the sour wine.” So she sat with his harvesters, and Boaz gave her some roasted grain to eat. She ate all she wanted and still had some left over.

¹⁵When Ruth went back to work again, Boaz ordered his young men, “Let her gather grain right among the sheaves without stopping her. ¹⁶And pull out some heads of barley from the bundles and drop them on purpose for her. Let her pick them up, and don’t give her a hard time!”

¹⁷So Ruth gathered barley there all day, and when she beat out the grain that evening, it filled an entire basket. ¹⁸She carried it back into town and showed it to her mother-in-law. Ruth also gave her the roasted grain that was left over from her meal.

¹⁹“Where did you gather all this grain today?” Naomi asked. “Where did you work? May the Lord bless the one who helped you!”

So Ruth told her mother-in-law about the man in whose field she had worked. She said, “The man I worked with today is named Boaz.”

²⁰“May the Lord bless him!” Naomi told her daughter-in-law. “He is showing his kindness to us as well as to your dead husband. That man is one of our closest relatives, one of our family redeemers.”

²¹Then Ruth said, “What’s more, Boaz even told me to come back and stay with his harvesters until the entire harvest is completed.”

²²“Good!” Naomi exclaimed. “Do as he said, my daughter. Stay with his young women right through the whole harvest. You might be harassed in other fields, but you’ll be safe with him.”

²³So Ruth worked alongside the women in Boaz’s fields and gathered grain with them until the end of the barley harvest. Then she continued working with them through the wheat harvest in early summer. And all the while she lived with her mother-in-law.

3

Ruth at the Threshing Floor

NE day Naomi said to Ruth, “My daughter, it’s time that I found a permanent home for you, so that you will be provided for. ²Boaz is a close relative of ours, and he’s been very kind by letting you gather grain with his young women. Tonight he will be winnowing barley at the threshing floor. ³Now do as I tell you—take a bath and put on perfume and dress in your nicest clothes. Then go to the threshing floor, but don’t let Boaz see you until he has finished eating and drinking. ⁴Be sure to notice where he lies down; then go and uncover his feet and lie down there. He will tell you what to do.”

⁵“I will do everything you say,” Ruth replied. ⁶So she went down to the threshing floor that night and followed the instructions of her mother-in-law.

⁷After Boaz had finished eating and drinking and was in good spirits, he lay down at the far end of the pile of grain and went to sleep. Then Ruth came quietly, uncovered his feet, and lay down. ⁸Around midnight Boaz suddenly woke up and turned over. He was surprised to find a woman lying at his feet! ⁹“Who are you?” he asked.

“I am your servant Ruth,” she replied. “Spread the corner of your covering over me, for you are my family redeemer.”

¹⁰“The Lord bless you, my daughter!” Boaz exclaimed. “You are showing even more family loyalty now than you did before, for you have not gone after a younger man, whether rich or poor. ¹¹Now

don't worry about a thing, my daughter. I will do what is necessary, for everyone in town knows you are a virtuous woman. ¹²But while it's true that I am one of your family redeemers, there is another man who is more closely related to you than I am. ¹³Stay here tonight, and in the morning I will talk to him. If he is willing to redeem you, very well. Let him marry you. But if he is not willing, then as surely as the Lord lives, I will redeem you myself! Now lie down here until morning."

¹⁴So Ruth lay at Boaz's feet until the morning, but she got up before it was light enough for people to recognize each other. For Boaz had said, "No one must know that a woman was here at the threshing floor." ¹⁵Then Boaz said to her, "Bring your cloak and spread it out." He measured six scoops of barley into the cloak and placed it on her back. Then he returned to the town.

¹⁶When Ruth went back to her mother-in-law, Naomi asked, "What happened, my daughter?"

Ruth told Naomi everything Boaz had done for her, ¹⁷and she added, "He gave me these six scoops of barley and said, 'Don't go back to your mother-in-law empty-handed.'"

¹⁸Then Naomi said to her, "Just be patient, my daughter, until we hear what happens. The man won't rest until he has settled things today."

4

Boaz Marries Ruth

BOAZ went to the town gate and took a seat there. Just then the family redeemer he had mentioned came by, so Boaz called out to him, "Come over here and sit down, friend. I want to talk to you." So they sat down together. ²Then Boaz called ten leaders from the town and asked them to sit as witnesses. ³And Boaz said to the family redeemer, "You know Naomi, who came back from Moab. She is selling the land that belonged to our relative Elimelech. ⁴I thought I

should speak to you about it so that you can redeem it if you wish. If you want the land, then buy it here in the presence of these witnesses. But if you don't want it, let me know right away, because I am next in line to redeem it after you."

The man replied, "All right, I'll redeem it."

⁵Then Boaz told him, "Of course, your purchase of the land from Naomi also requires that you marry Ruth, the Moabite widow. That way she can have children who will carry on her husband's name and keep the land in the family."

⁶"Then I can't redeem it," the family redeemer replied, "because this might endanger my own estate. You redeem the land; I cannot do it."

⁷Now in those days it was the custom in Israel for anyone transferring a right of purchase to remove his sandal and hand it to the other party. This publicly validated the transaction. ⁸So the other family redeemer drew off his sandal as he said to Boaz, "You buy the land."

⁹Then Boaz said to the elders and to the crowd standing around, "You are witnesses that today I have bought from Naomi all the property of Elimelech, Kilion, and Mahlon. ¹⁰And with the land I have acquired Ruth, the Moabite widow of Mahlon, to be my wife. This way she can have a son to carry on the family name of her dead husband and to inherit the family property here in his hometown. You are all witnesses today."

¹¹Then the elders and all the people standing in the gate replied, "We are witnesses! May the Lord make this woman who is coming into your home like Rachel and Leah, from whom all the nation of Israel descended! May you prosper in Ephrathah and be famous in Bethlehem. ¹²And may the Lord give you descendants by this young woman who will be like those of our ancestor Perez, the son of Tamar and Judah."

The Descendants of Boaz

¹³So Boaz took Ruth into his home, and she became his wife. When he slept with her, the Lord enabled her to become pregnant, and she gave birth to a son. ¹⁴Then the women of the town said to Naomi, "Praise the Lord, who has now provided a redeemer for your family! May this child be famous in Israel. ¹⁵May he restore your youth and care for you in your old age. For he is the son of your daughter-in-law who loves you and has been better to you than seven sons!"

¹⁶Naomi took the baby and cuddled him to her breast. And she cared for him as if he were her own. ¹⁷The neighbor women said, "Now at last Naomi has a son again!" And they named him Obed. He became the father of Jesse and the grandfather of David.

¹⁸This is the genealogical record of their ancestor Perez:

Perez was the father of Hezron. ¹⁹Hezron was the father of Ram. Ram was the father of Amminadab. ²⁰Amminadab was the father of Nahshon. Nahshon was the father of Salmon.

²¹Salmon was the father of Boaz. Boaz was the father of Obed.

²²Obed was the father of Jesse. Jesse was the father of David.

Psalms

Book One: Psalms 1–41

1



- H, the joys of those who do not
follow the advice of the wicked,
or stand around with sinners,
or join in with mockers.
- ²But they delight in the law of the Lord,
meditating on it day and night.
- ³They are like trees planted along the riverbank,
bearing fruit each season.
Their leaves never wither,
and they prosper in all they do.
- ⁴But not the wicked!
They are like worthless chaff, scattered by the wind.
- ⁵They will be condemned at the time of judgment.
Sinners will have no place among the godly.
- ⁶For the Lord watches over the path of the godly,
but the path of the wicked leads to destruction.

2



HY are the nations so angry?

Why do they waste their time with futile plans?

²The kings of the earth prepare for battle;
the rulers plot together
against the Lord
and against his anointed one.

³“Let us break their chains,” they cry,
“and free ourselves from slavery to God.”

⁴But the one who rules in heaven laughs.
The Lord scoffs at them.

⁵Then in anger he rebukes them,
terrifying them with his fierce fury.

⁶For the Lord declares, “I have placed my chosen king on the
throne
in Jerusalem, on my holy mountain.”

⁷The king proclaims the Lord’s decree:

“The Lord said to me, ‘You are my son.
Today I have become your Father.

⁸Only ask, and I will give you the nations as your inheritance,
the whole earth as your possession.

⁹You will break them with an iron rod
and smash them like clay pots.”

¹⁰Now then, you kings, act wisely!
Be warned, you rulers of the earth!

¹¹Serve the Lord with reverent fear,
and rejoice with trembling.

¹²Submit to God's royal son, or he will become angry,
and you will be destroyed in the midst of all your activities—
for his anger flares up in an instant.
But what joy for all who take refuge in him!

3

A psalm of David, regarding the time David fled from his son Absalom.



Lord, I have so many enemies;
so many are against me.

²So many are saying,
“God will never rescue him!”

Interlude

³But you, O Lord, are a shield around me;
you are my glory, the one who holds my head high.

⁴I cried out to the Lord,
and he answered me from his holy mountain.

Interlude

⁵I lay down and slept,
yet I woke up in safety,
for the Lord was watching over me.

⁶I am not afraid of ten thousand enemies
who surround me on every side.

⁷Arise, O Lord!
Rescue me, my God!
Slap all my enemies in the face!
Shatter the teeth of the wicked!

⁸Victory comes from you, O Lord.
May you bless your people.

Interlude

4

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be accompanied by stringed instruments.



ANSWER me when I call to you,
O God who declares me innocent.
Free me from my troubles.
Have mercy on me and hear my prayer.

²How long will you people ruin my reputation?
How long will you make groundless accusations?
How long will you continue your lies?

Interlude

³You can be sure of this:
The Lord set apart the godly for himself.
The Lord will answer when I call to him.

⁴Don't sin by letting anger control you.
Think about it overnight and remain silent.

Interlude

⁵Offer sacrifices in the right spirit,
and trust the Lord.

⁶Many people say, “Who will show us better times?”

Let your face smile on us, Lord.

⁷You have given me greater joy

than those who have abundant harvests of grain and new wine.

⁸In peace I will lie down and sleep,

for you alone, O Lord, will keep me safe.

5

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be accompanied by the flute.



Lord, hear me as I pray;

pay attention to my groaning.

²Listen to my cry for help, my King and my God,

for I pray to no one but you.

³Listen to my voice in the morning, Lord.

Each morning I bring my requests to you and wait expectantly.

⁴O God, you take no pleasure in wickedness;

you cannot tolerate the sins of the wicked.

⁵Therefore, the proud may not stand in your presence,

for you hate all who do evil.

⁶You will destroy those who tell lies.

The Lord detests murderers and deceivers.

⁷Because of your unfailing love, I can enter your house;

I will worship at your Temple with deepest awe.

⁸Lead me in the right path, O Lord,

or my enemies will conquer me.

Make your way plain for me to follow.

⁹My enemies cannot speak a truthful word.

Their deepest desire is to destroy others.
Their talk is foul, like the stench from an open grave.

Their tongues are filled with flattery.

¹⁰O God, declare them guilty.

Let them be caught in their own traps.
Drive them away because of their many sins,
for they have rebelled against you.

¹¹But let all who take refuge in you rejoice;
let them sing joyful praises forever.

Spread your protection over them,
that all who love your name may be filled with joy.

¹²For you bless the godly, O Lord;
you surround them with your shield of love.

6

*For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be accompanied by an
eight-stringed instrument.*



Lord, don't rebuke me in your anger
or discipline me in your rage.

²Have compassion on me, Lord, for I am weak.
Heal me, Lord, for my bones are in agony.

³I am sick at heart.
How long, O Lord, until you restore me?

⁴Return, O Lord, and rescue me.
Save me because of your unfailing love.

⁵For the dead do not remember you.
Who can praise you from the grave?

⁶I am worn out from sobbing.
All night I flood my bed with weeping,
drenching it with my tears.
⁷My vision is blurred by grief;
my eyes are worn out because of all my enemies.

⁸Go away, all you who do evil,
for the Lord has heard my weeping.
⁹The Lord has heard my plea;
the Lord will answer my prayer.
¹⁰May all my enemies be disgraced and terrified.
May they suddenly turn back in shame.

7

A psalm of David, which he sang to the Lord concerning Cush of the tribe of Benjamin.



come to you for protection, O Lord my God.
Save me from my persecutors—rescue me!
²If you don't, they will maul me like a lion,
tearing me to pieces with no one to rescue me.
³O Lord my God, if I have done wrong
or am guilty of injustice,
⁴if I have betrayed a friend
or plundered my enemy without cause,
⁵then let my enemies capture me.
Let them trample me into the ground
and drag my honor in the dust.

Interlude

⁶Arise, O Lord, in anger!

- Stand up against the fury of my enemies!
Wake up, my God, and bring justice!
- ⁷Gather the nations before you.
Rule over them from on high.
- ⁸The Lord judges the nations.
Declare me righteous, O Lord,
for I am innocent, O Most High!
- ⁹End the evil of those who are wicked,
and defend the righteous.
For you look deep within the mind and heart,
O righteous God.
- ¹⁰God is my shield,
saving those whose hearts are true and right.
- ¹¹God is an honest judge.
He is angry with the wicked every day.
- ¹²If a person does not repent,
God will sharpen his sword;
he will bend and string his bow.
- ¹³He will prepare his deadly weapons
and shoot his flaming arrows.
- ¹⁴The wicked conceive evil;
they are pregnant with trouble
and give birth to lies.
- ¹⁵They dig a deep pit to trap others,
then fall into it themselves.
- ¹⁶The trouble they make for others backfires on them.
The violence they plan falls on their own heads.

¹⁷I will thank the Lord because he is just;
I will sing praise to the name of the Lord Most High.

8

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be accompanied by a stringed instrument.



Lord, our Lord, your majestic name fills the earth!
Your glory is higher than the heavens.

²You have taught children and infants
to tell of your strength,
silencing your enemies
and all who oppose you.

³When I look at the night sky and see the work of your fingers—
the moon and the stars you set in place—

⁴what are mere mortals that you should think about them,
human beings that you should care for them?

⁵Yet you made them only a little lower than God
and crowned them with glory and honor.

⁶You gave them charge of everything you made,
putting all things under their authority—

⁷the flocks and the herds
and all the wild animals,

⁸the birds in the sky, the fish in the sea,
and everything that swims the ocean currents.

⁹O Lord, our Lord, your majestic name fills the earth!

9

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be sung to the tune "Death of the Son."



will praise you, Lord, with all my heart;

I will tell of all the marvelous things you have done.

²I will be filled with joy because of you.

I will sing praises to your name, O Most High.

³My enemies retreated;

they staggered and died when you appeared.

⁴For you have judged in my favor;

from your throne you have judged with fairness.

⁵You have rebuked the nations and destroyed the wicked;

you have erased their names forever.

⁶The enemy is finished, in endless ruins;

the cities you uprooted are now forgotten.

⁷But the Lord reigns forever,

executing judgment from his throne.

⁸He will judge the world with justice

and rule the nations with fairness.

⁹The Lord is a shelter for the oppressed,

a refuge in times of trouble.

¹⁰Those who know your name trust in you,

for you, O Lord, do not abandon those who search for you.

¹¹Sing praises to the Lord who reigns in Jerusalem.

Tell the world about his unforgettable deeds.

¹²For he who avenges murder cares for the helpless.

He does not ignore the cries of those who suffer.

Psalms 10

13 Lord, have mercy on me.

See how my enemies torment me.

Snatch me back from the jaws of death.

¹⁴Save me so I can praise you publicly at Jerusalem's gates,
so I can rejoice that you have rescued me.

¹⁵The nations have fallen into the pit they dug for others.

Their own feet have been caught in the trap they set.

¹⁶The Lord is known for his justice.

The wicked are trapped by their own deeds.

Quiet Interlude

¹⁷The wicked will go down to the grave.

This is the fate of all the nations who ignore God.

¹⁸But the needy will not be ignored forever;
the hopes of the poor will not always be crushed.

¹⁹Arise, O Lord!

Do not let mere mortals defy you!

Judge the nations!

²⁰Make them tremble in fear, O Lord.

Let the nations know they are merely human.

Interlude

10



Lord, why do you stand so far away?

Why do you hide when I am in trouble?

²The wicked arrogantly hunt down the poor.

Let them be caught in the evil they plan for others.

Psalms 10

³For they brag about their evil desires;
they praise the greedy and curse the Lord.

⁴The wicked are too proud to seek God.
They seem to think that God is dead.

⁵Yet they succeed in everything they do.
They do not see your punishment awaiting them.
They sneer at all their enemies.

⁶They think, “Nothing bad will ever happen to us!
We will be free of trouble forever!”

⁷Their mouths are full of cursing, lies, and threats.
Trouble and evil are on the tips of their tongues.

⁸They lurk in ambush in the villages,
waiting to murder innocent people.
They are always searching for helpless victims.

⁹Like lions crouched in hiding,
they wait to pounce on the helpless.
Like hunters they capture the helpless
and drag them away in nets.

¹⁰Their helpless victims are crushed;
they fall beneath the strength of the wicked.

¹¹The wicked think, “God isn’t watching us!
He has closed his eyes and won’t even see what we do!”

¹²Arise, O Lord!
Punish the wicked, O God!
Do not ignore the helpless!

¹³Why do the wicked get away with despising God?
They think, “God will never call us to account.”

¹⁴But you see the trouble and grief they cause.

You take note of it and punish them.
The helpless put their trust in you.
You defend the orphans.

- ¹⁵Break the arms of these wicked, evil people!
Go after them until the last one is destroyed.
¹⁶The Lord is king forever and ever!
The godless nations will vanish from the land.
¹⁷Lord, you know the hopes of the helpless.
Surely you will hear their cries and comfort them.
¹⁸You will bring justice to the orphans and the oppressed,
so mere people can no longer terrify them.

11

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



- trust in the Lord for protection.
So why do you say to me,
“Fly like a bird to the mountains for safety!”
²The wicked are stringing their bows
and fitting their arrows on the bowstrings.
They shoot from the shadows
at those whose hearts are right.
³The foundations of law and order have collapsed.
What can the righteous do?”

⁴But the Lord is in his holy Temple;
the Lord still rules from heaven.
He watches everyone closely,
examining every person on earth.
⁵The Lord examines both the righteous and the wicked.

- He hates those who love violence.
6He will rain down blazing coals and burning sulfur on the wicked,
punishing them with scorching winds.
7For the righteous Lord loves justice.
The virtuous will see his face.

12

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be accompanied by an eight-stringed instrument.



- HELP, O Lord, for the godly are fast disappearing!
The faithful have vanished from the earth!
2Neighbors lie to each other,
speaking with flattering lips and deceitful hearts.
3May the Lord cut off their flattering lips
and silence their boastful tongues.
4They say, “We will lie to our hearts’ content.
Our lips are our own—who can stop us?”

5The Lord replies, “I have seen violence done to the helpless,
and I have heard the groans of the poor.
Now I will rise up to rescue them,
as they have longed for me to do.”
6The Lord’s promises are pure,
like silver refined in a furnace,
purified seven times over.
7Therefore, Lord, we know you will protect the oppressed,
preserving them forever from this lying generation,
8even though the wicked strut about,
and evil is praised throughout the land.

13

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



Lord, how long will you forget me? Forever?

How long will you look the other way?

²How long must I struggle with anguish in my soul,
with sorrow in my heart every day?

How long will my enemy have the upper hand?

³Turn and answer me, O Lord my God!

Restore the sparkle to my eyes, or I will die.

⁴Don't let my enemies gloat, saying, "We have defeated him!"

Don't let them rejoice at my downfall.

⁵But I trust in your unfailing love.

I will rejoice because you have rescued me.

⁶I will sing to the Lord

because he is good to me.

14

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



ONLY fools say in their hearts,

"There is no God."

They are corrupt, and their actions are evil;
not one of them does good!

²The Lord looks down from heaven
on the entire human race;

he looks to see if anyone is truly wise,
if anyone seeks God.

³But no, all have turned away;
all have become corrupt.

No one does good,
not a single one!

⁴Will those who do evil never learn?
They eat up my people like bread
and wouldn't think of praying to the Lord.

⁵Terror will grip them,
for God is with those who obey him.

⁶The wicked frustrate the plans of the oppressed,
but the Lord will protect his people.

⁷Who will come from Mount Zion to rescue Israel?
When the Lord restores his people,
Jacob will shout with joy, and Israel will rejoice.

15

A psalm of David.



HO may worship in your sanctuary, Lord?

Who may enter your presence on your holy hill?

²Those who lead blameless lives and do what is right,
speaking the truth from sincere hearts.

³Those who refuse to gossip
or harm their neighbors
or speak evil of their friends.

⁴Those who despise flagrant sinners,
and honor the faithful followers of the Lord,

and keep their promises even when it hurts.
⁵Those who lend money without charging interest,
and who cannot be bribed to lie about the innocent.
Such people will stand firm forever.

16

A psalm of David.



KEEP me safe, O God,
for I have come to you for refuge.

- ²I said to the Lord, “You are my Master!
Every good thing I have comes from you.”
³The godly people in the land
are my true heroes!
I take pleasure in them!
⁴Troubles multiply for those who chase after other gods.
I will not take part in their sacrifices of blood
or even speak the names of their gods.
- ⁵Lord, you alone are my inheritance, my cup of blessing.
You guard all that is mine.
⁶The land you have given me is a pleasant land.
What a wonderful inheritance!
- ⁷I will bless the Lord who guides me;
even at night my heart instructs me.
⁸I know the Lord is always with me.
I will not be shaken, for he is right beside me.

- ⁹No wonder my heart is glad, and I rejoice.
My body rests in safety.
¹⁰For you will not leave my soul among the dead
or allow your holy one to rot in the grave.
¹¹You will show me the way of life,
granting me the joy of your presence
and the pleasures of living with you forever.

17

A prayer of David.



- Lord, hear my plea for justice.
Listen to my cry for help.
Pay attention to my prayer,
for it comes from honest lips.
²Declare me innocent,
for you see those who do right.

³You have tested my thoughts and examined my heart in the night.
You have scrutinized me and found nothing wrong.
I am determined not to sin in what I say.
⁴I have followed your commands,
which keep me from following cruel and evil people.
⁵My steps have stayed on your path;
I have not wavered from following you.

⁶I am praying to you because I know you will answer, O God.
Bend down and listen as I pray.
⁷Show me your unfailing love in wonderful ways.
By your mighty power you rescue
those who seek refuge from their enemies.

- ⁸Guard me as you would guard your own eyes.
Hide me in the shadow of your wings.
- ⁹Protect me from wicked people who attack me,
from murderous enemies who surround me.
- ¹⁰They are without pity.
Listen to their boasting!
- ¹¹They track me down and surround me,
watching for the chance to throw me to the ground.
- ¹²They are like hungry lions, eager to tear me apart—
like young lions hiding in ambush.
- ¹³Arise, O Lord!
Stand against them, and bring them to their knees!
Rescue me from the wicked with your sword!
- ¹⁴By the power of your hand, O Lord,
destroy those who look to this world for their reward.
But satisfy the hunger of your treasured ones.
May their children have plenty,
leaving an inheritance for their descendants.
- ¹⁵Because I am righteous, I will see you.
When I awake, I will see you face to face and be satisfied.

18

For the choir director: A psalm of David, the servant of the Lord. He sang this song to the Lord on the day the Lord rescued him from all his enemies and from Saul. He sang:



- love you, Lord;
you are my strength.
- ²The Lord is my rock, my fortress, and my savior;
my God is my rock, in whom I find protection.
He is my shield, the power that saves me,

and my place of safety.

³I called on the Lord, who is worthy of praise,
and he saved me from my enemies.

⁴The ropes of death entangled me;
floods of destruction swept over me.

⁵The grave wrapped its ropes around me;
death laid a trap in my path.

⁶But in my distress I cried out to the Lord;
yes, I prayed to my God for help.
He heard me from his sanctuary;
my cry to him reached his ears.

⁷Then the earth quaked and trembled.
The foundations of the mountains shook;
they quaked because of his anger.

⁸Smoke poured from his nostrils;
fierce flames leaped from his mouth.
Glowing coals blazed forth from him.

⁹He opened the heavens and came down;
dark storm clouds were beneath his feet.

¹⁰Mounted on a mighty angelic being, he flew,
soaring on the wings of the wind.

¹¹He shrouded himself in darkness,
veiling his approach with dark rain clouds.

¹²Thick clouds shielded the brightness around him
and rained down hail and burning coals.

¹³The Lord thundered from heaven;
the voice of the Most High resounded
amid the hail and burning coals.

¹⁴He shot his arrows and scattered his enemies;
great bolts of lightning flashed, and they were confused.

¹⁵Then at your command, O Lord,
at the blast of your breath,
the bottom of the sea could be seen,
and the foundations of the earth were laid bare.

¹⁶He reached down from heaven and rescued me;
he drew me out of deep waters.

¹⁷He rescued me from my powerful enemies,
from those who hated me and were too strong for me.

¹⁸They attacked me at a moment when I was in distress,
but the Lord supported me.

¹⁹He led me to a place of safety;
he rescued me because he delights in me.

²⁰The Lord rewarded me for doing right;
he restored me because of my innocence.

²¹For I have kept the ways of the Lord;
I have not turned from my God to follow evil.

²²I have followed all his regulations;
I have never abandoned his decrees.

²³I am blameless before God;
I have kept myself from sin.

²⁴The Lord rewarded me for doing right.
He has seen my innocence.

²⁵To the faithful you show yourself faithful;
to those with integrity you show integrity.

²⁶To the pure you show yourself pure,
but to the crooked you show yourself shrewd.

²⁷You rescue the humble,
but you humiliate the proud.

²⁸You light a lamp for me.
The Lord, my God, lights up my darkness.

²⁹In your strength I can crush an army;
with my God I can scale any wall.

³⁰God's way is perfect.
All the Lord's promises prove true.
He is a shield for all who look to him for protection.

³¹For who is God except the Lord?
Who but our God is a solid rock?

³²God arms me with strength,
and he makes my way perfect.

³³He makes me as surefooted as a deer,
enabling me to stand on mountain heights.

³⁴He trains my hands for battle;
he strengthens my arm to draw a bronze bow.

³⁵You have given me your shield of victory.
Your right hand supports me;
your help has made me great.

³⁶You have made a wide path for my feet
to keep them from slipping.

³⁷I chased my enemies and caught them;
I did not stop until they were conquered.

³⁸I struck them down so they could not get up;
they fell beneath my feet.

³⁹You have armed me with strength for the battle;
you have subdued my enemies under my feet.

⁴⁰You placed my foot on their necks.
I have destroyed all who hated me.

⁴¹They called for help, but no one came to their rescue.
They even cried to the Lord, but he refused to answer.

⁴²I ground them as fine as dust in the wind.
I swept them into the gutter like dirt.

⁴³You gave me victory over my accusers.
You appointed me ruler over nations;
people I don't even know now serve me.
⁴⁴As soon as they hear of me, they submit;
foreign nations cringe before me.
⁴⁵They all lose their courage
and come trembling from their strongholds.

⁴⁶The Lord lives! Praise to my Rock!
May the God of my salvation be exalted!
⁴⁷He is the God who pays back those who harm me;
he subdues the nations under me
⁴⁸and rescues me from my enemies.
You hold me safe beyond the reach of my enemies;
you save me from violent opponents.
⁴⁹For this, O Lord, I will praise you among the nations;
I will sing praises to your name.
⁵⁰You give great victories to your king;
you show unfailing love to your anointed,
to David and all his descendants forever.

19

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



HE heavens proclaim the glory of God.
The skies display his craftsmanship.
²Day after day they continue to speak;
night after night they make him known.
³They speak without a sound or word;
their voice is never heard.
⁴Yet their message has gone throughout the earth,
and their words to all the world.

God has made a home in the heavens for the sun.

⁵It bursts forth like a radiant bridegroom after his wedding.

It rejoices like a great athlete eager to run the race.

⁶The sun rises at one end of the heavens
and follows its course to the other end.

Nothing can hide from its heat.

⁷The instructions of the Lord are perfect,
reviving the soul.

The decrees of the Lord are trustworthy,
making wise the simple.

⁸The commandments of the Lord are right,
bringing joy to the heart.

The commands of the Lord are clear,
giving insight for living.

⁹Reverence for the Lord is pure,
lasting forever.

The laws of the Lord are true;
each one is fair.

¹⁰They are more desirable than gold,
even the finest gold.

They are sweeter than honey,
even honey dripping from the comb.

¹¹They are a warning to your servant,
a great reward for those who obey them.

¹²How can I know all the sins lurking in my heart?
Cleanse me from these hidden faults.

¹³Keep your servant from deliberate sins!
Don't let them control me.

Then I will be free of guilt
and innocent of great sin.

¹⁴May the words of my mouth
and the meditation of my heart
be pleasing to you,
O Lord, my rock and my redeemer.

20

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



N times of trouble, may the Lord answer your cry.

May the name of the God of Jacob keep you safe from all
harm.

²May he send you help from his sanctuary
and strengthen you from Jerusalem.

³May he remember all your gifts
and look favorably on your burnt offerings.

Interlude

⁴May he grant your heart's desires
and make all your plans succeed.

⁵May we shout for joy when we hear of your victory
and raise a victory banner in the name of our God.

May the Lord answer all your prayers.

⁶Now I know that the Lord rescues his anointed king.
He will answer him from his holy heaven
and rescue him by his great power.

⁷Some nations boast of their chariots and horses,
but we boast in the name of the Lord our God.

⁸Those nations will fall down and collapse,
but we will rise up and stand firm.

⁹Give victory to our king, O Lord!
Answer our cry for help.

21

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



ow the king rejoices in your strength, O Lord!

He shouts with joy because you give him victory.

²For you have given him his heart's desire;
you have withheld nothing he requested.

Interlude

³You welcomed him back with success and prosperity.
You placed a crown of finest gold on his head.

⁴He asked you to preserve his life,
and you granted his request.
The days of his life stretch on forever.

⁵Your victory brings him great honor,
and you have clothed him with splendor and majesty.

⁶You have endowed him with eternal blessings
and given him the joy of your presence.

⁷For the king trusts in the Lord.
The unfailing love of the Most High will keep him from stumbling.

⁸You will capture all your enemies.
Your strong right hand will seize all who hate you.

⁹You will throw them in a flaming furnace
when you appear.

The Lord will consume them in his anger;
fire will devour them.

- ¹⁰You will wipe their children from the face of the earth;
they will never have descendants.
¹¹Although they plot against you,
their evil schemes will never succeed.
¹²For they will turn and run
when they see your arrows aimed at them.
¹³Rise up, O Lord, in all your power.
With music and singing we celebrate your mighty acts.

22

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be sung to the tune "Doe of the Dawn."



- Y God, my God, why have you abandoned me?
Why are you so far away when I groan for help?
²Every day I call to you, my God, but you do not answer.
Every night I lift my voice, but I find no relief.

³Yet you are holy,
enthroned on the praises of Israel.
⁴Our ancestors trusted in you,
and you rescued them.
⁵They cried out to you and were saved.
They trusted in you and were never disgraced.

⁶But I am a worm and not a man.
I am scorned and despised by all!
⁷Everyone who sees me mocks me.
They sneer and shake their heads, saying,
⁸"Is this the one who relies on the Lord?
Then let the Lord save him!"

If the Lord loves him so much,
let the Lord rescue him!"

⁹Yet you brought me safely from my mother's womb
and led me to trust you at my mother's breast.

¹⁰I was thrust into your arms at my birth.
You have been my God from the moment I was born.

¹¹Do not stay so far from me,
for trouble is near,
and no one else can help me.

¹²My enemies surround me like a herd of bulls;
fierce bulls of Bashan have hemmed me in!

¹³Like lions they open their jaws against me,
roaring and tearing into their prey.

¹⁴My life is poured out like water,
and all my bones are out of joint.

My heart is like wax,
melting within me.

¹⁵My strength has dried up like sunbaked clay.
My tongue sticks to the roof of my mouth.
You have laid me in the dust and left me for dead.

¹⁶My enemies surround me like a pack of dogs;
an evil gang closes in on me.
They have pierced my hands and feet.

¹⁷I can count all my bones.
My enemies stare at me and gloat.

¹⁸They divide my garments among themselves
and throw dice for my clothing.

¹⁹O Lord, do not stay far away!

- You are my strength; come quickly to my aid!
- ²⁰Save me from the sword;
spare my precious life from these dogs.
- ²¹Snatch me from the lion's jaws
and from the horns of these wild oxen.
- ²²I will proclaim your name to my brothers and sisters.
I will praise you among your assembled people.
- ²³Praise the Lord, all you who fear him!
Honor him, all you descendants of Jacob!
Show him reverence, all you descendants of Israel!
- ²⁴For he has not ignored or belittled the suffering of the needy.
He has not turned his back on them,
but has listened to their cries for help.
- ²⁵I will praise you in the great assembly.
I will fulfill my vows in the presence of those who worship
you.
- ²⁶The poor will eat and be satisfied.
All who seek the Lord will praise him.
Their hearts will rejoice with everlasting joy.
- ²⁷The whole earth will acknowledge the Lord and return to him.
All the families of the nations will bow down before him.
- ²⁸For royal power belongs to the Lord.
He rules all the nations.
- ²⁹Let the rich of the earth feast and worship.
Bow before him, all who are mortal,
all whose lives will end as dust.
- ³⁰Our children will also serve him.
Future generations will hear about the wonders of the Lord.

³¹His righteous acts will be told to those not yet born.
They will hear about everything he has done.

23

A psalm of David.



HE Lord is my shepherd;
I have all that I need.

²He lets me rest in green meadows;
he leads me beside peaceful streams.

³He renews my strength.

He guides me along right paths,
bringing honor to his name.

⁴Even when I walk
through the darkest valley,
I will not be afraid,
for you are close beside me.

Your rod and your staff
protect and comfort me.

⁵You prepare a feast for me
in the presence of my enemies.

You honor me by anointing my head with oil.

My cup overflows with blessings.

⁶Surely your goodness and unfailing love will pursue me
all the days of my life,
and I will live in the house of the Lord
forever.

24

A psalm of David.



THE earth is the Lord's, and everything in it.

The world and all its people belong to him.

²For he laid the earth's foundation on the seas
and built it on the ocean depths.

³Who may climb the mountain of the Lord?

Who may stand in his holy place?

⁴Only those whose hands and hearts are pure,
who do not worship idols
and never tell lies.

⁵They will receive the Lord's blessing
and have a right relationship with God their savior.

⁶Such people may seek you
and worship in your presence, O God of Jacob.

Interlude

⁷Open up, ancient gates!
Open up, ancient doors,
and let the King of glory enter.

⁸Who is the King of glory?
The Lord, strong and mighty;
the Lord, invincible in battle.

⁹Open up, ancient gates!
Open up, ancient doors,
and let the King of glory enter.

¹⁰Who is the King of glory?
The Lord of Heaven's Armies—
he is the King of glory.

Interlude

25

A psalm of David.



Lord, I give my life to you.

²I trust in you, my God!

Do not let me be disgraced,

or let my enemies rejoice in my defeat.

³No one who trusts in you will ever be disgraced,
but disgrace comes to those who try to deceive others.

⁴Show me the right path, O Lord;
point out the road for me to follow.

⁵Lead me by your truth and teach me,
for you are the God who saves me.
All day long I put my hope in you.

⁶Remember, O Lord, your compassion and unfailing love,
which you have shown from long ages past.

⁷Do not remember the rebellious sins of my youth.
Remember me in the light of your unfailing love,
for you are merciful, O Lord.

⁸The Lord is good and does what is right;
he shows the proper path to those who go astray.

⁹He leads the humble in doing right,
teaching them his way.

¹⁰The Lord leads with unfailing love and faithfulness
all who keep his covenant and obey his demands.

¹¹For the honor of your name, O Lord,

forgive my many, many sins.

¹²Who are those who fear the Lord?

He will show them the path they should choose.

¹³They will live in prosperity,

and their children will inherit the land.

¹⁴The Lord is a friend to those who fear him.

He teaches them his covenant.

¹⁵My eyes are always on the Lord,

for he rescues me from the traps of my enemies.

¹⁶Turn to me and have mercy,

for I am alone and in deep distress.

¹⁷My problems go from bad to worse.

Oh, save me from them all!

¹⁸Feel my pain and see my trouble.

Forgive all my sins.

¹⁹See how many enemies I have

and how viciously they hate me!

²⁰Protect me! Rescue my life from them!

Do not let me be disgraced, for in you I take refuge.

²¹May integrity and honesty protect me,

for I put my hope in you.

²²O God, ransom Israel

from all its troubles.

26

A psalm of David.



DECLARE me innocent, O Lord,
for I have acted with integrity;

I have trusted in the Lord without wavering.
²Put me on trial, Lord, and cross-examine me.
Test my motives and my heart.
³For I am always aware of your unfailing love,
and I have lived according to your truth.
⁴I do not spend time with liars
or go along with hypocrites.
⁵I hate the gatherings of those who do evil,
and I refuse to join in with the wicked.
⁶I wash my hands to declare my innocence.
I come to your altar, O Lord,
⁷singing a song of thanksgiving
and telling of all your wonders.
⁸I love your sanctuary, Lord,
the place where your glorious presence dwells.

⁹Don't let me suffer the fate of sinners.
Don't condemn me along with murderers.
¹⁰Their hands are dirty with evil schemes,
and they constantly take bribes.
¹¹But I am not like that; I live with integrity.
So redeem me and show me mercy.
¹²Now I stand on solid ground,
and I will publicly praise the Lord.

27

A psalm of David.



HE Lord is my light and my salvation—
so why should I be afraid?

The Lord is my fortress, protecting me from danger,
so why should I tremble?

²When evil people come to devour me,
when my enemies and foes attack me,
they will stumble and fall.

³Though a mighty army surrounds me,
my heart will not be afraid.
Even if I am attacked,
I will remain confident.

⁴The one thing I ask of the Lord—
the thing I seek most—
is to live in the house of the Lord all the days of my life,
delighting in the Lord's perfections
and meditating in his Temple.

⁵For he will conceal me there when troubles come;
he will hide me in his sanctuary.
He will place me out of reach on a high rock.

⁶Then I will hold my head high
above my enemies who surround me.
At his sanctuary I will offer sacrifices with shouts of joy,
singing and praising the Lord with music.

⁷Hear me as I pray, O Lord.
Be merciful and answer me!

⁸My heart has heard you say, "Come and talk with me."
And my heart responds, "Lord, I am coming."

⁹Do not turn your back on me.
Do not reject your servant in anger.
You have always been my helper.
Don't leave me now; don't abandon me,
O God of my salvation!

¹⁰Even if my father and mother abandon me,
the Lord will hold me close.

- ¹¹Teach me how to live, O Lord.
Lead me along the right path,
for my enemies are waiting for me.
- ¹²Do not let me fall into their hands.
For they accuse me of things I've never done;
with every breath they threaten me with violence.
- ¹³Yet I am confident I will see the Lord's goodness
while I am here in the land of the living.
- ¹⁴Wait patiently for the Lord.
Be brave and courageous.
Yes, wait patiently for the Lord.

28

A psalm of David.



- L** pray to you, O Lord, my rock.
Do not turn a deaf ear to me.
For if you are silent,
I might as well give up and die.
- ²Listen to my prayer for mercy
as I cry out to you for help,
as I lift my hands toward your holy sanctuary.
- ³Do not drag me away with the wicked—
with those who do evil—
those who speak friendly words to their neighbors
while planning evil in their hearts.
- ⁴Give them the punishment they so richly deserve!
Measure it out in proportion to their wickedness.
Pay them back for all their evil deeds!

Give them a taste of what they have done to others.

⁵They care nothing for what the Lord has done
or for what his hands have made.

So he will tear them down,
and they will never be rebuilt!

⁶Praise the Lord!

For he has heard my cry for mercy.

⁷The Lord is my strength and shield.

I trust him with all my heart.

He helps me, and my heart is filled with joy.

I burst out in songs of thanksgiving.

⁸The Lord gives his people strength.

He is a safe fortress for his anointed king.

⁹Save your people!

Bless Israel, your special possession.

Lead them like a shepherd,
and carry them in your arms forever.

29

A psalm of David.



HONOR the Lord, you heavenly beings;
honor the Lord for his glory and strength.

²Honor the Lord for the glory of his name.
Worship the Lord in the splendor of his holiness.

³The voice of the Lord echoes above the sea.
The God of glory thunders.

- The Lord thunders over the mighty sea.
4The voice of the Lord is powerful;
the voice of the Lord is majestic.
5The voice of the Lord splits the mighty cedars;
the Lord shatters the cedars of Lebanon.
6He makes Lebanon's mountains skip like a calf;
he makes Mount Hermon leap like a young wild ox.
7The voice of the Lord strikes
with bolts of lightning.
8The voice of the Lord makes the barren wilderness quake;
the Lord shakes the wilderness of Kadesh.
9The voice of the Lord twists mighty oaks
and strips the forests bare.
In his Temple everyone shouts, "Glory!"
- 10The Lord rules over the floodwaters.
The Lord reigns as king forever.
11The Lord gives his people strength.
The Lord blesses them with peace.

30

A psalm of David. A song for the dedication of the Temple.



- will exalt you, Lord, for you rescued me.
You refused to let my enemies triumph over me.
2O Lord my God, I cried to you for help,
and you restored my health.
3You brought me up from the grave, O Lord.
You kept me from falling into the pit of death.

- 4Sing to the Lord, all you godly ones!

Praise his holy name.

⁵For his anger lasts only a moment,
but his favor lasts a lifetime!
Weeping may last through the night,
but joy comes with the morning.

⁶When I was prosperous, I said,
“Nothing can stop me now!”
⁷Your favor, O Lord, made me as secure as a mountain.
Then you turned away from me, and I was shattered.

⁸I cried out to you, O Lord.
I begged the Lord for mercy, saying,
⁹“What will you gain if I die,
if I sink into the grave?
Can my dust praise you?
Can it tell of your faithfulness?
¹⁰Hear me, Lord, and have mercy on me.
Help me, O Lord.”

¹¹You have turned my mourning into joyful dancing.
You have taken away my clothes of mourning and clothed me
with joy,
¹²that I might sing praises to you and not be silent.
O Lord my God, I will give you thanks forever!

31

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



Lord, I have come to you for protection;

don't let me be disgraced.

Save me, for you do what is right.

²Turn your ear to listen to me;
rescue me quickly.

Be my rock of protection,
a fortress where I will be safe.

³You are my rock and my fortress.
For the honor of your name, lead me out of this danger.

⁴Pull me from the trap my enemies set for me,
for I find protection in you alone.

⁵I entrust my spirit into your hand.
Rescue me, Lord, for you are a faithful God.

⁶I hate those who worship worthless idols.
I trust in the Lord.

⁷I will be glad and rejoice in your unfailing love,
for you have seen my troubles,
and you care about the anguish of my soul.

⁸You have not handed me over to my enemies
but have set me in a safe place.

⁹Have mercy on me, Lord, for I am in distress.
Tears blur my eyes.

My body and soul are withering away.

¹⁰I am dying from grief;
my years are shortened by sadness.

Sin has drained my strength;
I am wasting away from within.

¹¹I am scorned by all my enemies
and despised by my neighbors—
even my friends are afraid to come near me.

When they see me on the street,

they run the other way.

¹²I am ignored as if I were dead,
as if I were a broken pot.

¹³I have heard the many rumors about me,
and I am surrounded by terror.

My enemies conspire against me,
plotting to take my life.

¹⁴But I am trusting you, O Lord,
saying, "You are my God!"

¹⁵My future is in your hands.
Rescue me from those who hunt me down relentlessly.

¹⁶Let your favor shine on your servant.
In your unfailing love, rescue me.

¹⁷Don't let me be disgraced, O Lord,
for I call out to you for help.

Let the wicked be disgraced;
let them lie silent in the grave.

¹⁸Silence their lying lips—
those proud and arrogant lips that accuse the godly.

¹⁹How great is the goodness
you have stored up for those who fear you.
You lavish it on those who come to you for protection,
blessing them before the watching world.

²⁰You hide them in the shelter of your presence,
safe from those who conspire against them.

You shelter them in your presence,
far from accusing tongues.

²¹Praise the Lord,

for he has shown me the wonders of his unfailing love.

He kept me safe when my city was under attack.

²²In panic I cried out,

“I am cut off from the Lord!”

But you heard my cry for mercy

and answered my call for help.

²³Love the Lord, all you godly ones!

For the Lord protects those who are loyal to him,

but he harshly punishes the arrogant.

²⁴So be strong and courageous,

all you who put your hope in the Lord!

32

A psalm of David.



H, what joy for those

whose disobedience is forgiven,

whose sin is put out of sight!

²Yes, what joy for those

whose record the Lord has cleared of guilt,

whose lives are lived in complete honesty!

³When I refused to confess my sin,

my body wasted away,

and I groaned all day long.

⁴Day and night your hand of discipline was heavy on me.

My strength evaporated like water in the summer heat.

Interlude

⁵Finally, I confessed all my sins to you

and stopped trying to hide my guilt.

Psalms 33

I said to myself, “I will confess my rebellion to the Lord.”
And you forgave me! All my guilt is gone.

Interlude

⁶Therefore, let all the godly pray to you while there is still time,
that they may not drown in the floodwaters of judgment.
⁷For you are my hiding place;
you protect me from trouble.
You surround me with songs of victory.

Interlude

⁸The Lord says, “I will guide you along the best pathway for your
life.
I will advise you and watch over you.
⁹Do not be like a senseless horse or mule
that needs a bit and bridle to keep it under control.”

¹⁰Many sorrows come to the wicked,
but unfailing love surrounds those who trust the Lord.
¹¹So rejoice in the Lord and be glad, all you who obey him!
Shout for joy, all you whose hearts are pure!

33



ET the godly sing for joy to the Lord;
it is fitting for the pure to praise him.
²Praise the Lord with melodies on the lyre;
make music for him on the ten-stringed harp.
³Sing a new song of praise to him;
play skillfully on the harp, and sing with joy.

⁴For the word of the Lord holds true,
and we can trust everything he does.
⁵He loves whatever is just and good;
the unfailing love of the Lord fills the earth.

⁶The Lord merely spoke,
and the heavens were created.
He breathed the word,
and all the stars were born.
⁷He assigned the sea its boundaries
and locked the oceans in vast reservoirs.
⁸Let the whole world fear the Lord,
and let everyone stand in awe of him.
⁹For when he spoke, the world began!
It appeared at his command.

¹⁰The Lord frustrates the plans of the nations
and thwarts all their schemes.
¹¹But the Lord's plans stand firm forever;
his intentions can never be shaken.

¹²What joy for the nation whose God is the Lord,
whose people he has chosen as his inheritance.

¹³The Lord looks down from heaven
and sees the whole human race.
¹⁴From his throne he observes
all who live on the earth.
¹⁵He made their hearts,
so he understands everything they do.

- ¹⁶The best-equipped army cannot save a king,
nor is great strength enough to save a warrior.
- ¹⁷Don't count on your warhorse to give you victory—
for all its strength, it cannot save you.
- ¹⁸But the Lord watches over those who fear him,
those who rely on his unfailing love.
- ¹⁹He rescues them from death
and keeps them alive in times of famine.
- ²⁰We put our hope in the Lord.
He is our help and our shield.
- ²¹In him our hearts rejoice,
for we trust in his holy name.
- ²²Let your unfailing love surround us, Lord,
for our hope is in you alone.

34

*A psalm of David, regarding the time he pretended to be insane in front of
Abimelech, who sent him away.*



- will praise the Lord at all times.
I will constantly speak his praises.
- ²I will boast only in the Lord;
let all who are helpless take heart.
- ³Come, let us tell of the Lord's greatness;
let us exalt his name together.

- ⁴I prayed to the Lord, and he answered me.
He freed me from all my fears.

⁵Those who look to him for help will be radiant with joy;
no shadow of shame will darken their faces.

⁶In my desperation I prayed, and the Lord listened;
he saved me from all my troubles.

⁷For the angel of the Lord is a guard;
he surrounds and defends all who fear him.

⁸Taste and see that the Lord is good.
Oh, the joys of those who take refuge in him!

⁹Fear the Lord, you his godly people,
for those who fear him will have all they need.

¹⁰Even strong young lions sometimes go hungry,
but those who trust in the Lord will lack no good thing.

¹¹Come, my children, and listen to me,
and I will teach you to fear the Lord.

¹²Does anyone want to live a life
that is long and prosperous?

¹³Then keep your tongue from speaking evil
and your lips from telling lies!

¹⁴Turn away from evil and do good.
Search for peace, and work to maintain it.

¹⁵The eyes of the Lord watch over those who do right;
his ears are open to their cries for help.

¹⁶But the Lord turns his face against those who do evil;
he will erase their memory from the earth.

¹⁷The Lord hears his people when they call to him for help.
He rescues them from all their troubles.

¹⁸The Lord is close to the brokenhearted;
he rescues those whose spirits are crushed.

¹⁹The righteous person faces many troubles,
but the Lord comes to the rescue each time.

²⁰For the Lord protects the bones of the righteous;
not one of them is broken!

²¹Calamity will surely destroy the wicked,
and those who hate the righteous will be punished.

²²But the Lord will redeem those who serve him.
No one who takes refuge in him will be condemned.

35

A psalm of David.



Lord, oppose those who oppose me.

Fight those who fight against me.

²Put on your armor, and take up your shield.

Prepare for battle, and come to my aid.

³Lift up your spear and javelin
against those who pursue me.

Let me hear you say,

“I will give you victory!”

⁴Bring shame and disgrace on those trying to kill me;
turn them back and humiliate those who want to harm me.

⁵Blow them away like chaff in the wind—
a wind sent by the angel of the Lord.

⁶Make their path dark and slippery,
with the angel of the Lord pursuing them.

⁷I did them no wrong, but they laid a trap for me.

- I did them no wrong, but they dug a pit to catch me.
⁸So let sudden ruin come upon them!
Let them be caught in the trap they set for me!
Let them be destroyed in the pit they dug for me.
- ⁹Then I will rejoice in the Lord.
I will be glad because he rescues me.
- ¹⁰With every bone in my body I will praise him:
“Lord, who can compare with you?
Who else rescues the helpless from the strong?
Who else protects the helpless and poor from those who rob
them?”
- ¹¹Malicious witnesses testify against me.
They accuse me of crimes I know nothing about.
- ¹²They repay me evil for good.
I am sick with despair.
- ¹³Yet when they were ill, I grieved for them.
I denied myself by fasting for them,
but my prayers returned unanswered.
- ¹⁴I was sad, as though they were my friends or family,
as if I were grieving for my own mother.
- ¹⁵But they are glad now that I am in trouble;
they gleefully join together against me.
I am attacked by people I don’t even know;
they slander me constantly.
- ¹⁶They mock me and call me names;
they snarl at me.
- ¹⁷How long, O Lord, will you look on and do nothing?
Rescue me from their fierce attacks.

Protect my life from these lions!

¹⁸Then I will thank you in front of the great assembly.

I will praise you before all the people.

¹⁹Don't let my treacherous enemies rejoice over my defeat.

Don't let those who hate me without cause gloat over my sorrow.

²⁰They don't talk of peace;

they plot against innocent people who mind their own business.

²¹They shout, "Aha! Aha!

With our own eyes we saw him do it!"

²²O Lord, you know all about this.

Do not stay silent.

Do not abandon me now, O Lord.

²³Wake up! Rise to my defense!

Take up my case, my God and my Lord.

²⁴Declare me not guilty, O Lord my God, for you give justice.

Don't let my enemies laugh about me in my troubles.

²⁵Don't let them say, "Look, we got what we wanted!

Now we will eat him alive!"

²⁶May those who rejoice at my troubles

be humiliated and disgraced.

May those who triumph over me

be covered with shame and dishonor.

²⁷But give great joy to those who came to my defense.

Let them continually say, "Great is the Lord,
who delights in blessing his servant with peace!"

²⁸Then I will proclaim your justice,

and I will praise you all day long.

36

For the choir director: A psalm of David, the servant of the Lord.



IN whispers to the wicked, deep within their hearts.

They have no fear of God at all.

²In their blind conceit,

they cannot see how wicked they really are.

³Everything they say is crooked and deceitful.

They refuse to act wisely or do good.

⁴They lie awake at night, hatching sinful plots.

Their actions are never good.

They make no attempt to turn from evil.

⁵Your unfailing love, O Lord, is as vast as the heavens;
your faithfulness reaches beyond the clouds.

⁶Your righteousness is like the mighty mountains,
your justice like the ocean depths.

You care for people and animals alike, O Lord.

⁷How precious is your unfailing love, O God!

All humanity finds shelter

in the shadow of your wings.

⁸You feed them from the abundance of your own house,
letting them drink from your river of delights.

⁹For you are the fountain of life,
the light by which we see.

¹⁰Pour out your unfailing love on those who love you;
give justice to those with honest hearts.

¹¹Don't let the proud trample me
or the wicked push me around.

¹²Look! Those who do evil have fallen!
They are thrown down, never to rise again.

37

A psalm of David.



ON'T worry about the wicked
or envy those who do wrong.

²For like grass, they soon fade away.
Like spring flowers, they soon wither.

³Trust in the Lord and do good.
Then you will live safely in the land and prosper.

⁴Take delight in the Lord,
and he will give you your heart's desires.

⁵Commit everything you do to the Lord.
Trust him, and he will help you.

⁶He will make your innocence radiate like the dawn,
and the justice of your cause will shine like the noonday sun.

⁷Be still in the presence of the Lord,
and wait patiently for him to act.
Don't worry about evil people who prosper
or fret about their wicked schemes.

⁸Stop being angry!
Turn from your rage!
Do not lose your temper—
it only leads to harm.

⁹For the wicked will be destroyed,
but those who trust in the Lord will possess the land.

¹⁰Soon the wicked will disappear.

Though you look for them, they will be gone.

¹¹The lowly will possess the land

and will live in peace and prosperity.

¹²The wicked plot against the godly;

they snarl at them in defiance.

¹³But the Lord just laughs,

for he sees their day of judgment coming.

¹⁴The wicked draw their swords

and string their bows

to kill the poor and the oppressed,

to slaughter those who do right.

¹⁵But their swords will stab their own hearts,

and their bows will be broken.

¹⁶It is better to be godly and have little

than to be evil and rich.

¹⁷For the strength of the wicked will be shattered,

but the Lord takes care of the godly.

¹⁸Day by day the Lord takes care of the innocent,

and they will receive an inheritance that lasts forever.

¹⁹They will not be disgraced in hard times;

even in famine they will have more than enough.

²⁰But the wicked will die.

The Lord's enemies are like flowers in a field—

they will disappear like smoke.

²¹The wicked borrow and never repay,
but the godly are generous givers.

²²Those the Lord blesses will possess the land,
but those he curses will die.

²³The Lord directs the steps of the godly.
He delights in every detail of their lives.

²⁴Though they stumble, they will never fall,
for the Lord holds them by the hand.

²⁵Once I was young, and now I am old.
Yet I have never seen the godly abandoned
or their children begging for bread.

²⁶The godly always give generous loans to others,
and their children are a blessing.

²⁷Turn from evil and do good,
and you will live in the land forever.

²⁸For the Lord loves justice,
and he will never abandon the godly.

He will keep them safe forever,
but the children of the wicked will die.

²⁹The godly will possess the land
and will live there forever.

³⁰The godly offer good counsel;
they teach right from wrong.

³¹They have made God's law their own,
so they will never slip from his path.

³²The wicked wait in ambush for the godly,
looking for an excuse to kill them.

³³But the Lord will not let the wicked succeed
or let the godly be condemned when they are put on trial.

³⁴Put your hope in the Lord.
Travel steadily along his path.
He will honor you by giving you the land.
You will see the wicked destroyed.

³⁵I have seen wicked and ruthless people
flourishing like a tree in its native soil.
³⁶But when I looked again, they were gone!
Though I searched for them, I could not find them!

³⁷Look at those who are honest and good,
for a wonderful future awaits those who love peace.
³⁸But the rebellious will be destroyed;
they have no future.

³⁹The Lord rescues the godly;
he is their fortress in times of trouble.
⁴⁰The Lord helps them,
rescuing them from the wicked.

He saves them,
and they find shelter in him.

38

A psalm of David, asking God to remember him.



Lord, don't rebuke me in your anger
or discipline me in your rage!

²Your arrows have struck deep,
and your blows are crushing me.

³Because of your anger, my whole body is sick;
my health is broken because of my sins.

⁴My guilt overwhelms me—
it is a burden too heavy to bear.

⁵My wounds fester and stink
because of my foolish sins.

⁶I am bent over and racked with pain.
All day long I walk around filled with grief.

⁷A raging fever burns within me,
and my health is broken.

⁸I am exhausted and completely crushed.
My groans come from an anguished heart.

⁹You know what I long for, Lord;
you hear my every sigh.

¹⁰My heart beats wildly, my strength fails,
and I am going blind.

¹¹My loved ones and friends stay away, fearing my disease.
Even my own family stands at a distance.

¹²Meanwhile, my enemies lay traps to kill me.
Those who wish me harm make plans to ruin me.
All day long they plan their treachery.

- ¹³But I am deaf to all their threats.
I am silent before them as one who cannot speak.
- ¹⁴I choose to hear nothing,
and I make no reply.
- ¹⁵For I am waiting for you, O Lord.
You must answer for me, O Lord my God.
- ¹⁶I prayed, “Don’t let my enemies gloat over me
or rejoice at my downfall.”
- ¹⁷I am on the verge of collapse,
facing constant pain.
- ¹⁸But I confess my sins;
I am deeply sorry for what I have done.
- ¹⁹I have many aggressive enemies;
they hate me without reason.
- ²⁰They repay me evil for good
and oppose me for pursuing good.
- ²¹Do not abandon me, O Lord.
Do not stand at a distance, my God.
- ²²Come quickly to help me,
O Lord my savior.

39

For Jeduthun, the choir director: A psalm of David.



- said to myself, “I will watch what I do
and not sin in what I say.
I will hold my tongue
when the ungodly are around me.”
- ²But as I stood there in silence—
not even speaking of good things—
the turmoil within me grew worse.

- ³The more I thought about it,
the hotter I got,
igniting a fire of words:
- ⁴“Lord, remind me how brief my time on earth will be.
Remind me that my days are numbered—
how fleeting my life is.
- ⁵You have made my life no longer than the width of my hand.
My entire lifetime is just a moment to you;
at best, each of us is but a breath.”

Interlude

- ⁶We are merely moving shadows,
and all our busy rushing ends in nothing.
We heap up wealth,
not knowing who will spend it.
- ⁷And so, Lord, where do I put my hope?
My only hope is in you.
- ⁸Rescue me from my rebellion.
Do not let fools mock me.
- ⁹I am silent before you; I won't say a word,
for my punishment is from you.
- ¹⁰But please stop striking me!
I am exhausted by the blows from your hand.
- ¹¹When you discipline us for our sins,
you consume like a moth what is precious to us.
Each of us is but a breath.

Interlude

- ¹²Hear my prayer, O Lord!
Listen to my cries for help!
Don't ignore my tears.
For I am your guest—
a traveler passing through,

as my ancestors were before me.

¹³Leave me alone so I can smile again
before I am gone and exist no more.

40

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



waited patiently for the Lord to help me,
and he turned to me and heard my cry.

²He lifted me out of the pit of despair,
out of the mud and the mire.

He set my feet on solid ground
and steadied me as I walked along.

³He has given me a new song to sing,
a hymn of praise to our God.

Many will see what he has done and be amazed.
They will put their trust in the Lord.

⁴Oh, the joys of those who trust the Lord,
who have no confidence in the proud
or in those who worship idols.

⁵O Lord my God, you have performed many wonders for us.
Your plans for us are too numerous to list.
You have no equal.

If I tried to recite all your wonderful deeds,
I would never come to the end of them.

⁶You take no delight in sacrifices or offerings.
Now that you have made me listen, I finally understand—
you don't require burnt offerings or sin offerings.

⁷Then I said, "Look, I have come.

As is written about me in the Scriptures:

⁸I take joy in doing your will, my God,
for your instructions are written on my heart.”

⁹I have told all your people about your justice.

I have not been afraid to speak out,
as you, O Lord, well know.

¹⁰I have not kept the good news of your justice hidden in my
heart;

I have talked about your faithfulness and saving power.
I have told everyone in the great assembly
of your unfailing love and faithfulness.

11 Lord, don’t hold back your tender mercies from me.

Let your unfailing love and faithfulness always protect me.

¹²For troubles surround me—
too many to count!

My sins pile up so high
I can’t see my way out.

They outnumber the hairs on my head.
I have lost all courage.

¹³Please, Lord, rescue me!

Come quickly, Lord, and help me.

¹⁴May those who try to destroy me
be humiliated and put to shame.

May those who take delight in my trouble
be turned back in disgrace.

¹⁵Let them be horrified by their shame,
for they said, “Aha! We’ve got him now!”

¹⁶But may all who search for you
be filled with joy and gladness in you.
May those who love your salvation
repeatedly shout, "The Lord is great!"
¹⁷As for me, since I am poor and needy,
let the Lord keep me in his thoughts.
You are my helper and my savior.
O my God, do not delay.

41

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



H, the joys of those who are kind to the poor!
The Lord rescues them when they are in trouble.
²The Lord protects them
and keeps them alive.
He gives them prosperity in the land
and rescues them from their enemies.
³The Lord nurses them when they are sick
and restores them to health.

⁴"O Lord," I prayed, "have mercy on me.
Heal me, for I have sinned against you."
⁵But my enemies say nothing but evil about me.
"How soon will he die and be forgotten?" they ask.
⁶They visit me as if they were my friends,
but all the while they gather gossip,
and when they leave, they spread it everywhere.
⁷All who hate me whisper about me,
imagining the worst.
⁸"He has some fatal disease," they say.
"He will never get out of that bed!"

⁹Even my best friend, the one I trusted completely,
the one who shared my food, has turned against me.

¹⁰Lord, have mercy on me.

Make me well again, so I can pay them back!

¹¹I know you are pleased with me,
for you have not let my enemies triumph over me.

¹²You have preserved my life because I am innocent;
you have brought me into your presence forever.

¹³Praise the Lord, the God of Israel,
who lives from everlasting to everlasting.
Amen and amen!

Book Two: Psalms 42-72

42

For the choir director: A psalm of the descendants of Korah.



As the deer longs for streams of water,
so I long for you, O God.

²I thirst for God, the living God.

When can I go and stand before him?

³Day and night I have only tears for food,
while my enemies continually taunt me, saying,
“Where is this God of yours?”

⁴My heart is breaking
as I remember how it used to be:

I walked among the crowds of worshipers,
 leading a great procession to the house of God,
singing for joy and giving thanks
 amid the sound of a great celebration!

⁵Why am I discouraged?
 Why is my heart so sad?
I will put my hope in God!
 I will praise him again—
 my Savior and ⁶my God!

Now I am deeply discouraged,
 but I will remember you—
even from distant Mount Hermon, the source of the Jordan,
 from the land of Mount Mizar.
⁷I hear the tumult of the raging seas
 as your waves and surging tides sweep over me.
⁸But each day the Lord pours his unfailing love upon me,
 and through each night I sing his songs,
 praying to God who gives me life.

⁹“O God my rock,” I cry,
 “why have you forgotten me?
Why must I wander around in grief,
 oppressed by my enemies?”
¹⁰Their taunts break my bones.
 They scoff, “Where is this God of yours?”

¹¹Why am I discouraged?
 Why is my heart so sad?

I will put my hope in God!
I will praise him again—
my Savior and my God!

43



DECLARE me innocent, O God!
Defend me against these ungodly people.
Rescue me from these unjust liars.
²For you are God, my only safe haven.
Why have you tossed me aside?
Why must I wander around in grief,
oppressed by my enemies?
³Send out your light and your truth;
let them guide me.
Let them lead me to your holy mountain,
to the place where you live.
⁴There I will go to the altar of God,
to God—the source of all my joy.
I will praise you with my harp,
O God, my God!

⁵Why am I discouraged?
Why is my heart so sad?
I will put my hope in God!
I will praise him again—
my Savior and my God!

For the choir director: A psalm of the descendants of Korah.



God, we have heard it with our own ears—
our ancestors have told us
of all you did in their day,
in days long ago:
²You drove out the pagan nations by your power
and gave all the land to our ancestors.
You crushed their enemies
and set our ancestors free.
³They did not conquer the land with their swords;
it was not their own strong arm that gave them victory.
It was your right hand and strong arm
and the blinding light from your face that helped them,
for you loved them.

⁴You are my King and my God.
You command victories for Israel.
⁵Only by your power can we push back our enemies;
only in your name can we trample our foes.
⁶I do not trust in my bow;
I do not count on my sword to save me.
⁷You are the one who gives us victory over our enemies;
you disgrace those who hate us.
⁸O God, we give glory to you all day long
and constantly praise your name.

Interlude

⁹But now you have tossed us aside in dishonor.
You no longer lead our armies to battle.
¹⁰You make us retreat from our enemies

and allow those who hate us to plunder our land.

¹¹You have butchered us like sheep
and scattered us among the nations.

¹²You sold your precious people for a pittance,
making nothing on the sale.

¹³You let our neighbors mock us.

We are an object of scorn and derision to those around us.

¹⁴You have made us the butt of their jokes;
they shake their heads at us in scorn.

¹⁵We can't escape the constant humiliation;
shame is written across our faces.

¹⁶All we hear are the taunts of our mockers.
All we see are our vengeful enemies.

¹⁷All this has happened though we have not forgotten you.
We have not violated your covenant.

¹⁸Our hearts have not deserted you.
We have not strayed from your path.

¹⁹Yet you have crushed us in the jackal's desert home.
You have covered us with darkness and death.

²⁰If we had forgotten the name of our God
or spread our hands in prayer to foreign gods,

²¹God would surely have known it,
for he knows the secrets of every heart.

²²But for your sake we are killed every day;
we are being slaughtered like sheep.

²³Wake up, O Lord! Why do you sleep?
Get up! Do not reject us forever.

²⁴Why do you look the other way?
Why do you ignore our suffering and oppression?

²⁵We collapse in the dust,

lying face down in the dirt.

²⁶Rise up! Help us!

Ransom us because of your unfailing love.

45

For the choir director: A love song to be sung to the tune "Lilies." A psalm of the descendants of Korah.



BEAUTIFUL words stir my heart.

I will recite a lovely poem about the king,
for my tongue is like the pen of a skillful poet.

²You are the most handsome of all.

Gracious words stream from your lips.

God himself has blessed you forever.

³Put on your sword, O mighty warrior!

You are so glorious, so majestic!

⁴In your majesty, ride out to victory,

defending truth, humility, and justice.

Go forth to perform awe-inspiring deeds!

⁵Your arrows are sharp, piercing your enemies' hearts.

The nations fall beneath your feet.

⁶Your throne, O God, endures forever and ever.

You rule with a scepter of justice.

⁷You love justice and hate evil.

Therefore God, your God, has anointed you,

pouring out the oil of joy on you more than on anyone else.

⁸Myrrh, aloes, and cassia perfume your robes.

In ivory palaces the music of strings entertains you.

⁹Kings' daughters are among your noble women.

At your right side stands the queen,

wearing jewelry of finest gold from Ophir!

- ¹⁰Listen to me, O royal daughter; take to heart what I say.
Forget your people and your family far away.
- ¹¹For your royal husband delights in your beauty;
honor him, for he is your lord.
- ¹²The princess of Tyre will shower you with gifts.
The wealthy will beg your favor.
- ¹³The bride, a princess, looks glorious
in her golden gown.
- ¹⁴In her beautiful robes, she is led to the king,
accompanied by her bridesmaids.
- ¹⁵What a joyful and enthusiastic procession
as they enter the king's palace!
- ¹⁶Your sons will become kings like their father.
You will make them rulers over many lands.
- ¹⁷I will bring honor to your name in every generation.
Therefore, the nations will praise you forever and ever.

46

*For the choir director: A song of the descendants of Korah, to be sung by
soprano voices.*



- OD is our refuge and strength,
always ready to help in times of trouble.
- ²So we will not fear when earthquakes come
and the mountains crumble into the sea.
- ³Let the oceans roar and foam.
Let the mountains tremble as the waters surge!

Interlude

- ⁴A river brings joy to the city of our God,

- the sacred home of the Most High.
5 God dwells in that city; it cannot be destroyed.
From the very break of day, God will protect it.
6 The nations are in chaos,
and their kingdoms crumble!
God's voice thunders,
and the earth melts!
7 The Lord of Heaven's Armies is here among us;
the God of Israel is our fortress.

Interlude

- 8 Come, see the glorious works of the Lord:
See how he brings destruction upon the world.
9 He causes wars to end throughout the earth.
He breaks the bow and snaps the spear;
he burns the shields with fire.

- 10 "Be still, and know that I am God!
I will be honored by every nation.
I will be honored throughout the world."

- 11 The Lord of Heaven's Armies is here among us;
the God of Israel is our fortress.

Interlude

47

For the choir director: A psalm of the descendants of Korah.



OME, everyone! Clap your hands!
Shout to God with joyful praise!

- ²For the Lord Most High is awesome.
He is the great King of all the earth.
³He subdues the nations before us,
putting our enemies beneath our feet.
⁴He chose the Promised Land as our inheritance,
the proud possession of Jacob's descendants, whom he loves.

Interlude

- ⁵God has ascended with a mighty shout.
The Lord has ascended with trumpets blaring.
⁶Sing praises to God, sing praises;
sing praises to our King, sing praises!
⁷For God is the King over all the earth.
Praise him with a psalm.
⁸God reigns above the nations,
sitting on his holy throne.
⁹The rulers of the world have gathered together
with the people of the God of Abraham.
For all the kings of the earth belong to God.
He is highly honored everywhere.

48

A song. A psalm of the descendants of Korah.

ow great is the Lord,
how deserving of praise,
in the city of our God,
which sits on his holy mountain!
²It is high and magnificent;
the whole earth rejoices to see it!
Mount Zion, the holy mountain,
is the city of the great King!

³God himself is in Jerusalem's towers,
revealing himself as its defender.

⁴The kings of the earth joined forces
and advanced against the city.

⁵But when they saw it, they were stunned;
they were terrified and ran away.

⁶They were gripped with terror
and writhed in pain like a woman in labor.

⁷You destroyed them like the mighty ships of Tarshish
shattered by a powerful east wind.

⁸We had heard of the city's glory,
but now we have seen it ourselves—
the city of the Lord of Heaven's Armies.
It is the city of our God;
he will make it safe forever.

Interlude

⁹O God, we meditate on your unfailing love
as we worship in your Temple.

¹⁰As your name deserves, O God,
you will be praised to the ends of the earth.
Your strong right hand is filled with victory.

¹¹Let the people on Mount Zion rejoice.
Let all the towns of Judah be glad
because of your justice.

¹²Go, inspect the city of Jerusalem.
Walk around and count the many towers.

¹³Take note of the fortified walls,

and tour all the citadels,
that you may describe them
to future generations.
¹⁴For that is what God is like.
He is our God forever and ever,
and he will guide us until we die.

49

For the choir director: A psalm of the descendants of Korah.



LISTEN to this, all you people!
Pay attention, everyone in the world!
²High and low,
rich and poor—listen!
³For my words are wise,
and my thoughts are filled with insight.
⁴I listen carefully to many proverbs
and solve riddles with inspiration from a harp.

⁵Why should I fear when trouble comes,
when enemies surround me?
⁶They trust in their wealth
and boast of great riches.
⁷Yet they cannot redeem themselves from death
by paying a ransom to God.
⁸Redemption does not come so easily,
for no one can ever pay enough
⁹to live forever
and never see the grave.

¹⁰Those who are wise must finally die,

- just like the foolish and senseless,
leaving all their wealth behind.
¹¹The grave is their eternal home,
where they will stay forever.
They may name their estates after themselves,
¹²but their fame will not last.
They will die, just like animals.
¹³This is the fate of fools,
though they are remembered as being wise.

Interlude

- ¹⁴Like sheep, they are led to the grave,
where death will be their shepherd.
In the morning the godly will rule over them.
Their bodies will rot in the grave,
far from their grand estates.
¹⁵But as for me, God will redeem my life.
He will snatch me from the power of the grave.

Interlude

- ¹⁶So don't be dismayed when the wicked grow rich
and their homes become ever more splendid.
¹⁷For when they die, they take nothing with them.
Their wealth will not follow them into the grave.
¹⁸In this life they consider themselves fortunate
and are applauded for their success.
¹⁹But they will die like all before them
and never again see the light of day.
²⁰People who boast of their wealth don't understand;
they will die, just like animals.

50

A psalm of Asaph.



- THE Lord, the Mighty One, is God,
and he has spoken;
he has summoned all humanity
from where the sun rises to where it sets.
²From Mount Zion, the perfection of beauty,
God shines in glorious radiance.
³Our God approaches,
and he is not silent.
Fire devours everything in his way,
and a great storm rages around him.
⁴He calls on the heavens above and earth below
to witness the judgment of his people.
⁵*“Bring my faithful people to me—
those who made a covenant with me by giving sacrifices.”*
⁶Then let the heavens proclaim his justice,
for God himself will be the judge.

Interlude

- ⁷*“O my people, listen as I speak.
Here are my charges against you, O Israel:
I am God, your God!*
⁸*I have no complaint about your sacrifices
or the burnt offerings you constantly offer.*
⁹*But I do not need the bulls from your barns
or the goats from your pens.*
¹⁰*For all the animals of the forest are mine,
and I own the cattle on a thousand hills.*
¹¹*I know every bird on the mountains,
and all the animals of the field are mine.*
¹²*If I were hungry, I would not tell you,*

for all the world is mine and everything in it.

¹³Do I eat the meat of bulls?

Do I drink the blood of goats?

¹⁴Make thankfulness your sacrifice to God,
and keep the vows you made to the Most High.

¹⁵Then call on me when you are in trouble,
and I will rescue you,
and you will give me glory.”

¹⁶But God says to the wicked:

“Why bother reciting my decrees
and pretending to obey my covenant?

¹⁷For you refuse my discipline
and treat my words like trash.

¹⁸When you see thieves, you approve of them,
and you spend your time with adulterers.

¹⁹Your mouth is filled with wickedness,
and your tongue is full of lies.

²⁰You sit around and slander your brother—
your own mother’s son.

²¹While you did all this, I remained silent,
and you thought I didn’t care.

But now I will rebuke you,
listing all my charges against you.

²²Repent, all of you who forget me,
or I will tear you apart,
and no one will help you.

²³But giving thanks is a sacrifice that truly honors me.
If you keep to my path,
I will reveal to you the salvation of God.”

51

For the choir director: A psalm of David, regarding the time Nathan the prophet came to him after David had committed adultery with Bathsheba.



- AVE mercy on me, O God,
because of your unfailing love.
Because of your great compassion,
blot out the stain of my sins.
²Wash me clean from my guilt.
Purify me from my sin.
³For I recognize my rebellion;
it haunts me day and night.
⁴Against you, and you alone, have I sinned;
I have done what is evil in your sight.
You will be proved right in what you say,
and your judgment against me is just.
⁵For I was born a sinner—
yes, from the moment my mother conceived me.
⁶But you desire honesty from the womb,
teaching me wisdom even there.
- ⁷Purify me from my sins, and I will be clean;
wash me, and I will be whiter than snow.
⁸Oh, give me back my joy again;
you have broken me—
now let me rejoice.
⁹Don't keep looking at my sins.
Remove the stain of my guilt.
¹⁰Create in me a clean heart, O God.
Renew a loyal spirit within me.
¹¹Do not banish me from your presence,
and don't take your Holy Spirit from me.

- ¹²Restore to me the joy of your salvation,
and make me willing to obey you.
- ¹³Then I will teach your ways to rebels,
and they will return to you.
- ¹⁴Forgive me for shedding blood, O God who saves;
then I will joyfully sing of your forgiveness.
- ¹⁵Unseal my lips, O Lord,
that my mouth may praise you.
- ¹⁶You do not desire a sacrifice, or I would offer one.
You do not want a burnt offering.
- ¹⁷The sacrifice you desire is a broken spirit.
You will not reject a broken and repentant heart, O God.
- ¹⁸Look with favor on Zion and help her;
rebuild the walls of Jerusalem.
- ¹⁹Then you will be pleased with sacrifices offered in the right
spirit—
with burnt offerings and whole burnt offerings.
Then bulls will again be sacrificed on your altar.

52

For the choir director: A psalm of David, regarding the time Doeg the Edomite said to Saul, "David has gone to see Ahimelech."



- WHY do you boast about your crimes, great warrior?
Don't you realize God's justice continues forever?
- ²All day long you plot destruction.
Your tongue cuts like a sharp razor;
you're an expert at telling lies.
- ³You love evil more than good
and lies more than truth.

Interlude

⁴You love to destroy others with your words,
you liar!
⁵But God will strike you down once and for all.
He will pull you from your home
and uproot you from the land of the living.

Interlude

⁶The righteous will see it and be amazed.
They will laugh and say,
⁷“Look what happens to mighty warriors
who do not trust in God.
They trust their wealth instead
and grow more and more bold in their wickedness.”

⁸But I am like an olive tree, thriving in the house of God.
I will always trust in God’s unfailing love.
⁹I will praise you forever, O God,
for what you have done.
I will trust in your good name
in the presence of your faithful people.

53

For the choir director: A meditation; a psalm of David.



ONLY fools say in their hearts,
“There is no God.”

They are corrupt, and their actions are evil;
not one of them does good!

²God looks down from heaven

on the entire human race;
he looks to see if anyone is truly wise,
if anyone seeks God.

³But no, all have turned away;
all have become corrupt.
No one does good,
not a single one!

⁴Will those who do evil never learn?
They eat up my people like bread
and wouldn't think of praying to God.

⁵Terror will grip them,
terror like they have never known before.
God will scatter the bones of your enemies.
You will put them to shame, for God has rejected them.

⁶Who will come from Mount Zion to rescue Israel?
When God restores his people,
Jacob will shout with joy, and Israel will rejoice.

54

For the choir director: A psalm of David, regarding the time the Ziphites came and said to Saul, "We know where David is hiding." To be accompanied by stringed instruments.



OME with great power, O God, and rescue me!
Defend me with your might.

²Listen to my prayer, O God.

Pay attention to my plea.

³For strangers are attacking me;
violent people are trying to kill me.

They care nothing for God.

Interlude

⁴But God is my helper.

The Lord keeps me alive!

⁵May the evil plans of my enemies be turned against them.

Do as you promised and put an end to them.

⁶I will sacrifice a voluntary offering to you;

I will praise your name, O Lord,

for it is good.

⁷For you have rescued me from my troubles

and helped me to triumph over my enemies.

55

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be accompanied by stringed instruments.



ISTEN to my prayer, O God.

Do not ignore my cry for help!

²Please listen and answer me,

for I am overwhelmed by my troubles.

³My enemies shout at me,

making loud and wicked threats.

They bring trouble on me

and angrily hunt me down.

⁴My heart pounds in my chest.

The terror of death assaults me.

⁵Fear and trembling overwhelm me,

and I can't stop shaking.

⁶Oh, that I had wings like a dove;
then I would fly away and rest!

⁷I would fly far away
to the quiet of the wilderness.

Interlude

⁸How quickly I would escape—
far from this wild storm of hatred.

⁹Confuse them, Lord, and frustrate their plans,
for I see violence and conflict in the city.

¹⁰Its walls are patrolled day and night against invaders,
but the real danger is wickedness within the city.

¹¹Everything is falling apart;
threats and cheating are rampant in the streets.

¹²It is not an enemy who taunts me—
I could bear that.

It is not my foes who so arrogantly insult me—
I could have hidden from them.

¹³Instead, it is you—my equal,
my companion and close friend.

¹⁴What good fellowship we once enjoyed
as we walked together to the house of God.

¹⁵Let death stalk my enemies;
let the grave swallow them alive,
for evil makes its home within them.

- ¹⁶But I will call on God,
and the Lord will rescue me.
¹⁷Morning, noon, and night
I cry out in my distress,
and the Lord hears my voice.
¹⁸He ransoms me and keeps me safe
from the battle waged against me,
though many still oppose me.
¹⁹God, who has ruled forever,
will hear me and humble them.

Interlude

For my enemies refuse to change their ways;
they do not fear God.

- ²⁰As for my companion, he betrayed his friends;
he broke his promises.
²¹His words are as smooth as butter,
but in his heart is war.
His words are as soothing as lotion,
but underneath are daggers!

- ²²Give your burdens to the Lord,
and he will take care of you.
He will not permit the godly to slip and fall.

- ²³But you, O God, will send the wicked
down to the pit of destruction.
Murderers and liars will die young,
but I am trusting you to save me.

56

For the choir director: A psalm of David, regarding the time the Philistines seized him in Gath. To be sung to the tune "Dove on Distant Oaks."



- God, have mercy on me,
for people are hounding me.
My foes attack me all day long.
- ²I am constantly hounded by those who slander me,
and many are boldly attacking me.
- ³But when I am afraid,
I will put my trust in you.
- ⁴I praise God for what he has promised.
I trust in God, so why should I be afraid?
What can mere mortals do to me?
- ⁵They are always twisting what I say;
they spend their days plotting to harm me.
- ⁶They come together to spy on me—
watching my every step, eager to kill me.
- ⁷Don't let them get away with their wickedness;
in your anger, O God, bring them down.
- ⁸You keep track of all my sorrows.
You have collected all my tears in your bottle.
You have recorded each one in your book.
- ⁹My enemies will retreat when I call to you for help.
This I know: God is on my side!
- ¹⁰I praise God for what he has promised;
yes, I praise the Lord for what he has promised.
- ¹¹I trust in God, so why should I be afraid?

What can mere mortals do to me?

¹²I will fulfill my vows to you, O God,
and will offer a sacrifice of thanks for your help.

¹³For you have rescued me from death;
you have kept my feet from slipping.
So now I can walk in your presence, O God,
in your life-giving light.

57

For the choir director: A psalm of David, regarding the time he fled from Saul and went into the cave. To be sung to the tune "Do Not Destroy!"



AVE mercy on me, O God, have mercy!

I look to you for protection.

I will hide beneath the shadow of your wings
until the danger passes by.

²I cry out to God Most High,
to God who will fulfill his purpose for me.

³He will send help from heaven to rescue me,
disgracing those who hound me.

Interlude

My God will send forth his unfailing love and faithfulness.

⁴I am surrounded by fierce lions
who greedily devour human prey—
whose teeth pierce like spears and arrows,
and whose tongues cut like swords.

⁵Be exalted, O God, above the highest heavens!
May your glory shine over all the earth.

⁶My enemies have set a trap for me.
I am weary from distress.
They have dug a deep pit in my path,
but they themselves have fallen into it.

Interlude

⁷My heart is confident in you, O God;
my heart is confident.
No wonder I can sing your praises!
⁸Wake up, my heart!
Wake up, O lyre and harp!
I will wake the dawn with my song.
⁹I will thank you, Lord, among all the people.
I will sing your praises among the nations.
¹⁰For your unfailing love is as high as the heavens.
Your faithfulness reaches to the clouds.

¹¹Be exalted, O God, above the highest heavens.
May your glory shine over all the earth.

58

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be sung to the tune "Do Not Destroy!"



USTICE—DO you rulers know the meaning of the word?
Do you judge the people fairly?

²No! You plot injustice in your hearts.

You spread violence throughout the land.

³These wicked people are born sinners;
even from birth they have lied and gone their own way.

⁴They spit venom like deadly snakes;
they are like cobras that refuse to listen,

⁵ignoring the tunes of the snake charmers,
no matter how skillfully they play.

⁶Break off their fangs, O God!

Smash the jaws of these lions, O Lord!

⁷May they disappear like water into thirsty ground.

Make their weapons useless in their hands.

⁸May they be like snails that dissolve into slime,
like a stillborn child who will never see the sun.

⁹God will sweep them away, both young and old,
faster than a pot heats over burning thorns.

¹⁰The godly will rejoice when they see injustice avenged.

They will wash their feet in the blood of the wicked.

¹¹Then at last everyone will say,

“There truly is a reward for those who live for God;
surely there is a God who judges justly here on earth.”

59

For the choir director: A psalm of David, regarding the time Saul sent soldiers to watch David's house in order to kill him. To be sung to the tune "Do Not Destroy!"



RESCUE me from my enemies, O God.

Protect me from those who have come to destroy me.

²Rescue me from these criminals;

save me from these murderers.

³They have set an ambush for me.

Fierce enemies are out there waiting, Lord,
though I have not sinned or offended them.

⁴I have done nothing wrong,
yet they prepare to attack me.

Wake up! See what is happening and help me!

⁵O Lord God of Heaven's Armies, the God of Israel,
wake up and punish those hostile nations.

Show no mercy to wicked traitors.

Interlude

⁶They come out at night,
snarling like vicious dogs
as they prowl the streets.

⁷Listen to the filth that comes from their mouths;
their words cut like swords.

"After all, who can hear us?" they sneer.

⁸But Lord, you laugh at them.

You scoff at all the hostile nations.

⁹You are my strength; I wait for you to rescue me,
for you, O God, are my fortress.

¹⁰In his unfailing love, my God will stand with me.
He will let me look down in triumph on all my enemies.

¹¹Don't kill them, for my people soon forget such lessons;
stagger them with your power, and bring them to their knees,
O Lord our shield.

¹²Because of the sinful things they say,
because of the evil that is on their lips,
let them be captured by their pride,
their curses, and their lies.

¹³Destroy them in your anger!
Wipe them out completely!
Then the whole world will know
that God reigns in Israel.

Interlude

¹⁴My enemies come out at night,
snarling like vicious dogs
as they prowl the streets.
¹⁵They scavenge for food
but go to sleep unsatisfied.

¹⁶But as for me, I will sing about your power.
Each morning I will sing with joy about your unfailing love.
For you have been my refuge,
a place of safety when I am in distress.
¹⁷O my Strength, to you I sing praises,
for you, O God, are my refuge,
the God who shows me unfailing love.

60

For the choir director: A psalm of David useful for teaching, regarding the time David fought Aram-naharaim and Aram-zobah, and Joab returned and killed 12,000 Edomites in the Valley of Salt. To be sung to the tune "Lily of the Testimony."



YOU have rejected us, O God, and broken our defenses.
You have been angry with us; now restore us to your favor.
²You have shaken our land and split it open.
Seal the cracks, for the land trembles.
³You have been very hard on us,

making us drink wine that sent us reeling.

⁴But you have raised a banner for those who fear you—
a rallying point in the face of attack.

Interlude

⁵Now rescue your beloved people.

Answer and save us by your power.

⁶God has promised this by his holiness:

“I will divide up Shechem with joy.

I will measure out the valley of Succoth.

⁷Gilead is mine,

and Manasseh, too.

Ephraim, my helmet, will produce my warriors,

and Judah, my scepter, will produce my kings.

⁸But Moab, my washbasin, will become my servant,

and I will wipe my feet on Edom

and shout in triumph over Philistia.”

⁹Who will bring me into the fortified city?

Who will bring me victory over Edom?

¹⁰Have you rejected us, O God?

Will you no longer march with our armies?

¹¹Oh, please help us against our enemies,

for all human help is useless.

¹²With God’s help we will do mighty things,

for he will trample down our foes.

61

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be accompanied by stringed instruments.



God, listen to my cry!

Hear my prayer!
²From the ends of the earth,
I cry to you for help
when my heart is overwhelmed.
Lead me to the towering rock of safety,
³for you are my safe refuge,
a fortress where my enemies cannot reach me.
⁴Let me live forever in your sanctuary,
safe beneath the shelter of your wings!

Interlude

⁵For you have heard my vows, O God.
You have given me an inheritance reserved for those who fear
your name.
⁶Add many years to the life of the king!
May his years span the generations!
⁷May he reign under God's protection forever.
May your unfailing love and faithfulness watch over him.
⁸Then I will sing praises to your name forever
as I fulfill my vows each day.

62

For Jeduthun, the choir director: A psalm of David.



wait quietly before God,
for my victory comes from him.
²He alone is my rock and my salvation,
my fortress where I will never be shaken.

³So many enemies against one man—
all of them trying to kill me.

To them I'm just a broken-down wall
or a tottering fence.

⁴They plan to topple me from my high position.

They delight in telling lies about me.

They praise me to my face

but curse me in their hearts.

Interlude

⁵Let all that I am wait quietly before God,
for my hope is in him.

⁶He alone is my rock and my salvation,
my fortress where I will not be shaken.

⁷My victory and honor come from God alone.

He is my refuge, a rock where no enemy can reach me.

⁸O my people, trust in him at all times.

Pour out your heart to him,
for God is our refuge.

Interlude

⁹Common people are as worthless as a puff of wind,
and the powerful are not what they appear to be.

If you weigh them on the scales,
together they are lighter than a breath of air.

¹⁰Don't make your living by extortion
or put your hope in stealing.

And if your wealth increases,
don't make it the center of your life.

¹¹God has spoken plainly,
and I have heard it many times:

Power, O God, belongs to you;
 ¹²unfailing love, O Lord, is yours.
Surely you repay all people
 according to what they have done.

63

A psalm of David, regarding a time when David was in the wilderness of Judah.



God, you are my God;
 I earnestly search for you.
My soul thirsts for you;
 my whole body longs for you
in this parched and weary land
 where there is no water.
²I have seen you in your sanctuary
 and gazed upon your power and glory.
³Your unfailing love is better than life itself;
 how I praise you!
⁴I will praise you as long as I live,
 lifting up my hands to you in prayer.
⁵You satisfy me more than the richest feast.
 I will praise you with songs of joy.

⁶I lie awake thinking of you,
 meditating on you through the night.
⁷Because you are my helper,
 I sing for joy in the shadow of your wings.
⁸I cling to you;
 your strong right hand holds me securely.

⁹But those plotting to destroy me will come to ruin.

- They will go down into the depths of the earth.
¹⁰They will die by the sword
and become the food of jackals.
¹¹But the king will rejoice in God.
All who swear to tell the truth will praise him,
while liars will be silenced.

64

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



- God, listen to my complaint.
Protect my life from my enemies' threats.
²Hide me from the plots of this evil mob,
from this gang of wrongdoers.
³They sharpen their tongues like swords
and aim their bitter words like arrows.
⁴They shoot from ambush at the innocent,
attacking suddenly and fearlessly.
⁵They encourage each other to do evil
and plan how to set their traps in secret.
"Who will ever notice?" they ask.
⁶As they plot their crimes, they say,
"We have devised the perfect plan!"
Yes, the human heart and mind are cunning.

⁷But God himself will shoot them with his arrows,
suddenly striking them down.
⁸Their own tongues will ruin them,
and all who see them will shake their heads in scorn.
⁹Then everyone will be afraid;
they will proclaim the mighty acts of God
and realize all the amazing things he does.

¹⁰The godly will rejoice in the Lord
and find shelter in him.
And those who do what is right
will praise him.

65

For the choir director: A song. A psalm of David.



WHAT mighty praise, O God,
belongs to you in Zion.

We will fulfill our vows to you,
²for you answer our prayers.
All of us must come to you.

³Though we are overwhelmed by our sins,
you forgive them all.

⁴What joy for those you choose to bring near,
those who live in your holy courts.

What festivities await us
inside your holy Temple.

⁵You faithfully answer our prayers with awesome deeds,
O God our savior.

You are the hope of everyone on earth,
even those who sail on distant seas.

⁶You formed the mountains by your power
and armed yourself with mighty strength.

⁷You quieted the raging oceans
with their pounding waves
and silenced the shouting of the nations.

⁸Those who live at the ends of the earth
stand in awe of your wonders.

From where the sun rises to where it sets,

you inspire shouts of joy.

- ⁹You take care of the earth and water it,
making it rich and fertile.
The river of God has plenty of water;
it provides a bountiful harvest of grain,
for you have ordered it so.
- ¹⁰You drench the plowed ground with rain,
melting the clods and leveling the ridges.
You soften the earth with showers
and bless its abundant crops.
- ¹¹You crown the year with a bountiful harvest;
even the hard pathways overflow with abundance.
- ¹²The grasslands of the wilderness become a lush pasture,
and the hillsides blossom with joy.
- ¹³The meadows are clothed with flocks of sheep,
and the valleys are carpeted with grain.
They all shout and sing for joy!

66

For the choir director: A song. A psalm.



- SHOUT joyful praises to God, all the earth!
²Sing about the glory of his name!
Tell the world how glorious he is.
- ³Say to God, "How awesome are your deeds!
Your enemies cringe before your mighty power.
- ⁴Everything on earth will worship you;
they will sing your praises,
shouting your name in glorious songs."

Interlude

Psalms 66

- ⁵Come and see what our God has done,
what awesome miracles he performs for people!
⁶He made a dry path through the Red Sea,
and his people went across on foot.
There we rejoiced in him.
⁷For by his great power he rules forever.
He watches every movement of the nations;
let no rebel rise in defiance.

Interlude

- ⁸Let the whole world bless our God
and loudly sing his praises.
⁹Our lives are in his hands,
and he keeps our feet from stumbling.
¹⁰You have tested us, O God;
you have purified us like silver.
¹¹You captured us in your net
and laid the burden of slavery on our backs.
¹²Then you put a leader over us.
We went through fire and flood,
but you brought us to a place of great abundance.

- ¹³Now I come to your Temple with burnt offerings
to fulfill the vows I made to you—
¹⁴yes, the sacred vows that I made
when I was in deep trouble.
¹⁵That is why I am sacrificing burnt offerings to you—
the best of my rams as a pleasing aroma,
and a sacrifice of bulls and male goats.

Interlude

- ¹⁶Come and listen, all you who fear God,

and I will tell you what he did for me.

¹⁷For I cried out to him for help,
praising him as I spoke.

¹⁸If I had not confessed the sin in my heart,
the Lord would not have listened.

¹⁹But God did listen!

He paid attention to my prayer.

²⁰Praise God, who did not ignore my prayer
or withdraw his unfailing love from me.

67

For the choir director: A song. A psalm, to be accompanied by stringed instruments.



AY God be merciful and bless us.

May his face smile with favor on us.

Interlude

²May your ways be known throughout the earth,
your saving power among people everywhere.

³May the nations praise you, O God.

Yes, may all the nations praise you.

⁴Let the whole world sing for joy,
because you govern the nations with justice
and guide the people of the whole world.

Interlude

⁵May the nations praise you, O God.

Yes, may all the nations praise you.

⁶Then the earth will yield its harvests,
and God, our God, will richly bless us.

⁷Yes, God will bless us,
and people all over the world will fear him.

68

For the choir director: A song. A psalm of David.



RISE up, O God, and scatter your enemies.
Let those who hate God run for their lives.
²Blow them away like smoke.
Melt them like wax in a fire.
Let the wicked perish in the presence of God.
³But let the godly rejoice.
Let them be glad in God's presence.
Let them be filled with joy.
⁴Sing praises to God and to his name!
Sing loud praises to him who rides the clouds.
His name is the Lord—
rejoice in his presence!

⁵Father to the fatherless, defender of widows—
this is God, whose dwelling is holy.
⁶God places the lonely in families;
he sets the prisoners free and gives them joy.
But he makes the rebellious live in a sun-scorched land.

⁷O God, when you led your people out from Egypt,
when you marched through the dry wasteland,

Interlude

⁸the earth trembled, and the heavens poured down rain

- before you, the God of Sinai,
before God, the God of Israel.
- ⁹You sent abundant rain, O God,
to refresh the weary land.
- ¹⁰There your people finally settled,
and with a bountiful harvest, O God,
you provided for your needy people.
- ¹¹The Lord gives the word,
and a great army brings the good news.
- ¹²Enemy kings and their armies flee,
while the women of Israel divide the plunder.
- ¹³Even those who lived among the sheepfolds found treasures—
doves with wings of silver
and feathers of gold.
- ¹⁴The Almighty scattered the enemy kings
like a blowing snowstorm on Mount Zalmon.
- ¹⁵The mountains of Bashan are majestic,
with many peaks stretching high into the sky.
- ¹⁶Why do you look with envy, O rugged mountains,
at Mount Zion, where God has chosen to live,
where the Lord himself will live forever?
- ¹⁷Surrounded by unnumbered thousands of chariots,
the Lord came from Mount Sinai into his sanctuary.
- ¹⁸When you ascended to the heights,
you led a crowd of captives.
- You received gifts from the people,
even from those who rebelled against you.
Now the Lord God will live among us there.

¹⁹Praise the Lord; praise God our savior!
For each day he carries us in his arms.

Interlude

²⁰Our God is a God who saves!
The Sovereign Lord rescues us from death.

²¹But God will smash the heads of his enemies,
crushing the skulls of those who love their guilty ways.
²²The Lord says, “I will bring my enemies down from Bashan;
I will bring them up from the depths of the sea.
²³You, my people, will wash your feet in their blood,
and even your dogs will get their share!”

²⁴Your procession has come into view, O God—
the procession of my God and King as he goes into the sanctuary.
²⁵Singers are in front, musicians behind;
between them are young women playing tambourines.
²⁶Praise God, all you people of Israel;
praise the Lord, the source of Israel’s life.
²⁷Look, the little tribe of Benjamin leads the way.
Then comes a great throng of rulers from Judah
and all the rulers of Zebulun and Naphtali.

²⁸Summon your might, O God.
Display your power, O God, as you have in the past.
²⁹The kings of the earth are bringing tribute
to your Temple in Jerusalem.
³⁰Rebuke these enemy nations—
these wild animals lurking in the reeds,

this herd of bulls among the weaker calves.
Make them bring bars of silver in humble tribute.
Scatter the nations that delight in war.
³¹Let Egypt come with gifts of precious metals;
let Ethiopia bring tribute to God.
³²Sing to God, you kingdoms of the earth.
Sing praises to the Lord.

Interlude

³³Sing to the one who rides across the ancient heavens,
his mighty voice thundering from the sky.
³⁴Tell everyone about God's power.
His majesty shines down on Israel;
his strength is mighty in the heavens.
³⁵God is awesome in his sanctuary.
The God of Israel gives power and strength to his people.

Praise be to God!

69

For the choir director: A psalm of David, to be sung to the tune "Lilies."



AVE me, O God,
for the floodwaters are up to my neck.
²Deeper and deeper I sink into the mire;
I can't find a foothold.
I am in deep water,
and the floods overwhelm me.
³I am exhausted from crying for help;
my throat is parched.
My eyes are swollen with weeping,

waiting for my God to help me.

⁴Those who hate me without cause
outnumber the hairs on my head.
Many enemies try to destroy me with lies,
demanding that I give back what I didn't steal.

⁵O God, you know how foolish I am;
my sins cannot be hidden from you.
⁶Don't let those who trust in you be ashamed because of me,
O Sovereign Lord of Heaven's Armies.
Don't let me cause them to be humiliated,
O God of Israel.
⁷For I endure insults for your sake;
humiliation is written all over my face.
⁸Even my own brothers pretend they don't know me;
they treat me like a stranger.

⁹Passion for your house has consumed me,
and the insults of those who insult you have fallen on me.
¹⁰When I weep and fast,
they scoff at me.
¹¹When I dress in burlap to show sorrow,
they make fun of me.
¹²I am the favorite topic of town gossip,
and all the drunks sing about me.

¹³But I keep praying to you, Lord,
hoping this time you will show me favor.
In your unfailing love, O God,
answer my prayer with your sure salvation.
¹⁴Rescue me from the mud;

- don't let me sink any deeper!
Save me from those who hate me,
and pull me from these deep waters.
- ¹⁵Don't let the floods overwhelm me,
or the deep waters swallow me,
or the pit of death devour me.
- ¹⁶Answer my prayers, O Lord,
for your unfailing love is wonderful.
Take care of me,
for your mercy is so plentiful.
- ¹⁷Don't hide from your servant;
answer me quickly, for I am in deep trouble!
- ¹⁸Come and redeem me;
free me from my enemies.
- ¹⁹You know of my shame, scorn, and disgrace.
You see all that my enemies are doing.
- ²⁰Their insults have broken my heart,
and I am in despair.
If only one person would show some pity;
if only one would turn and comfort me.
- ²¹But instead, they give me poison for food;
they offer me sour wine for my thirst.
- ²²Let the bountiful table set before them become a snare
and their prosperity become a trap.
- ²³Let their eyes go blind so they cannot see,
and make their bodies shake continually.
- ²⁴Pour out your fury on them;
consume them with your burning anger.

²⁵Let their homes become desolate
and their tents be deserted.

²⁶To the one you have punished, they add insult to injury;
they add to the pain of those you have hurt.

²⁷Pile their sins up high,
and don't let them go free.

²⁸Erase their names from the Book of Life;
don't let them be counted among the righteous.

²⁹I am suffering and in pain.
Rescue me, O God, by your saving power.

³⁰Then I will praise God's name with singing,
and I will honor him with thanksgiving.

³¹For this will please the Lord more than sacrificing cattle,
more than presenting a bull with its horns and hooves.

³²The humble will see their God at work and be glad.
Let all who seek God's help be encouraged.

³³For the Lord hears the cries of the needy;
he does not despise his imprisoned people.

³⁴Praise him, O heaven and earth,
the seas and all that move in them.

³⁵For God will save Jerusalem
and rebuild the towns of Judah.

His people will live there
and settle in their own land.

³⁶The descendants of those who obey him will inherit the land,
and those who love him will live there in safety.

70

For the choir director: A psalm of David, asking God to remember him.



PLEASE, God, rescue me!

Come quickly, Lord, and help me.

²May those who try to kill me
be humiliated and put to shame.

May those who take delight in my trouble
be turned back in disgrace.

³Let them be horrified by their shame,
for they said, "Aha! We've got him now!"

⁴But may all who search for you
be filled with joy and gladness in you.

May those who love your salvation
repeatedly shout, "God is great!"

⁵But as for me, I am poor and needy;
please hurry to my aid, O God.

You are my helper and my savior;
O Lord, do not delay.

71



Lord, I have come to you for protection;
don't let me be disgraced.

²Save me and rescue me,
for you do what is right.

Turn your ear to listen to me,
and set me free.

³Be my rock of safety
where I can always hide.

Give the order to save me,
for you are my rock and my fortress.

- ⁴My God, rescue me from the power of the wicked,
from the clutches of cruel oppressors.
- ⁵O Lord, you alone are my hope.
I've trusted you, O Lord, from childhood.
- ⁶Yes, you have been with me from birth;
from my mother's womb you have cared for me.
No wonder I am always praising you!
- ⁷My life is an example to many,
because you have been my strength and protection.
- ⁸That is why I can never stop praising you;
I declare your glory all day long.
- ⁹And now, in my old age, don't set me aside.
Don't abandon me when my strength is failing.
- ¹⁰For my enemies are whispering against me.
They are plotting together to kill me.
- ¹¹They say, "God has abandoned him.
Let's go and get him,
for no one will help him now."
- ¹²O God, don't stay away.
My God, please hurry to help me.
- ¹³Bring disgrace and destruction on my accusers.
Humiliate and shame those who want to harm me.
- ¹⁴But I will keep on hoping for your help;
I will praise you more and more.
- ¹⁵I will tell everyone about your righteousness.
All day long I will proclaim your saving power,
though I am not skilled with words.
- ¹⁶I will praise your mighty deeds, O Sovereign Lord.
I will tell everyone that you alone are just.

¹⁷O God, you have taught me from my earliest childhood,
and I constantly tell others about the wonderful things you
do.

¹⁸Now that I am old and gray,
do not abandon me, O God.

Let me proclaim your power to this new generation,
your mighty miracles to all who come after me.

¹⁹Your righteousness, O God, reaches to the highest heavens.
You have done such wonderful things.
Who can compare with you, O God?

²⁰You have allowed me to suffer much hardship,
but you will restore me to life again
and lift me up from the depths of the earth.

²¹You will restore me to even greater honor
and comfort me once again.

²²Then I will praise you with music on the harp,
because you are faithful to your promises, O my God.
I will sing praises to you with a lyre,
O Holy One of Israel.

²³I will shout for joy and sing your praises,
for you have ransomed me.

²⁴I will tell about your righteous deeds
all day long,
for everyone who tried to hurt me
has been shamed and humiliated.

A psalm of Solomon.

GIVE your love of justice to the king, O God,
and righteousness to the king's son.

²Help him judge your people in the right way;
let the poor always be treated fairly.

³May the mountains yield prosperity for all,
and may the hills be fruitful.

⁴Help him to defend the poor,
to rescue the children of the needy,
and to crush their oppressors.

⁵May they fear you as long as the sun shines,
as long as the moon remains in the sky.
Yes, forever!

⁶May the king's rule be refreshing like spring rain on freshly cut
grass,
like the showers that water the earth.

⁷May all the godly flourish during his reign.
May there be abundant prosperity until the moon is no more.

⁸May he reign from sea to sea,
and from the Euphrates River to the ends of the earth.

⁹Desert nomads will bow before him;
his enemies will fall before him in the dust.

¹⁰The western kings of Tarshish and other distant lands
will bring him tribute.

The eastern kings of Sheba and Seba
will bring him gifts.

¹¹All kings will bow before him,
and all nations will serve him.

¹²He will rescue the poor when they cry to him;
he will help the oppressed, who have no one to defend them.

¹³He feels pity for the weak and the needy,
and he will rescue them.

¹⁴He will redeem them from oppression and violence,
for their lives are precious to him.

¹⁵Long live the king!
May the gold of Sheba be given to him.
May the people always pray for him
and bless him all day long.

¹⁶May there be abundant grain throughout the land,
flourishing even on the hilltops.
May the fruit trees flourish like the trees of Lebanon,
and may the people thrive like grass in a field.

¹⁷May the king's name endure forever;
may it continue as long as the sun shines.
May all nations be blessed through him
and bring him praise.

¹⁸Praise the Lord God, the God of Israel,
who alone does such wonderful things.

¹⁹Praise his glorious name forever!
Let the whole earth be filled with his glory.
Amen and amen!

20(This ends the prayers of David son of Jesse.)

Book 3: Psalms 73-89

73

A psalm of Asaph.



- T**RULY God is good to Israel,
to those whose hearts are pure.
- ²But as for me, I almost lost my footing.
My feet were slipping, and I was almost gone.
- ³For I envied the proud
when I saw them prosper despite their wickedness.
- ⁴They seem to live such painless lives;
their bodies are so healthy and strong.
- ⁵They don't have troubles like other people;
they're not plagued with problems like everyone else.
- ⁶They wear pride like a jeweled necklace
and clothe themselves with cruelty.
- ⁷These fat cats have everything
their hearts could ever wish for!
- ⁸They scoff and speak only evil;
in their pride they seek to crush others.
- ⁹They boast against the very heavens,
and their words strut throughout the earth.
- ¹⁰And so the people are dismayed and confused,
drinking in all their words.
- ¹¹"What does God know?" they ask.
"Does the Most High even know what's happening?"
- ¹²Look at these wicked people—
enjoying a life of ease while their riches multiply.
- ¹³Did I keep my heart pure for nothing?
Did I keep myself innocent for no reason?
- ¹⁴I get nothing but trouble all day long;
every morning brings me pain.

- ¹⁵If I had really spoken this way to others,
I would have been a traitor to your people.
- ¹⁶So I tried to understand why the wicked prosper.
But what a difficult task it is!
- ¹⁷Then I went into your sanctuary, O God,
and I finally understood the destiny of the wicked.
- ¹⁸Truly, you put them on a slippery path
and send them sliding over the cliff to destruction.
- ¹⁹In an instant they are destroyed,
completely swept away by terrors.
- ²⁰When you arise, O Lord,
you will laugh at their silly ideas
as a person laughs at dreams in the morning.
- ²¹Then I realized that my heart was bitter,
and I was all torn up inside.
- ²²I was so foolish and ignorant—
I must have seemed like a senseless animal to you.
- ²³Yet I still belong to you;
you hold my right hand.
- ²⁴You guide me with your counsel,
leading me to a glorious destiny.
- ²⁵Whom have I in heaven but you?
I desire you more than anything on earth.
- ²⁶My health may fail, and my spirit may grow weak,
but God remains the strength of my heart;
he is mine forever.
- ²⁷Those who desert him will perish,
for you destroy those who abandon you.
- ²⁸But as for me, how good it is to be near God!
I have made the Sovereign Lord my shelter,

and I will tell everyone about the wonderful things you do.

74

A psalm of Asaph.



- God, why have you rejected us so long?
Why is your anger so intense against the sheep of your own pasture?
- ²Remember that we are the people you chose long ago,
the tribe you redeemed as your own special possession!
And remember Jerusalem, your home here on earth.
- ³Walk through the awful ruins of the city;
see how the enemy has destroyed your sanctuary.
- ⁴There your enemies shouted their victorious battle cries;
there they set up their battle standards.
- ⁵They swung their axes
like woodcutters in a forest.
- ⁶With axes and picks,
they smashed the carved paneling.
- ⁷They burned your sanctuary to the ground.
They defiled the place that bears your name.
- ⁸Then they thought, "Let's destroy everything!"
So they burned down all the places where God was worshiped.
- ⁹We no longer see your miraculous signs.
All the prophets are gone,
and no one can tell us when it will end.
- ¹⁰How long, O God, will you allow our enemies to insult you?
Will you let them dishonor your name forever?
- ¹¹Why do you hold back your strong right hand?

Unleash your powerful fist and destroy them.

- ¹²You, O God, are my king from ages past,
bringing salvation to the earth.
- ¹³You split the sea by your strength
and smashed the heads of the sea monsters.
- ¹⁴You crushed the heads of Leviathan
and let the desert animals eat him.
- ¹⁵You caused the springs and streams to gush forth,
and you dried up rivers that never run dry.
- ¹⁶Both day and night belong to you;
you made the starlight and the sun.
- ¹⁷You set the boundaries of the earth,
and you made both summer and winter.
- ¹⁸See how these enemies insult you, Lord.
A foolish nation has dishonored your name.
- ¹⁹Don't let these wild beasts destroy your turtledoves.
Don't forget your suffering people forever.
- ²⁰Remember your covenant promises,
for the land is full of darkness and violence!
- ²¹Don't let the downtrodden be humiliated again.
Instead, let the poor and needy praise your name.
- ²²Arise, O God, and defend your cause.
Remember how these fools insult you all day long.
- ²³Don't overlook what your enemies have said
or their growing uproar.

75

For the choir director: A psalm of Asaph. A song to be sung to the tune "Do Not Destroy!"



WE thank you, O God!

We give thanks because you are near.

People everywhere tell of your wonderful deeds.

²God says, "At the time I have planned,
I will bring justice against the wicked.

³When the earth quakes and its people live in turmoil,
I am the one who keeps its foundations firm.

Interlude

⁴"I warned the proud, 'Stop your boasting!'
I told the wicked, 'Don't raise your fists!

⁵Don't raise your fists in defiance at the heavens
or speak with such arrogance."

⁶For no one on earth—from east or west,
or even from the wilderness—
should raise a defiant fist.

⁷It is God alone who judges;
he decides who will rise and who will fall.

⁸For the Lord holds a cup in his hand
that is full of foaming wine mixed with spices.

He pours out the wine in judgment,
and all the wicked must drink it,
draining it to the dregs.

⁹But as for me, I will always proclaim what God has done;
I will sing praises to the God of Jacob.

¹⁰For God says, “I will break the strength of the wicked,
but I will increase the power of the godly.”

76

*For the choir director: A psalm of Asaph. A song to be accompanied by
stringed instruments.*



OD is honored in Judah;
his name is great in Israel.

²Jerusalem is where he lives;
Mount Zion is his home.

³There he has broken the fiery arrows of the enemy,
the shields and swords and weapons of war.

Interlude

⁴You are glorious and more majestic
than the everlasting mountains.

⁵Our boldest enemies have been plundered.
They lie before us in the sleep of death.
No warrior could lift a hand against us.

⁶At the blast of your breath, O God of Jacob,
their horses and chariots lay still.

⁷No wonder you are greatly feared!

Who can stand before you when your anger explodes?

⁸From heaven you sentenced your enemies;
the earth trembled and stood silent before you.

⁹You stand up to judge those who do evil, O God,
and to rescue the oppressed of the earth.

Interlude

¹⁰Human defiance only enhances your glory,
for you use it as a weapon.

¹¹Make vows to the Lord your God, and keep them.
Let everyone bring tribute to the Awesome One.

¹²For he breaks the pride of princes,
and the kings of the earth fear him.

77

For Jeduthun, the choir director: A psalm of Asaph.



cry out to God; yes, I shout.

Oh, that God would listen to me!

²When I was in deep trouble,
I searched for the Lord.

All night long I prayed, with hands lifted toward heaven,
but my soul was not comforted.

³I think of God, and I moan,
overwhelmed with longing for his help.

Interlude

⁴You don't let me sleep.

I am too distressed even to pray!

⁵I think of the good old days,
long since ended,

⁶when my nights were filled with joyful songs.

I search my soul and ponder the difference now.

⁷Has the Lord rejected me forever?

Will he never again be kind to me?

⁸Is his unfailing love gone forever?

Have his promises permanently failed?

- ⁹Has God forgotten to be gracious?
Has he slammed the door on his compassion?

Interlude

- ¹⁰And I said, “This is my fate;
the Most High has turned his hand against me.”
¹¹But then I recall all you have done, O Lord;
I remember your wonderful deeds of long ago.
¹²They are constantly in my thoughts.
I cannot stop thinking about your mighty works.

- ¹³O God, your ways are holy.
Is there any god as mighty as you?
¹⁴You are the God of great wonders!
You demonstrate your awesome power among the nations.
¹⁵By your strong arm, you redeemed your people,
the descendants of Jacob and Joseph.

Interlude

- ¹⁶When the Red Sea saw you, O God,
its waters looked and trembled!
The sea quaked to its very depths.
¹⁷The clouds poured down rain;
the thunder rumbled in the sky.
Your arrows of lightning flashed.
¹⁸Your thunder roared from the whirlwind;
the lightning lit up the world!
The earth trembled and shook.
¹⁹Your road led through the sea,
your pathway through the mighty waters—
a pathway no one knew was there!
²⁰You led your people along that road like a flock of sheep,

with Moses and Aaron as their shepherds.

78

A psalm of Asaph.



my people, listen to my instructions.
Open your ears to what I am saying,
²for I will speak to you in a parable.
I will teach you hidden lessons from our past—
³stories we have heard and known,
stories our ancestors handed down to us.
⁴We will not hide these truths from our children;
we will tell the next generation
about the glorious deeds of the Lord,
about his power and his mighty wonders.
⁵For he issued his laws to Jacob;
he gave his instructions to Israel.
He commanded our ancestors
to teach them to their children,
⁶so the next generation might know them—
even the children not yet born—
and they in turn will teach their own children.
⁷So each generation should set its hope anew on God,
not forgetting his glorious miracles
and obeying his commands.
⁸Then they will not be like their ancestors—
stubborn, rebellious, and unfaithful,
refusing to give their hearts to God.

⁹The warriors of Ephraim, though armed with bows,
turned their backs and fled on the day of battle.
¹⁰They did not keep God's covenant

- and refused to live by his instructions.
- ¹¹They forgot what he had done—
the great wonders he had shown them,
- ¹²the miracles he did for their ancestors
on the plain of Zoan in the land of Egypt.
- ¹³For he divided the sea and led them through,
making the water stand up like walls!
- ¹⁴In the daytime he led them by a cloud,
and all night by a pillar of fire.
- ¹⁵He split open the rocks in the wilderness
to give them water, as from a gushing spring.
- ¹⁶He made streams pour from the rock,
making the waters flow down like a river!
- ¹⁷Yet they kept on sinning against him,
rebellious against the Most High in the desert.
- ¹⁸They stubbornly tested God in their hearts,
demanding the foods they craved.
- ¹⁹They even spoke against God himself, saying,
“God can’t give us food in the wilderness.
- ²⁰Yes, he can strike a rock so water gushes out,
but he can’t give his people bread and meat.”
- ²¹When the Lord heard them, he was furious.
The fire of his wrath burned against Jacob.
Yes, his anger rose against Israel,
- ²²for they did not believe God
or trust him to care for them.
- ²³But he commanded the skies to open;
he opened the doors of heaven.
- ²⁴He rained down manna for them to eat;
he gave them bread from heaven.
- ²⁵They ate the food of angels!
God gave them all they could hold.

²⁶He released the east wind in the heavens
and guided the south wind by his mighty power.

²⁷He rained down meat as thick as dust—
birds as plentiful as the sand on the seashore!

²⁸He caused the birds to fall within their camp
and all around their tents.

²⁹The people ate their fill.
He gave them what they craved.

³⁰But before they satisfied their craving,
while the meat was yet in their mouths,

³¹the anger of God rose against them,
and he killed their strongest men.
He struck down the finest of Israel's young men.

³²But in spite of this, the people kept sinning.
Despite his wonders, they refused to trust him.

³³So he ended their lives in failure,
their years in terror.

³⁴When God began killing them,
they finally sought him.

They repented and took God seriously.

³⁵Then they remembered that God was their rock,
that God Most High was their redeemer.

³⁶But all they gave him was lip service;
they lied to him with their tongues.

³⁷Their hearts were not loyal to him.
They did not keep his covenant.

³⁸Yet he was merciful and forgave their sins
and did not destroy them all.

Many times he held back his anger
and did not unleash his fury!

³⁹For he remembered that they were merely mortal,
gone like a breath of wind that never returns.

- ⁴⁰Oh, how often they rebelled against him in the wilderness
and grieved his heart in that dry wasteland.
- ⁴¹Again and again they tested God's patience
and provoked the Holy One of Israel.
- ⁴²They did not remember his power
and how he rescued them from their enemies.
- ⁴³They did not remember his miraculous signs in Egypt,
his wonders on the plain of Zoan.
- ⁴⁴For he turned their rivers into blood,
so no one could drink from the streams.
- ⁴⁵He sent vast swarms of flies to consume them
and hordes of frogs to ruin them.
- ⁴⁶He gave their crops to caterpillars;
their harvest was consumed by locusts.
- ⁴⁷He destroyed their grapevines with hail
and shattered their sycamore-figs with sleet.
- ⁴⁸He abandoned their cattle to the hail,
their livestock to bolts of lightning.
- ⁴⁹He loosed on them his fierce anger—
all his fury, rage, and hostility.
He dispatched against them
a band of destroying angels.
- ⁵⁰He turned his anger against them;
he did not spare the Egyptians' lives
but ravaged them with the plague.
- ⁵¹He killed the oldest son in each Egyptian family,
the flower of youth throughout the land of Egypt.
- ⁵²But he led his own people like a flock of sheep,
guiding them safely through the wilderness.
- ⁵³He kept them safe so they were not afraid;
but the sea covered their enemies.
- ⁵⁴He brought them to the border of his holy land,
to this land of hills he had won for them.
- ⁵⁵He drove out the nations before them;

he gave them their inheritance by lot.
He settled the tribes of Israel into their homes.

- ⁵⁶But they kept testing and rebelling against God Most High.
They did not obey his laws.
- ⁵⁷They turned back and were as faithless as their parents.
They were as undependable as a crooked bow.
- ⁵⁸They angered God by building shrines to other gods;
they made him jealous with their idols.
- ⁵⁹When God heard them, he was very angry,
and he completely rejected Israel.
- ⁶⁰Then he abandoned his dwelling at Shiloh,
the Tabernacle where he had lived among the people.
- ⁶¹He allowed the Ark of his might to be captured;
he surrendered his glory into enemy hands.
- ⁶²He gave his people over to be butchered by the sword,
because he was so angry with his own people—his special
possession.
- ⁶³Their young men were killed by fire;
their young women died before singing their wedding songs.
- ⁶⁴Their priests were slaughtered,
and their widows could not mourn their deaths.
- ⁶⁵Then the Lord rose up as though waking from sleep,
like a warrior aroused from a drunken stupor.
- ⁶⁶He routed his enemies
and sent them to eternal shame.
- ⁶⁷But he rejected Joseph's descendants;
he did not choose the tribe of Ephraim.
- ⁶⁸He chose instead the tribe of Judah,
and Mount Zion, which he loved.
- ⁶⁹There he built his sanctuary as high as the heavens,

as solid and enduring as the earth.

⁷⁰He chose his servant David,
calling him from the sheep pens.

⁷¹He took David from tending the ewes and lambs
and made him the shepherd of Jacob's descendants—
God's own people, Israel.

⁷²He cared for them with a true heart
and led them with skillful hands.

79

A psalm of Asaph.



God, pagan nations have conquered your land,
your special possession.

They have defiled your holy Temple
and made Jerusalem a heap of ruins.

²They have left the bodies of your servants
as food for the birds of heaven.

The flesh of your godly ones
has become food for the wild animals.

³Blood has flowed like water all around Jerusalem;
no one is left to bury the dead.

⁴We are mocked by our neighbors,
an object of scorn and derision to those around us.

⁵O Lord, how long will you be angry with us? Forever?
How long will your jealousy burn like fire?

⁶Pour out your wrath on the nations that refuse to acknowledge
you—

on kingdoms that do not call upon your name.

⁷For they have devoured your people Israel,
making the land a desolate wilderness.

⁸Do not hold us guilty for the sins of our ancestors!
Let your compassion quickly meet our needs,
for we are on the brink of despair.

⁹Help us, O God of our salvation!
Help us for the glory of your name.
Save us and forgive our sins
for the honor of your name.

¹⁰Why should pagan nations be allowed to scoff,
asking, “Where is their God?”
Show us your vengeance against the nations,
for they have spilled the blood of your servants.

¹¹Listen to the moaning of the prisoners.
Demonstrate your great power by saving those condemned to
die.

¹²O Lord, pay back our neighbors seven times
for the scorn they have hurled at you.

¹³Then we your people, the sheep of your pasture,
will thank you forever and ever,
praising your greatness from generation to generation.

80

*For the choir director: A psalm of Asaph, to be sung to the tune “Lilies of the
Covenant.”*



PLEASE listen, O Shepherd of Israel,
you who lead Joseph's descendants like a flock.

O God, enthroned above the cherubim,
display your radiant glory
²to Ephraim, Benjamin, and Manasseh.

Show us your mighty power.
Come to rescue us!

³Turn us again to yourself, O God.

Make your face shine down upon us.

Only then will we be saved.

⁴O Lord God of Heaven's Armies,

how long will you be angry with our prayers?

⁵You have fed us with sorrow

and made us drink tears by the bucketful.

⁶You have made us the scorn of neighboring nations.

Our enemies treat us as a joke.

⁷Turn us again to yourself, O God of Heaven's Armies.

Make your face shine down upon us.

Only then will we be saved.

⁸You brought us from Egypt like a grapevine;

you drove away the pagan nations and transplanted us into
your land.

⁹You cleared the ground for us,

and we took root and filled the land.

¹⁰Our shade covered the mountains;

our branches covered the mighty cedars.

¹¹We spread our branches west to the Mediterranean Sea;

our shoots spread east to the Euphrates River.

¹²But now, why have you broken down our walls

so that all who pass by may steal our fruit?

¹³The wild boar from the forest devours it,

and the wild animals feed on it.

¹⁴Come back, we beg you, O God of Heaven's Armies.

- Look down from heaven and see our plight.
Take care of this grapevine
 ¹⁵that you yourself have planted,
 this son you have raised for yourself.
¹⁶For we are chopped up and burned by our enemies.
 May they perish at the sight of your frown.
¹⁷Strengthen the man you love,
 the son of your choice.
¹⁸Then we will never abandon you again.
 Revive us so we can call on your name once more.
- ¹⁹Turn us again to yourself, O Lord God of Heaven's Armies.
 Make your face shine down upon us.
 Only then will we be saved.

81

For the choir director: A psalm of Asaph, to be accompanied by a stringed instrument.



- ING praises to God, our strength.
 Sing to the God of Jacob.
²Sing! Beat the tambourine.
 Play the sweet lyre and the harp.
³Blow the ram's horn at new moon,
 and again at full moon to call a festival!
⁴For this is required by the decrees of Israel;
 it is a regulation of the God of Jacob.
⁵He made it a law for Israel
 when he attacked Egypt to set us free.

I heard an unknown voice say,

- ⁶“Now I will take the load from your shoulders;
I will free your hands from their heavy tasks.
⁷You cried to me in trouble, and I saved you;
I answered out of the thundercloud
and tested your faith when there was no water at Meribah.

Interlude

- ⁸“Listen to me, O my people, while I give you stern warnings.
O Israel, if you would only listen to me!
⁹You must never have a foreign god;
you must not bow down before a false god.
¹⁰For it was I, the Lord your God,
who rescued you from the land of Egypt.
Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it with good things.
- ¹¹“But no, my people wouldn’t listen.
Israel did not want me around.
¹²So I let them follow their own stubborn desires,
living according to their own ideas.
¹³Oh, that my people would listen to me!
Oh, that Israel would follow me, walking in my paths!
¹⁴How quickly I would then subdue their enemies!
How soon my hands would be upon their foes!
¹⁵Those who hate the Lord would cringe before him;
they would be doomed forever.
¹⁶But I would feed you with the finest wheat.
I would satisfy you with wild honey from the rock.”

82

A psalm of Asaph.



OD presides over heaven's court;
he pronounces judgment on the heavenly beings:

²“How long will you hand down unjust decisions
by favoring the wicked?”

Interlude

³“Give justice to the poor and the orphan;
uphold the rights of the oppressed and the destitute.

⁴Rescue the poor and helpless;
deliver them from the grasp of evil people.

⁵But these oppressors know nothing;
they are so ignorant!

They wander about in darkness,
while the whole world is shaken to the core.

⁶I say, ‘You are gods;
you are all children of the Most High.

⁷But you will die like mere mortals
and fall like every other ruler.’”

⁸Rise up, O God, and judge the earth,
for all the nations belong to you.

83

A song. A psalm of Asaph.



God, do not be silent!
Do not be deaf.

Do not be quiet, O God.

²Don't you hear the uproar of your enemies?

Don't you see that your arrogant enemies are rising up?

³They devise crafty schemes against your people;
they conspire against your precious ones.

⁴"Come," they say, "let us wipe out Israel as a nation.
We will destroy the very memory of its existence."

⁵Yes, this was their unanimous decision.

They signed a treaty as allies against you—

⁶these Edomites and Ishmaelites;
Moabites and Hagrites;

⁷Gebalites, Ammonites, and Amalekites;
and people from Philistia and Tyre.

⁸Assyria has joined them, too,
and is allied with the descendants of Lot.

Interlude

⁹Do to them as you did to the Midianites
and as you did to Sisera and Jabin at the Kishon River.

¹⁰They were destroyed at Endor,
and their decaying corpses fertilized the soil.

¹¹Let their mighty nobles die as Oreb and Zeeb did.
Let all their princes die like Zebah and Zalmunna,

¹²for they said, "Let us seize for our own use
these pasturelands of God!"

¹³O my God, scatter them like tumbleweed,
like chaff before the wind!

¹⁴As a fire burns a forest
and as a flame sets mountains ablaze,

¹⁵chase them with your fierce storm;
terrify them with your tempest.

¹⁶Utterly disgrace them
until they submit to your name, O Lord.

¹⁷Let them be ashamed and terrified forever.

Let them die in disgrace.

¹⁸Then they will learn that you alone are called the Lord,
that you alone are the Most High,
supreme over all the earth.

84

*For the choir director: A psalm of the descendants of Korah, to be accompanied
by a stringed instrument.*



ow lovely is your dwelling place,
O Lord of Heaven's Armies.

²I long, yes, I faint with longing
to enter the courts of the Lord.

With my whole being, body and soul,
I will shout joyfully to the living God.

³Even the sparrow finds a home,
and the swallow builds her nest and raises her young
at a place near your altar,
O Lord of Heaven's Armies, my King and my God!

⁴What joy for those who can live in your house,
always singing your praises.

Interlude

⁵What joy for those whose strength comes from the Lord,
who have set their minds on a pilgrimage to Jerusalem.

⁶When they walk through the Valley of Weeping,
it will become a place of refreshing springs.
The autumn rains will clothe it with blessings.

⁷They will continue to grow stronger,
and each of them will appear before God in Jerusalem.

⁸O Lord God of Heaven's Armies, hear my prayer.
Listen, O God of Jacob.

Interlude

⁹O God, look with favor upon the king, our shield!
Show favor to the one you have anointed.

¹⁰A single day in your courts
is better than a thousand anywhere else!
I would rather be a gatekeeper in the house of my God
than live the good life in the homes of the wicked.
¹¹For the Lord God is our sun and our shield.
He gives us grace and glory.
The Lord will withhold no good thing
from those who do what is right.
¹²O Lord of Heaven's Armies,
what joy for those who trust in you.

85

For the choir director: A psalm of the descendants of Korah.



ORD, you poured out blessings on your land!
You restored the fortunes of Israel.

²You forgave the guilt of your people—
yes, you covered all their sins.

Interlude

³You held back your fury.
You kept back your blazing anger.

- ⁴Now restore us again, O God of our salvation.
Put aside your anger against us once more.
- ⁵Will you be angry with us always?
Will you prolong your wrath to all generations?
- ⁶Won't you revive us again,
so your people can rejoice in you?
- ⁷Show us your unfailing love, O Lord,
and grant us your salvation.
- ⁸I listen carefully to what God the Lord is saying,
for he speaks peace to his faithful people.
But let them not return to their foolish ways.
- ⁹Surely his salvation is near to those who fear him,
so our land will be filled with his glory.
- ¹⁰Unfailing love and truth have met together.
Righteousness and peace have kissed!
- ¹¹Truth springs up from the earth,
and righteousness smiles down from heaven.
- ¹²Yes, the Lord pours down his blessings.
Our land will yield its bountiful harvest.
- ¹³Righteousness goes as a herald before him,
preparing the way for his steps.

86

A prayer of David.



END down, O Lord, and hear my prayer;
answer me, for I need your help.

- ²Protect me, for I am devoted to you.
Save me, for I serve you and trust you.

You are my God.

³Be merciful to me, O Lord,
for I am calling on you constantly.

⁴Give me happiness, O Lord,
for I give myself to you.

⁵O Lord, you are so good, so ready to forgive,
so full of unfailing love for all who ask for your help.

⁶Listen closely to my prayer, O Lord;
hear my urgent cry.

⁷I will call to you whenever I'm in trouble,
and you will answer me.

⁸No pagan god is like you, O Lord.
None can do what you do!

⁹All the nations you made
will come and bow before you, Lord;
they will praise your holy name.

¹⁰For you are great and perform wonderful deeds.
You alone are God.

¹¹Teach me your ways, O Lord,
that I may live according to your truth!

Grant me purity of heart,
so that I may honor you.

¹²With all my heart I will praise you, O Lord my God.
I will give glory to your name forever,

¹³for your love for me is very great.
You have rescued me from the depths of death.

¹⁴O God, insolent people rise up against me;
a violent gang is trying to kill me.

You mean nothing to them.

¹⁵But you, O Lord,
are a God of compassion and mercy,
slow to get angry
and filled with unfailing love and faithfulness.

¹⁶Look down and have mercy on me.
Give your strength to your servant;
save me, the son of your servant.

¹⁷Send me a sign of your favor.
Then those who hate me will be put to shame,
for you, O Lord, help and comfort me.

87

A song. A psalm of the descendants of Korah.



IN the holy mountain
stands the city founded by the Lord.

²He loves the city of Jerusalem
more than any other city in Israel.

³O city of God,
what glorious things are said of you!

Interlude

⁴I will count Egypt and Babylon among those who know me—
also Philistia and Tyre, and even distant Ethiopia.
They have all become citizens of Jerusalem!

⁵Regarding Jerusalem it will be said,
“Everyone enjoys the rights of citizenship there.”
And the Most High will personally bless this city.

⁶When the Lord registers the nations, he will say,
“They have all become citizens of Jerusalem.”

Interlude

⁷The people will play flutes and sing,
“The source of my life springs from Jerusalem!”

88

For the choir director: A psalm of the descendants of Korah. A song to be sung to the tune “The Suffering of Affliction.” A psalm of Heman the Ezrahite.



Lord, God of my salvation,
I cry out to you by day.
I come to you at night.
²Now hear my prayer;
listen to my cry.
³For my life is full of troubles,
and death draws near.
⁴I am as good as dead,
like a strong man with no strength left.
⁵They have left me among the dead,
and I lie like a corpse in a grave.
I am forgotten,
cut off from your care.
⁶You have thrown me into the lowest pit,
into the darkest depths.
⁷Your anger weighs me down;
with wave after wave you have engulfed me.

Interlude

⁸You have driven my friends away
by making me repulsive to them.
I am in a trap with no way of escape.
⁹My eyes are blinded by my tears.
Each day I beg for your help, O Lord;
I lift my hands to you for mercy.

- ¹⁰Are your wonderful deeds of any use to the dead?
Do the dead rise up and praise you?

Interlude

- ¹¹Can those in the grave declare your unfailing love?
Can they proclaim your faithfulness in the place of destruction?
- ¹²Can the darkness speak of your wonderful deeds?
Can anyone in the land of forgetfulness talk about your righteousness?
- ¹³O Lord, I cry out to you.
I will keep on pleading day by day.
- ¹⁴O Lord, why do you reject me?
Why do you turn your face from me?
- ¹⁵I have been sick and close to death since my youth.
I stand helpless and desperate before your terrors.
- ¹⁶Your fierce anger has overwhelmed me.
Your terrors have paralyzed me.
- ¹⁷They swirl around me like floodwaters all day long.
They have engulfed me completely.
- ¹⁸You have taken away my companions and loved ones.
Darkness is my closest friend.

89

A psalm of Ethan the Ezrahite.



will sing of the Lord's unfailing love forever!
Young and old will hear of your faithfulness.
²Your unfailing love will last forever.
Your faithfulness is as enduring as the heavens.

³The Lord said, “I have made a covenant with David, my chosen servant.

I have sworn this oath to him:

⁴“I will establish your descendants as kings forever;
they will sit on your throne from now until eternity.”

Interlude

⁵All heaven will praise your great wonders, Lord;
myriads of angels will praise you for your faithfulness.

⁶For who in all of heaven can compare with the Lord?
What mightiest angel is anything like the Lord?

⁷The highest angelic powers stand in awe of God.
He is far more awesome than all who surround his throne.

⁸O Lord God of Heaven’s Armies!
Where is there anyone as mighty as you, O Lord?
You are entirely faithful.

⁹You rule the oceans.
You subdue their storm-tossed waves.

¹⁰You crushed the great sea monster.
You scattered your enemies with your mighty arm.

¹¹The heavens are yours, and the earth is yours;
everything in the world is yours—you created it all.

¹²You created north and south.
Mount Tabor and Mount Hermon praise your name.

¹³Powerful is your arm!
Strong is your hand!
Your right hand is lifted high in glorious strength.

¹⁴Righteousness and justice are the foundation of your throne.
Unfailing love and truth walk before you as attendants.

¹⁵Happy are those who hear the joyful call to worship,
for they will walk in the light of your presence, Lord.

¹⁶They rejoice all day long in your wonderful reputation.

They exult in your righteousness.

¹⁷You are their glorious strength.

It pleases you to make us strong.

¹⁸Yes, our protection comes from the Lord,

and he, the Holy One of Israel, has given us our king.

¹⁹Long ago you spoke in a vision to your faithful people.

You said, "I have raised up a warrior.

I have selected him from the common people to be king.

²⁰I have found my servant David.

I have anointed him with my holy oil.

²¹I will steady him with my hand;

with my powerful arm I will make him strong.

²²His enemies will not defeat him,

nor will the wicked overpower him.

²³I will beat down his adversaries before him

and destroy those who hate him.

²⁴My faithfulness and unfailing love will be with him,

and by my authority he will grow in power.

²⁵I will extend his rule over the sea,

his dominion over the rivers.

²⁶And he will call out to me, 'You are my Father,

my God, and the Rock of my salvation.'

²⁷I will make him my firstborn son,

the mightiest king on earth.

²⁸I will love him and be kind to him forever;

my covenant with him will never end.

²⁹I will preserve an heir for him;

his throne will be as endless as the days of heaven.

³⁰But if his descendants forsake my instructions

and fail to obey my regulations,

³¹if they do not obey my decrees

- and fail to keep my commands,
³²then I will punish their sin with the rod,
and their disobedience with beating.
³³But I will never stop loving him
nor fail to keep my promise to him.
³⁴No, I will not break my covenant;
I will not take back a single word I said.
³⁵I have sworn an oath to David,
and in my holiness I cannot lie:
³⁶His dynasty will go on forever;
his kingdom will endure as the sun.
³⁷It will be as eternal as the moon,
my faithful witness in the sky!”

Interlude

- ³⁸But now you have rejected him and cast him off.
You are angry with your anointed king.
³⁹You have renounced your covenant with him;
you have thrown his crown in the dust.
⁴⁰You have broken down the walls protecting him
and ruined every fort defending him.
⁴¹Everyone who comes along has robbed him,
and he has become a joke to his neighbors.
⁴²You have strengthened his enemies
and made them all rejoice.
⁴³You have made his sword useless
and refused to help him in battle.
⁴⁴You have ended his splendor
and overturned his throne.
⁴⁵You have made him old before his time
and publicly disgraced him.

Interlude

- ⁴⁶O Lord, how long will this go on?
Will you hide yourself forever?
How long will your anger burn like fire?
- ⁴⁷Remember how short my life is,
how empty and futile this human existence!
- ⁴⁸No one can live forever; all will die.
No one can escape the power of the grave.

Interlude

- ⁴⁹Lord, where is your unfailing love?
You promised it to David with a faithful pledge.
- ⁵⁰Consider, Lord, how your servants are disgraced!
I carry in my heart the insults of so many people.
- ⁵¹Your enemies have mocked me, O Lord;
they mock your anointed king wherever he goes.
- ⁵²Praise the Lord forever!
Amen and amen!

Book Four: Psalms 90-106

90

A prayer of Moses, the man of God.



ORD, through all the generations
you have been our home!

²Before the mountains were born,
before you gave birth to the earth and the world,
from beginning to end, you are God.

- ³You turn people back to dust, saying,
“Return to dust, you mortals!”
- ⁴For you, a thousand years are as a passing day,
as brief as a few night hours.
- ⁵You sweep people away like dreams that disappear.
They are like grass that springs up in the morning.
- ⁶In the morning it blooms and flourishes,
but by evening it is dry and withered.
- ⁷We wither beneath your anger;
we are overwhelmed by your fury.
- ⁸You spread out our sins before you—
our secret sins—and you see them all.
- ⁹We live our lives beneath your wrath,
ending our years with a groan.
- ¹⁰Seventy years are given to us!
Some even live to eighty.
But even the best years are filled with pain and trouble;
soon they disappear, and we fly away.
- ¹¹Who can comprehend the power of your anger?
Your wrath is as awesome as the fear you deserve.
- ¹²Teach us to realize the brevity of life,
so that we may grow in wisdom.
- ¹³O Lord, come back to us!
How long will you delay?
Take pity on your servants!
- ¹⁴Satisfy us each morning with your unfailing love,
so we may sing for joy to the end of our lives.
- ¹⁵Give us gladness in proportion to our former misery!
Replace the evil years with good.
- ¹⁶Let us, your servants, see you work again;

let our children see your glory.
¹⁷And may the Lord our God show us his approval
and make our efforts successful.
Yes, make our efforts successful!

91



HOSE who live in the shelter of the Most High
will find rest in the shadow of the Almighty.

- ²This I declare about the Lord:
He alone is my refuge, my place of safety;
he is my God, and I trust him.
- ³For he will rescue you from every trap
and protect you from deadly disease.
- ⁴He will cover you with his feathers.
He will shelter you with his wings.
His faithful promises are your armor and protection.
- ⁵Do not be afraid of the terrors of the night,
nor the arrow that flies in the day.
- ⁶Do not dread the disease that stalks in darkness,
nor the disaster that strikes at midday.
- ⁷Though a thousand fall at your side,
though ten thousand are dying around you,
these evils will not touch you.
- ⁸Just open your eyes,
and see how the wicked are punished.
- ⁹If you make the Lord your refuge,
if you make the Most High your shelter,
- ¹⁰no evil will conquer you;
no plague will come near your home.
- ¹¹For he will order his angels

- to protect you wherever you go.
- ¹²They will hold you up with their hands
so you won't even hurt your foot on a stone.
- ¹³You will trample upon lions and cobras;
you will crush fierce lions and serpents under your feet!
- ¹⁴The Lord says, "I will rescue those who love me.
I will protect those who trust in my name.
- ¹⁵When they call on me, I will answer;
I will be with them in trouble.
I will rescue and honor them.
- ¹⁶I will reward them with a long life
and give them my salvation."

92

A psalm. A song to be sung on the Sabbath Day.



- It is good to give thanks to the Lord,
to sing praises to the Most High.
- ²It is good to proclaim your unfailing love in the morning,
your faithfulness in the evening,
- ³accompanied by a ten-stringed instrument, a harp,
and the melody of a lyre.
- ⁴You thrill me, Lord, with all you have done for me!
I sing for joy because of what you have done.
- ⁵O Lord, what great works you do!
And how deep are your thoughts.
- ⁶Only a simpleton would not know,
and only a fool would not understand this:
- ⁷Though the wicked sprout like weeds

and evildoers flourish,
they will be destroyed forever.

⁸But you, O Lord, will be exalted forever.

⁹Your enemies, Lord, will surely perish;
all evildoers will be scattered.

¹⁰But you have made me as strong as a wild ox.
You have anointed me with the finest oil.

¹¹My eyes have seen the downfall of my enemies;
my ears have heard the defeat of my wicked opponents.

¹²But the godly will flourish like palm trees
and grow strong like the cedars of Lebanon.

¹³For they are transplanted to the Lord's own house.
They flourish in the courts of our God.

¹⁴Even in old age they will still produce fruit;
they will remain vital and green.

¹⁵They will declare, "The Lord is just!
He is my rock!
There is no evil in him!"

93



HE Lord is king! He is robed in majesty.

Indeed, the Lord is robed in majesty and armed with
strength.

The world stands firm
and cannot be shaken.

²Your throne, O Lord, has stood from time immemorial.
You yourself are from the everlasting past.

³The floods have risen up, O Lord.

- The floods have roared like thunder;
the floods have lifted their pounding waves.
⁴But mightier than the violent raging of the seas,
mightier than the breakers on the shore—
the Lord above is mightier than these!
⁵Your royal laws cannot be changed.
Your reign, O Lord, is holy forever and ever.

94



- Lord, the God of vengeance,
O God of vengeance, let your glorious justice shine forth!
²Arise, O Judge of the earth.
Give the proud what they deserve.
³How long, O Lord?
How long will the wicked be allowed to gloat?
⁴How long will they speak with arrogance?
How long will these evil people boast?
⁵They crush your people, Lord,
hurting those you claim as your own.
⁶They kill widows and foreigners
and murder orphans.
⁷“The Lord isn’t looking,” they say,
“and besides, the God of Israel doesn’t care.”

⁸Think again, you fools!
When will you finally catch on?
⁹Is he deaf—the one who made your ears?
Is he blind—the one who formed your eyes?
¹⁰He punishes the nations—won’t he also punish you?
He knows everything—doesn’t he also know what you are
doing?

¹¹The Lord knows people's thoughts;
he knows they are worthless!

¹²Joyful are those you discipline, Lord,
those you teach with your instructions.

¹³You give them relief from troubled times
until a pit is dug to capture the wicked.

¹⁴The Lord will not reject his people;
he will not abandon his special possession.

¹⁵Judgment will again be founded on justice,
and those with virtuous hearts will pursue it.

¹⁶Who will protect me from the wicked?
Who will stand up for me against evildoers?

¹⁷Unless the Lord had helped me,
I would soon have settled in the silence of the grave.

¹⁸I cried out, "I am slipping!"
but your unfailing love, O Lord, supported me.

¹⁹When doubts filled my mind,
your comfort gave me renewed hope and cheer.

²⁰Can unjust leaders claim that God is on their side—
leaders whose decrees permit injustice?

²¹They gang up against the righteous
and condemn the innocent to death.

²²But the Lord is my fortress;
my God is the mighty rock where I hide.

²³God will turn the sins of evil people back on them.
He will destroy them for their sins.
The Lord our God will destroy them.

95



OME, let us sing to the Lord!

Let us shout joyfully to the Rock of our salvation.

²Let us come to him with thanksgiving.

Let us sing psalms of praise to him.

³For the Lord is a great God,
a great King above all gods.

⁴He holds in his hands the depths of the earth
and the mightiest mountains.

⁵The sea belongs to him, for he made it.
His hands formed the dry land, too.

⁶Come, let us worship and bow down.

Let us kneel before the Lord our maker,

⁷for he is our God.

We are the people he watches over,
the flock under his care.

If only you would listen to his voice today!

⁸The Lord says, “Don’t harden your hearts as Israel did at
Meribah,

as they did at Massah in the wilderness.

⁹For there your ancestors tested and tried my patience,
even though they saw everything I did.

¹⁰For forty years I was angry with them, and I said,

‘They are a people whose hearts turn away from me.
They refuse to do what I tell them.’

¹¹So in my anger I took an oath:

‘They will never enter my place of rest.’”

96



- ING a new song to the Lord!
Let the whole earth sing to the Lord!
²Sing to the Lord; praise his name.
Each day proclaim the good news that he saves.
³Publish his glorious deeds among the nations.
Tell everyone about the amazing things he does.
⁴Great is the Lord! He is most worthy of praise!
He is to be feared above all gods.
⁵The gods of other nations are mere idols,
but the Lord made the heavens!
⁶Honor and majesty surround him;
strength and beauty fill his sanctuary.
- ⁷O nations of the world, recognize the Lord;
recognize that the Lord is glorious and strong.
⁸Give to the Lord the glory he deserves!
Bring your offering and come into his courts.
⁹Worship the Lord in all his holy splendor.
Let all the earth tremble before him.
¹⁰Tell all the nations, "The Lord reigns!"
The world stands firm and cannot be shaken.
He will judge all peoples fairly.
- ¹¹Let the heavens be glad, and the earth rejoice!
Let the sea and everything in it shout his praise!
¹²Let the fields and their crops burst out with joy!
Let the trees of the forest sing for joy
¹³before the Lord, for he is coming!
He is coming to judge the earth.
He will judge the world with justice,

and the nations with his truth.

97



HE Lord is king!

Let the earth rejoice!

Let the farthest coastlands be glad.

²Dark clouds surround him.

Righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne.

³Fire spreads ahead of him
and burns up all his foes.

⁴His lightning flashes out across the world.
The earth sees and trembles.

⁵The mountains melt like wax before the Lord,
before the Lord of all the earth.

⁶The heavens proclaim his righteousness;
every nation sees his glory.

⁷Those who worship idols are disgraced—
all who brag about their worthless gods—
for every god must bow to him.

⁸Jerusalem has heard and rejoiced,
and all the towns of Judah are glad
because of your justice, O Lord!

⁹For you, O Lord, are supreme over all the earth;
you are exalted far above all gods.

¹⁰You who love the Lord, hate evil!
He protects the lives of his godly people
and rescues them from the power of the wicked.

¹¹Light shines on the godly,
and joy on those whose hearts are right.

¹²May all who are godly rejoice in the Lord

and praise his holy name!

98

A psalm.



- ING a new song to the Lord,
for he has done wonderful deeds.
His right hand has won a mighty victory;
his holy arm has shown his saving power!
- ²The Lord has announced his victory
and has revealed his righteousness to every nation!
- ³He has remembered his promise to love and be faithful to Israel.
The ends of the earth have seen the victory of our God.
- ⁴Shout to the Lord, all the earth;
break out in praise and sing for joy!
- ⁵Sing your praise to the Lord with the harp,
with the harp and melodious song,
- ⁶with trumpets and the sound of the ram's horn.
Make a joyful symphony before the Lord, the King!
- ⁷Let the sea and everything in it shout his praise!
Let the earth and all living things join in.
- ⁸Let the rivers clap their hands in glee!
Let the hills sing out their songs of joy
- ⁹before the Lord,
for he is coming to judge the earth.
He will judge the world with justice,
and the nations with fairness.

99



HE Lord is king!

Let the nations tremble!

He sits on his throne between the cherubim.

Let the whole earth quake!

²The Lord sits in majesty in Jerusalem,
exalted above all the nations.

³Let them praise your great and awesome name.
Your name is holy!

⁴Mighty King, lover of justice,
you have established fairness.

You have acted with justice
and righteousness throughout Israel.

⁵Exalt the Lord our God!
Bow low before his feet, for he is holy!

⁶Moses and Aaron were among his priests;
Samuel also called on his name.

They cried to the Lord for help,
and he answered them.

⁷He spoke to Israel from the pillar of cloud,
and they followed the laws and decrees he gave them.

⁸O Lord our God, you answered them.
You were a forgiving God to them,
but you punished them when they went wrong.

⁹Exalt the Lord our God,
and worship at his holy mountain in Jerusalem,
for the Lord our God is holy!

100

A psalm of thanksgiving.



- SHOUT with joy to the Lord, all the earth!
²Worship the Lord with gladness.
Come before him, singing with joy.
³Acknowledge that the Lord is God!
He made us, and we are his.
We are his people, the sheep of his pasture.
⁴Enter his gates with thanksgiving;
go into his courts with praise.
Give thanks to him and praise his name.
⁵For the Lord is good.
His unfailing love continues forever,
and his faithfulness continues to each generation.

101

A psalm of David.



- I will sing of your love and justice, Lord.
I will praise you with songs.
²I will be careful to live a blameless life—
when will you come to help me?
I will lead a life of integrity
in my own home.
³I will refuse to look at
anything vile and vulgar.
I hate all who deal crookedly;
I will have nothing to do with them.
⁴I will reject perverse ideas
and stay away from every evil.
⁵I will not tolerate people who slander their neighbors.

I will not endure conceit and pride.

⁶I will search for faithful people
to be my companions.

Only those who are above reproach
will be allowed to serve me.

⁷I will not allow deceivers to serve in my house,
and liars will not stay in my presence.

⁸My daily task will be to ferret out the wicked
and free the city of the Lord from their grip.

102

A prayer of one overwhelmed with trouble, pouring out problems before the Lord.



ORD, hear my prayer!

Listen to my plea!

²Don't turn away from me
in my time of distress.

Bend down to listen,
and answer me quickly when I call to you.

³For my days disappear like smoke,
and my bones burn like red-hot coals.

⁴My heart is sick, withered like grass,
and I have lost my appetite.

⁵Because of my groaning,
I am reduced to skin and bones.

⁶I am like an owl in the desert,
like a little owl in a far-off wilderness.

⁷I lie awake,
lonely as a solitary bird on the roof.

⁸My enemies taunt me day after day.

They mock and curse me.

⁹I eat ashes for food.

My tears run down into my drink

¹⁰because of your anger and wrath.

For you have picked me up and thrown me out.

¹¹My life passes as swiftly as the evening shadows.

I am withering away like grass.

¹²But you, O Lord, will sit on your throne forever.

Your fame will endure to every generation.

¹³You will arise and have mercy on Jerusalem—

and now is the time to pity her,

now is the time you promised to help.

¹⁴For your people love every stone in her walls

and cherish even the dust in her streets.

¹⁵Then the nations will tremble before the Lord.

The kings of the earth will tremble before his glory.

¹⁶For the Lord will rebuild Jerusalem.

He will appear in his glory.

¹⁷He will listen to the prayers of the destitute.

He will not reject their pleas.

¹⁸Let this be recorded for future generations,
so that a people not yet born will praise the Lord.

¹⁹Tell them the Lord looked down
from his heavenly sanctuary.

He looked down to earth from heaven

²⁰to hear the groans of the prisoners,
to release those condemned to die.

²¹And so the Lord's fame will be celebrated in Zion,
his praises in Jerusalem,

²²when multitudes gather together

and kingdoms come to worship the Lord.

- ²³He broke my strength in midlife,
cutting short my days.
²⁴But I cried to him, "O my God, who lives forever,
don't take my life while I am so young!
²⁵Long ago you laid the foundation of the earth
and made the heavens with your hands.
²⁶They will perish, but you remain forever;
they will wear out like old clothing.
You will change them like a garment
and discard them.
²⁷But you are always the same;
you will live forever.
²⁸The children of your people
will live in security.
Their children's children
will thrive in your presence."

103

A psalm of David.



- LET all that I am praise the Lord;
with my whole heart, I will praise his holy name.
²Let all that I am praise the Lord;
may I never forget the good things he does for me.
³He forgives all my sins
and heals all my diseases.
⁴He redeems me from death
and crowns me with love and tender mercies.
⁵He fills my life with good things.
My youth is renewed like the eagle's!

⁶The Lord gives righteousness
and justice to all who are treated unfairly.

⁷He revealed his character to Moses
and his deeds to the people of Israel.

⁸The Lord is compassionate and merciful,
slow to get angry and filled with unfailing love.

⁹He will not constantly accuse us,
nor remain angry forever.

¹⁰He does not punish us for all our sins;
he does not deal harshly with us, as we deserve.

¹¹For his unfailing love toward those who fear him
is as great as the height of the heavens above the earth.

¹²He has removed our sins as far from us
as the east is from the west.

¹³The Lord is like a father to his children,
tender and compassionate to those who fear him.

¹⁴For he knows how weak we are;
he remembers we are only dust.

¹⁵Our days on earth are like grass;
like wildflowers, we bloom and die.

¹⁶The wind blows, and we are gone—
as though we had never been here.

¹⁷But the love of the Lord remains forever
with those who fear him.

His salvation extends to the children's children

¹⁸of those who are faithful to his covenant,
of those who obey his commandments!

¹⁹The Lord has made the heavens his throne;
from there he rules over everything.

- ²⁰Praise the Lord, you angels,
you mighty ones who carry out his plans,
listening for each of his commands.
- ²¹Yes, praise the Lord, you armies of angels
who serve him and do his will!
- ²²Praise the Lord, everything he has created,
everything in all his kingdom.

Let all that I am praise the Lord.

104



ET all that I am praise the Lord.

- O Lord my God, how great you are!
You are robed with honor and majesty.
- ²You are dressed in a robe of light.
You stretch out the starry curtain of the heavens;
³you lay out the rafters of your home in the rain clouds.
- You make the clouds your chariot;
you ride upon the wings of the wind.
- ⁴The winds are your messengers;
flames of fire are your servants.
- ⁵You placed the world on its foundation
so it would never be moved.
- ⁶You clothed the earth with floods of water,
water that covered even the mountains.
- ⁷At your command, the water fled;
at the sound of your thunder, it hurried away.

- ⁸Mountains rose and valleys sank
to the levels you decreed.
- ⁹Then you set a firm boundary for the seas,
so they would never again cover the earth.
- ¹⁰You make springs pour water into the ravines,
so streams gush down from the mountains.
- ¹¹They provide water for all the animals,
and the wild donkeys quench their thirst.
- ¹²The birds nest beside the streams
and sing among the branches of the trees.
- ¹³You send rain on the mountains from your heavenly home,
and you fill the earth with the fruit of your labor.
- ¹⁴You cause grass to grow for the livestock
and plants for people to use.
You allow them to produce food from the earth—
- ¹⁵wine to make them glad,
olive oil to soothe their skin,
and bread to give them strength.
- ¹⁶The trees of the Lord are well cared for—
the cedars of Lebanon that he planted.
- ¹⁷There the birds make their nests,
and the storks make their homes in the cypresses.
- ¹⁸High in the mountains live the wild goats,
and the rocks form a refuge for the hyraxes.
- ¹⁹You made the moon to mark the seasons,
and the sun knows when to set.
- ²⁰You send the darkness, and it becomes night,
when all the forest animals prowl about.
- ²¹Then the young lions roar for their prey,
stalking the food provided by God.

²²At dawn they slink back
into their dens to rest.

²³Then people go off to their work,
where they labor until evening.

²⁴O Lord, what a variety of things you have made!
In wisdom you have made them all.
The earth is full of your creatures.

²⁵Here is the ocean, vast and wide,
teeming with life of every kind,
both large and small.

²⁶See the ships sailing along,
and Leviathan, which you made to play in the sea.

²⁷They all depend on you
to give them food as they need it.

²⁸When you supply it, they gather it.
You open your hand to feed them,
and they are richly satisfied.

²⁹But if you turn away from them, they panic.
When you take away their breath,
they die and turn again to dust.

³⁰When you give them your breath, life is created,
and you renew the face of the earth.

³¹May the glory of the Lord continue forever!
The Lord takes pleasure in all he has made!

³²The earth trembles at his glance;
the mountains smoke at his touch.

³³I will sing to the Lord as long as I live.

I will praise my God to my last breath!

³⁴May all my thoughts be pleasing to him,
for I rejoice in the Lord.

³⁵Let all sinners vanish from the face of the earth;
let the wicked disappear forever.

Let all that I am praise the Lord.

Praise the Lord!

105



GIVE thanks to the Lord and proclaim his greatness.

Let the whole world know what he has done.

²Sing to him; yes, sing his praises.

Tell everyone about his wonderful deeds.

³Exult in his holy name;

rejoice, you who worship the Lord.

⁴Search for the Lord and for his strength;
continually seek him.

⁵Remember the wonders he has performed,
his miracles, and the rulings he has given,

⁶you children of his servant Abraham,
you descendants of Jacob, his chosen ones.

⁷He is the Lord our God.

His justice is seen throughout the land.

⁸He always stands by his covenant—
the commitment he made to a thousand generations.

- ⁹This is the covenant he made with Abraham
and the oath he swore to Isaac.
- ¹⁰He confirmed it to Jacob as a decree,
and to the people of Israel as a never-ending covenant:
- ¹¹*"I will give you the land of Canaan
as your special possession."*
- ¹²He said this when they were few in number,
a tiny group of strangers in Canaan.
- ¹³They wandered from nation to nation,
from one kingdom to another.
- ¹⁴Yet he did not let anyone oppress them.
He warned kings on their behalf:
- ¹⁵*"Do not touch my chosen people,
and do not hurt my prophets."*
- ¹⁶He called for a famine on the land of Canaan,
cutting off its food supply.
- ¹⁷Then he sent someone to Egypt ahead of them—
Joseph, who was sold as a slave.
- ¹⁸They bruised his feet with fetters
and placed his neck in an iron collar.
- ¹⁹Until the time came to fulfill his dreams,
the Lord tested Joseph's character.
- ²⁰Then Pharaoh sent for him and set him free;
the ruler of the nation opened his prison door.
- ²¹Joseph was put in charge of all the king's household;
he became ruler over all the king's possessions.
- ²²He could instruct the king's aides as he pleased
and teach the king's advisers.

- ²³Then Israel arrived in Egypt;
 Jacob lived as a foreigner in the land of Ham.
- ²⁴And the Lord multiplied the people of Israel
 until they became too mighty for their enemies.
- ²⁵Then he turned the Egyptians against the Israelites,
 and they plotted against the Lord's servants.
- ²⁶But the Lord sent his servant Moses,
 along with Aaron, whom he had chosen.
- ²⁷They performed miraculous signs among the Egyptians,
 and wonders in the land of Ham.
- ²⁸The Lord blanketed Egypt in darkness,
 for they had defied his commands to let his people go.
- ²⁹He turned their water into blood,
 poisoning all the fish.
- ³⁰Then frogs overran the land
 and even invaded the king's bedrooms.
- ³¹When the Lord spoke, flies descended on the Egyptians,
 and gnats swarmed across Egypt.
- ³²He sent them hail instead of rain,
 and lightning flashed over the land.
- ³³He ruined their grapevines and fig trees
 and shattered all the trees.
- ³⁴He spoke, and hordes of locusts came—
 young locusts beyond number.
- ³⁵They ate up everything green in the land,
 destroying all the crops in their fields.
- ³⁶Then he killed the oldest son in each Egyptian home,
 the pride and joy of each family.
- ³⁷The Lord brought his people out of Egypt, loaded with silver
 and gold;

- and not one among the tribes of Israel even stumbled.
- ³⁸Egypt was glad when they were gone,
for they feared them greatly.
- ³⁹The Lord spread a cloud above them as a covering
and gave them a great fire to light the darkness.
- ⁴⁰They asked for meat, and he sent them quail;
he satisfied their hunger with manna—bread from heaven.
- ⁴¹He split open a rock, and water gushed out
to form a river through the dry wasteland.
- ⁴²For he remembered his sacred promise
to his servant Abraham.
- ⁴³So he brought his people out of Egypt with joy,
his chosen ones with rejoicing.
- ⁴⁴He gave his people the lands of pagan nations,
and they harvested crops that others had planted.
- ⁴⁵All this happened so they would follow his decrees
and obey his instructions.

Praise the Lord!

106



RAISE the Lord!

Give thanks to the Lord, for he is good!
His faithful love endures forever.

²Who can list the glorious miracles of the Lord?
Who can ever praise him enough?

³There is joy for those who deal justly with others
and always do what is right.

⁴Remember me, Lord, when you show favor to your people;
come near and rescue me.

⁵Let me share in the prosperity of your chosen ones.
Let me rejoice in the joy of your people;
let me praise you with those who are your heritage.

⁶Like our ancestors, we have sinned.
We have done wrong! We have acted wickedly!

⁷Our ancestors in Egypt
were not impressed by the Lord's miraculous deeds.
They soon forgot his many acts of kindness to them.
Instead, they rebelled against him at the Red Sea.

⁸Even so, he saved them—
to defend the honor of his name
and to demonstrate his mighty power.

⁹He commanded the Red Sea to dry up.
He led Israel across the sea as if it were a desert.

¹⁰So he rescued them from their enemies
and redeemed them from their foes.

¹¹Then the water returned and covered their enemies;
not one of them survived.

¹²Then his people believed his promises.
Then they sang his praise.

¹³Yet how quickly they forgot what he had done!
They wouldn't wait for his counsel!

¹⁴In the wilderness their desires ran wild,
testing God's patience in that dry wasteland.

¹⁵So he gave them what they asked for,
but he sent a plague along with it.

¹⁶The people in the camp were jealous of Moses
and envious of Aaron, the Lord's holy priest.

¹⁷Because of this, the earth opened up;
it swallowed Dathan
and buried Abiram and the other rebels.

¹⁸Fire fell upon their followers;
a flame consumed the wicked.

¹⁹The people made a calf at Mount Sinai;
they bowed before an image made of gold.

²⁰They traded their glorious God
for a statue of a grass-eating bull.

²¹They forgot God, their savior,
who had done such great things in Egypt—

²²such wonderful things in the land of Ham,
such awesome deeds at the Red Sea.

²³So he declared he would destroy them.
But Moses, his chosen one, stepped between the Lord and the
people.
He begged him to turn from his anger and not destroy them.

²⁴The people refused to enter the pleasant land,
for they wouldn't believe his promise to care for them.

²⁵Instead, they grumbled in their tents
and refused to obey the Lord.

²⁶Therefore, he solemnly swore
that he would kill them in the wilderness,

²⁷that he would scatter their descendants among the nations,
exiling them to distant lands.

²⁸Then our ancestors joined in the worship of Baal at Peor;
they even ate sacrifices offered to the dead!

²⁹They angered the Lord with all these things,

so a plague broke out among them.

³⁰But Phinehas had the courage to intervene,
and the plague was stopped.

³¹So he has been regarded as a righteous man
ever since that time.

³²At Meribah, too, they angered the Lord,
causing Moses serious trouble.

³³They made Moses angry,
and he spoke foolishly.

³⁴Israel failed to destroy the nations in the land,
as the Lord had commanded them.

³⁵Instead, they mingled among the pagans
and adopted their evil customs.

³⁶They worshiped their idols,
which led to their downfall.

³⁷They even sacrificed their sons
and their daughters to the demons.

³⁸They shed innocent blood,
the blood of their sons and daughters.

By sacrificing them to the idols of Canaan,
they polluted the land with murder.

³⁹They defiled themselves by their evil deeds,
and their love of idols was adultery in the Lord's sight.

⁴⁰That is why the Lord's anger burned against his people,
and he abhorred his own special possession.

⁴¹He handed them over to pagan nations,
and they were ruled by those who hated them.

⁴²Their enemies crushed them

and brought them under their cruel power.

⁴³ Again and again he rescued them,
but they chose to rebel against him,
and they were finally destroyed by their sin.

⁴⁴ Even so, he pitied them in their distress
and listened to their cries.

⁴⁵ He remembered his covenant with them
and relented because of his unfailing love.

⁴⁶ He even caused their captors
to treat them with kindness.

⁴⁷ Save us, O Lord our God!
Gather us back from among the nations,
so we can thank your holy name
and rejoice and praise you.

⁴⁸ Praise the Lord, the God of Israel,
who lives from everlasting to everlasting!
Let all the people say, "Amen!"

Praise the Lord!

Book Five: Psalms 107-150

107



GIVE thanks to the Lord, for he is good!
His faithful love endures forever.

²Has the Lord redeemed you? Then speak out!

Tell others he has redeemed you from your enemies.

³For he has gathered the exiles from many lands,
from east and west,
from north and south.

⁴Some wandered in the wilderness,
lost and homeless.

⁵Hungry and thirsty,
they nearly died.

⁶“Lord, help!” they cried in their trouble,
and he rescued them from their distress.

⁷He led them straight to safety,
to a city where they could live.

⁸Let them praise the Lord for his great love
and for the wonderful things he has done for them.

⁹For he satisfies the thirsty
and fills the hungry with good things.

¹⁰Some sat in darkness and deepest gloom,
imprisoned in iron chains of misery.

¹¹They rebelled against the words of God,
scorning the counsel of the Most High.

¹²That is why he broke them with hard labor;
they fell, and no one was there to help them.

¹³“Lord, help!” they cried in their trouble,
and he saved them from their distress.

¹⁴He led them from the darkness and deepest gloom;
he snapped their chains.

¹⁵Let them praise the Lord for his great love
and for the wonderful things he has done for them.

¹⁶For he broke down their prison gates of bronze;
he cut apart their bars of iron.

- ¹⁷Some were fools; they rebelled
and suffered for their sins.
- ¹⁸They couldn't stand the thought of food,
and they were knocking on death's door.
- ¹⁹"Lord, help!" they cried in their trouble,
and he saved them from their distress.
- ²⁰He sent out his word and healed them,
snatching them from the door of death.
- ²¹Let them praise the Lord for his great love
and for the wonderful things he has done for them.
- ²²Let them offer sacrifices of thanksgiving
and sing joyfully about his glorious acts.
- ²³Some went off to sea in ships,
plying the trade routes of the world.
- ²⁴They, too, observed the Lord's power in action,
his impressive works on the deepest seas.
- ²⁵He spoke, and the winds rose,
stirring up the waves.
- ²⁶Their ships were tossed to the heavens
and plunged again to the depths;
the sailors cringed in terror.
- ²⁷They reeled and staggered like drunkards
and were at their wits' end.
- ²⁸"Lord, help!" they cried in their trouble,
and he saved them from their distress.
- ²⁹He calmed the storm to a whisper
and stilled the waves.
- ³⁰What a blessing was that stillness
as he brought them safely into harbor!
- ³¹Let them praise the Lord for his great love
and for the wonderful things he has done for them.
- ³²Let them exalt him publicly before the congregation

and before the leaders of the nation.

- ³³He changes rivers into deserts,
and springs of water into dry, thirsty land.
- ³⁴He turns the fruitful land into salty wastelands,
because of the wickedness of those who live there.
- ³⁵But he also turns deserts into pools of water,
the dry land into springs of water.
- ³⁶He brings the hungry to settle there
and to build their cities.
- ³⁷They sow their fields, plant their vineyards,
and harvest their bumper crops.
- ³⁸How he blesses them!
They raise large families there,
and their herds of livestock increase.
- ³⁹When they decrease in number and become impoverished
through oppression, trouble, and sorrow,
- ⁴⁰the Lord pours contempt on their princes,
causing them to wander in trackless wastelands.
- ⁴¹But he rescues the poor from trouble
and increases their families like flocks of sheep.
- ⁴²The godly will see these things and be glad,
while the wicked are struck silent.
- ⁴³Those who are wise will take all this to heart;
they will see in our history the faithful love of the Lord.

108

A song. A psalm of David.



Y heart is confident in you, O God;

no wonder I can sing your praises with all my heart!

²Wake up, lyre and harp!

I will wake the dawn with my song.

³I will thank you, Lord, among all the people.

I will sing your praises among the nations.

⁴For your unfailing love is higher than the heavens.

Your faithfulness reaches to the clouds.

⁵Be exalted, O God, above the highest heavens.

May your glory shine over all the earth.

⁶Now rescue your beloved people.

Answer and save us by your power.

⁷God has promised this by his holiness:

"I will divide up Shechem with joy.

I will measure out the valley of Succoth.

⁸Gilead is mine,

and Manasseh, too.

Ephraim, my helmet, will produce my warriors,

and Judah, my scepter, will produce my kings.

⁹But Moab, my washbasin, will become my servant,

and I will wipe my feet on Edom

and shout in triumph over Philistia."

¹⁰Who will bring me into the fortified city?

Who will bring me victory over Edom?

¹¹Have you rejected us, O God?

Will you no longer march with our armies?

¹²Oh, please help us against our enemies,

for all human help is useless.

¹³With God's help we will do mighty things,

for he will trample down our foes.

109

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



- God, whom I praise,
don't stand silent and aloof
²while the wicked slander me
and tell lies about me.
³They surround me with hateful words
and fight against me for no reason.
⁴I love them, but they try to destroy me with accusations
even as I am praying for them!
⁵They repay evil for good,
and hatred for my love.
- ⁶They say, "Get an evil person to turn against him.
Send an accuser to bring him to trial.
⁷When his case comes up for judgment,
let him be pronounced guilty.
Count his prayers as sins.
⁸Let his years be few;
let someone else take his position.
⁹May his children become fatherless,
and his wife a widow.
¹⁰May his children wander as beggars
and be driven from their ruined homes.
¹¹May creditors seize his entire estate,
and strangers take all he has earned.
¹²Let no one be kind to him;
let no one pity his fatherless children.
¹³May all his offspring die.
May his family name be blotted out in the next generation.
¹⁴May the Lord never forget the sins of his fathers;
may his mother's sins never be erased from the record.

- ¹⁵May the Lord always remember these sins,
and may his name disappear from human memory.
- ¹⁶For he refused all kindness to others;
he persecuted the poor and needy,
and he hounded the brokenhearted to death.
- ¹⁷He loved to curse others;
now you curse him.
He never blessed others;
now don't you bless him.
- ¹⁸Cursing is as natural to him as his clothing,
or the water he drinks,
or the rich food he eats.
- ¹⁹Now may his curses return and cling to him like clothing;
may they be tied around him like a belt."
- ²⁰May those curses become the Lord's punishment
for my accusers who speak evil of me.
- ²¹But deal well with me, O Sovereign Lord,
for the sake of your own reputation!
Rescue me
because you are so faithful and good.
- ²²For I am poor and needy,
and my heart is full of pain.
- ²³I am fading like a shadow at dusk;
I am brushed off like a locust.
- ²⁴My knees are weak from fasting,
and I am skin and bones.
- ²⁵I am a joke to people everywhere;
when they see me, they shake their heads in scorn.
- ²⁶Help me, O Lord my God!
Save me because of your unfailing love.

- ²⁷Let them see that this is your doing,
that you yourself have done it, Lord.
²⁸Then let them curse me if they like,
but you will bless me!
When they attack me, they will be disgraced!
But I, your servant, will go right on rejoicing!
²⁹May my accusers be clothed with disgrace;
may their humiliation cover them like a cloak.
³⁰But I will give repeated thanks to the Lord,
praising him to everyone.
³¹For he stands beside the needy,
ready to save them from those who condemn them.

110

A psalm of David.



HE Lord said to my Lord,
“Sit in the place of honor at my right hand
until I humble your enemies,
making them a footstool under your feet.”

- ²The Lord will extend your powerful kingdom from Jerusalem;
you will rule over your enemies.
³When you go to war,
your people will serve you willingly.
You are arrayed in holy garments,
and your strength will be renewed each day like the morning
dew.

- ⁴The Lord has taken an oath and will not break his vow:
“You are a priest forever in the order of Melchizedek.”

- ⁵The Lord stands at your right hand to protect you.
He will strike down many kings when his anger erupts.
- ⁶He will punish the nations
and fill their lands with corpses;
he will shatter heads over the whole earth.
- ⁷But he himself will be refreshed from brooks along the way.
He will be victorious.

111



RAISE the Lord!

- I will thank the Lord with all my heart
as I meet with his godly people.
- ²How amazing are the deeds of the Lord!
All who delight in him should ponder them.
- ³Everything he does reveals his glory and majesty.
His righteousness never fails.
- ⁴He causes us to remember his wonderful works.
How gracious and merciful is our Lord!
- ⁵He gives food to those who fear him;
he always remembers his covenant.
- ⁶He has shown his great power to his people
by giving them the lands of other nations.
- ⁷All he does is just and good,
and all his commandments are trustworthy.
- ⁸They are forever true,
to be obeyed faithfully and with integrity.
- ⁹He has paid a full ransom for his people.
He has guaranteed his covenant with them forever.
What a holy, awe-inspiring name he has!
- ¹⁰Fear of the Lord is the foundation of true wisdom.

All who obey his commandments will grow in wisdom.

Praise him forever!

112



RAISE the Lord!

How joyful are those who fear the Lord
and delight in obeying his commands.

²Their children will be successful everywhere;
an entire generation of godly people will be blessed.

³They themselves will be wealthy,
and their good deeds will last forever.

⁴Light shines in the darkness for the godly.
They are generous, compassionate, and righteous.

⁵Good comes to those who lend money generously
and conduct their business fairly.

⁶Such people will not be overcome by evil.
Those who are righteous will be long remembered.

⁷They do not fear bad news;
they confidently trust the Lord to care for them.

⁸They are confident and fearless
and can face their foes triumphantly.

⁹They share freely and give generously to those in need.
Their good deeds will be remembered forever.
They will have influence and honor.

¹⁰The wicked will see this and be infuriated.
They will grind their teeth in anger;
they will slink away, their hopes thwarted.

113



RAISE the Lord!

Yes, give praise, O servants of the Lord.

Praise the name of the Lord!

²Blessed be the name of the Lord
now and forever.

³Everywhere—from east to west—
praise the name of the Lord.

⁴For the Lord is high above the nations;
his glory is higher than the heavens.

⁵Who can be compared with the Lord our God,
who is enthroned on high?

⁶He stoops to look down
on heaven and on earth.

⁷He lifts the poor from the dust
and the needy from the garbage dump.

⁸He sets them among princes,
even the princes of his own people!

⁹He gives the childless woman a family,
making her a happy mother.

Praise the Lord!

114



HEN the Israelites escaped from Egypt—

- when the family of Jacob left that foreign land—
²the land of Judah became God's sanctuary,
and Israel became his kingdom.
- ³The Red Sea saw them coming and hurried out of their way!
The water of the Jordan River turned away.
- ⁴The mountains skipped like rams,
the hills like lambs!
- ⁵What's wrong, Red Sea, that made you hurry out of their way?
What happened, Jordan River, that you turned away?
- ⁶Why, mountains, did you skip like rams?
Why, hills, like lambs?
- ⁷Tremble, O earth, at the presence of the Lord,
at the presence of the God of Jacob.
- ⁸He turned the rock into a pool of water;
yes, a spring of water flowed from solid rock.

115



- NOT to us, O Lord, not to us,
but to your name goes all the glory
for your unfailing love and faithfulness.
- ²Why let the nations say,
“Where is their God?”
- ³Our God is in the heavens,
and he does as he wishes.
- ⁴Their idols are merely things of silver and gold,
shaped by human hands.
- ⁵They have mouths but cannot speak,
and eyes but cannot see.

- ⁶They have ears but cannot hear,
and noses but cannot smell.
⁷They have hands but cannot feel,
and feet but cannot walk,
and throats but cannot make a sound.
⁸And those who make idols are just like them,
as are all who trust in them.

- ⁹O Israel, trust the Lord!
He is your helper and your shield.
¹⁰O priests, descendants of Aaron, trust the Lord!
He is your helper and your shield.
¹¹All you who fear the Lord, trust the Lord!
He is your helper and your shield.

- ¹²The Lord remembers us and will bless us.
He will bless the people of Israel
and bless the priests, the descendants of Aaron.
¹³He will bless those who fear the Lord,
both great and lowly.

- ¹⁴May the Lord richly bless
both you and your children.
¹⁵May you be blessed by the Lord,
who made heaven and earth.
¹⁶The heavens belong to the Lord,
but he has given the earth to all humanity.
¹⁷The dead cannot sing praises to the Lord,
for they have gone into the silence of the grave.
¹⁸But we can praise the Lord
both now and forever!

Praise the Lord!

116



love the Lord because he hears my voice
and my prayer for mercy.

²Because he bends down to listen,
I will pray as long as I have breath!

³Death wrapped its ropes around me;
the terrors of the grave overtook me.
I saw only trouble and sorrow.

⁴Then I called on the name of the Lord:
“Please, Lord, save me!”

⁵How kind the Lord is! How good he is!
So merciful, this God of ours!

⁶The Lord protects those of childlike faith;
I was facing death, and he saved me.

⁷Let my soul be at rest again,
for the Lord has been good to me.

⁸He has saved me from death,
my eyes from tears,
my feet from stumbling.

⁹And so I walk in the Lord’s presence
as I live here on earth!

¹⁰I believed in you, so I said,
“I am deeply troubled, Lord.”

¹¹In my anxiety I cried out to you,
“These people are all liars!”

¹²What can I offer the Lord
for all he has done for me?

¹³I will lift up the cup of salvation
and praise the Lord’s name for saving me.

¹⁴I will keep my promises to the Lord

in the presence of all his people.

¹⁵The Lord cares deeply

when his loved ones die.

¹⁶O Lord, I am your servant;

yes, I am your servant, born into your household;
you have freed me from my chains.

¹⁷I will offer you a sacrifice of thanksgiving

and call on the name of the Lord.

¹⁸I will fulfill my vows to the Lord

in the presence of all his people—

¹⁹in the house of the Lord

in the heart of Jerusalem.

Praise the Lord!

117



RAISE the Lord, all you nations.

Praise him, all you people of the earth.

²For his unfailing love for us is powerful;
the Lord's faithfulness endures forever.

Praise the Lord!

118



GIVE thanks to the Lord, for he is good!

His faithful love endures forever.

²Let all Israel repeat:

“His faithful love endures forever.”

³Let Aaron’s descendants, the priests, repeat:

“His faithful love endures forever.”

⁴Let all who fear the Lord repeat:

“His faithful love endures forever.”

⁵In my distress I prayed to the Lord,
and the Lord answered me and set me free.

⁶The Lord is for me, so I will have no fear.
What can mere people do to me?

⁷Yes, the Lord is for me; he will help me.
I will look in triumph at those who hate me.

⁸It is better to take refuge in the Lord
than to trust in people.

⁹It is better to take refuge in the Lord
than to trust in princes.

¹⁰Though hostile nations surrounded me,
I destroyed them all with the authority of the Lord.

¹¹Yes, they surrounded and attacked me,
but I destroyed them all with the authority of the Lord.

¹²They swarmed around me like bees;
they blazed against me like a crackling fire.
But I destroyed them all with the authority of the Lord.

¹³My enemies did their best to kill me,
but the Lord rescued me.

¹⁴The Lord is my strength and my song;
he has given me victory.

- ¹⁵Songs of joy and victory are sung in the camp of the godly.
The strong right arm of the Lord has done glorious things!
- ¹⁶The strong right arm of the Lord is raised in triumph.
The strong right arm of the Lord has done glorious things!
- ¹⁷I will not die; instead, I will live
to tell what the Lord has done.
- ¹⁸The Lord has punished me severely,
but he did not let me die.
- ¹⁹Open for me the gates where the righteous enter,
and I will go in and thank the Lord.
- ²⁰These gates lead to the presence of the Lord,
and the godly enter there.
- ²¹I thank you for answering my prayer
and giving me victory!
- ²²The stone that the builders rejected
has now become the cornerstone.
- ²³This is the Lord's doing,
and it is wonderful to see.
- ²⁴This is the day the Lord has made.
We will rejoice and be glad in it.
- ²⁵Please, Lord, please save us.
Please, Lord, please give us success.
- ²⁶Bless the one who comes in the name of the Lord.
We bless you from the house of the Lord.
- ²⁷The Lord is God, shining upon us.
Take the sacrifice and bind it with cords on the altar.
- ²⁸You are my God, and I will praise you!
You are my God, and I will exalt you!

²⁹Give thanks to the Lord, for he is good!
His faithful love endures forever.

119

Aleph



JOYFUL are people of integrity,
who follow the instructions of the Lord.
²Joyful are those who obey his laws
and search for him with all their hearts.
³They do not compromise with evil,
and they walk only in his paths.
⁴You have charged us
to keep your commandments carefully.
⁵Oh, that my actions would consistently
reflect your decrees!
⁶Then I will not be ashamed
when I compare my life with your commands.
⁷As I learn your righteous regulations,
I will thank you by living as I should!
⁸I will obey your decrees.
Please don't give up on me!

Beth

⁹How can a young person stay pure?
By obeying your word.
¹⁰I have tried hard to find you—
don't let me wander from your commands.
¹¹I have hidden your word in my heart,
that I might not sin against you.
¹²I praise you, O Lord;
teach me your decrees.

- ¹³I have recited aloud
all the regulations you have given us.
¹⁴I have rejoiced in your laws
as much as in riches.
¹⁵I will study your commandments
and reflect on your ways.
¹⁶I will delight in your decrees
and not forget your word.

Gimel

- ¹⁷Be good to your servant,
that I may live and obey your word.
¹⁸Open my eyes to see
the wonderful truths in your instructions.
¹⁹I am only a foreigner in the land.
Don't hide your commands from me!
²⁰I am always overwhelmed
with a desire for your regulations.
²¹You rebuke the arrogant;
those who wander from your commands are cursed.
²²Don't let them scorn and insult me,
for I have obeyed your laws.
²³Even princes sit and speak against me,
but I will meditate on your decrees.
²⁴Your laws please me;
they give me wise advice.

Daleth

- ²⁵I lie in the dust;
revive me by your word.
²⁶I told you my plans, and you answered.
Now teach me your decrees.
²⁷Help me understand the meaning of your commandments,

and I will meditate on your wonderful deeds.

²⁸I weep with sorrow;

encourage me by your word.

²⁹Keep me from lying to myself;

give me the privilege of knowing your instructions.

³⁰I have chosen to be faithful;

I have determined to live by your regulations.

³¹I cling to your laws.

Lord, don't let me be put to shame!

³²I will pursue your commands,

for you expand my understanding.

He

³³Teach me your decrees, O Lord;

I will keep them to the end.

³⁴Give me understanding and I will obey your instructions;

I will put them into practice with all my heart.

³⁵Make me walk along the path of your commands,

for that is where my happiness is found.

³⁶Give me an eagerness for your laws

rather than a love for money!

³⁷Turn my eyes from worthless things,

and give me life through your word.

³⁸Reassure me of your promise,

made to those who fear you.

³⁹Help me abandon my shameful ways;

for your regulations are good.

⁴⁰I long to obey your commandments!

Renew my life with your goodness.

Waw

⁴¹Lord, give me your unfailing love,

the salvation that you promised me.

- ⁴²Then I can answer those who taunt me,
for I trust in your word.
- ⁴³Do not snatch your word of truth from me,
for your regulations are my only hope.
- ⁴⁴I will keep on obeying your instructions
forever and ever.
- ⁴⁵I will walk in freedom,
for I have devoted myself to your commandments.
- ⁴⁶I will speak to kings about your laws,
and I will not be ashamed.
- ⁴⁷How I delight in your commands!
How I love them!
- ⁴⁸I honor and love your commands.
I meditate on your decrees.

Zayin

- ⁴⁹Remember your promise to me;
it is my only hope.
- ⁵⁰Your promise revives me;
it comforts me in all my troubles.
- ⁵¹The proud hold me in utter contempt,
but I do not turn away from your instructions.
- ⁵²I meditate on your age-old regulations;
O Lord, they comfort me.
- ⁵³I become furious with the wicked,
because they reject your instructions.
- ⁵⁴Your decrees have been the theme of my songs
wherever I have lived.
- ⁵⁵I reflect at night on who you are, O Lord;
therefore, I obey your instructions.
- ⁵⁶This is how I spend my life:
obeying your commandments.

Heth

⁵⁷Lord, you are mine!

I promise to obey your words!

⁵⁸With all my heart I want your blessings.

Be merciful as you promised.

⁵⁹I pondered the direction of my life,
and I turned to follow your laws.

⁶⁰I will hurry, without delay,
to obey your commands.

⁶¹Evil people try to drag me into sin,
but I am firmly anchored to your instructions.

⁶²I rise at midnight to thank you
for your just regulations.

⁶³I am a friend to anyone who fears you—
anyone who obeys your commandments.

⁶⁴O Lord, your unfailing love fills the earth;
teach me your decrees.

Teth

⁶⁵You have done many good things for me, Lord,
just as you promised.

⁶⁶I believe in your commands;
now teach me good judgment and knowledge.

⁶⁷I used to wander off until you disciplined me;
but now I closely follow your word.

⁶⁸You are good and do only good;
teach me your decrees.

⁶⁹Arrogant people smear me with lies,
but in truth I obey your commandments with all my heart.

⁷⁰Their hearts are dull and stupid,
but I delight in your instructions.

⁷¹My suffering was good for me,
for it taught me to pay attention to your decrees.

⁷²Your instructions are more valuable to me

than millions in gold and silver.

Yodh

⁷³You made me; you created me.

Now give me the sense to follow your commands.

⁷⁴May all who fear you find in me a cause for joy,
for I have put my hope in your word.

⁷⁵I know, O Lord, that your regulations are fair;
you disciplined me because I needed it.

⁷⁶Now let your unfailing love comfort me,
just as you promised me, your servant.

⁷⁷Surround me with your tender mercies so I may live,
for your instructions are my delight.

⁷⁸Bring disgrace upon the arrogant people who lied about me;
meanwhile, I will concentrate on your commandments.

⁷⁹Let me be united with all who fear you,
with those who know your laws.

⁸⁰May I be blameless in keeping your decrees;
then I will never be ashamed.

Kaph

⁸¹I am worn out waiting for your rescue,
but I have put my hope in your word.

⁸²My eyes are straining to see your promises come true.
When will you comfort me?

⁸³I am shriveled like a wineskin in the smoke,
but I have not forgotten to obey your decrees.

⁸⁴How long must I wait?
When will you punish those who persecute me?

⁸⁵These arrogant people who hate your instructions
have dug deep pits to trap me.

⁸⁶All your commands are trustworthy.
Protect me from those who hunt me down without cause.

- ⁸⁷They almost finished me off,
but I refused to abandon your commandments.
⁸⁸In your unfailing love, spare my life;
then I can continue to obey your laws.

Lamedh

- ⁸⁹Your eternal word, O Lord,
stands firm in heaven.
⁹⁰Your faithfulness extends to every generation,
as enduring as the earth you created.
⁹¹Your regulations remain true to this day,
for everything serves your plans.
⁹²If your instructions hadn't sustained me with joy,
I would have died in my misery.
⁹³I will never forget your commandments,
for by them you give me life.
⁹⁴I am yours; rescue me!
For I have worked hard at obeying your commandments.
⁹⁵Though the wicked hide along the way to kill me,
I will quietly keep my mind on your laws.
⁹⁶Even perfection has its limits,
but your commands have no limit.

Mem

- ⁹⁷Oh, how I love your instructions!
I think about them all day long.
⁹⁸Your commands make me wiser than my enemies,
for they are my constant guide.
⁹⁹Yes, I have more insight than my teachers,
for I am always thinking of your laws.
¹⁰⁰I am even wiser than my elders,
for I have kept your commandments.
¹⁰¹I have refused to walk on any evil path,

Psalms 119

- so that I may remain obedient to your word.
¹⁰²I haven't turned away from your regulations,
for you have taught me well.
¹⁰³How sweet your words taste to me;
they are sweeter than honey.
¹⁰⁴Your commandments give me understanding;
no wonder I hate every false way of life.

Nun

- ¹⁰⁵Your word is a lamp to guide my feet
and a light for my path.
¹⁰⁶I've promised it once, and I'll promise it again:
I will obey your righteous regulations.
¹⁰⁷I have suffered much, O Lord;
restore my life again as you promised.
¹⁰⁸Lord, accept my offering of praise,
and teach me your regulations.
¹⁰⁹My life constantly hangs in the balance,
but I will not stop obeying your instructions.
¹¹⁰The wicked have set their traps for me,
but I will not turn from your commandments.
¹¹¹Your laws are my treasure;
they are my heart's delight.
¹¹²I am determined to keep your decrees
to the very end.

Samekh

- ¹¹³I hate those with divided loyalties,
but I love your instructions.
¹¹⁴You are my refuge and my shield;
your word is my source of hope.
¹¹⁵Get out of my life, you evil-minded people,
for I intend to obey the commands of my God.

- 116 Lord, sustain me as you promised, that I may live!
Do not let my hope be crushed.
- 117 Sustain me, and I will be rescued;
then I will meditate continually on your decrees.
- 118 But you have rejected all who stray from your decrees.
They are only fooling themselves.
- 119 You skim off the wicked of the earth like scum;
no wonder I love to obey your laws!
- 120 I tremble in fear of you;
I stand in awe of your regulations.

Ayin

- 121 Don't leave me to the mercy of my enemies,
for I have done what is just and right.
- 122 Please guarantee a blessing for me.
Don't let the arrogant oppress me!
- 123 My eyes strain to see your rescue,
to see the truth of your promise fulfilled.
- 124 I am your servant; deal with me in unfailing love,
and teach me your decrees.
- 125 Give discernment to me, your servant;
then I will understand your laws.
- 126 Lord, it is time for you to act,
for these evil people have violated your instructions.
- 127 Truly, I love your commands
more than gold, even the finest gold.
- 128 Each of your commandments is right.
That is why I hate every false way.

Pe

- 129 Your laws are wonderful.
No wonder I obey them!
- 130 The teaching of your word gives light,

so even the simple can understand.

¹³¹I pant with expectation,

longing for your commands.

¹³²Come and show me your mercy,

as you do for all who love your name.

¹³³Guide my steps by your word,

so I will not be overcome by evil.

¹³⁴Ransom me from the oppression of evil people;

then I can obey your commandments.

¹³⁵Look upon me with love;

teach me your decrees.

¹³⁶Rivers of tears gush from my eyes

because people disobey your instructions.

Tsadhe

¹³⁷O Lord, you are righteous,

and your regulations are fair.

¹³⁸Your laws are perfect

and completely trustworthy.

¹³⁹I am overwhelmed with indignation,

for my enemies have disregarded your words.

¹⁴⁰Your promises have been thoroughly tested;

that is why I love them so much.

¹⁴¹I am insignificant and despised,

but I don't forget your commandments.

¹⁴²Your justice is eternal,

and your instructions are perfectly true.

¹⁴³As pressure and stress bear down on me,

I find joy in your commands.

¹⁴⁴Your laws are always right;

help me to understand them so I may live.

Qoph

- ¹⁴⁵I pray with all my heart; answer me, Lord!
I will obey your decrees.
- ¹⁴⁶I cry out to you; rescue me,
that I may obey your laws.
- ¹⁴⁷I rise early, before the sun is up;
I cry out for help and put my hope in your words.
- ¹⁴⁸I stay awake through the night,
thinking about your promise.
- ¹⁴⁹In your faithful love, O Lord, hear my cry;
let me be revived by following your regulations.
- ¹⁵⁰Lawless people are coming to attack me;
they live far from your instructions.
- ¹⁵¹But you are near, O Lord,
and all your commands are true.
- ¹⁵²I have known from my earliest days
that your laws will last forever.

Resh

- ¹⁵³Look upon my suffering and rescue me,
for I have not forgotten your instructions.
- ¹⁵⁴Argue my case; take my side!
Protect my life as you promised.
- ¹⁵⁵The wicked are far from rescue,
for they do not bother with your decrees.
- ¹⁵⁶Lord, how great is your mercy;
let me be revived by following your regulations.
- ¹⁵⁷Many persecute and trouble me,
yet I have not swerved from your laws.
- ¹⁵⁸Seeing these traitors makes me sick at heart,
because they care nothing for your word.
- ¹⁵⁹See how I love your commandments, Lord.
Give back my life because of your unfailing love.
- ¹⁶⁰The very essence of your words is truth;

all your just regulations will stand forever.

Shin

- ¹⁶¹Powerful people harass me without cause,
but my heart trembles only at your word.
- ¹⁶²I rejoice in your word
like one who discovers a great treasure.
- ¹⁶³I hate and abhor all falsehood,
but I love your instructions.
- ¹⁶⁴I will praise you seven times a day
because all your regulations are just.
- ¹⁶⁵Those who love your instructions have great peace
and do not stumble.
- ¹⁶⁶I long for your rescue, Lord,
so I have obeyed your commands.
- ¹⁶⁷I have obeyed your laws,
for I love them very much.
- ¹⁶⁸Yes, I obey your commandments and laws
because you know everything I do.

Taw

- ¹⁶⁹O Lord, listen to my cry;
give me the discerning mind you promised.
- ¹⁷⁰Listen to my prayer;
rescue me as you promised.
- ¹⁷¹Let praise flow from my lips,
for you have taught me your decrees.
- ¹⁷²Let my tongue sing about your word,
for all your commands are right.
- ¹⁷³Give me a helping hand,
for I have chosen to follow your commandments.
- ¹⁷⁴O Lord, I have longed for your rescue,
and your instructions are my delight.

- ¹⁷⁵Let me live so I can praise you,
and may your regulations help me.
¹⁷⁶I have wandered away like a lost sheep;
come and find me,
for I have not forgotten your commands.

120

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.



- took my troubles to the Lord;
I cried out to him, and he answered my prayer.
²Rescue me, O Lord, from liars
and from all deceitful people.
³O deceptive tongue, what will God do to you?
How will he increase your punishment?
⁴You will be pierced with sharp arrows
and burned with glowing coals.

⁵How I suffer in far-off Meshech.
It pains me to live in distant Kedar.
⁶I am tired of living
among people who hate peace.
⁷I search for peace;
but when I speak of peace, they want war!

121

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.



- look up to the mountains—
does my help come from there?

²My help comes from the Lord,
who made heaven and earth!

³He will not let you stumble;
the one who watches over you will not slumber.

⁴Indeed, he who watches over Israel
never slumbers or sleeps.

⁵The Lord himself watches over you!
The Lord stands beside you as your protective shade.

⁶The sun will not harm you by day,
nor the moon at night.

⁷The Lord keeps you from all harm
and watches over your life.

⁸The Lord keeps watch over you as you come and go,
both now and forever.

122

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem. A psalm of David.



was glad when they said to me,
“Let us go to the house of the Lord.”

²And now here we are,
standing inside your gates, O Jerusalem.

³Jerusalem is a well-built city;
its seamless walls cannot be breached.

⁴All the tribes of Israel—the Lord’s people—
make their pilgrimage here.

They come to give thanks to the name of the Lord,

as the law requires of Israel.

⁵Here stand the thrones where judgment is given,
the thrones of the dynasty of David.

⁶Pray for peace in Jerusalem.

May all who love this city prosper.

⁷O Jerusalem, may there be peace within your walls
and prosperity in your palaces.

⁸For the sake of my family and friends, I will say,
“May you have peace.”

⁹For the sake of the house of the Lord our God,
I will seek what is best for you, O Jerusalem.

123

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.



lift my eyes to you,
O God, enthroned in heaven.

²We keep looking to the Lord our God for his mercy,
just as servants keep their eyes on their master,
as a slave girl watches her mistress for the slightest signal.

³Have mercy on us, Lord, have mercy,
for we have had our fill of contempt.

⁴We have had more than our fill of the scoffing of the proud
and the contempt of the arrogant.

124

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem. A psalm of David.



HAT if the Lord had not been on our side?

Let all Israel repeat:

²What if the Lord had not been on our side
when people attacked us?

³They would have swallowed us alive
in their burning anger.

⁴The waters would have engulfed us;
a torrent would have overwhelmed us.

⁵Yes, the raging waters of their fury
would have overwhelmed our very lives.

⁶Praise the Lord,
who did not let their teeth tear us apart!

⁷We escaped like a bird from a hunter's trap.
The trap is broken, and we are free!

⁸Our help is from the Lord,
who made heaven and earth.

125

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.



HOSE who trust in the Lord are as secure as Mount Zion;
they will not be defeated but will endure forever.

²Just as the mountains surround Jerusalem,
so the Lord surrounds his people, both now and forever.

³The wicked will not rule the land of the godly,
for then the godly might be tempted to do wrong.

⁴O Lord, do good to those who are good,
whose hearts are in tune with you.

⁵But banish those who turn to crooked ways, O Lord.
Take them away with those who do evil.

May Israel have peace!

126

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.



WHEN the Lord brought back his exiles to Jerusalem,
it was like a dream!

²We were filled with laughter,
and we sang for joy.
And the other nations said,
“What amazing things the Lord has done for them.”
³Yes, the Lord has done amazing things for us!
What joy!

⁴Restore our fortunes, Lord,
as streams renew the desert.
⁵Those who plant in tears
will harvest with shouts of joy.
⁶They weep as they go to plant their seed,
but they sing as they return with the harvest.

127

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem. A psalm of Solomon.



UNLESS the Lord builds a house,
the work of the builders is wasted.
Unless the Lord protects a city,
guarding it with sentries will do no good.
²It is useless for you to work so hard
from early morning until late at night,

anxiously working for food to eat;
for God gives rest to his loved ones.

³Children are a gift from the Lord;
they are a reward from him.

⁴Children born to a young man
are like arrows in a warrior's hands.

⁵How joyful is the man whose quiver is full of them!
He will not be put to shame when he confronts his accusers
at the city gates.

128

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.

ow joyful are those who fear the Lord—
all who follow his ways!

²You will enjoy the fruit of your labor.
How joyful and prosperous you will be!

³Your wife will be like a fruitful grapevine,
flourishing within your home.
Your children will be like vigorous young olive trees
as they sit around your table.

⁴That is the Lord's blessing
for those who fear him.

⁵May the Lord continually bless you from Zion.
May you see Jerusalem prosper as long as you live.

⁶May you live to enjoy your grandchildren.
May Israel have peace!

129

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.



FROM my earliest youth my enemies have persecuted me.

Let all Israel repeat this:

²From my earliest youth my enemies have persecuted me,
but they have never defeated me.

³My back is covered with cuts,
as if a farmer had plowed long furrows.

⁴But the Lord is good;
he has cut me free from the ropes of the ungodly.

⁵May all who hate Jerusalem
be turned back in shameful defeat.

⁶May they be as useless as grass on a rooftop,
turning yellow when only half grown,

⁷ignored by the harvester,
despised by the binder.

⁸And may those who pass by
refuse to give them this blessing:

“The Lord bless you;
we bless you in the Lord’s name.”

130

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.



FROM the depths of despair, O Lord,

I call for your help.

²Hear my cry, O Lord.

Pay attention to my prayer.

³Lord, if you kept a record of our sins,
who, O Lord, could ever survive?

⁴But you offer forgiveness,
that we might learn to fear you.

⁵I am counting on the Lord;
yes, I am counting on him.
I have put my hope in his word.

⁶I long for the Lord
more than sentries long for the dawn,
yes, more than sentries long for the dawn.

⁷O Israel, hope in the Lord;
for with the Lord there is unfailing love.
His redemption overflows.

⁸He himself will redeem Israel
from every kind of sin.

131

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem. A psalm of David.



ORD, my heart is not proud;
my eyes are not haughty.

I don't concern myself with matters too great
or too awesome for me to grasp.

²Instead, I have calmed and quieted myself,
like a weaned child who no longer cries for its mother's milk.
Yes, like a weaned child is my soul within me.

³O Israel, put your hope in the Lord—

now and always.

132

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.



LORD, remember David
and all that he suffered.

- ²He made a solemn promise to the Lord.
He vowed to the Mighty One of Israel,
³“I will not go home;
I will not let myself rest.
⁴I will not let my eyes sleep
nor close my eyelids in slumber
⁵until I find a place to build a house for the Lord,
a sanctuary for the Mighty One of Israel.”

- ⁶We heard that the Ark was in Ephrathah;
then we found it in the distant countryside of Jaar.
⁷Let us go to the sanctuary of the Lord;
let us worship at the footstool of his throne.
⁸Arise, O Lord, and enter your resting place,
along with the Ark, the symbol of your power.
⁹May your priests be clothed in godliness;
may your loyal servants sing for joy.
¹⁰For the sake of your servant David,
do not reject the king you have anointed.
¹¹The Lord swore an oath to David
with a promise he will never take back:
“I will place one of your descendants
on your throne.
¹²If your descendants obey the terms of my covenant
and the laws that I teach them,

then your royal line
will continue forever and ever.”

¹³For the Lord has chosen Jerusalem;
he has desired it for his home.

¹⁴“This is my resting place forever,” he said.
“I will live here, for this is the home I desired.

¹⁵I will bless this city and make it prosperous;
I will satisfy its poor with food.

¹⁶I will clothe its priests with godliness;
its faithful servants will sing for joy.

¹⁷Here I will increase the power of David;
my anointed one will be a light for my people.

¹⁸I will clothe his enemies with shame,
but he will be a glorious king.”

133

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem. A psalm of David.



ow wonderful and pleasant it is
when brothers live together in harmony!

²For harmony is as precious as the anointing oil
that was poured over Aaron’s head,
that ran down his beard
and onto the border of his robe.

³Harmony is as refreshing as the dew from Mount Hermon
that falls on the mountains of Zion.

And there the Lord has pronounced his blessing,
even life everlasting.

134

A song for pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem.

H, praise the Lord, all you servants of the Lord,
you who serve at night in the house of the Lord.
²Lift your hands toward the sanctuary,
and praise the Lord.

³May the Lord, who made heaven and earth,
bless you from Jerusalem.

135

RAISE the Lord!

Praise the name of the Lord!

Praise him, you who serve the Lord,
²you who serve in the house of the Lord,
in the courts of the house of our God.

³Praise the Lord, for the Lord is good;
celebrate his lovely name with music.

⁴For the Lord has chosen Jacob for himself,
Israel for his own special treasure.

⁵I know the greatness of the Lord—
that our Lord is greater than any other god.

⁶The Lord does whatever pleases him

- throughout all heaven and earth,
and on the seas and in their depths.
- ⁷He causes the clouds to rise over the whole earth.
He sends the lightning with the rain
and releases the wind from his storehouses.
- ⁸He destroyed the firstborn in each Egyptian home,
both people and animals.
- ⁹He performed miraculous signs and wonders in Egypt
against Pharaoh and all his people.
- ¹⁰He struck down great nations
and slaughtered mighty kings—
- ¹¹Sihon king of the Amorites,
Og king of Bashan,
and all the kings of Canaan.
- ¹²He gave their land as an inheritance,
a special possession to his people Israel.
- ¹³Your name, O Lord, endures forever;
your fame, O Lord, is known to every generation.
- ¹⁴For the Lord will give justice to his people
and have compassion on his servants.
- ¹⁵The idols of the nations are merely things of silver and gold,
shaped by human hands.
- ¹⁶They have mouths but cannot speak,
and eyes but cannot see.
- ¹⁷They have ears but cannot hear,
and mouths but cannot breathe.
- ¹⁸And those who make idols are just like them,
as are all who trust in them.

¹⁹O Israel, praise the Lord!

O priests—descendants of Aaron—praise the Lord!

²⁰O Levites, praise the Lord!

All you who fear the Lord, praise the Lord!

²¹The Lord be praised from Zion,
for he lives here in Jerusalem.

Praise the Lord!

136



GIVE thanks to the Lord, for he is good!

His faithful love endures forever.

²Give thanks to the God of gods.

His faithful love endures forever.

³Give thanks to the Lord of lords.

His faithful love endures forever.

⁴Give thanks to him who alone does mighty miracles.

His faithful love endures forever.

⁵Give thanks to him who made the heavens so skillfully.

His faithful love endures forever.

⁶Give thanks to him who placed the earth among the waters.

His faithful love endures forever.

⁷Give thanks to him who made the heavenly lights—

His faithful love endures forever.

⁸the sun to rule the day,

His faithful love endures forever.

⁹and the moon and stars to rule the night.

His faithful love endures forever.

¹⁰Give thanks to him who killed the firstborn of Egypt.

His faithful love endures forever.

¹¹He brought Israel out of Egypt.

His faithful love endures forever.

¹²He acted with a strong hand and powerful arm.

His faithful love endures forever.

¹³Give thanks to him who parted the Red Sea.

His faithful love endures forever.

¹⁴He led Israel safely through,

His faithful love endures forever.

¹⁵but he hurled Pharaoh and his army into the Red Sea.

His faithful love endures forever.

¹⁶Give thanks to him who led his people through the wilderness.

His faithful love endures forever.

¹⁷Give thanks to him who struck down mighty kings.

His faithful love endures forever.

¹⁸He killed powerful kings—

His faithful love endures forever.

¹⁹Sihon king of the Amorites,

His faithful love endures forever.

²⁰and Og king of Bashan.

His faithful love endures forever.

²¹God gave the land of these kings as an inheritance—

His faithful love endures forever.

²²a special possession to his servant Israel.

His faithful love endures forever.

²³He remembered us in our weakness.

His faithful love endures forever.

²⁴He saved us from our enemies.

His faithful love endures forever.

²⁵He gives food to every living thing.

His faithful love endures forever.

²⁶Give thanks to the God of heaven.

His faithful love endures forever.

137

BESIDE the rivers of Babylon, we sat and wept
as we thought of Jerusalem.

²We put away our harps,
hanging them on the branches of poplar trees.

³For our captors demanded a song from us.
Our tormentors insisted on a joyful hymn:
“Sing us one of those songs of Jerusalem!”

⁴But how can we sing the songs of the Lord
while in a pagan land?

⁵If I forget you, O Jerusalem,
let my right hand forget how to play the harp.

⁶May my tongue stick to the roof of my mouth
if I fail to remember you,
if I don’t make Jerusalem my greatest joy.

⁷O Lord, remember what the Edomites did
on the day the armies of Babylon captured Jerusalem.

“Destroy it!” they yelled.
“Level it to the ground!”

- ⁸O Babylon, you will be destroyed.
Happy is the one who pays you back
for what you have done to us.
⁹Happy is the one who takes your babies
and smashes them against the rocks!

138

A psalm of David.



- give you thanks, O Lord, with all my heart;
I will sing your praises before the gods.
²I bow before your holy Temple as I worship.
I praise your name for your unfailing love and faithfulness;
for your promises are backed
by all the honor of your name.
³As soon as I pray, you answer me;
you encourage me by giving me strength.
- ⁴Every king in all the earth will thank you, Lord,
for all of them will hear your words.
⁵Yes, they will sing about the Lord's ways,
for the glory of the Lord is very great.
⁶Though the Lord is great, he cares for the humble,
but he keeps his distance from the proud.
- ⁷Though I am surrounded by troubles,
you will protect me from the anger of my enemies.
You reach out your hand,
and the power of your right hand saves me.
⁸The Lord will work out his plans for my life—
for your faithful love, O Lord, endures forever.

Don't abandon me, for you made me.

139

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



Lord, you have examined my heart
and know everything about me.

²You know when I sit down or stand up.

You know my thoughts even when I'm far away.

³You see me when I travel
and when I rest at home.

You know everything I do.

⁴You know what I am going to say
even before I say it, Lord.

⁵You go before me and follow me.

You place your hand of blessing on my head.

⁶Such knowledge is too wonderful for me,
too great for me to understand!

⁷I can never escape from your Spirit!

I can never get away from your presence!

⁸If I go up to heaven, you are there;
if I go down to the grave, you are there.

⁹If I ride the wings of the morning,
if I dwell by the farthest oceans,

¹⁰even there your hand will guide me,
and your strength will support me.

¹¹I could ask the darkness to hide me
and the light around me to become night—

¹²but even in darkness I cannot hide from you.

To you the night shines as bright as day.

Darkness and light are the same to you.

¹³You made all the delicate, inner parts of my body
and knit me together in my mother's womb.
¹⁴Thank you for making me so wonderfully complex!
Your workmanship is marvelous—how well I know it.
¹⁵You watched me as I was being formed in utter seclusion,
as I was woven together in the dark of the womb.
¹⁶You saw me before I was born.
Every day of my life was recorded in your book.
Every moment was laid out
before a single day had passed.

¹⁷How precious are your thoughts about me, O God.
They cannot be numbered!
¹⁸I can't even count them;
they outnumber the grains of sand!
And when I wake up,
you are still with me!

¹⁹O God, if only you would destroy the wicked!
Get out of my life, you murderers!
²⁰They blaspheme you;
your enemies misuse your name.
²¹O Lord, shouldn't I hate those who hate you?
Shouldn't I despise those who oppose you?
²²Yes, I hate them with total hatred,
for your enemies are my enemies.

²³Search me, O God, and know my heart;
test me and know my anxious thoughts.
²⁴Point out anything in me that offends you,
and lead me along the path of everlasting life.

140

For the choir director: A psalm of David.



Lord, rescue me from evil people.
Protect me from those who are violent,
²those who plot evil in their hearts
and stir up trouble all day long.
³Their tongues sting like a snake;
the venom of a viper drips from their lips.

Interlude

⁴O Lord, keep me out of the hands of the wicked.
Protect me from those who are violent,
for they are plotting against me.
⁵The proud have set a trap to catch me;
they have stretched out a net;
they have placed traps all along the way.

Interlude

⁶I said to the Lord, "You are my God!"
Listen, O Lord, to my cries for mercy!
⁷O Sovereign Lord, the strong one who rescued me,
you protected me on the day of battle.
⁸Lord, do not let evil people have their way.
Do not let their evil schemes succeed,
or they will become proud.

Interlude

⁹Let my enemies be destroyed
by the very evil they have planned for me.
¹⁰Let burning coals fall down on their heads.

Let them be thrown into the fire
or into watery pits from which they can't escape.
¹¹Don't let liars prosper here in our land.
Cause great disasters to fall on the violent.

¹²But I know the Lord will help those they persecute;
he will give justice to the poor.
¹³Surely righteous people are praising your name;
the godly will live in your presence.

141

A psalm of David.



Lord, I am calling to you. Please hurry!
Listen when I cry to you for help!
²Accept my prayer as incense offered to you,
and my upraised hands as an evening offering.

³Take control of what I say, O Lord,
and guard my lips.
⁴Don't let me drift toward evil
or take part in acts of wickedness.
Don't let me share in the delicacies
of those who do wrong.

⁵Let the godly strike me!
It will be a kindness!
If they correct me, it is soothing medicine.
Don't let me refuse it.

- But I pray constantly
against the wicked and their deeds.
- ⁶When their leaders are thrown down from a cliff,
the wicked will listen to my words and find them true.
- ⁷Like rocks brought up by a plow,
the bones of the wicked will lie scattered without burial.
- ⁸I look to you for help, O Sovereign Lord.
You are my refuge; don't let them kill me.
- ⁹Keep me from the traps they have set for me,
from the snares of those who do wrong.
- ¹⁰Let the wicked fall into their own nets,
but let me escape.

142

A psalm of David, regarding his experience in the cave. A prayer.



- L** cry out to the Lord;
I plead for the Lord's mercy.
- ²I pour out my complaints before him
and tell him all my troubles.
- ³When I am overwhelmed,
you alone know the way I should turn.
Wherever I go,
my enemies have set traps for me.
- ⁴I look for someone to come and help me,
but no one gives me a passing thought!
No one will help me;
no one cares a bit what happens to me.
- ⁵Then I pray to you, O Lord.
I say, "You are my place of refuge.
You are all I really want in life."

⁶Hear my cry,
for I am very low.
Rescue me from my persecutors,
for they are too strong for me.
⁷Bring me out of prison
so I can thank you.
The godly will crowd around me,
for you are good to me.”

143

A psalm of David.



HEAR my prayer, O Lord;
listen to my plea!
Answer me because you are faithful and righteous.
²Don't put your servant on trial,
for no one is innocent before you.
³My enemy has chased me.
He has knocked me to the ground
and forces me to live in darkness like those in the grave.
⁴I am losing all hope;
I am paralyzed with fear.
⁵I remember the days of old.
I ponder all your great works
and think about what you have done.
⁶I lift my hands to you in prayer.
I thirst for you as parched land thirsts for rain.

Interlude

⁷Come quickly, Lord, and answer me,
for my depression deepens.
Don't turn away from me,

or I will die.

⁸Let me hear of your unfailing love each morning,
for I am trusting you.

Show me where to walk,
for I give myself to you.

⁹Rescue me from my enemies, Lord;
I run to you to hide me.

¹⁰Teach me to do your will,
for you are my God.

May your gracious Spirit lead me forward
on a firm footing.

¹¹For the glory of your name, O Lord, preserve my life.
Because of your faithfulness, bring me out of this distress.

¹²In your unfailing love, silence all my enemies
and destroy all my foes,
for I am your servant.

144

A psalm of David.



RAISE the Lord, who is my rock.

He trains my hands for war
and gives my fingers skill for battle.

²He is my loving ally and my fortress,
my tower of safety, my rescuer.

He is my shield, and I take refuge in him.
He makes the nations submit to me.

³O Lord, what are human beings that you should notice them,
mere mortals that you should think about them?

⁴For they are like a breath of air;
their days are like a passing shadow.

⁵Open the heavens, Lord, and come down.

Touch the mountains so they billow smoke.

⁶Hurl your lightning bolts and scatter your enemies!

Shoot your arrows and confuse them!

⁷Reach down from heaven and rescue me;

rescue me from deep waters,

from the power of my enemies.

⁸Their mouths are full of lies;

they swear to tell the truth, but they lie instead.

⁹I will sing a new song to you, O God!

I will sing your praises with a ten-stringed harp.

¹⁰For you grant victory to kings!

You rescued your servant David from the fatal sword.

¹¹Save me!

Rescue me from the power of my enemies.

Their mouths are full of lies;

they swear to tell the truth, but they lie instead.

¹²May our sons flourish in their youth

like well-nurtured plants.

May our daughters be like graceful pillars,

carved to beautify a palace.

¹³May our barns be filled

with crops of every kind.

May the flocks in our fields multiply by the thousands,

even tens of thousands,

¹⁴and may our oxen be loaded down with produce.

May there be no enemy breaking through our walls,

no going into captivity,

no cries of alarm in our town squares.

¹⁵Yes, joyful are those who live like this!

Joyful indeed are those whose God is the Lord.

145

A psalm of praise of David.



will exalt you, my God and King,
and praise your name forever and ever.

²I will praise you every day;
yes, I will praise you forever.

³Great is the Lord! He is most worthy of praise!
No one can measure his greatness.

⁴Let each generation tell its children of your mighty acts;
let them proclaim your power.

⁵I will meditate on your majestic, glorious splendor
and your wonderful miracles.

⁶Your awe-inspiring deeds will be on every tongue;
I will proclaim your greatness.

⁷Everyone will share the story of your wonderful goodness;
they will sing with joy about your righteousness.

⁸The Lord is merciful and compassionate,
slow to get angry and filled with unfailing love.

⁹The Lord is good to everyone.
He showers compassion on all his creation.

¹⁰All of your works will thank you, Lord,
and your faithful followers will praise you.

¹¹They will speak of the glory of your kingdom;
they will give examples of your power.

¹²They will tell about your mighty deeds
and about the majesty and glory of your reign.

¹³For your kingdom is an everlasting kingdom.
You rule throughout all generations.

The Lord always keeps his promises;
he is gracious in all he does.

¹⁴The Lord helps the fallen
and lifts those bent beneath their loads.

¹⁵The eyes of all look to you in hope;
you give them their food as they need it.

¹⁶When you open your hand,
you satisfy the hunger and thirst of every living thing.

¹⁷The Lord is righteous in everything he does;
he is filled with kindness.

¹⁸The Lord is close to all who call on him,
yes, to all who call on him in truth.

¹⁹He grants the desires of those who fear him;
he hears their cries for help and rescues them.

²⁰The Lord protects all those who love him,
but he destroys the wicked.

²¹I will praise the Lord,
and may everyone on earth bless his holy name
forever and ever.

146



RAISE the Lord!

Let all that I am praise the Lord.

²I will praise the Lord as long as I live.

I will sing praises to my God with my dying breath.

³Don't put your confidence in powerful people;
there is no help for you there.

⁴When they breathe their last, they return to the earth,
and all their plans die with them.

⁵But joyful are those who have the God of Israel as their helper,
whose hope is in the Lord their God.

⁶He made heaven and earth,
the sea, and everything in them.
He keeps every promise forever.

⁷He gives justice to the oppressed
and food to the hungry.

The Lord frees the prisoners.

⁸The Lord opens the eyes of the blind.
The Lord lifts up those who are weighed down.
The Lord loves the godly.

⁹The Lord protects the foreigners among us.
He cares for the orphans and widows,
but he frustrates the plans of the wicked.

¹⁰The Lord will reign forever.
He will be your God, O Jerusalem, throughout the generations.

Praise the Lord!



How good to sing praises to our God!
How delightful and how fitting!

²The Lord is rebuilding Jerusalem
and bringing the exiles back to Israel.

³He heals the brokenhearted
and bandages their wounds.

⁴He counts the stars
and calls them all by name.

⁵How great is our Lord! His power is absolute!
His understanding is beyond comprehension!

⁶The Lord supports the humble,
but he brings the wicked down into the dust.

⁷Sing out your thanks to the Lord;
sing praises to our God with a harp.

⁸He covers the heavens with clouds,
provides rain for the earth,
and makes the grass grow in mountain pastures.

⁹He gives food to the wild animals
and feeds the young ravens when they cry.

¹⁰He takes no pleasure in the strength of a horse
or in human might.

¹¹No, the Lord's delight is in those who fear him,
those who put their hope in his unfailing love.

¹²Glorify the Lord, O Jerusalem!
Praise your God, O Zion!

¹³For he has strengthened the bars of your gates
and blessed your children within your walls.

¹⁴He sends peace across your nation
and satisfies your hunger with the finest wheat.

¹⁵He sends his orders to the world—

how swiftly his word flies!

¹⁶He sends the snow like white wool;
he scatters frost upon the ground like ashes.

¹⁷He hurls the hail like stones.

Who can stand against his freezing cold?

¹⁸Then, at his command, it all melts.

He sends his winds, and the ice thaws.

¹⁹He has revealed his words to Jacob,
his decrees and regulations to Israel.

²⁰He has not done this for any other nation;
they do not know his regulations.

Praise the Lord!

148



RAISE the Lord!

Praise the Lord from the heavens!

Praise him from the skies!

²Praise him, all his angels!

Praise him, all the armies of heaven!

³Praise him, sun and moon!

Praise him, all you twinkling stars!

⁴Praise him, skies above!

Praise him, vapors high above the clouds!

⁵Let every created thing give praise to the Lord,
for he issued his command, and they came into being.

⁶He set them in place forever and ever.

His decree will never be revoked.

⁷Praise the Lord from the earth,
you creatures of the ocean depths,
⁸fire and hail, snow and clouds,
wind and weather that obey him,
⁹mountains and all hills,
fruit trees and all cedars,
¹⁰wild animals and all livestock,
small scurrying animals and birds,
¹¹kings of the earth and all people,
rulers and judges of the earth,
¹²young men and young women,
old men and children.

¹³Let them all praise the name of the Lord.
For his name is very great;
his glory towers over the earth and heaven!
¹⁴He has made his people strong,
honoring his faithful ones—
the people of Israel who are close to him.

Praise the Lord!

149



RAISE the Lord!

Sing to the Lord a new song.
Sing his praises in the assembly of the faithful.

²O Israel, rejoice in your Maker.

- O people of Jerusalem, exult in your King.
³Praise his name with dancing,
 accompanied by tambourine and harp.
⁴For the Lord delights in his people;
 he crowns the humble with victory.
⁵Let the faithful rejoice that he honors them.
 Let them sing for joy as they lie on their beds.
- ⁶Let the praises of God be in their mouths,
 and a sharp sword in their hands—
⁷to execute vengeance on the nations
 and punishment on the peoples,
⁸to bind their kings with shackles
 and their leaders with iron chains,
⁹to execute the judgment written against them.
 This is the glorious privilege of his faithful ones.

Praise the Lord!

150



RAISE the Lord!

- Praise God in his sanctuary;
 praise him in his mighty heaven!
²Praise him for his mighty works;
 praise his unequaled greatness!
³Praise him with a blast of the ram's horn;
 praise him with the lyre and harp!
⁴Praise him with the tambourine and dancing;

Psalms 150

praise him with strings and flutes!

⁵Praise him with a clash of cymbals;

praise him with loud clanging cymbals.

⁶Let everything that breathes sing praises to the Lord!

Praise the Lord!

Job

1

Prologue



HERE once was a man named Job who lived in the land of Uz. He was blameless—a man of complete integrity. He feared God and stayed away from evil. ²He had seven sons and three daughters. ³He owned 7,000 sheep, 3,000 camels, 500 teams of oxen, and 500 female donkeys. He also had many servants. He was, in fact, the richest person in that entire area.

⁴Job's sons would take turns preparing feasts in their homes, and they would also invite their three sisters to celebrate with them. ⁵When these celebrations ended—sometimes after several days—Job would purify his children. He would get up early in the morning and offer a burnt offering for each of them. For Job said to himself, "Perhaps my children have sinned and have cursed God in their hearts." This was Job's regular practice.

Job's First Test

⁶One day the members of the heavenly court came to present themselves before the Lord, and the Accuser, Satan, came with them. ⁷**"Where have you come from?"** the Lord asked Satan.

Satan answered the Lord, “I have been patrolling the earth, watching everything that’s going on.”

⁸Then the Lord asked Satan, “Have you noticed my servant Job? He is the finest man in all the earth. He is blameless—a man of complete integrity. He fears God and stays away from evil.”

⁹Satan replied to the Lord, “Yes, but Job has good reason to fear God. ¹⁰You have always put a wall of protection around him and his home and his property. You have made him prosper in everything he does. Look how rich he is! ¹¹But reach out and take away everything he has, and he will surely curse you to your face!”

¹²“All right, you may test him,” the Lord said to Satan. “Do whatever you want with everything he possesses, but don’t harm him physically.” So Satan left the Lord’s presence.

¹³One day when Job’s sons and daughters were feasting at the oldest brother’s house, ¹⁴a messenger arrived at Job’s home with this news: “Your oxen were plowing, with the donkeys feeding beside them, ¹⁵when the Sabeans raided us. They stole all the animals and killed all the farmhands. I am the only one who escaped to tell you.”

¹⁶While he was still speaking, another messenger arrived with this news: “The fire of God has fallen from heaven and burned up your sheep and all the shepherds. I am the only one who escaped to tell you.”

¹⁷While he was still speaking, a third messenger arrived with this news: “Three bands of Chaldean raiders have stolen your camels and killed your servants. I am the only one who escaped to tell you.”

¹⁸While he was still speaking, another messenger arrived with this news: “Your sons and daughters were feasting in their oldest brother’s home. ¹⁹Suddenly, a powerful wind swept in from the wilderness and hit the house on all sides. The house collapsed, and all your children are dead. I am the only one who escaped to tell you.”

²⁰Job stood up and tore his robe in grief. Then he shaved his head and fell to the ground to worship. ²¹He said,

“I came naked from my mother’s womb,
and I will be naked when I leave.
The Lord gave me what I had,
and the Lord has taken it away.
Praise the name of the Lord!”

²²In all of this, Job did not sin by blaming God.

2

Job’s Second Test

NE day the members of the heavenly court came again to present themselves before the Lord, and the Accuser, Satan, came with them. ²“Where have you come from?” the Lord asked Satan.

Satan answered the Lord, “I have been patrolling the earth, watching everything that’s going on.”

³Then the Lord asked Satan, “Have you noticed my servant Job? He is the finest man in all the earth. He is blameless—a man of complete integrity. He fears God and stays away from evil. And he has maintained his integrity, even though you urged me to harm him without cause.”

⁴Satan replied to the Lord, “Skin for skin! A man will give up everything he has to save his life. ⁵But reach out and take away his health, and he will surely curse you to your face!”

⁶“All right, do with him as you please,” the Lord said to Satan. “But spare his life.” ⁷So Satan left the Lord’s presence, and he struck Job with terrible boils from head to foot.

⁸Job scraped his skin with a piece of broken pottery as he sat among the ashes. ⁹His wife said to him, “Are you still trying to maintain your integrity? Curse God and die.”

¹⁰But Job replied, “You talk like a foolish woman. Should we accept only good things from the hand of God and never anything bad?” So in all this, Job said nothing wrong.

Job’s Three Friends Share His Anguish

¹¹When three of Job’s friends heard of the tragedy he had suffered, they got together and traveled from their homes to comfort and console him. Their names were Eliphaz the Temanite, Bildad the Shuhite, and Zophar the Naamathite. ¹²When they saw Job from a distance, they scarcely recognized him. Wailing loudly, they tore their robes and threw dust into the air over their heads to show their grief. ¹³Then they sat on the ground with him for seven days and nights. No one said a word to Job, for they saw that his suffering was too great for words.

3

Job’s First Speech



At last Job spoke, and he cursed the day of his birth. ²He said:

³“Let the day of my birth be erased,
and the night I was conceived.

⁴Let that day be turned to darkness.
Let it be lost even to God on high,
and let no light shine on it.

⁵Let the darkness and utter gloom claim that day for its own.
Let a black cloud overshadow it,
and let the darkness terrify it.

⁶Let that night be blotted off the calendar,
never again to be counted among the days of the year,
never again to appear among the months.

- ⁷Let that night be childless.
Let it have no joy.
- ⁸Let those who are experts at cursing—
whose cursing could rouse Leviathan—
curse that day.
- ⁹Let its morning stars remain dark.
Let it hope for light, but in vain;
may it never see the morning light.
- ¹⁰Curse that day for failing to shut my mother's womb,
for letting me be born to see all this trouble.
- ¹¹“Why wasn't I born dead?
Why didn't I die as I came from the womb?”
- ¹²Why was I laid on my mother's lap?
Why did she nurse me at her breasts?
- ¹³Had I died at birth, I would now be at peace.
I would be asleep and at rest.
- ¹⁴I would rest with the world's kings and prime ministers,
whose great buildings now lie in ruins.
- ¹⁵I would rest with princes, rich in gold,
whose palaces were filled with silver.
- ¹⁶Why wasn't I buried like a stillborn child,
like a baby who never lives to see the light?
- ¹⁷For in death the wicked cause no trouble,
and the weary are at rest.
- ¹⁸Even captives are at ease in death,
with no guards to curse them.
- ¹⁹Rich and poor are both there,
and the slave is free from his master.
- ²⁰“Oh, why give light to those in misery,
and life to those who are bitter?”

²¹They long for death, and it won't come.

They search for death more eagerly than for hidden treasure.

²²They're filled with joy when they finally die,
and rejoice when they find the grave.

²³Why is life given to those with no future,
those God has surrounded with difficulties?

²⁴I cannot eat for sighing;
my groans pour out like water.

²⁵What I always feared has happened to me.
What I dreaded has come true.

²⁶I have no peace, no quietness.
I have no rest; only trouble comes."

4

Eliphaz's First Response to Job



HEN Eliphaz the Temanite replied to Job:

²"Will you be patient and let me say a word?
For who could keep from speaking out?

³"In the past you have encouraged many people;
you have strengthened those who were weak.

⁴Your words have supported those who were falling;
you encouraged those with shaky knees.

⁵But now when trouble strikes, you lose heart.
You are terrified when it touches you.

⁶Doesn't your reverence for God give you confidence?
Doesn't your life of integrity give you hope?

- ⁷“Stop and think! Do the innocent die?
When have the upright been destroyed?
- ⁸My experience shows that those who plant trouble
and cultivate evil will harvest the same.
- ⁹A breath from God destroys them.
They vanish in a blast of his anger.
- ¹⁰The lion roars and the wildcat snarls,
but the teeth of strong lions will be broken.
- ¹¹The fierce lion will starve for lack of prey,
and the cubs of the lioness will be scattered.
- ¹²“This truth was given to me in secret,
as though whispered in my ear.
- ¹³It came to me in a disturbing vision at night,
when people are in a deep sleep.
- ¹⁴Fear gripped me,
and my bones trembled.
- ¹⁵A spirit swept past my face,
and my hair stood on end.
- ¹⁶The spirit stopped, but I couldn’t see its shape.
There was a form before my eyes.
- In the silence I heard a voice say,
- ¹⁷“Can a mortal be innocent before God?
Can anyone be pure before the Creator?”
- ¹⁸“If God does not trust his own angels
and has charged his messengers with foolishness,
- ¹⁹how much less will he trust people made of clay!
They are made of dust, crushed as easily as a moth.
- ²⁰They are alive in the morning but dead by evening,
gone forever without a trace.
- ²¹Their tent-cords are pulled and the tent collapses,

and they die in ignorance.

5

Eliphaz's Response Continues



RY for help, but will anyone answer you?

Which of the angels will help you?

²Surely resentment destroys the fool,
and jealousy kills the simple.

³I have seen that fools may be successful for the moment,
but then comes sudden disaster.

⁴Their children are abandoned far from help;
they are crushed in court with no one to defend them.

⁵The hungry devour their harvest,
even when it is guarded by brambles.
The thirsty pant after their wealth.

⁶But evil does not spring from the soil,
and trouble does not sprout from the earth.

⁷People are born for trouble
as readily as sparks fly up from a fire.

⁸"If I were you, I would go to God
and present my case to him.

⁹He does great things too marvelous to understand.
He performs countless miracles.

¹⁰He gives rain for the earth
and water for the fields.

¹¹He gives prosperity to the poor
and protects those who suffer.

¹²He frustrates the plans of schemers

so the work of their hands will not succeed.

¹³He traps the wise in their own cleverness
so their cunning schemes are thwarted.

¹⁴They find it is dark in the daytime,
and they grope at noon as if it were night.

¹⁵He rescues the poor from the cutting words of the strong,
and rescues them from the clutches of the powerful.

¹⁶And so at last the poor have hope,
and the snapping jaws of the wicked are shut.

¹⁷“But consider the joy of those corrected by God!
Do not despise the discipline of the Almighty when you sin.

¹⁸For though he wounds, he also bandages.
He strikes, but his hands also heal.

¹⁹From six disasters he will rescue you;
even in the seventh, he will keep you from evil.

²⁰He will save you from death in time of famine,
from the power of the sword in time of war.

²¹You will be safe from slander
and have no fear when destruction comes.

²²You will laugh at destruction and famine;
wild animals will not terrify you.

²³You will be at peace with the stones of the field,
and its wild animals will be at peace with you.

²⁴You will know that your home is safe.
When you survey your possessions, nothing will be missing.

²⁵You will have many children;
your descendants will be as plentiful as grass!

²⁶You will go to the grave at a ripe old age,
like a sheaf of grain harvested at the proper time!

²⁷“We have studied life and found all this to be true.

Listen to my counsel, and apply it to yourself.”

6

Job’s Second Speech: A Response to Eliphaz



HEN Job spoke again:

- ²“If my misery could be weighed
and my troubles be put on the scales,
³they would outweigh all the sands of the sea.
That is why I spoke impulsively.
⁴For the Almighty has struck me down with his arrows.
Their poison infects my spirit.
God’s terrors are lined up against me.
⁵Don’t I have a right to complain?
Don’t wild donkeys bray when they find no grass,
and oxen bellow when they have no food?
⁶Don’t people complain about unsalted food?
Does anyone want the tasteless white of an egg?
⁷My appetite disappears when I look at it;
I gag at the thought of eating it!
- ⁸“Oh, that I might have my request,
that God would grant my desire.
⁹I wish he would crush me.
I wish he would reach out his hand and kill me.
¹⁰At least I can take comfort in this:
Despite the pain,
I have not denied the words of the Holy One.

¹¹But I don't have the strength to endure.

I have nothing to live for.

¹²Do I have the strength of a stone?

Is my body made of bronze?

¹³No, I am utterly helpless,
without any chance of success.

¹⁴"One should be kind to a fainting friend,
but you accuse me without any fear of the Almighty.

¹⁵My brothers, you have proved as unreliable as a seasonal brook
that overflows its banks in the spring

¹⁶when it is swollen with ice and melting snow.

¹⁷But when the hot weather arrives, the water disappears.
The brook vanishes in the heat.

¹⁸The caravans turn aside to be refreshed,
but there is nothing to drink, so they die.

¹⁹The caravans from Tema search for this water;
the travelers from Sheba hope to find it.

²⁰They count on it but are disappointed.
When they arrive, their hopes are dashed.

²¹You, too, have given no help.
You have seen my calamity, and you are afraid.

²²But why? Have I ever asked you for a gift?
Have I begged for anything of yours for myself?

²³Have I asked you to rescue me from my enemies,
or to save me from ruthless people?

²⁴Teach me, and I will keep quiet.
Show me what I have done wrong.

²⁵Honest words can be painful,
but what do your criticisms amount to?

²⁶Do you think your words are convincing
when you disregard my cry of desperation?

²⁷You would even send an orphan into slavery

or sell a friend.

²⁸Look at me!

Would I lie to your face?

²⁹Stop assuming my guilt,
for I have done no wrong.

³⁰Do you think I am lying?

Don't I know the difference between right and wrong?

7



Is not all human life a struggle?

Our lives are like that of a hired hand,
²like a worker who longs for the shade,
like a servant waiting to be paid.

³I, too, have been assigned months of futility,
long and weary nights of misery.

⁴Lying in bed, I think, 'When will it be morning?'
But the night drags on, and I toss till dawn.

⁵My body is covered with maggots and scabs.
My skin breaks open, oozing with pus.

Job Cries Out to God

⁶"My days fly faster than a weaver's shuttle.
They end without hope.

⁷O God, remember that my life is but a breath,
and I will never again feel happiness.

⁸You see me now, but not for long.
You will look for me, but I will be gone.

⁹Just as a cloud dissipates and vanishes,
those who die will not come back.

¹⁰They are gone forever from their home—
never to be seen again.

¹¹“I cannot keep from speaking.
I must express my anguish.
My bitter soul must complain.

¹²Am I a sea monster or a dragon
that you must place me under guard?

¹³I think, ‘My bed will comfort me,
and sleep will ease my misery,’

¹⁴but then you shatter me with dreams
and terrify me with visions.

¹⁵I would rather be strangled—
rather die than suffer like this.

¹⁶I hate my life and don’t want to go on living.
Oh, leave me alone for my few remaining days.

¹⁷“What are people, that you should make so much of us,
that you should think of us so often?

¹⁸For you examine us every morning
and test us every moment.

¹⁹Why won’t you leave me alone,
at least long enough for me to swallow!

²⁰If I have sinned, what have I done to you,
O watcher of all humanity?

Why make me your target?

Am I a burden to you?

²¹Why not just forgive my sin
and take away my guilt?

For soon I will lie down in the dust and die.

When you look for me, I will be gone.”

8

Bildad's First Response to Job



HEN Bildad the Shuhite replied to Job:

²“How long will you go on like this?

You sound like a blustering wind.

³Does God twist justice?

Does the Almighty twist what is right?

⁴Your children must have sinned against him,

so their punishment was well deserved.

⁵But if you pray to God

and seek the favor of the Almighty,

⁶and if you are pure and live with integrity,

he will surely rise up and restore your happy home.

⁷And though you started with little,

you will end with much.

⁸“Just ask the previous generation.

Pay attention to the experience of our ancestors.

⁹For we were born but yesterday and know nothing.

Our days on earth are as fleeting as a shadow.

¹⁰But those who came before us will teach you.

They will teach you the wisdom of old.

¹¹“Can papyrus reeds grow tall without a marsh?

Can marsh grass flourish without water?

¹²While they are still flowering, not ready to be cut,

they begin to wither more quickly than grass.

¹³The same happens to all who forget God.

The hopes of the godless evaporate.

- ¹⁴Their confidence hangs by a thread.
They are leaning on a spider's web.
- ¹⁵They cling to their home for security, but it won't last.
They try to hold it tight, but it will not endure.
- ¹⁶The godless seem like a lush plant growing in the sunshine,
its branches spreading across the garden.
- ¹⁷Its roots grow down through a pile of stones;
it takes hold on a bed of rocks.
- ¹⁸But when it is uprooted,
it's as though it never existed!
- ¹⁹That's the end of its life,
and others spring up from the earth to replace it.
- ²⁰"But look, God will not reject a person of integrity,
nor will he lend a hand to the wicked.
- ²¹He will once again fill your mouth with laughter
and your lips with shouts of joy.
- ²²Those who hate you will be clothed with shame,
and the home of the wicked will be destroyed."

9

Job's Third Speech: A Response to Bildad



HEN Job spoke again:

- ²"Yes, I know all this is true in principle.
But how can a person be declared innocent in God's sight?
- ³If someone wanted to take God to court,
would it be possible to answer him even once in a thousand
times?
- ⁴For God is so wise and so mighty.

Who has ever challenged him successfully?

⁵“Without warning, he moves the mountains,
overturning them in his anger.

⁶He shakes the earth from its place,
and its foundations tremble.

⁷If he commands it, the sun won’t rise
and the stars won’t shine.

⁸He alone has spread out the heavens
and marches on the waves of the sea.

⁹He made all the stars—the Bear and Orion,
the Pleiades and the constellations of the southern sky.

¹⁰He does great things too marvelous to understand.
He performs countless miracles.

¹¹“Yet when he comes near, I cannot see him.

When he moves by, I do not see him go.

¹²If he snatches someone in death, who can stop him?

Who dares to ask, ‘What are you doing?’

¹³And God does not restrain his anger.

Even the monsters of the sea are crushed beneath his feet.

¹⁴“So who am I, that I should try to answer God
or even reason with him?

¹⁵Even if I were right, I would have no defense.
I could only plead for mercy.

¹⁶And even if I summoned him and he responded,
I’m not sure he would listen to me.

¹⁷For he attacks me with a storm
and repeatedly wounds me without cause.

¹⁸He will not let me catch my breath,

but fills me instead with bitter sorrows.

¹⁹If it's a question of strength, he's the strong one.

If it's a matter of justice, who dares to summon him to court?

²⁰Though I am innocent, my own mouth would pronounce me guilty.

Though I am blameless, it would prove me wicked.

²¹"I am innocent,

but it makes no difference to me—

I despise my life.

²²Innocent or wicked, it is all the same to God.

That's why I say, 'He destroys both the blameless and the wicked.'

²³When a plague sweeps through,

he laughs at the death of the innocent.

²⁴The whole earth is in the hands of the wicked,

and God blinds the eyes of the judges.

If he's not the one who does it, who is?

²⁵"My life passes more swiftly than a runner.

It flees away without a glimpse of happiness.

²⁶It disappears like a swift papyrus boat,

like an eagle swooping down on its prey.

²⁷If I decided to forget my complaints,

to put away my sad face and be cheerful,

²⁸I would still dread all the pain,

for I know you will not find me innocent, O God.

²⁹Whatever happens, I will be found guilty.

So what's the use of trying?

³⁰Even if I were to wash myself with soap

and clean my hands with lye,

³¹you would plunge me into a muddy ditch,

and my own filthy clothing would hate me.

- ³²“God is not a mortal like me,
so I cannot argue with him or take him to trial.
³³If only there were a mediator between us,
someone who could bring us together.
³⁴The mediator could make God stop beating me,
and I would no longer live in terror of his punishment.
³⁵Then I could speak to him without fear,
but I cannot do that in my own strength.

10

Job Frames His Plea to God



- I am disgusted with my life.
Let me complain freely.
My bitter soul must complain.
²I will say to God, ‘Don’t simply condemn me—
tell me the charge you are bringing against me.
³What do you gain by oppressing me?
Why do you reject me, the work of your own hands,
while smiling on the schemes of the wicked?
⁴Are your eyes like those of a human?
Do you see things only as people see them?
⁵Is your lifetime only as long as ours?
Is your life so short
⁶that you must quickly probe for my guilt
and search for my sin?
⁷Although you know I am not guilty,
no one can rescue me from your hands.

- ⁸“You formed me with your hands; you made me,
yet now you completely destroy me.
⁹Remember that you made me from dust—
will you turn me back to dust so soon?
¹⁰You guided my conception
and formed me in the womb.
¹¹You clothed me with skin and flesh,
and you knit my bones and sinews together.
¹²You gave me life and showed me your unfailing love.
My life was preserved by your care.
- ¹³“Yet your real motive—
your true intent—
¹⁴was to watch me, and if I sinned,
you would not forgive my guilt.
¹⁵If I am guilty, too bad for me;
and even if I’m innocent, I can’t hold my head high,
because I am filled with shame and misery.
¹⁶And if I hold my head high, you hunt me like a lion
and display your awesome power against me.
¹⁷Again and again you witness against me.
You pour out your growing anger on me
and bring fresh armies against me.
- ¹⁸“Why, then, did you deliver me from my mother’s womb?
Why didn’t you let me die at birth?
¹⁹It would be as though I had never existed,
going directly from the womb to the grave.
²⁰I have only a few days left, so leave me alone,
that I may have a moment of comfort
²¹before I leave—never to return—
for the land of darkness and utter gloom.

²²It is a land as dark as midnight,
a land of gloom and confusion,
where even the light is dark as midnight.”

11

Zophar's First Response to Job



HEN Zophar the Naamathite replied to Job:

- ²“Shouldn’t someone answer this torrent of words?
Is a person proved innocent just by a lot of talking?
³Should I remain silent while you babble on?
When you mock God, shouldn’t someone make you ashamed?
⁴You claim, ‘My beliefs are pure,’
and ‘I am clean in the sight of God.’
⁵If only God would speak;
if only he would tell you what he thinks!
⁶If only he would tell you the secrets of wisdom,
for true wisdom is not a simple matter.
Listen! God is doubtless punishing you
far less than you deserve!
- ⁷“Can you solve the mysteries of God?
Can you discover everything about the Almighty?
⁸Such knowledge is higher than the heavens—
and who are you?
It is deeper than the underworld—
what do you know?
⁹It is broader than the earth
and wider than the sea.
¹⁰If God comes and puts a person in prison

or calls the court to order, who can stop him?

¹¹For he knows those who are false,
and he takes note of all their sins.

¹²An empty-headed person won't become wise
any more than a wild donkey can bear a human child.

¹³"If only you would prepare your heart
and lift up your hands to him in prayer!

¹⁴Get rid of your sins,
and leave all iniquity behind you.

¹⁵Then your face will brighten with innocence.
You will be strong and free of fear.

¹⁶You will forget your misery;
it will be like water flowing away.

¹⁷Your life will be brighter than the noonday.
Even darkness will be as bright as morning.

¹⁸Having hope will give you courage.
You will be protected and will rest in safety.

¹⁹You will lie down unafraid,
and many will look to you for help.

²⁰But the wicked will be blinded.
They will have no escape.
Their only hope is death."

12

Job's Fourth Speech: A Response to Zophar



HEN Job spoke again:

²"You people really know everything, don't you?
And when you die, wisdom will die with you!

³Well, I know a few things myself—
and you're no better than I am.
Who doesn't know these things you've been saying?

⁴Yet my friends laugh at me,
for I call on God and expect an answer.
I am a just and blameless man,
yet they laugh at me.

⁵People who are at ease mock those in trouble.
They give a push to people who are stumbling.

⁶But robbers are left in peace,
and those who provoke God live in safety—
though God keeps them in his power.

⁷"Just ask the animals, and they will teach you.
Ask the birds of the sky, and they will tell you.

⁸Speak to the earth, and it will instruct you.
Let the fish in the sea speak to you.

⁹For they all know
that my disaster has come from the hand of the Lord.

¹⁰For the life of every living thing is in his hand,
and the breath of every human being.

¹¹The ear tests the words it hears
just as the mouth distinguishes between foods.

¹²Wisdom belongs to the aged,
and understanding to the old.

¹³"But true wisdom and power are found in God;
counsel and understanding are his.

¹⁴What he destroys cannot be rebuilt.
When he puts someone in prison, there is no escape.

¹⁵If he holds back the rain, the earth becomes a desert.
If he releases the waters, they flood the earth.

- ¹⁶Yes, strength and wisdom are his;
deceivers and deceived are both in his power.
- ¹⁷He leads counselors away, stripped of good judgment;
wise judges become fools.
- ¹⁸He removes the royal robe of kings.
They are led away with ropes around their waist.
- ¹⁹He leads priests away, stripped of status;
he overthrows those with long years in power.
- ²⁰He silences the trusted adviser
and removes the insight of the elders.
- ²¹He pours disgrace upon princes
and disarms the strong.
- ²²“He uncovers mysteries hidden in darkness;
he brings light to the deepest gloom.
- ²³He builds up nations, and he destroys them.
He expands nations, and he abandons them.
- ²⁴He strips kings of understanding
and leaves them wandering in a pathless wasteland.
- ²⁵They grope in the darkness without a light.
He makes them stagger like drunkards.

13

Job Wants to Argue His Case with God



- OOK, I have seen all this with my own eyes
and heard it with my own ears, and now I understand.
- ²I know as much as you do.
You are no better than I am.
- ³As for me, I would speak directly to the Almighty.

I want to argue my case with God himself.

⁴As for you, you smear me with lies.

As physicians, you are worthless quacks.

⁵If only you could be silent!

That's the wisest thing you could do.

⁶Listen to my charge;

pay attention to my arguments.

⁷"Are you defending God with lies?

Do you make your dishonest arguments for his sake?

⁸Will you slant your testimony in his favor?

Will you argue God's case for him?

⁹What will happen when he finds out what you are doing?

Can you fool him as easily as you fool people?

¹⁰No, you will be in trouble with him

if you secretly slant your testimony in his favor.

¹¹Doesn't his majesty terrify you?

Doesn't your fear of him overwhelm you?

¹²Your platitudes are as valuable as ashes.

Your defense is as fragile as a clay pot.

¹³"Be silent now and leave me alone.

Let me speak, and I will face the consequences.

¹⁴Why should I put myself in mortal danger

and take my life in my own hands?

¹⁵God might kill me, but I have no other hope.

I am going to argue my case with him.

¹⁶But this is what will save me—I am not godless.

If I were, I could not stand before him.

¹⁷"Listen closely to what I am about to say.

Hear me out.

¹⁸I have prepared my case;

I will be proved innocent.

¹⁹Who can argue with me over this?

And if you prove me wrong, I will remain silent and die.

Job Asks How He Has Sinned

²⁰“O God, grant me these two things,

and then I will be able to face you.

²¹Remove your heavy hand from me,

and don't terrify me with your awesome presence.

²²Now summon me, and I will answer!

Or let me speak to you, and you reply.

²³Tell me, what have I done wrong?

Show me my rebellion and my sin.

²⁴Why do you turn away from me?

Why do you treat me as your enemy?

²⁵Would you terrify a leaf blown by the wind?

Would you chase dry straw?

²⁶“You write bitter accusations against me

and bring up all the sins of my youth.

²⁷You put my feet in stocks.

You examine all my paths.

You trace all my footprints.

²⁸I waste away like rotting wood,

like a moth-eaten coat.

14



ow frail is humanity!

How short is life, how full of trouble!

²We blossom like a flower and then wither.

Like a passing shadow, we quickly disappear.

³Must you keep an eye on such a frail creature
and demand an accounting from me?

⁴Who can bring purity out of an impure person?
No one!

⁵You have decided the length of our lives.
You know how many months we will live,
and we are not given a minute longer.

⁶So leave us alone and let us rest!
We are like hired hands, so let us finish our work in peace.

⁷“Even a tree has more hope!
If it is cut down, it will sprout again
and grow new branches.

⁸Though its roots have grown old in the earth
and its stump decays,

⁹at the scent of water it will bud
and sprout again like a new seedling.

¹⁰“But when people die, their strength is gone.
They breathe their last, and then where are they?

¹¹As water evaporates from a lake
and a river disappears in drought,

¹²people are laid to rest and do not rise again.
Until the heavens are no more, they will not wake up
nor be roused from their sleep.

- ¹³“I wish you would hide me in the grave
and forget me there until your anger has passed.
But mark your calendar to think of me again!
- ¹⁴Can the dead live again?
If so, this would give me hope through all my years of struggle,
and I would eagerly await the release of death.
- ¹⁵You would call and I would answer,
and you would yearn for me, your handiwork.
- ¹⁶For then you would guard my steps,
instead of watching for my sins.
- ¹⁷My sins would be sealed in a pouch,
and you would cover my guilt.
- ¹⁸“But instead, as mountains fall and crumble
and as rocks fall from a cliff,
- ¹⁹as water wears away the stones
and floods wash away the soil,
so you destroy people’s hope.
- ²⁰You always overpower them, and they pass from the scene.
You disfigure them in death and send them away.
- ²¹They never know if their children grow up in honor
or sink to insignificance.
- ²²They suffer painfully;
their life is full of trouble.”

15

Eliphaz’s Second Response to Job



HEN Eliphaz the Temanite replied:

- ²“A wise man wouldn’t answer with such empty talk!

You are nothing but a windbag.

³The wise don't engage in empty chatter.

What good are such words?

⁴Have you no fear of God,
no reverence for him?

⁵Your sins are telling your mouth what to say.
Your words are based on clever deception.

⁶Your own mouth condemns you, not I.
Your own lips testify against you.

⁷"Were you the first person ever born?
Were you born before the hills were made?

⁸Were you listening at God's secret council?
Do you have a monopoly on wisdom?

⁹What do you know that we don't?
What do you understand that we do not?

¹⁰On our side are aged, gray-haired men
much older than your father!

¹¹"Is God's comfort too little for you?
Is his gentle word not enough?

¹²What has taken away your reason?
What has weakened your vision,

¹³that you turn against God
and say all these evil things?

¹⁴Can any mortal be pure?
Can anyone born of a woman be just?

¹⁵Look, God does not even trust the angels.
Even the heavens are not absolutely pure in his sight.

¹⁶How much less pure is a corrupt and sinful person
with a thirst for wickedness!

¹⁷“If you will listen, I will show you.

I will answer you from my own experience.

¹⁸And it is confirmed by the reports of wise men
who have heard the same thing from their fathers—

¹⁹from those to whom the land was given
long before any foreigners arrived.

²⁰“The wicked writhe in pain throughout their lives.

Years of trouble are stored up for the ruthless.

²¹The sound of terror rings in their ears,
and even on good days they fear the attack of the destroyer.

²²They dare not go out into the darkness
for fear they will be murdered.

²³They wander around, saying, ‘Where can I find bread?’
They know their day of destruction is near.

²⁴That dark day terrifies them.
They live in distress and anguish,
like a king preparing for battle.

²⁵For they shake their fists at God,
defying the Almighty.

²⁶Holding their strong shields,
they defiantly charge against him.

²⁷“These wicked people are heavy and prosperous;
their waists bulge with fat.

²⁸But their cities will be ruined.
They will live in abandoned houses
that are ready to tumble down.

²⁹Their riches will not last,
and their wealth will not endure.
Their possessions will no longer spread across the horizon.

- ³⁰“They will not escape the darkness.
The burning sun will wither their shoots,
and the breath of God will destroy them.
- ³¹Let them no longer fool themselves by trusting in empty riches,
for emptiness will be their only reward.
- ³²They will be cut down in the prime of life;
their branches will never again be green.
- ³³They will be like a vine whose grapes are harvested too early,
like an olive tree that loses its blossoms before the fruit can
form.
- ³⁴For the godless are barren.
Their homes, enriched through bribery, will burn.
- ³⁵They conceive trouble and give birth to evil.
Their womb produces deceit.”

16

Job's Fifth Speech: A Response to Eliphaz



HEN Job spoke again:

- ²“I have heard all this before.
What miserable comforters you are!
- ³Won't you ever stop blowing hot air?
What makes you keep on talking?
- ⁴I could say the same things if you were in my place.
I could spout off criticism and shake my head at you.
- ⁵But if it were me, I would encourage you.
I would try to take away your grief.
- ⁶Instead, I suffer if I defend myself,
and I suffer no less if I refuse to speak.

- ⁷“O God, you have ground me down
and devastated my family.
- ⁸As if to prove I have sinned, you’ve reduced me to skin and bones.
My gaunt flesh testifies against me.
- ⁹God hates me and angrily tears me apart.
He snaps his teeth at me
and pierces me with his eyes.
- ¹⁰People jeer and laugh at me.
They slap my cheek in contempt.
A mob gathers against me.
- ¹¹God has handed me over to sinners.
He has tossed me into the hands of the wicked.
- ¹²“I was living quietly until he shattered me.
He took me by the neck and broke me in pieces.
Then he set me up as his target,
¹³and now his archers surround me.
His arrows pierce me without mercy.
The ground is wet with my blood.
- ¹⁴Again and again he smashes against me,
charging at me like a warrior.
- ¹⁵I wear burlap to show my grief.
My pride lies in the dust.
- ¹⁶My eyes are red with weeping;
dark shadows circle my eyes.
- ¹⁷Yet I have done no wrong,
and my prayer is pure.
- ¹⁸“O earth, do not conceal my blood.
Let it cry out on my behalf.
- ¹⁹Even now my witness is in heaven.
My advocate is there on high.

- ²⁰My friends scorn me,
but I pour out my tears to God.
²¹I need someone to mediate between God and me,
as a person mediates between friends.
²²For soon I must go down that road
from which I will never return.

17

Job Continues to Defend His Innocence



- My spirit is crushed,
and my life is nearly snuffed out.
The grave is ready to receive me.
²I am surrounded by mockers.
I watch how bitterly they taunt me.
- ³“You must defend my innocence, O God,
since no one else will stand up for me.
⁴You have closed their minds to understanding,
but do not let them triumph.
⁵They betray their friends for their own advantage,
so let their children faint with hunger.
- ⁶“God has made a mockery of me among the people;
they spit in my face.
⁷My eyes are swollen with weeping,
and I am but a shadow of my former self.
⁸The virtuous are horrified when they see me.
The innocent rise up against the ungodly.

⁹The righteous keep moving forward,
and those with clean hands become stronger and stronger.

¹⁰“As for all of you, come back with a better argument,
though I still won’t find a wise man among you.

¹¹My days are over.
My hopes have disappeared.
My heart’s desires are broken.

¹²These men say that night is day;
they claim that the darkness is light.

¹³What if I go to the grave
and make my bed in darkness?

¹⁴What if I call the grave my father,
and the maggot my mother or my sister?

¹⁵Where then is my hope?
Can anyone find it?

¹⁶No, my hope will go down with me to the grave.
We will rest together in the dust!”

18

Bildad’s Second Response to Job



HEN Bildad the Shuhite replied:

²“How long before you stop talking?
Speak sense if you want us to answer!

³Do you think we are mere animals?
Do you think we are stupid?

⁴You may tear out your hair in anger,
but will that destroy the earth?
Will it make the rocks tremble?

⁵“Surely the light of the wicked will be snuffed out.

The sparks of their fire will not glow.

⁶The light in their tent will grow dark.

The lamp hanging above them will be quenched.

⁷The confident stride of the wicked will be shortened.

Their own schemes will be their downfall.

⁸The wicked walk into a net.

They fall into a pit.

⁹A trap grabs them by the heel.

A snare holds them tight.

¹⁰A noose lies hidden on the ground.

A rope is stretched across their path.

¹¹“Terrors surround the wicked
and trouble them at every step.

¹²Hunger depletes their strength,
and calamity waits for them to stumble.

¹³Disease eats their skin;
death devours their limbs.

¹⁴They are torn from the security of their homes
and are brought down to the king of terrors.

¹⁵The homes of the wicked will burn down;
burning sulfur rains on their houses.

¹⁶Their roots will dry up,
and their branches will wither.

¹⁷All memory of their existence will fade from the earth;
no one will remember their names.

¹⁸They will be thrust from light into darkness,
driven from the world.

¹⁹They will have neither children nor grandchildren,
nor any survivor in the place where they lived.

²⁰People in the west are appalled at their fate;
people in the east are horrified.

²¹They will say, ‘This was the home of a wicked person,
the place of one who rejected God.’”

19

Job’s Sixth Speech: A Response to Bildad



HEN Job spoke again:

²“How long will you torture me?

How long will you try to crush me with your words?

³You have already insulted me ten times.

You should be ashamed of treating me so badly.

⁴Even if I have sinned,
that is my concern, not yours.

⁵You think you’re better than I am,
using my humiliation as evidence of my sin.

⁶But it is God who has wronged me,
capturing me in his net.

⁷“I cry out, ‘Help!’ but no one answers me.
I protest, but there is no justice.

⁸God has blocked my way so I cannot move.
He has plunged my path into darkness.

⁹He has stripped me of my honor
and removed the crown from my head.

¹⁰He has demolished me on every side, and I am finished.
He has uprooted my hope like a fallen tree.

¹¹His fury burns against me;
he counts me as an enemy.

¹²His troops advance.
They build up roads to attack me.

They camp all around my tent.

¹³“My relatives stay far away,
and my friends have turned against me.

¹⁴My family is gone,
and my close friends have forgotten me.

¹⁵My servants and maids consider me a stranger.
I am like a foreigner to them.

¹⁶When I call my servant, he doesn't come;
I have to plead with him!

¹⁷My breath is repulsive to my wife.
I am rejected by my own family.

¹⁸Even young children despise me.
When I stand to speak, they turn their backs on me.

¹⁹My close friends detest me.
Those I loved have turned against me.

²⁰I have been reduced to skin and bones
and have escaped death by the skin of my teeth.

²¹“Have mercy on me, my friends, have mercy,
for the hand of God has struck me.

²²Must you also persecute me, like God does?
Haven't you chewed me up enough?

²³“Oh, that my words could be recorded.
Oh, that they could be inscribed on a monument,
²⁴carved with an iron chisel and filled with lead,
engraved forever in the rock.

²⁵“But as for me, I know that my Redeemer lives,

and he will stand upon the earth at last.

²⁶And after my body has decayed,
yet in my body I will see God!

²⁷I will see him for myself.

Yes, I will see him with my own eyes.

I am overwhelmed at the thought!

²⁸“How dare you go on persecuting me,
saying, ‘It’s his own fault’?

²⁹You should fear punishment yourselves,
for your attitude deserves punishment.

Then you will know that there is indeed a judgment.”

20

Zophar’s Second Response to Job ¹Then Zophar the Naamathite replied:

²“I must reply
because I am greatly disturbed.

³I’ve had to endure your insults,
but now my spirit prompts me to reply.

⁴“Don’t you realize that from the beginning of time,
ever since people were first placed on the earth,

⁵the triumph of the wicked has been short lived
and the joy of the godless has been only temporary?

⁶Though the pride of the godless reaches to the heavens
and their heads touch the clouds,

⁷yet they will vanish forever,
thrown away like their own dung.

Those who knew them will ask,

‘Where are they?’

⁸They will fade like a dream and not be found.

They will vanish like a vision in the night.

⁹Those who once saw them will see them no more.

Their families will never see them again.

¹⁰Their children will beg from the poor,

for they must give back their stolen riches.

¹¹Though they are young,

their bones will lie in the dust.

¹²“They enjoyed the sweet taste of wickedness,
letting it melt under their tongue.

¹³They savored it,

holding it long in their mouths.

¹⁴But suddenly the food in their bellies turns sour,
a poisonous venom in their stomach.

¹⁵They will vomit the wealth they swallowed.

God won’t let them keep it down.

¹⁶They will suck the poison of cobras.

The viper will kill them.

¹⁷They will never again enjoy streams of olive oil
or rivers of milk and honey.

¹⁸They will give back everything they worked for.

Their wealth will bring them no joy.

¹⁹For they oppressed the poor and left them destitute.

They foreclosed on their homes.

²⁰They were always greedy and never satisfied.

Nothing remains of all the things they dreamed about.

²¹Nothing is left after they finish gorging themselves.

Therefore, their prosperity will not endure.

- ²²“In the midst of plenty, they will run into trouble
and be overcome by misery.
²³May God give them a bellyful of trouble.
May God rain down his anger upon them.
²⁴When they try to escape an iron weapon,
a bronze-tipped arrow will pierce them.
²⁵The arrow is pulled from their back,
and the arrowhead glistens with blood.
The terrors of death are upon them.
²⁶Their treasures will be thrown into deepest darkness.
A wildfire will devour their goods,
consuming all they have left.
²⁷The heavens will reveal their guilt,
and the earth will testify against them.
²⁸A flood will sweep away their house.
God’s anger will descend on them in torrents.
²⁹This is the reward that God gives the wicked.
It is the inheritance decreed by God.”

21

Job’s Seventh Speech: A Response to Zophar



WHEN Job spoke again:

- ²“Listen closely to what I am saying.
That’s one consolation you can give me.
³Bear with me, and let me speak.
After I have spoken, you may resume mocking me.

⁴“My complaint is with God, not with people.
I have good reason to be so impatient.

⁵Look at me and be stunned.

Put your hand over your mouth in shock.

⁶When I think about what I am saying, I shudder.

My body trembles.

⁷“Why do the wicked prosper,
growing old and powerful?

⁸They live to see their children grow up and settle down,
and they enjoy their grandchildren.

⁹Their homes are safe from every fear,
and God does not punish them.

¹⁰Their bulls never fail to breed.

Their cows bear calves and never miscarry.

¹¹They let their children frisk about like lambs.
Their little ones skip and dance.

¹²They sing with tambourine and harp.
They celebrate to the sound of the flute.

¹³They spend their days in prosperity,
then go down to the grave in peace.

¹⁴And yet they say to God, ‘Go away.

We want no part of you and your ways.

¹⁵Who is the Almighty, and why should we obey him?
What good will it do us to pray?’

¹⁶(They think their prosperity is of their own doing,
but I will have nothing to do with that kind of thinking.)

¹⁷“Yet the light of the wicked never seems to be extinguished.
Do they ever have trouble?

Does God distribute sorrows to them in anger?

¹⁸Are they driven before the wind like straw?

Are they carried away by the storm like chaff?

Not at all!

¹⁹“Well,’ you say, ‘at least God will punish their children!’

But I say he should punish the ones who sin,
so that they understand his judgment.

²⁰Let them see their destruction with their own eyes.

Let them drink deeply of the anger of the Almighty.

²¹For they will not care what happens to their family
after they are dead.

²²“But who can teach a lesson to God,
since he judges even the most powerful?

²³One person dies in prosperity,
completely comfortable and secure,

²⁴the picture of good health,
vigorous and fit.

²⁵Another person dies in bitter poverty,
never having tasted the good life.

²⁶But both are buried in the same dust,
both eaten by the same maggots.

²⁷“Look, I know what you’re thinking.

I know the schemes you plot against me.

²⁸You will tell me of rich and wicked people
whose houses have vanished because of their sins.

²⁹But ask those who have been around,
and they will tell you the truth.

³⁰Evil people are spared in times of calamity
and are allowed to escape disaster.

³¹No one criticizes them openly
or pays them back for what they have done.

³²When they are carried to the grave,
an honor guard keeps watch at their tomb.

³³A great funeral procession goes to the cemetery.

Many pay their respects as the body is laid to rest,
and the earth gives sweet repose.

³⁴“How can your empty clichés comfort me?
All your explanations are lies!”

22

Eliphaz's Third Response to Job



HEN Eliphaz the Temanite replied:

²“Can a person do anything to help God?

Can even a wise person be helpful to him?

³Is it any advantage to the Almighty if you are righteous?

Would it be any gain to him if you were perfect?

⁴Is it because you're so pious that he accuses you
and brings judgment against you?

⁵No, it's because of your wickedness!

There's no limit to your sins.

⁶“For example, you must have lent money to your friend
and demanded clothing as security.

Yes, you stripped him to the bone.

⁷You must have refused water for the thirsty
and food for the hungry.

⁸You probably think the land belongs to the powerful
and only the privileged have a right to it!

⁹You must have sent widows away empty-handed
and crushed the hopes of orphans.

¹⁰That is why you are surrounded by traps

and tremble from sudden fears.

¹¹That is why you cannot see in the darkness,
and waves of water cover you.

¹²“God is so great—higher than the heavens,
higher than the farthest stars.

¹³But you reply, ‘That’s why God can’t see what I am doing!
How can he judge through the thick darkness?

¹⁴For thick clouds swirl about him, and he cannot see us.
He is way up there, walking on the vault of heaven.’

¹⁵“Will you continue on the old paths
where evil people have walked?

¹⁶They were snatched away in the prime of life,
the foundations of their lives washed away.

¹⁷For they said to God, ‘Leave us alone!
What can the Almighty do to us?’

¹⁸Yet he was the one who filled their homes with good things,
so I will have nothing to do with that kind of thinking.

¹⁹“The righteous will be happy to see the wicked destroyed,
and the innocent will laugh in contempt.

²⁰They will say, ‘See how our enemies have been destroyed.
The last of them have been consumed in the fire.’

²¹“Submit to God, and you will have peace;
then things will go well for you.

²²Listen to his instructions,
and store them in your heart.

²³If you return to the Almighty, you will be restored—

so clean up your life.

²⁴If you give up your lust for money
and throw your precious gold into the river,

²⁵the Almighty himself will be your treasure.
He will be your precious silver!

²⁶“Then you will take delight in the Almighty
and look up to God.

²⁷You will pray to him, and he will hear you,
and you will fulfill your vows to him.

²⁸You will succeed in whatever you choose to do,
and light will shine on the road ahead of you.

²⁹If people are in trouble and you say, ‘Help them,’
God will save them.

³⁰Even sinners will be rescued;
they will be rescued because your hands are pure.”

23

Job’s Eighth Speech: A Response to Eliphaz



HEN Job spoke again:

²“My complaint today is still a bitter one,
and I try hard not to groan aloud.

³If only I knew where to find God,
I would go to his court.

⁴I would lay out my case
and present my arguments.

⁵Then I would listen to his reply
and understand what he says to me.

⁶Would he use his great power to argue with me?

- No, he would give me a fair hearing.
⁷Honest people can reason with him,
 so I would be forever acquitted by my judge.
⁸I go east, but he is not there.
 I go west, but I cannot find him.
⁹I do not see him in the north, for he is hidden.
 I look to the south, but he is concealed.
- ¹⁰“But he knows where I am going.
 And when he tests me, I will come out as pure as gold.
¹¹For I have stayed on God’s paths;
 I have followed his ways and not turned aside.
¹²I have not departed from his commands,
 but have treasured his words more than daily food.
¹³But once he has made his decision, who can change his mind?
 Whatever he wants to do, he does.
¹⁴So he will do to me whatever he has planned.
 He controls my destiny.
¹⁵No wonder I am so terrified in his presence.
 When I think of it, terror grips me.
¹⁶God has made me sick at heart;
 the Almighty has terrified me.
¹⁷Darkness is all around me;
 thick, impenetrable darkness is everywhere.

24

Job Asks Why the Wicked Are Not Punished



WHY doesn't the Almighty bring the wicked to judgment?
Why must the godly wait for him in vain?

- ²Evil people steal land by moving the boundary markers.
They steal livestock and put them in their own pastures.
- ³They take the orphan's donkey
and demand the widow's ox as security for a loan.
- ⁴The poor are pushed off the path;
the needy must hide together for safety.
- ⁵Like wild donkeys in the wilderness,
the poor must spend all their time looking for food,
searching even in the desert for food for their children.
- ⁶They harvest a field they do not own,
and they glean in the vineyards of the wicked.
- ⁷All night they lie naked in the cold,
without clothing or covering.
- ⁸They are soaked by mountain showers,
and they huddle against the rocks for want of a home.
- ⁹"The wicked snatch a widow's child from her breast,
taking the baby as security for a loan.
- ¹⁰The poor must go about naked, without any clothing.
They harvest food for others while they themselves are starving.
- ¹¹They press out olive oil without being allowed to taste it,
and they tread in the winepress as they suffer from thirst.
- ¹²The groans of the dying rise from the city,
and the wounded cry for help,
yet God ignores their moaning.
- ¹³"Wicked people rebel against the light.
They refuse to acknowledge its ways
or stay in its paths.
- ¹⁴The murderer rises in the early dawn
to kill the poor and needy;

at night he is a thief.

¹⁵The adulterer waits for the twilight,
saying, 'No one will see me then.'

He hides his face so no one will know him.

¹⁶Thieves break into houses at night
and sleep in the daytime.

They are not acquainted with the light.

¹⁷The black night is their morning.

They ally themselves with the terrors of the darkness.

¹⁸"But they disappear like foam down a river.

Everything they own is cursed,
and they are afraid to enter their own vineyards.

¹⁹The grave consumes sinners
just as drought and heat consume snow.

²⁰Their own mothers will forget them.

Maggots will find them sweet to eat.

No one will remember them.

Wicked people are broken like a tree in the storm.

²¹They cheat the woman who has no son to help her.

They refuse to help the needy widow.

²²"God, in his power, drags away the rich.

They may rise high, but they have no assurance of life.

²³They may be allowed to live in security,
but God is always watching them.

²⁴And though they are great now,
in a moment they will be gone like all others,
cut off like heads of grain.

²⁵Can anyone claim otherwise?

Who can prove me wrong?"

25

Bildad's Third Response to Job



HEN Bildad the Shuhite replied:

²“God is powerful and dreadful.

He enforces peace in the heavens.

³Who is able to count his heavenly army?

Doesn't his light shine on all the earth?

⁴How can a mortal be innocent before God?

Can anyone born of a woman be pure?

⁵God is more glorious than the moon;

he shines brighter than the stars.

⁶In comparison, people are maggots;

we mortals are mere worms.”

26

Job's Ninth Speech: A Response to Bildad



HEN Job spoke again:

²“How you have helped the powerless!

How you have saved the weak!

³How you have enlightened my stupidity!

What wise advice you have offered!

⁴Where have you gotten all these wise sayings?

Whose spirit speaks through you?

⁵“The dead tremble—

- those who live beneath the waters.
- ⁶The underworld is naked in God's presence.
The place of destruction is uncovered.
- ⁷God stretches the northern sky over empty space
and hangs the earth on nothing.
- ⁸He wraps the rain in his thick clouds,
and the clouds don't burst with the weight.
- ⁹He covers the face of the moon,
shrouding it with his clouds.
- ¹⁰He created the horizon when he separated the waters;
he set the boundary between day and night.
- ¹¹The foundations of heaven tremble;
they shudder at his rebuke.
- ¹²By his power the sea grew calm.
By his skill he crushed the great sea monster.
- ¹³His Spirit made the heavens beautiful,
and his power pierced the gliding serpent.
- ¹⁴These are just the beginning of all that he does,
merely a whisper of his power.
Who, then, can comprehend the thunder of his power?"

27

Job's Final Speech



OB continued speaking:

- ²"I vow by the living God, who has taken away my rights,
by the Almighty who has embittered my soul—
- ³As long as I live,
while I have breath from God,
- ⁴my lips will speak no evil,
and my tongue will speak no lies.

- ⁵I will never concede that you are right;
I will defend my integrity until I die.
- ⁶I will maintain my innocence without wavering.
My conscience is clear for as long as I live.
- ⁷“May my enemy be punished like the wicked,
my adversary like those who do evil.
- ⁸For what hope do the godless have when God cuts them off
and takes away their life?
- ⁹Will God listen to their cry
when trouble comes upon them?
- ¹⁰Can they take delight in the Almighty?
Can they call to God at any time?
- ¹¹I will teach you about God’s power.
I will not conceal anything concerning the Almighty.
- ¹²But you have seen all this,
yet you say all these useless things to me.
- ¹³“This is what the wicked will receive from God;
this is their inheritance from the Almighty.
- ¹⁴They may have many children,
but the children will die in war or starve to death.
- ¹⁵Those who survive will die of a plague,
and not even their widows will mourn them.
- ¹⁶“Evil people may have piles of money
and may store away mounds of clothing.
- ¹⁷But the righteous will wear that clothing,
and the innocent will divide that money.
- ¹⁸The wicked build houses as fragile as a spider’s web,
as flimsy as a shelter made of branches.

- ¹⁹The wicked go to bed rich
but wake to find that all their wealth is gone.
²⁰Terror overwhelms them like a flood,
and they are blown away in the storms of the night.
²¹The east wind carries them away, and they are gone.
It sweeps them away.
²²It whirls down on them without mercy.
They struggle to flee from its power.
²³But everyone jeers at them
and mocks them.

28

Job Speaks of Wisdom and Understanding



- PEOPLE know where to mine silver
and how to refine gold.
²They know where to dig iron from the earth
and how to smelt copper from rock.
³They know how to shine light in the darkness
and explore the farthest regions of the earth
as they search in the dark for ore.
⁴They sink a mine shaft into the earth
far from where anyone lives.
They descend on ropes, swinging back and forth.
⁵Food is grown on the earth above,
but down below, the earth is melted as by fire.
⁶Here the rocks contain precious lapis lazuli,
and the dust contains gold.
⁷These are treasures no bird of prey can see,
no falcon's eye observe.
⁸No wild animal has walked upon these treasures;

no lion has ever set his paw there.

⁹People know how to tear apart flinty rocks
and overturn the roots of mountains.

¹⁰They cut tunnels in the rocks
and uncover precious stones.

¹¹They dam up the trickling streams
and bring to light the hidden treasures.

¹²“But do people know where to find wisdom?
Where can they find understanding?

¹³No one knows where to find it,
for it is not found among the living.

¹⁴“It is not here,” says the ocean.

“Nor is it here,” says the sea.

¹⁵It cannot be bought with gold.

It cannot be purchased with silver.

¹⁶It’s worth more than all the gold of Ophir,
greater than precious onyx or lapis lazuli.

¹⁷Wisdom is more valuable than gold and crystal.
It cannot be purchased with jewels mounted in fine gold.

¹⁸Coral and jasper are worthless in trying to get it.

The price of wisdom is far above rubies.

¹⁹Precious peridot from Ethiopia cannot be exchanged for it.
It’s worth more than the purest gold.

²⁰“But do people know where to find wisdom?
Where can they find understanding?

²¹It is hidden from the eyes of all humanity.
Even the sharp-eyed birds in the sky cannot discover it.

²²Destruction and Death say,
“We’ve heard only rumors of where wisdom can be found.”

²³“God alone understands the way to wisdom;
he knows where it can be found,
²⁴for he looks throughout the whole earth
and sees everything under the heavens.
²⁵He decided how hard the winds should blow
and how much rain should fall.
²⁶He made the laws for the rain
and laid out a path for the lightning.
²⁷Then he saw wisdom and evaluated it.
He set it in place and examined it thoroughly.
²⁸And this is what he says to all humanity:
*‘The fear of the Lord is true wisdom;
to forsake evil is real understanding.’”*

29

Job Speaks of His Former Blessings



OB continued speaking:

²“I long for the years gone by
when God took care of me,
³when he lit up the way before me
and I walked safely through the darkness.
⁴When I was in my prime,
God’s friendship was felt in my home.
⁵The Almighty was still with me,
and my children were around me.
⁶My steps were awash in cream,
and the rocks gushed olive oil for me.

⁷“Those were the days when I went to the city gate

and took my place among the honored leaders.

⁸The young stepped aside when they saw me,
and even the aged rose in respect at my coming.

⁹The princes stood in silence
and put their hands over their mouths.

¹⁰The highest officials of the city stood quietly,
holding their tongues in respect.

¹¹“All who heard me praised me.

All who saw me spoke well of me.

¹²For I assisted the poor in their need
and the orphans who required help.

¹³I helped those without hope, and they blessed me.
And I caused the widows’ hearts to sing for joy.

¹⁴Everything I did was honest.
Righteousness covered me like a robe,
and I wore justice like a turban.

¹⁵I served as eyes for the blind
and feet for the lame.

¹⁶I was a father to the poor
and assisted strangers who needed help.

¹⁷I broke the jaws of godless oppressors
and plucked their victims from their teeth.

¹⁸“I thought, ‘Surely I will die surrounded by my family
after a long, good life.

¹⁹For I am like a tree whose roots reach the water,
whose branches are refreshed with the dew.

²⁰New honors are constantly bestowed on me,
and my strength is continually renewed.’

²¹“Everyone listened to my advice.

They were silent as they waited for me to speak.

²²And after I spoke, they had nothing to add,
for my counsel satisfied them.

²³They longed for me to speak as people long for rain.

They drank my words like a refreshing spring rain.

²⁴When they were discouraged, I smiled at them.

My look of approval was precious to them.

²⁵Like a chief, I told them what to do.

I lived like a king among his troops
and comforted those who mourned.

30

Job Speaks of His Anguish



UT now I am mocked by people younger than I,

by young men whose fathers are not worthy to run with my
sheepdogs.

²A lot of good they are to me—
those worn-out wretches!

³They are gaunt from poverty and hunger.

They claw the dry ground in desolate wastelands.

⁴They pluck wild greens from among the bushes
and eat from the roots of broom trees.

⁵They are driven from human society,
and people shout at them as if they were thieves.

⁶So now they live in frightening ravines,
in caves and among the rocks.

⁷They sound like animals howling among the bushes,
huddled together beneath the nettles.

⁸They are nameless fools,

outcasts from society.

⁹“And now they mock me with vulgar songs!

They taunt me!

¹⁰They despise me and won’t come near me,
except to spit in my face.

¹¹For God has cut my bowstring.
He has humbled me,
so they have thrown off all restraint.

¹²These outcasts oppose me to my face.
They send me sprawling
and lay traps in my path.

¹³They block my road
and do everything they can to destroy me.

They know I have no one to help me.

¹⁴They come at me from all directions.

They jump on me when I am down.

¹⁵I live in terror now.

My honor has blown away in the wind,
and my prosperity has vanished like a cloud.

¹⁶“And now my life seeps away.

Depression haunts my days.

¹⁷At night my bones are filled with pain,
which gnaws at me relentlessly.

¹⁸With a strong hand, God grabs my shirt.
He grips me by the collar of my coat.

¹⁹He has thrown me into the mud.
I’m nothing more than dust and ashes.

²⁰“I cry to you, O God, but you don’t answer.

- I stand before you, but you don't even look.
²¹You have become cruel toward me.
You use your power to persecute me.
²²You throw me into the whirlwind
and destroy me in the storm.
²³And I know you are sending me to my death—
the destination of all who live.
- ²⁴"Surely no one would turn against the needy
when they cry for help in their trouble.
²⁵Did I not weep for those in trouble?
Was I not deeply grieved for the needy?
²⁶So I looked for good, but evil came instead.
I waited for the light, but darkness fell.
²⁷My heart is troubled and restless.
Days of suffering torment me.
²⁸I walk in gloom, without sunlight.
I stand in the public square and cry for help.
²⁹Instead, I am considered a brother to jackals
and a companion to owls.
³⁰My skin has turned dark,
and my bones burn with fever.
³¹My harp plays sad music,
and my flute accompanies those who weep.

31

Job's Final Protest of Innocence



made a covenant with my eyes
not to look with lust at a young woman.

²For what has God above chosen for us?

What is our inheritance from the Almighty on high?

³Isn't it calamity for the wicked

and misfortune for those who do evil?

⁴Doesn't he see everything I do

and every step I take?

⁵"Have I lied to anyone

or deceived anyone?

⁶Let God weigh me on the scales of justice,

for he knows my integrity.

⁷If I have strayed from his pathway,

or if my heart has lusted for what my eyes have seen,

or if I am guilty of any other sin,

⁸then let someone else eat the crops I have planted.

Let all that I have planted be uprooted.

⁹"If my heart has been seduced by a woman,

or if I have lusted for my neighbor's wife,

¹⁰then let my wife serve another man;

let other men sleep with her.

¹¹For lust is a shameful sin,

a crime that should be punished.

¹²It is a fire that burns all the way to hell.

It would wipe out everything I own.

¹³"If I have been unfair to my male or female servants

when they brought their complaints to me,

¹⁴how could I face God?

What could I say when he questioned me?

¹⁵For God created both me and my servants.

He created us both in the womb.

- ¹⁶“Have I refused to help the poor,
or crushed the hopes of widows?
¹⁷Have I been stingy with my food
and refused to share it with orphans?
¹⁸No, from childhood I have cared for orphans like a father,
and all my life I have cared for widows.
¹⁹Whenever I saw the homeless without clothes
and the needy with nothing to wear,
²⁰did they not praise me
for providing wool clothing to keep them warm?
- ²¹“If I raised my hand against an orphan,
knowing the judges would take my side,
²²then let my shoulder be wrenched out of place!
Let my arm be torn from its socket!
²³That would be better than facing God’s judgment.
For if the majesty of God opposes me, what hope is there?
- ²⁴“Have I put my trust in money
or felt secure because of my gold?
²⁵Have I gloated about my wealth
and all that I own?
- ²⁶“Have I looked at the sun shining in the skies,
or the moon walking down its silver pathway,
²⁷and been secretly enticed in my heart
to throw kisses at them in worship?
²⁸If so, I should be punished by the judges,

for it would mean I had denied the God of heaven.

²⁹“Have I ever rejoiced when disaster struck my enemies,
or become excited when harm came their way?

³⁰No, I have never sinned by cursing anyone
or by asking for revenge.

³¹“My servants have never said,
‘He let others go hungry.’

³²I have never turned away a stranger
but have opened my doors to everyone.

³³“Have I tried to hide my sins like other people do,
concealing my guilt in my heart?

³⁴Have I feared the crowd
or the contempt of the masses,
so that I kept quiet and stayed indoors?

³⁵“If only someone would listen to me!
Look, I will sign my name to my defense.

Let the Almighty answer me.

Let my accuser write out the charges against me.

³⁶I would face the accusation proudly.
I would wear it like a crown.

³⁷For I would tell him exactly what I have done.
I would come before him like a prince.

³⁸“If my land accuses me
and all its furrows cry out together,

³⁹or if I have stolen its crops
or murdered its owners,
⁴⁰then let thistles grow on that land instead of wheat,
and weeds instead of barley.”

Job’s words are ended.

32

Elihu Responds to Job’s Friends

OB’s three friends refused to reply further to him because he kept insisting on his innocence.

²Then Elihu son of Barakel the Buzite, of the clan of Ram, became angry. He was angry because Job refused to admit that he had sinned and that God was right in punishing him. ³He was also angry with Job’s three friends, for they made God appear to be wrong by their inability to answer Job’s arguments. ⁴Elihu had waited for the others to speak to Job because they were older than he. ⁵But when he saw that they had no further reply, he spoke out angrily. ⁶Elihu son of Barakel the Buzite said,

“I am young and you are old,
so I held back from telling you what I think.

⁷I thought, ‘Those who are older should speak,
for wisdom comes with age.’

⁸But there is a spirit within people,
the breath of the Almighty within them,
that makes them intelligent.

⁹Sometimes the elders are not wise.
Sometimes the aged do not understand justice.

¹⁰So listen to me,
and let me tell you what I think.

- ¹¹“I have waited all this time,
listening very carefully to your arguments,
listening to you grope for words.
- ¹²I have listened,
but not one of you has refuted Job
or answered his arguments.
- ¹³And don’t tell me, ‘He is too wise for us.
Only God can convince him.’
- ¹⁴If Job had been arguing with me,
I would not answer with your kind of logic!
- ¹⁵You sit there baffled,
with nothing more to say.
- ¹⁶Should I continue to wait, now that you are silent?
Must I also remain silent?
- ¹⁷No, I will say my piece.
I will speak my mind.
- ¹⁸For I am full of pent-up words,
and the spirit within me urges me on.
- ¹⁹I am like a cask of wine without a vent,
like a new wineskin ready to burst!
- ²⁰I must speak to find relief,
so let me give my answers.
- ²¹I won’t play favorites
or try to flatter anyone.
- ²²For if I tried flattery,
my Creator would soon destroy me.

33

Elihu Presents His Case against Job



LISTEN to my words, Job;

- pay attention to what I have to say.
²Now that I have begun to speak,
let me continue.
- ³I speak with all sincerity;
I speak the truth.
- ⁴For the Spirit of God has made me,
and the breath of the Almighty gives me life.
- ⁵Answer me, if you can;
make your case and take your stand.
- ⁶Look, you and I both belong to God.
I, too, was formed from clay.
- ⁷So you don't need to be afraid of me.
I won't come down hard on you.
- ⁸"You have spoken in my hearing,
and I have heard your very words.
- ⁹You said, 'I am pure; I am without sin;
I am innocent; I have no guilt.
- ¹⁰God is picking a quarrel with me,
and he considers me his enemy.
- ¹¹He puts my feet in the stocks
and watches my every move.'
- ¹²"But you are wrong, and I will show you why.
For God is greater than any human being.
- ¹³So why are you bringing a charge against him?
Why say he does not respond to people's complaints?
- ¹⁴For God speaks again and again,
though people do not recognize it.
- ¹⁵He speaks in dreams, in visions of the night,
when deep sleep falls on people
as they lie in their beds.

- ¹⁶He whispers in their ears
and terrifies them with warnings.
¹⁷He makes them turn from doing wrong;
he keeps them from pride.

- ¹⁸He protects them from the grave,
from crossing over the river of death.

- ¹⁹“Or God disciplines people with pain on their sickbeds,
with ceaseless aching in their bones.

- ²⁰They lose their appetite
for even the most delicious food.

- ²¹Their flesh wastes away,
and their bones stick out.

- ²²They are at death’s door;
the angels of death wait for them.

- ²³“But if an angel from heaven appears—
a special messenger to intercede for a person
and declare that he is upright—

- ²⁴he will be gracious and say,

- ‘Rescue him from the grave,
for I have found a ransom for his life.’

- ²⁵Then his body will become as healthy as a child’s,
firm and youthful again.

- ²⁶When he prays to God,
he will be accepted.

- And God will receive him with joy
and restore him to good standing.

- ²⁷He will declare to his friends,
‘I sinned and twisted the truth,

but it was not worth it.

²⁸God rescued me from the grave,
and now my life is filled with light.’

²⁹“Yes, God does these things
again and again for people.

³⁰He rescues them from the grave
so they may enjoy the light of life.

³¹Mark this well, Job. Listen to me,
for I have more to say.

³²But if you have anything to say, go ahead.
Speak, for I am anxious to see you justified.

³³But if not, then listen to me.
Keep silent and I will teach you wisdom!”

34

Elihu Accuses Job of Arrogance



HEN Elihu said:

²“Listen to me, you wise men.

Pay attention, you who have knowledge.

³Job said, ‘The ear tests the words it hears
just as the mouth distinguishes between foods.’

⁴So let us discern for ourselves what is right;
let us learn together what is good.

⁵For Job also said, ‘I am innocent,
but God has taken away my rights.

⁶I am innocent, but they call me a liar.
My suffering is incurable, though I have not sinned.’

⁷“Tell me, has there ever been a man like Job,
with his thirst for irreverent talk?

⁸He chooses evil people as companions.
He spends his time with wicked men.

⁹He has even said, ‘Why waste time
trying to please God?’

¹⁰“Listen to me, you who have understanding.
Everyone knows that God doesn’t sin!
The Almighty can do no wrong.

¹¹He repays people according to their deeds.
He treats people as they deserve.

¹²Truly, God will not do wrong.
The Almighty will not twist justice.

¹³Did someone else put the world in his care?
Who set the whole world in place?

¹⁴If God were to take back his spirit
and withdraw his breath,

¹⁵all life would cease,
and humanity would turn again to dust.

¹⁶“Now listen to me if you are wise.
Pay attention to what I say.

¹⁷Could God govern if he hated justice?
Are you going to condemn the almighty judge?

¹⁸For he says to kings, ‘You are wicked,’
and to nobles, ‘You are unjust.’

¹⁹He doesn’t care how great a person may be,
and he pays no more attention to the rich than to the poor.
He made them all.

²⁰In a moment they die.
In the middle of the night they pass away;

the mighty are removed without human hand.

- ²¹“For God watches how people live;
he sees everything they do.
²²No darkness is thick enough
to hide the wicked from his eyes.
²³We don’t set the time
when we will come before God in judgment.
²⁴He brings the mighty to ruin without asking anyone,
and he sets up others in their place.
²⁵He knows what they do,
and in the night he overturns and destroys them.
²⁶He strikes them down because they are wicked,
doing it openly for all to see.
²⁷For they turned away from following him.
They have no respect for any of his ways.
²⁸They cause the poor to cry out, catching God’s attention.
He hears the cries of the needy.
²⁹But if he chooses to remain quiet,
who can criticize him?
When he hides his face, no one can find him,
whether an individual or a nation.
³⁰He prevents the godless from ruling
so they cannot be a snare to the people.
- ³¹“Why don’t people say to God, ‘I have sinned,
but I will sin no more’?
³²Or ‘I don’t know what evil I have done—tell me.
If I have done wrong, I will stop at once’?
- ³³“Must God tailor his justice to your demands?

But you have rejected him!
The choice is yours, not mine.
Go ahead, share your wisdom with us.
³⁴After all, bright people will tell me,
and wise people will hear me say,
³⁵‘Job speaks out of ignorance;
his words lack insight.’
³⁶Job, you deserve the maximum penalty
for the wicked way you have talked.
³⁷For you have added rebellion to your sin;
you show no respect,
and you speak many angry words against God.”

35

Elihu Reminds Job of God’s Justice



HEN Elihu said:

- ²“Do you think it is right for you to claim,
‘I am righteous before God’?
³For you also ask, ‘What’s in it for me?
What’s the use of living a righteous life?’

⁴“I will answer you
and all your friends, too.
⁵Look up into the sky,
and see the clouds high above you.
⁶If you sin, how does that affect God?
Even if you sin again and again,
what effect will it have on him?
⁷If you are good, is this some great gift to him?

What could you possibly give him?

⁸No, your sins affect only people like yourself,
and your good deeds also affect only humans.

⁹“People cry out when they are oppressed.

They groan beneath the power of the mighty.

¹⁰Yet they don’t ask, ‘Where is God my Creator,
the one who gives songs in the night?’

¹¹Where is the one who makes us smarter than the animals
and wiser than the birds of the sky?’

¹²And when they cry out, God does not answer
because of their pride.

¹³But it is wrong to say God doesn’t listen,
to say the Almighty isn’t concerned.

¹⁴You say you can’t see him,
but he will bring justice if you will only wait.

¹⁵You say he does not respond to sinners with anger
and is not greatly concerned about wickedness.

¹⁶But you are talking nonsense, Job.
You have spoken like a fool.”

36



LIHU continued speaking:

²“Let me go on, and I will show you the truth.
For I have not finished defending God!

³I will present profound arguments
for the righteousness of my Creator.

⁴I am telling you nothing but the truth,

+for I am a man of great knowledge.

⁵“God is mighty, but he does not despise anyone!

He is mighty in both power and understanding.

⁶He does not let the wicked live
but gives justice to the afflicted.

⁷He never takes his eyes off the innocent,
but he sets them on thrones with kings
and exalts them forever.

⁸If they are bound in chains
and caught up in a web of trouble,

⁹he shows them the reason.

He shows them their sins of pride.

¹⁰He gets their attention
and commands that they turn from evil.

¹¹“If they listen and obey God,
they will be blessed with prosperity throughout their lives.
All their years will be pleasant.

¹²But if they refuse to listen to him,
they will cross over the river of death,
dying from lack of understanding.

¹³For the godless are full of resentment.
Even when he punishes them,
they refuse to cry out to him for help.

¹⁴They die when they are young,
after wasting their lives in immoral living.

¹⁵But by means of their suffering, he rescues those who suffer.
For he gets their attention through adversity.

¹⁶“God is leading you away from danger, Job,
to a place free from distress.
He is setting your table with the best food.

¹⁷But you are obsessed with whether the godless will be judged.
Don’t worry, judgment and justice will be upheld.

- ¹⁸But watch out, or you may be seduced by wealth.
Don't let yourself be bribed into sin.
- ¹⁹Could all your wealth
or all your mighty efforts
keep you from distress?
- ²⁰Do not long for the cover of night,
for that is when people will be destroyed.
- ²¹Be on guard! Turn back from evil,
for God sent this suffering
to keep you from a life of evil.

Elihu Reminds Job of God's Power

- ²²"Look, God is all-powerful.
Who is a teacher like him?
- ²³No one can tell him what to do,
or say to him, 'You have done wrong.'
- ²⁴Instead, glorify his mighty works,
singing songs of praise.
- ²⁵Everyone has seen these things,
though only from a distance.
- ²⁶"Look, God is greater than we can understand.
His years cannot be counted.
- ²⁷He draws up the water vapor
and then distills it into rain.
- ²⁸The rain pours down from the clouds,
and everyone benefits.
- ²⁹Who can understand the spreading of the clouds
and the thunder that rolls forth from heaven?
- ³⁰See how he spreads the lightning around him

and how it lights up the depths of the sea.

³¹By these mighty acts he nourishes the people,
giving them food in abundance.

³²He fills his hands with lightning bolts
and hurls each at its target.

³³The thunder announces his presence;
the storm announces his indignant anger.

37



Y heart pounds as I think of this.

It trembles within me.

²Listen carefully to the thunder of God's voice
as it rolls from his mouth.

³It rolls across the heavens,
and his lightning flashes in every direction.

⁴Then comes the roaring of the thunder—
the tremendous voice of his majesty.
He does not restrain it when he speaks.

⁵God's voice is glorious in the thunder.
We can't even imagine the greatness of his power.

⁶"He directs the snow to fall on the earth
and tells the rain to pour down.

⁷Then everyone stops working
so they can watch his power.

⁸The wild animals take cover
and stay inside their dens.

⁹The stormy wind comes from its chamber,
and the driving winds bring the cold.

¹⁰God's breath sends the ice,
freezing wide expanses of water.

- ¹¹He loads the clouds with moisture,
and they flash with his lightning.
¹²The clouds churn about at his direction.
They do whatever he commands throughout the earth.
¹³He makes these things happen either to punish people
or to show his unfailing love.

- ¹⁴“Pay attention to this, Job.
Stop and consider the wonderful miracles of God!
¹⁵Do you know how God controls the storm
and causes the lightning to flash from his clouds?
¹⁶Do you understand how he moves the clouds
with wonderful perfection and skill?
¹⁷When you are sweltering in your clothes
and the south wind dies down and everything is still,
¹⁸he makes the skies reflect the heat like a bronze mirror.
Can you do that?

- ¹⁹“So teach the rest of us what to say to God.
We are too ignorant to make our own arguments.
²⁰Should God be notified that I want to speak?
Can people even speak when they are confused?
²¹We cannot look at the sun,
for it shines brightly in the sky
when the wind clears away the clouds.
²²So also, golden splendor comes from the mountain of God.
He is clothed in dazzling splendor.
²³We cannot imagine the power of the Almighty;
but even though he is just and righteous,
he does not destroy us.
²⁴No wonder people everywhere fear him.
All who are wise show him reverence.”

38

The Lord Challenges Job



HEN the Lord answered Job from the whirlwind:

- ²“Who is this that questions my wisdom
with such ignorant words?
- ³Brace yourself like a man,
because I have some questions for you,
and you must answer them.
- ⁴“Where were you when I laid the foundations of the earth?
Tell me, if you know so much.
- ⁵Who determined its dimensions
and stretched out the surveying line?
- ⁶What supports its foundations,
and who laid its cornerstone
- ⁷as the morning stars sang together
and all the angels shouted for joy?
- ⁸“Who kept the sea inside its boundaries
as it burst from the womb,
- ⁹and as I clothed it with clouds
and wrapped it in thick darkness?
- ¹⁰For I locked it behind barred gates,
limiting its shores.
- ¹¹I said, ‘This far and no farther will you come.
Here your proud waves must stop!’
- ¹²“Have you ever commanded the morning to appear

and caused the dawn to rise in the east?

¹³ Have you made daylight spread to the ends of the earth,
to bring an end to the night's wickedness?

¹⁴ As the light approaches,
the earth takes shape like clay pressed beneath a seal;
it is robed in brilliant colors.

¹⁵ The light disturbs the wicked
and stops the arm that is raised in violence.

¹⁶ "Have you explored the springs from which the seas come?
Have you explored their depths?

¹⁷ Do you know where the gates of death are located?
Have you seen the gates of utter gloom?

¹⁸ Do you realize the extent of the earth?
Tell me about it if you know!

¹⁹ "Where does light come from,
and where does darkness go?

²⁰ Can you take each to its home?
Do you know how to get there?

²¹ But of course you know all this!
For you were born before it was all created,
and you are so very experienced!

²² "Have you visited the storehouses of the snow
or seen the storehouses of hail?

²³ (I have reserved them as weapons for the time of trouble,
for the day of battle and war.)

²⁴ Where is the path to the source of light?
Where is the home of the east wind?

25“Who created a channel for the torrents of rain?
Who laid out the path for the lightning?

26Who makes the rain fall on barren land,
in a desert where no one lives?

27Who sends rain to satisfy the parched ground
and make the tender grass spring up?

28“Does the rain have a father?
Who gives birth to the dew?

29Who is the mother of the ice?
Who gives birth to the frost from the heavens?

30For the water turns to ice as hard as rock,
and the surface of the water freezes.

31“Can you direct the movement of the stars—
binding the cluster of the Pleiades
or loosening the cords of Orion?

32Can you direct the constellations through the seasons
or guide the Bear with her cubs across the heavens?

33Do you know the laws of the universe?
Can you use them to regulate the earth?

34“Can you shout to the clouds
and make it rain?

35Can you make lightning appear
and cause it to strike as you direct?

36Who gives intuition to the heart
and instinct to the mind?

37Who is wise enough to count all the clouds?
Who can tilt the water jars of heaven

38when the parched ground is dry

and the soil has hardened into clods?

- ³⁹“Can you stalk prey for a lioness
and satisfy the young lions’ appetites
⁴⁰as they lie in their dens
or crouch in the thicket?
⁴¹Who provides food for the ravens
when their young cry out to God
and wander about in hunger?

39

The Lord’s Challenge Continues



- o you know when the wild goats give birth?
Have you watched as deer are born in the wild?
²Do you know how many months they carry their young?
Are you aware of the time of their delivery?
³They crouch down to give birth to their young
and deliver their offspring.
⁴Their young grow up in the open fields,
then leave home and never return.
- ⁵“Who gives the wild donkey its freedom?
Who untied its ropes?
⁶I have placed it in the wilderness;
its home is the wasteland.
⁷It hates the noise of the city
and has no driver to shout at it.
⁸The mountains are its pastureland,

where it searches for every blade of grass.

⁹“Will the wild ox consent to being tamed?

Will it spend the night in your stall?

¹⁰Can you hitch a wild ox to a plow?

Will it plow a field for you?

¹¹Given its strength, can you trust it?

Can you leave and trust the ox to do your work?

¹²Can you rely on it to bring home your grain
and deliver it to your threshing floor?

¹³“The ostrich flaps her wings grandly,
but they are no match for the feathers of the stork.

¹⁴She lays her eggs on top of the earth,
letting them be warmed in the dust.

¹⁵She doesn’t worry that a foot might crush them
or a wild animal might destroy them.

¹⁶She is harsh toward her young,
as if they were not her own.
She doesn’t care if they die.

¹⁷For God has deprived her of wisdom.
He has given her no understanding.

¹⁸But whenever she jumps up to run,
she passes the swiftest horse with its rider.

¹⁹“Have you given the horse its strength
or clothed its neck with a flowing mane?

²⁰Did you give it the ability to leap like a locust?
Its majestic snorting is terrifying!

²¹It paws the earth and rejoices in its strength
when it charges out to battle.

- ²²It laughs at fear and is unafraid.
It does not run from the sword.
- ²³The arrows rattle against it,
and the spear and javelin flash.
- ²⁴It paws the ground fiercely
and rushes forward into battle when the ram's horn blows.
- ²⁵It snorts at the sound of the horn.
It senses the battle in the distance.
It quivers at the captain's commands and the noise of battle.
- ²⁶"Is it your wisdom that makes the hawk soar
and spread its wings toward the south?
- ²⁷Is it at your command that the eagle rises
to the heights to make its nest?
- ²⁸It lives on the cliffs,
making its home on a distant, rocky crag.
- ²⁹From there it hunts its prey,
keeping watch with piercing eyes.
- ³⁰Its young gulp down blood.
Where there's a carcass, there you'll find it."

40



HEN the Lord said to Job,

- ²"Do you still want to argue with the Almighty?
You are God's critic, but do you have the answers?"

Job Responds to the Lord

- ³Then Job replied to the Lord,

- ⁴“I am nothing—how could I ever find the answers?
I will cover my mouth with my hand.
⁵I have said too much already.
I have nothing more to say.”

The Lord Challenges Job Again

- ⁶Then the Lord answered Job from the whirlwind:

- ⁷“Brace yourself like a man,
because I have some questions for you,
and you must answer them.
- ⁸“Will you discredit my justice
and condemn me just to prove you are right?
⁹Are you as strong as God?
Can you thunder with a voice like his?
¹⁰All right, put on your glory and splendor,
your honor and majesty.
¹¹Give vent to your anger.
Let it overflow against the proud.
¹²Humiliate the proud with a glance;
walk on the wicked where they stand.
¹³Bury them in the dust.
Imprison them in the world of the dead.
¹⁴Then even I would praise you,
for your own strength would save you.
- ¹⁵“Take a look at Behemoth,
which I made, just as I made you.

- It eats grass like an ox.
¹⁶See its powerful loins
and the muscles of its belly.
¹⁷Its tail is as strong as a cedar.
The sinews of its thighs are knit tightly together.
¹⁸Its bones are tubes of bronze.
Its limbs are bars of iron.
¹⁹It is a prime example of God's handiwork,
and only its Creator can threaten it.
²⁰The mountains offer it their best food,
where all the wild animals play.
²¹It lies under the lotus plants,
hidden by the reeds in the marsh.
²²The lotus plants give it shade
among the willows beside the stream.
²³It is not disturbed by the raging river,
not concerned when the swelling Jordan rushes around it.
²⁴No one can catch it off guard
or put a ring in its nose and lead it away.

41

The Lord's Challenge Continues



- Can you catch Leviathan with a hook
or put a noose around its jaw?
²Can you tie it with a rope through the nose
or pierce its jaw with a spike?
³Will it beg you for mercy
or implore you for pity?
⁴Will it agree to work for you,
to be your slave for life?

⁵ Can you make it a pet like a bird,
or give it to your little girls to play with?
⁶ Will merchants try to buy it
to sell it in their shops?
⁷ Will its hide be hurt by spears
or its head by a harpoon?
⁸ If you lay a hand on it,
you will certainly remember the battle that follows.
You won't try that again!
⁹ No, it is useless to try to capture it.
The hunter who attempts it will be knocked down.
¹⁰ And since no one dares to disturb it,
who then can stand up to me?
¹¹ Who has given me anything that I need to pay back?
Everything under heaven is mine.

¹² "I want to emphasize Leviathan's limbs
and its enormous strength and graceful form.
¹³ Who can strip off its hide,
and who can penetrate its double layer of armor?
¹⁴ Who could pry open its jaws?
For its teeth are terrible!
¹⁵ The scales on its back are like rows of shields
tightly sealed together.
¹⁶ They are so close together
that no air can get between them.
¹⁷ Each scale sticks tight to the next.
They interlock and cannot be penetrated.

¹⁸ "When it sneezes, it flashes light!
Its eyes are like the red of dawn.
¹⁹ Lightning leaps from its mouth;

flames of fire flash out.

²⁰Smoke streams from its nostrils
like steam from a pot heated over burning rushes.

²¹Its breath would kindle coals,
for flames shoot from its mouth.

²²“The tremendous strength in Leviathan’s neck
strikes terror wherever it goes.

²³Its flesh is hard and firm
and cannot be penetrated.

²⁴Its heart is hard as rock,
hard as a millstone.

²⁵When it rises, the mighty are afraid,
gripped by terror.

²⁶No sword can stop it,
no spear, dart, or javelin.

²⁷Iron is nothing but straw to that creature,
and bronze is like rotten wood.

²⁸Arrows cannot make it flee.
Stones shot from a sling are like bits of grass.

²⁹Clubs are like a blade of grass,
and it laughs at the swish of javelins.

³⁰Its belly is covered with scales as sharp as glass.
It plows up the ground as it drags through the mud.

³¹“Leviathan makes the water boil with its commotion.
It stirs the depths like a pot of ointment.

³²The water glistens in its wake,
making the sea look white.

³³Nothing on earth is its equal,
no other creature so fearless.

³⁴Of all the creatures, it is the proudest.

It is the king of beasts.”

42

Job Responds to the Lord



HEN Job replied to the Lord:

²“I know that you can do anything,
and no one can stop you.

³You asked, ‘Who is this that questions my wisdom with such
ignorance?’

It is I—and I was talking about things I knew nothing about,
things far too wonderful for me.

⁴You said, ‘Listen and I will speak!
I have some questions for you,
and you must answer them.’

⁵I had only heard about you before,
but now I have seen you with my own eyes.

⁶I take back everything I said,
and I sit in dust and ashes to show my repentance.”

Conclusion: The Lord Blesses Job

⁷After the Lord had finished speaking to Job, he said to Eliphaz the Temanite: “I am angry with you and your two friends, for you have not spoken accurately about me, as my servant Job has. ⁸So take seven bulls and seven rams and go to my servant Job and offer a burnt offering for yourselves. My servant Job will pray for you, and I will accept his prayer on your behalf. I will not treat you as you deserve, for you have not spoken accurately about me, as my servant Job has.” ⁹So Eliphaz the Temanite, Bildad the Shuhite, and Zophar

the Naamathite did as the Lord commanded them, and the Lord accepted Job's prayer.

¹⁰When Job prayed for his friends, the Lord restored his fortunes. In fact, the Lord gave him twice as much as before! ¹¹Then all his brothers, sisters, and former friends came and feasted with him in his home. And they consoled him and comforted him because of all the trials the Lord had brought against him. And each of them brought him a gift of money and a gold ring.

¹²So the Lord blessed Job in the second half of his life even more than in the beginning. For now he had 14,000 sheep, 6,000 camels, 1,000 teams of oxen, and 1,000 female donkeys. ¹³He also gave Job seven more sons and three more daughters. ¹⁴He named his first daughter Jemimah, the second Keziah, and the third Keren-happuch. ¹⁵In all the land no women were as lovely as the daughters of Job. And their father put them into his will along with their brothers.

¹⁶Job lived 140 years after that, living to see four generations of his children and grandchildren. ¹⁷Then he died, an old man who had lived a long, full life.

Proverbs

1

The Purpose of Proverbs



THESE are the proverbs of Solomon, David's son, king of Israel.

- ²Their purpose is to teach people wisdom and discipline,
to help them understand the insights of the wise.
- ³Their purpose is to teach people to live disciplined and successful
lives,
to help them do what is right, just, and fair.
- ⁴These proverbs will give insight to the simple,
knowledge and discernment to the young.
- ⁵Let the wise listen to these proverbs and become even wiser.
Let those with understanding receive guidance
- ⁶by exploring the meaning in these proverbs and parables,
the words of the wise and their riddles.
- ⁷Fear of the Lord is the foundation of true knowledge,
but fools despise wisdom and discipline.

A Father's Exhortation: Acquire Wisdom

⁸My child, listen when your father corrects you.

Don't neglect your mother's instruction.

⁹What you learn from them will crown you with grace
and be a chain of honor around your neck.

¹⁰My child, if sinners entice you,
turn your back on them!

¹¹They may say, "Come and join us.

Let's hide and kill someone!

Just for fun, let's ambush the innocent!

¹²Let's swallow them alive, like the grave;
let's swallow them whole, like those who go down to the pit
of death.

¹³Think of the great things we'll get!

We'll fill our houses with all the stuff we take.

¹⁴Come, throw in your lot with us;
we'll all share the loot."

¹⁵My child, don't go along with them!

Stay far away from their paths.

¹⁶They rush to commit evil deeds.

They hurry to commit murder.

¹⁷If a bird sees a trap being set,
it knows to stay away.

¹⁸But these people set an ambush for themselves;
they are trying to get themselves killed.

¹⁹Such is the fate of all who are greedy for money;
it robs them of life.

Wisdom Shouts in the Streets

²⁰Wisdom shouts in the streets.

She cries out in the public square.

²¹She calls to the crowds along the main street,
to those gathered in front of the city gate:

²²“How long, you simpletons,
will you insist on being simpleminded?
How long will you mockers relish your mocking?
How long will you fools hate knowledge?

²³Come and listen to my counsel.
I'll share my heart with you
and make you wise.

²⁴“I called you so often, but you wouldn't come.
I reached out to you, but you paid no attention.

²⁵You ignored my advice
and rejected the correction I offered.

²⁶So I will laugh when you are in trouble!
I will mock you when disaster overtakes you—

²⁷when calamity overtakes you like a storm,
when disaster engulfs you like a cyclone,
and anguish and distress overwhelm you.

²⁸“When they cry for help, I will not answer.
Though they anxiously search for me, they will not find me.

²⁹For they hated knowledge
and chose not to fear the Lord.

³⁰They rejected my advice
and paid no attention when I corrected them.

³¹Therefore, they must eat the bitter fruit of living their own way,

choking on their own schemes.

³²For simpletons turn away from me—to death.

Fools are destroyed by their own complacency.

³³But all who listen to me will live in peace,
untroubled by fear of harm.”

2

The Benefits of Wisdom



Y child, listen to what I say,
and treasure my commands.

²Tune your ears to wisdom,
and concentrate on understanding.

³Cry out for insight,
and ask for understanding.

⁴Search for them as you would for silver;
seek them like hidden treasures.

⁵Then you will understand what it means to fear the Lord,
and you will gain knowledge of God.

⁶For the Lord grants wisdom!
From his mouth come knowledge and understanding.

⁷He grants a treasure of common sense to the honest.
He is a shield to those who walk with integrity.

⁸He guards the paths of the just
and protects those who are faithful to him.

⁹Then you will understand what is right, just, and fair,
and you will find the right way to go.

¹⁰For wisdom will enter your heart,
and knowledge will fill you with joy.

- ¹¹Wise choices will watch over you.
Understanding will keep you safe.
- ¹²Wisdom will save you from evil people,
from those whose words are twisted.
- ¹³These men turn from the right way
to walk down dark paths.
- ¹⁴They take pleasure in doing wrong,
and they enjoy the twisted ways of evil.
- ¹⁵Their actions are crooked,
and their ways are wrong.
- ¹⁶Wisdom will save you from the immoral woman,
from the seductive words of the promiscuous woman.
- ¹⁷She has abandoned her husband
and ignores the covenant she made before God.
- ¹⁸Entering her house leads to death;
it is the road to the grave.
- ¹⁹The man who visits her is doomed.
He will never reach the paths of life.
- ²⁰So follow the steps of the good,
and stay on the paths of the righteous.
- ²¹For only the godly will live in the land,
and those with integrity will remain in it.
- ²²But the wicked will be removed from the land,
and the treacherous will be uprooted.

3

Trusting in the Lord



My child, never forget the things I have taught you.

Store my commands in your heart.

²If you do this, you will live many years,
and your life will be satisfying.

³Never let loyalty and kindness leave you!
Tie them around your neck as a reminder.
Write them deep within your heart.

⁴Then you will find favor with both God and people,
and you will earn a good reputation.

⁵Trust in the Lord with all your heart;
do not depend on your own understanding.

⁶Seek his will in all you do,
and he will show you which path to take.

⁷Don't be impressed with your own wisdom.
Instead, fear the Lord and turn away from evil.

⁸Then you will have healing for your body
and strength for your bones.

⁹Honor the Lord with your wealth
and with the best part of everything you produce.

¹⁰Then he will fill your barns with grain,
and your vats will overflow with good wine.

- ¹¹My child, don't reject the Lord's discipline,
and don't be upset when he corrects you.
- ¹²For the Lord corrects those he loves,
just as a father corrects a child in whom he delights.
- ¹³Joyful is the person who finds wisdom,
the one who gains understanding.
- ¹⁴For wisdom is more profitable than silver,
and her wages are better than gold.
- ¹⁵Wisdom is more precious than rubies;
nothing you desire can compare with her.
- ¹⁶She offers you long life in her right hand,
and riches and honor in her left.
- ¹⁷She will guide you down delightful paths;
all her ways are satisfying.
- ¹⁸Wisdom is a tree of life to those who embrace her;
happy are those who hold her tightly.
- ¹⁹By wisdom the Lord founded the earth;
by understanding he created the heavens.
- ²⁰By his knowledge the deep fountains of the earth burst forth,
and the dew settles beneath the night sky.
- ²¹My child, don't lose sight of common sense and discernment.
Hang on to them,
- ²²for they will refresh your soul.
They are like jewels on a necklace.
- ²³They keep you safe on your way,
and your feet will not stumble.
- ²⁴You can go to bed without fear;
you will lie down and sleep soundly.

²⁵You need not be afraid of sudden disaster
or the destruction that comes upon the wicked,
²⁶for the Lord is your security.
He will keep your foot from being caught in a trap.

²⁷Do not withhold good from those who deserve it
when it's in your power to help them.
²⁸If you can help your neighbor now, don't say,
"Come back tomorrow, and then I'll help you."

²⁹Don't plot harm against your neighbor,
for those who live nearby trust you.
³⁰Don't pick a fight without reason,
when no one has done you harm.

³¹Don't envy violent people
or copy their ways.
³²Such wicked people are detestable to the Lord,
but he offers his friendship to the godly.

³³The Lord curses the house of the wicked,
but he blesses the home of the upright.

³⁴The Lord mocks the mockers
but is gracious to the humble.

³⁵The wise inherit honor,
but fools are put to shame!

A Father's Wise Advice



My children, listen when your father corrects you.

Pay attention and learn good judgment,
²for I am giving you good guidance.

Don't turn away from my instructions.

³For I, too, was once my father's son,
tenderly loved as my mother's only child.

⁴My father taught me,

"Take my words to heart.

Follow my commands, and you will live.

⁵Get wisdom; develop good judgment.

Don't forget my words or turn away from them.

⁶Don't turn your back on wisdom, for she will protect you.

Love her, and she will guard you.

⁷Getting wisdom is the wisest thing you can do!

And whatever else you do, develop good judgment.

⁸If you prize wisdom, she will make you great.

Embrace her, and she will honor you.

⁹She will place a lovely wreath on your head;

she will present you with a beautiful crown."

¹⁰My child, listen to me and do as I say,
and you will have a long, good life.

¹¹I will teach you wisdom's ways
and lead you in straight paths.

¹²When you walk, you won't be held back;
when you run, you won't stumble.

¹³Take hold of my instructions; don't let them go.
Guard them, for they are the key to life.

¹⁴Don't do as the wicked do,
and don't follow the path of evildoers.

¹⁵Don't even think about it; don't go that way.
Turn away and keep moving.

¹⁶For evil people can't sleep until they've done their evil deed for
the day.

They can't rest until they've caused someone to stumble.

¹⁷They eat the food of wickedness
and drink the wine of violence!

¹⁸The way of the righteous is like the first gleam of dawn,
which shines ever brighter until the full light of day.

¹⁹But the way of the wicked is like total darkness.
They have no idea what they are stumbling over.

²⁰My child, pay attention to what I say.
Listen carefully to my words.

²¹Don't lose sight of them.
Let them penetrate deep into your heart,
²²for they bring life to those who find them,
and healing to their whole body.

²³Guard your heart above all else,
for it determines the course of your life.

²⁴Avoid all perverse talk;

stay away from corrupt speech.

²⁵Look straight ahead,
and fix your eyes on what lies before you.

²⁶Mark out a straight path for your feet;
stay on the safe path.

²⁷Don't get sidetracked;
keep your feet from following evil.

5

Avoid Immoral Women



Y son, pay attention to my wisdom;
listen carefully to my wise counsel.

²Then you will show discernment,
and your lips will express what you've learned.

³For the lips of an immoral woman are as sweet as honey,
and her mouth is smoother than oil.

⁴But in the end she is as bitter as poison,
as dangerous as a double-edged sword.

⁵Her feet go down to death;
her steps lead straight to the grave.

⁶For she cares nothing about the path to life.
She staggers down a crooked trail and doesn't realize it.

⁷So now, my sons, listen to me.
Never stray from what I am about to say:

⁸Stay away from her!
Don't go near the door of her house!

- ⁹If you do, you will lose your honor
and will lose to merciless people all you have achieved.
¹⁰Strangers will consume your wealth,
and someone else will enjoy the fruit of your labor.
¹¹In the end you will groan in anguish
when disease consumes your body.
¹²You will say, "How I hated discipline!
If only I had not ignored all the warnings!
¹³Oh, why didn't I listen to my teachers?
Why didn't I pay attention to my instructors?
¹⁴I have come to the brink of utter ruin,
and now I must face public disgrace."

- ¹⁵Drink water from your own well—
share your love only with your wife.
¹⁶Why spill the water of your springs in the streets,
having sex with just anyone?
¹⁷You should reserve it for yourselves.
Never share it with strangers.

- ¹⁸Let your wife be a fountain of blessing for you.
Rejoice in the wife of your youth.
¹⁹She is a loving deer, a graceful doe.
Let her breasts satisfy you always.
May you always be captivated by her love.
²⁰Why be captivated, my son, by an immoral woman,
or fondle the breasts of a promiscuous woman?

- ²¹For the Lord sees clearly what a man does,
examining every path he takes.
²²An evil man is held captive by his own sins;

they are ropes that catch and hold him.
²³He will die for lack of self-control;
he will be lost because of his great foolishness.

6

Lessons for Daily Life



My child, if you have put up security for a friend's debt
or agreed to guarantee the debt of a stranger—
²if you have trapped yourself by your agreement
and are caught by what you said—
³follow my advice and save yourself,
for you have placed yourself at your friend's mercy.
Now swallow your pride;
go and beg to have your name erased.
⁴Don't put it off; do it now!
Don't rest until you do.
⁵Save yourself like a gazelle escaping from a hunter,
like a bird fleeing from a net.

⁶Take a lesson from the ants, you lazybones.
Learn from their ways and become wise!
⁷Though they have no prince
or governor or ruler to make them work,
⁸they labor hard all summer,
gathering food for the winter.
⁹But you, lazybones, how long will you sleep?
When will you wake up?
¹⁰A little extra sleep, a little more slumber,
a little folding of the hands to rest—

¹¹then poverty will pounce on you like a bandit;
scarcity will attack you like an armed robber.

¹²What are worthless and wicked people like?

They are constant liars,

¹³signaling their deceit with a wink of the eye,
a nudge of the foot, or the wiggle of fingers.

¹⁴Their perverted hearts plot evil,
and they constantly stir up trouble.

¹⁵But they will be destroyed suddenly,
broken in an instant beyond all hope of healing.

¹⁶There are six things the Lord hates—
no, seven things he detests:

¹⁷haughty eyes,
a lying tongue,
hands that kill the innocent,

¹⁸a heart that plots evil,
feet that race to do wrong,

¹⁹a false witness who pours out lies,
a person who sows discord in a family.

²⁰My son, obey your father's commands,
and don't neglect your mother's instruction.

²¹Keep their words always in your heart.
Tie them around your neck.

²²When you walk, their counsel will lead you.
When you sleep, they will protect you.
When you wake up, they will advise you.

²³For their command is a lamp
and their instruction a light;

their corrective discipline
is the way to life.

²⁴It will keep you from the immoral woman,
from the smooth tongue of a promiscuous woman.

²⁵Don't lust for her beauty.
Don't let her coy glances seduce you.

²⁶For a prostitute will bring you to poverty,
but sleeping with another man's wife will cost you your life.

²⁷Can a man scoop a flame into his lap
and not have his clothes catch on fire?

²⁸Can he walk on hot coals
and not blister his feet?

²⁹So it is with the man who sleeps with another man's wife.
He who embraces her will not go unpunished.

³⁰Excuses might be found for a thief
who steals because he is starving.

³¹But if he is caught, he must pay back seven times what he stole,
even if he has to sell everything in his house.

³²But the man who commits adultery is an utter fool,
for he destroys himself.

³³He will be wounded and disgraced.
His shame will never be erased.

³⁴For the woman's jealous husband will be furious,
and he will show no mercy when he takes revenge.

³⁵He will accept no compensation,
nor be satisfied with a payoff of any size.



FOLLOW my advice, my son;
always treasure my commands.

²Obey my commands and live!

Guard my instructions as you guard your own eyes.

³Tie them on your fingers as a reminder.

Write them deep within your heart.

⁴Love wisdom like a sister;

make insight a beloved member of your family.

⁵Let them protect you from an affair with an immoral woman,
from listening to the flattery of a promiscuous woman.

⁶While I was at the window of my house,
looking through the curtain,

⁷I saw some naive young men,
and one in particular who lacked common sense.

⁸He was crossing the street near the house of an immoral woman,
strolling down the path by her house.

⁹It was at twilight, in the evening,
as deep darkness fell.

¹⁰The woman approached him,
seductively dressed and sly of heart.

¹¹She was the brash, rebellious type,
never content to stay at home.

¹²She is often in the streets and markets,
soliciting at every corner.

¹³She threw her arms around him and kissed him,
and with a brazen look she said,

¹⁴“I’ve just made my peace offerings
and fulfilled my vows.

¹⁵You’re the one I was looking for!
I came out to find you, and here you are!

- ¹⁶My bed is spread with beautiful blankets,
with colored sheets of Egyptian linen.
¹⁷I've perfumed my bed
with myrrh, aloes, and cinnamon.
¹⁸Come, let's drink our fill of love until morning.
Let's enjoy each other's caresses,
¹⁹for my husband is not home.
He's away on a long trip.
²⁰He has taken a wallet full of money with him
and won't return until later this month."

- ²¹So she seduced him with her pretty speech
and enticed him with her flattery.
²²He followed her at once,
like an ox going to the slaughter.
He was like a stag caught in a trap,
²³awaiting the arrow that would pierce its heart.
He was like a bird flying into a snare,
little knowing it would cost him his life.

- ²⁴So listen to me, my sons,
and pay attention to my words.
²⁵Don't let your hearts stray away toward her.
Don't wander down her wayward path.
²⁶For she has been the ruin of many;
many men have been her victims.
²⁷Her house is the road to the grave.
Her bedroom is the den of death.

8

Wisdom Calls for a Hearing



LISTEN as Wisdom calls out!

Hear as understanding raises her voice!

²On the hilltop along the road,
she takes her stand at the crossroads.

³By the gates at the entrance to the town,
on the road leading in, she cries aloud,

⁴"I call to you, to all of you!
I raise my voice to all people.

⁵You simple people, use good judgment.
You foolish people, show some understanding.

⁶Listen to me! For I have important things to tell you.
Everything I say is right,

⁷for I speak the truth
and detest every kind of deception.

⁸My advice is wholesome.
There is nothing devious or crooked in it.

⁹My words are plain to anyone with understanding,
clear to those with knowledge.

¹⁰Choose my instruction rather than silver,
and knowledge rather than pure gold.

¹¹For wisdom is far more valuable than rubies.
Nothing you desire can compare with it.

¹²"I, Wisdom, live together with good judgment.
I know where to discover knowledge and discernment.

¹³All who fear the Lord will hate evil.
Therefore, I hate pride and arrogance,
corruption and perverse speech.

¹⁴Common sense and success belong to me.

Insight and strength are mine.

¹⁵Because of me, kings reign,
and rulers make just decrees.

¹⁶Rulers lead with my help,
and nobles make righteous judgments.

¹⁷“I love all who love me.

Those who search will surely find me.

¹⁸I have riches and honor,
as well as enduring wealth and justice.

¹⁹My gifts are better than gold, even the purest gold,
my wages better than sterling silver!

²⁰I walk in righteousness,
in paths of justice.

²¹Those who love me inherit wealth.
I will fill their treasuries.

²²“The Lord formed me from the beginning,
before he created anything else.

²³I was appointed in ages past,
at the very first, before the earth began.

²⁴I was born before the oceans were created,
before the springs bubbled forth their waters.

²⁵Before the mountains were formed,
before the hills, I was born—

²⁶before he had made the earth and fields
and the first handfuls of soil.

²⁷I was there when he established the heavens,
when he drew the horizon on the oceans.

²⁸I was there when he set the clouds above,
when he established springs deep in the earth.

²⁹I was there when he set the limits of the seas,
so they would not spread beyond their boundaries.
And when he marked off the earth's foundations,

³⁰I was the architect at his side.
I was his constant delight,
rejoicing always in his presence.

³¹And how happy I was with the world he created;
how I rejoiced with the human family!

³²“And so, my children, listen to me,
for all who follow my ways are joyful.

³³Listen to my instruction and be wise.
Don't ignore it.

³⁴Joyful are those who listen to me,
watching for me daily at my gates,
waiting for me outside my home!

³⁵For whoever finds me finds life
and receives favor from the Lord.

³⁶But those who miss me injure themselves.
All who hate me love death.”

9



WISDOM has built her house;
she has carved its seven columns.

²She has prepared a great banquet,
mixed the wines, and set the table.

³She has sent her servants to invite everyone to come.
She calls out from the heights overlooking the city.

⁴“Come in with me,” she urges the simple.
To those who lack good judgment, she says,

⁵“Come, eat my food,

and drink the wine I have mixed.

⁶Leave your simple ways behind, and begin to live;
learn to use good judgment.”

⁷Anyone who rebukes a mocker will get an insult in return.

Anyone who corrects the wicked will get hurt.

⁸So don't bother correcting mockers;
they will only hate you.

But correct the wise,
and they will love you.

⁹Instruct the wise,
and they will be even wiser.

Teach the righteous,
and they will learn even more.

¹⁰Fear of the Lord is the foundation of wisdom.

Knowledge of the Holy One results in good judgment.

¹¹Wisdom will multiply your days
and add years to your life.

¹²If you become wise, you will be the one to benefit.
If you scorn wisdom, you will be the one to suffer.

Folly Calls for a Hearing

¹³The woman named Folly is brash.

She is ignorant and doesn't know it.

¹⁴She sits in her doorway
on the heights overlooking the city.

- ¹⁵She calls out to men going by
who are minding their own business.
- ¹⁶“Come in with me,” she urges the simple.
To those who lack good judgment, she says,
- ¹⁷“Stolen water is refreshing;
food eaten in secret tastes the best!”
- ¹⁸But little do they know that the dead are there.
Her guests are in the depths of the grave.

10

The Proverbs of Solomon



HE proverbs of Solomon:

- A wise child brings joy to a father;
a foolish child brings grief to a mother.
- ²Tainted wealth has no lasting value,
but right living can save your life.
- ³The Lord will not let the godly go hungry,
but he refuses to satisfy the craving of the wicked.
- ⁴Lazy people are soon poor;
hard workers get rich.
- ⁵A wise youth harvests in the summer,
but one who sleeps during harvest is a disgrace.

⁶The godly are showered with blessings;
the words of the wicked conceal violent intentions.

⁷We have happy memories of the godly,
but the name of a wicked person rots away.

⁸The wise are glad to be instructed,
but babbling fools fall flat on their faces.

⁹People with integrity walk safely,
but those who follow crooked paths will be exposed.

¹⁰People who wink at wrong cause trouble,
but a bold reproof promotes peace.

¹¹The words of the godly are a life-giving fountain;
the words of the wicked conceal violent intentions.

¹²Hatred stirs up quarrels,
but love makes up for all offenses.

¹³Wise words come from the lips of people with understanding,
but those lacking sense will be beaten with a rod.

¹⁴Wise people treasure knowledge,
but the babbling of a fool invites disaster.

- ¹⁵The wealth of the rich is their fortress;
the poverty of the poor is their destruction.
- ¹⁶The earnings of the godly enhance their lives,
but evil people squander their money on sin.
- ¹⁷People who accept discipline are on the pathway to life,
but those who ignore correction will go astray.
- ¹⁸Hiding hatred makes you a liar;
slandering others makes you a fool.
- ¹⁹Too much talk leads to sin.
Be sensible and keep your mouth shut.
- ²⁰The words of the godly are like sterling silver;
the heart of a fool is worthless.
- ²¹The words of the godly encourage many,
but fools are destroyed by their lack of common sense.
- ²²The blessing of the Lord makes a person rich,
and he adds no sorrow with it.
- ²³Doing wrong is fun for a fool,
but living wisely brings pleasure to the sensible.

²⁴The fears of the wicked will be fulfilled;
the hopes of the godly will be granted.

²⁵When the storms of life come, the wicked are whirled away,
but the godly have a lasting foundation.

²⁶Lazy people irritate their employers,
like vinegar to the teeth or smoke in the eyes.

²⁷Fear of the Lord lengthens one's life,
but the years of the wicked are cut short.

²⁸The hopes of the godly result in happiness,
but the expectations of the wicked come to nothing.

²⁹The way of the Lord is a stronghold to those with integrity,
but it destroys the wicked.

³⁰The godly will never be disturbed,
but the wicked will be removed from the land.

³¹The mouth of the godly person gives wise advice,
but the tongue that deceives will be cut off.

³²The lips of the godly speak helpful words,
but the mouth of the wicked speaks perverse words.

11



HE Lord detests the use of dishonest scales,
but he delights in accurate weights.

²Pride leads to disgrace,
but with humility comes wisdom.

³Honesty guides good people;
dishonesty destroys treacherous people.

⁴Riches won't help on the day of judgment,
but right living can save you from death.

⁵The godly are directed by honesty;
the wicked fall beneath their load of sin.

⁶The godliness of good people rescues them;
the ambition of treacherous people traps them.

⁷When the wicked die, their hopes die with them,
for they rely on their own feeble strength.

⁸The godly are rescued from trouble,
and it falls on the wicked instead.

- ⁹With their words, the godless destroy their friends,
but knowledge will rescue the righteous.
- ¹⁰The whole city celebrates when the godly succeed;
they shout for joy when the wicked die.
- ¹¹Upright citizens are good for a city and make it prosper,
but the talk of the wicked tears it apart.
- ¹²It is foolish to belittle one's neighbor;
a sensible person keeps quiet.
- ¹³A gossip goes around telling secrets,
but those who are trustworthy can keep a confidence.
- ¹⁴Without wise leadership, a nation falls;
there is safety in having many advisers.
- ¹⁵There's danger in putting up security for a stranger's debt;
it's safer not to guarantee another person's debt.
- ¹⁶A gracious woman gains respect,
but ruthless men gain only wealth.
- ¹⁷Your kindness will reward you,
but your cruelty will destroy you.

- ¹⁸ Evil people get rich for the moment,
but the reward of the godly will last.
- ¹⁹ Godly people find life;
evil people find death.
- ²⁰ The Lord detests people with crooked hearts,
but he delights in those with integrity.
- ²¹ Evil people will surely be punished,
but the children of the godly will go free.
- ²² A beautiful woman who lacks discretion
is like a gold ring in a pig's snout.
- ²³ The godly can look forward to a reward,
while the wicked can expect only judgment.
- ²⁴ Give freely and become more wealthy;
be stingy and lose everything.
- ²⁵ The generous will prosper;
those who refresh others will themselves be refreshed.
- ²⁶ People curse those who hoard their grain,
but they bless the one who sells in time of need.

²⁷If you search for good, you will find favor;
but if you search for evil, it will find you!

²⁸Trust in your money and down you go!
But the godly flourish like leaves in spring.

²⁹Those who bring trouble on their families inherit the wind.
The fool will be a servant to the wise.

³⁰The seeds of good deeds become a tree of life;
a wise person wins friends.

³¹If the righteous are rewarded here on earth,
what will happen to wicked sinners?

12



o learn, you must love discipline;
it is stupid to hate correction.

²The Lord approves of those who are good,
but he condemns those who plan wickedness.

³Wickedness never brings stability,
but the godly have deep roots.

⁴A worthy wife is a crown for her husband,

but a disgraceful woman is like cancer in his bones.

⁵The plans of the godly are just;
the advice of the wicked is treacherous.

⁶The words of the wicked are like a murderous ambush,
but the words of the godly save lives.

⁷The wicked die and disappear,
but the family of the godly stands firm.

⁸A sensible person wins admiration,
but a warped mind is despised.

⁹Better to be an ordinary person with a servant
than to be self-important but have no food.

¹⁰The godly care for their animals,
but the wicked are always cruel.

¹¹A hard worker has plenty of food,
but a person who chases fantasies has no sense.

¹²Thieves are jealous of each other's loot,
but the godly are well rooted and bear their own fruit.

¹³The wicked are trapped by their own words,
but the godly escape such trouble.

¹⁴Wise words bring many benefits,
and hard work brings rewards.

¹⁵Fools think their own way is right,
but the wise listen to others.

¹⁶A fool is quick-tempered,
but a wise person stays calm when insulted.

¹⁷An honest witness tells the truth;
a false witness tells lies.

¹⁸Some people make cutting remarks,
but the words of the wise bring healing.

¹⁹Truthful words stand the test of time,
but lies are soon exposed.

²⁰Deceit fills hearts that are plotting evil;
joy fills hearts that are planning peace!

²¹No harm comes to the godly,
but the wicked have their fill of trouble.

- ²²The Lord detests lying lips,
but he delights in those who tell the truth.
- ²³The wise don't make a show of their knowledge,
but fools broadcast their foolishness.
- ²⁴Work hard and become a leader;
be lazy and become a slave.
- ²⁵Worry weighs a person down;
an encouraging word cheers a person up.
- ²⁶The godly give good advice to their friends;
the wicked lead them astray.
- ²⁷Lazy people don't even cook the game they catch,
but the diligent make use of everything they find.
- ²⁸The way of the godly leads to life;
that path does not lead to death.

13



wise child accepts a parent's discipline;
a mocker refuses to listen to correction.

- ²Wise words will win you a good meal,

but treacherous people have an appetite for violence.

³Those who control their tongue will have a long life;
opening your mouth can ruin everything.

⁴Lazy people want much but get little,
but those who work hard will prosper.

⁵The godly hate lies;
the wicked cause shame and disgrace.

⁶Godliness guards the path of the blameless,
but the evil are misled by sin.

⁷Some who are poor pretend to be rich;
others who are rich pretend to be poor.

⁸The rich can pay a ransom for their lives,
but the poor won't even get threatened.

⁹The life of the godly is full of light and joy,
but the light of the wicked will be snuffed out.

¹⁰Pride leads to conflict;
those who take advice are wise.

- ¹¹Wealth from get-rich-quick schemes quickly disappears;
wealth from hard work grows over time.
- ¹²Hope deferred makes the heart sick,
but a dream fulfilled is a tree of life.
- ¹³People who despise advice are asking for trouble;
those who respect a command will succeed.
- ¹⁴The instruction of the wise is like a life-giving fountain;
those who accept it avoid the snares of death.
- ¹⁵A person with good sense is respected;
a treacherous person is headed for destruction.
- ¹⁶Wise people think before they act;
fools don't—and even brag about their foolishness.
- ¹⁷An unreliable messenger stumbles into trouble,
but a reliable messenger brings healing.
- ¹⁸If you ignore criticism, you will end in poverty and disgrace;
if you accept correction, you will be honored.
- ¹⁹It is pleasant to see dreams come true,
but fools refuse to turn from evil to attain them.

²⁰Walk with the wise and become wise;
associate with fools and get in trouble.

²¹Trouble chases sinners,
while blessings reward the righteous.

²²Good people leave an inheritance to their grandchildren,
but the sinner's wealth passes to the godly.

²³A poor person's farm may produce much food,
but injustice sweeps it all away.

²⁴Those who spare the rod of discipline hate their children.
Those who love their children care enough to discipline them.

²⁵The godly eat to their hearts' content,
but the belly of the wicked goes hungry.

14



wise woman builds her home,
but a foolish woman tears it down with her own hands.

²Those who follow the right path fear the Lord;
those who take the wrong path despise him.

³A fool's proud talk becomes a rod that beats him,

but the words of the wise keep them safe.

⁴Without oxen a stable stays clean,
but you need a strong ox for a large harvest.

⁵An honest witness does not lie;
a false witness breathes lies.

⁶A mocker seeks wisdom and never finds it,
but knowledge comes easily to those with understanding.

⁷Stay away from fools,
for you won't find knowledge on their lips.

⁸The prudent understand where they are going,
but fools deceive themselves.

⁹Fools make fun of guilt,
but the godly acknowledge it and seek reconciliation.

¹⁰Each heart knows its own bitterness,
and no one else can fully share its joy.

¹¹The house of the wicked will be destroyed,
but the tent of the godly will flourish.

¹²There is a path before each person that seems right,
but it ends in death.

¹³Laughter can conceal a heavy heart,
but when the laughter ends, the grief remains.

¹⁴Backsliders get what they deserve;
good people receive their reward.

¹⁵Only simpletons believe everything they're told!
The prudent carefully consider their steps.

¹⁶The wise are cautious and avoid danger;
fools plunge ahead with reckless confidence.

¹⁷Short-tempered people do foolish things,
and schemers are hated.

¹⁸Simpletons are clothed with foolishness,
but the prudent are crowned with knowledge.

¹⁹Evil people will bow before good people;
the wicked will bow at the gates of the godly.

²⁰The poor are despised even by their neighbors,
while the rich have many "friends."

- ²¹It is a sin to belittle one's neighbor;
blessed are those who help the poor.
- ²²If you plan to do evil, you will be lost;
if you plan to do good, you will receive unfailing love and
faithfulness.
- ²³Work brings profit,
but mere talk leads to poverty!
- ²⁴Wealth is a crown for the wise;
the effort of fools yields only foolishness.
- ²⁵A truthful witness saves lives,
but a false witness is a traitor.
- ²⁶Those who fear the Lord are secure;
he will be a refuge for their children.
- ²⁷Fear of the Lord is a life-giving fountain;
it offers escape from the snares of death.
- ²⁸A growing population is a king's glory;
a prince without subjects has nothing.
- ²⁹People with understanding control their anger;
a hot temper shows great foolishness.

³⁰A peaceful heart leads to a healthy body;
jealousy is like cancer in the bones.

³¹Those who oppress the poor insult their Maker,
but helping the poor honors him.

³²The wicked are crushed by disaster,
but the godly have a refuge when they die.

³³Wisdom is enshrined in an understanding heart;
wisdom is not found among fools.

³⁴Godliness makes a nation great,
but sin is a disgrace to any people.

³⁵A king rejoices in wise servants
but is angry with those who disgrace him.

15



gentle answer deflects anger,
but harsh words make tempers flare.

²The tongue of the wise makes knowledge appealing,
but the mouth of a fool belches out foolishness.

³The Lord is watching everywhere,

keeping his eye on both the evil and the good.

⁴Gentle words are a tree of life;
a deceitful tongue crushes the spirit.

⁵Only a fool despises a parent's discipline;
whoever learns from correction is wise.

⁶There is treasure in the house of the godly,
but the earnings of the wicked bring trouble.

⁷The lips of the wise give good advice;
the heart of a fool has none to give.

⁸The Lord detests the sacrifice of the wicked,
but he delights in the prayers of the upright.

⁹The Lord detests the way of the wicked,
but he loves those who pursue godliness.

¹⁰Whoever abandons the right path will be severely disciplined;
whoever hates correction will die.

¹¹Even Death and Destruction hold no secrets from the Lord.
How much more does he know the human heart!

¹²Mockers hate to be corrected,
so they stay away from the wise.

¹³A glad heart makes a happy face;
a broken heart crushes the spirit.

¹⁴A wise person is hungry for knowledge,
while the fool feeds on trash.

¹⁵For the despondent, every day brings trouble;
for the happy heart, life is a continual feast.

¹⁶Better to have little, with fear for the Lord,
than to have great treasure and inner turmoil.

¹⁷A bowl of vegetables with someone you love
is better than steak with someone you hate.

¹⁸A hot-tempered person starts fights;
a cool-tempered person stops them.

¹⁹A lazy person's way is blocked with briers,
but the path of the upright is an open highway.

²⁰Sensible children bring joy to their father;
foolish children despise their mother.

- ²¹Foolishness brings joy to those with no sense;
a sensible person stays on the right path.
- ²²Plans go wrong for lack of advice;
many advisers bring success.
- ²³Everyone enjoys a fitting reply;
it is wonderful to say the right thing at the right time!
- ²⁴The path of life leads upward for the wise;
they leave the grave behind.
- ²⁵The Lord tears down the house of the proud,
but he protects the property of widows.
- ²⁶The Lord detests evil plans,
but he delights in pure words.
- ²⁷Greed brings grief to the whole family,
but those who hate bribes will live.
- ²⁸The heart of the godly thinks carefully before speaking;
the mouth of the wicked overflows with evil words.
- ²⁹The Lord is far from the wicked,
but he hears the prayers of the righteous.

³⁰A cheerful look brings joy to the heart;
good news makes for good health.

³¹If you listen to constructive criticism,
you will be at home among the wise.

³²If you reject discipline, you only harm yourself;
but if you listen to correction, you grow in understanding.

³³Fear of the Lord teaches wisdom;
humility precedes honor.

16



WE can make our own plans,
but the Lord gives the right answer.

²People may be pure in their own eyes,
but the Lord examines their motives.

³Commit your actions to the Lord,
and your plans will succeed.

⁴The Lord has made everything for his own purposes,
even the wicked for a day of disaster.

⁵The Lord detests the proud;

they will surely be punished.

⁶Unfailing love and faithfulness make atonement for sin.
By fearing the Lord, people avoid evil.

⁷When people's lives please the Lord,
even their enemies are at peace with them.

⁸Better to have little, with godliness,
than to be rich and dishonest.

⁹We can make our plans,
but the Lord determines our steps.

¹⁰The king speaks with divine wisdom;
he must never judge unfairly.

¹¹The Lord demands accurate scales and balances;
he sets the standards for fairness.

¹²A king detests wrongdoing,
for his rule is built on justice.

¹³The king is pleased with words from righteous lips;
he loves those who speak honestly.

¹⁴The anger of the king is a deadly threat;
the wise will try to appease it.

¹⁵When the king smiles, there is life;
his favor refreshes like a spring rain.

¹⁶How much better to get wisdom than gold,
and good judgment than silver!

¹⁷The path of the virtuous leads away from evil;
whoever follows that path is safe.

¹⁸Pride goes before destruction,
and haughtiness before a fall.

¹⁹Better to live humbly with the poor
than to share plunder with the proud.

²⁰Those who listen to instruction will prosper;
those who trust the Lord will be joyful.

²¹The wise are known for their understanding,
and pleasant words are persuasive.

²²Discretion is a life-giving fountain to those who possess it,
but discipline is wasted on fools.

- ²³From a wise mind comes wise speech;
the words of the wise are persuasive.
- ²⁴Kind words are like honey—
sweet to the soul and healthy for the body.
- ²⁵There is a path before each person that seems right,
but it ends in death.
- ²⁶It is good for workers to have an appetite;
an empty stomach drives them on.
- ²⁷Scoundrels create trouble;
their words are a destructive blaze.
- ²⁸A troublemaker plants seeds of strife;
gossip separates the best of friends.
- ²⁹Violent people mislead their companions,
leading them down a harmful path.
- ³⁰With narrowed eyes, people plot evil;
with a smirk, they plan their mischief.
- ³¹Gray hair is a crown of glory;
it is gained by living a godly life.

³²Better to be patient than powerful;
better to have self-control than to conquer a city.

³³We may throw the dice,
but the Lord determines how they fall.

17

ETTER a dry crust eaten in peace
than a house filled with feasting—and conflict.

²A wise servant will rule over the master's disgraceful son
and will share the inheritance of the master's children.

³Fire tests the purity of silver and gold,
but the Lord tests the heart.

⁴Wrongdoers eagerly listen to gossip;
liars pay close attention to slander.

⁵Those who mock the poor insult their Maker;
those who rejoice at the misfortune of others will be punished.

⁶Grandchildren are the crowning glory of the aged;
parents are the pride of their children.

⁷Eloquent words are not fitting for a fool;

even less are lies fitting for a ruler.

⁸A bribe is like a lucky charm;
whoever gives one will prosper!

⁹Love prospers when a fault is forgiven,
but dwelling on it separates close friends.

¹⁰A single rebuke does more for a person of understanding
than a hundred lashes on the back of a fool.

¹¹Evil people are eager for rebellion,
but they will be severely punished.

¹²It is safer to meet a bear robbed of her cubs
than to confront a fool caught in foolishness.

¹³If you repay good with evil,
evil will never leave your house.

¹⁴Starting a quarrel is like opening a floodgate,
so stop before a dispute breaks out.

¹⁵Acquitting the guilty and condemning the innocent—
both are detestable to the Lord.

- ¹⁶It is senseless to pay to educate a fool,
since he has no heart for learning.
- ¹⁷A friend is always loyal,
and a brother is born to help in time of need.
- ¹⁸It's poor judgment to guarantee another person's debt
or put up security for a friend.
- ¹⁹Anyone who loves to quarrel loves sin;
anyone who trusts in high walls invites disaster.
- ²⁰The crooked heart will not prosper;
the lying tongue tumbles into trouble.
- ²¹It is painful to be the parent of a fool;
there is no joy for the father of a rebel.
- ²²A cheerful heart is good medicine,
but a broken spirit saps a person's strength.
- ²³The wicked take secret bribes
to pervert the course of justice.
- ²⁴Sensible people keep their eyes glued on wisdom,
but a fool's eyes wander to the ends of the earth.

²⁵Foolish children bring grief to their father
and bitterness to the one who gave them birth.

²⁶It is wrong to punish the godly for being good
or to flog leaders for being honest.

²⁷A truly wise person uses few words;
a person with understanding is even-tempered.

²⁸Even fools are thought wise when they keep silent;
with their mouths shut, they seem intelligent.

18



UNFRIENDLY people care only about themselves;
they lash out at common sense.

²Fools have no interest in understanding;
they only want to air their own opinions.

³Doing wrong leads to disgrace,
and scandalous behavior brings contempt.

⁴Wise words are like deep waters;
wisdom flows from the wise like a bubbling brook.

⁵It is not right to acquit the guilty

or deny justice to the innocent.

⁶Fools' words get them into constant quarrels;
they are asking for a beating.

⁷The mouths of fools are their ruin;
they trap themselves with their lips.

⁸Rumors are dainty morsels
that sink deep into one's heart.

⁹A lazy person is as bad as
someone who destroys things.

¹⁰The name of the Lord is a strong fortress;
the godly run to him and are safe.

¹¹The rich think of their wealth as a strong defense;
they imagine it to be a high wall of safety.

¹²Haughtiness goes before destruction;
humility precedes honor.

¹³Spouting off before listening to the facts
is both shameful and foolish.

- ¹⁴The human spirit can endure a sick body,
but who can bear a crushed spirit?
- ¹⁵Intelligent people are always ready to learn.
Their ears are open for knowledge.
- ¹⁶Giving a gift can open doors;
it gives access to important people!
- ¹⁷The first to speak in court sounds right—
until the cross-examination begins.
- ¹⁸Flipping a coin can end arguments;
it settles disputes between powerful opponents.
- ¹⁹An offended friend is harder to win back than a fortified city.
Arguments separate friends like a gate locked with bars.
- ²⁰Wise words satisfy like a good meal;
the right words bring satisfaction.
- ²¹The tongue can bring death or life;
those who love to talk will reap the consequences.
- ²²The man who finds a wife finds a treasure,
and he receives favor from the Lord.

²³The poor plead for mercy;
the rich answer with insults.

²⁴There are “friends” who destroy each other,
but a real friend sticks closer than a brother.

19



BETTER to be poor and honest
than to be dishonest and a fool.

²Enthusiasm without knowledge is no good;
haste makes mistakes.

³People ruin their lives by their own foolishness
and then are angry at the Lord.

⁴Wealth makes many “friends”;
poverty drives them all away.

⁵A false witness will not go unpunished,
nor will a liar escape.

⁶Many seek favors from a ruler;
everyone is the friend of a person who gives gifts!

⁷The relatives of the poor despise them;

how much more will their friends avoid them!
Though the poor plead with them,
their friends are gone.

⁸To acquire wisdom is to love yourself;
people who cherish understanding will prosper.

⁹A false witness will not go unpunished,
and a liar will be destroyed.

¹⁰It isn't right for a fool to live in luxury
or for a slave to rule over princes!

¹¹Sensible people control their temper;
they earn respect by overlooking wrongs.

¹²The king's anger is like a lion's roar,
but his favor is like dew on the grass.

¹³A foolish child is a calamity to a father;
a quarrelsome wife is as annoying as constant dripping.

¹⁴Fathers can give their sons an inheritance of houses and wealth,
but only the Lord can give an understanding wife.

¹⁵Lazy people sleep soundly,
but idleness leaves them hungry.

- ¹⁶Keep the commandments and keep your life;
despising them leads to death.
- ¹⁷If you help the poor, you are lending to the Lord—
and he will repay you!
- ¹⁸Discipline your children while there is hope.
Otherwise you will ruin their lives.
- ¹⁹Hot-tempered people must pay the penalty.
If you rescue them once, you will have to do it again.
- ²⁰Get all the advice and instruction you can,
so you will be wise the rest of your life.
- ²¹You can make many plans,
but the Lord's purpose will prevail.
- ²²Loyalty makes a person attractive.
It is better to be poor than dishonest.
- ²³Fear of the Lord leads to life,
bringing security and protection from harm.
- ²⁴Lazy people take food in their hand
but don't even lift it to their mouth.

²⁵If you punish a mocker, the simpleminded will learn a lesson;
if you correct the wise, they will be all the wiser.

²⁶Children who mistreat their father or chase away their mother
are an embarrassment and a public disgrace.

²⁷If you stop listening to instruction, my child,
you will turn your back on knowledge.

²⁸A corrupt witness makes a mockery of justice;
the mouth of the wicked gulps down evil.

²⁹Punishment is made for mockers,
and the backs of fools are made to be beaten.

20



INE produces mockers; alcohol leads to brawls.
Those led astray by drink cannot be wise.

²The king's fury is like a lion's roar;
to rouse his anger is to risk your life.

³Avoiding a fight is a mark of honor;
only fools insist on quarreling.

⁴Those too lazy to plow in the right season

will have no food at the harvest.

⁵Though good advice lies deep within the heart,
a person with understanding will draw it out.

⁶Many will say they are loyal friends,
but who can find one who is truly reliable?

⁷The godly walk with integrity;
blessed are their children who follow them.

⁸When a king sits in judgment, he weighs all the evidence,
distinguishing the bad from the good.

⁹Who can say, “I have cleansed my heart;
I am pure and free from sin”?

¹⁰False weights and unequal measures—
the Lord detests double standards of every kind.

¹¹Even children are known by the way they act,
whether their conduct is pure, and whether it is right.

¹²Ears to hear and eyes to see—
both are gifts from the Lord.

- ¹³If you love sleep, you will end in poverty.
Keep your eyes open, and there will be plenty to eat!
- ¹⁴The buyer haggles over the price, saying, "It's worthless,"
then brags about getting a bargain!
- ¹⁵Wise words are more valuable
than much gold and many rubies.
- ¹⁶Get security from someone who guarantees a stranger's debt.
Get a deposit if he does it for foreigners.
- ¹⁷Stolen bread tastes sweet,
but it turns to gravel in the mouth.
- ¹⁸Plans succeed through good counsel;
don't go to war without wise advice.
- ¹⁹A gossip goes around telling secrets,
so don't hang around with chatterers.
- ²⁰If you insult your father or mother,
your light will be snuffed out in total darkness.
- ²¹An inheritance obtained too early in life
is not a blessing in the end.

- ²²Don't say, "I will get even for this wrong."
Wait for the Lord to handle the matter.
- ²³The Lord detests double standards;
he is not pleased by dishonest scales.
- ²⁴The Lord directs our steps,
so why try to understand everything along the way?
- ²⁵Don't trap yourself by making a rash promise to God
and only later counting the cost.
- ²⁶A wise king scatters the wicked like wheat,
then runs his threshing wheel over them.
- ²⁷The Lord's light penetrates the human spirit,
exposing every hidden motive.
- ²⁸Unfailing love and faithfulness protect the king;
his throne is made secure through love.
- ²⁹The glory of the young is their strength;
the gray hair of experience is the splendor of the old.
- ³⁰Physical punishment cleanses away evil;
such discipline purifies the heart.

21



HE king's heart is like a stream of water directed by the Lord;
he guides it wherever he pleases.

²People may be right in their own eyes,
but the Lord examines their heart.

³The Lord is more pleased when we do what is right and just
than when we offer him sacrifices.

⁴Haughty eyes, a proud heart,
and evil actions are all sin.

⁵Good planning and hard work lead to prosperity,
but hasty shortcuts lead to poverty.

⁶Wealth created by a lying tongue
is a vanishing mist and a deadly trap.

⁷The violence of the wicked sweeps them away,
because they refuse to do what is just.

⁸The guilty walk a crooked path;
the innocent travel a straight road.

⁹It's better to live alone in the corner of an attic
than with a quarrelsome wife in a lovely home.

¹⁰Evil people desire evil;
their neighbors get no mercy from them.

¹¹If you punish a mocker, the simpleminded become wise;
if you instruct the wise, they will be all the wiser.

¹²The Righteous One knows what is going on in the homes of
the wicked;
he will bring disaster on them.

¹³Those who shut their ears to the cries of the poor
will be ignored in their own time of need.

¹⁴A secret gift calms anger;
a bribe under the table pacifies fury.

¹⁵Justice is a joy to the godly,
but it terrifies evildoers.

¹⁶The person who strays from common sense
will end up in the company of the dead.

¹⁷Those who love pleasure become poor;
those who love wine and luxury will never be rich.

- ¹⁸The wicked are punished in place of the godly,
and traitors in place of the honest.
- ¹⁹It's better to live alone in the desert
than with a quarrelsome, complaining wife.
- ²⁰The wise have wealth and luxury,
but fools spend whatever they get.
- ²¹Whoever pursues righteousness and unfailing love
will find life, righteousness, and honor.
- ²²The wise conquer the city of the strong
and level the fortress in which they trust.
- ²³Watch your tongue and keep your mouth shut,
and you will stay out of trouble.
- ²⁴Mockers are proud and haughty;
they act with boundless arrogance.
- ²⁵Despite their desires, the lazy will come to ruin,
for their hands refuse to work.
- ²⁶Some people are always greedy for more,
but the godly love to give!

²⁷The sacrifice of an evil person is detestable,
especially when it is offered with wrong motives.

²⁸A false witness will be cut off,
but a credible witness will be allowed to speak.

²⁹The wicked bluff their way through,
but the virtuous think before they act.

³⁰No human wisdom or understanding or plan
can stand against the Lord.

³¹The horse is prepared for the day of battle,
but the victory belongs to the Lord.

22



CHOOSE a good reputation over great riches;
being held in high esteem is better than silver or gold.

²The rich and poor have this in common:
The Lord made them both.

³A prudent person foresees danger and takes precautions.
The simpleton goes blindly on and suffers the consequences.

⁴True humility and fear of the Lord

lead to riches, honor, and long life.

⁵Corrupt people walk a thorny, treacherous road;
whoever values life will avoid it.

⁶Direct your children onto the right path,
and when they are older, they will not leave it.

⁷Just as the rich rule the poor,
so the borrower is servant to the lender.

⁸Those who plant injustice will harvest disaster,
and their reign of terror will come to an end.

⁹Blessed are those who are generous,
because they feed the poor.

¹⁰Throw out the mocker, and fighting goes, too.
Quarrels and insults will disappear.

¹¹Whoever loves a pure heart and gracious speech
will have the king as a friend.

¹²The Lord preserves those with knowledge,
but he ruins the plans of the treacherous.

- ¹³The lazy person claims, “There’s a lion out there!
If I go outside, I might be killed!”
- ¹⁴The mouth of an immoral woman is a dangerous trap;
those who make the Lord angry will fall into it.
- ¹⁵A youngster’s heart is filled with foolishness,
but physical discipline will drive it far away.
- ¹⁶A person who gets ahead by oppressing the poor
or by showering gifts on the rich will end in poverty.

Sayings of the Wise

- ¹⁷Listen to the words of the wise;
apply your heart to my instruction.
- ¹⁸For it is good to keep these sayings in your heart
and always ready on your lips.
- ¹⁹I am teaching you today—yes, you—
so you will trust in the Lord.
- ²⁰I have written thirty sayings for you,
filled with advice and knowledge.
- ²¹In this way, you may know the truth
and take an accurate report to those who sent you.
- ²²Don’t rob the poor just because you can,
or exploit the needy in court.
- ²³For the Lord is their defender.

He will ruin anyone who ruins them.

²⁴Don't befriend angry people
or associate with hot-tempered people,
²⁵or you will learn to be like them
and endanger your soul.

²⁶Don't agree to guarantee another person's debt
or put up security for someone else.
²⁷If you can't pay it,
even your bed will be snatched from under you.

²⁸Don't cheat your neighbor by moving the ancient boundary
markers
set up by previous generations.

²⁹Do you see any truly competent workers?
They will serve kings
rather than working for ordinary people.

23



WHILE dining with a ruler,
pay attention to what is put before you.
²If you are a big eater,
put a knife to your throat;
³don't desire all the delicacies,
for he might be trying to trick you.

⁴Don't wear yourself out trying to get rich.

Be wise enough to know when to quit.

⁵In the blink of an eye wealth disappears,

for it will sprout wings

and fly away like an eagle.

⁶Don't eat with people who are stingy;

don't desire their delicacies.

⁷They are always thinking about how much it costs.

"Eat and drink," they say, but they don't mean it.

⁸You will throw up what little you've eaten,

and your compliments will be wasted.

⁹Don't waste your breath on fools,

for they will despise the wisest advice.

¹⁰Don't cheat your neighbor by moving the ancient boundary markers;

don't take the land of defenseless orphans.

¹¹For their Redeemer is strong;

he himself will bring their charges against you.

¹²Commit yourself to instruction;

listen carefully to words of knowledge.

¹³Don't fail to discipline your children.

The rod of punishment won't kill them.

¹⁴Physical discipline

may well save them from death.

¹⁵My child, if your heart is wise,
my own heart will rejoice!

¹⁶Everything in me will celebrate
when you speak what is right.

¹⁷Don't envy sinners,
but always continue to fear the Lord.

¹⁸You will be rewarded for this;
your hope will not be disappointed.

¹⁹My child, listen and be wise:
Keep your heart on the right course.

²⁰Do not carouse with drunkards
or feast with gluttons,

²¹for they are on their way to poverty,
and too much sleep clothes them in rags.

²²Listen to your father, who gave you life,
and don't despise your mother when she is old.

²³Get the truth and never sell it;
also get wisdom, discipline, and good judgment.

²⁴The father of godly children has cause for joy.
What a pleasure to have children who are wise.

²⁵So give your father and mother joy!
May she who gave you birth be happy.

²⁶O my son, give me your heart.
May your eyes take delight in following my ways.

²⁷A prostitute is a dangerous trap;

a promiscuous woman is as dangerous as falling into a narrow well.

²⁸She hides and waits like a robber,
eager to make more men unfaithful.

²⁹Who has anguish? Who has sorrow?
Who is always fighting? Who is always complaining?
Who has unnecessary bruises? Who has bloodshot eyes?

³⁰It is the one who spends long hours in the taverns,
trying out new drinks.

³¹Don't gaze at the wine, seeing how red it is,
how it sparkles in the cup, how smoothly it goes down.

³²For in the end it bites like a poisonous snake;
it stings like a viper.

³³You will see hallucinations,
and you will say crazy things.

³⁴You will stagger like a sailor tossed at sea,
clinging to a swaying mast.

³⁵And you will say, "They hit me, but I didn't feel it.
I didn't even know it when they beat me up.

When will I wake up
so I can look for another drink?"

24



ON'T envy evil people
or desire their company.

²For their hearts plot violence,
and their words always stir up trouble.

³A house is built by wisdom

and becomes strong through good sense.

⁴Through knowledge its rooms are filled
with all sorts of precious riches and valuables.

⁵The wise are mightier than the strong,
and those with knowledge grow stronger and stronger.

⁶So don't go to war without wise guidance;
victory depends on having many advisers.

⁷Wisdom is too lofty for fools.
Among leaders at the city gate, they have nothing to say.

⁸A person who plans evil
will get a reputation as a troublemaker.

⁹The schemes of a fool are sinful;
everyone detests a mocker.

¹⁰If you fail under pressure,
your strength is too small.

¹¹Rescue those who are unjustly sentenced to die;
save them as they stagger to their death.

¹²Don't excuse yourself by saying, "Look, we didn't know."
For God understands all hearts, and he sees you.
He who guards your soul knows you knew.
He will repay all people as their actions deserve.

¹³My child, eat honey, for it is good,

and the honeycomb is sweet to the taste.

¹⁴In the same way, wisdom is sweet to your soul.

If you find it, you will have a bright future,
and your hopes will not be cut short.

¹⁵Don't wait in ambush at the home of the godly,
and don't raid the house where the godly live.

¹⁶The godly may trip seven times, but they will get up again.
But one disaster is enough to overthrow the wicked.

¹⁷Don't rejoice when your enemies fall;
don't be happy when they stumble.

¹⁸For the Lord will be displeased with you
and will turn his anger away from them.

¹⁹Don't fret because of evildoers;
don't envy the wicked.

²⁰For evil people have no future;
the light of the wicked will be snuffed out.

²¹My child, fear the Lord and the king.

Don't associate with rebels,

²²for disaster will hit them suddenly.

Who knows what punishment will come
from the Lord and the king?

More Sayings of the Wise

²³Here are some further sayings of the wise:

It is wrong to show favoritism when passing judgment.

²⁴A judge who says to the wicked, “You are innocent,”
will be cursed by many people and denounced by the nations.

²⁵But it will go well for those who convict the guilty;
rich blessings will be showered on them.

²⁶An honest answer
is like a kiss of friendship.

²⁷Do your planning and prepare your fields
before building your house.

²⁸Don’t testify against your neighbors without cause;
don’t lie about them.

²⁹And don’t say, “Now I can pay them back for what they’ve done
to me!
I’ll get even with them!”

³⁰I walked by the field of a lazy person,
the vineyard of one with no common sense.

³¹I saw that it was overgrown with nettles.
It was covered with weeds,
and its walls were broken down.

³²Then, as I looked and thought about it,
I learned this lesson:

³³A little extra sleep, a little more slumber,
a little folding of the hands to rest—

³⁴then poverty will pounce on you like a bandit;
scarcity will attack you like an armed robber.

25

More Proverbs of Solomon



THESE are more proverbs of Solomon, collected by the advisers of King Hezekiah of Judah.

²It is God's privilege to conceal things
and the king's privilege to discover them.

³No one can comprehend the height of heaven, the depth of the
earth,
or all that goes on in the king's mind!

⁴Remove the impurities from silver,
and the sterling will be ready for the silversmith.

⁵Remove the wicked from the king's court,
and his reign will be made secure by justice.

⁶Don't demand an audience with the king
or push for a place among the great.

⁷It's better to wait for an invitation to the head table
than to be sent away in public disgrace.

Just because you've seen something,
⁸don't be in a hurry to go to court.
For what will you do in the end
if your neighbor deals you a shameful defeat?

- ⁹When arguing with your neighbor,
don't betray another person's secret.
- ¹⁰Others may accuse you of gossip,
and you will never regain your good reputation.
- ¹¹Timely advice is lovely,
like golden apples in a silver basket.
- ¹²To one who listens, valid criticism
is like a gold earring or other gold jewelry.
- ¹³Trustworthy messengers refresh like snow in summer.
They revive the spirit of their employer.
- ¹⁴A person who promises a gift but doesn't give it
is like clouds and wind that bring no rain.
- ¹⁵Patience can persuade a prince,
and soft speech can break bones.
- ¹⁶Do you like honey?
Don't eat too much, or it will make you sick!
- ¹⁷Don't visit your neighbors too often,
or you will wear out your welcome.
- ¹⁸Telling lies about others

is as harmful as hitting them with an ax,
wounding them with a sword,
or shooting them with a sharp arrow.

¹⁹Putting confidence in an unreliable person in times of trouble
is like chewing with a broken tooth or walking on a lame foot.

²⁰Singing cheerful songs to a person with a heavy heart
is like taking someone's coat in cold weather
or pouring vinegar in a wound.

²¹If your enemies are hungry, give them food to eat.
If they are thirsty, give them water to drink.

²²You will heap burning coals of shame on their heads,
and the Lord will reward you.

²³As surely as a north wind brings rain,
so a gossiping tongue causes anger!

²⁴It's better to live alone in the corner of an attic
than with a quarrelsome wife in a lovely home.

²⁵Good news from far away
is like cold water to the thirsty.

²⁶If the godly give in to the wicked,
it's like polluting a fountain or muddying a spring.

²⁷It's not good to eat too much honey,
and it's not good to seek honors for yourself.

²⁸A person without self-control
is like a city with broken-down walls.

26



HONOR is no more associated with fools
than snow with summer or rain with harvest.

²Like a fluttering sparrow or a darting swallow,
an undeserved curse will not land on its intended victim.

³Guide a horse with a whip, a donkey with a bridle,
and a fool with a rod to his back!

⁴Don't answer the foolish arguments of fools,
or you will become as foolish as they are.

⁵Be sure to answer the foolish arguments of fools,
or they will become wise in their own estimation.

⁶Trusting a fool to convey a message
is like cutting off one's feet or drinking poison!

⁷A proverb in the mouth of a fool

is as useless as a paralyzed leg.

⁸Honoring a fool

is as foolish as tying a stone to a slingshot.

⁹A proverb in the mouth of a fool

is like a thorny branch brandished by a drunk.

¹⁰An employer who hires a fool or a bystander

is like an archer who shoots at random.

¹¹As a dog returns to its vomit,

so a fool repeats his foolishness.

¹²There is more hope for fools

than for people who think they are wise.

¹³The lazy person claims, "There's a lion on the road!

Yes, I'm sure there's a lion out there!"

¹⁴As a door swings back and forth on its hinges,

so the lazy person turns over in bed.

¹⁵Lazy people take food in their hand

but don't even lift it to their mouth.

¹⁶Lazy people consider themselves smarter
than seven wise counselors.

¹⁷Interfering in someone else's argument
is as foolish as yanking a dog's ears.

¹⁸Just as damaging
as a madman shooting a deadly weapon
¹⁹is someone who lies to a friend
and then says, "I was only joking."

²⁰Fire goes out without wood,
and quarrels disappear when gossip stops.

²¹A quarrelsome person starts fights
as easily as hot embers light charcoal or fire lights wood.

²²Rumors are dainty morsels
that sink deep into one's heart.

²³Smooth words may hide a wicked heart,
just as a pretty glaze covers a clay pot.

²⁴People may cover their hatred with pleasant words,
but they're deceiving you.

²⁵They pretend to be kind, but don't believe them.
Their hearts are full of many evils.

²⁶While their hatred may be concealed by trickery,
their wrongdoing will be exposed in public.

²⁷If you set a trap for others,
you will get caught in it yourself.
If you roll a boulder down on others,
it will crush you instead.

²⁸A lying tongue hates its victims,
and flattering words cause ruin.

27



ON'T brag about tomorrow,
since you don't know what the day will bring.

²Let someone else praise you, not your own mouth—
a stranger, not your own lips.

³A stone is heavy and sand is weighty,
but the resentment caused by a fool is even heavier.

⁴Anger is cruel, and wrath is like a flood,
but jealousy is even more dangerous.

⁵An open rebuke
is better than hidden love!

⁶Wounds from a sincere friend
are better than many kisses from an enemy.

⁷A person who is full refuses honey,
but even bitter food tastes sweet to the hungry.

⁸A person who strays from home
is like a bird that strays from its nest.

⁹The heartfelt counsel of a friend
is as sweet as perfume and incense.

¹⁰Never abandon a friend—
either yours or your father's.

When disaster strikes, you won't have to ask your brother for
assistance.

It's better to go to a neighbor than to a brother who lives far
away.

¹¹Be wise, my child, and make my heart glad.
Then I will be able to answer my critics.

¹²A prudent person foresees danger and takes precautions.
The simpleton goes blindly on and suffers the consequences.

¹³Get security from someone who guarantees a stranger's debt.
Get a deposit if he does it for foreigners.

¹⁴A loud and cheerful greeting early in the morning
will be taken as a curse!

¹⁵A quarrelsome wife is as annoying
as constant dripping on a rainy day.

¹⁶Stopping her complaints is like trying to stop the wind
or trying to hold something with greased hands.

¹⁷As iron sharpens iron,
so a friend sharpens a friend.

¹⁸As workers who tend a fig tree are allowed to eat the fruit,
so workers who protect their employer's interests will be re-
warded.

¹⁹As a face is reflected in water,
so the heart reflects the real person.

²⁰Just as Death and Destruction are never satisfied,
so human desire is never satisfied.

²¹Fire tests the purity of silver and gold,
but a person is tested by being praised.

²²You cannot separate fools from their foolishness,
even though you grind them like grain with mortar and pestle.

- ²³ Know the state of your flocks,
and put your heart into caring for your herds,
²⁴ for riches don't last forever,
and the crown might not be passed to the next generation.
²⁵ After the hay is harvested and the new crop appears
and the mountain grasses are gathered in,
²⁶ your sheep will provide wool for clothing,
and your goats will provide the price of a field.
²⁷ And you will have enough goats' milk for yourself,
your family, and your servant girls.

28



HE wicked run away when no one is chasing them,
but the godly are as bold as lions.

- ² When there is moral rot within a nation, its government topples
easily.
But wise and knowledgeable leaders bring stability.

- ³ A poor person who oppresses the poor
is like a pounding rain that destroys the crops.

- ⁴ To reject the law is to praise the wicked;
to obey the law is to fight them.

- ⁵ Evil people don't understand justice,
but those who follow the Lord understand completely.

⁶Better to be poor and honest
than to be dishonest and rich.

⁷Young people who obey the law are wise;
those with wild friends bring shame to their parents.

⁸Income from charging high interest rates
will end up in the pocket of someone who is kind to the poor.

⁹God detests the prayers
of a person who ignores the law.

¹⁰Those who lead good people along an evil path
will fall into their own trap,
but the honest will inherit good things.

¹¹Rich people may think they are wise,
but a poor person with discernment can see right through
them.

¹²When the godly succeed, everyone is glad.
When the wicked take charge, people go into hiding.

¹³People who conceal their sins will not prosper,
but if they confess and turn from them, they will receive mercy.

¹⁴Blessed are those who fear to do wrong,

but the stubborn are headed for serious trouble.

¹⁵ A wicked ruler is as dangerous to the poor
as a roaring lion or an attacking bear.

¹⁶ A ruler with no understanding will oppress his people,
but one who hates corruption will have a long life.

¹⁷ A murderer's tormented conscience will drive him into the
grave.
Don't protect him!

¹⁸ The blameless will be rescued from harm,
but the crooked will be suddenly destroyed.

¹⁹ A hard worker has plenty of food,
but a person who chases fantasies ends up in poverty.

²⁰ The trustworthy person will get a rich reward,
but a person who wants quick riches will get into trouble.

²¹ Showing partiality is never good,
yet some will do wrong for a mere piece of bread.

²² Greedy people try to get rich quick
but don't realize they're headed for poverty.

²³In the end, people appreciate honest criticism
far more than flattery.

²⁴Anyone who steals from his father and mother
and says, “What’s wrong with that?”
is no better than a murderer.

²⁵Greed causes fighting;
trusting the Lord leads to prosperity.

²⁶Those who trust their own insight are foolish,
but anyone who walks in wisdom is safe.

²⁷Whoever gives to the poor will lack nothing,
but those who close their eyes to poverty will be cursed.

²⁸When the wicked take charge, people go into hiding.
When the wicked meet disaster, the godly flourish.

29



HOEVER stubbornly refuses to accept criticism
will suddenly be destroyed beyond recovery.

²When the godly are in authority, the people rejoice.
But when the wicked are in power, they groan.

³The man who loves wisdom brings joy to his father,
but if he hangs around with prostitutes, his wealth is wasted.

⁴A just king gives stability to his nation,
but one who demands bribes destroys it.

⁵To flatter friends
is to lay a trap for their feet.

⁶Evil people are trapped by sin,
but the righteous escape, shouting for joy.

⁷The godly care about the rights of the poor;
the wicked don't care at all.

⁸Mockers can get a whole town agitated,
but the wise will calm anger.

⁹If a wise person takes a fool to court,
there will be ranting and ridicule but no satisfaction.

¹⁰The bloodthirsty hate blameless people,
but the upright seek to help them.

¹¹Fools vent their anger,
but the wise quietly hold it back.

¹²If a ruler pays attention to liars,
all his advisers will be wicked.

¹³The poor and the oppressor have this in common—
the Lord gives sight to the eyes of both.

¹⁴If a king judges the poor fairly,
his throne will last forever.

¹⁵To discipline a child produces wisdom,
but a mother is disgraced by an undisciplined child.

¹⁶When the wicked are in authority, sin flourishes,
but the godly will live to see their downfall.

¹⁷Discipline your children, and they will give you peace of mind
and will make your heart glad.

¹⁸When people do not accept divine guidance, they run wild.
But whoever obeys the law is joyful.

¹⁹Words alone will not discipline a servant;
the words may be understood, but they are not heeded.

²⁰There is more hope for a fool
than for someone who speaks without thinking.

²¹A servant pampered from childhood
will become a rebel.

²²An angry person starts fights;
a hot-tempered person commits all kinds of sin.

²³Pride ends in humiliation,
while humility brings honor.

²⁴If you assist a thief, you only hurt yourself.
You are sworn to tell the truth, but you dare not testify.

²⁵Fearing people is a dangerous trap,
but trusting the Lord means safety.

²⁶Many seek the ruler's favor,
but justice comes from the Lord.

²⁷The righteous despise the unjust;
the wicked despise the godly.

30

The Sayings of Agur



HE sayings of Agur son of Jakeh contain this message.

- I am weary, O God;
I am weary and worn out, O God.
- ²I am too stupid to be human,
and I lack common sense.
- ³I have not mastered human wisdom,
nor do I know the Holy One.
- ⁴Who but God goes up to heaven and comes back down?
Who holds the wind in his fists?
Who wraps up the oceans in his cloak?
Who has created the whole wide world?
What is his name—and his son's name?
Tell me if you know!
- ⁵Every word of God proves true.
He is a shield to all who come to him for protection.
- ⁶Do not add to his words,
or he may rebuke you and expose you as a liar.
- ⁷O God, I beg two favors from you;
let me have them before I die.
- ⁸First, help me never to tell a lie.
Second, give me neither poverty nor riches!
Give me just enough to satisfy my needs.
- ⁹For if I grow rich, I may deny you and say, "Who is the Lord?"
And if I am too poor, I may steal and thus insult God's holy
name.
- ¹⁰Never slander a worker to the employer,
or the person will curse you, and you will pay for it.

¹¹Some people curse their father
and do not thank their mother.

¹²They are pure in their own eyes,
but they are filthy and unwashed.

¹³They look proudly around,
casting disdainful glances.

¹⁴They have teeth like swords
and fangs like knives.

They devour the poor from the earth
and the needy from among humanity.

¹⁵The leech has two suckers
that cry out, “More, more!”

There are three things that are never satisfied—
no, four that never say, “Enough!”:

¹⁶the grave,
the barren womb,
the thirsty desert,
the blazing fire.

¹⁷The eye that mocks a father
and despises a mother’s instructions
will be plucked out by ravens of the valley
and eaten by vultures.

¹⁸There are three things that amaze me—
no, four things that I don’t understand:

¹⁹how an eagle glides through the sky,
how a snake slithers on a rock,

how a ship navigates the ocean,
how a man loves a woman.

²⁰ An adulterous woman consumes a man,
then wipes her mouth and says, “What’s wrong with that?”

²¹ There are three things that make the earth tremble—
no, four it cannot endure:

²² a slave who becomes a king,
an overbearing fool who prospers,
²³ a bitter woman who finally gets a husband,
a servant girl who supplants her mistress.

²⁴ There are four things on earth that are small but unusually wise:

²⁵ Ants—they aren’t strong,
but they store up food all summer.

²⁶ Hyraxes—they aren’t powerful,
but they make their homes among the rocks.

²⁷ Locusts—they have no king,
but they march in formation.

²⁸ Lizards—they are easy to catch,
but they are found even in kings’ palaces.

²⁹ There are three things that walk with stately stride—
no, four that strut about:

³⁰ the lion, king of animals, who won’t turn aside for anything,
³¹ the strutting rooster,
the male goat,
a king as he leads his army.

³²If you have been a fool by being proud or plotting evil,
cover your mouth in shame.

³³As the beating of cream yields butter
and striking the nose causes bleeding,
so stirring up anger causes quarrels.

31

The Sayings of King Lemuel



HE sayings of King Lemuel contain this message, which his
mother taught him.

²O my son, O son of my womb,
O son of my vows,

³do not waste your strength on women,
on those who ruin kings.

⁴It is not for kings, O Lemuel, to guzzle wine.
Rulers should not crave alcohol.

⁵For if they drink, they may forget the law
and not give justice to the oppressed.

⁶Alcohol is for the dying,
and wine for those in bitter distress.

⁷Let them drink to forget their poverty
and remember their troubles no more.

⁸Speak up for those who cannot speak for themselves;
ensure justice for those being crushed.

⁹Yes, speak up for the poor and helpless,
and see that they get justice.

A Wife of Noble Character

¹⁰Who can find a virtuous and capable wife?
She is more precious than rubies.

¹¹Her husband can trust her,
and she will greatly enrich his life.

¹²She brings him good, not harm,
all the days of her life.

¹³She finds wool and flax
and busily spins it.

¹⁴She is like a merchant's ship,
bringing her food from afar.

¹⁵She gets up before dawn to prepare breakfast for her household
and plan the day's work for her servant girls.

¹⁶She goes to inspect a field and buys it;
with her earnings she plants a vineyard.

¹⁷She is energetic and strong,
a hard worker.

¹⁸She makes sure her dealings are profitable;
her lamp burns late into the night.

¹⁹Her hands are busy spinning thread,
her fingers twisting fiber.

²⁰She extends a helping hand to the poor

and opens her arms to the needy.

²¹She has no fear of winter for her household,
for everyone has warm clothes.

²²She makes her own bedspreads.

She dresses in fine linen and purple gowns.

²³Her husband is well known at the city gates,
where he sits with the other civic leaders.

²⁴She makes belted linen garments
and sashes to sell to the merchants.

²⁵She is clothed with strength and dignity,
and she laughs without fear of the future.

²⁶When she speaks, her words are wise,
and she gives instructions with kindness.

²⁷She carefully watches everything in her household
and suffers nothing from laziness.

²⁸Her children stand and bless her.
Her husband praises her:

²⁹“There are many virtuous and capable women in the world,
but you surpass them all!”

³⁰Charm is deceptive, and beauty does not last;
but a woman who fears the Lord will be greatly praised.

³¹Reward her for all she has done.
Let her deeds publicly declare her praise.

Ecclesiastes

1



THESE are the words of the Teacher, King David's son, who ruled in Jerusalem.

Everything Is Meaningless

²“Everything is meaningless,” says the Teacher, “completely meaningless!”

³What do people get for all their hard work under the sun? ⁴Generations come and generations go, but the earth never changes. ⁵The sun rises and the sun sets, then hurries around to rise again. ⁶The wind blows south, and then turns north. Around and around it goes, blowing in circles. ⁷Rivers run into the sea, but the sea is never full. Then the water returns again to the rivers and flows out again to the sea. ⁸Everything is wearisome beyond description. No matter how much we see, we are never satisfied. No matter how much we hear, we are not content.

⁹History merely repeats itself. It has all been done before. Nothing under the sun is truly new. ¹⁰Sometimes people say, “Here is something new!” But actually it is old; nothing is ever truly new. ¹¹We don't remember what happened in the past, and in future generations, no one will remember what we are doing now.

The Teacher Speaks: The Futility of Wisdom

¹²I, the Teacher, was king of Israel, and I lived in Jerusalem. ¹³I devoted myself to search for understanding and to explore by wisdom everything being done under heaven. I soon discovered that God has dealt a tragic existence to the human race. ¹⁴I observed everything going on under the sun, and really, it is all meaningless—like chasing the wind.

¹⁵What is wrong cannot be made right.
What is missing cannot be recovered.

¹⁶I said to myself, “Look, I am wiser than any of the kings who ruled in Jerusalem before me. I have greater wisdom and knowledge than any of them.” ¹⁷So I set out to learn everything from wisdom to madness and folly. But I learned firsthand that pursuing all this is like chasing the wind.

¹⁸The greater my wisdom, the greater my grief.
To increase knowledge only increases sorrow.

2

The Futility of Pleasure

 said to myself, “Come on, let’s try pleasure. Let’s look for the ‘good things’ in life.” But I found that this, too, was meaningless. ²So I said, “Laughter is silly. What good does it do to seek pleasure?” ³After much thought, I decided to cheer myself with wine. And while still seeking wisdom, I clutched at foolishness. In this way, I tried to experience the only happiness most people find during their brief life in this world.

⁴I also tried to find meaning by building huge homes for myself and by planting beautiful vineyards. ⁵I made gardens and parks, filling them with all kinds of fruit trees. ⁶I built reservoirs to collect the water to irrigate my many flourishing groves. ⁷I bought slaves, both men and women, and others were born into my household. I also owned large herds and flocks, more than any of the kings who had lived in Jerusalem before me. ⁸I collected great sums of silver and gold, the treasure of many kings and provinces. I hired wonderful singers, both men and women, and had many beautiful concubines. I had everything a man could desire!

⁹So I became greater than all who had lived in Jerusalem before me, and my wisdom never failed me. ¹⁰Anything I wanted, I would take. I denied myself no pleasure. I even found great pleasure in hard work, a reward for all my labors. ¹¹But as I looked at everything I had worked so hard to accomplish, it was all so meaningless—like chasing the wind. There was nothing really worthwhile anywhere.

The Wise and the Foolish

¹²So I decided to compare wisdom with foolishness and madness (for who can do this better than I, the king?). ¹³I thought, “Wisdom is better than foolishness, just as light is better than darkness. ¹⁴For the wise can see where they are going, but fools walk in the dark.” Yet I saw that the wise and the foolish share the same fate. ¹⁵Both will die. So I said to myself, “Since I will end up the same as the fool, what’s the value of all my wisdom? This is all so meaningless!” ¹⁶For the wise and the foolish both die. The wise will not be remembered any longer than the fool. In the days to come, both will be forgotten.

¹⁷So I came to hate life because everything done here under the sun is so troubling. Everything is meaningless—like chasing the wind.

The Futility of Work

¹⁸I came to hate all my hard work here on earth, for I must leave to others everything I have earned. ¹⁹And who can tell whether my successors will be wise or foolish? Yet they will control everything I have gained by my skill and hard work under the sun. How meaningless! ²⁰So I gave up in despair, questioning the value of all my hard work in this world.

²¹Some people work wisely with knowledge and skill, then must leave the fruit of their efforts to someone who hasn't worked for it. This, too, is meaningless, a great tragedy. ²²So what do people get in this life for all their hard work and anxiety? ²³Their days of labor are filled with pain and grief; even at night their minds cannot rest. It is all meaningless.

²⁴So I decided there is nothing better than to enjoy food and drink and to find satisfaction in work. Then I realized that these pleasures are from the hand of God. ²⁵For who can eat or enjoy anything apart from him? ²⁶God gives wisdom, knowledge, and joy to those who please him. But if a sinner becomes wealthy, God takes the wealth away and gives it to those who please him. This, too, is meaningless—like chasing the wind.

3

A Time for Everything



OR everything there is a season,
a time for every activity under heaven.

²A time to be born and a time to die.

A time to plant and a time to harvest.

³A time to kill and a time to heal.

A time to tear down and a time to build up.

⁴A time to cry and a time to laugh.

A time to grieve and a time to dance.

⁵A time to scatter stones and a time to gather stones.

A time to embrace and a time to turn away.

⁶A time to search and a time to quit searching.

A time to keep and a time to throw away.

⁷A time to tear and a time to mend.

A time to be quiet and a time to speak.

⁸A time to love and a time to hate.

A time for war and a time for peace.

⁹What do people really get for all their hard work? ¹⁰I have seen the burden God has placed on us all. ¹¹Yet God has made everything beautiful for its own time. He has planted eternity in the human heart, but even so, people cannot see the whole scope of God's work from beginning to end. ¹²So I concluded there is nothing better than to be happy and enjoy ourselves as long as we can. ¹³And people should eat and drink and enjoy the fruits of their labor, for these are gifts from God.

¹⁴And I know that whatever God does is final. Nothing can be added to it or taken from it. God's purpose is that people should fear him. ¹⁵What is happening now has happened before, and what will happen in the future has happened before, because God makes the same things happen over and over again.

The Injustices of Life

¹⁶I also noticed that under the sun there is evil in the courtroom. Yes, even the courts of law are corrupt! ¹⁷I said to myself, "In due season God will judge everyone, both good and bad, for all their deeds."

¹⁸I also thought about the human condition—how God proves to people that they are like animals. ¹⁹For people and animals share the same fate—both breathe and both must die. So people have no real advantage over the animals. How meaningless! ²⁰Both go to the same place—they came from dust and they return to dust. ²¹For who can prove that the human spirit goes up and the spirit of animals goes

down into the earth? ²²So I saw that there is nothing better for people than to be happy in their work. That is our lot in life. And no one can bring us back to see what happens after we die.

4

A ¹GAIN, I observed all the oppression that takes place under the sun. I saw the tears of the oppressed, with no one to comfort them. The oppressors have great power, and their victims are helpless. ²So I concluded that the dead are better off than the living. ³But most fortunate of all are those who are not yet born. For they have not seen all the evil that is done under the sun.

⁴Then I observed that most people are motivated to success because they envy their neighbors. But this, too, is meaningless—like chasing the wind.

⁵“Fools fold their idle hands,
leading them to ruin.”

⁶And yet,

“Better to have one handful with quietness
than two handfuls with hard work
and chasing the wind.”

The Advantages of Companionship

⁷I observed yet another example of something meaningless under the sun. ⁸This is the case of a man who is all alone, without a child or a brother, yet who works hard to gain as much wealth as he can. But then he asks himself, “Who am I working for? Why am I giving up so much pleasure now?” It is all so meaningless and depressing.

⁹Two people are better off than one, for they can help each other succeed. ¹⁰If one person falls, the other can reach out and help. But someone who falls alone is in real trouble. ¹¹Likewise, two people lying close together can keep each other warm. But how can one be warm alone? ¹²A person standing alone can be attacked and defeated, but two can stand back-to-back and conquer. Three are even better, for a triple-braided cord is not easily broken.

The Futility of Political Power

¹³It is better to be a poor but wise youth than an old and foolish king who refuses all advice. ¹⁴Such a youth could rise from poverty and succeed. He might even become king, though he has been in prison. ¹⁵But then everyone rushes to the side of yet another youth who replaces him. ¹⁶Endless crowds stand around him, but then another generation grows up and rejects him, too. So it is all meaningless—like chasing the wind.

5

Approaching God with Care

As you enter the house of God, keep your ears open and your mouth shut. It is evil to make mindless offerings to God. ²Don't make rash promises, and don't be hasty in bringing matters before God. After all, God is in heaven, and you are here on earth. So let your words be few.

³Too much activity gives you restless dreams; too many words make you a fool.

⁴When you make a promise to God, don't delay in following through, for God takes no pleasure in fools. Keep all the promises you make to him. ⁵It is better to say nothing than to make a promise and not keep it. ⁶Don't let your mouth make you sin. And don't defend yourself by telling the Temple messenger that the promise

you made was a mistake. That would make God angry, and he might wipe out everything you have achieved.

⁷Talk is cheap, like daydreams and other useless activities. Fear God instead.

The Futility of Wealth

⁸Don't be surprised if you see a poor person being oppressed by the powerful and if justice is being miscarried throughout the land. For every official is under orders from higher up, and matters of justice get lost in red tape and bureaucracy. ⁹Even the king milks the land for his own profit!

¹⁰Those who love money will never have enough. How meaningless to think that wealth brings true happiness! ¹¹The more you have, the more people come to help you spend it. So what good is wealth—except perhaps to watch it slip through your fingers!

¹²People who work hard sleep well, whether they eat little or much. But the rich seldom get a good night's sleep.

¹³There is another serious problem I have seen under the sun. Hoarding riches harms the saver. ¹⁴Money is put into risky investments that turn sour, and everything is lost. In the end, there is nothing left to pass on to one's children. ¹⁵We all come to the end of our lives as naked and empty-handed as on the day we were born. We can't take our riches with us.

¹⁶And this, too, is a very serious problem. People leave this world no better off than when they came. All their hard work is for nothing—like working for the wind. ¹⁷Throughout their lives, they live under a cloud—frustrated, discouraged, and angry.

¹⁸Even so, I have noticed one thing, at least, that is good. It is good for people to eat, drink, and enjoy their work under the sun during the short life God has given them, and to accept their lot in life. ¹⁹And it is a good thing to receive wealth from God and the good health to enjoy it. To enjoy your work and accept your lot in life—this is indeed

a gift from God. ²⁰God keeps such people so busy enjoying life that they take no time to brood over the past.

6



HERE is another serious tragedy I have seen under the sun, and it weighs heavily on humanity. ²God gives some people great wealth and honor and everything they could ever want, but then he doesn't give them the chance to enjoy these things. They die, and someone else, even a stranger, ends up enjoying their wealth! This is meaningless—a sickening tragedy.

³A man might have a hundred children and live to be very old. But if he finds no satisfaction in life and doesn't even get a decent burial, it would have been better for him to be born dead. ⁴His birth would have been meaningless, and he would have ended in darkness. He wouldn't even have had a name, ⁵and he would never have seen the sun or known of its existence. Yet he would have had more peace than in growing up to be an unhappy man. ⁶He might live a thousand years twice over but still not find contentment. And since he must die like everyone else—well, what's the use?

⁷All people spend their lives scratching for food, but they never seem to have enough. ⁸So are wise people really better off than fools? Do poor people gain anything by being wise and knowing how to act in front of others?

⁹Enjoy what you have rather than desiring what you don't have. Just dreaming about nice things is meaningless—like chasing the wind.

The Future—Determined and Unknown

¹⁰Everything has already been decided. It was known long ago what each person would be. So there's no use arguing with God about your destiny.

¹¹The more words you speak, the less they mean. So what good are they?

¹²In the few days of our meaningless lives, who knows how our days can best be spent? Our lives are like a shadow. Who can tell what will happen on this earth after we are gone?

7

Wisdom for Life



good reputation is more valuable than costly perfume.

And the day you die is better than the day you are born.

²Better to spend your time at funerals than at parties.

After all, everyone dies—

so the living should take this to heart.

³Sorrow is better than laughter,

for sadness has a refining influence on us.

⁴A wise person thinks a lot about death,

while a fool thinks only about having a good time.

⁵Better to be criticized by a wise person
than to be praised by a fool.

⁶A fool's laughter is quickly gone,
like thorns crackling in a fire.

This also is meaningless.

⁷Extortion turns wise people into fools,
and bribes corrupt the heart.

⁸Finishing is better than starting.
Patience is better than pride.

⁹Control your temper,
for anger labels you a fool.

¹⁰Don't long for "the good old days."
This is not wise.

¹¹Wisdom is even better when you have money.
Both are a benefit as you go through life.

¹²Wisdom and money can get you almost anything,
but only wisdom can save your life.

¹³Accept the way God does things,
for who can straighten what he has made crooked?

¹⁴Enjoy prosperity while you can,
but when hard times strike, realize that both come from God.
Remember that nothing is certain in this life.

The Limits of Human Wisdom

¹⁵I have seen everything in this meaningless life, including the death of good young people and the long life of wicked people. ¹⁶So don't be too good or too wise! Why destroy yourself? ¹⁷On the other hand, don't be too wicked either. Don't be a fool! Why die before your time? ¹⁸Pay attention to these instructions, for anyone who fears God will avoid both extremes.

¹⁹One wise person is stronger than ten leading citizens of a town!

²⁰Not a single person on earth is always good and never sins.

²¹Don't eavesdrop on others—you may hear your servant curse you.

²²For you know how often you yourself have cursed others.

²³I have always tried my best to let wisdom guide my thoughts and actions. I said to myself, “I am determined to be wise.” But it didn’t work. ²⁴Wisdom is always distant and difficult to find. ²⁵I searched everywhere, determined to find wisdom and to understand the reason for things. I was determined to prove to myself that wickedness is stupid and that foolishness is madness.

²⁶I discovered that a seductive woman is a trap more bitter than death. Her passion is a snare, and her soft hands are chains. Those who are pleasing to God will escape her, but sinners will be caught in her snare.

²⁷“This is my conclusion,” says the Teacher. “I discovered this after looking at the matter from every possible angle. ²⁸Though I have searched repeatedly, I have not found what I was looking for. Only one out of a thousand men is virtuous, but not one woman! ²⁹But I did find this: God created people to be virtuous, but they have each turned to follow their own downward path.”

8

ow wonderful to be wise,
to analyze and interpret things.
Wisdom lights up a person’s face,
softening its harshness.

Obedience to the King

²Obey the king since you vowed to God that you would. ³Don’t try to avoid doing your duty, and don’t stand with those who plot evil, for the king can do whatever he wants. ⁴His command is backed by great power. No one can resist or question it. ⁵Those who obey him will not be punished. Those who are wise will find a time and a way to do what is right, ⁶for there is a time and a way for everything, even when a person is in trouble.

⁷Indeed, how can people avoid what they don't know is going to happen? ⁸None of us can hold back our spirit from departing. None of us has the power to prevent the day of our death. There is no escaping that obligation, that dark battle. And in the face of death, wickedness will certainly not rescue the wicked.

The Wicked and the Righteous

⁹I have thought deeply about all that goes on here under the sun, where people have the power to hurt each other. ¹⁰I have seen wicked people buried with honor. Yet they were the very ones who frequented the Temple and are now praised in the same city where they committed their crimes! This, too, is meaningless. ¹¹When a crime is not punished quickly, people feel it is safe to do wrong. ¹²But even though a person sins a hundred times and still lives a long time, I know that those who fear God will be better off. ¹³The wicked will not prosper, for they do not fear God. Their days will never grow long like the evening shadows.

¹⁴And this is not all that is meaningless in our world. In this life, good people are often treated as though they were wicked, and wicked people are often treated as though they were good. This is so meaningless!

¹⁵So I recommend having fun, because there is nothing better for people in this world than to eat, drink, and enjoy life. That way they will experience some happiness along with all the hard work God gives them under the sun.

¹⁶In my search for wisdom and in my observation of people's burdens here on earth, I discovered that there is ceaseless activity, day and night. ¹⁷I realized that no one can discover everything God is doing under the sun. Not even the wisest people discover everything, no matter what they claim.

Death Comes to All

THIS, too, I carefully explored: Even though the actions of godly and wise people are in God's hands, no one knows whether God will show them favor. ²The same destiny ultimately awaits everyone, whether righteous or wicked, good or bad, ceremonially clean or unclean, religious or irreligious. Good people receive the same treatment as sinners, and people who make promises to God are treated like people who don't.

³It seems so wrong that everyone under the sun suffers the same fate. Already twisted by evil, people choose their own mad course, for they have no hope. There is nothing ahead but death anyway. ⁴There is hope only for the living. As they say, "It's better to be a live dog than a dead lion!"

⁵The living at least know they will die, but the dead know nothing. They have no further reward, nor are they remembered. ⁶Whatever they did in their lifetime—loving, hating, envying—is all long gone. They no longer play a part in anything here on earth. ⁷So go ahead. Eat your food with joy, and drink your wine with a happy heart, for God approves of this! ⁸Wear fine clothes, with a splash of cologne!

⁹Live happily with the woman you love through all the meaningless days of life that God has given you under the sun. The wife God gives you is your reward for all your earthly toil. ¹⁰Whatever you do, do well. For when you go to the grave, there will be no work or planning or knowledge or wisdom.

¹¹I have observed something else under the sun. The fastest runner doesn't always win the race, and the strongest warrior doesn't always win the battle. The wise sometimes go hungry, and the skillful are not necessarily wealthy. And those who are educated don't always lead successful lives. It is all decided by chance, by being in the right place at the right time.

¹²People can never predict when hard times might come. Like fish in a net or birds in a trap, people are caught by sudden tragedy.

Thoughts on Wisdom and Folly

¹³Here is another bit of wisdom that has impressed me as I have watched the way our world works. ¹⁴There was a small town with only a few people, and a great king came with his army and besieged it. ¹⁵A poor, wise man knew how to save the town, and so it was rescued. But afterward no one thought to thank him. ¹⁶So even though wisdom is better than strength, those who are wise will be despised if they are poor. What they say will not be appreciated for long.

¹⁷Better to hear the quiet words of a wise person
than the shouts of a foolish king.

¹⁸Better to have wisdom than weapons of war,
but one sinner can destroy much that is good.

10



As dead flies cause even a bottle of perfume to stink,
so a little foolishness spoils great wisdom and honor.

²A wise person chooses the right road;
a fool takes the wrong one.

³You can identify fools
just by the way they walk down the street!

⁴If your boss is angry at you, don't quit!
A quiet spirit can overcome even great mistakes.

The Ironies of Life

⁵There is another evil I have seen under the sun. Kings and rulers make a grave mistake ⁶when they give great authority to foolish people and low positions to people of proven worth. ⁷I have even seen servants riding horseback like princes—and princes walking like servants!

⁸When you dig a well,
you might fall in.
When you demolish an old wall,
you could be bitten by a snake.
⁹When you work in a quarry,
stones might fall and crush you.
When you chop wood,
there is danger with each stroke of your ax.

¹⁰Using a dull ax requires great strength,
so sharpen the blade.
That's the value of wisdom;
it helps you succeed.

¹¹If a snake bites before you charm it,
what's the use of being a snake charmer?

¹²Wise words bring approval,

but fools are destroyed by their own words.

- ¹³Fools base their thoughts on foolish assumptions,
so their conclusions will be wicked madness;
¹⁴they chatter on and on.

No one really knows what is going to happen;
no one can predict the future.

- ¹⁵Fools are so exhausted by a little work
that they can't even find their way home.

- ¹⁶What sorrow for the land ruled by a servant,
the land whose leaders feast in the morning.

- ¹⁷Happy is the land whose king is a noble leader
and whose leaders feast at the proper time
to gain strength for their work, not to get drunk.

- ¹⁸Laziness leads to a sagging roof;
idleness leads to a leaky house.

- ¹⁹A party gives laughter,
wine gives happiness,
and money gives everything!

- ²⁰Never make light of the king, even in your thoughts.

And don't make fun of the powerful, even in your own bedroom.
For a little bird might deliver your message
and tell them what you said.

11

The Uncertainties of Life



END your grain across the seas,
and in time, profits will flow back to you.

²But divide your investments among many places,
for you do not know what risks might lie ahead.

³When clouds are heavy, the rains come down.
Whether a tree falls north or south, it stays where it falls.

⁴Farmers who wait for perfect weather never plant.
If they watch every cloud, they never harvest.

⁵Just as you cannot understand the path of the wind or the mystery of a tiny baby growing in its mother's womb, so you cannot understand the activity of God, who does all things.

⁶Plant your seed in the morning and keep busy all afternoon, for you don't know if profit will come from one activity or another—or maybe both.

Advice for Young and Old

⁷Light is sweet; how pleasant to see a new day dawning.

⁸When people live to be very old, let them rejoice in every day of life. But let them also remember there will be many dark days. Everything still to come is meaningless.

⁹Young people, it's wonderful to be young! Enjoy every minute of it. Do everything you want to do; take it all in. But remember that you must give an account to God for everything you do. ¹⁰So refuse to worry, and keep your body healthy. But remember that youth, with a whole life before you, is meaningless.

12

DON'T let the excitement of youth cause you to forget your Creator. Honor him in your youth before you grow old and say, "Life is not pleasant anymore." ²Remember him before the light of the sun, moon, and stars is dim to your old eyes, and rain clouds continually darken your sky. ³Remember him before your legs—the guards of your house—start to tremble; and before your shoulders—the strong men—stoop. Remember him before your teeth—your few remaining servants—stop grinding; and before your eyes—the women looking through the windows—see dimly.

⁴Remember him before the door to life's opportunities is closed and the sound of work fades. Now you rise at the first chirping of the birds, but then all their sounds will grow faint.

⁵Remember him before you become fearful of falling and worry about danger in the streets; before your hair turns white like an almond tree in bloom, and you drag along without energy like a dying grasshopper, and the caperberry no longer inspires sexual desire. Remember him before you near the grave, your everlasting home, when the mourners will weep at your funeral.

⁶Yes, remember your Creator now while you are young, before the silver cord of life snaps and the golden bowl is broken. Don't wait until the water jar is smashed at the spring and the pulley is broken at the well. ⁷For then the dust will return to the earth, and the spirit will return to God who gave it.

Concluding Thoughts about the Teacher

⁸“Everything is meaningless,” says the Teacher, “completely meaningless.”

⁹Keep this in mind: The Teacher was considered wise, and he taught the people everything he knew. He listened carefully to many proverbs, studying and classifying them. ¹⁰The Teacher sought to find just the right words to express truths clearly.

¹¹The words of the wise are like cattle prods—painful but helpful. Their collected sayings are like a nail-studded stick with which a shepherd drives the sheep.

¹²But, my child, let me give you some further advice: Be careful, for writing books is endless, and much study wears you out.

¹³That’s the whole story. Here now is my final conclusion: Fear God and obey his commands, for this is everyone’s duty. ¹⁴God will judge us for everything we do, including every secret thing, whether good or bad.

Song of Songs

1



HIS is Solomon's song of songs, more wonderful than any other. *Young Woman*

- ²Kiss me and kiss me again,
for your love is sweeter than wine.
- ³How pleasing is your fragrance;
your name is like the spreading fragrance of scented oils.
No wonder all the young women love you!
- ⁴Take me with you; come, let's run!
The king has brought me into his bedroom.

Young Women of Jerusalem

How happy we are for you, O king.
We praise your love even more than wine.

Young Woman

How right they are to adore you.

- ⁵I am dark but beautiful,
O women of Jerusalem—
dark as the tents of Kedar,

Song of Songs 1

dark as the curtains of Solomon's tents.
⁶Don't stare at me because I am dark—
the sun has darkened my skin.
My brothers were angry with me;
they forced me to care for their vineyards,
so I couldn't care for myself—my own vineyard.

⁷Tell me, my love, where are you leading your flock today?
Where will you rest your sheep at noon?
For why should I wander like a prostitute
among your friends and their flocks?

Young Man

⁸If you don't know, O most beautiful woman,
follow the trail of my flock,
and graze your young goats by the shepherds' tents.
⁹You are as exciting, my darling,
as a mare among Pharaoh's stallions.
¹⁰How lovely are your cheeks;
your earrings set them afire!
How lovely is your neck,
enhanced by a string of jewels.
¹¹We will make for you earrings of gold
and beads of silver.

Young Woman

¹²The king is lying on his couch,
enchanted by the fragrance of my perfume.
¹³My lover is like a sachet of myrrh
lying between my breasts.
¹⁴He is like a bouquet of sweet henna blossoms

from the vineyards of En-gedi.

Young Man

¹⁵How beautiful you are, my darling,
how beautiful!
Your eyes are like doves.

Young Woman

¹⁶You are so handsome, my love,
pleasing beyond words!
The soft grass is our bed;
¹⁷fragrant cedar branches are the beams of our house,
and pleasant smelling firs are the rafters.

2

Young Woman

¹I am the spring crocus blooming on the Sharon Plain,
the lily of the valley.

Young Man

²Like a lily among thistles
is my darling among young women.

Young Woman

³Like the finest apple tree in the orchard
is my lover among other young men.
I sit in his delightful shade
and taste his delicious fruit.

⁴He escorts me to the banquet hall;
it's obvious how much he loves me.

⁵Strengthen me with raisin cakes,
refresh me with apples,
for I am weak with love.

⁶His left arm is under my head,
and his right arm embraces me.

⁷Promise me, O women of Jerusalem,
by the gazelles and wild deer,
not to awaken love until the time is right.

⁸Ah, I hear my lover coming!
He is leaping over the mountains,
bounding over the hills.

⁹My lover is like a swift gazelle
or a young stag.

Look, there he is behind the wall,
looking through the window,
peering into the room.

¹⁰My lover said to me,
"Rise up, my darling!
Come away with me, my fair one!"

¹¹Look, the winter is past,
and the rains are over and gone.

¹²The flowers are springing up,
the season of singing birds has come,
and the cooing of turtledoves fills the air.

¹³The fig trees are forming young fruit,
and the fragrant grapevines are blossoming.

Rise up, my darling!
Come away with me, my fair one!"

Young Man

¹⁴My dove is hiding behind the rocks,
behind an outcrop on the cliff.
Let me see your face;
let me hear your voice.
For your voice is pleasant,
and your face is lovely.

Young Women of Jerusalem

¹⁵Catch all the foxes,
those little foxes,
before they ruin the vineyard of love,
for the grapevines are blossoming!

Young Woman

¹⁶My lover is mine, and I am his.
He browses among the lilies.
¹⁷Before the dawn breezes blow
and the night shadows flee,
return to me, my love, like a gazelle
or a young stag on the rugged mountains.

3

Young Woman

¹One night as I lay in bed, I yearned for my lover.
I yearned for him, but he did not come.

²So I said to myself, "I will get up and roam the city,
searching in all its streets and squares.

I will search for the one I love."

So I searched everywhere but did not find him.

³The watchmen stopped me as they made their rounds,
and I asked, "Have you seen the one I love?"

⁴Then scarcely had I left them
when I found my love!

I caught and held him tightly,
then I brought him to my mother's house,
into my mother's bed, where I had been conceived.

⁵Promise me, O women of Jerusalem,
by the gazelles and wild deer,
not to awaken love until the time is right.

Young Women of Jerusalem

⁶Who is this sweeping in from the wilderness
like a cloud of smoke?

Who is it, fragrant with myrrh and frankincense
and every kind of spice?

⁷Look, it is Solomon's carriage,
surrounded by sixty heroic men,
the best of Israel's soldiers.

⁸They are all skilled swordsmen,
experienced warriors.

Each wears a sword on his thigh,
ready to defend the king against an attack in the night.

⁹King Solomon's carriage is built
of wood imported from Lebanon.

¹⁰Its posts are silver,
its canopy gold;

its cushions are purple.
It was decorated with love
by the young women of Jerusalem.

Young Woman

¹¹Come out to see King Solomon,
young women of Jerusalem.
He wears the crown his mother gave him on his wedding day,
his most joyous day.

4

Young Man

¹You are beautiful, my darling,
beautiful beyond words.
Your eyes are like doves
behind your veil.
Your hair falls in waves,
like a flock of goats winding down the slopes of Gilead.
²Your teeth are as white as sheep,
recently shorn and freshly washed.
Your smile is flawless,
each tooth matched with its twin.
³Your lips are like scarlet ribbon;
your mouth is inviting.
Your cheeks are like rosy pomegranates
behind your veil.
⁴Your neck is as beautiful as the tower of David,
jeweled with the shields of a thousand heroes.
⁵Your breasts are like two fawns,
twin fawns of a gazelle grazing among the lilies.
⁶Before the dawn breezes blow

and the night shadows flee,
I will hurry to the mountain of myrrh
and to the hill of frankincense.
⁷You are altogether beautiful, my darling,
beautiful in every way.

⁸Come with me from Lebanon, my bride,
come with me from Lebanon.
Come down from Mount Amana,
from the peaks of Senir and Hermon,
where the lions have their dens
and leopards live among the hills.

⁹You have captured my heart,
my treasure, my bride.
You hold it hostage with one glance of your eyes,
with a single jewel of your necklace.

¹⁰Your love delights me,
my treasure, my bride.
Your love is better than wine,
your perfume more fragrant than spices.

¹¹Your lips are as sweet as nectar, my bride.
Honey and milk are under your tongue.
Your clothes are scented
like the cedars of Lebanon.

¹²You are my private garden, my treasure, my bride,
a secluded spring, a hidden fountain.

¹³Your thighs shelter a paradise of pomegranates
with rare spices—
henna with nard,

¹⁴nard and saffron,
fragrant calamus and cinnamon,
with all the trees of frankincense, myrrh, and aloes,
and every other lovely spice.
¹⁵You are a garden fountain,
a well of fresh water
streaming down from Lebanon's mountains.

Young Woman

¹⁶Awake, north wind!
Rise up, south wind!
Blow on my garden
and spread its fragrance all around.
Come into your garden, my love;
taste its finest fruits.

5

Young Man

¹I have entered my garden, my treasure, my bride!
I gather myrrh with my spices
and eat honeycomb with my honey.
I drink wine with my milk.

Young Women of Jerusalem

Oh, lover and beloved, eat and drink!
Yes, drink deeply of your love!

Young Woman

²I slept, but my heart was awake,

when I heard my lover knocking and calling:
“Open to me, my treasure, my darling,
my dove, my perfect one.
My head is drenched with dew,
my hair with the dampness of the night.”

³But I responded,
“I have taken off my robe.
Should I get dressed again?
I have washed my feet.
Should I get them soiled?”

⁴My lover tried to unlatch the door,
and my heart thrilled within me.
⁵I jumped up to open the door for my love,
and my hands dripped with perfume.
My fingers dripped with lovely myrrh
as I pulled back the bolt.

⁶I opened to my lover,
but he was gone!
My heart sank.
I searched for him
but could not find him anywhere.
I called to him,
but there was no reply.

⁷The night watchmen found me
as they made their rounds.
They beat and bruised me
and stripped off my veil,
those watchmen on the walls.

⁸Make this promise, O women of Jerusalem—
If you find my lover,
tell him I am weak with love.

Young Women of Jerusalem

⁹Why is your lover better than all others,
O woman of rare beauty?
What makes your lover so special
that we must promise this?

Young Woman

¹⁰My lover is dark and dazzling,
better than ten thousand others!
¹¹His head is finest gold,
his wavy hair is black as a raven.
¹²His eyes sparkle like doves
beside springs of water;
they are set like jewels
washed in milk.
¹³His cheeks are like gardens of spices
giving off fragrance.
His lips are like lilies,
perfumed with myrrh.
¹⁴His arms are like rounded bars of gold,
set with beryl.
His body is like bright ivory,
glowing with lapis lazuli.
¹⁵His legs are like marble pillars
set in sockets of finest gold.
His posture is stately,
like the noble cedars of Lebanon.
¹⁶His mouth is sweetness itself;

he is desirable in every way.
Such, O women of Jerusalem,
is my lover, my friend.

6

Young Women of Jerusalem

¹Where has your lover gone,
O woman of rare beauty?
Which way did he turn
so we can help you find him?

Young Woman

²My lover has gone down to his garden,
to his spice beds,
to browse in the gardens
and gather the lilies.
³I am my lover's, and my lover is mine.
He browses among the lilies.

Young Man

⁴You are beautiful, my darling,
like the lovely city of Tirzah.
Yes, as beautiful as Jerusalem,
as majestic as an army with billowing banners.
⁵Turn your eyes away,
for they overpower me.
Your hair falls in waves,
like a flock of goats winding down the slopes of Gilead.
⁶Your teeth are as white as sheep
that are freshly washed.

Song of Songs 6

Your smile is flawless,
each tooth matched with its twin.
⁷Your cheeks are like rosy pomegranates
behind your veil.

⁸Even among sixty queens
and eighty concubines
and countless young women,
⁹I would still choose my dove, my perfect one—
the favorite of her mother,
dearly loved by the one who bore her.
The young women see her and praise her;
even queens and royal concubines sing her praises:
¹⁰“Who is this, arising like the dawn,
as fair as the moon,
as bright as the sun,
as majestic as an army with billowing banners?”

Young Woman

¹¹I went down to the grove of walnut trees
and out to the valley to see the new spring growth,
to see whether the grapevines had budded
or the pomegranates were in bloom.
¹²Before I realized it,
my strong desires had taken me to the chariot of a noble man.

Young Women of Jerusalem

¹³Return, return to us, O maid of Shulam.
Come back, come back, that we may see you again.

Young Man

Why do you stare at this young woman of Shulam,
as she moves so gracefully between two lines of dancers?

7



ow beautiful are your sandaled feet,
O queenly maiden.

Your rounded thighs are like jewels,
the work of a skilled craftsman.

²Your navel is perfectly formed
like a goblet filled with mixed wine.
Between your thighs lies a mound of wheat
bordered with lilies.

³Your breasts are like two fawns,
twin fawns of a gazelle.

⁴Your neck is as beautiful as an ivory tower.
Your eyes are like the sparkling pools in Heshbon
by the gate of Bath-rabbim.
Your nose is as fine as the tower of Lebanon
overlooking Damascus.

⁵Your head is as majestic as Mount Carmel,
and the sheen of your hair radiates royalty.
The king is held captive by its tresses.

⁶Oh, how beautiful you are!
How pleasing, my love, how full of delights!

⁷You are slender like a palm tree,
and your breasts are like its clusters of fruit.

⁸I said, "I will climb the palm tree
and take hold of its fruit."

May your breasts be like grape clusters,
and the fragrance of your breath like apples.

⁹May your kisses be as exciting as the best wine—

Young Woman

Yes, wine that goes down smoothly for my lover,
flowing gently over lips and teeth.

¹⁰I am my lover's,
and he claims me as his own.

¹¹Come, my love, let us go out to the fields
and spend the night among the wildflowers.

¹²Let us get up early and go to the vineyards
to see if the grapevines have budded,
if the blossoms have opened,

and if the pomegranates have bloomed.

There I will give you my love.

¹³There the mandrakes give off their fragrance,
and the finest fruits are at our door,
new delights as well as old,
which I have saved for you, my lover.

8

Young Woman

¹Oh, I wish you were my brother,
who nursed at my mother's breasts.

Then I could kiss you no matter who was watching,
and no one would criticize me.

²I would bring you to my childhood home,
and there you would teach me.

I would give you spiced wine to drink,
my sweet pomegranate wine.

³Your left arm would be under my head,
and your right arm would embrace me.

⁴Promise me, O women of Jerusalem,
not to awaken love until the time is right.

Young Women of Jerusalem

⁵Who is this sweeping in from the desert,
leaning on her lover?

Young Woman

I aroused you under the apple tree,
where your mother gave you birth,
where in great pain she delivered you.

⁶Place me like a seal over your heart,
like a seal on your arm.

For love is as strong as death,
its jealousy as enduring as the grave.

Love flashes like fire,
the brightest kind of flame.

⁷Many waters cannot quench love,
nor can rivers drown it.

If a man tried to buy love
with all his wealth,
his offer would be utterly scorned.

The Young Woman's Brothers

⁸We have a little sister
too young to have breasts.
What will we do for our sister
if someone asks to marry her?

⁹If she is a virgin, like a wall,
we will protect her with a silver tower.
But if she is promiscuous, like a swinging door,

we will block her door with a cedar bar.

Young Woman

¹⁰I was a virgin, like a wall;
now my breasts are like towers.
When my lover looks at me,
he is delighted with what he sees.

¹¹Solomon has a vineyard at Baal-hamon,
which he leases out to tenant farmers.
Each of them pays a thousand pieces of silver
for harvesting its fruit.

¹²But my vineyard is mine to give,
and Solomon need not pay a thousand pieces of silver.
But I will give two hundred pieces
to those who care for its vines.

Young Man

¹³O my darling, lingering in the gardens,
your companions are fortunate to hear your voice.
Let me hear it, too!

Young Woman

¹⁴Come away, my love! Be like a gazelle
or a young stag on the mountains of spices.

Lamentations

1

Sorrow in Jerusalem



ERUSALEM, once so full of people,
is now deserted.

She who was once great among the nations
now sits alone like a widow.
Once the queen of all the earth,
she is now a slave.

²She sobs through the night;
tears stream down her cheeks.
Among all her lovers,
there is no one left to comfort her.
All her friends have betrayed her
and become her enemies.

³Judah has been led away into captivity,
oppressed with cruel slavery.
She lives among foreign nations
and has no place of rest.

Lamentations 1

Her enemies have chased her down,
and she has nowhere to turn.

⁴The roads to Jerusalem are in mourning,
for crowds no longer come to celebrate the festivals.
The city gates are silent,
her priests groan,
her young women are crying—
how bitter is her fate!

⁵Her oppressors have become her masters,
and her enemies prosper,
for the Lord has punished Jerusalem
for her many sins.
Her children have been captured
and taken away to distant lands.

⁶All the majesty of beautiful Jerusalem
has been stripped away.
Her princes are like starving deer
searching for pasture.
They are too weak to run
from the pursuing enemy.

⁷In the midst of her sadness and wandering,
Jerusalem remembers her ancient splendor.
But now she has fallen to her enemy,
and there is no one to help her.
Her enemy struck her down
and laughed as she fell.

⁸Jerusalem has sinned greatly,
so she has been tossed away like a filthy rag.
All who once honored her now despise her,
for they have seen her stripped naked and humiliated.
All she can do is groan
and hide her face.

⁹She defiled herself with immorality
and gave no thought to her future.
Now she lies in the gutter
with no one to lift her out.
“Lord, see my misery,” she cries.
“The enemy has triumphed.”

¹⁰The enemy has plundered her completely,
taking every precious thing she owns.
She has seen foreigners violate her sacred Temple,
the place the Lord had forbidden them to enter.

¹¹Her people groan as they search for bread.
They have sold their treasures for food to stay alive.
“O Lord, look,” she mourns,
“and see how I am despised.”

¹²“Does it mean nothing to you, all you who pass by?
Look around and see if there is any suffering like mine,
which the Lord brought on me
when he erupted in fierce anger.”

Lamentations 1

¹³“He has sent fire from heaven that burns in my bones.
He has placed a trap in my path and turned me back.
He has left me devastated,
racked with sickness all day long.

¹⁴“He wove my sins into ropes
to hitch me to a yoke of captivity.
The Lord sapped my strength and turned me over to my enemies;
I am helpless in their hands.

¹⁵“The Lord has treated my mighty men
with contempt.
At his command a great army has come
to crush my young warriors.
The Lord has trampled his beloved city
like grapes are trampled in a winepress.

¹⁶“For all these things I weep;
tears flow down my cheeks.
No one is here to comfort me;
any who might encourage me are far away.
My children have no future,
for the enemy has conquered us.”

¹⁷Jerusalem reaches out for help,
but no one comforts her.
Regarding his people Israel,
the Lord has said,
“Let their neighbors be their enemies!
Let them be thrown away like a filthy rag!”

¹⁸“The Lord is right,” Jerusalem says,
“for I rebelled against him.
Listen, people everywhere;
look upon my anguish and despair,
for my sons and daughters
have been taken captive to distant lands.

¹⁹“I begged my allies for help,
but they betrayed me.
My priests and leaders
starved to death in the city,
even as they searched for food
to save their lives.

²⁰“Lord, see my anguish!
My heart is broken
and my soul despairs,
for I have rebelled against you.
In the streets the sword kills,
and at home there is only death.

²¹“Others heard my groans,
but no one turned to comfort me.
When my enemies heard about my troubles,
they were happy to see what you had done.
Oh, bring the day you promised,
when they will suffer as I have suffered.

²²“Look at all their evil deeds, Lord.
Punish them,

as you have punished me
for all my sins.
My groans are many,
and I am sick at heart.”

2

God's Anger at Sin



HE Lord in his anger
has cast a dark shadow over beautiful Jerusalem.
The fairest of Israel's cities lies in the dust,
thrown down from the heights of heaven.
In his day of great anger,
the Lord has shown no mercy even to his Temple.

²Without mercy the Lord has destroyed
every home in Israel.
In his anger he has broken down
the fortress walls of beautiful Jerusalem.
He has brought them to the ground,
dishonoring the kingdom and its rulers.

³All the strength of Israel
vanishes beneath his fierce anger.
The Lord has withdrawn his protection
as the enemy attacks.
He consumes the whole land of Israel
like a raging fire.

⁴He bends his bow against his people,
as though he were their enemy.
His strength is used against them
to kill their finest youth.
His fury is poured out like fire
on beautiful Jerusalem.

⁵Yes, the Lord has vanquished Israel
like an enemy.
He has destroyed her palaces
and demolished her fortresses.
He has brought unending sorrow and tears
upon beautiful Jerusalem.

⁶He has broken down his Temple
as though it were merely a garden shelter.
The Lord has blotted out all memory
of the holy festivals and Sabbath days.
Kings and priests fall together
before his fierce anger.

⁷The Lord has rejected his own altar;
he despises his own sanctuary.
He has given Jerusalem's palaces
to her enemies.
They shout in the Lord's Temple
as though it were a day of celebration.

⁸The Lord was determined
to destroy the walls of beautiful Jerusalem.

He made careful plans for their destruction,
then did what he had planned.
Therefore, the ramparts and walls
have fallen down before him.

⁹Jerusalem's gates have sunk into the ground.
He has smashed their locks and bars.
Her kings and princes have been exiled to distant lands;
her law has ceased to exist.
Her prophets receive
no more visions from the Lord.

¹⁰The leaders of beautiful Jerusalem
sit on the ground in silence.
They are clothed in burlap
and throw dust on their heads.
The young women of Jerusalem
hang their heads in shame.

¹¹I have cried until the tears no longer come;
my heart is broken.
My spirit is poured out in agony
as I see the desperate plight of my people.
Little children and tiny babies
are fainting and dying in the streets.

¹²They cry out to their mothers,
"We need food and drink!"
Their lives ebb away in the streets
like the life of a warrior wounded in battle.

They gasp for life
as they collapse in their mothers' arms.

¹³What can I say about you?
Who has ever seen such sorrow?
O daughter of Jerusalem,
to what can I compare your anguish?
O virgin daughter of Zion,
how can I comfort you?
For your wound is as deep as the sea.
Who can heal you?

¹⁴Your prophets have said
so many foolish things, false to the core.
They did not save you from exile
by pointing out your sins.
Instead, they painted false pictures,
filling you with false hope.

¹⁵All who pass by jeer at you.
They scoff and insult beautiful Jerusalem, saying,
"Is this the city called 'Most Beautiful in All the World'
and 'Joy of All the Earth'?"

¹⁶All your enemies mock you.
They scoff and snarl and say,
"We have destroyed her at last!
We have long waited for this day,
and it is finally here!"

¹⁷But it is the Lord who did just as he planned.

He has fulfilled the promises of disaster
he made long ago.

He has destroyed Jerusalem without mercy.

He has caused her enemies to gloat over her
and has given them power over her.

¹⁸Cry aloud before the Lord,

O walls of beautiful Jerusalem!

Let your tears flow like a river
day and night.

Give yourselves no rest;
give your eyes no relief.

¹⁹Rise during the night and cry out.

Pour out your hearts like water to the Lord.

Lift up your hands to him in prayer,
pleading for your children,

for in every street
they are faint with hunger.

²⁰“O Lord, think about this!

Should you treat your own people this way?

Should mothers eat their own children,

those they once bounced on their knees?

Should priests and prophets be killed

within the Lord’s Temple?

²¹“See them lying in the streets—

young and old,

boys and girls,
killed by the swords of the enemy.
You have killed them in your anger,
slaughtering them without mercy.

²²“You have invited terrors from all around,
as though you were calling them to a day of feasting.
In the day of the Lord’s anger,
no one has escaped or survived.
The enemy has killed all the children
whom I carried and raised.”

3

Hope in the Lord’s Faithfulness



I am the one who has seen the afflictions
that come from the rod of the Lord’s anger.

²He has led me into darkness,
shutting out all light.

³He has turned his hand against me
again and again, all day long.

⁴He has made my skin and flesh grow old.
He has broken my bones.

⁵He has besieged and surrounded me
with anguish and distress.

⁶He has buried me in a dark place,
like those long dead.

⁷He has walled me in, and I cannot escape.

He has bound me in heavy chains.

⁸And though I cry and shout,

he has shut out my prayers.

⁹He has blocked my way with a high stone wall;

he has made my road crooked.

¹⁰He has hidden like a bear or a lion,

waiting to attack me.

¹¹He has dragged me off the path and torn me in pieces,

leaving me helpless and devastated.

¹²He has drawn his bow

and made me the target for his arrows.

¹³He shot his arrows

deep into my heart.

¹⁴My own people laugh at me.

All day long they sing their mocking songs.

¹⁵He has filled me with bitterness

and given me a bitter cup of sorrow to drink.

¹⁶He has made me chew on gravel.

He has rolled me in the dust.

¹⁷Peace has been stripped away,

and I have forgotten what prosperity is.

¹⁸I cry out, "My splendor is gone!

Everything I had hoped for from the Lord is lost!"

¹⁹The thought of my suffering and homelessness

is bitter beyond words.

²⁰I will never forget this awful time,
as I grieve over my loss.

²¹Yet I still dare to hope
when I remember this:

²²The faithful love of the Lord never ends!
His mercies never cease.

²³Great is his faithfulness;
his mercies begin afresh each morning.

²⁴I say to myself, "The Lord is my inheritance;
therefore, I will hope in him!"

²⁵The Lord is good to those who depend on him,
to those who search for him.

²⁶So it is good to wait quietly
for salvation from the Lord.

²⁷And it is good for people to submit at an early age
to the yoke of his discipline:

²⁸Let them sit alone in silence
beneath the Lord's demands.

²⁹Let them lie face down in the dust,
for there may be hope at last.

³⁰Let them turn the other cheek to those who strike them
and accept the insults of their enemies.

³¹For no one is abandoned
by the Lord forever.

³²Though he brings grief, he also shows compassion
because of the greatness of his unfailing love.

³³For he does not enjoy hurting people
or causing them sorrow.

³⁴If people crush underfoot
all the prisoners of the land,
³⁵if they deprive others of their rights
in defiance of the Most High,
³⁶if they twist justice in the courts—
doesn't the Lord see all these things?

³⁷Who can command things to happen
without the Lord's permission?
³⁸Does not the Most High
send both calamity and good?
³⁹Then why should we, mere humans, complain
when we are punished for our sins?

⁴⁰Instead, let us test and examine our ways.
Let us turn back to the Lord.
⁴¹Let us lift our hearts and hands
to God in heaven and say,
⁴²"We have sinned and rebelled,
and you have not forgiven us.

⁴³"You have engulfed us with your anger, chased us down,
and slaughtered us without mercy.
⁴⁴You have hidden yourself in a cloud
so our prayers cannot reach you.
⁴⁵You have discarded us as refuse and garbage
among the nations.

- ⁴⁶“All our enemies
have spoken out against us.
⁴⁷We are filled with fear,
for we are trapped, devastated, and ruined.”
⁴⁸Tears stream from my eyes
because of the destruction of my people!
- ⁴⁹My tears flow endlessly;
they will not stop
⁵⁰until the Lord looks down
from heaven and sees.
⁵¹My heart is breaking
over the fate of all the women of Jerusalem.
- ⁵²My enemies, whom I have never harmed,
hunted me down like a bird.
⁵³They threw me into a pit
and dropped stones on me.
⁵⁴The water rose over my head,
and I cried out, “This is the end!”
- ⁵⁵But I called on your name, Lord,
from deep within the pit.
⁵⁶You heard me when I cried, “Listen to my pleading!
Hear my cry for help!”
⁵⁷Yes, you came when I called;
you told me, “**Do not fear.**”
- ⁵⁸Lord, you have come to my defense;
you have redeemed my life.

⁵⁹You have seen the wrong they have done to me, Lord.
Be my judge, and prove me right.

⁶⁰You have seen the vengeful plots
my enemies have laid against me.

⁶¹Lord, you have heard the vile names they call me.
You know all about the plans they have made.

⁶²My enemies whisper and mutter
as they plot against me all day long.

⁶³Look at them! Whether they sit or stand,
I am the object of their mocking songs.

⁶⁴Pay them back, Lord,
for all the evil they have done.

⁶⁵Give them hard and stubborn hearts,
and then let your curse fall on them!

⁶⁶Chase them down in your anger,
destroying them beneath the Lord's heavens.

4

God's Anger Satisfied



ow the gold has lost its luster!
Even the finest gold has become dull.
The sacred gemstones
lie scattered in the streets!

²See how the precious children of Jerusalem,

worth their weight in fine gold,
are now treated like pots of clay
made by a common potter.

³Even the jackals feed their young,
but not my people Israel.
They ignore their children's cries,
like ostriches in the desert.

⁴The parched tongues of their little ones
stick to the roofs of their mouths in thirst.
The children cry for bread,
but no one has any to give them.

⁵The people who once ate the richest foods
now beg in the streets for anything they can get.
Those who once wore the finest clothes
now search the garbage dumps for food.

⁶The guilt of my people
is greater than that of Sodom,
where utter disaster struck in a moment
and no hand offered help.

⁷Our princes once glowed with health—
brighter than snow, whiter than milk.
Their faces were as ruddy as rubies,
their appearance like fine jewels.

⁸But now their faces are blacker than soot.

No one recognizes them in the streets.
Their skin sticks to their bones;
it is as dry and hard as wood.

⁹Those killed by the sword are better off
than those who die of hunger.

Starving, they waste away
for lack of food from the fields.

¹⁰Tenderhearted women
have cooked their own children.

They have eaten them
to survive the siege.

¹¹But now the anger of the Lord is satisfied.

His fierce anger has been poured out.
He started a fire in Jerusalem
that burned the city to its foundations.

¹²Not a king in all the earth—

no one in all the world—
would have believed that an enemy
could march through the gates of Jerusalem.

¹³Yet it happened because of the sins of her prophets

and the sins of her priests,
who defiled the city
by shedding innocent blood.

¹⁴They wandered blindly
 through the streets,
so defiled by blood
 that no one dared touch them.

¹⁵“Get away!” the people shouted at them.
 “You’re defiled! Don’t touch us!”
So they fled to distant lands
 and wandered among foreign nations,
but none would let them stay.

¹⁶The Lord himself has scattered them,
 and he no longer helps them.
People show no respect for the priests
 and no longer honor the leaders.

¹⁷We looked in vain for our allies
 to come and save us,
but we were looking to nations
 that could not help us.

¹⁸We couldn’t go into the streets
 without danger to our lives.
Our end was near; our days were numbered.
 We were doomed!

¹⁹Our enemies were swifter than eagles in flight.
 If we fled to the mountains, they found us.
If we hid in the wilderness,

they were waiting for us there.

²⁰Our king—the Lord’s anointed, the very life of our nation—
was caught in their snares.
We had thought that his shadow
would protect us against any nation on earth!

²¹Are you rejoicing in the land of Uz,
O people of Edom?
But you, too, must drink from the cup of the Lord’s anger.
You, too, will be stripped naked in your drunkenness.

²²O beautiful Jerusalem, your punishment will end;
you will soon return from exile.
But Edom, your punishment is just beginning;
soon your many sins will be exposed.

5

Prayer for Restoration



ORD, remember what has happened to us.

See how we have been disgraced!

²Our inheritance has been turned over to strangers,
our homes to foreigners.

³We are orphaned and fatherless.
Our mothers are widowed.

⁴We have to pay for water to drink,
and even firewood is expensive.

- ⁵Those who pursue us are at our heels;
we are exhausted but are given no rest.
- ⁶We submitted to Egypt and Assyria
to get enough food to survive.
- ⁷Our ancestors sinned, but they have died—
and we are suffering the punishment they deserved!
- ⁸Slaves have now become our masters;
there is no one left to rescue us.
- ⁹We hunt for food at the risk of our lives,
for violence rules the countryside.
- ¹⁰The famine has blackened our skin
as though baked in an oven.
- ¹¹Our enemies rape the women in Jerusalem
and the young girls in all the towns of Judah.
- ¹²Our princes are being hanged by their thumbs,
and our elders are treated with contempt.
- ¹³Young men are led away to work at millstones,
and boys stagger under heavy loads of wood.
- ¹⁴The elders no longer sit in the city gates;
the young men no longer dance and sing.
- ¹⁵Joy has left our hearts;
our dancing has turned to mourning.
- ¹⁶The garlands have fallen from our heads.
Weep for us because we have sinned.
- ¹⁷Our hearts are sick and weary,
and our eyes grow dim with tears.
- ¹⁸For Jerusalem is empty and desolate,
a place haunted by jackals.
- ¹⁹But Lord, you remain the same forever!
Your throne continues from generation to generation.

Lamentations 5

²⁰Why do you continue to forget us?

Why have you abandoned us for so long?

²¹Restore us, O Lord, and bring us back to you again!

Give us back the joys we once had!

²²Or have you utterly rejected us?

Are you angry with us still?

Daniel

The Greek additions to Daniel (Susanna, Bel and the Dragon, and the Prayer of Azariah with the Song of the Three Young Men) are collected in Volume IV, The Apocrypha.

1

Daniel in Nebuchadnezzar's Court

DURING the third year of King Jehoiakim's reign in Judah, King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon came to Jerusalem and besieged it. ²The Lord gave him victory over King Jehoiakim of Judah and permitted him to take some of the sacred objects from the Temple of God. So Nebuchadnezzar took them back to the land of Babylonia and placed them in the treasure-house of his god.

³Then the king ordered Ashpenaz, his chief of staff, to bring to the palace some of the young men of Judah's royal family and other noble families, who had been brought to Babylon as captives. ⁴"Select only strong, healthy, and good-looking young men," he said. "Make sure they are well versed in every branch of learning, are gifted with knowledge and good judgment, and are suited to serve in the royal palace.

Train these young men in the language and literature of Babylon.”

⁵The king assigned them a daily ration of food and wine from his own kitchens. They were to be trained for three years, and then they would enter the royal service.

⁶Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah were four of the young men chosen, all from the tribe of Judah. ⁷The chief of staff renamed them with these Babylonian names:

Daniel was called Belteshazzar.

Hananiah was called Shadrach.

Mishael was called Meshach.

Azariah was called Abednego.

⁸But Daniel was determined not to defile himself by eating the food and wine given to them by the king. He asked the chief of staff for permission not to eat these unacceptable foods. ⁹Now God had given the chief of staff both respect and affection for Daniel. ¹⁰But he responded, “I am afraid of my lord the king, who has ordered that you eat this food and wine. If you become pale and thin compared to the other youths your age, I am afraid the king will have me beheaded.”

¹¹Daniel spoke with the attendant who had been appointed by the chief of staff to look after Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah. ¹²“Please test us for ten days on a diet of vegetables and water,” Daniel said. ¹³“At the end of the ten days, see how we look compared to the other young men who are eating the king’s food. Then make your decision in light of what you see.” ¹⁴The attendant agreed to Daniel’s suggestion and tested them for ten days.

¹⁵At the end of the ten days, Daniel and his three friends looked healthier and better nourished than the young men who had been eating the food assigned by the king. ¹⁶So after that, the attendant fed them only vegetables instead of the food and wine provided for the others.

¹⁷God gave these four young men an unusual aptitude for understanding every aspect of literature and wisdom. And God gave Daniel the special ability to interpret the meanings of visions and dreams.

¹⁸When the training period ordered by the king was completed, the chief of staff brought all the young men to King Nebuchadnezzar.

¹⁹The king talked with them, and no one impressed him as much as Daniel, Hananiah, Mishaël, and Azariah. So they entered the royal service. ²⁰Whenever the king consulted them in any matter requiring wisdom and balanced judgment, he found them ten times more capable than any of the magicians and enchanters in his entire kingdom.

²¹Daniel remained in the royal service until the first year of the reign of King Cyrus.

2

Nebuchadnezzar's Dream



ONE night during the second year of his reign, Nebuchadnezzar had such disturbing dreams that he couldn't sleep. ²He called in his magicians, enchanters, sorcerers, and astrologers, and he demanded that they tell him what he had dreamed. As they stood before the king, ³he said, "I have had a dream that deeply troubles me, and I must know what it means."

⁴Then the astrologers answered the king in Aramaic, "Long live the king! Tell us the dream, and we will tell you what it means."

⁵But the king said to the astrologers, "I am serious about this. If you don't tell me what my dream was and what it means, you will be torn limb from limb, and your houses will be turned into heaps of rubble! ⁶But if you tell me what I dreamed and what the dream means, I will give you many wonderful gifts and honors. Just tell me the dream and what it means!"

⁷They said again, "Please, Your Majesty. Tell us the dream, and we will tell you what it means."

⁸The king replied, “I know what you are doing! You’re stalling for time because you know I am serious when I say, ⁹‘If you don’t tell me the dream, you are doomed.’ So you have conspired to tell me lies, hoping I will change my mind. But tell me the dream, and then I’ll know that you can tell me what it means.”

¹⁰The astrologers replied to the king, “No one on earth can tell the king his dream! And no king, however great and powerful, has ever asked such a thing of any magician, enchanter, or astrologer! ¹¹The king’s demand is impossible. No one except the gods can tell you your dream, and they do not live here among people.”

¹²The king was furious when he heard this, and he ordered that all the wise men of Babylon be executed. ¹³And because of the king’s decree, men were sent to find and kill Daniel and his friends.

¹⁴When Arioch, the commander of the king’s guard, came to kill them, Daniel handled the situation with wisdom and discretion. ¹⁵He asked Arioch, “Why has the king issued such a harsh decree?” So Arioch told him all that had happened. ¹⁶Daniel went at once to see the king and requested more time to tell the king what the dream meant.

¹⁷Then Daniel went home and told his friends Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah what had happened. ¹⁸He urged them to ask the God of heaven to show them his mercy by telling them the secret, so they would not be executed along with the other wise men of Babylon. ¹⁹That night the secret was revealed to Daniel in a vision. Then Daniel praised the God of heaven. ²⁰He said,

“Praise the name of God forever and ever,
for he has all wisdom and power.

²¹He controls the course of world events;
he removes kings and sets up other kings.

He gives wisdom to the wise
and knowledge to the scholars.

²²He reveals deep and mysterious things

and knows what lies hidden in darkness,
though he is surrounded by light.
²³I thank and praise you, God of my ancestors,
for you have given me wisdom and strength.
You have told me what we asked of you
and revealed to us what the king demanded.”

Daniel Interprets the Dream

²⁴Then Daniel went in to see Arioch, whom the king had ordered to execute the wise men of Babylon. Daniel said to him, “Don’t kill the wise men. Take me to the king, and I will tell him the meaning of his dream.”

²⁵Arioch quickly took Daniel to the king and said, “I have found one of the captives from Judah who will tell the king the meaning of his dream!”

²⁶The king said to Daniel (also known as Belteshazzar), “Is this true? Can you tell me what my dream was and what it means?”

²⁷Daniel replied, “There are no wise men, enchanters, magicians, or fortune-tellers who can reveal the king’s secret. ²⁸But there is a God in heaven who reveals secrets, and he has shown King Nebuchadnezzar what will happen in the future. Now I will tell you your dream and the visions you saw as you lay on your bed.

²⁹“While Your Majesty was sleeping, you dreamed about coming events. He who reveals secrets has shown you what is going to happen. ³⁰And it is not because I am wiser than anyone else that I know the secret of your dream, but because God wants you to understand what was in your heart.

³¹“In your vision, Your Majesty, you saw standing before you a huge, shining statue of a man. It was a frightening sight. ³²The head of the statue was made of fine gold. Its chest and arms were silver, its belly and thighs were bronze, ³³its legs were iron, and its feet were a combination of iron and baked clay. ³⁴As you watched, a rock was

cut from a mountain, but not by human hands. It struck the feet of iron and clay, smashing them to bits. ³⁵The whole statue was crushed into small pieces of iron, clay, bronze, silver, and gold. Then the wind blew them away without a trace, like chaff on a threshing floor. But the rock that knocked the statue down became a great mountain that covered the whole earth.

³⁶“That was the dream. Now we will tell the king what it means. ³⁷Your Majesty, you are the greatest of kings. The God of heaven has given you sovereignty, power, strength, and honor. ³⁸He has made you the ruler over all the inhabited world and has put even the wild animals and birds under your control. You are the head of gold.

³⁹“But after your kingdom comes to an end, another kingdom, inferior to yours, will rise to take your place. After that kingdom has fallen, yet a third kingdom, represented by bronze, will rise to rule the world. ⁴⁰Following that kingdom, there will be a fourth one, as strong as iron. That kingdom will smash and crush all previous empires, just as iron smashes and crushes everything it strikes. ⁴¹The feet and toes you saw were a combination of iron and baked clay, showing that this kingdom will be divided. Like iron mixed with clay, it will have some of the strength of iron. ⁴²But while some parts of it will be as strong as iron, other parts will be as weak as clay. ⁴³This mixture of iron and clay also shows that these kingdoms will try to strengthen themselves by forming alliances with each other through intermarriage. But they will not hold together, just as iron and clay do not mix.

⁴⁴“During the reigns of those kings, the God of heaven will set up a kingdom that will never be destroyed or conquered. It will crush all these kingdoms into nothingness, and it will stand forever. ⁴⁵That is the meaning of the rock cut from the mountain, though not by human hands, that crushed to pieces the statue of iron, bronze, clay, silver, and gold. The great God was showing the king what will happen in the future. The dream is true, and its meaning is certain.”

Nebuchadnezzar Rewards Daniel

⁴⁶Then King Nebuchadnezzar threw himself down before Daniel and worshiped him, and he commanded his people to offer sacrifices and burn sweet incense before him. ⁴⁷The king said to Daniel, “Truly, your God is the greatest of gods, the Lord over kings, a revealer of mysteries, for you have been able to reveal this secret.”

⁴⁸Then the king appointed Daniel to a high position and gave him many valuable gifts. He made Daniel ruler over the whole province of Babylon, as well as chief over all his wise men. ⁴⁹At Daniel’s request, the king appointed Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego to be in charge of all the affairs of the province of Babylon, while Daniel remained in the king’s court.

3

Nebuchadnezzar’s Gold Statue

KING Nebuchadnezzar made a gold statue ninety feet tall and nine feet wide and set it up on the plain of Dura in the province of Babylon. ²Then he sent messages to the high officers, officials, governors, advisers, treasurers, judges, magistrates, and all the provincial officials to come to the dedication of the statue he had set up. ³So all these officials came and stood before the statue King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.

⁴Then a herald shouted out, “People of all races and nations and languages, listen to the king’s command! ⁵When you hear the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, pipes, and other musical instruments, bow to the ground to worship King Nebuchadnezzar’s gold statue. ⁶Anyone who refuses to obey will immediately be thrown into a blazing furnace.”

⁷So at the sound of the musical instruments, all the people, whatever their race or nation or language, bowed to the ground and worshiped the gold statue that King Nebuchadnezzar had set up.

⁸But some of the astrologers went to the king and informed on the Jews. ⁹They said to King Nebuchadnezzar, “Long live the king! ¹⁰You issued a decree requiring all the people to bow down and worship the gold statue when they hear the sound of the horn, flute, zither, lyre, harp, pipes, and other musical instruments. ¹¹That decree also states that those who refuse to obey must be thrown into a blazing furnace. ¹²But there are some Jews—Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego—whom you have put in charge of the province of Babylon. They pay no attention to you, Your Majesty. They refuse to serve your gods and do not worship the gold statue you have set up.”

¹³Then Nebuchadnezzar flew into a rage and ordered that Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego be brought before him. When they were brought in, ¹⁴Nebuchadnezzar said to them, “Is it true, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, that you refuse to serve my gods or to worship the gold statue I have set up? ¹⁵I will give you one more chance to bow down and worship the statue I have made when you hear the sound of the musical instruments. But if you refuse, you will be thrown immediately into the blazing furnace. And then what god will be able to rescue you from my power?”

¹⁶Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego replied, “O Nebuchadnezzar, we do not need to defend ourselves before you. ¹⁷If we are thrown into the blazing furnace, the God whom we serve is able to save us. He will rescue us from your power, Your Majesty. ¹⁸But even if he doesn’t, we want to make it clear to you, Your Majesty, that we will never serve your gods or worship the gold statue you have set up.”

The Blazing Furnace

¹⁹Nebuchadnezzar was so furious with Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego that his face became distorted with rage. He commanded that the furnace be heated seven times hotter than usual. ²⁰Then he ordered some of the strongest men of his army to bind Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego and throw them into the blazing furnace. ²¹So they tied them up and threw them into the furnace, fully dressed

in their pants, turbans, robes, and other garments. ²²And because the king, in his anger, had demanded such a hot fire in the furnace, the flames killed the soldiers as they threw the three men in. ²³So Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, securely tied, fell into the roaring flames.

²⁴But suddenly, Nebuchadnezzar jumped up in amazement and exclaimed to his advisers, "Didn't we tie up three men and throw them into the furnace?"

"Yes, Your Majesty, we certainly did," they replied.

²⁵"Look!" Nebuchadnezzar shouted. "I see four men, unbound, walking around in the fire unharmed! And the fourth looks like a god!"

²⁶Then Nebuchadnezzar came as close as he could to the door of the flaming furnace and shouted: "Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, servants of the Most High God, come out! Come here!"

So Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego stepped out of the fire. ²⁷Then the high officers, officials, governors, and advisers crowded around them and saw that the fire had not touched them. Not a hair on their heads was singed, and their clothing was not scorched. They didn't even smell of smoke!

²⁸Then Nebuchadnezzar said, "Praise to the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego! He sent his angel to rescue his servants who trusted in him. They defied the king's command and were willing to die rather than serve or worship any god except their own God. ²⁹Therefore, I make this decree: If any people, whatever their race or nation or language, speak a word against the God of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, they will be torn limb from limb, and their houses will be turned into heaps of rubble. There is no other god who can rescue like this!"

³⁰Then the king promoted Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego to even higher positions in the province of Babylon.

Nebuchadnezzar's Dream about a Tree



ING Nebuchadnezzar sent this message to the people of every race and nation and language throughout the world:

“Peace and prosperity to you! ²“I want you all to know about the miraculous signs and wonders the Most High God has performed for me.

³How great are his signs,
how powerful his wonders!
His kingdom will last forever,
his rule through all generations.

⁴“I, Nebuchadnezzar, was living in my palace in comfort and prosperity. ⁵But one night I had a dream that frightened me; I saw visions that terrified me as I lay in my bed. ⁶So I issued an order calling in all the wise men of Babylon, so they could tell me what my dream meant. ⁷When all the magicians, enchanters, astrologers, and fortune-tellers came in, I told them the dream, but they could not tell me what it meant. ⁸At last Daniel came in before me, and I told him the dream. (He was named Belteshazzar after my god, and the spirit of the holy gods is in him.)

⁹“I said to him, ‘Belteshazzar, chief of the magicians, I know that the spirit of the holy gods is in you and that no mystery is too great for you to solve. Now tell me what my dream means.

¹⁰“While I was lying in my bed, this is what I dreamed. I saw a large tree in the middle of the earth. ¹¹The tree grew very tall and strong, reaching high into the heavens for all the world to see. ¹²It had fresh green leaves, and it was loaded with fruit for all to eat. Wild animals lived in its shade, and birds nested in its branches. All the world was fed from this tree.

¹³“Then as I lay there dreaming, I saw a messenger, a holy one, coming down from heaven. ¹⁴The messenger shouted,

“Cut down the tree and lop off its branches!

Shake off its leaves and scatter its fruit!

Chase the wild animals from its shade

and the birds from its branches.

¹⁵But leave the stump and the roots in the ground,

bound with a band of iron and bronze

and surrounded by tender grass.

Now let him be drenched with the dew of heaven,

and let him live with the wild animals among the plants of the field.

¹⁶For seven periods of time,

let him have the mind of a wild animal

instead of the mind of a human.

¹⁷For this has been decreed by the messengers;

it is commanded by the holy ones,

so that everyone may know

that the Most High rules over the kingdoms of the world.

He gives them to anyone he chooses—

even to the lowliest of people.”

¹⁸“Belteshazzar, that was the dream that I, King Nebuchadnezzar, had. Now tell me what it means, for none of the wise

men of my kingdom can do so. But you can tell me because the spirit of the holy gods is in you.’

Daniel Explains the Dream

¹⁹“Upon hearing this, Daniel (also known as Belteshazzar) was overcome for a time, frightened by the meaning of the dream. Then the king said to him, ‘Belteshazzar, don’t be alarmed by the dream and what it means.’

“Belteshazzar replied, ‘I wish the events foreshadowed in this dream would happen to your enemies, my lord, and not to you!’ ²⁰The tree you saw was growing very tall and strong, reaching high into the heavens for all the world to see. ²¹It had fresh green leaves and was loaded with fruit for all to eat. Wild animals lived in its shade, and birds nested in its branches. ²²That tree, Your Majesty, is you. For you have grown strong and great; your greatness reaches up to heaven, and your rule to the ends of the earth.

²³“Then you saw a messenger, a holy one, coming down from heaven and saying, “Cut down the tree and destroy it. But leave the stump and the roots in the ground, bound with a band of iron and bronze and surrounded by tender grass. Let him be drenched with the dew of heaven. Let him live with the animals of the field for seven periods of time.”

²⁴“This is what the dream means, Your Majesty, and what the Most High has declared will happen to my lord the king. ²⁵You will be driven from human society, and you will live in the fields with the wild animals. You will eat grass like a cow, and you will be drenched with the dew of heaven. Seven periods of time will pass while you live this way, until you learn that the Most High rules over the kingdoms of the world

and gives them to anyone he chooses. ²⁶But the stump and roots of the tree were left in the ground. This means that you will receive your kingdom back again when you have learned that heaven rules.

²⁷“King Nebuchadnezzar, please accept my advice. Stop sinning and do what is right. Break from your wicked past and be merciful to the poor. Perhaps then you will continue to prosper.’

The Dream’s Fulfillment

²⁸“But all these things did happen to King Nebuchadnezzar. ²⁹Twelve months later he was taking a walk on the flat roof of the royal palace in Babylon. ³⁰As he looked out across the city, he said, ‘Look at this great city of Babylon! By my own mighty power, I have built this beautiful city as my royal residence to display my majestic splendor.’

³¹“While these words were still in his mouth, a voice called down from heaven, ‘O King Nebuchadnezzar, this message is for you! You are no longer ruler of this kingdom. ³²You will be driven from human society. You will live in the fields with the wild animals, and you will eat grass like a cow. Seven periods of time will pass while you live this way, until you learn that the Most High rules over the kingdoms of the world and gives them to anyone he chooses.’

³³“That same hour the judgment was fulfilled, and Nebuchadnezzar was driven from human society. He ate grass like a cow, and he was drenched with the dew of heaven. He lived this way until his hair was as long as eagles’ feathers and his nails were like birds’ claws.

Nebuchadnezzar Praises God

³⁴“After this time had passed, I, Nebuchadnezzar, looked up to heaven. My sanity returned, and I praised and worshiped the Most High and honored the one who lives forever.

His rule is everlasting,
and his kingdom is eternal.

³⁵All the people of the earth
are nothing compared to him.

He does as he pleases
among the angels of heaven
and among the people of the earth.

No one can stop him or say to him,
“What do you mean by doing these things?”

³⁶“When my sanity returned to me, so did my honor and glory and kingdom. My advisers and nobles sought me out, and I was restored as head of my kingdom, with even greater honor than before.

³⁷“Now I, Nebuchadnezzar, praise and glorify and honor the King of heaven. All his acts are just and true, and he is able to humble the proud.”

5

The Writing on the Wall



ANY years later King Belshazzar gave a great feast for 1,000 of his nobles, and he drank wine with them. ²While Belshazzar

was drinking the wine, he gave orders to bring in the gold and silver cups that his predecessor, Nebuchadnezzar, had taken from the Temple in Jerusalem. He wanted to drink from them with his nobles, his wives, and his concubines. ³So they brought these gold cups taken from the Temple, the house of God in Jerusalem, and the king and his nobles, his wives, and his concubines drank from them. ⁴While they drank from them they praised their idols made of gold, silver, bronze, iron, wood, and stone.

⁵Suddenly, they saw the fingers of a human hand writing on the plaster wall of the king's palace, near the lampstand. The king himself saw the hand as it wrote, ⁶and his face turned pale with fright. His knees knocked together in fear and his legs gave way beneath him.

⁷The king shouted for the enchanters, astrologers, and fortune-tellers to be brought before him. He said to these wise men of Babylon, "Whoever can read this writing and tell me what it means will be dressed in purple robes of royal honor and will have a gold chain placed around his neck. He will become the third highest ruler in the kingdom!"

⁸But when all the king's wise men had come in, none of them could read the writing or tell him what it meant. ⁹So the king grew even more alarmed, and his face turned pale. His nobles, too, were shaken.

¹⁰But when the queen mother heard what was happening, she hurried to the banquet hall. She said to Belshazzar, "Long live the king! Don't be so pale and frightened. ¹¹There is a man in your kingdom who has within him the spirit of the holy gods. During Nebuchadnezzar's reign, this man was found to have insight, understanding, and wisdom like that of the gods. Your predecessor, the king—your predecessor King Nebuchadnezzar—made him chief over all the magicians, enchanters, astrologers, and fortune-tellers of Babylon. ¹²This man Daniel, whom the king named Belteshazzar, has exceptional ability and is filled with divine knowledge and understanding. He can interpret dreams, explain riddles, and solve difficult problems. Call for Daniel, and he will tell you what the writing means."

Daniel Explains the Writing

¹³So Daniel was brought in before the king. The king asked him, “Are you Daniel, one of the exiles brought from Judah by my predecessor, King Nebuchadnezzar? ¹⁴I have heard that you have the spirit of the gods within you and that you are filled with insight, understanding, and wisdom. ¹⁵My wise men and enchanters have tried to read the words on the wall and tell me their meaning, but they cannot do it. ¹⁶I am told that you can give interpretations and solve difficult problems. If you can read these words and tell me their meaning, you will be clothed in purple robes of royal honor, and you will have a gold chain placed around your neck. You will become the third highest ruler in the kingdom.”

¹⁷Daniel answered the king, “Keep your gifts or give them to someone else, but I will tell you what the writing means. ¹⁸Your Majesty, the Most High God gave sovereignty, majesty, glory, and honor to your predecessor, Nebuchadnezzar. ¹⁹He made him so great that people of all races and nations and languages trembled before him in fear. He killed those he wanted to kill and spared those he wanted to spare. He honored those he wanted to honor and disgraced those he wanted to disgrace. ²⁰But when his heart and mind were puffed up with arrogance, he was brought down from his royal throne and stripped of his glory. ²¹He was driven from human society. He was given the mind of a wild animal, and he lived among the wild donkeys. He ate grass like a cow, and he was drenched with the dew of heaven, until he learned that the Most High God rules over the kingdoms of the world and appoints anyone he desires to rule over them.

²²“You are his successor, O Belshazzar, and you knew all this, yet you have not humbled yourself. ²³For you have proudly defied the Lord of heaven and have had these cups from his Temple brought before you. You and your nobles and your wives and concubines have been drinking wine from them while praising gods of silver, gold, bronze, iron, wood, and stone—gods that neither see nor hear nor know anything at all. But you have not honored the God who gives

you the breath of life and controls your destiny! ²⁴So God has sent this hand to write this message.

²⁵“This is the message that was written: Mene, Mene, Tekel, and Parsin. ²⁶This is what these words mean:

Mene means ‘numbered’—God has numbered the days of your reign and has brought it to an end.

²⁷Tekel means ‘weighed’—you have been weighed on the balances and have not measured up.

²⁸Parsin means ‘divided’—your kingdom has been divided and given to the Medes and Persians.”

²⁹Then at Belshazzar’s command, Daniel was dressed in purple robes, a gold chain was hung around his neck, and he was proclaimed the third highest ruler in the kingdom.

³⁰That very night Belshazzar, the Babylonian king, was killed.

31 And Darius the Mede took over the kingdom at the age of sixty-two.

6

Daniel in the Lions’ Den

DARIUS the Mede decided to divide the kingdom into 120 provinces, and he appointed a high officer to rule over each province. ²The king also chose Daniel and two others as administrators to supervise the high officers and protect the king’s interests. ³Daniel soon proved himself more capable than all the other administrators and high officers. Because of Daniel’s great ability, the king made plans to place him over the entire empire.

⁴Then the other administrators and high officers began searching for some fault in the way Daniel was handling government affairs, but they couldn’t find anything to criticize or condemn. He was faithful, always responsible, and completely trustworthy. ⁵So they concluded,

“Our only chance of finding grounds for accusing Daniel will be in connection with the rules of his religion.”

“So the administrators and high officers went to the king and said, “Long live King Darius! ⁷We are all in agreement—we administrators, officials, high officers, advisers, and governors—that the king should make a law that will be strictly enforced. Give orders that for the next thirty days any person who prays to anyone, divine or human—except to you, Your Majesty—will be thrown into the den of lions. ⁸And now, Your Majesty, issue and sign this law so it cannot be changed, an official law of the Medes and Persians that cannot be revoked.” ⁹So King Darius signed the law.

¹⁰But when Daniel learned that the law had been signed, he went home and knelt down as usual in his upstairs room, with its windows open toward Jerusalem. He prayed three times a day, just as he had always done, giving thanks to his God. ¹¹Then the officials went together to Daniel’s house and found him praying and asking for God’s help. ¹²So they went straight to the king and reminded him about his law. “Did you not sign a law that for the next thirty days any person who prays to anyone, divine or human—except to you, Your Majesty—will be thrown into the den of lions?”

“Yes,” the king replied, “that decision stands; it is an official law of the Medes and Persians that cannot be revoked.”

¹³Then they told the king, “That man Daniel, one of the captives from Judah, is ignoring you and your law. He still prays to his God three times a day.”

¹⁴Hearing this, the king was deeply troubled, and he tried to think of a way to save Daniel. He spent the rest of the day looking for a way to get Daniel out of this predicament.

¹⁵In the evening the men went together to the king and said, “Your Majesty, you know that according to the law of the Medes and the Persians, no law that the king signs can be changed.”

¹⁶So at last the king gave orders for Daniel to be arrested and thrown into the den of lions. The king said to him, “May your God, whom you serve so faithfully, rescue you.”

¹⁷A stone was brought and placed over the mouth of the den. The king sealed the stone with his own royal seal and the seals of his nobles, so that no one could rescue Daniel. ¹⁸Then the king returned to his palace and spent the night fasting. He refused his usual entertainment and couldn't sleep at all that night.

¹⁹Very early the next morning, the king got up and hurried out to the lions' den. ²⁰When he got there, he called out in anguish, "Daniel, servant of the living God! Was your God, whom you serve so faithfully, able to rescue you from the lions?"

²¹Daniel answered, "Long live the king! ²²My God sent his angel to shut the lions' mouths so that they would not hurt me, for I have been found innocent in his sight. And I have not wronged you, Your Majesty."

²³The king was overjoyed and ordered that Daniel be lifted from the den. Not a scratch was found on him, for he had trusted in his God.

²⁴Then the king gave orders to arrest the men who had maliciously accused Daniel. He had them thrown into the lions' den, along with their wives and children. The lions leaped on them and tore them apart before they even hit the floor of the den.

²⁵Then King Darius sent this message to the people of every race and nation and language throughout the world:

"Peace and prosperity to you!

²⁶"I decree that everyone throughout my kingdom should tremble with fear before the God of Daniel.

For he is the living God,
and he will endure forever.
His kingdom will never be destroyed,
and his rule will never end.

²⁷He rescues and saves his people;
he performs miraculous signs and wonders

in the heavens and on earth.
He has rescued Daniel
from the power of the lions.”

²⁸So Daniel prospered during the reign of Darius and the reign of Cyrus the Persian.

7

Daniel's Vision of Four Beasts

 **B**ARLIER, during the first year of King Belshazzar's reign in Babylon, Daniel had a dream and saw visions as he lay in his bed. He wrote down the dream, and this is what he saw.

²In my vision that night, I, Daniel, saw a great storm churning the surface of a great sea, with strong winds blowing from every direction.

³Then four huge beasts came up out of the water, each different from the others.

⁴The first beast was like a lion with eagles' wings. As I watched, its wings were pulled off, and it was left standing with its two hind feet on the ground, like a human being. And it was given a human mind.

⁵Then I saw a second beast, and it looked like a bear. It was rearing up on one side, and it had three ribs in its mouth between its teeth. And I heard a voice saying to it, “Get up! Devour the flesh of many people!”

⁶Then the third of these strange beasts appeared, and it looked like a leopard. It had four bird's wings on its back, and it had four heads. Great authority was given to this beast.

⁷Then in my vision that night, I saw a fourth beast—terrifying, dreadful, and very strong. It devoured and crushed its victims with huge iron teeth and trampled their remains beneath its feet. It was different from any of the other beasts, and it had ten horns.

⁸As I was looking at the horns, suddenly another small horn appeared among them. Three of the first horns were torn out by the

roots to make room for it. This little horn had eyes like human eyes and a mouth that was boasting arrogantly.

⁹I watched as thrones were put in place
and the Ancient One sat down to judge.
His clothing was as white as snow,
his hair like purest wool.
He sat on a fiery throne
with wheels of blazing fire,
¹⁰and a river of fire was pouring out,
flowing from his presence.
Millions of angels ministered to him;
many millions stood to attend him.
Then the court began its session,
and the books were opened.

¹¹I continued to watch because I could hear the little horn's boastful speech. I kept watching until the fourth beast was killed and its body was destroyed by fire. ¹²The other three beasts had their authority taken from them, but they were allowed to live a while longer.

¹³As my vision continued that night, I saw someone like a son of man coming with the clouds of heaven. He approached the Ancient One and was led into his presence. ¹⁴He was given authority, honor, and sovereignty over all the nations of the world, so that people of every race and nation and language would obey him. His rule is eternal—it will never end. His kingdom will never be destroyed.

The Vision Is Explained

¹⁵I, Daniel, was troubled by all I had seen, and my visions terrified me. ¹⁶So I approached one of those standing beside the throne and asked him what it all meant. He explained it to me like this: ¹⁷"These

four huge beasts represent four kingdoms that will arise from the earth. ¹⁸But in the end, the holy people of the Most High will be given the kingdom, and they will rule forever and ever.”

¹⁹Then I wanted to know the true meaning of the fourth beast, the one so different from the others and so terrifying. It had devoured and crushed its victims with iron teeth and bronze claws, trampling their remains beneath its feet. ²⁰I also asked about the ten horns on the fourth beast’s head and the little horn that came up afterward and destroyed three of the other horns. This horn had seemed greater than the others, and it had human eyes and a mouth that was boasting arrogantly. ²¹As I watched, this horn was waging war against God’s holy people and was defeating them, ²²until the Ancient One—the Most High—came and judged in favor of his holy people. Then the time arrived for the holy people to take over the kingdom.

²³Then he said to me, “This fourth beast is the fourth world power that will rule the earth. It will be different from all the others. It will devour the whole world, trampling and crushing everything in its path. ²⁴Its ten horns are ten kings who will rule that empire. Then another king will arise, different from the other ten, who will subdue three of them. ²⁵He will defy the Most High and oppress the holy people of the Most High. He will try to change their sacred festivals and laws, and they will be placed under his control for a time, times, and half a time.

²⁶“But then the court will pass judgment, and all his power will be taken away and completely destroyed. ²⁷Then the sovereignty, power, and greatness of all the kingdoms under heaven will be given to the holy people of the Most High. His kingdom will last forever, and all rulers will serve and obey him.”

²⁸That was the end of the vision. I, Daniel, was terrified by my thoughts and my face was pale with fear, but I kept these things to myself.

Daniel's Vision of a Ram and Goat

DURING the third year of King Belshazzar's reign, I, Daniel, saw another vision, following the one that had already appeared to me. ²In this vision I was at the fortress of Susa, in the province of Elam, standing beside the Ulai River.

³As I looked up, I saw a ram with two long horns standing beside the river. One of the horns was longer than the other, even though it had grown later than the other one. ⁴The ram butted everything out of his way to the west, to the north, and to the south, and no one could stand against him or help his victims. He did as he pleased and became very great.

⁵While I was watching, suddenly a male goat appeared from the west, crossing the land so swiftly that he didn't even touch the ground. This goat, which had one very large horn between its eyes, ⁶headed toward the two-horned ram that I had seen standing beside the river, rushing at him in a rage. ⁷The goat charged furiously at the ram and struck him, breaking off both his horns. Now the ram was helpless, and the goat knocked him down and trampled him. No one could rescue the ram from the goat's power.

⁸The goat became very powerful. But at the height of his power, his large horn was broken off. In the large horn's place grew four prominent horns pointing in the four directions of the earth. ⁹Then from one of the prominent horns came a small horn whose power grew very great. It extended toward the south and the east and toward the glorious land of Israel. ¹⁰Its power reached to the heavens, where it attacked the heavenly army, throwing some of the heavenly beings and some of the stars to the ground and trampling them. ¹¹It even challenged the Commander of heaven's army by canceling the daily sacrifices offered to him and by destroying his Temple. ¹²The army of heaven was restrained from responding to this rebellion. So the daily

sacrifice was halted, and truth was overthrown. The horn succeeded in everything it did.

¹³Then I heard two holy ones talking to each other. One of them asked, “How long will the events of this vision last? How long will the rebellion that causes desecration stop the daily sacrifices? How long will the Temple and heaven’s army be trampled on?”

¹⁴The other replied, “It will take 2,300 evenings and mornings; then the Temple will be made right again.”

Gabriel Explains the Vision

¹⁵As I, Daniel, was trying to understand the meaning of this vision, someone who looked like a man stood in front of me. ¹⁶And I heard a human voice calling out from the Ulai River, “Gabriel, tell this man the meaning of his vision.”

¹⁷As Gabriel approached the place where I was standing, I became so terrified that I fell with my face to the ground. “Son of man,” he said, “you must understand that the events you have seen in your vision relate to the time of the end.”

¹⁸While he was speaking, I fainted and lay there with my face to the ground. But Gabriel roused me with a touch and helped me to my feet.

¹⁹Then he said, “I am here to tell you what will happen later in the time of wrath. What you have seen pertains to the very end of time. ²⁰The two-horned ram represents the kings of Media and Persia.

²¹The shaggy male goat represents the king of Greece, and the large horn between his eyes represents the first king of the Greek Empire.

²²The four prominent horns that replaced the one large horn show that the Greek Empire will break into four kingdoms, but none as great as the first.

²³“At the end of their rule, when their sin is at its height, a fierce king, a master of intrigue, will rise to power. ²⁴He will become very strong, but not by his own power. He will cause a shocking amount of destruction and succeed in everything he does. He will destroy

powerful leaders and devastate the holy people. ²⁵He will be a master of deception and will become arrogant; he will destroy many without warning. He will even take on the Prince of princes in battle, but he will be broken, though not by human power.

²⁶“This vision about the 2,300 evenings and mornings is true. But none of these things will happen for a long time, so keep this vision a secret.”

²⁷Then I, Daniel, was overcome and lay sick for several days. Afterward I got up and performed my duties for the king, but I was greatly troubled by the vision and could not understand it.

9

Daniel's Prayer for His People

 It was the first year of the reign of Darius the Mede, the son of Ahasuerus, who became king of the Babylonians. ²During the first year of his reign, I, Daniel, learned from reading the word of the Lord, as revealed to Jeremiah the prophet, that Jerusalem must lie desolate for seventy years. ³So I turned to the Lord God and pleaded with him in prayer and fasting. I also wore rough burlap and sprinkled myself with ashes.

⁴I prayed to the Lord my God and confessed:

“O Lord, you are a great and awesome God! You always fulfill your covenant and keep your promises of unfailing love to those who love you and obey your commands. ⁵But we have sinned and done wrong. We have rebelled against you and scorned your commands and regulations. ⁶We have refused to listen to your servants the prophets, who spoke on your authority to our kings and princes and ancestors and to all the people of the land.

⁷“Lord, you are in the right; but as you see, our faces are covered with shame. This is true of all of us, including the

people of Judah and Jerusalem and all Israel, scattered near and far, wherever you have driven us because of our disloyalty to you. ⁸O Lord, we and our kings, princes, and ancestors are covered with shame because we have sinned against you. ⁹But the Lord our God is merciful and forgiving, even though we have rebelled against him. ¹⁰We have not obeyed the Lord our God, for we have not followed the instructions he gave us through his servants the prophets. ¹¹All Israel has disobeyed your instruction and turned away, refusing to listen to your voice.

“So now the solemn curses and judgments written in the Law of Moses, the servant of God, have been poured down on us because of our sin. ¹²You have kept your word and done to us and our rulers exactly as you warned. Never has there been such a disaster as happened in Jerusalem. ¹³Every curse written against us in the Law of Moses has come true. Yet we have refused to seek mercy from the Lord our God by turning from our sins and recognizing his truth. ¹⁴Therefore, the Lord has brought upon us the disaster he prepared. The Lord our God was right to do all of these things, for we did not obey him.

¹⁵“O Lord our God, you brought lasting honor to your name by rescuing your people from Egypt in a great display of power. But we have sinned and are full of wickedness. ¹⁶In view of all your faithful mercies, Lord, please turn your furious anger away from your city Jerusalem, your holy mountain. All the neighboring nations mock Jerusalem and your people because of our sins and the sins of our ancestors.

¹⁷“O our God, hear your servant’s prayer! Listen as I plead. For your own sake, Lord, smile again on your desolate sanctuary.

¹⁸“O my God, lean down and listen to me. Open your eyes and see our despair. See how your city—the city that bears your name—lies in ruins. We make this plea, not because we deserve help, but because of your mercy.

¹⁹“O Lord, hear. O Lord, forgive. O Lord, listen and act! For your own sake, do not delay, O my God, for your people and your city bear your name.”

Gabriel's Message about the Anointed One

²⁰I went on praying and confessing my sin and the sin of my people, pleading with the Lord my God for Jerusalem, his holy mountain. ²¹As I was praying, Gabriel, whom I had seen in the earlier vision, came swiftly to me at the time of the evening sacrifice. ²²He explained to me, “Daniel, I have come here to give you insight and understanding. ²³The moment you began praying, a command was given. And now I am here to tell you what it was, for you are very precious to God. Listen carefully so that you can understand the meaning of your vision.

²⁴“A period of seventy sets of seven has been decreed for your people and your holy city to finish their rebellion, to put an end to their sin, to atone for their guilt, to bring in everlasting righteousness, to confirm the prophetic vision, and to anoint the Most Holy Place. ²⁵Now listen and understand! Seven sets of seven plus sixty-two sets of seven will pass from the time the command is given to rebuild Jerusalem until a ruler—the Anointed One—comes. Jerusalem will be rebuilt with streets and strong defenses, despite the perilous times.

²⁶“After this period of sixty-two sets of seven, the Anointed One will be killed, appearing to have accomplished nothing, and a ruler will arise whose armies will destroy the city and the Temple. The end will come with a flood, and war and its miseries are decreed from that time to the very end. ²⁷The ruler will make a treaty with the people for a period of one set of seven, but after half this time, he will put an

end to the sacrifices and offerings. And as a climax to all his terrible deeds, he will set up a sacrilegious object that causes desecration, until the fate decreed for this defiler is finally poured out on him.”

10

Daniel’s Vision of a Messenger

IN the third year of the reign of King Cyrus of Persia, Daniel (also known as Belteshazzar) had another vision. He understood that the vision concerned events certain to happen in the future—times of war and great hardship.

²When this vision came to me, I, Daniel, had been in mourning for three whole weeks. ³All that time I had eaten no rich food. No meat or wine crossed my lips, and I used no fragrant lotions until those three weeks had passed.

⁴On April 23, as I was standing on the bank of the great Tigris River, ⁵I looked up and saw a man dressed in linen clothing, with a belt of pure gold around his waist. ⁶His body looked like a precious gem. His face flashed like lightning, and his eyes flamed like torches. His arms and feet shone like polished bronze, and his voice roared like a vast multitude of people.

⁷Only I, Daniel, saw this vision. The men with me saw nothing, but they were suddenly terrified and ran away to hide. ⁸So I was left there all alone to see this amazing vision. My strength left me, my face grew deathly pale, and I felt very weak. ⁹Then I heard the man speak, and when I heard the sound of his voice, I fainted and lay there with my face to the ground.

¹⁰Just then a hand touched me and lifted me, still trembling, to my hands and knees. ¹¹And the man said to me, “Daniel, you are very precious to God, so listen carefully to what I have to say to you. Stand up, for I have been sent to you.” When he said this to me, I stood up, still trembling.

¹²Then he said, “Don’t be afraid, Daniel. Since the first day you began to pray for understanding and to humble yourself before your God, your request has been heard in heaven. I have come in answer to your prayer. ¹³But for twenty-one days the spirit prince of the kingdom of Persia blocked my way. Then Michael, one of the archangels, came to help me, and I left him there with the spirit prince of the kingdom of Persia. ¹⁴Now I am here to explain what will happen to your people in the future, for this vision concerns a time yet to come.”

¹⁵While he was speaking to me, I looked down at the ground, unable to say a word. ¹⁶Then the one who looked like a man touched my lips, and I opened my mouth and began to speak. I said to the one standing in front of me, “I am filled with anguish because of the vision I have seen, my lord, and I am very weak. ¹⁷How can someone like me, your servant, talk to you, my lord? My strength is gone, and I can hardly breathe.”

¹⁸Then the one who looked like a man touched me again, and I felt my strength returning. ¹⁹“Don’t be afraid,” he said, “for you are very precious to God. Peace! Be encouraged! Be strong!”

As he spoke these words to me, I suddenly felt stronger and said to him, “Please speak to me, my lord, for you have strengthened me.”

²⁰He replied, “Do you know why I have come? Soon I must return to fight against the spirit prince of the kingdom of Persia, and after that the spirit prince of the kingdom of Greece will come. ²¹Meanwhile, I will tell you what is written in the Book of Truth. (No one helps me against these spirit princes except Michael, your spirit prince.

11



have been standing beside Michael to support and strengthen him since the first year of the reign of Darius the Mede.)

Kings of the South and North

²“Now then, I will reveal the truth to you. Three more Persian kings will reign, to be succeeded by a fourth, far richer than the others. He

will use his wealth to stir up everyone to fight against the kingdom of Greece.

³“Then a mighty king will rise to power who will rule with great authority and accomplish everything he sets out to do. ⁴But at the height of his power, his kingdom will be broken apart and divided into four parts. It will not be ruled by the king’s descendants, nor will the kingdom hold the authority it once had. For his empire will be uprooted and given to others.

⁵“The king of the south will increase in power, but one of his own officials will become more powerful than he and will rule his kingdom with great strength.

⁶“Some years later an alliance will be formed between the king of the north and the king of the south. The daughter of the king of the south will be given in marriage to the king of the north to secure the alliance, but she will lose her influence over him, and so will her father. She will be abandoned along with her supporters. ⁷But when one of her relatives becomes king of the south, he will raise an army and enter the fortress of the king of the north and defeat him. ⁸When he returns to Egypt, he will carry back their idols with him, along with priceless articles of gold and silver. For some years afterward he will leave the king of the north alone.

⁹“Later the king of the north will invade the realm of the king of the south but will soon return to his own land. ¹⁰However, the sons of the king of the north will assemble a mighty army that will advance like a flood and carry the battle as far as the enemy’s fortress.

¹¹“Then, in a rage, the king of the south will rally against the vast forces assembled by the king of the north and will defeat them. ¹²After the enemy army is swept away, the king of the south will be filled with pride and will execute many thousands of his enemies. But his success will be short lived.

¹³“A few years later the king of the north will return with a fully equipped army far greater than before. ¹⁴At that time there will be a general uprising against the king of the south. Violent men among your own people will join them in fulfillment of this vision, but they

will not succeed. ¹⁵Then the king of the north will come and lay siege to a fortified city and capture it. The best troops of the south will not be able to stand in the face of the onslaught.

¹⁶“The king of the north will march onward unopposed; none will be able to stop him. He will pause in the glorious land of Israel, intent on destroying it. ¹⁷He will make plans to come with the might of his entire kingdom and will form an alliance with the king of the south. He will give him a daughter in marriage in order to overthrow the kingdom from within, but his plan will fail.

¹⁸“After this, he will turn his attention to the coastland and conquer many cities. But a commander from another land will put an end to his insolence and cause him to retreat in shame. ¹⁹He will take refuge in his own fortresses but will stumble and fall and be seen no more.

²⁰“His successor will send out a tax collector to maintain the royal splendor. But after a very brief reign, he will die, though not from anger or in battle.

²¹“The next to come to power will be a despicable man who is not in line for royal succession. He will slip in when least expected and take over the kingdom by flattery and intrigue. ²²Before him great armies will be swept away, including a covenant prince. ²³With deceitful promises, he will make various alliances. He will become strong despite having only a handful of followers. ²⁴Without warning he will enter the richest areas of the land. Then he will distribute among his followers the plunder and wealth of the rich—something his predecessors had never done. He will plot the overthrow of strongholds, but this will last for only a short while.

²⁵“Then he will stir up his courage and raise a great army against the king of the south. The king of the south will go to battle with a mighty army, but to no avail, for there will be plots against him. ²⁶His own household will cause his downfall. His army will be swept away, and many will be killed. ²⁷Seeking nothing but each other’s harm, these kings will plot against each other at the conference table, attempting to deceive each other. But it will make no difference, for the end will come at the appointed time.

²⁸“The king of the north will then return home with great riches. On the way he will set himself against the people of the holy covenant, doing much damage before continuing his journey.

²⁹“Then at the appointed time he will once again invade the south, but this time the result will be different. ³⁰For warships from western coastlands will scare him off, and he will withdraw and return home. But he will vent his anger against the people of the holy covenant and reward those who forsake the covenant.

³¹“His army will take over the Temple fortress, pollute the sanctuary, put a stop to the daily sacrifices, and set up the sacrilegious object that causes desecration. ³²He will flatter and win over those who have violated the covenant. But the people who know their God will be strong and will resist him.

³³“Wise leaders will give instruction to many, but these teachers will die by fire and sword, or they will be jailed and robbed. ³⁴During these persecutions, little help will arrive, and many who join them will not be sincere. ³⁵And some of the wise will fall victim to persecution. In this way, they will be refined and cleansed and made pure until the time of the end, for the appointed time is still to come.

³⁶“The king will do as he pleases, exalting himself and claiming to be greater than every god, even blaspheming the God of gods. He will succeed, but only until the time of wrath is completed. For what has been determined will surely take place. ³⁷He will have no respect for the gods of his ancestors, or for the god loved by women, or for any other god, for he will boast that he is greater than them all. ³⁸Instead of these, he will worship the god of fortresses—a god his ancestors never knew—and lavish on him gold, silver, precious stones, and expensive gifts. ³⁹Claiming this foreign god’s help, he will attack the strongest fortresses. He will honor those who submit to him, appointing them to positions of authority and dividing the land among them as their reward.

⁴⁰“Then at the time of the end, the king of the south will attack the king of the north. The king of the north will storm out with chariots, charioteers, and a vast navy. He will invade various lands and sweep

through them like a flood. ⁴¹He will enter the glorious land of Israel, and many nations will fall, but Moab, Edom, and the best part of Ammon will escape. ⁴²He will conquer many countries, and even Egypt will not escape. ⁴³He will gain control over the gold, silver, and treasures of Egypt, and the Libyans and Ethiopians will be his servants.

⁴⁴“But then news from the east and the north will alarm him, and he will set out in great anger to destroy and obliterate many. ⁴⁵He will stop between the glorious holy mountain and the sea and will pitch his royal tents. But while he is there, his time will suddenly run out, and no one will help him.

12

The Time of the End

T that time Michael, the archangel who stands guard over your nation, will arise. Then there will be a time of anguish greater than any since nations first came into existence. But at that time every one of your people whose name is written in the book will be rescued. ²Many of those whose bodies lie dead and buried will rise up, some to everlasting life and some to shame and everlasting disgrace. ³Those who are wise will shine as bright as the sky, and those who lead many to righteousness will shine like the stars forever. ⁴But you, Daniel, keep this prophecy a secret; seal up the book until the time of the end, when many will rush here and there, and knowledge will increase.”

⁵Then I, Daniel, looked and saw two others standing on opposite banks of the river. ⁶One of them asked the man dressed in linen, who was now standing above the river, “How long will it be until these shocking events are over?”

⁷The man dressed in linen, who was standing above the river, raised both his hands toward heaven and took a solemn oath by the One who lives forever, saying, “It will go on for a time, times, and half a

time. When the shattering of the holy people has finally come to an end, all these things will have happened.”

⁸I heard what he said, but I did not understand what he meant. So I asked, “How will all this finally end, my lord?”

⁹But he said, “Go now, Daniel, for what I have said is kept secret and sealed until the time of the end. ¹⁰Many will be purified, cleansed, and refined by these trials. But the wicked will continue in their wickedness, and none of them will understand. Only those who are wise will know what it means.

¹¹“From the time the daily sacrifice is stopped and the sacrilegious object that causes desecration is set up to be worshiped, there will be 1,290 days. ¹²And blessed are those who wait and remain until the end of the 1,335 days!

¹³“As for you, go your way until the end. You will rest, and then at the end of the days, you will rise again to receive the inheritance set aside for you.”

Esther

The Greek additions to Esther (Chapters A-F in Catholic editions) are collected in Volume IV, The Apocrypha

1

The King's Banquet

HESE events happened in the days of King Xerxes, who reigned over 127 provinces stretching from India to Ethiopia. ²At that time Xerxes ruled his empire from his royal throne at the fortress of Susa. ³In the third year of his reign, he gave a banquet for all his nobles and officials. He invited all the military officers of Persia and Media as well as the princes and nobles of the provinces. ⁴The celebration lasted 180 days—a tremendous display of the opulent wealth of his empire and the pomp and splendor of his majesty.

⁵When it was all over, the king gave a banquet for all the people, from the greatest to the least, who were in the fortress of Susa. It lasted for seven days and was held in the courtyard of the palace garden. ⁶The courtyard was beautifully decorated with white cotton curtains and blue hangings, which were fastened with white linen cords and purple

ribbons to silver rings embedded in marble pillars. Gold and silver couches stood on a mosaic pavement of porphyry, marble, mother-of-pearl, and other costly stones.

⁷Drinks were served in gold goblets of many designs, and there was an abundance of royal wine, reflecting the king's generosity. ⁸By edict of the king, no limits were placed on the drinking, for the king had instructed all his palace officials to serve each man as much as he wanted.

⁹At the same time, Queen Vashti gave a banquet for the women in the royal palace of King Xerxes.

Queen Vashti Deposed

¹⁰On the seventh day of the feast, when King Xerxes was in high spirits because of the wine, he told the seven eunuchs who attended him—Mehuman, Biztha, Harbona, Bigtha, Abagtha, Zethar, and Carcas—¹¹to bring Queen Vashti to him with the royal crown on her head. He wanted the nobles and all the other men to gaze on her beauty, for she was a very beautiful woman. ¹²But when they conveyed the king's order to Queen Vashti, she refused to come. This made the king furious, and he burned with anger.

¹³He immediately consulted with his wise advisers, who knew all the Persian laws and customs, for he always asked their advice. ¹⁴The names of these men were Carshena, Shethar, Admatha, Tarshish, Meres, Marsena, and Memucan—seven nobles of Persia and Media. They met with the king regularly and held the highest positions in the empire.

¹⁵“What must be done to Queen Vashti?” the king demanded. “What penalty does the law provide for a queen who refuses to obey the king's orders, properly sent through his eunuchs?”

¹⁶Memucan answered the king and his nobles, “Queen Vashti has wronged not only the king but also every noble and citizen throughout your empire. ¹⁷Women everywhere will begin to despise their husbands when they learn that Queen Vashti has refused to appear

before the king. ¹⁸Before this day is out, the wives of all the king's nobles throughout Persia and Media will hear what the queen did and will start treating their husbands the same way. There will be no end to their contempt and anger.

¹⁹"So if it please the king, we suggest that you issue a written decree, a law of the Persians and Medes that cannot be revoked. It should order that Queen Vashti be forever banished from the presence of King Xerxes, and that the king should choose another queen more worthy than she. ²⁰When this decree is published throughout the king's vast empire, husbands everywhere, whatever their rank, will receive proper respect from their wives!"

²¹The king and his nobles thought this made good sense, so he followed Memucan's counsel. ²²He sent letters to all parts of the empire, to each province in its own script and language, proclaiming that every man should be the ruler of his own home and should say whatever he pleases.

2

Esther Becomes Queen

BUT after Xerxes' anger had subsided, he began thinking about Vashti and what she had done and the decree he had made. ²So his personal attendants suggested, "Let us search the empire to find beautiful young virgins for the king. ³Let the king appoint agents in each province to bring these beautiful young women into the royal harem at the fortress of Susa. Hegai, the king's eunuch in charge of the harem, will see that they are all given beauty treatments. ⁴After that, the young woman who most pleases the king will be made queen instead of Vashti." This advice was very appealing to the king, so he put the plan into effect.

⁵At that time there was a Jewish man in the fortress of Susa whose name was Mordecai son of Jair. He was from the tribe of Benjamin and was a descendant of Kish and Shimei. ⁶His family had been

among those who, with King Jehoiachin of Judah, had been exiled from Jerusalem to Babylon by King Nebuchadnezzar. ⁷This man had a very beautiful and lovely young cousin, Hadassah, who was also called Esther. When her father and mother died, Mordecai adopted her into his family and raised her as his own daughter.

⁸As a result of the king's decree, Esther, along with many other young women, was brought to the king's harem at the fortress of Susa and placed in Hegai's care. ⁹Hegai was very impressed with Esther and treated her kindly. He quickly ordered a special menu for her and provided her with beauty treatments. He also assigned her seven maids specially chosen from the king's palace, and he moved her and her maids into the best place in the harem.

¹⁰Esther had not told anyone of her nationality and family background, because Mordecai had directed her not to do so. ¹¹Every day Mordecai would take a walk near the courtyard of the harem to find out about Esther and what was happening to her.

¹²Before each young woman was taken to the king's bed, she was given the prescribed twelve months of beauty treatments—six months with oil of myrrh, followed by six months with special perfumes and ointments. ¹³When it was time for her to go to the king's palace, she was given her choice of whatever clothing or jewelry she wanted to take from the harem. ¹⁴That evening she was taken to the king's private rooms, and the next morning she was brought to the second harem, where the king's wives lived. There she would be under the care of Shaashgaz, the king's eunuch in charge of the concubines. She would never go to the king again unless he had especially enjoyed her and requested her by name.

¹⁵Esther was the daughter of Abihail, who was Mordecai's uncle. (Mordecai had adopted his younger cousin Esther.) When it was Esther's turn to go to the king, she accepted the advice of Hegai, the eunuch in charge of the harem. She asked for nothing except what he suggested, and she was admired by everyone who saw her.

¹⁶Esther was taken to King Xerxes at the royal palace in early winter of the seventh year of his reign. ¹⁷And the king loved Esther more than

any of the other young women. He was so delighted with her that he set the royal crown on her head and declared her queen instead of Vashti. ¹⁸To celebrate the occasion, he gave a great banquet in Esther's honor for all his nobles and officials, declaring a public holiday for the provinces and giving generous gifts to everyone.

¹⁹Even after all the young women had been transferred to the second harem and Mordecai had become a palace official, ²⁰Esther continued to keep her family background and nationality a secret. She was still following Mordecai's directions, just as she did when she lived in his home.

Mordecai's Loyalty to the King

²¹One day as Mordecai was on duty at the king's gate, two of the king's eunuchs, Bigthana and Teresh—who were guards at the door of the king's private quarters—became angry at King Xerxes and plotted to assassinate him. ²²But Mordecai heard about the plot and gave the information to Queen Esther. She then told the king about it and gave Mordecai credit for the report. ²³When an investigation was made and Mordecai's story was found to be true, the two men were impaled on a sharpened pole. This was all recorded in The Book of the History of King Xerxes' Reign.

3

Haman's Plot against the Jews



OME time later King Xerxes promoted Haman son of Hammedatha the Agagite over all the other nobles, making him the most powerful official in the empire. ²All the king's officials would bow down before Haman to show him respect whenever he passed by, for so the king had commanded. But Mordecai refused to bow down or show him respect.

³Then the palace officials at the king's gate asked Mordecai, "Why are you disobeying the king's command?" ⁴They spoke to him day after day, but still he refused to comply with the order. So they spoke to Haman about this to see if he would tolerate Mordecai's conduct, since Mordecai had told them he was a Jew.

⁵When Haman saw that Mordecai would not bow down or show him respect, he was filled with rage. ⁶He had learned of Mordecai's nationality, so he decided it was not enough to lay hands on Mordecai alone. Instead, he looked for a way to destroy all the Jews throughout the entire empire of Xerxes.

⁷So in the month of April, during the twelfth year of King Xerxes' reign, lots were cast in Haman's presence (the lots were called purim) to determine the best day and month to take action. And the day selected was March 7, nearly a year later.

⁸Then Haman approached King Xerxes and said, "There is a certain race of people scattered through all the provinces of your empire who keep themselves separate from everyone else. Their laws are different from those of any other people, and they refuse to obey the laws of the king. So it is not in the king's interest to let them live. ⁹If it please the king, issue a decree that they be destroyed, and I will give 10,000 large sacks of silver to the government administrators to be deposited in the royal treasury."

¹⁰The king agreed, confirming his decision by removing his signet ring from his finger and giving it to Haman son of Hammedatha the Agagite, the enemy of the Jews. ¹¹The king said, "The money and the people are both yours to do with as you see fit."

¹²So on April 17 the king's secretaries were summoned, and a decree was written exactly as Haman dictated. It was sent to the king's highest officers, the governors of the respective provinces, and the nobles of each province in their own scripts and languages. The decree was written in the name of King Xerxes and sealed with the king's signet ring. ¹³Dispatches were sent by swift messengers into all the provinces of the empire, giving the order that all Jews—young and old, including women and children—must be killed, slaughtered, and annihilated

on a single day. This was scheduled to happen on March 7 of the next year. The property of the Jews would be given to those who killed them.

¹⁴A copy of this decree was to be issued as law in every province and proclaimed to all peoples, so that they would be ready to do their duty on the appointed day. ¹⁵At the king's command, the decree went out by swift messengers, and it was also proclaimed in the fortress of Susa. Then the king and Haman sat down to drink, but the city of Susa fell into confusion.

4

Mordecai Requests Esther's Help

WHEN Mordecai learned about all that had been done, he tore his clothes, put on burlap and ashes, and went out into the city, crying with a loud and bitter wail. ²He went as far as the gate of the palace, for no one was allowed to enter the palace gate while wearing clothes of mourning. ³And as news of the king's decree reached all the provinces, there was great mourning among the Jews. They fasted, wept, and wailed, and many people lay in burlap and ashes.

⁴When Queen Esther's maids and eunuchs came and told her about Mordecai, she was deeply distressed. She sent clothing to him to replace the burlap, but he refused it. ⁵Then Esther sent for Hathach, one of the king's eunuchs who had been appointed as her attendant. She ordered him to go to Mordecai and find out what was troubling him and why he was in mourning. ⁶So Hathach went out to Mordecai in the square in front of the palace gate.

⁷Mordecai told him the whole story, including the exact amount of money Haman had promised to pay into the royal treasury for the destruction of the Jews. ⁸Mordecai gave Hathach a copy of the decree issued in Susa that called for the death of all Jews. He asked Hathach to show it to Esther and explain the situation to her. He also asked

Hathach to direct her to go to the king to beg for mercy and plead for her people. ⁹So Hathach returned to Esther with Mordecai's message.

¹⁰Then Esther told Hathach to go back and relay this message to Mordecai: ¹¹"All the king's officials and even the people in the provinces know that anyone who appears before the king in his inner court without being invited is doomed to die unless the king holds out his gold scepter. And the king has not called for me to come to him for thirty days." ¹²So Hathach gave Esther's message to Mordecai.

¹³Mordecai sent this reply to Esther: "Don't think for a moment that because you're in the palace you will escape when all other Jews are killed. ¹⁴If you keep quiet at a time like this, deliverance and relief for the Jews will arise from some other place, but you and your relatives will die. Who knows if perhaps you were made queen for just such a time as this?"

¹⁵Then Esther sent this reply to Mordecai: ¹⁶"Go and gather together all the Jews of Susa and fast for me. Do not eat or drink for three days, night or day. My maids and I will do the same. And then, though it is against the law, I will go in to see the king. If I must die, I must die." ¹⁷So Mordecai went away and did everything as Esther had ordered him.

5

Esther's Request to the King

N the third day of the fast, Esther put on her royal robes and entered the inner court of the palace, just across from the king's hall. The king was sitting on his royal throne, facing the entrance. ²When he saw Queen Esther standing there in the inner court, he welcomed her and held out the gold scepter to her. So Esther approached and touched the end of the scepter.

³Then the king asked her, "What do you want, Queen Esther? What is your request? I will give it to you, even if it is half the kingdom!"

⁴And Esther replied, “If it please the king, let the king and Haman come today to a banquet I have prepared for the king.”

⁵The king turned to his attendants and said, “Tell Haman to come quickly to a banquet, as Esther has requested.” So the king and Haman went to Esther’s banquet.

⁶And while they were drinking wine, the king said to Esther, “Now tell me what you really want. What is your request? I will give it to you, even if it is half the kingdom!”

⁷Esther replied, “This is my request and deepest wish. ⁸If I have found favor with the king, and if it pleases the king to grant my request and do what I ask, please come with Haman tomorrow to the banquet I will prepare for you. Then I will explain what this is all about.”

Haman’s Plan to Kill Mordecai

⁹Haman was a happy man as he left the banquet! But when he saw Mordecai sitting at the palace gate, not standing up or trembling nervously before him, Haman became furious. ¹⁰However, he restrained himself and went on home.

Then Haman gathered together his friends and Zeresh, his wife, ¹¹and boasted to them about his great wealth and his many children. He bragged about the honors the king had given him and how he had been promoted over all the other nobles and officials.

¹²Then Haman added, “And that’s not all! Queen Esther invited only me and the king himself to the banquet she prepared for us. And she has invited me to dine with her and the king again tomorrow!” ¹³Then he added, “But this is all worth nothing as long as I see Mordecai the Jew just sitting there at the palace gate.”

¹⁴So Haman’s wife, Zeresh, and all his friends suggested, “Set up a sharpened pole that stands seventy-five feet tall, and in the morning ask the king to impale Mordecai on it. When this is done, you can go on your merry way to the banquet with the king.” This pleased Haman, and he ordered the pole set up.

6**The King Honors Mordecai**

THAT night the king had trouble sleeping, so he ordered an attendant to bring the book of the history of his reign so it could be read to him. ²In those records he discovered an account of how Mordecai had exposed the plot of Bigthana and Teresh, two of the eunuchs who guarded the door to the king's private quarters. They had plotted to assassinate King Xerxes.

³"What reward or recognition did we ever give Mordecai for this?" the king asked.

His attendants replied, "Nothing has been done for him."

⁴"Who is that in the outer court?" the king inquired. As it happened, Haman had just arrived in the outer court of the palace to ask the king to impale Mordecai on the pole he had prepared.

⁵So the attendants replied to the king, "Haman is out in the court."

"Bring him in," the king ordered. ⁶So Haman came in, and the king said, "What should I do to honor a man who truly pleases me?"

Haman thought to himself, "Whom would the king wish to honor more than me?" ⁷So he replied, "If the king wishes to honor someone, ⁸he should bring out one of the king's own royal robes, as well as a horse that the king himself has ridden—one with a royal emblem on its head. ⁹Let the robes and the horse be handed over to one of the king's most noble officials. And let him see that the man whom the king wishes to honor is dressed in the king's robes and led through the city square on the king's horse. Have the official shout as they go, 'This is what the king does for someone he wishes to honor!'"

¹⁰"Excellent!" the king said to Haman. "Quick! Take the robes and my horse, and do just as you have said for Mordecai the Jew, who sits at the gate of the palace. Leave out nothing you have suggested!"

¹¹So Haman took the robes and put them on Mordecai, placed him on the king's own horse, and led him through the city square, shouting, "This is what the king does for someone he wishes to honor!"

¹²Afterward Mordecai returned to the palace gate, but Haman hurried home dejected and completely humiliated.

¹³When Haman told his wife, Zeresh, and all his friends what had happened, his wise advisers and his wife said, “Since Mordecai—this man who has humiliated you—is of Jewish birth, you will never succeed in your plans against him. It will be fatal to continue opposing him.”

¹⁴While they were still talking, the king’s eunuchs arrived and quickly took Haman to the banquet Esther had prepared.

7

The King Executes Haman

o the king and Haman went to Queen Esther’s banquet. ²On this second occasion, while they were drinking wine, the king again said to Esther, “Tell me what you want, Queen Esther. What is your request? I will give it to you, even if it is half the kingdom!”

³Queen Esther replied, “If I have found favor with the king, and if it pleases the king to grant my request, I ask that my life and the lives of my people will be spared. ⁴For my people and I have been sold to those who would kill, slaughter, and annihilate us. If we had merely been sold as slaves, I could remain quiet, for that would be too trivial a matter to warrant disturbing the king.”

⁵“Who would do such a thing?” King Xerxes demanded. “Who would be so presumptuous as to touch you?”

⁶Esther replied, “This wicked Haman is our adversary and our enemy.” Haman grew pale with fright before the king and queen. ⁷Then the king jumped to his feet in a rage and went out into the palace garden.

Haman, however, stayed behind to plead for his life with Queen Esther, for he knew that the king intended to kill him. ⁸In despair he fell on the couch where Queen Esther was reclining, just as the king was returning from the palace garden.

The king exclaimed, “Will he even assault the queen right here in the palace, before my very eyes?” And as soon as the king spoke, his attendants covered Haman’s face, signaling his doom.

⁹Then Harbona, one of the king’s eunuchs, said, “Haman has set up a sharpened pole that stands seventy-five feet tall in his own courtyard. He intended to use it to impale Mordecai, the man who saved the king from assassination.”

“Then impale Haman on it!” the king ordered. ¹⁰So they impaled Haman on the pole he had set up for Mordecai, and the king’s anger subsided.

8

A Decree to Help the Jews

N that same day King Xerxes gave the property of Haman, the enemy of the Jews, to Queen Esther. Then Mordecai was brought before the king, for Esther had told the king how they were related. ²The king took off his signet ring—which he had taken back from Haman—and gave it to Mordecai. And Esther appointed Mordecai to be in charge of Haman’s property.

³Then Esther went again before the king, falling down at his feet and begging him with tears to stop the evil plot devised by Haman the Agagite against the Jews. ⁴Again the king held out the gold scepter to Esther. So she rose and stood before him.

⁵Esther said, “If it please the king, and if I have found favor with him, and if he thinks it is right, and if I am pleasing to him, let there be a decree that reverses the orders of Haman son of Hammedatha the Agagite, who ordered that Jews throughout all the king’s provinces should be destroyed. ⁶For how can I endure to see my people and my family slaughtered and destroyed?”

⁷Then King Xerxes said to Queen Esther and Mordecai the Jew, “I have given Esther the property of Haman, and he has been impaled on a pole because he tried to destroy the Jews. ⁸Now go ahead and

send a message to the Jews in the king's name, telling them whatever you want, and seal it with the king's signet ring. But remember that whatever has already been written in the king's name and sealed with his signet ring can never be revoked."

⁹So on June 25 the king's secretaries were summoned, and a decree was written exactly as Mordecai dictated. It was sent to the Jews and to the highest officers, the governors, and the nobles of all the 127 provinces stretching from India to Ethiopia. The decree was written in the scripts and languages of all the peoples of the empire, including that of the Jews. ¹⁰The decree was written in the name of King Xerxes and sealed with the king's signet ring. Mordecai sent the dispatches by swift messengers, who rode fast horses especially bred for the king's service.

¹¹The king's decree gave the Jews in every city authority to unite to defend their lives. They were allowed to kill, slaughter, and annihilate anyone of any nationality or province who might attack them or their children and wives, and to take the property of their enemies. ¹²The day chosen for this event throughout all the provinces of King Xerxes was March 7 of the next year.

¹³A copy of this decree was to be issued as law in every province and proclaimed to all peoples, so that the Jews would be ready to take revenge on their enemies on the appointed day. ¹⁴So urged on by the king's command, the messengers rode out swiftly on fast horses bred for the king's service. The same decree was also proclaimed in the fortress of Susa.

¹⁵Then Mordecai left the king's presence, wearing the royal robe of blue and white, the great crown of gold, and an outer cloak of fine linen and purple. And the people of Susa celebrated the new decree. ¹⁶The Jews were filled with joy and gladness and were honored everywhere. ¹⁷In every province and city, wherever the king's decree arrived, the Jews rejoiced and had a great celebration and declared a public festival and holiday. And many of the people of the land became Jews themselves, for they feared what the Jews might do to them.

The Victory of the Jews

So on March 7 the two decrees of the king were put into effect. On that day, the enemies of the Jews had hoped to overpower them, but quite the opposite happened. It was the Jews who overpowered their enemies. ²The Jews gathered in their cities throughout all the king's provinces to attack anyone who tried to harm them. But no one could make a stand against them, for everyone was afraid of them. ³And all the nobles of the provinces, the highest officers, the governors, and the royal officials helped the Jews for fear of Mordecai. ⁴For Mordecai had been promoted in the king's palace, and his fame spread throughout all the provinces as he became more and more powerful.

⁵So the Jews went ahead on the appointed day and struck down their enemies with the sword. They killed and annihilated their enemies and did as they pleased with those who hated them. ⁶In the fortress of Susa itself, the Jews killed 500 men. ⁷They also killed Parshandatha, Dalphon, Aspatha, ⁸Poratha, Adalia, Aridatha, ⁹Parmashta, Arisai, Aridai, and Vaizatha— ¹⁰the ten sons of Haman son of Hammedatha, the enemy of the Jews. But they did not take any plunder.

¹¹That very day, when the king was informed of the number of people killed in the fortress of Susa, ¹²he called for Queen Esther. He said, "The Jews have killed 500 men in the fortress of Susa alone, as well as Haman's ten sons. If they have done that here, what has happened in the rest of the provinces? But now, what more do you want? It will be granted to you; tell me and I will do it."

¹³Esther responded, "If it please the king, give the Jews in Susa permission to do again tomorrow as they have done today, and let the bodies of Haman's ten sons be impaled on a pole."

¹⁴So the king agreed, and the decree was announced in Susa. And they impaled the bodies of Haman's ten sons. ¹⁵Then the Jews at

Susa gathered together on March 8 and killed 300 more men, and again they took no plunder.

¹⁶Meanwhile, the other Jews throughout the king's provinces had gathered together to defend their lives. They gained relief from all their enemies, killing 75,000 of those who hated them. But they did not take any plunder. ¹⁷This was done throughout the provinces on March 7, and on March 8 they rested, celebrating their victory with a day of feasting and gladness. ¹⁸(The Jews at Susa killed their enemies on March 7 and again on March 8, then rested on March 9, making that their day of feasting and gladness.) ¹⁹So to this day, rural Jews living in remote villages celebrate an annual festival and holiday on the appointed day in late winter, when they rejoice and send gifts of food to each other.

The Festival of Purim

²⁰Mordecai recorded these events and sent letters to the Jews near and far, throughout all the provinces of King Xerxes, ²¹calling on them to celebrate an annual festival on these two days. ²²He told them to celebrate these days with feasting and gladness and by giving gifts of food to each other and presents to the poor. This would commemorate a time when the Jews gained relief from their enemies, when their sorrow was turned into gladness and their mourning into joy.

²³So the Jews accepted Mordecai's proposal and adopted this annual custom. ²⁴Haman son of Hammedatha the Agagite, the enemy of the Jews, had plotted to crush and destroy them on the date determined by casting lots (the lots were called purim). ²⁵But when Esther came before the king, he issued a decree causing Haman's evil plot to backfire, and Haman and his sons were impaled on a sharpened pole. ²⁶That is why this celebration is called Purim, because it is the ancient word for casting lots.

So because of Mordecai's letter and because of what they had experienced, ²⁷the Jews throughout the realm agreed to inaugurate this

tradition and to pass it on to their descendants and to all who became Jews. They declared they would never fail to celebrate these two prescribed days at the appointed time each year. ²⁸These days would be remembered and kept from generation to generation and celebrated by every family throughout the provinces and cities of the empire. This Festival of Purim would never cease to be celebrated among the Jews, nor would the memory of what happened ever die out among their descendants.

²⁹Then Queen Esther, the daughter of Abihail, along with Mordecai the Jew, wrote another letter putting the queen's full authority behind Mordecai's letter to establish the Festival of Purim. ³⁰Letters wishing peace and security were sent to the Jews throughout the 127 provinces of the empire of Xerxes. ³¹These letters established the Festival of Purim—an annual celebration of these days at the appointed time, decreed by both Mordecai the Jew and Queen Esther. (The people decided to observe this festival, just as they had decided for themselves and their descendants to establish the times of fasting and mourning.) ³²So the command of Esther confirmed the practices of Purim, and it was all written down in the records.

10

The Greatness of Xerxes and Mordecai

ING Xerxes imposed a tribute throughout his empire, even to the distant coastlands. ²His great achievements and the full account of the greatness of Mordecai, whom the king had promoted, are recorded in The Book of the History of the Kings of Media and Persia. ³Mordecai the Jew became the prime minister, with authority next to that of King Xerxes himself. He was very great among the Jews, who held him in high esteem, because he continued to work for the good of his people and to speak up for the welfare of all their descendants.

Ezra

1

Cyrus Allows the Exiles to Return

IN the first year of King Cyrus of Persia, the Lord fulfilled the prophecy he had given through Jeremiah. He stirred the heart of Cyrus to put this proclamation in writing and to send it throughout his kingdom:

²“This is what King Cyrus of Persia says:

“The Lord, the God of heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth. He has appointed me to build him a Temple at Jerusalem, which is in Judah. ³Any of you who are his people may go to Jerusalem in Judah to rebuild this Temple of the Lord, the God of Israel, who lives in Jerusalem. And may your God be with you! ⁴Wherever this Jewish remnant is found, let their neighbors contribute toward their expenses by giving them silver and gold, supplies for the journey, and livestock, as well as a voluntary offering for the Temple of God in Jerusalem.”

⁵Then God stirred the hearts of the priests and Levites and the leaders of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin to go to Jerusalem to rebuild the Temple of the Lord. ⁶And all their neighbors assisted by

giving them articles of silver and gold, supplies for the journey, and livestock. They gave them many valuable gifts in addition to all the voluntary offerings.

⁷King Cyrus himself brought out the articles that King Nebuchadnezzar had taken from the Lord's Temple in Jerusalem and had placed in the temple of his own gods. ⁸Cyrus directed Mithredath, the treasurer of Persia, to count these items and present them to Sheshbazzar, the leader of the exiles returning to Judah. ⁹This is a list of the items that were returned:

Gold basins	30
Silver basins	1,000
Silver incense burners	29
¹⁰ Gold bowls	30
Silver bowls	410
Other items	1,000

¹¹In all, there were 5,400 articles of gold and silver. Sheshbazzar brought all of these along when the exiles went from Babylon to Jerusalem.

2

Exiles Who Returned with Zerubbabel



ERE is the list of the Jewish exiles of the provinces who returned from their captivity. King Nebuchadnezzar had deported them to Babylon, but now they returned to Jerusalem and the other towns in Judah where they originally lived. ²Their leaders were Zerubbabel, Jeshua, Nehemiah, Seraiah, Reelaiah, Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispar, Bigvai, Rehum, and Baanah. This is the number of the men of Israel who returned from exile:

³The family of Parosh2,172

⁴ The family of Shephatiah.....	372
⁵ The family of Arah.....	775
⁶ The family of Pahath-moab (descendants of Jeshua and Joab).....	2,812
⁷ The family of Elam.....	1,254
⁸ The family of Zattu.....	945
⁹ The family of Zaccai.....	760
¹⁰ The family of Bani.....	642
¹¹ The family of Bebai.....	623
¹² The family of Azgad.....	1,222
¹³ The family of Adonikam.....	666
¹⁴ The family of Bigvai.....	2,056
¹⁵ The family of Adin.....	454
¹⁶ The family of Ater (descendants of Hezekiah).....	98
¹⁷ The family of Bezai.....	323
¹⁸ The family of Jorah.....	112
¹⁹ The family of Hashum.....	223
²⁰ The family of Gibbar.....	95
²¹ The people of Bethlehem.....	123
²² The people of Netophah.....	56
²³ The people of Anathoth.....	128
²⁴ The people of Beth-azmaveth.....	42
²⁵ The people of Kiriath-jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth.....	743
²⁶ The people of Ramah and Geba.....	621
²⁷ The people of Micmash.....	122
²⁸ The people of Bethel and Ai.....	223
²⁹ The citizens of Nebo.....	52
³⁰ The citizens of Magbish.....	156
³¹ The citizens of West Elam.....	1,254
³² The citizens of Harim.....	320
³³ The citizens of Lod, Hadid, and Ono.....	725
³⁴ The citizens of Jericho.....	345
³⁵ The citizens of Senaah.....	3,630

³⁶These are the priests who returned from exile:

The family of Jedaiah (through the line of Jeshua)	973
³⁷ The family of Immer	1,052
³⁸ The family of Pashhur	1,247
³⁹ The family of Harim	1,017

⁴⁰These are the Levites who returned from exile:

The families of Jeshua and Kadmiel (descendants of Hodaviah)	74
⁴¹ The singers of the family of Asaph	128
⁴² The gatekeepers of the families of Shallum, Ater, Talmon, Akkub, Hatita, and Shobai	139

⁴³The descendants of the following Temple servants returned from exile:

Ziha, Hasupha, Tabbaoth, ⁴⁴Keros, Siaha, Padon, ⁴⁵Lebanah, Hagabah, Akkub, ⁴⁶Hagab, Shalmi, Hanan, ⁴⁷Giddel, Gahar, Reaiah, ⁴⁸Rezin, Nekoda, Gazzam, ⁴⁹Uzza, Paseah, Besai, ⁵⁰Asnah, Meunim, Nephusim, ⁵¹Bakbuk, Hakupha, Harhur, ⁵²Bazluth, Mehida, Harsha, ⁵³Barkos, Sisera, Temah, ⁵⁴Neziah, and Hatipha.

⁵⁵The descendants of these servants of King Solomon returned from exile:

Sotai, Hassophereth, Peruda, ⁵⁶Jaalah, Darkon, Giddel, ⁵⁷Shephatiah, Hattil, Pokereth-hazzebaim, and Ami.

⁵⁸In all, the Temple servants and the descendants of Solomon's servants numbered 392.

⁵⁹Another group returned at this time from the towns of Tel-melah, Tel-harsha, Kerub, Addan, and Immer. However, they could not

prove that they or their families were descendants of Israel. ⁶⁰This group included the families of Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda—a total of 652 people.

⁶¹Three families of priests—Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai—also returned. (This Barzillai had married a woman who was a descendant of Barzillai of Gilead, and he had taken her family name.) ⁶²They searched for their names in the genealogical records, but they were not found, so they were disqualified from serving as priests. ⁶³The governor told them not to eat the priests' share of food from the sacrifices until a priest could consult the Lord about the matter by using the Urim and Thummim—the sacred lots.

⁶⁴So a total of 42,360 people returned to Judah, ⁶⁵in addition to 7,337 servants and 200 singers, both men and women. ⁶⁶They took with them 736 horses, 245 mules, 67435 camels, and 6,720 donkeys.

⁶⁸When they arrived at the Temple of the Lord in Jerusalem, some of the family leaders made voluntary offerings toward the rebuilding of God's Temple on its original site, ⁶⁹and each leader gave as much as he could. The total of their gifts came to 61,000 gold coins, 6,250 pounds of silver, and 100 robes for the priests.

⁷⁰So the priests, the Levites, the singers, the gatekeepers, the Temple servants, and some of the common people settled in villages near Jerusalem. The rest of the people returned to their own towns throughout Israel.

3

The Altar Is Rebuilt



LN early autumn, when the Israelites had settled in their towns, all the people assembled in Jerusalem with a unified purpose. ²Then Jeshua son of Jehozadak joined his fellow priests and Zerubbabel son of Shealtiel with his family in rebuilding the altar of the God of Israel. They wanted to sacrifice burnt offerings on it, as instructed in the Law of Moses, the man of God. ³Even though the people were

afraid of the local residents, they rebuilt the altar at its old site. Then they began to sacrifice burnt offerings on the altar to the Lord each morning and evening.

⁴They celebrated the Festival of Shelters as prescribed in the Law, sacrificing the number of burnt offerings specified for each day of the festival. ⁵They also offered the regular burnt offerings and the offerings required for the new moon celebrations and the annual festivals as prescribed by the Lord. The people also gave voluntary offerings to the Lord. ⁶Fifteen days before the Festival of Shelters began, the priests had begun to sacrifice burnt offerings to the Lord. This was even before they had started to lay the foundation of the Lord's Temple.

The People Begin to Rebuild the Temple

⁷Then the people hired masons and carpenters and bought cedar logs from the people of Tyre and Sidon, paying them with food, wine, and olive oil. The logs were brought down from the Lebanon mountains and floated along the coast of the Mediterranean Sea to Joppa, for King Cyrus had given permission for this.

⁸The construction of the Temple of God began in midspring, during the second year after they arrived in Jerusalem. The work force was made up of everyone who had returned from exile, including Zerubbabel son of Shealtiel, Jeshua son of Jehozadak and his fellow priests, and all the Levites. The Levites who were twenty years old or older were put in charge of rebuilding the Lord's Temple. ⁹The workers at the Temple of God were supervised by Jeshua with his sons and relatives, and Kadmiel and his sons, all descendants of Hodaviah. They were helped in this task by the Levites of the family of Henadad.

¹⁰When the builders completed the foundation of the Lord's Temple, the priests put on their robes and took their places to blow their trumpets. And the Levites, descendants of Asaph, clashed their cymbals to praise the Lord, just as King David had prescribed. ¹¹With praise and thanks, they sang this song to the Lord:

“He is so good!

His faithful love for Israel endures forever!”

Then all the people gave a great shout, praising the Lord because the foundation of the Lord’s Temple had been laid.

¹²But many of the older priests, Levites, and other leaders who had seen the first Temple wept aloud when they saw the new Temple’s foundation. The others, however, were shouting for joy. ¹³The joyful shouting and weeping mingled together in a loud noise that could be heard far in the distance.

4

Enemies Oppose the Rebuilding



HE enemies of Judah and Benjamin heard that the exiles were rebuilding a Temple to the Lord, the God of Israel. ²So they approached Zerubbabel and the other leaders and said, “Let us build with you, for we worship your God just as you do. We have sacrificed to him ever since King Esarhaddon of Assyria brought us here.”

³But Zerubbabel, Jeshua, and the other leaders of Israel replied, “You may have no part in this work. We alone will build the Temple for the Lord, the God of Israel, just as King Cyrus of Persia commanded us.”

⁴Then the local residents tried to discourage and frighten the people of Judah to keep them from their work. ⁵They bribed agents to work against them and to frustrate their plans. This went on during the entire reign of King Cyrus of Persia and lasted until King Darius of Persia took the throne.

Later Opposition under Xerxes and Artaxerxes

⁶Years later when Xerxes began his reign, the enemies of Judah wrote a letter of accusation against the people of Judah and Jerusalem.

⁷Even later, during the reign of King Artaxerxes of Persia, the enemies of Judah, led by Bishlam, Mithredath, and Tabeel, sent a letter to Artaxerxes in the Aramaic language, and it was translated for the king.

⁸Rehum the governor and Shimshai the court secretary wrote the letter, telling King Artaxerxes about the situation in Jerusalem. ⁹They greeted the king for all their colleagues—the judges and local leaders, the people of Tarpel, the Persians, the Babylonians, and the people of Erech and Susa (that is, Elam). ¹⁰They also sent greetings from the rest of the people whom the great and noble Ashurbanipal had deported and relocated in Samaria and throughout the neighboring lands of the province west of the Euphrates River. ¹¹This is a copy of their letter:

“To King Artaxerxes, from your loyal subjects in the province west of the Euphrates River.

¹²“The king should know that the Jews who came here to Jerusalem from Babylon are rebuilding this rebellious and evil city. They have already laid the foundation and will soon finish its walls. ¹³And the king should know that if this city is rebuilt and its walls are completed, it will be much to your disadvantage, for the Jews will then refuse to pay their tribute, customs, and tolls to you.

¹⁴“Since we are your loyal subjects and do not want to see the king dishonored in this way, we have sent the king this information. ¹⁵We suggest that a search be made in your ancestors’ records, where you will discover what a rebellious city this has been in the past. In fact, it was destroyed because of its long and troublesome history of revolt against the kings and countries who controlled it. ¹⁶We declare to the king that if this city is rebuilt and its walls are completed, the province west of the Euphrates River will be lost to you.”

¹⁷Then King Artaxerxes sent this reply:

“To Rehum the governor, Shimshai the court secretary, and their colleagues living in Samaria and throughout the province west of the Euphrates River. Greetings.

¹⁸“The letter you sent has been translated and read to me. ¹⁹I ordered a search of the records and have found that Jerusalem has indeed been a hotbed of insurrection against many kings. In fact, rebellion and revolt are normal there! ²⁰Powerful kings have ruled over Jerusalem and the entire province west of the Euphrates River, receiving tribute, customs, and tolls. ²¹Therefore, issue orders to have these men stop their work. That city must not be rebuilt except at my express command. ²²Be diligent, and don’t neglect this matter, for we must not permit the situation to harm the king’s interests.”

²³When this letter from King Artaxerxes was read to Rehum, Shimshai, and their colleagues, they hurried to Jerusalem. Then, with a show of strength, they forced the Jews to stop building.

The Rebuilding Resumes

²⁴So the work on the Temple of God in Jerusalem had stopped, and it remained at a standstill until the second year of the reign of King Darius of Persia.

5

T that time the prophets Haggai and Zechariah son of Iddo prophesied to the Jews in Judah and Jerusalem. They prophesied in the name of the God of Israel who was over them. ²Zerubbabel son of Shealtiel and Jeshua son of Jehozadak responded by starting again to rebuild the Temple of God in Jerusalem. And the prophets of God were with them and helped them.

³But Tattenai, governor of the province west of the Euphrates River, and Shethar-bozenai and their colleagues soon arrived in Jerusalem

and asked, “Who gave you permission to rebuild this Temple and restore this structure?” ⁴They also asked for the names of all the men working on the Temple. ⁵But because their God was watching over them, the leaders of the Jews were not prevented from building until a report was sent to Darius and he returned his decision.

Tattenai’s Letter to King Darius

⁶This is a copy of the letter that Tattenai the governor, Shethar-bozenai, and the other officials of the province west of the Euphrates River sent to King Darius:

⁷“To King Darius. Greetings.

⁸“The king should know that we went to the construction site of the Temple of the great God in the province of Judah. It is being rebuilt with specially prepared stones, and timber is being laid in its walls. The work is going forward with great energy and success.

⁹“We asked the leaders, ‘Who gave you permission to rebuild this Temple and restore this structure?’ ¹⁰And we demanded their names so that we could tell you who the leaders were.

¹¹“This was their answer: ‘We are the servants of the God of heaven and earth, and we are rebuilding the Temple that was built here many years ago by a great king of Israel. ¹²But because our ancestors angered the God of heaven, he abandoned them to King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon, who destroyed this Temple and exiled the people to Babylonia. ¹³However, King Cyrus of Babylon, during the first year of his reign, issued a decree that the Temple of God should be rebuilt. ¹⁴King Cyrus returned the gold and silver cups that Nebuchadnezzar had taken from the Temple of God in Jerusalem and had placed in the temple of Babylon. These cups were

taken from that temple and presented to a man named Sheshbazzar, whom King Cyrus appointed as governor of Judah. ¹⁵The king instructed him to return the cups to their place in Jerusalem and to rebuild the Temple of God there on its original site. ¹⁶So this Sheshbazzar came and laid the foundations of the Temple of God in Jerusalem. The people have been working on it ever since, though it is not yet completed.’

¹⁷“Therefore, if it pleases the king, we request that a search be made in the royal archives of Babylon to discover whether King Cyrus ever issued a decree to rebuild God’s Temple in Jerusalem. And then let the king send us his decision in this matter.”

6

Darius Approves the Rebuilding

o King Darius issued orders that a search be made in the Babylonian archives, which were stored in the treasury. ²But it was at the fortress at Ecbatana in the province of Media that a scroll was found. This is what it said:

“Memorandum:

³“In the first year of King Cyrus’s reign, a decree was sent out concerning the Temple of God at Jerusalem.

“Let the Temple be rebuilt on the site where Jews used to offer their sacrifices, using the original foundations. Its height will be ninety feet, and its width will be ninety feet. ⁴Every three layers of specially prepared stones will be topped by a layer of timber. All expenses will be paid by the royal treasury.

⁵Furthermore, the gold and silver cups, which were taken to Babylon by Nebuchadnezzar from the Temple of God in Jerusalem, must be returned to Jerusalem and put back where they belong. Let them be taken back to the Temple of God.”

⁶So King Darius sent this message:

“Now therefore, Tattenai, governor of the province west of the Euphrates River, and Shethar-bozenai, and your colleagues and other officials west of the Euphrates River—stay away from there! ⁷Do not disturb the construction of the Temple of God. Let it be rebuilt on its original site, and do not hinder the governor of Judah and the elders of the Jews in their work.

⁸“Moreover, I hereby decree that you are to help these elders of the Jews as they rebuild this Temple of God. You must pay the full construction costs, without delay, from my taxes collected in the province west of the Euphrates River so that the work will not be interrupted.

⁹“Give the priests in Jerusalem whatever is needed in the way of young bulls, rams, and male lambs for the burnt offerings presented to the God of heaven. And without fail, provide them with as much wheat, salt, wine, and olive oil as they need each day. ¹⁰Then they will be able to offer acceptable sacrifices to the God of heaven and pray for the welfare of the king and his sons.

¹¹“Those who violate this decree in any way will have a beam pulled from their house. Then they will be lifted up and impaled on it, and their house will be reduced to a pile of rubble. ¹²May the God who has chosen the city of Jerusalem as the place to honor his name destroy any king or nation that violates this command and destroys this Temple.

“I, Darius, have issued this decree. Let it be obeyed with all diligence.”

The Temple's Dedication

¹³Tattenai, governor of the province west of the Euphrates River, and Shethar-bozenai and their colleagues complied at once with the command of King Darius. ¹⁴So the Jewish elders continued their work, and they were greatly encouraged by the preaching of the prophets Haggai and Zechariah son of Iddo. The Temple was finally finished, as had been commanded by the God of Israel and decreed by Cyrus, Darius, and Artaxerxes, the kings of Persia. ¹⁵The Temple was completed on March 12, during the sixth year of King Darius's reign.

¹⁶The Temple of God was then dedicated with great joy by the people of Israel, the priests, the Levites, and the rest of the people who had returned from exile. ¹⁷During the dedication ceremony for the Temple of God, 100 young bulls, 200 rams, and 400 male lambs were sacrificed. And 12 male goats were presented as a sin offering for the twelve tribes of Israel. ¹⁸Then the priests and Levites were divided into their various divisions to serve at the Temple of God in Jerusalem, as prescribed in the Book of Moses.

Celebration of Passover

¹⁹On April 21 the returned exiles celebrated Passover. ²⁰The priests and Levites had purified themselves and were ceremonially clean. So they slaughtered the Passover lamb for all the returned exiles, for their fellow priests, and for themselves. ²¹The Passover meal was eaten by the people of Israel who had returned from exile and by the others in the land who had turned from their corrupt practices to worship the Lord, the God of Israel. ²²Then they celebrated the Festival of Unleavened Bread for seven days. There was great joy throughout the land because the Lord had caused the king of Assyria to be favorable

to them, so that he helped them to rebuild the Temple of God, the God of Israel.

7

Ezra Arrives in Jerusalem

MANY years later, during the reign of King Artaxerxes of Persia, there was a man named Ezra. He was the son of Seraiah, son of Azariah, son of Hilkiah, ²son of Shallum, son of Zadok, son of Ahitub, ³son of Amariah, son of Azariah, son of Meraioth, ⁴son of Zerahiah, son of Uzzi, son of Bukki, ⁵son of Abishua, son of Phinehas, son of Eleazar, son of Aaron the high priest. ⁶This Ezra was a scribe who was well versed in the Law of Moses, which the Lord, the God of Israel, had given to the people of Israel. He came up to Jerusalem from Babylon, and the king gave him everything he asked for, because the gracious hand of the Lord his God was on him. ⁷Some of the people of Israel, as well as some of the priests, Levites, singers, gatekeepers, and Temple servants, traveled up to Jerusalem with him in the seventh year of King Artaxerxes' reign.

⁸Ezra arrived in Jerusalem in August of that year. ⁹He had arranged to leave Babylon on April 8, the first day of the new year, and he arrived at Jerusalem on August 4, for the gracious hand of his God was on him. ¹⁰This was because Ezra had determined to study and obey the Law of the Lord and to teach those decrees and regulations to the people of Israel.

Artaxerxes' Letter to Ezra

¹¹King Artaxerxes had given a copy of the following letter to Ezra, the priest and scribe who studied and taught the commands and decrees of the Lord to Israel:

¹²“From Artaxerxes, the king of kings, to Ezra the priest, the teacher of the law of the God of heaven. Greetings.

¹³“I decree that any of the people of Israel in my kingdom, including the priests and Levites, may volunteer to return to Jerusalem with you. ¹⁴I and my council of seven hereby instruct you to conduct an inquiry into the situation in Judah and Jerusalem, based on your God’s law, which is in your hand. ¹⁵We also commission you to take with you silver and gold, which we are freely presenting as an offering to the God of Israel who lives in Jerusalem.

¹⁶“Furthermore, you are to take any silver and gold that you may obtain from the province of Babylon, as well as the voluntary offerings of the people and the priests that are presented for the Temple of their God in Jerusalem. ¹⁷These donations are to be used specifically for the purchase of bulls, rams, male lambs, and the appropriate grain offerings and liquid offerings, all of which will be offered on the altar of the Temple of your God in Jerusalem. ¹⁸Any silver and gold that is left over may be used in whatever way you and your colleagues feel is the will of your God.

¹⁹“But as for the cups we are entrusting to you for the service of the Temple of your God, deliver them all to the God of Jerusalem. ²⁰If you need anything else for your God’s Temple or for any similar needs, you may take it from the royal treasury.

²¹“I, Artaxerxes the king, hereby send this decree to all the treasurers in the province west of the Euphrates River: ‘You are to give Ezra, the priest and teacher of the law of the God of heaven, whatever he requests of you. ²²You are to give him up to 7,500 pounds of silver, 500 bushels of wheat, 550 gallons of wine, 550 gallons of olive oil, and an unlimited supply of salt. ²³Be careful to provide whatever the God of heaven demands for his Temple, for why should we risk bringing God’s anger against the realm of the king and his sons? ²⁴I also decree that

no priest, Levite, singer, gatekeeper, Temple servant, or other worker in this Temple of God will be required to pay tribute, customs, or tolls of any kind.’

²⁵“And you, Ezra, are to use the wisdom your God has given you to appoint magistrates and judges who know your God’s laws to govern all the people in the province west of the Euphrates River. Teach the law to anyone who does not know it.

²⁶Anyone who refuses to obey the law of your God and the law of the king will be punished immediately, either by death, banishment, confiscation of goods, or imprisonment.”

Ezra Praises the Lord

²⁷Praise the Lord, the God of our ancestors, who made the king want to beautify the Temple of the Lord in Jerusalem! ²⁸And praise him for demonstrating such unfailing love to me by honoring me before the king, his council, and all his mighty nobles! I felt encouraged because the gracious hand of the Lord my God was on me. And I gathered some of the leaders of Israel to return with me to Jerusalem.

8

Exiles Who Returned with Ezra

ERE is a list of the family leaders and the genealogies of those who came with me from Babylon during the reign of King Artaxerxes:

²From the family of Phinehas: Gershom.

From the family of Ithamar: Daniel.

From the family of David: Hattush, ³a descendant of Shecaniah.

From the family of Parosh: Zechariah and 150 other men were registered.

- ⁴From the family of Pahath-moab: Eliehoenai son of Zerahiah and 200 other men.
- ⁵From the family of Zattu: Shecaniah son of Jahaziel and 300 other men.
- ⁶From the family of Adin: Ebed son of Jonathan and 50 other men.
- ⁷From the family of Elam: Jeshaiah son of Athaliah and 70 other men.
- ⁸From the family of Shephatiah: Zebadiah son of Michael and 80 other men.
- ⁹From the family of Joab: Obadiah son of Jehiel and 218 other men.
- ¹⁰From the family of Bani: Shelomith son of Josiphiah and 160 other men.
- ¹¹From the family of Bebai: Zechariah son of Bebai and 28 other men.
- ¹²From the family of Azgad: Johanan son of Hakkatan and 110 other men.
- ¹³From the family of Adonikam, who came later: Eliphelet, Jeuel, Shemaiah, and 60 other men.
- ¹⁴From the family of Bigvai: Uthai, Zaccur, and 70 other men.

Ezra's Journey to Jerusalem

¹⁵I assembled the exiles at the Ahava Canal, and we camped there for three days while I went over the lists of the people and the priests who had arrived. I found that not one Levite had volunteered to come along. ¹⁶So I sent for Eliezer, Ariel, Shemaiah, Elnathan, Jarib, Elnathan, Nathan, Zechariah, and Meshullam, who were leaders of the people. I also sent for Joiarib and Elnathan, who were men of discernment. ¹⁷I sent them to Iddo, the leader of the Levites at Casiphia, to ask him and his relatives and the Temple servants to send us ministers for the Temple of God at Jerusalem.

¹⁸Since the gracious hand of our God was on us, they sent us a man named Sherebiah, along with eighteen of his sons and brothers. He was a very astute man and a descendant of Mahli, who was a descendant of Levi son of Israel. ¹⁹They also sent Hashabiah, together

with Jeshaiiah from the descendants of Merari, and twenty of his sons and brothers,²⁰ and 220 Temple servants. The Temple servants were assistants to the Levites—a group of Temple workers first instituted by King David and his officials. They were all listed by name.

²¹And there by the Ahava Canal, I gave orders for all of us to fast and humble ourselves before our God. We prayed that he would give us a safe journey and protect us, our children, and our goods as we traveled. ²²For I was ashamed to ask the king for soldiers and horsemen to accompany us and protect us from enemies along the way. After all, we had told the king, “Our God’s hand of protection is on all who worship him, but his fierce anger rages against those who abandon him.” ²³So we fasted and earnestly prayed that our God would take care of us, and he heard our prayer.

²⁴I appointed twelve leaders of the priests—Sherebiah, Hashabiah, and ten other priests—²⁵to be in charge of transporting the silver, the gold, the gold bowls, and the other items that the king, his council, his officials, and all the people of Israel had presented for the Temple of God. ²⁶I weighed the treasure as I gave it to them and found the totals to be as follows:

24 tons of silver,
7,500 pounds of silver articles,
7,500 pounds of gold,
2720 gold bowls, equal in value to 1,000 gold coins,
2 fine articles of polished bronze, as precious as gold.

²⁸And I said to these priests, “You and these treasures have been set apart as holy to the Lord. This silver and gold is a voluntary offering to the Lord, the God of our ancestors. ²⁹Guard these treasures well until you present them to the leading priests, the Levites, and the leaders of Israel, who will weigh them at the storerooms of the Lord’s Temple in Jerusalem.” ³⁰So the priests and the Levites accepted the task of transporting these treasures of silver and gold to the Temple of our God in Jerusalem.

³¹We broke camp at the Ahava Canal on April 19 and started off to Jerusalem. And the gracious hand of our God protected us and saved us from enemies and bandits along the way. ³²So we arrived safely in Jerusalem, where we rested for three days.

³³On the fourth day after our arrival, the silver, gold, and other valuables were weighed at the Temple of our God and entrusted to Meremoth son of Uriah the priest and to Eleazar son of Phinehas, along with Jozabad son of Jeshua and Noadiah son of Binnui—both of whom were Levites. ³⁴Everything was accounted for by number and weight, and the total weight was officially recorded.

³⁵Then the exiles who had come out of captivity sacrificed burnt offerings to the God of Israel. They presented twelve bulls for all the people of Israel, as well as ninety-six rams and seventy-seven male lambs. They also offered twelve male goats as a sin offering. All this was given as a burnt offering to the Lord. ³⁶The king's decrees were delivered to his highest officers and the governors of the province west of the Euphrates River, who then cooperated by supporting the people and the Temple of God.

9

Ezra's Prayer concerning Intermarriage

WHEN these things had been done, the Jewish leaders came to me and said, “Many of the people of Israel, and even some of the priests and Levites, have not kept themselves separate from the other peoples living in the land. They have taken up the detestable practices of the Canaanites, Hittites, Perizzites, Jebusites, Ammonites, Moabites, Egyptians, and Amorites. ²For the men of Israel have married women from these people and have taken them as wives for their sons. So the holy race has become polluted by these mixed marriages. Worse yet, the leaders and officials have led the way in this outrage.”

³When I heard this, I tore my cloak and my shirt, pulled hair from my head and beard, and sat down utterly shocked. ⁴Then all who trembled at the words of the God of Israel came and sat with me because of this outrage committed by the returned exiles. And I sat there utterly appalled until the time of the evening sacrifice.

⁵At the time of the sacrifice, I stood up from where I had sat in mourning with my clothes torn. I fell to my knees and lifted my hands to the Lord my God. ⁶I prayed,

“O my God, I am utterly ashamed; I blush to lift up my face to you. For our sins are piled higher than our heads, and our guilt has reached to the heavens. ⁷From the days of our ancestors until now, we have been steeped in sin. That is why we and our kings and our priests have been at the mercy of the pagan kings of the land. We have been killed, captured, robbed, and disgraced, just as we are today.

⁸“But now we have been given a brief moment of grace, for the Lord our God has allowed a few of us to survive as a remnant. He has given us security in this holy place. Our God has brightened our eyes and granted us some relief from our slavery. ⁹For we were slaves, but in his unfailing love our God did not abandon us in our slavery. Instead, he caused the kings of Persia to treat us favorably. He revived us so we could rebuild the Temple of our God and repair its ruins. He has given us a protective wall in Judah and Jerusalem.

¹⁰“And now, O our God, what can we say after all of this? For once again we have abandoned your commands! ¹¹Your servants the prophets warned us when they said, ‘*The land you are entering to possess is totally defiled by the detestable practices of the people living there. From one end to the other, the land is filled with corruption.*’ ¹²Don’t let your daughters marry their sons! Don’t take their daughters as wives for your sons. Don’t ever promote the peace and prosperity of those

nations. If you follow these instructions, you will be strong and will enjoy the good things the land produces, and you will leave this prosperity to your children forever.’

¹³“Now we are being punished because of our wickedness and our great guilt. But we have actually been punished far less than we deserve, for you, our God, have allowed some of us to survive as a remnant. ¹⁴But even so, we are again breaking your commands and intermarrying with people who do these detestable things. Won’t your anger be enough to destroy us, so that even this little remnant no longer survives? ¹⁵O Lord, God of Israel, you are just. We come before you in our guilt as nothing but an escaped remnant, though in such a condition none of us can stand in your presence.”

10

The People Confess Their Sin



WHILE Ezra prayed and made this confession, weeping and lying face down on the ground in front of the Temple of God, a very large crowd of people from Israel—men, women, and children—gathered and wept bitterly with him. ²Then Shecaniah son of Jehiel, a descendant of Elam, said to Ezra, “We have been unfaithful to our God, for we have married these pagan women of the land. But in spite of this there is hope for Israel. ³Let us now make a covenant with our God to divorce our pagan wives and to send them away with their children. We will follow the advice given by you and by the others who respect the commands of our God. Let it be done according to the Law of God. ⁴Get up, for it is your duty to tell us how to proceed in setting things straight. We are behind you, so be strong and take action.”

⁵So Ezra stood up and demanded that the leaders of the priests and the Levites and all the people of Israel swear that they would do as

Shecaniah had said. And they all swore a solemn oath. ⁶Then Ezra left the front of the Temple of God and went to the room of Jehohanan son of Eliashib. He spent the night there without eating or drinking anything. He was still in mourning because of the unfaithfulness of the returned exiles.

⁷Then a proclamation was made throughout Judah and Jerusalem that all the exiles should come to Jerusalem. ⁸Those who failed to come within three days would, if the leaders and elders so decided, forfeit all their property and be expelled from the assembly of the exiles.

⁹Within three days, all the people of Judah and Benjamin had gathered in Jerusalem. This took place on December 19, and all the people were sitting in the square before the Temple of God. They were trembling both because of the seriousness of the matter and because it was raining. ¹⁰Then Ezra the priest stood and said to them: "You have committed a terrible sin. By marrying pagan women, you have increased Israel's guilt. ¹¹So now confess your sin to the Lord, the God of your ancestors, and do what he demands. Separate yourselves from the people of the land and from these pagan women."

¹²Then the whole assembly raised their voices and answered, "Yes, you are right; we must do as you say!" ¹³Then they added, "This isn't something that can be done in a day or two, for many of us are involved in this extremely sinful affair. And this is the rainy season, so we cannot stay out here much longer. ¹⁴Let our leaders act on behalf of us all. Let everyone who has a pagan wife come at a scheduled time, accompanied by the leaders and judges of his city, so that the fierce anger of our God concerning this affair may be turned away from us."

¹⁵Only Jonathan son of Asahel and Jahzeiah son of Tikvah opposed this course of action, and they were supported by Meshullam and Shabbethai the Levite.

¹⁶So this was the plan they followed. Ezra selected leaders to represent their families, designating each of the representatives by name. On December 29, the leaders sat down to investigate the matter. ¹⁷By

March 27, the first day of the new year, they had finished dealing with all the men who had married pagan wives.

Those Guilty of Intermarriage

¹⁸These are the priests who had married pagan wives:

From the family of Jeshua son of Jehozadak and his brothers: Maaseiah, Eliezer, Jarib, and Gedaliah. ¹⁹They vowed to divorce their wives, and they each acknowledged their guilt by offering a ram as a guilt offering.

²⁰From the family of Immer: Hanani and Zebadiah.

²¹From the family of Harim: Maaseiah, Elijah, Shemaiah, Jehiel, and Uzziah.

²²From the family of Pashhur: Elioenai, Maaseiah, Ishmael, Nethanel, Jozabad, and Elasa.

²³These are the Levites who were guilty: Jozabad, Shimei, Kelaiah (also called Kelita), Pethahiah, Judah, and Eliezer.

²⁴This is the singer who was guilty: Eliashib.

These are the gatekeepers who were guilty: Shallum, Telem, and Uri. ²⁵These are the other people of Israel who were guilty:

From the family of Parosh: Ramiah, Izziah, Malkijah, Mijamin, Eleazar, Hashabiah, and Benaiah.

²⁶From the family of Elam: Mattaniah, Zechariah, Jehiel, Abdi, Jeremoth, and Elijah.

²⁷From the family of Zattu: Elioenai, Eliashib, Mattaniah, Jeremoth, Zabad, and Aziza.

²⁸From the family of Bebai: Jehohanan, Hananiah, Zabbai, and Athlai.

²⁹From the family of Bani: Meshullam, Malluch, Adaiah, Jashub, Sheal, and Jeremoth.

³⁰From the family of Pahath-moab: Adna, Kelal, Benaiah, Maaseiah, Mattaniah, Bezalel, Binnui, and Manasseh.

³¹From the family of Harim: Eliezer, Ishijah, Malkijah, Shemaiah, Shimeon, ³²Benjamin, Malluch, and Shemariah.

³³From the family of Hashum: Mattenai, Mattattah, Zabad, Eliphelet, Jeremai, Manasseh, and Shimei.

³⁴From the family of Bani: Maadai, Amram, Uel, ³⁵Benaiah, Bedeiah, Keluhi, ³⁶Vaniah, Meremoth, Eliashib, ³⁷Mattaniah, Mattenai, and Jaasu.

³⁸From the family of Binnui: Shimei, ³⁹Shelemiah, Nathan, Adaiah, ⁴⁰Macnadebai, Shashai, Sharai, ⁴¹Azarel, Shelemiah, Shemariah, ⁴²Shallum, Amariah, and Joseph.

⁴³From the family of Nebo: Jeiel, Mattithiah, Zabad, Zebina, Jaddai, Joel, and Benaiah.

⁴⁴Each of these men had a pagan wife, and some even had children by these wives.

Nehemiah

1



THESE are the memoirs of Nehemiah son of Hacaliah.

Nehemiah's Concern for Jerusalem

In late autumn, in the month of Kislev, in the twentieth year of King Artaxerxes' reign, I was at the fortress of Susa. ²Hanani, one of my brothers, came to visit me with some other men who had just arrived from Judah. I asked them about the Jews who had returned there from captivity and about how things were going in Jerusalem.

³They said to me, "Things are not going well for those who returned to the province of Judah. They are in great trouble and disgrace. The wall of Jerusalem has been torn down, and the gates have been destroyed by fire."

⁴When I heard this, I sat down and wept. In fact, for days I mourned, fasted, and prayed to the God of heaven. ⁵Then I said,

"O Lord, God of heaven, the great and awesome God who keeps his covenant of unfailing love with those who love him and obey his commands, ⁶listen to my prayer! Look down and see me praying night and day for your people Israel. I confess that we have sinned against you. Yes, even my own family and I have sinned! ⁷We have sinned terribly by not obeying the commands, decrees, and regulations that you gave us through your servant Moses.

⁸“Please remember what you told your servant Moses: ‘If you are unfaithful to me, I will scatter you among the nations. ⁹But if you return to me and obey my commands and live by them, then even if you are exiled to the ends of the earth, I will bring you back to the place I have chosen for my name to be honored.’

¹⁰“The people you rescued by your great power and strong hand are your servants. ¹¹O Lord, please hear my prayer! Listen to the prayers of those of us who delight in honoring you. Please grant me success today by making the king favorable to me. Put it into his heart to be kind to me.”

In those days I was the king’s cup-bearer.

2

Nehemiah Goes to Jerusalem

EARLY the following spring, in the month of Nisan, during the twentieth year of King Artaxerxes’ reign, I was serving the king his wine. I had never before appeared sad in his presence. ²So the king asked me, “Why are you looking so sad? You don’t look sick to me. You must be deeply troubled.”

Then I was terrified, ³but I replied, “Long live the king! How can I not be sad? For the city where my ancestors are buried is in ruins, and the gates have been destroyed by fire.”

⁴The king asked, “Well, how can I help you?”

With a prayer to the God of heaven, ⁵I replied, “If it please the king, and if you are pleased with me, your servant, send me to Judah to rebuild the city where my ancestors are buried.”

⁶The king, with the queen sitting beside him, asked, “How long will you be gone? When will you return?” After I told him how long I would be gone, the king agreed to my request.

⁷I also said to the king, “If it please the king, let me have letters addressed to the governors of the province west of the Euphrates River, instructing them to let me travel safely through their territories on my way to Judah. ⁸And please give me a letter addressed to Asaph, the manager of the king’s forest, instructing him to give me timber. I will need it to make beams for the gates of the Temple fortress, for the city walls, and for a house for myself.” And the king granted these requests, because the gracious hand of God was on me.

⁹When I came to the governors of the province west of the Euphrates River, I delivered the king’s letters to them. The king, I should add, had sent along army officers and horsemen to protect me. ¹⁰But when Sanballat the Horonite and Tobiah the Ammonite official heard of my arrival, they were very displeased that someone had come to help the people of Israel.

Nehemiah Inspects Jerusalem’s Wall

¹¹So I arrived in Jerusalem. Three days later, ¹²I slipped out during the night, taking only a few others with me. I had not told anyone about the plans God had put in my heart for Jerusalem. We took no pack animals with us except the donkey I was riding. ¹³After dark I went out through the Valley Gate, past the Jackal’s Well, and over to the Dung Gate to inspect the broken walls and burned gates. ¹⁴Then I went to the Fountain Gate and to the King’s Pool, but my donkey couldn’t get through the rubble. ¹⁵So, though it was still dark, I went up the Kidron Valley instead, inspecting the wall before I turned back and entered again at the Valley Gate.

¹⁶The city officials did not know I had been out there or what I was doing, for I had not yet said anything to anyone about my plans. I had not yet spoken to the Jewish leaders—the priests, the nobles, the officials, or anyone else in the administration. ¹⁷But now I said to them, “You know very well what trouble we are in. Jerusalem lies in ruins, and its gates have been destroyed by fire. Let us rebuild the wall of Jerusalem and end this disgrace!” ¹⁸Then I told them about how

the gracious hand of God had been on me, and about my conversation with the king.

They replied at once, “Yes, let’s rebuild the wall!” So they began the good work.

¹⁹But when Sanballat, Tobiah, and Geshem the Arab heard of our plan, they scoffed contemptuously. “What are you doing? Are you rebelling against the king?” they asked.

²⁰I replied, “The God of heaven will help us succeed. We, his servants, will start rebuilding this wall. But you have no share, legal right, or historic claim in Jerusalem.”

3

Rebuilding the Wall of Jerusalem



THEN Eliashib the high priest and the other priests started to rebuild at the Sheep Gate. They dedicated it and set up its doors, building the wall as far as the Tower of the Hundred, which they dedicated, and the Tower of Hananel. ²People from the town of Jericho worked next to them, and beyond them was Zaccur son of Imri.

³The Fish Gate was built by the sons of Hassenaah. They laid the beams, set up its doors, and installed its bolts and bars. ⁴Meremoth son of Uriah and grandson of Hakkoz repaired the next section of wall. Beside him were Meshullam son of Berekiah and grandson of Meshezabel, and then Zadok son of Baana. ⁵Next were the people from Tekoa, though their leaders refused to work with the construction supervisors.

⁶The Old City Gate was repaired by Joiada son of Paseah and Meshullam son of Besodeiah. They laid the beams, set up its doors, and installed its bolts and bars. ⁷Next to them were Melatiah from Gibeon, Jadon from Meronoth, people from Gibeon, and people from Mizpah, the headquarters of the governor of the province west of the Euphrates River. ⁸Next was Uzziel son of Harhaiah, a goldsmith

by trade, who also worked on the wall. Beyond him was Hananiah, a manufacturer of perfumes. They left out a section of Jerusalem as they built the Broad Wall.

⁹Rephaiah son of Hur, the leader of half the district of Jerusalem, was next to them on the wall. ¹⁰Next Jedaiah son of Harumaph repaired the wall across from his own house, and next to him was Hattush son of Hashabneiah. ¹¹Then came Malkijah son of Harim and Hasshub son of Pahath-moab, who repaired another section of the wall and the Tower of the Ovens. ¹²Shallum son of Hallohesh and his daughters repaired the next section. He was the leader of the other half of the district of Jerusalem.

¹³The Valley Gate was repaired by the people from Zanoah, led by Hanun. They set up its doors and installed its bolts and bars. They also repaired the 1,500 feet of wall to the Dung Gate.

¹⁴The Dung Gate was repaired by Malkijah son of Recab, the leader of the Beth-hakkerem district. He rebuilt it, set up its doors, and installed its bolts and bars.

¹⁵The Fountain Gate was repaired by Shallum son of Col-hozeh, the leader of the Mizpah district. He rebuilt it, roofed it, set up its doors, and installed its bolts and bars. Then he repaired the wall of the pool of Siloam near the king's garden, and he rebuilt the wall as far as the stairs that descend from the City of David. ¹⁶Next to him was Nehemiah son of Azbuk, the leader of half the district of Beth-zur. He rebuilt the wall from a place across from the tombs of David's family as far as the water reservoir and the House of the Warriors.

¹⁷Next to him, repairs were made by a group of Levites working under the supervision of Rehum son of Bani. Then came Hashabiah, the leader of half the district of Keilah, who supervised the building of the wall on behalf of his own district. ¹⁸Next down the line were his countrymen led by Binnui son of Henadad, the leader of the other half of the district of Keilah.

¹⁹Next to them, Ezer son of Jeshua, the leader of Mizpah, repaired another section of wall across from the ascent to the armory near the angle in the wall. ²⁰Next to him was Baruch son of Zabbai, who

zealously repaired an additional section from the angle to the door of the house of Eliashib the high priest. ²¹Meremoth son of Uriah and grandson of Hakkoz rebuilt another section of the wall extending from the door of Eliashib's house to the end of the house.

²²The next repairs were made by the priests from the surrounding region. ²³After them, Benjamin and Hasshub repaired the section across from their house, and Azariah son of Maaseiah and grandson of Ananiah repaired the section across from his house. ²⁴Next was Binnui son of Henadad, who rebuilt another section of the wall from Azariah's house to the angle and the corner. ²⁵Palal son of Uzai carried on the work from a point opposite the angle and the tower that projects up from the king's upper house beside the court of the guard. Next to him were Pedaiah son of Parosh, ²⁶with the Temple servants living on the hill of Ophel, who repaired the wall as far as a point across from the Water Gate to the east and the projecting tower. ²⁷Then came the people of Tekoa, who repaired another section across from the great projecting tower and over to the wall of Ophel.

²⁸Above the Horse Gate, the priests repaired the wall. Each one repaired the section immediately across from his own house. ²⁹Next Zadok son of Immer also rebuilt the wall across from his own house, and beyond him was Shemaiah son of Shecaniah, the gatekeeper of the East Gate. ³⁰Next Hananiah son of Shelemiah and Hanun, the sixth son of Zalaph, repaired another section, while Meshullam son of Berekiah rebuilt the wall across from where he lived. ³¹Malkijah, one of the goldsmiths, repaired the wall as far as the housing for the Temple servants and merchants, across from the Inspection Gate. Then he continued as far as the upper room at the corner. ³²The other goldsmiths and merchants repaired the wall from that corner to the Sheep Gate.

SANBALLAT was very angry when he learned that we were rebuilding the wall. He flew into a rage and mocked the Jews, ²saying in front of his friends and the Samaritan army officers, “What does this bunch of poor, feeble Jews think they’re doing? Do they think they can build the wall in a single day by just offering a few sacrifices? Do they actually think they can make something of stones from a rubbish heap—and charred ones at that?”

³Tobiah the Ammonite, who was standing beside him, remarked, “That stone wall would collapse if even a fox walked along the top of it!”

⁴Then I prayed, “Hear us, our God, for we are being mocked. May their scoffing fall back on their own heads, and may they themselves become captives in a foreign land! ⁵Do not ignore their guilt. Do not blot out their sins, for they have provoked you to anger here in front of the builders.”

⁶At last the wall was completed to half its height around the entire city, for the people had worked with enthusiasm.

⁷But when Sanballat and Tobiah and the Arabs, Ammonites, and Ashdodites heard that the work was going ahead and that the gaps in the wall of Jerusalem were being repaired, they were furious. ⁸They all made plans to come and fight against Jerusalem and throw us into confusion. ⁹But we prayed to our God and guarded the city day and night to protect ourselves.

¹⁰Then the people of Judah began to complain, “The workers are getting tired, and there is so much rubble to be moved. We will never be able to build the wall by ourselves.”

¹¹Meanwhile, our enemies were saying, “Before they know what’s happening, we will swoop down on them and kill them and end their work.”

¹²The Jews who lived near the enemy came and told us again and again, “They will come from all directions and attack us!” ¹³So I placed armed guards behind the lowest parts of the wall in the exposed areas. I stationed the people to stand guard by families, armed with swords, spears, and bows.

¹⁴Then as I looked over the situation, I called together the nobles and the rest of the people and said to them, “Don’t be afraid of the enemy! Remember the Lord, who is great and glorious, and fight for your brothers, your sons, your daughters, your wives, and your homes!”

¹⁵When our enemies heard that we knew of their plans and that God had frustrated them, we all returned to our work on the wall.

¹⁶But from then on, only half my men worked while the other half stood guard with spears, shields, bows, and coats of mail. The leaders stationed themselves behind the people of Judah ¹⁷who were building the wall. The laborers carried on their work with one hand supporting their load and one hand holding a weapon. ¹⁸All the builders had a sword belted to their side. The trumpeter stayed with me to sound the alarm.

¹⁹Then I explained to the nobles and officials and all the people, “The work is very spread out, and we are widely separated from each other along the wall. ²⁰When you hear the blast of the trumpet, rush to wherever it is sounding. Then our God will fight for us!”

²¹We worked early and late, from sunrise to sunset. And half the men were always on guard. ²²I also told everyone living outside the walls to stay in Jerusalem. That way they and their servants could help with guard duty at night and work during the day. ²³During this time, none of us—not I, nor my relatives, nor my servants, nor the guards who were with me—ever took off our clothes. We carried our weapons with us at all times, even when we went for water.

5

Nehemiah Defends the Oppressed



ABOUT this time some of the men and their wives raised a cry of protest against their fellow Jews. ²They were saying, “We have such large families. We need more food to survive.”

³Others said, "We have mortgaged our fields, vineyards, and homes to get food during the famine."

⁴And others said, "We have had to borrow money on our fields and vineyards to pay our taxes. ⁵We belong to the same family as those who are wealthy, and our children are just like theirs. Yet we must sell our children into slavery just to get enough money to live. We have already sold some of our daughters, and we are helpless to do anything about it, for our fields and vineyards are already mortgaged to others."

⁶When I heard their complaints, I was very angry. ⁷After thinking it over, I spoke out against these nobles and officials. I told them, "You are hurting your own relatives by charging interest when they borrow money!" Then I called a public meeting to deal with the problem.

⁸At the meeting I said to them, "We are doing all we can to redeem our Jewish relatives who have had to sell themselves to pagan foreigners, but you are selling them back into slavery again. How often must we redeem them?" And they had nothing to say in their defense.

⁹Then I pressed further, "What you are doing is not right! Should you not walk in the fear of our God in order to avoid being mocked by enemy nations? ¹⁰I myself, as well as my brothers and my workers, have been lending the people money and grain, but now let us stop this business of charging interest. ¹¹You must restore their fields, vineyards, olive groves, and homes to them this very day. And repay the interest you charged when you lent them money, grain, new wine, and olive oil."

¹²They replied, "We will give back everything and demand nothing more from the people. We will do as you say." Then I called the priests and made the nobles and officials swear to do what they had promised.

¹³I shook out the folds of my robe and said, "If you fail to keep your promise, may God shake you like this from your homes and from your property!"

/ The whole assembly responded, "Amen," and they praised the Lord. And the people did as they had promised.

¹⁴For the entire twelve years that I was governor of Judah—from the twentieth year to the thirty-second year of the reign of King Artaxerxes—neither I nor my officials drew on our official food allowance.

¹⁵The former governors, in contrast, had laid heavy burdens on the people, demanding a daily ration of food and wine, besides forty pieces of silver. Even their assistants took advantage of the people. But because I feared God, I did not act that way.

¹⁶I also devoted myself to working on the wall and refused to acquire any land. And I required all my servants to spend time working on the wall. ¹⁷I asked for nothing, even though I regularly fed 150 Jewish officials at my table, besides all the visitors from other lands! ¹⁸The provisions I paid for each day included one ox, six choice sheep or goats, and a large number of poultry. And every ten days we needed a large supply of all kinds of wine. Yet I refused to claim the governor's food allowance because the people already carried a heavy burden.

¹⁹Remember, O my God, all that I have done for these people, and bless me for it.

6

Continued Opposition to Rebuilding



ANBALLAT, Tobiah, Geshem the Arab, and the rest of our enemies found out that I had finished rebuilding the wall and that no gaps remained—though we had not yet set up the doors in the gates. ²So Sanballat and Geshem sent a message asking me to meet them at one of the villages in the plain of Ono.

But I realized they were plotting to harm me, ³so I replied by sending this message to them: “I am engaged in a great work, so I can’t come. Why should I stop working to come and meet with you?”

⁴Four times they sent the same message, and each time I gave the same reply. ⁵The fifth time, Sanballat’s servant came with an open letter in his hand, ⁶and this is what it said:

“There is a rumor among the surrounding nations, and Geshem tells me it is true, that you and the Jews are planning to rebel and that is why you are building the wall. According to his reports, you plan to be their king. ⁷He also reports that you have appointed prophets in Jerusalem to proclaim about you, ‘Look! There is a king in Judah!’

“You can be very sure that this report will get back to the king, so I suggest that you come and talk it over with me.”

⁸I replied, “There is no truth in any part of your story. You are making up the whole thing.”

⁹They were just trying to intimidate us, imagining that they could discourage us and stop the work. So I continued the work with even greater determination.

¹⁰Later I went to visit Shemaiah son of Delaiah and grandson of Mehetabel, who was confined to his home. He said, “Let us meet together inside the Temple of God and bolt the doors shut. Your enemies are coming to kill you tonight.”

¹¹But I replied, “Should someone in my position run from danger? Should someone in my position enter the Temple to save his life? No, I won’t do it!” ¹²I realized that God had not spoken to him, but that he had uttered this prophecy against me because Tobiah and Sanballat had hired him. ¹³They were hoping to intimidate me and make me sin. Then they would be able to accuse and discredit me.

¹⁴Remember, O my God, all the evil things that Tobiah and Sanballat have done. And remember Noadiah the prophet and all the prophets like her who have tried to intimidate me.

The Builders Complete the Wall

¹⁵So on October 2 the wall was finished—just fifty-two days after we had begun. ¹⁶When our enemies and the surrounding nations

heard about it, they were frightened and humiliated. They realized this work had been done with the help of our God.

¹⁷During those fifty-two days, many letters went back and forth between Tobiah and the nobles of Judah. ¹⁸For many in Judah had sworn allegiance to him because his father-in-law was Shecaniah son of Arah, and his son Jehohanan was married to the daughter of Meshullam son of Berekiah. ¹⁹They kept telling me about Tobiah's good deeds, and then they told him everything I said. And Tobiah kept sending threatening letters to intimidate me.

7



AFTER the wall was finished and I had set up the doors in the gates, the gatekeepers, singers, and Levites were appointed. ²I gave the responsibility of governing Jerusalem to my brother Hanani, along with Hananiah, the commander of the fortress, for he was a faithful man who feared God more than most. ³I said to them, "Do not leave the gates open during the hottest part of the day. And even while the gatekeepers are on duty, have them shut and bar the doors. Appoint the residents of Jerusalem to act as guards, everyone on a regular watch. Some will serve at sentry posts and some in front of their own homes."

Nehemiah Registers the People

⁴At that time the city was large and spacious, but the population was small, and none of the houses had been rebuilt. ⁵So my God gave me the idea to call together all the nobles and leaders of the city, along with the ordinary citizens, for registration. I had found the genealogical record of those who had first returned to Judah. This is what was written there:

⁶Here is the list of the Jewish exiles of the provinces who returned from their captivity. King Nebuchadnezzar had deported them to Babylon, but now they returned to Jerusalem

and the other towns in Judah where they originally lived.
⁷Their leaders were Zerubbabel, Jeshua, Nehemiah, Seraiah, Reelaiah, Nahamani, Mordecai, Bilshan, Mispar, Bigvai, Rehum, and Baanah.

This is the number of the men of Israel who returned from exile:

⁸ The family of Parosh	2,172
⁹ The family of Shephatiah	372
¹⁰ The family of Arah	652
¹¹ The family of Pahath-moab (descendants of Jeshua and Joab)	2,818
¹² The family of Elam	1,254
¹³ The family of Zattu	845
¹⁴ The family of Zaccai	760
¹⁵ The family of Bani	648
¹⁶ The family of Bebai	628
¹⁷ The family of Azgad	2,322
¹⁸ The family of Adonikam	667
¹⁹ The family of Bigvai	2,067
²⁰ The family of Adin	655
²¹ The family of Ater (descendants of Hezekiah)	98
²² The family of Hashum	328
²³ The family of Bezai	324
²⁴ The family of Jorah	112
²⁵ The family of Gibbar	95
²⁶ The people of Bethlehem and Netophah	188
²⁷ The people of Anathoth	128
²⁸ The people of Beth-azmaveth	42
²⁹ The people of Kiriath-jearim, Kephirah, and Beeroth	743
³⁰ The people of Ramah and Geba	621
³¹ The people of Micmash	122
³² The people of Bethel and Ai	123
³³ The people of West Nebo	52

³⁴ The citizens of West Elam	1,254
³⁵ The citizens of Harim	320
³⁶ The citizens of Jericho	345
³⁷ The citizens of Lod, Hadid, and Ono	721
³⁸ The citizens of Senaah	3,930

³⁹These are the priests who returned from exile:

The family of Jedaiah (through the line of Jeshua)	973
⁴⁰ The family of Immer	1,052
⁴¹ The family of Pashhur	1,247
⁴² The family of Harim	1,017

⁴³These are the Levites who returned from exile:

The families of Jeshua and Kadmiel (descendants of Hodaviah)	74
⁴⁴ The singers of the family of Asaph	148
⁴⁵ The gatekeepers of the families of Shallum, Ater, Talmon, Akkub, Hatita, and Shobai	138

⁴⁶The descendants of the following Temple servants returned from exile: Ziha, Hasupha, Tabbaoth, ⁴⁷Keros, Siaha, Padon, ⁴⁸Lebanah, Hagabah, Shalmal, ⁴⁹Hanan, Giddel, Gahar, ⁵⁰Reaiah, Rezin, Nekoda, ⁵¹Gazzam, Uzza, Paseah, ⁵²Besai, Meunim, Nephusim, ⁵³Bakbuk, Hakupha, Harhur, ⁵⁴Bazluth, Mehida, Harsha, ⁵⁵Barkos, Sisera, Temah, ⁵⁶Neziah, and Hatipha.

⁵⁷The descendants of these servants of King Solomon returned from exile: Sotai, Hassophereth, Peruda, ⁵⁸Jaalah, Darkon, Giddel, ⁵⁹Shephatiah, Hattil, Pokereth-hazzebaim, and Ami.

⁶⁰In all, the Temple servants and the descendants of Solomon's servants numbered 392.

⁶¹Another group returned at this time from the towns of Tel-melah, Tel-harsha, Kerub, Addan, and Immer. However, they could not prove that they or their families were descendants of Israel. ⁶²This group included the families of Delaiah, Tobiah, and Nekoda—a total of 642 people.

⁶³Three families of priests—Hobaiah, Hakkoz, and Barzillai—also returned. (This Barzillai had married a woman who was a descendant of Barzillai of Gilead, and he had taken her family name.) ⁶⁴They searched for their names in the genealogical records, but they were not found, so they were disqualified from serving as priests. ⁶⁵The governor told them not to eat the priests' share of food from the sacrifices until a priest could consult the Lord about the matter by using the Urim and Thummim—the sacred lots.

⁶⁶So a total of 42,360 people returned to Judah, ⁶⁷in addition to 7,337 servants and 245 singers, both men and women. ⁶⁸They took with them 736 horses, 245 mules, 69435 camels, and 6,720 donkeys.

⁷⁰Some of the family leaders gave gifts for the work. The governor gave to the treasury 1,000 gold coins, 50 gold basins, and 530 robes for the priests. ⁷¹The other leaders gave to the treasury a total of 20,000 gold coins and some 2,750 pounds of silver for the work. ⁷²The rest of the people gave 20,000 gold coins, about 2,500 pounds of silver, and 67 robes for the priests.

⁷³So the priests, the Levites, the gatekeepers, the singers, the Temple servants, and some of the common people settled near Jerusalem. The rest of the people returned to their own towns throughout Israel.

8

Ezra Reads the Law

In October when the Israelites had settled in their towns, ¹all the people assembled with a unified purpose at the square just inside the Water Gate. They asked Ezra the scribe to bring out the Book of the Law of Moses, which the Lord had given for Israel to obey.

²So on October 8 Ezra the priest brought the Book of the Law before the assembly, which included the men and women and all the children old enough to understand. ³He faced the square just inside the Water Gate from early morning until noon and read aloud to everyone who could understand. All the people listened closely to the Book of the Law.

⁴Ezra the scribe stood on a high wooden platform that had been made for the occasion. To his right stood Mattithiah, Shema, Anaiah, Uriah, Hilkiah, and Maaseiah. To his left stood Pedaiah, Mishael, Malkijah, Hashum, Hashbaddanah, Zechariah, and Meshullam. ⁵Ezra stood on the platform in full view of all the people. When they saw him open the book, they all rose to their feet.

⁶Then Ezra praised the Lord, the great God, and all the people chanted, “Amen! Amen!” as they lifted their hands. Then they bowed down and worshiped the Lord with their faces to the ground.

⁷The Levites—Jeshua, Bani, Sherebiah, Jamin, Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodiah, Maaseiah, Kelita, Azariah, Jozabad, Hanan, and Pelaiah—then instructed the people in the Law while everyone remained in their places. ⁸They read from the Book of the Law of God and clearly explained the meaning of what was being read, helping the people understand each passage.

⁹Then Nehemiah the governor, Ezra the priest and scribe, and the Levites who were interpreting for the people said to them, “Don’t mourn or weep on such a day as this! For today is a sacred day before the Lord your God.” For the people had all been weeping as they listened to the words of the Law.

¹⁰And Nehemiah continued, “Go and celebrate with a feast of rich foods and sweet drinks, and share gifts of food with people who have nothing prepared. This is a sacred day before our Lord. Don’t be dejected and sad, for the joy of the Lord is your strength!”

¹¹And the Levites, too, quieted the people, telling them, “Hush! Don’t weep! For this is a sacred day.” ¹²So the people went away to eat and drink at a festive meal, to share gifts of food, and to celebrate with great joy because they had heard God’s words and understood them.

The Festival of Shelters

¹³On October 9 the family leaders of all the people, together with the priests and Levites, met with Ezra the scribe to go over the Law in greater detail. ¹⁴As they studied the Law, they discovered that the Lord had commanded through Moses that the Israelites should live in shelters during the festival to be held that month. ¹⁵He had said that a proclamation should be made throughout their towns and in Jerusalem, telling the people to go to the hills to get branches from olive, wild olive, myrtle, palm, and other leafy trees. They were to use these branches to make shelters in which they would live during the festival, as prescribed in the Law.

¹⁶So the people went out and cut branches and used them to build shelters on the roofs of their houses, in their courtyards, in the courtyards of God’s Temple, or in the squares just inside the Water Gate and the Ephraim Gate. ¹⁷So everyone who had returned from captivity lived in these shelters during the festival, and they were all filled with great joy! The Israelites had not celebrated like this since the days of Joshua son of Nun.

¹⁸Ezra read from the Book of the Law of God on each of the seven days of the festival. Then on the eighth day they held a solemn assembly, as was required by law.

The People Confess Their Sins



ON October 31 the people assembled again, and this time they fasted and dressed in burlap and sprinkled dust on their heads.

²Those of Israelite descent separated themselves from all foreigners as they confessed their own sins and the sins of their ancestors. ³They remained standing in place for three hours while the Book of the Law of the Lord their God was read aloud to them. Then for three more hours they confessed their sins and worshiped the Lord their God. ⁴The Levites—Jeshua, Bani, Kadmiel, Shebaniah, Bunni, Sherebiah, Bani, and Kenani—stood on the stairway of the Levites and cried out to the Lord their God with loud voices.

⁵Then the leaders of the Levites—Jeshua, Kadmiel, Bani, Hashabneiah, Sherebiah, Hodiah, Shebaniah, and Pethahiah—called out to the people: “Stand up and praise the Lord your God, for he lives from everlasting to everlasting!” Then they prayed:

“May your glorious name be praised! May it be exalted above all blessing and praise!

⁶“You alone are the Lord. You made the skies and the heavens and all the stars. You made the earth and the seas and everything in them. You preserve them all, and the angels of heaven worship you.

⁷“You are the Lord God, who chose Abram and brought him from Ur of the Chaldeans and renamed him Abraham.

⁸When he had proved himself faithful, you made a covenant with him to give him and his descendants the land of the Canaanites, Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Jebusites, and Girgashites. And you have done what you promised, for you are always true to your word.

⁹“You saw the misery of our ancestors in Egypt, and you heard their cries from beside the Red Sea. ¹⁰You displayed miraculous signs and wonders against Pharaoh, his officials, and all his people, for you knew how arrogantly they were treating our ancestors. You have a glorious reputation that has never been forgotten. ¹¹You divided the sea for your people so they could walk through on dry land! And then you hurled their enemies into the depths of the sea. They sank like stones beneath the mighty waters. ¹²You led our ancestors by a pillar of cloud during the day and a pillar of fire at night so that they could find their way.

¹³“You came down at Mount Sinai and spoke to them from heaven. You gave them regulations and instructions that were just, and decrees and commands that were good. ¹⁴You instructed them concerning your holy Sabbath. And you commanded them, through Moses your servant, to obey all your commands, decrees, and instructions.

¹⁵“You gave them bread from heaven when they were hungry and water from the rock when they were thirsty. You commanded them to go and take possession of the land you had sworn to give them.

¹⁶“But our ancestors were proud and stubborn, and they paid no attention to your commands. ¹⁷They refused to obey and did not remember the miracles you had done for them. Instead, they became stubborn and appointed a leader to take them back to their slavery in Egypt. But you are a God of forgiveness, gracious and merciful, slow to become angry, and rich in unfailing love. You did not abandon them, ¹⁸even when they made an idol shaped like a calf and said, ‘This is your god who brought you out of Egypt!’ They committed terrible blasphemies.

¹⁹“But in your great mercy you did not abandon them to die in the wilderness. The pillar of cloud still led them forward by day, and the pillar of fire showed them the way through the night. ²⁰You sent your good Spirit to instruct them, and you did not stop giving them manna from heaven or water for their thirst. ²¹For forty years you sustained them in the wilderness, and they lacked nothing. Their clothes did not wear out, and their feet did not swell!

²²“Then you helped our ancestors conquer kingdoms and nations, and you placed your people in every corner of the land. They took over the land of King Sihon of Heshbon and the land of King Og of Bashan. ²³You made their descendants as numerous as the stars in the sky and brought them into the land you had promised to their ancestors.

²⁴“They went in and took possession of the land. You subdued whole nations before them. Even the Canaanites, who inhabited the land, were powerless! Your people could deal with these nations and their kings as they pleased. ²⁵Our ancestors captured fortified cities and fertile land. They took over houses full of good things, with cisterns already dug and vineyards and olive groves and fruit trees in abundance. So they ate until they were full and grew fat and enjoyed themselves in all your blessings.

²⁶“But despite all this, they were disobedient and rebelled against you. They turned their backs on your Law, they killed your prophets who warned them to return to you, and they committed terrible blasphemies. ²⁷So you handed them over to their enemies, who made them suffer. But in their time of trouble they cried to you, and you heard them from heaven. In your great mercy, you sent them liberators who rescued them from their enemies.

²⁸“But as soon as they were at peace, your people again committed evil in your sight, and once more you let their enemies conquer them. Yet whenever your people turned and cried to you again for help, you listened once more from heaven. In your wonderful mercy, you rescued them many times!

²⁹“You warned them to return to your Law, but they became proud and obstinate and disobeyed your commands. They did not follow your regulations, by which people will find life if only they obey. They stubbornly turned their backs on you and refused to listen. ³⁰In your love, you were patient with them for many years. You sent your Spirit, who warned them through the prophets. But still they wouldn’t listen! So once again you allowed the peoples of the land to conquer them. ³¹But in your great mercy, you did not destroy them completely or abandon them forever. What a gracious and merciful God you are!

³²“And now, our God, the great and mighty and awesome God, who keeps his covenant of unfailing love, do not let all the hardships we have suffered seem insignificant to you. Great trouble has come upon us and upon our kings and leaders and priests and prophets and ancestors—all of your people—from the days when the kings of Assyria first triumphed over us until now. ³³Every time you punished us you were being just. We have sinned greatly, and you gave us only what we deserved. ³⁴Our kings, leaders, priests, and ancestors did not obey your Law or listen to the warnings in your commands and laws. ³⁵Even while they had their own kingdom, they did not serve you, though you showered your goodness on them. You gave them a large, fertile land, but they refused to turn from their wickedness.

³⁶“So now today we are slaves in the land of plenty that you gave our ancestors for their enjoyment! We are slaves here in

this good land. ³⁷The lush produce of this land piles up in the hands of the kings whom you have set over us because of our sins. They have power over us and our livestock. We serve them at their pleasure, and we are in great misery.”

The People Agree to Obey

38 The people responded, “In view of all this, we are making a solemn promise and putting it in writing. On this sealed document are the names of our leaders and Levites and priests.”

10



HE document was ratified and sealed with the following names:

The governor:

Nehemiah son of Hacaliah, and also Zedekiah.

²The following priests:

Seraiah, Azariah, Jeremiah, ³Pashhur, Amariah, Malkijah, ⁴Hattush, Shebaniah, Malluch, ⁵Harim, Meremoth, Obadiah, ⁶Daniel, Ginnethon, Baruch, ⁷Meshullam, Abijah, Mijamin, ⁸Maaziah, Bilgai, and Shemaiah. These were the priests.

⁹The following Levites:

Jeshua son of Azaniah, Binnui from the family of Henadad, Kadmiel, ¹⁰and their fellow Levites: Shebaniah, Hodiah, Kelita, Pelaiah, Hanan, ¹¹Mica, Rehob, Hashabiah, ¹²Zaccur, Sherebiah, Shebaniah, ¹³Hodiah, Bani, and Beninu.

¹⁴The following leaders:

Parosh, Pahath-moab, Elam, Zattu, Bani, ¹⁵Bunni, Azgad, Bebai, ¹⁶Adonijah, Bigvai, Adin, ¹⁷Ater, Hezekiah, Azzur, ¹⁸Hodiah, Hashum, Bezai, ¹⁹Hariph, Anathoth, Nebai, ²⁰Magpiash, Meshullam, Hezir, ²¹Meshezabel, Zadok, Jaddua, ²²Pelatiah, Hanan, Ananiah, ²³Hoshea, Hananiah, Hasshub, ²⁴Hallohesh, Pilha, Shobek, ²⁵Rehum, Hashabnah, Maaseiah, ²⁶Ahiah, Hanan, Anan, ²⁷Malluch, Harim, and Baanah.

The Vow of the People

²⁸Then the rest of the people—the priests, Levites, gatekeepers, singers, Temple servants, and all who had separated themselves from the pagan people of the land in order to obey the Law of God, together with their wives, sons, daughters, and all who were old enough to understand—²⁹joined their leaders and bound themselves with an oath. They swore a curse on themselves if they failed to obey the Law of God as issued by his servant Moses. They solemnly promised to carefully follow all the commands, regulations, and decrees of the Lord our Lord:

³⁰“We promise not to let our daughters marry the pagan people of the land, and not to let our sons marry their daughters.

³¹“We also promise that if the people of the land should bring any merchandise or grain to be sold on the Sabbath or on any other holy day, we will refuse to buy it. Every seventh year we will let our land rest, and we will cancel all debts owed to us.

³²“In addition, we promise to obey the command to pay the annual Temple tax of one-eighth of an ounce of silver for the care of the Temple of our God. ³³This will provide for the Bread of the Presence; for the regular grain offerings and burnt offerings; for the offerings on the Sabbaths, the new moon celebrations, and the annual festivals; for the holy offerings; and for the sin offerings to make atonement for Israel. It will provide for everything necessary for the work of the Temple of our God.

³⁴“We have cast sacred lots to determine when—at regular times each year—the families of the priests, Levites, and the common people should bring wood to God’s Temple to be burned on the altar of the Lord our God, as is written in the Law.

³⁵“We promise to bring the first part of every harvest to the Lord’s Temple year after year—whether it be a crop from the soil or from our fruit trees. ³⁶We agree to give God our oldest sons and the firstborn of all our herds and flocks, as prescribed in the Law. We will present them to the priests who minister in the Temple of our God. ³⁷We will store the produce in the storerooms of the Temple of our God. We will bring the best of our flour and other grain offerings, the best of our fruit, and the best of our new wine and olive oil. And we promise to bring to the Levites a tenth of everything our land produces, for it is the Levites who collect the tithes in all our rural towns.

³⁸“A priest—a descendant of Aaron—will be with the Levites as they receive these tithes. And a tenth of all that is collected as tithes will be delivered by the Levites to the Temple of our God and placed in the storerooms. ³⁹The people and the Levites must bring these offerings of grain, new wine, and olive oil to the storerooms and place them in the sacred containers near the ministering priests, the gatekeepers, and the singers.

“We promise together not to neglect the Temple of our God.”

11

The People Occupy Jerusalem

HE leaders of the people were living in Jerusalem, the holy city. A tenth of the people from the other towns of Judah and Benjamin were chosen by sacred lots to live there, too, while the rest stayed where they were. ²And the people commended everyone who volunteered to resettle in Jerusalem.

³Here is a list of the names of the provincial officials who came to live in Jerusalem. (Most of the people, priests, Levites, Temple servants, and descendants of Solomon's servants continued to live in their own homes in the various towns of Judah, ⁴but some of the people from Judah and Benjamin resettled in Jerusalem.)

From the tribe of Judah:

Athaiah son of Uziah, son of Zechariah, son of Amariah, son of Shephatiah, son of Mahalalel, of the family of Perez. ⁵Also Maaseiah son of Baruch, son of Col-hozeh, son of Hazaiah, son of Adaiah, son of Joarib, son of Zechariah, of the family of Shelah.

⁶There were 468 descendants of Perez who lived in Jerusalem—all outstanding men.

⁷From the tribe of Benjamin:

Sallu son of Meshullam, son of Joed, son of Pedaiah, son of Kolaiah, son of Maaseiah, son of Ithiel, son of Jeshaiiah. ⁸After him were Gabbai and Sallai and a total of 928 relatives. ⁹Their chief officer was Joel son of Zicri, who was assisted by Judah son of Hassenuah, second-in-command over the city.

¹⁰From the priests:

Jedaiah son of Joarib; Jakin; ¹¹and Seraiah son of Hilkiah, son of Meshullam, son of Zadok, son of Meraioth, son of Ahitub, the supervisor of the Temple of God. ¹²Also 822 of their associates, who worked at the Temple. Also Adaiah son of Jeroham, son of Pelaliah, son of Amzi, son of Zechariah, son of Pashhur, son of Malkijah, ¹³along with 242 of his associates, who were heads of their families. Also Amashsai son of Azarel, son of Ahzai, son of Meshillemoth, son of Immer, ¹⁴and 128 of his outstanding associates. Their chief officer was Zabdiel son of Haggadolim.

¹⁵From the Levites:

Shemaiah son of Hasshub, son of Azrikam, son of Hashabiah, son of Bunni. ¹⁶Also Shabbethai and Jozabad, who were in charge of the work outside the Temple of God. ¹⁷Also Mattaniah son of Mica, son of Zabdi, a descendant of Asaph, who led in thanksgiving and

prayer. Also Bakbukiah, who was Mattaniah's assistant, and Abda son of Shammua, son of Galal, son of Jeduthun. ¹⁸In all, there were 284 Levites in the holy city.

¹⁹From the gatekeepers:

Akkub, Talmon, and 172 of their associates, who guarded the gates.

²⁰The other priests, Levites, and the rest of the Israelites lived wherever their family inheritance was located in any of the towns of Judah.

²¹The Temple servants, however, whose leaders were Ziha and Gishpa, all lived on the hill of Ophel.

²²The chief officer of the Levites in Jerusalem was Uzzi son of Bani, son of Hashabiah, son of Mattaniah, son of Mica, a descendant of Asaph, whose family served as singers at God's Temple. ²³Their daily responsibilities were carried out according to the terms of a royal command.

²⁴Pethahiah son of Meshezabel, a descendant of Zerah son of Judah, was the royal adviser in all matters of public administration.

²⁵As for the surrounding villages with their open fields, some of the people of Judah lived in Kiriath-arba with its settlements, Dibon with its settlements, and Jekabzeel with its villages. ²⁶They also lived in Jeshua, Moladah, Beth-pelet, ²⁷Hazar-shual, Beersheba with its settlements, ²⁸Ziklag, and Meconah with its settlements. ²⁹They also lived in En-rimmon, Zorah, Jarmuth, ³⁰Zanoah, and Adullam with their surrounding villages. They also lived in Lachish with its nearby fields and Azekah with its surrounding villages. So the people of Judah were living all the way from Beersheba in the south to the valley of Hinnom.

³¹Some of the people of Benjamin lived at Geba, Micmash, Aija, and Bethel with its settlements. ³²They also lived in Anathoth, Nob, Ananiah, ³³Hazor, Ramah, Gittaim, ³⁴Hadid, Zeboim, Neballat, ³⁵Lod, Ono, and the Valley of Craftsmen. ³⁶Some of the Levites who lived in Judah were sent to live with the tribe of Benjamin.

12

A History of the Priests and Levites



HERE is the list of the priests and Levites who returned with Zerubbabel son of Shealtiel and Jeshua the high priest:

Seraiah, Jeremiah, Ezra,

²Amariah, Malluch, Hattush,

³Shecaniah, Harim, Meremoth,

⁴Iddo, Ginnethon, Abijah,

⁵Miniamin, Moadiah, Bilgah,

⁶Shemaiah, Joiarib, Jedaiah,

⁷Sallu, Amok, Hilkiyah, and Jedaiah.

These were the leaders of the priests and their associates in the days of Jeshua.

⁸The Levites who returned with them were Jeshua, Binnui, Kadmiel, Sherebiah, Judah, and Mattaniah, who with his associates was in charge of the songs of thanksgiving. ⁹Their associates, Bakbukiah and Unni, stood opposite them during the service.

¹⁰Jeshua the high priest was the father of Joiakim.

Joiakim was the father of Eliashib.

Eliashib was the father of Joiada.

¹¹Joiada was the father of Johanan.

Johanan was the father of Jaddua.

¹²Now when Joiakim was high priest, the family leaders of the priests were as follows:

Meraiah was leader of the family of Seraiah.

Hananiah was leader of the family of Jeremiah.

¹³Meshullam was leader of the family of Ezra.

Jehohanan was leader of the family of Amariah.

¹⁴Jonathan was leader of the family of Malluch.

Joseph was leader of the family of Shecaniah.

¹⁵Adna was leader of the family of Harim.

Helkai was leader of the family of Meremoth.

¹⁶Zechariah was leader of the family of Iddo.

Meshullam was leader of the family of Ginnethon.

¹⁷Zicri was leader of the family of Abijah.

There was also a leader of the family of Miniamin.

Piltai was leader of the family of Moadiah.

¹⁸Shammua was leader of the family of Bilgah.

Jehonathan was leader of the family of Shemaiah.

¹⁹Mattenai was leader of the family of Joiarib.

Uzzi was leader of the family of Jedaiah.

²⁰Kallai was leader of the family of Sallu.

Eber was leader of the family of Amok.

²¹Hashabiah was leader of the family of Hilkiah.

Nethanel was leader of the family of Jedaiah.

²²A record of the Levite families was kept during the years when Eliashib, Joiada, Johanan, and Jaddua served as high priest. Another record of the priests was kept during the reign of Darius the Persian.

²³A record of the heads of the Levite families was kept in The Book of History down to the days of Johanan, the grandson of Eliashib.

²⁴These were the family leaders of the Levites: Hashabiah, Sherebiah, Jeshua, Binnui, Kadmiel, and other associates, who stood opposite them during the ceremonies of praise and thanksgiving, one section responding to the other, as commanded by David, the man of God. ²⁵This included Mattaniah, Bakbukiah, and Obadiah.

Meshullam, Talmon, and Akkub were the gatekeepers in charge of the storerooms at the gates. ²⁶These all served in the days of Joiakim son of Jeshua, son of Jehozadak, and in the days of Nehemiah the governor and of Ezra the priest and scribe.

Dedication of Jerusalem's Wall

²⁷For the dedication of the new wall of Jerusalem, the Levites throughout the land were asked to come to Jerusalem to assist in the ceremonies. They were to take part in the joyous occasion with their songs of thanksgiving and with the music of cymbals, harps, and lyres. ²⁸The singers were brought together from the region around Jerusalem and from the villages of the Netophathites. ²⁹They also came from Beth-gilgal and the rural areas near Geba and Azmaveth, for the singers had built their own settlements around Jerusalem. ³⁰The priests and Levites first purified themselves; then they purified the people, the gates, and the wall.

³¹I led the leaders of Judah to the top of the wall and organized two large choirs to give thanks. One of the choirs proceeded southward along the top of the wall to the Dung Gate. ³²Hoshaiah and half the leaders of Judah followed them, ³³along with Azariah, Ezra, Meshullam, ³⁴Judah, Benjamin, Shemaiah, and Jeremiah. ³⁵Then came some priests who played trumpets, including Zechariah son of Jonathan, son of Shemaiah, son of Mattaniah, son of Micaiah, son of Zaccur, a descendant of Asaph. ³⁶And Zechariah's colleagues were Shemaiah, Azarel, Milalai, Gilalai, Maai, Nethanel, Judah, and Hanani. They used the musical instruments prescribed by David, the man of God. Ezra the scribe led this procession. ³⁷At the Fountain Gate they went straight up the steps on the ascent of the city wall toward the City of David. They passed the house of David and then proceeded to the Water Gate on the east.

³⁸The second choir giving thanks went northward around the other way to meet them. I followed them, together with the other half of the people, along the top of the wall past the Tower of the Ovens to the Broad Wall, ³⁹then past the Ephraim Gate to the Old City Gate, past the Fish Gate and the Tower of Hananel, and on to the Tower of the Hundred. Then we continued on to the Sheep Gate and stopped at the Guard Gate.

⁴⁰The two choirs that were giving thanks then proceeded to the Temple of God, where they took their places. So did I, together with the group of leaders who were with me. ⁴¹We went together with the trumpet-playing priests—Eliakim, Maaseiah, Miniamin, Micaiah, Elioenai, Zechariah, and Hananiah—⁴²and the singers—Maaseiah, Shemaiah, Eleazar, Uzzi, Jehohanan, Malkijah, Elam, and Ezer. They played and sang loudly under the direction of Jezrahiah the choir director.

⁴³Many sacrifices were offered on that joyous day, for God had given the people cause for great joy. The women and children also participated in the celebration, and the joy of the people of Jerusalem could be heard far away.

Provisions for Temple Worship

⁴⁴On that day men were appointed to be in charge of the storerooms for the offerings, the first part of the harvest, and the tithes. They were responsible to collect from the fields outside the towns the portions required by the Law for the priests and Levites. For all the people of Judah took joy in the priests and Levites and their work. ⁴⁵They performed the service of their God and the service of purification, as commanded by David and his son Solomon, and so did the singers and the gatekeepers. ⁴⁶The custom of having choir directors to lead the choirs in hymns of praise and thanksgiving to God began long ago in the days of David and Asaph. ⁴⁷So now, in the days of Zerubbabel and of Nehemiah, all Israel brought a daily supply of food for the singers, the gatekeepers, and the Levites. The Levites, in turn, gave a portion of what they received to the priests, the descendants of Aaron.

13**Nehemiah's Various Reforms**

QUIN that same day, as the Book of Moses was being read to the people, the passage was found that said no Ammonite or Moabite should ever be permitted to enter the assembly of God.² For they had not provided the Israelites with food and water in the wilderness. Instead, they hired Balaam to curse them, though our God turned the curse into a blessing.³ When this passage of the Law was read, all those of foreign descent were immediately excluded from the assembly.

⁴Before this had happened, Eliashib the priest, who had been appointed as supervisor of the storerooms of the Temple of our God and who was also a relative of Tobiah,⁵ had converted a large storage room and placed it at Tobiah's disposal. The room had previously been used for storing the grain offerings, the frankincense, various articles for the Temple, and the tithes of grain, new wine, and olive oil (which were prescribed for the Levites, the singers, and the gatekeepers), as well as the offerings for the priests.

⁶I was not in Jerusalem at that time, for I had returned to King Artaxerxes of Babylon in the thirty-second year of his reign, though I later asked his permission to return.⁷ When I arrived back in Jerusalem, I learned about Eliashib's evil deed in providing Tobiah with a room in the courtyards of the Temple of God.⁸ I became very upset and threw all of Tobiah's belongings out of the room.⁹ Then I demanded that the rooms be purified, and I brought back the articles for God's Temple, the grain offerings, and the frankincense.

¹⁰I also discovered that the Levites had not been given their prescribed portions of food, so they and the singers who were to conduct the worship services had all returned to work their fields.¹¹ I immediately confronted the leaders and demanded, "Why has the Temple of God been neglected?" Then I called all the Levites back again and restored them to their proper duties.¹² And once more all the people

of Judah began bringing their tithes of grain, new wine, and olive oil to the Temple storerooms.

¹³I assigned supervisors for the storerooms: Shelemiah the priest, Zadok the scribe, and Pedaiah, one of the Levites. And I appointed Hanan son of Zaccur and grandson of Mattaniah as their assistant. These men had an excellent reputation, and it was their job to make honest distributions to their fellow Levites.

¹⁴Remember this good deed, O my God, and do not forget all that I have faithfully done for the Temple of my God and its services.

¹⁵In those days I saw men of Judah treading out their winepresses on the Sabbath. They were also bringing in grain, loading it on donkeys, and bringing their wine, grapes, figs, and all sorts of produce to Jerusalem to sell on the Sabbath. So I rebuked them for selling their produce on that day. ¹⁶Some men from Tyre, who lived in Jerusalem, were bringing in fish and all kinds of merchandise. They were selling it on the Sabbath to the people of Judah—and in Jerusalem at that!

¹⁷So I confronted the nobles of Judah. “Why are you profaning the Sabbath in this evil way?” I asked. ¹⁸“Wasn’t it just this sort of thing that your ancestors did that caused our God to bring all this trouble upon us and our city? Now you are bringing even more wrath upon Israel by permitting the Sabbath to be desecrated in this way!”

¹⁹Then I commanded that the gates of Jerusalem should be shut as darkness fell every Friday evening, not to be opened until the Sabbath ended. I sent some of my own servants to guard the gates so that no merchandise could be brought in on the Sabbath day. ²⁰The merchants and tradesmen with a variety of wares camped outside Jerusalem once or twice. ²¹But I spoke sharply to them and said, “What are you doing out here, camping around the wall? If you do this again, I will arrest you!” And that was the last time they came on the Sabbath. ²²Then I commanded the Levites to purify themselves and to guard the gates in order to preserve the holiness of the Sabbath.

Remember this good deed also, O my God! Have compassion on me according to your great and unfailing love.

²³About the same time I realized that some of the men of Judah had married women from Ashdod, Ammon, and Moab. ²⁴Furthermore, half their children spoke the language of Ashdod or of some other people and could not speak the language of Judah at all. ²⁵So I confronted them and called down curses on them. I beat some of them and pulled out their hair. I made them swear in the name of God that they would not let their children intermarry with the pagan people of the land.

²⁶“Wasn’t this exactly what led King Solomon of Israel into sin?” I demanded. “There was no king from any nation who could compare to him, and God loved him and made him king over all Israel. But even he was led into sin by his foreign wives. ²⁷How could you even think of committing this sinful deed and acting unfaithfully toward God by marrying foreign women?”

²⁸One of the sons of Joiada son of Eliashib the high priest had married a daughter of Sanballat the Horonite, so I banished him from my presence.

²⁹Remember them, O my God, for they have defiled the priesthood and the solemn vows of the priests and Levites.

³⁰So I purged out everything foreign and assigned tasks to the priests and Levites, making certain that each knew his work. ³¹I also made sure that the supply of wood for the altar and the first portions of the harvest were brought at the proper times.

Remember this in my favor, O my God.

1 Chronicles

1

From Adam to Noah's Sons



THE descendants of Adam were Seth, Enosh, ²Kenan, Mahalalel, Jared, ³Enoch, Methuselah, Lamech, ⁴and Noah.

The sons of Noah were Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

Descendants of Japheth

⁵The descendants of Japheth were Gomer, Magog, Madai, Javan, Tubal, Meshech, and Tiras.

⁶The descendants of Gomer were Ashkenaz, Riphath, and Togarmah.

⁷The descendants of Javan were Elishah, Tarshish, Kittim, and Rodanim.

Descendants of Ham

⁸The descendants of Ham were Cush, Mizraim, Put, and Canaan.

⁹The descendants of Cush were Seba, Havilah, Sabtah, Raamah, and Sabteca. The descendants of Raamah were Sheba and Dedan.

¹⁰Cush was also the ancestor of Nimrod, who was the first heroic warrior on earth.

¹¹Mizraim was the ancestor of the Ludites, Anamites, Lehabites, Naphtuhites, ¹²Pathrusites, Casluhites, and the Caphtorites, from whom the Philistines came.

¹³Canaan's oldest son was Sidon, the ancestor of the Sidonians. Canaan was also the ancestor of the Hittites, ¹⁴Jebusites, Amorites, Girgashites, ¹⁵Hivites, Arkites, Sinites, ¹⁶Arvadites, Zemarites, and Hamathites.

Descendants of Shem

¹⁷The descendants of Shem were Elam, Asshur, Arphaxad, Lud, and Aram.

The descendants of Aram were Uz, Hul, Gether, and Mash.

¹⁸Arphaxad was the father of Shelah.

Shelah was the father of Eber.

¹⁹Eber had two sons. The first was named Peleg (which means "division"), for during his lifetime the people of the world were divided into different language groups. His brother's name was Joktan.

²⁰Joktan was the ancestor of Almodad, Sheleph, Hazarmaveth, Jerah, ²¹Hadoram, Uzal, Diklah, ²²Obal, Abimael, Sheba, ²³Ophir, Havilah, and Jobab. All these were descendants of Joktan.

²⁴So this is the family line descended from Shem: Arphaxad, Shelah, ²⁵Eber, Peleg, Reu, ²⁶Serug, Nahor, Terah, ²⁷and Abram, later known as Abraham.

Descendants of Abraham

²⁸The sons of Abraham were Isaac and Ishmael. ²⁹These are their genealogical records:

The sons of Ishmael were Nebaioth (the oldest), Kedar, Adbeel, Mibsam, ³⁰Mishma, Dumah, Massa, Hadad, Tema, ³¹Jetur, Naphish, and Kedemah. These were the sons of Ishmael.

³²The sons of Keturah, Abraham's concubine, were Zimran, Jokshan, Medan, Midian, Ishbak, and Shuah.

The sons of Jokshan were Sheba and Dedan.

³³The sons of Midian were Ephah, Ephher, Hanoch, Abida, and Eldaah.

All these were descendants of Abraham through his concubine Keturah.

Descendants of Isaac

³⁴Abraham was the father of Isaac. The sons of Isaac were Esau and Israel.

Descendants of Esau

³⁵The sons of Esau were Eliphaz, Reuel, Jeush, Jalam, and Korah.

³⁶The descendants of Eliphaz were Teman, Omar, Zepho, Gatam, Kenaz, and Amalek, who was born to Timna.

³⁷The descendants of Reuel were Nahath, Zerah, Shammah, and Mizzah.

Original Peoples of Edom

³⁸The descendants of Seir were Lotan, Shobal, Zibeon, Anah, Dishon, Ezer, and Dishan.

³⁹The descendants of Lotan were Hori and Hemam. Lotan's sister was named Timna.

⁴⁰The descendants of Shobal were Alvan, Manahath, Ebal, Shepho, and Onam.

The descendants of Zibeon were Aiah and Anah.

⁴¹The son of Anah was Dishon.

The descendants of Dishon were Hemdan, Eshban, Ithran, and Keran.

⁴²The descendants of Ezer were Bilhan, Zaavan, and Akan.

The descendants of Dishan were Uz and Aran.

Rulers of Edom

⁴³These are the kings who ruled in the land of Edom before any king ruled over the Israelites:

Bela son of Beor, who ruled from his city of Dinhabah.

⁴⁴When Bela died, Jobab son of Zerah from Bozrah became king in his place.

⁴⁵When Jobab died, Husham from the land of the Temanites became king in his place.

⁴⁶When Husham died, Hadad son of Bedad became king in his place and ruled from the city of Avith. He was the one who destroyed the Midianite army in the land of Moab.

⁴⁷When Hadad died, Samlah from the city of Masrekah became king in his place.

⁴⁸When Samlah died, Shaul from the city of Rehoboth-on-the-River became king in his place.

⁴⁹When Shaul died, Baal-hanan son of Acbor became king in his place.

⁵⁰When Baal-hanan died, Hadad became king in his place and ruled from the city of Pau. His wife was Mehetabel, the daughter of Matred and granddaughter of Me-zahab. ⁵¹Then Hadad died.

The clan leaders of Edom were Timna, Alvah, Jetheth, ⁵²Oholibamah, Elah, Pinon, ⁵³Kenaz, Teman, Mibzar, ⁵⁴Magdiel, and Iram. These are the clan leaders of Edom.

2

Descendants of Israel



HE sons of Israel were Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun, ²Dan, Joseph, Benjamin, Naphtali, Gad, and Asher.

Descendants of Judah

³Judah had three sons from Bathshua, a Canaanite woman. Their names were Er, Onan, and Shelah. But the Lord saw that the oldest son, Er, was a wicked man, so he killed him. ⁴Later Judah had twin sons from Tamar, his widowed daughter-in-law. Their names were Perez and Zerah. So Judah had five sons in all.

⁵The sons of Perez were Hezron and Hamul.

⁶The sons of Zerah were Zimri, Ethan, Heman, Calcol, and Darda—five in all.

⁷The son of Carmi (a descendant of Zimri) was Achan, who brought disaster on Israel by taking plunder that had been set apart for the Lord.

⁸The son of Ethan was Azariah.

From Judah's Grandson Hezron to David

⁹The sons of Hezron were Jerahmeel, Ram, and Caleb.

¹⁰Ram was the father of Amminadab.

Amminadab was the father of Nahshon, a leader of Judah.

¹¹Nahshon was the father of Salmon.

Salmon was the father of Boaz.

¹²Boaz was the father of Obed.

Obed was the father of Jesse.

¹³Jesse's first son was Eliab, his second was Abinadab, his third was Shimea, ¹⁴his fourth was Nethanel, his fifth was Raddai, ¹⁵his sixth was Ozem, and his seventh was David.

¹⁶Their sisters were named Zeruiah and Abigail. Zeruiah had three sons named Abishai, Joab, and Asahel. ¹⁷Abigail married a man named Jether, an Ishmaelite, and they had a son named Amasa.

Other Descendants of Hezron

¹⁸Hezron's son Caleb had sons from his wife Azubah and from Jerioth. Her sons were named Jesher, Shobab, and Ardon. ¹⁹After Azubah

died, Caleb married Ephrathah, and they had a son named Hur.

²⁰Hur was the father of Uri. Uri was the father of Bezalel.

²¹When Hezron was sixty years old, he married Gilead's sister, the daughter of Makir. They had a son named Segub. ²²Segub was the father of Jair, who ruled twenty-three towns in the land of Gilead. ²³(But Geshur and Aram captured the Towns of Jair and also took Kenath and its sixty surrounding villages.) All these were descendants of Makir, the father of Gilead.

²⁴Soon after Hezron died in the town of Caleb-ephrathah, his wife Abijah gave birth to a son named Ashhur (the father of Tekoa).

Descendants of Hezron's Son Jerahmeel

²⁵The sons of Jerahmeel, the oldest son of Hezron, were Ram (the firstborn), Bunah, Oren, Ozem, and Ahijah. ²⁶Jerahmeel had a second wife named Atarah. She was the mother of Onam.

²⁷The sons of Ram, the oldest son of Jerahmeel, were Maaz, Jamin, and Eker.

²⁸The sons of Onam were Shammai and Jada.

The sons of Shammai were Nadab and Abishur.

²⁹The sons of Abishur and his wife Abihail were Ahban and Molid.

³⁰The sons of Nadab were Seled and Appaim. Seled died without children, ³¹but Appaim had a son named Ishi. The son of Ishi was Sheshan. Sheshan had a descendant named Ahlai.

³²The sons of Jada, Shammai's brother, were Jether and Jonathan. Jether died without children, ³³but Jonathan had two sons named Peleth and Zaza.

These were all descendants of Jerahmeel.

³⁴Sheshan had no sons, though he did have daughters. He also had an Egyptian servant named Jarha. ³⁵Sheshan gave one of his daughters to be the wife of Jarha, and they had a son named Attai.

³⁶Attai was the father of Nathan.

Nathan was the father of Zabad.

³⁷Zabad was the father of Ephlal.

Ephlal was the father of Obed.

³⁸Obed was the father of Jehu.

Jehu was the father of Azariah.

³⁹Azariah was the father of Helez.

Helez was the father of Eleasah.

⁴⁰Eleasah was the father of Sismai.

Sismai was the father of Shallum.

⁴¹Shallum was the father of Jekamiah.

Jekamiah was the father of Elishama.

Descendants of Hezron's Son Caleb

⁴²The descendants of Caleb, the brother of Jerahmeel, included Meshah (the firstborn), who became the father of Ziph. Caleb's descendants also included the sons of Mareshah, the father of Hebron.

⁴³The sons of Hebron were Korah, Tappuah, Rekem, and Shema.

⁴⁴Shema was the father of Raham. Raham was the father of Jorkeam. Rekem was the father of Shammai. ⁴⁵The son of Shammai was Maon. Maon was the father of Beth-zur.

⁴⁶Caleb's concubine Ephah gave birth to Haran, Moza, and Gazez. Haran was the father of Gazez.

⁴⁷The sons of Jahdai were Regem, Jotham, Geshan, Pelet, Ephah, and Shaaph.

⁴⁸Another of Caleb's concubines, Maacah, gave birth to Sheber and Tirhanah. ⁴⁹She also gave birth to Shaaph (the father of Madmannah) and Sheva (the father of Macbenah and Gibeon). Caleb also had a daughter named Acsah.

⁵⁰These were all descendants of Caleb.

Descendants of Caleb's Son Hur

The sons of Hur, the oldest son of Caleb's wife Ephrathah, were Shobal (the founder of Kiriath-jearim), ⁵¹Salma (the founder of Bethlehem), and Hareph (the founder of Beth-gader).

⁵²The descendants of Shobal (the founder of Kiriath-jearim) were Haroeh, half the Manahathites, ⁵³and the families of Kiriath-jearim—the Ithrites, Puthites, Shumathites, and Mishraites, from whom came the people of Zorah and Eshtaol.

⁵⁴The descendants of Salma were the people of Bethlehem, the Ne-tophathites, Atroth-beth-joab, the other half of the Manahathites, the Zorites, ⁵⁵and the families of scribes living at Jabez—the Tirathites, Shimeathites, and Sucathites. All these were Kenites who descended from Hammath, the father of the family of Recab.

3

Descendants of David



THESE are the sons of David who were born in Hebron: The oldest was Amnon, whose mother was Ahinoam from Jezreel.

The second was Daniel, whose mother was Abigail from Carmel.

²The third was Absalom, whose mother was Maacah, the daughter of Talmai, king of Geshur.

The fourth was Adonijah, whose mother was Haggith.

³The fifth was Shephatiah, whose mother was Abital.

The sixth was Ithream, whose mother was Eglah, David's wife.

⁴These six sons were born to David in Hebron, where he reigned seven and a half years.

Then David reigned another thirty-three years in Jerusalem. ⁵The sons born to David in Jerusalem included Shammua, Shobab, Nathan, and Solomon. Their mother was Bathsheba, the daughter of Ammiel.

⁶David also had nine other sons: Ibhar, Elishua, Elpelet, ⁷Nogah, Nepheg, Japhia, ⁸Elishama, Eliada, and Eliphelet.

⁹These were the sons of David, not including his sons born to his concubines. Their sister was named Tamar.

Descendants of Solomon

- ¹⁰The descendants of Solomon were Rehoboam, Abijah, Asa, Jehoshaphat, ¹¹Jehoram, Ahaziah, Joash, ¹²Amaziah, Uzziah, Jotham, ¹³Ahaz, Hezekiah, Manasseh, ¹⁴Amon, and Josiah.
- ¹⁵The sons of Josiah were Johanan (the oldest), Jehoiakim (the second), Zedekiah (the third), and Jehoahaz (the fourth).
- ¹⁶The successors of Jehoiakim were his son Jehoiachin and his brother Zedekiah.

Descendants of Jehoiachin

- ¹⁷The sons of Jehoiachin, who was taken prisoner by the Babylonians, were Shealtiel, ¹⁸Malkiram, Pedaiah, Shenazzar, Jekamiah, Hoshama, and Nedabiah.
- ¹⁹The sons of Pedaiah were Zerubbabel and Shimei.
- The sons of Zerubbabel were Meshullam and Hananiah. (Their sister was Shelomith.) ²⁰His five other sons were Hashubah, Ohel, Berekiah, Hasadiah, and Jushab-hesed.
- ²¹The sons of Hananiah were Pelatiah and Jeshaiah. Jeshaiah's son was Rephaiah. Rephaiah's son was Arnan. Arnan's son was Obadiah. Obadiah's son was Shecaniah.
- ²²The descendants of Shecaniah were Shemaiah and his sons, Hattush, Igal, Bariah, Neariah, and Shaphat—six in all.
- ²³The sons of Neariah were Elioenai, Hizkiah, and Azrikam—three in all.
- ²⁴The sons of Elioenai were Hodaviah, Eliashib, Pelaiah, Akkub, Johanan, Delaiah, and Anani—seven in all.

Other Descendants of Judah



THE descendants of Judah were Perez, Hezron, Carmi, Hur, and Shobal.

²Shobal's son Reaiah was the father of Jahath. Jahath was the father of Ahumai and Lahad. These were the families of the Zorathites.

³The descendants of Etam were Jezreel, Ishma, Idbash, their sister Hazzelepni, ⁴Penuel (the father of Gedor), and Ezer (the father of Hushah). These were the descendants of Hur (the firstborn of Ephrathah), the ancestor of Bethlehem.

⁵Ashhur (the father of Tekoa) had two wives, named Helah and Naarah. ⁶Naarah gave birth to Ahuzzam, Hepher, Temeni, and Haahashtari. ⁷Helah gave birth to Zereth, Izhar, Ethnan, ⁸and Koz, who became the ancestor of Anub, Zobebah, and all the families of Aharhel son of Harum.

⁹There was a man named Jabez who was more honorable than any of his brothers. His mother named him Jabez because his birth had been so painful. ¹⁰He was the one who prayed to the God of Israel, "Oh, that you would bless me and expand my territory! Please be with me in all that I do, and keep me from all trouble and pain!" And God granted him his request.

¹¹Kelub (the brother of Shuhah) was the father of Mehir. Mehir was the father of Eshton. ¹²Eshton was the father of Beth-rapha, Paseah, and Tehinnah. Tehinnah was the father of Ir-nahash. These were the descendants of Recah.

¹³The sons of Kenaz were Othniel and Seraiah. Othniel's sons were Hathath and Meonothai. ¹⁴Meonothai was the father of Ophrah. Seraiah was the father of Joab, the founder of the Valley of Craftsmen, so called because they were craftsmen.

¹⁵The sons of Caleb son of Jephunneh were Iru, Elah, and Naam. The son of Elah was Kenaz.

¹⁶The sons of Jehallelel were Ziph, Ziphah, Tiria, and Asarel.

¹⁷The sons of Ezra were Jether, Mered, Ephraim, and Jalon. One of Mered's wives became the mother of Miriam, Shammai, and Ishbah (the father of Eshtemoa). ¹⁸He married a woman from Judah, who became the mother of Jered (the father of Gedor), Heber (the father of Soco), and Jekuthiel (the father of Zanoah). Mered also married Bithiah, a daughter of Pharaoh, and she bore him children.

¹⁹Hodiah's wife was the sister of Naham. One of her sons was the father of Keilah the Garmite, and another was the father of Eshtemoa the Maacathite.

²⁰The sons of Shimon were Amnon, Rinnah, Ben-hanan, and Tilon. The descendants of Ishi were Zoheth and Ben-zoheth.

Descendants of Judah's Son Shelah

²¹Shelah was one of Judah's sons. The descendants of Shelah were Er (the father of Lecah); Laadah (the father of Mareshah); the families of linen workers at Beth-ashbea; ²²Jokim; the men of Cozeba; and Joash and Saraph, who ruled over Moab and Jashubi-lehem. These names all come from ancient records. ²³They were the pottery makers who lived in Netaim and Gederah. They lived there and worked for the king.

Descendants of Simeon

²⁴The sons of Simeon were Jemuel, Jamin, Jarib, Zohar, and Shaul.

²⁵The descendants of Shaul were Shallum, Mibsam, and Mishma.

²⁶The descendants of Mishma were Hammuel, Zaccur, and Shimei.

²⁷Shimei had sixteen sons and six daughters, but none of his brothers had large families. So Simeon's tribe never grew as large as the tribe of Judah.

²⁸They lived in Beersheba, Moladah, Hazar-shual, ²⁹Bilhah, Ezem, Tolad, ³⁰Bethuel, Hormah, Ziklag, ³¹Beth-marcaboth, Hazar-susim,

Beth-biri, and Shaaraim. These towns were under their control until the time of King David. ³²Their descendants also lived in Etam, Ain, Rimmon, Token, and Ashan—five towns ³³and their surrounding villages as far away as Baalath. This was their territory, and these names are listed in their genealogical records.

³⁴Other descendants of Simeon included Meshobab, Jamlech, Joshah son of Amaziah, ³⁵Joel, Jehu son of Joshibiah, son of Seraiah, son of Asiel, ³⁶Elioenai, Jaakobah, Jeshohaiah, Asaiah, Adiel, Jesimiel, Benaiah, ³⁷and Ziza son of Shiphi, son of Allon, son of Jedaiah, son of Shimri, son of Shemaiah.

³⁸These were the names of some of the leaders of Simeon's wealthy clans. Their families grew, ³⁹and they traveled to the region of Gerar, in the east part of the valley, seeking pastureland for their flocks. ⁴⁰They found lush pastures there, and the land was spacious, quiet, and peaceful.

Some of Ham's descendants had been living in that region. ⁴¹But during the reign of King Hezekiah of Judah, these leaders of Simeon invaded the region and completely destroyed the homes of the descendants of Ham and of the Meunites. No trace of them remains today. They killed everyone who lived there and took the land for themselves, because they wanted its good pastureland for their flocks. ⁴²Five hundred of these invaders from the tribe of Simeon went to Mount Seir, led by Pelatiah, Neariah, Rephaiah, and Uzziel—all sons of Ishi. ⁴³They destroyed the few Amalekites who had survived, and they have lived there ever since.

5

Descendants of Reuben

THE oldest son of Israel was Reuben. But since he dishonored his father by sleeping with one of his father's concubines, his birthright was given to the sons of his brother Joseph. For this reason,

Reuben is not listed in the genealogical records as the firstborn son.

²The descendants of Judah became the most powerful tribe and provided a ruler for the nation, but the birthright belonged to Joseph.

³The sons of Reuben, the oldest son of Israel, were Hanoch, Pallu, Hezron, and Carmi.

⁴The descendants of Joel were Shemaiah, Gog, Shimei, ⁵Micah, Reaiah, Baal, ⁶and Beerah. Beerah was the leader of the Reubenites when they were taken into captivity by King Tiglath-pileser of Assyria.

⁷Beerah's relatives are listed in their genealogical records by their clans: Jeiel (the leader), Zechariah, ⁸and Bela son of Azaz, son of Shema, son of Joel.

The Reubenites lived in the area that stretches from Aroer to Nebo and Baal-meon. ⁹And since they had so many livestock in the land of Gilead, they spread east toward the edge of the desert that stretches to the Euphrates River.

¹⁰During the reign of Saul, the Reubenites defeated the Hagrites in battle. Then they moved into the Hagrite settlements all along the eastern edge of Gilead.

Descendants of Gad

¹¹Next to the Reubenites, the descendants of Gad lived in the land of Bashan as far east as Salecah. ¹²Joel was the leader in the land of Bashan, and Shapham was second-in-command, followed by Janai and Shaphat.

¹³Their relatives, the leaders of seven other clans, were Michael, Meshullam, Sheba, Jorai, Jacan, Zia, and Eber. ¹⁴These were all descendants of Abihail son of Huri, son of Jaroah, son of Gilead, son of Michael, son of Jeshishai, son of Jahdo, son of Buz. ¹⁵Ahi son of Abdiel, son of Guni, was the leader of their clans.

¹⁶The Gadites lived in the land of Gilead, in Bashan and its villages, and throughout all the pasturelands of Sharon. ¹⁷All of these were listed in the genealogical records during the days of King Jotham of Judah and King Jeroboam of Israel.

The Tribes East of the Jordan

¹⁸There were 44,760 capable warriors in the armies of Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh. They were all skilled in combat and armed with shields, swords, and bows. ¹⁹They waged war against the Hagrites, the Jeturites, the Naphishites, and the Nodabites. ²⁰They cried out to God during the battle, and he answered their prayer because they trusted in him. So the Hagrites and all their allies were defeated. ²¹The plunder taken from the Hagrites included 50,000 camels, 250,000 sheep and goats, 2,000 donkeys, and 100,000 captives. ²²Many of the Hagrites were killed in the battle because God was fighting against them. The people of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh lived in their land until they were taken into exile.

²³The half-tribe of Manasseh was very large and spread through the land from Bashan to Baal-hermon, Senir, and Mount Hermon. ²⁴These were the leaders of their clans: Ephraim, Ishi, Eliel, Azriel, Jeremiah, Hodaviah, and Jahdiel. These men had a great reputation as mighty warriors and leaders of their clans.

²⁵But these tribes were unfaithful to the God of their ancestors. They worshiped the gods of the nations that God had destroyed. ²⁶So the God of Israel caused King Pul of Assyria (also known as Tiglath-pileser) to invade the land and take away the people of Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh as captives. The Assyrians exiled them to Halah, Habor, Hara, and the Gozan River, where they remain to this day.

6

The Priestly Line



THE sons of Levi were Gershon, Kohath, and Merari.
The descendants of Kohath included Amram, Izhar, Hebron,
and Uzziel.

³The children of Amram were Aaron, Moses, and Miriam.
The sons of Aaron were Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar, and Ithamar.

⁴Eleazar was the father of Phinehas.

Phinehas was the father of Abishua.

⁵Abishua was the father of Bukki.

Bukki was the father of Uzzi.

⁶Uzzi was the father of Zerariah.

Zerariah was the father of Meraioth.

⁷Meraioth was the father of Amariah.

Amariah was the father of Ahitub.

⁸Ahitub was the father of Zadok.

Zadok was the father of Ahimaaz.

⁹Ahimaaz was the father of Azariah.

Azariah was the father of Johanan.

¹⁰Johanan was the father of Azariah, the high priest at the Temple
built by Solomon in Jerusalem.

¹¹Azariah was the father of Amariah.

Amariah was the father of Ahitub.

¹²Ahitub was the father of Zadok.

Zadok was the father of Shallum.

¹³Shallum was the father of Hilkiah.

Hilkiah was the father of Azariah.

¹⁴Azariah was the father of Seraiah.

Seraiah was the father of Jehozadak, ¹⁵who went into exile when the
Lord sent the people of Judah and Jerusalem into captivity under
Nebuchadnezzar.

The Levite Clans

¹⁶The sons of Levi were Gershon, Kohath, and Merari.

¹⁷The descendants of Gershon included Libni and Shimei.

¹⁸The descendants of Kohath included Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel.

¹⁹The descendants of Merari included Mahli and Mushi.

The following were the Levite clans, listed according to their ancestral descent:

²⁰The descendants of Gershon included Libni, Jahath, Zimmah, ²¹Joah, Iddo, Zerah, and Jeatherai.

²²The descendants of Kohath included Amminadab, Korah, Assir, ²³Elkanah, Abiasaph, Assir, ²⁴Tahath, Uriel, Uzziel, and Shaul.

²⁵The descendants of Elkanah included Amasai, Ahimoth, ²⁶Elkanah, Zophai, Nahath, ²⁷Eliab, Jeroham, Elkanah, and Samuel.

²⁸The sons of Samuel were Joel (the older) and Abijah (the second).

²⁹The descendants of Merari included Mahli, Libni, Shimei, Uzzah, ³⁰Shimea, Haggiah, and Asaiah.

The Temple Musicians

³¹David assigned the following men to lead the music at the house of the Lord after the Ark was placed there. ³²They ministered with music at the Tabernacle until Solomon built the Temple of the Lord in Jerusalem. They carried out their work, following all the regulations handed down to them. ³³These are the men who served, along with their sons:

Heman the musician was from the clan of Kohath. His genealogy was traced back through Joel, Samuel, ³⁴Elkanah, Jeroham, Eliel, Toah, ³⁵Zuph, Elkanah, Mahath, Amasai, ³⁶Elkanah, Joel, Azariah, Zephaniah, ³⁷Tahath, Assir, Abiasaph, Korah, ³⁸Izhar, Kohath, Levi, and Israel.

³⁹Heman's first assistant was Asaph from the clan of Gershon. Asaph's genealogy was traced back through Berekiyah, Shimea, ⁴⁰Michael, Baaseiah, Malkijah, ⁴¹Ethni, Zerah, Adaiah, ⁴²Ethan, Zimmah, Shimei, ⁴³Jahath, Gershon, and Levi.

⁴⁴Heman's second assistant was Ethan from the clan of Merari. Ethan's genealogy was traced back through Kishi, Abdi, Malluch, ⁴⁵Hashabiah, Amaziah, Hilkiah, ⁴⁶Amzi, Bani, Shemer, ⁴⁷Mahli, Mushi, Merari, and Levi.

⁴⁸Their fellow Levites were appointed to various other tasks in the Tabernacle, the house of God.

Aaron's Descendants

⁴⁹Only Aaron and his descendants served as priests. They presented the offerings on the altar of burnt offering and the altar of incense, and they performed all the other duties related to the Most Holy Place. They made atonement for Israel by doing everything that Moses, the servant of God, had commanded them.

⁵⁰The descendants of Aaron were Eleazar, Phinehas, Abishua, ⁵¹Bukki, Uzzi, Zerahiah, ⁵²Meraioth, Amariah, Ahitub, ⁵³Zadok, and Ahimaaz.

Territory for the Levites

⁵⁴This is a record of the towns and territory assigned by means of sacred lots to the descendants of Aaron, who were from the clan of Kohath. ⁵⁵This territory included Hebron and its surrounding pasturelands in Judah, ⁵⁶but the fields and outlying areas belonging to the city were given to Caleb son of Jephunneh. ⁵⁷So the descendants of Aaron were given the following towns, each with its pasturelands: Hebron (a city of refuge), Libnah, Jattir, Eshtemoa, ⁵⁸Holon, Debir, ⁵⁹Ain, Juttah, and Beth-shemesh. ⁶⁰And from the territory of Benjamin they were given Gibeon, Geba, Alemeth, and Anathoth, each with its pasturelands. So thirteen towns were given to the descendants of Aaron. ⁶¹The remaining descendants of Kohath received ten towns

from the territory of the half-tribe of Manasseh by means of sacred lots.

⁶²The descendants of Gershon received by sacred lots thirteen towns from the territories of Issachar, Asher, Naphtali, and from the Bashan area of Manasseh, east of the Jordan.

⁶³The descendants of Merari received by sacred lots twelve towns from the territories of Reuben, Gad, and Zebulun.

⁶⁴So the people of Israel assigned all these towns and pasturelands to the Levites. ⁶⁵The towns in the territories of Judah, Simeon, and Benjamin, mentioned above, were assigned to them by means of sacred lots.

⁶⁶The descendants of Kohath were given the following towns from the territory of Ephraim, each with its pasturelands: ⁶⁷Shechem (a city of refuge in the hill country of Ephraim), Gezer, ⁶⁸Jokmeam, Beth-horon, ⁶⁹Aijalon, and Gath-rimmon. ⁷⁰The remaining descendants of Kohath were assigned the towns of Aner and Bileam from the territory of the half-tribe of Manasseh, each with its pasturelands.

⁷¹The descendants of Gershon received the towns of Golan (in Bashan) and Ashtaroth from the territory of the half-tribe of Manasseh, each with its pasturelands. ⁷²From the territory of Issachar, they were given Kedesh, Daberath, ⁷³Ramoth, and Anem, each with its pasturelands. ⁷⁴From the territory of Asher, they received Mashal, Abdon, ⁷⁵Hukok, and Rehob, each with its pasturelands. ⁷⁶From the territory of Naphtali, they were given Kedesh in Galilee, Hammon, and Kiriathaim, each with its pasturelands.

⁷⁷The remaining descendants of Merari received the towns of Jokneam, Kartah, Rimmon, and Tabor from the territory of Zebulun, each with its pasturelands. ⁷⁸From the territory of Reuben, east of the Jordan River opposite Jericho, they received Bezer (a desert town), Jahaz, ⁷⁹Kedemoth, and Mephaath, each with its pasturelands. ⁸⁰And from the territory of Gad, they received Ramoth in Gilead, Mahanaim, ⁸¹Heshbon, and Jazer, each with its pasturelands.

Descendants of Issachar



THE four sons of Issachar were Tola, Puah, Jashub, and Shimron.

²The sons of Tola were Uzzi, Rephaiah, Jeriel, Jahmai, Ibsam, and Shemuel. Each of them was the leader of an ancestral clan. At the time of King David, the total number of mighty warriors listed in the records of these clans was 22,600.

³The son of Uzzi was Izrahiah. The sons of Izrahiah were Michael, Obadiah, Joel, and Isshiah. These five became the leaders of clans. ⁴All of them had many wives and many sons, so the total number of men available for military service among their descendants was 36,000.

⁵The total number of mighty warriors from all the clans of the tribe of Issachar was 87,000. All of them were listed in their genealogical records.

Descendants of Benjamin

⁶Three of Benjamin's sons were Bela, Beker, and Jediahel.

⁷The five sons of Bela were Ezbon, Uzzi, Uzziel, Jerimoth, and Iri. Each of them was the leader of an ancestral clan. The total number of mighty warriors from these clans was 22,034, as listed in their genealogical records.

⁸The sons of Beker were Zemirah, Joash, Eliezer, Elioenai, Omri, Jeremoth, Abijah, Anathoth, and Alemeth. ⁹Each of them was the leader of an ancestral clan. The total number of mighty warriors and leaders from these clans was 20,200, as listed in their genealogical records.

¹⁰The son of Jediahel was Bilhan. The sons of Bilhan were Jeush, Benjamin, Ehud, Kenaanah, Zethan, Tarshish, and Ahishahar. ¹¹Each

of them was the leader of an ancestral clan. From these clans the total number of mighty warriors ready for war was 17,200.

¹²The sons of Ir were Shuppm and Huppm. Hushim was the son of Aher.

Descendants of Naphtali

¹³The sons of Naphtali were Jahzeel, Guni, Jezer, and Shillem. They were all descendants of Jacob's concubine Bilhah.

Descendants of Manasseh

¹⁴The descendants of Manasseh through his Aramean concubine included Asriel. She also bore Makir, the father of Gilead. ¹⁵Makir found wives for Huppm and Shuppm. Makir had a sister named Maacah. One of his descendants was Zelophehad, who had only daughters.

¹⁶Makir's wife, Maacah, gave birth to a son whom she named Peresh. His brother's name was Sheresh. The sons of Peresh were Ulam and Rakem. ¹⁷The son of Ulam was Bedan. All these were considered Gileadites, descendants of Makir son of Manasseh.

¹⁸Makir's sister Hammoleketh gave birth to Ishhod, Abiezer, and Mahlah.

¹⁹The sons of Shemida were Ahian, Shechem, Likhi, and Aniam.

Descendants of Ephraim

²⁰The descendants of Ephraim were Shuthelah, Bered, Tahath, Eleadah, Tahath, ²¹Zabad, Shuthelah, Ezer, and Elead. These two were killed trying to steal livestock from the local farmers near Gath. ²²Their father, Ephraim, mourned for them a long time, and his relatives came to comfort him. ²³Afterward Ephraim slept with his wife, and she became pregnant and gave birth to a son. Ephraim named him Beriah because of the tragedy his family

had suffered. ²⁴He had a daughter named Sheerah. She built the towns of Lower and Upper Beth-horon and Uzen-sheerah.

²⁵The descendants of Ephraim included Rephah, Resheph, Telah, Tahan, ²⁶Ladan, Ammihud, Elishama, ²⁷Nun, and Joshua.

²⁸The descendants of Ephraim lived in the territory that included Bethel and its surrounding towns to the south, Naaran to the east, Gezer and its villages to the west, and Shechem and its surrounding villages to the north as far as Ayyah and its towns. ²⁹Along the border of Manasseh were the towns of Beth-shan, Taanach, Megiddo, Dor, and their surrounding villages. The descendants of Joseph son of Israel lived in these towns.

Descendants of Asher

³⁰The sons of Asher were Imnah, Ishvah, Ishvi, and Beriah. They had a sister named Serah.

³¹The sons of Beriah were Heber and Malkiel (the father of Birzaith).

³²The sons of Heber were Japhlet, Shomer, and Hotham. They had a sister named Shua.

³³The sons of Japhlet were Pasach, Bimhal, and Ashvath.

³⁴The sons of Shomer were Ahi, Rohgah, Hubbah, and Aram.

³⁵The sons of his brother Helem were Zophah, Imna, Shelesh, and Amal.

³⁶The sons of Zophah were Suah, Harnepher, Shual, Beri, Imrah,

³⁷Bezer, Hod, Shamma, Shilshah, Ithran, and Beera.

³⁸The sons of Jether were Jephunneh, Pispah, and Ara.

³⁹The sons of Ulla were Arah, Hanniel, and Rizia.

⁴⁰Each of these descendants of Asher was the head of an ancestral clan. They were all select men—mighty warriors and outstanding leaders. The total number of men available for military service was 26,000, as listed in their genealogical records.

8

Descendants of Benjamin

BENJAMIN's first son was Bela, the second was Ashbel, the third was Aharah, ²the fourth was Nohah, and the fifth was Rapha.

³The sons of Bela were Addar, Gera, Abihud, ⁴Abishua, Naaman, Ahoah, ⁵Gera, Shephuphan, and Huram.

⁶The sons of Ehud, leaders of the clans living at Geba, were exiled to Manahath. ⁷Ehud's sons were Naaman, Ahijah, and Gera. Gera, who led them into exile, was the father of Uzza and Ahihud.

⁸After Shaharaim divorced his wives Hushim and Baara, he had children in the land of Moab. ⁹His wife Hodesh gave birth to Jobab, Zibia, Mesha, Malcam, ¹⁰Jeuz, Sakia, and Mirmah. These sons all became the leaders of clans.

¹¹Shaharaim's wife Hushim had already given birth to Abitub and Elpaal. ¹²The sons of Elpaal were Eber, Misham, Shemed (who built the towns of Ono and Lod and their nearby villages), ¹³Beriah, and Shema. They were the leaders of the clans living in Aijalon, and they drove out the inhabitants of Gath.

¹⁴Ahio, Shashak, Jeremoth, ¹⁵Zebadiah, Arad, Eder, ¹⁶Michael, Ishpah, and Joha were the sons of Beriah.

¹⁷Zebadiah, Meshullam, Hizki, Heber, ¹⁸Ishmerai, Izliah, and Jobab were the sons of Elpaal.

¹⁹Jakim, Zicri, Zabdi, ²⁰Eliehai, Zillethai, Eliel, ²¹Adaiah, Beraiah, and Shimrath were the sons of Shimei.

²²Ishpan, Eber, Eliel, ²³Abdon, Zicri, Hanan, ²⁴Hananiah, Elam, Anthothijah, ²⁵Iphdeiah, and Penuel were the sons of Shashak.

²⁶Shamsherai, Shehariah, Athaliah, ²⁷Jareshiah, Elijah, and Zicri were the sons of Jeroham.

²⁸These were the leaders of the ancestral clans; they were listed in their genealogical records, and they all lived in Jerusalem.

The Family of Saul

²⁹Jeiel (the father of Gibeon) lived in the town of Gibeon. His wife's name was Maacah, ³⁰and his oldest son was named Abdon. Jeiel's other sons were Zur, Kish, Baal, Ner, Nadab, ³¹Gedor, Ahio, Zechariah, ³²and Mikloth, who was the father of Shimeam. All these families lived near each other in Jerusalem.

³³Ner was the father of Kish.

Kish was the father of Saul.

Saul was the father of Jonathan, Malkishua, Abinadab, and Esh-baal.

³⁴Jonathan was the father of Merib-baal.

Merib-baal was the father of Micah.

³⁵Micah was the father of Pithon, Melech, Tahrea, and Ahaz.

³⁶Ahaz was the father of Jadah.

Jadah was the father of Alemeth, Azmaveth, and Zimri.

Zimri was the father of Moza.

³⁷Moza was the father of Binea.

Binea was the father of Rephaiah.

Rephaiah was the father of Eleasah.

Eleasah was the father of Azel.

³⁸Azel had six sons: Azrikam, Bokeru, Ishmael, Sheariah, Obadiah, and Hanan. These were the sons of Azel.

³⁹Azel's brother Eshek had three sons: the first was Ulam, the second was Jeush, and the third was Eliphelet. ⁴⁰Ulam's sons were all mighty warriors and expert archers. They had many sons and grandsons—150 in all.

All these were descendants of Benjamin.

9



So all Israel was listed in the genealogical records in *The Book of the Kings of Israel*.

The Returning Exiles

The people of Judah were exiled to Babylon because they were unfaithful to the Lord. ²The first of the exiles to return to their property in their former towns were priests, Levites, Temple servants, and other Israelites. ³Some of the people from the tribes of Judah, Benjamin, Ephraim, and Manasseh came and settled in Jerusalem.

⁴One family that returned was that of Uthai son of Ammihud, son of Omri, son of Imri, son of Bani, a descendant of Perez son of Judah.

⁵Others returned from the Shilonite clan, including Asaiah (the oldest) and his sons.

⁶From the Zerahite clan, Jeuel returned with his relatives.

In all, 690 families from the tribe of Judah returned.

++

⁷From the tribe of Benjamin came Sallu son of Meshullam, son of Hodaviah, son of Hassenuah; ⁸Ibneiah son of Jeroham; Elah son of Uzzi, son of Micri; and Meshullam son of Shephatiah, son of Reuel, son of Ibnijah.

⁹These men were all leaders of clans, and they were listed in their genealogical records. In all, 956 families from the tribe of Benjamin returned.

The Returning Priests

¹⁰Among the priests who returned were Jedaiah, Jehoiarib, Jakin,

¹¹Azariah son of Hilkiyah, son of Meshullam, son of Zadok, son of Meraioth, son of Ahitub. Azariah was the chief officer of the house of God.

¹²Other returning priests were Adaiah son of Jeroham, son of Pashhur, son of Malkijah, and Maasai son of Adiel, son of Jahzerah, son of Meshullam, son of Meshillemith, son of Immer.

¹³In all, 1,760 priests returned. They were heads of clans and very able men. They were responsible for ministering at the house of God.

The Returning Levites

¹⁴The Levites who returned were Shemaiah son of Hasshub, son of Azrikam, son of Hashabiah, a descendant of Merari; ¹⁵Bakbakkar; Heresh; Galal; Mattaniah son of Mica, son of Zicri, son of Asaph; ¹⁶Obadiah son of Shemaiah, son of Galal, son of Jeduthun; and Berekiah son of Asa, son of Elkanah, who lived in the area of Netophah.

¹⁷The gatekeepers who returned were Shallum, Akkub, Talmon, Ahiman, and their relatives. Shallum was the chief gatekeeper. ¹⁸Prior to this time, they were responsible for the King's Gate on the east side. These men served as gatekeepers for the camps of the Levites.

¹⁹Shallum was the son of Kore, a descendant of Abiasaph, from the clan of Korah. He and his relatives, the Korahites, were responsible for guarding the entrance to the sanctuary, just as their ancestors had guarded the Tabernacle in the camp of the Lord.

²⁰Phinehas son of Eleazar had been in charge of the gatekeepers in earlier times, and the Lord had been with him. ²¹And later Zechariah son of Meshelemiah was responsible for guarding the entrance to the Tabernacle.

²²In all, there were 212 gatekeepers in those days, and they were listed according to the genealogies in their villages. David and Samuel the seer had appointed their ancestors because they were reliable men.

²³These gatekeepers and their descendants, by their divisions, were responsible for guarding the entrance to the house of the Lord when that house was a tent. ²⁴The gatekeepers were stationed on all four sides—east, west, north, and south. ²⁵Their relatives in the villages came regularly to share their duties for seven-day periods.

²⁶The four chief gatekeepers, all Levites, were trusted officials, for they were responsible for the rooms and treasuries at the house of God. ²⁷They would spend the night around the house of God, since it was their duty to guard it and to open the gates every morning.

²⁸Some of the gatekeepers were assigned to care for the various articles used in worship. They checked them in and out to avoid any loss. ²⁹Others were responsible for the furnishings, the items in the sanctuary, and the supplies, such as choice flour, wine, olive oil, frankincense, and spices. ³⁰But it was the priests who blended the spices. ³¹Mattithiah, a Levite and the oldest son of Shallum the Korahite, was entrusted with baking the bread used in the offerings. ³²And some members of the clan of Kohath were in charge of preparing the bread to be set on the table each Sabbath day.

³³The musicians, all prominent Levites, lived at the Temple. They were exempt from other responsibilities since they were on duty at all hours. ³⁴All these men lived in Jerusalem. They were the heads of Levite families and were listed as prominent leaders in their genealogical records.

King Saul's Family Tree

³⁵Jeiel (the father of Gibeon) lived in the town of Gibeon. His wife's name was Maacah, ³⁶and his oldest son was named Abdon. Jeiel's other sons were Zur, Kish, Baal, Ner, Nadab, ³⁷Gedor, Ahio, Zechariah, and Mikloth. ³⁸Mikloth was the father of Shimeam. All these families lived near each other in Jerusalem.

³⁹Ner was the father of Kish.

Kish was the father of Saul.

Saul was the father of Jonathan, Malkishua, Abinadab, and Esh-baal.

⁴⁰Jonathan was the father of Merib-baal.

Merib-baal was the father of Micah.

⁴¹The sons of Micah were Pithon, Melech, Tahrea, and Ahaz.

⁴²Ahaz was the father of Jadah.

Jadah was the father of Alemeth, Azmaveth, and Zimri.

Zimri was the father of Moza.

⁴³Moza was the father of Binea.

Binea's son was Rephaiah.

Rephaiah's son was Eleasah.

Eleasah's son was Azel.

⁴⁴Azel had six sons, whose names were Azrikam, Bokeru, Ishmael, Sheariah, Obadiah, and Hanan. These were the sons of Azel.

10

The Death of King Saul

Now the Philistines attacked Israel, and the men of Israel fled before them. Many were slaughtered on the slopes of Mount Gilboa. ²The Philistines closed in on Saul and his sons, and they killed three of his sons—Jonathan, Abinadab, and Malkishua. ³The fighting grew very fierce around Saul, and the Philistine archers caught up with him and wounded him.

⁴Saul groaned to his armor bearer, “Take your sword and kill me before these pagan Philistines come to taunt and torture me.”

But his armor bearer was afraid and would not do it. So Saul took his own sword and fell on it. ⁵When his armor bearer realized that Saul was dead, he fell on his own sword and died. ⁶So Saul and his three sons died there together, bringing his dynasty to an end.

⁷When all the Israelites in the Jezreel Valley saw that their army had fled and that Saul and his sons were dead, they abandoned their towns and fled. So the Philistines moved in and occupied their towns.

⁸The next day, when the Philistines went out to strip the dead, they found the bodies of Saul and his sons on Mount Gilboa. ⁹So they stripped off Saul's armor and cut off his head. Then they proclaimed the good news of Saul's death before their idols and to the people throughout the land of Philistia. ¹⁰They placed his armor in the temple of their gods, and they fastened his head to the temple of Dagon.

¹¹But when everyone in Jabesh-gilead heard about everything the Philistines had done to Saul, ¹²all their mighty warriors brought the bodies of Saul and his sons back to Jabesh. Then they buried their bones beneath the great tree at Jabesh, and they fasted for seven days.

¹³So Saul died because he was unfaithful to the Lord. He failed to obey the Lord's command, and he even consulted a medium ¹⁴instead of asking the Lord for guidance. So the Lord killed him and turned the kingdom over to David son of Jesse.

11

David Becomes King of All Israel

HEN all Israel gathered before David at Hebron and told him, "We are your own flesh and blood. ²In the past, even when Saul was king, you were the one who really led the forces of Israel. And the Lord your God told you, 'You will be the shepherd of my people Israel. You will be the leader of my people Israel.'"

³So there at Hebron, David made a covenant before the Lord with all the elders of Israel. And they anointed him king of Israel, just as the Lord had promised through Samuel.

David Captures Jerusalem

⁴Then David and all Israel went to Jerusalem (or Jebus, as it used to be called), where the Jebusites, the original inhabitants of the land, were living. ⁵The people of Jebus taunted David, saying, "You'll never get in here!" But David captured the fortress of Zion, which is now called the City of David.

⁶David had said to his troops, "Whoever is first to attack the Jebusites will become the commander of my armies!" And Joab, the son of David's sister Zeruiah, was first to attack, so he became the commander of David's armies.

⁷David made the fortress his home, and that is why it is called the City of David. ⁸He extended the city from the supporting terraces to the surrounding area, while Joab rebuilt the rest of Jerusalem. ⁹And David became more and more powerful, because the Lord of Heaven's Armies was with him.

David's Mightiest Warriors

¹⁰These are the leaders of David's mighty warriors. Together with all Israel, they decided to make David their king, just as the Lord had promised concerning Israel.

¹¹Here is the record of David's mightiest warriors: The first was Jashobeam the Hacmonite, who was leader of the Three—the mightiest warriors among David's men. He once used his spear to kill 300 enemy warriors in a single battle.

¹²Next in rank among the Three was Eleazar son of Dodai, a descendant of Ahoah. ¹³He was with David when the Philistines gathered for battle at Pas-dammim and attacked the Israelites in a field full of barley. The Israelite army fled, ¹⁴but Eleazar and David held their ground in the middle of the field and beat back the Philistines. So the Lord saved them by giving them a great victory.

¹⁵Once when David was at the rock near the cave of Adullam, the Philistine army was camped in the valley of Rephaim. The Three (who were among the Thirty—an elite group among David's fighting men) went down to meet him there. ¹⁶David was staying in the stronghold at the time, and a Philistine detachment had occupied the town of Bethlehem.

¹⁷David remarked longingly to his men, "Oh, how I would love some of that good water from the well by the gate in Bethlehem."

¹⁸So the Three broke through the Philistine lines, drew some water from the well by the gate in Bethlehem, and brought it back to David. But David refused to drink it. Instead, he poured it out as an offering to the Lord. ¹⁹"God forbid that I should drink this!" he exclaimed. "This water is as precious as the blood of these men who risked their lives to bring it to me." So David did not drink it. These are examples of the exploits of the Three.

David's Thirty Mighty Men

²⁰Abishai, the brother of Joab, was the leader of the Thirty. He once used his spear to kill 300 enemy warriors in a single battle. It was by such feats that he became as famous as the Three. ²¹Abishai was the most famous of the Thirty and was their commander, though he was not one of the Three.

²²There was also Benaiah son of Jehoiada, a valiant warrior from Kabzeel. He did many heroic deeds, which included killing two champions of Moab. Another time, on a snowy day, he chased a lion down into a pit and killed it. ²³Once, armed only with a club, he killed an Egyptian warrior who was 7-1/2 feet tall and who was armed with a spear as thick as a weaver's beam. Benaiah wrenched the spear from the Egyptian's hand and killed him with it. ²⁴Deeds like these made Benaiah as famous as the three mightiest warriors. ²⁵He was more honored than the other members of the Thirty, though he was not one of the Three. And David made him captain of his bodyguard.

²⁶David's mighty warriors also included:

Asahel, Joab's brother;

Elhanan son of Dodo from Bethlehem;

²⁷Shammah from Harod;

Helez from Pelon;

²⁸Ira son of Ikkesh from Tekoa;

Abiezer from Anathoth;

²⁹Sibbecai from Hushah;

Zalmon from Ahoah;

³⁰Maharai from Netophah;

Heled son of Baanah from Netophah;

³¹Ithai son of Ribai from Gibeah (in the land of Benjamin);

Benaiah from Pirathon;

³²Hurai from near Nahale-gaash;

Abi-albon from Arabah;

³³Azmaveth from Bahurim;

Eliabha from Shaalbon;

³⁴the sons of Jashen from Gizon;

Jonathan son of Shagee from Harar;

³⁵ Ahiam son of Sharar from Harar;

Eliphai son of Ur;

³⁶ Hephher from Mekerah;

Ahijah from Pelon;

³⁷ Hezro from Carmel;

Paarai son of Ezbai;

³⁸ Joel, the brother of Nathan;

Mibhar son of Hagri;

³⁹ Zelek from Ammon;

Naharai from Beeroth, the armor bearer of Joab son of Zeruiah;

⁴⁰ Ira from Jattir;

Gareb from Jattir;

⁴¹ Uriah the Hittite;

Zabad son of Ahlai;

⁴² Adina son of Shiza, the Reubenite leader who had thirty men with him;

⁴³ Hanan son of Maacah;

Joshaphat from Mithna;

⁴⁴ Uzzia from Ashtaroth;

Shama and Jeiel, the sons of Hotham, from Aroer;

⁴⁵ Jediahel son of Shimri;

Joha, his brother, from Tiz;

⁴⁶ Eliel from Mahavah;

Jeribai and Joshaviah, the sons of Elnaam;

Ithmah from Moab;

⁴⁷ Eliel and Obed;

Jaasiel from Zobah.

12

Warriors Join David's Army

THE following men joined David at Ziklag while he was hiding from Saul son of Kish. They were among the warriors who fought beside David in battle. ²All of them were expert archers, and they could shoot arrows or sling stones with their left hand as well as their right. They were all relatives of Saul from the tribe of Benjamin. ³Their leader was Ahiezer son of Shemaah from Gibeah; his brother Joash was second-in-command. These were the other warriors:

Jeziel and Pelet, sons of Azmaveth;
Beracah;

Jehu from Anathoth;

⁴Ishmaiah from Gibeon, a famous warrior and leader among the
Thirty;

Jeremiah, Jahaziel, Johanan, and Jozabad from Gederah;

⁵Eluzai, Jerimoth, Bealiah, Shemariah, and Shephatiah from Haruph;

⁶Elkanah, Isshiah, Azarel, Joezer, and Jashobeam, who were Korahites;

⁷Joelah and Zebadiah, sons of Jeroham from Gedor.

⁸Some brave and experienced warriors from the tribe of Gad also defected to David while he was at the stronghold in the wilderness. They were expert with both shield and spear, as fierce as lions and as swift as deer on the mountains.

⁹Ezer was their leader.

Obadiah was second.

Eliab was third.

¹⁰Mishmannah was fourth.

Jeremiah was fifth.

¹¹Attai was sixth.

Eliel was seventh.

¹²Johanan was eighth.

Elzabad was ninth.

¹³Jeremiah was tenth.

Macbannai was eleventh.

¹⁴These warriors from Gad were army commanders. The weakest among them could take on a hundred regular troops, and the strongest could take on a thousand! ¹⁵These were the men who crossed the Jordan River during its seasonal flooding at the beginning of the year and drove out all the people living in the lowlands on both the east and west banks.

¹⁶Others from Benjamin and Judah came to David at the stronghold. ¹⁷David went out to meet them and said, "If you have come in peace to help me, we are friends. But if you have come to betray me to my enemies when I am innocent, then may the God of our ancestors see it and punish you."

¹⁸Then the Spirit came upon Amasai, the leader of the Thirty, and he said,

"We are yours, David!

We are on your side, son of Jesse.

Peace and prosperity be with you,

and success to all who help you,

for your God is the one who helps you."

So David let them join him, and he made them officers over his troops.

¹⁹Some men from Manasseh defected from the Israelite army and joined David when he set out with the Philistines to fight against Saul. But as it turned out, the Philistine rulers refused to let David and his men go with them. After much discussion, they sent them back, for

they said, “It will cost us our heads if David switches loyalties to Saul and turns against us.”

²⁰Here is a list of the men from Manasseh who defected to David as he was returning to Ziklag: Adnah, Jozabad, Jediael, Michael, Jozabad, Elihu, and Zillethai. Each commanded 1,000 troops from the tribe of Manasseh. ²¹They helped David chase down bands of raiders, for they were all brave and able warriors who became commanders in his army. ²²Day after day more men joined David until he had a great army, like the army of God.

²³These are the numbers of armed warriors who joined David at Hebron. They were all eager to see David become king instead of Saul, just as the Lord had promised.

²⁴From the tribe of Judah, there were 6,800 warriors armed with shields and spears.

²⁵From the tribe of Simeon, there were 7,100 brave warriors.

²⁶From the tribe of Levi, there were 4,600 warriors. ²⁷This included Jehoiada, leader of the family of Aaron, who had 3,700 under his command. ²⁸This also included Zadok, a brave young warrior, with 22 members of his family who were all officers.

²⁹From the tribe of Benjamin, Saul’s relatives, there were 3,000 warriors. Most of the men from Benjamin had remained loyal to Saul until this time.

³⁰From the tribe of Ephraim, there were 20,800 brave warriors, each highly respected in his own clan.

³¹From the half-tribe of Manasseh west of the Jordan, 18,000 men were designated by name to help David become king.

³²From the tribe of Issachar, there were 200 leaders of the tribe with their relatives. All these men understood the signs of the times and knew the best course for Israel to take.

³³From the tribe of Zebulun, there were 50,000 skilled warriors. They were fully armed and prepared for battle and completely loyal to David.

³⁴From the tribe of Naphtali, there were 1,000 officers and 37,000 warriors armed with shields and spears.

³⁵From the tribe of Dan, there were 28,600 warriors, all prepared for battle.

³⁶From the tribe of Asher, there were 40,000 trained warriors, all prepared for battle.

³⁷From the east side of the Jordan River—where the tribes of Reuben and Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh lived—there were 120,000 troops armed with every kind of weapon.

³⁸All these men came in battle array to Hebron with the single purpose of making David the king over all Israel. In fact, everyone in Israel agreed that David should be their king. ³⁹They feasted and drank with David for three days, for preparations had been made by their relatives for their arrival. ⁴⁰And people from as far away as Issachar, Zebulun, and Naphtali brought food on donkeys, camels, mules, and oxen. Vast supplies of flour, fig cakes, clusters of raisins, wine, olive oil, cattle, sheep, and goats were brought to the celebration. There was great joy throughout the land of Israel.

13

David Attempts to Move the Ark

DAVID consulted with all his officials, including the generals and captains of his army. ²Then he addressed the entire assembly of Israel as follows: “If you approve and if it is the will of the Lord our God, let us send messages to all the Israelites throughout the land, including the priests and Levites in their towns and pasturelands. Let us invite them to come and join us. ³It is time to bring back the Ark of our God, for we neglected it during the reign of Saul.”

⁴The whole assembly agreed to this, for the people could see it was the right thing to do. ⁵So David summoned all Israel, from the Shihor Brook of Egypt in the south all the way to the town of Lebo-hamath

in the north, to join in bringing the Ark of God from Kiriath-jearim. ⁶Then David and all Israel went to Baalah of Judah (also called Kiriath-jearim) to bring back the Ark of God, which bears the name of the Lord who is enthroned between the cherubim. ⁷They placed the Ark of God on a new cart and brought it from Abinadab's house. Uzzah and Ahio were guiding the cart. ⁸David and all Israel were celebrating before God with all their might, singing songs and playing all kinds of musical instruments—lyres, harps, tambourines, cymbals, and trumpets.

⁹But when they arrived at the threshing floor of Nacon, the oxen stumbled, and Uzzah reached out his hand to steady the Ark. ¹⁰Then the Lord's anger was aroused against Uzzah, and he struck him dead because he had laid his hand on the Ark. So Uzzah died there in the presence of God.

¹¹David was angry because the Lord's anger had burst out against Uzzah. He named that place Perez-uzzah (which means "to burst out against Uzzah"), as it is still called today.

¹²David was now afraid of God, and he asked, "How can I ever bring the Ark of God back into my care?" ¹³So David did not move the Ark into the City of David. Instead, he took it to the house of Obed-edom of Gath. ¹⁴The Ark of God remained there in Obed-edom's house for three months, and the Lord blessed the household of Obed-edom and everything he owned.

14

David's Palace and Family

THEN King Hiram of Tyre sent messengers to David, along with cedar timber, and stonemasons and carpenters to build him a palace. ²And David realized that the Lord had confirmed him as king over Israel and had greatly blessed his kingdom for the sake of his people Israel.

³Then David married more wives in Jerusalem, and they had more sons and daughters. ⁴These are the names of David's sons who were born in Jerusalem: Shammua, Shobab, Nathan, Solomon, ⁵Ibhar, Elishua, Elpelet, ⁶Nogah, Nepheg, Japhia, ⁷Elishama, Eliada, and Eliphelet.

David Conquers the Philistines

⁸When the Philistines heard that David had been anointed king over all Israel, they mobilized all their forces to capture him. But David was told they were coming, so he marched out to meet them. ⁹The Philistines arrived and made a raid in the valley of Rephaim. ¹⁰So David asked God, "Should I go out to fight the Philistines? Will you hand them over to me?"

The Lord replied, "Yes, go ahead. I will hand them over to you."

¹¹So David and his troops went up to Baal-perazim and defeated the Philistines there. "God did it!" David exclaimed. "He used me to burst through my enemies like a raging flood!" So they named that place Baal-perazim (which means "the Lord who bursts through"). ¹²The Philistines had abandoned their gods there, so David gave orders to burn them.

¹³But after a while the Philistines returned and raided the valley again. ¹⁴And once again David asked God what to do. "Do not attack them straight on," God replied. "Instead, circle around behind and attack them near the poplar trees. ¹⁵When you hear a sound like marching feet in the tops of the poplar trees, go out and attack! That will be the signal that God is moving ahead of you to strike down the Philistine army." ¹⁶So David did what God commanded, and they struck down the Philistine army all the way from Gibeon to Gezer.

¹⁷So David's fame spread everywhere, and the Lord caused all the nations to fear David.

15

Preparing to Move the Ark

DAVID now built several buildings for himself in the City of David. He also prepared a place for the Ark of God and set up a special tent for it. ²Then he commanded, “No one except the Levites may carry the Ark of God. The Lord has chosen them to carry the Ark of the Lord and to serve him forever.”

³Then David summoned all Israel to Jerusalem to bring the Ark of the Lord to the place he had prepared for it. ⁴This is the number of the descendants of Aaron (the priests) and the Levites who were called together:

⁵From the clan of Kohath, 120, with Uriel as their leader.

⁶From the clan of Merari, 220, with Asaiah as their leader.

⁷From the clan of Gershon, 130, with Joel as their leader.

⁸From the descendants of Elizaphan, 200, with Shemaiah as their leader.

⁹From the descendants of Hebron, 80, with Eliel as their leader.

¹⁰From the descendants of Uzziel, 112, with Amminadab as their leader.

¹¹Then David summoned the priests, Zadok and Abiathar, and these Levite leaders: Uriel, Asaiah, Joel, Shemaiah, Eliel, and Amminadab. ¹²He said to them, “You are the leaders of the Levite families. You must purify yourselves and all your fellow Levites, so you can bring the Ark of the Lord, the God of Israel, to the place I have prepared for it. ¹³Because you Levites did not carry the Ark the first time, the anger of the Lord our God burst out against us. We failed to ask God how to move it properly.” ¹⁴So the priests and the Levites purified themselves in order to bring the Ark of the Lord, the God of Israel, to Jerusalem. ¹⁵Then the Levites carried the Ark of God on

their shoulders with its carrying poles, just as the Lord had instructed Moses.

¹⁶David also ordered the Levite leaders to appoint a choir of Levites who were singers and musicians to sing joyful songs to the accompaniment of harps, lyres, and cymbals. ¹⁷So the Levites appointed Heman son of Joel along with his fellow Levites: Asaph son of Berekiah, and Ethan son of Kushaiah from the clan of Merari. ¹⁸The following men were chosen as their assistants: Zechariah, Jaaziel, Shemiramoth, Jehiel, Unni, Eliab, Benaiah, Maaseiah, Mattithiah, Eliphlehu, Mikneiah, and the gatekeepers—Obed-edom and Jeiel.

¹⁹The musicians Heman, Asaph, and Ethan were chosen to sound the bronze cymbals. ²⁰Zechariah, Aziel, Shemiramoth, Jehiel, Unni, Eliab, Maaseiah, and Benaiah were chosen to play the harps. ²¹Mattithiah, Eliphlehu, Mikneiah, Obed-edom, Jeiel, and Azaziah were chosen to play the lyres. ²²Kenaniah, the head Levite, was chosen as the choir leader because of his skill.

²³Berekiah and Elkanah were chosen to guard the Ark. ²⁴Shebaniah, Joshaphat, Nethanel, Amasai, Zechariah, Benaiah, and Eliezer—all of whom were priests—were chosen to blow the trumpets as they marched in front of the Ark of God. Obed-edom and Jehiah were chosen to guard the Ark.

Moving the Ark to Jerusalem

²⁵Then David and the elders of Israel and the generals of the army went to the house of Obed-edom to bring the Ark of the Lord's Covenant up to Jerusalem with a great celebration. ²⁶And because God was clearly helping the Levites as they carried the Ark of the Lord's Covenant, they sacrificed seven bulls and seven rams.

²⁷David was dressed in a robe of fine linen, as were all the Levites who carried the Ark, and also the singers, and Kenaniah the choir leader. David was also wearing a priestly garment. ²⁸So all Israel brought up the Ark of the Lord's Covenant with shouts of joy, the

blowing of rams' horns and trumpets, the crashing of cymbals, and loud playing on harps and lyres.

²⁹But as the Ark of the Lord's Covenant entered the City of David, Michal, the daughter of Saul, looked down from her window. When she saw King David skipping about and laughing with joy, she was filled with contempt for him.

16

HEY brought the Ark of God and placed it inside the special tent David had prepared for it. And they presented burnt offerings and peace offerings to God. ²When he had finished his sacrifices, David blessed the people in the name of the Lord. ³Then he gave to every man and woman in all Israel a loaf of bread, a cake of dates, and a cake of raisins.

⁴David appointed the following Levites to lead the people in worship before the Ark of the Lord—to invoke his blessings, to give thanks, and to praise the Lord, the God of Israel. ⁵Asaph, the leader of this group, sounded the cymbals. Second to him was Zechariah, followed by Jeiel, Shemiramoth, Jehiel, Mattithiah, Eliab, Benaiah, Obed-edom, and Jeiel. They played the harps and lyres. ⁶The priests, Benaiah and Jahaziel, played the trumpets regularly before the Ark of God's Covenant.

David's Song of Praise

⁷On that day David gave to Asaph and his fellow Levites this song of thanksgiving to the Lord:

⁸Give thanks to the Lord and proclaim his greatness.

Let the whole world know what he has done.

⁹Sing to him; yes, sing his praises.

Tell everyone about his wonderful deeds.

¹⁰Exult in his holy name;

rejoice, you who worship the Lord.

¹¹Search for the Lord and for his strength;
continually seek him.

¹²Remember the wonders he has performed,
his miracles, and the rulings he has given,

¹³you children of his servant Israel,
you descendants of Jacob, his chosen ones.

¹⁴He is the Lord our God.

His justice is seen throughout the land.

¹⁵Remember his covenant forever—
the commitment he made to a thousand generations.

¹⁶This is the covenant he made with Abraham
and the oath he swore to Isaac.

¹⁷He confirmed it to Jacob as a decree,
and to the people of Israel as a never-ending covenant:

¹⁸*“I will give you the land of Canaan
as your special possession.”*

¹⁹He said this when you were few in number,
a tiny group of strangers in Canaan.

²⁰They wandered from nation to nation,
from one kingdom to another.

²¹Yet he did not let anyone oppress them.
He warned kings on their behalf:

²²*“Do not touch my chosen people,
and do not hurt my prophets.”*

²³Let the whole earth sing to the Lord!
Each day proclaim the good news that he saves.

²⁴Publish his glorious deeds among the nations.

Tell everyone about the amazing things he does.

²⁵Great is the Lord! He is most worthy of praise!

He is to be feared above all gods.

²⁶The gods of other nations are mere idols,

but the Lord made the heavens!

²⁷Honor and majesty surround him;

strength and joy fill his dwelling.

²⁸O nations of the world, recognize the Lord,

recognize that the Lord is glorious and strong.

²⁹Give to the Lord the glory he deserves!

Bring your offering and come into his presence.

Worship the Lord in all his holy splendor.

³⁰Let all the earth tremble before him.

The world stands firm and cannot be shaken.

³¹Let the heavens be glad, and the earth rejoice!

Tell all the nations, "The Lord reigns!"

³²Let the sea and everything in it shout his praise!

Let the fields and their crops burst out with joy!

³³Let the trees of the forest sing for joy before the Lord,

for he is coming to judge the earth.

³⁴Give thanks to the Lord, for he is good!

His faithful love endures forever.

³⁵Cry out, "Save us, O God of our salvation!

Gather and rescue us from among the nations,

so we can thank your holy name

and rejoice and praise you."

³⁶Praise the Lord, the God of Israel,
who lives from everlasting to everlasting!

And all the people shouted “Amen!” and praised the Lord.

Worship at Jerusalem and Gibeon

³⁷David arranged for Asaph and his fellow Levites to serve regularly before the Ark of the Lord’s Covenant, doing whatever needed to be done each day. ³⁸This group included Obed-edom (son of Jeduthun), Hosah, and sixty-eight other Levites as gatekeepers.

³⁹Meanwhile, David stationed Zadok the priest and his fellow priests at the Tabernacle of the Lord at the place of worship in Gibeon, where they continued to minister before the Lord. ⁴⁰They sacrificed the regular burnt offerings to the Lord each morning and evening on the altar set aside for that purpose, obeying everything written in the Law of the Lord, as he had commanded Israel. ⁴¹David also appointed Heman, Jeduthun, and the others chosen by name to give thanks to the Lord, for “his faithful love endures forever.” ⁴²They used their trumpets, cymbals, and other instruments to accompany their songs of praise to God. And the sons of Jeduthun were appointed as gatekeepers.

⁴³Then all the people returned to their homes, and David turned and went home to bless his own family.

17

The Lord’s Covenant Promise to David



WHEN David was settled in his palace, he summoned Nathan the prophet. “Look,” David said, “I am living in a beautiful cedar palace, but the Ark of the Lord’s Covenant is out there under a tent!”

²Nathan replied to David, “Do whatever you have in mind, for God is with you.”

³But that same night God said to Nathan,

⁴“Go and tell my servant David, ‘This is what the Lord has declared: You are not the one to build a house for me to live in. ⁵I have never lived in a house, from the day I brought the Israelites out of Egypt until this very day. My home has always been a tent, moving from one place to another in a Tabernacle. ⁶Yet no matter where I have gone with the Israelites, I have never once complained to Israel’s leaders, the shepherds of my people. I have never asked them, ‘Why haven’t you built me a beautiful cedar house?’”

⁷“Now go and say to my servant David, ‘This is what the Lord of Heaven’s Armies has declared: I took you from tending sheep in the pasture and selected you to be the leader of my people Israel. ⁸I have been with you wherever you have gone, and I have destroyed all your enemies before your eyes. Now I will make your name as famous as anyone who has ever lived on the earth! ⁹And I will provide a homeland for my people Israel, planting them in a secure place where they will never be disturbed. Evil nations won’t oppress them as they’ve done in the past, ¹⁰starting from the time I appointed judges to rule my people Israel. And I will defeat all your enemies.

“Furthermore, I declare that the Lord will build a house for you—a dynasty of kings! ¹¹For when you die and join your ancestors, I will raise up one of your descendants, one of your sons, and I will make his kingdom strong. ¹²He is the one who will build a house—a temple—for me. And I will secure his throne forever. ¹³I will be his father, and he will be my son. I will never take my favor from him as I took it from the one who ruled before you. ¹⁴I will confirm him as king over my house and my kingdom for all time, and his throne will be secure forever.”

¹⁵So Nathan went back to David and told him everything the Lord had said in this vision.

David's Prayer of Thanks

¹⁶Then King David went in and sat before the Lord and prayed,

“Who am I, O Lord God, and what is my family, that you have brought me this far? ¹⁷And now, O God, in addition to everything else, you speak of giving your servant a lasting dynasty! You speak as though I were someone very great, O Lord God!

¹⁸“What more can I say to you about the way you have honored me? You know what your servant is really like. ¹⁹For the sake of your servant, O Lord, and according to your will, you have done all these great things and have made them known.

²⁰“O Lord, there is no one like you. We have never even heard of another God like you! ²¹What other nation on earth is like your people Israel? What other nation, O God, have you redeemed from slavery to be your own people? You made a great name for yourself when you redeemed your people from Egypt. You performed awesome miracles and drove out the nations that stood in their way. ²²You chose Israel to be your very own people forever, and you, O Lord, became their God.

²³“And now, O Lord, I am your servant; do as you have promised concerning me and my family. May it be a promise that will last forever. ²⁴And may your name be established and honored forever so that everyone will say, ‘The Lord of Heaven’s Armies, the God of Israel, is Israel’s God!’ And may the house of your servant David continue before you forever.

²⁵“O my God, I have been bold enough to pray to you because you have revealed to your servant that you will build a house for him—a dynasty of kings! ²⁶For you are God, O Lord. And you have promised these good things to your servant. ²⁷And now, it has pleased you to bless the house of your servant, so that it will continue forever before you. For when you grant a blessing, O Lord, it is an eternal blessing!”

18

David's Military Victories

AFTER this, David defeated and subdued the Philistines by conquering Gath and its surrounding towns. ²David also conquered the land of Moab, and the Moabites who were spared became David's subjects and paid him tribute money.

³David also destroyed the forces of Hadadezer, king of Zobah, as far as Hamath, when Hadadezer marched out to strengthen his control along the Euphrates River. ⁴David captured 1,000 chariots, 7,000 charioteers, and 20,000 foot soldiers. He crippled all the chariot horses except enough for 100 chariots.

⁵When Arameans from Damascus arrived to help King Hadadezer, David killed 22,000 of them. ⁶Then he placed several army garrisons in Damascus, the Aramean capital, and the Arameans became David's subjects and paid him tribute money. So the Lord made David victorious wherever he went.

⁷David brought the gold shields of Hadadezer's officers to Jerusalem, ⁸along with a large amount of bronze from Hadadezer's towns of Tebah and Cun. Later Solomon melted the bronze and molded it into the great bronze basin called the Sea, the pillars, and the various bronze articles used at the Temple.

⁹When King Toi of Hamath heard that David had destroyed the entire army of King Hadadezer of Zobah, ¹⁰he sent his son Joram to

congratulate King David for his successful campaign. Hadadezer and Toi had been enemies and were often at war. Joram presented David with many gifts of gold, silver, and bronze.

¹¹King David dedicated all these gifts to the Lord, along with the silver and gold he had taken from the other nations—from Edom, Moab, Ammon, Philistia, and Amalek.

¹²Abishai son of Zeruiah destroyed 18,000 Edomites in the Valley of Salt. ¹³He placed army garrisons in Edom, and all the Edomites became David's subjects. In fact, the Lord made David victorious wherever he went.

¹⁴So David reigned over all Israel and did what was just and right for all his people. ¹⁵Joab son of Zeruiah was commander of the army. Jehoshaphat son of Ahilud was the royal historian. ¹⁶Zadok son of Ahitub and Ahimelech son of Abiathar were the priests. Seraiah was the court secretary. ¹⁷Benaiah son of Jehoiada was captain of the king's bodyguard. And David's sons served as the king's chief assistants.

19

David Defeats the Ammonites

OME time after this, King Nahash of the Ammonites died, and his son Hanun became king. ²David said, "I am going to show loyalty to Hanun because his father, Nahash, was always loyal to me." So David sent messengers to express sympathy to Hanun about his father's death.

But when David's ambassadors arrived in the land of Ammon, ³the Ammonite commanders said to Hanun, "Do you really think these men are coming here to honor your father? No! David has sent them to spy out the land so they can come in and conquer it!" ⁴So Hanun seized David's ambassadors and shaved them, cut off their robes at the buttocks, and sent them back to David in shame.

⁵When David heard what had happened to the men, he sent messengers to tell them, “Stay at Jericho until your beards grow out, and then come back.” For they felt deep shame because of their appearance.

⁶When the people of Ammon realized how seriously they had angered David, Hanun and the Ammonites sent 75,000 pounds of silver to hire chariots and charioteers from Aram-naharaim, Aram-maacah, and Zobah. ⁷They also hired 32,000 chariots and secured the support of the king of Maacah and his army. These forces camped at Medeba, where they were joined by the Ammonite troops that Hanun had recruited from his own towns. ⁸When David heard about this, he sent Joab and all his warriors to fight them. ⁹The Ammonite troops came out and drew up their battle lines at the entrance of the city, while the other kings positioned themselves to fight in the open fields.

¹⁰When Joab saw that he would have to fight on both the front and the rear, he chose some of Israel’s elite troops and placed them under his personal command to fight the Arameans in the fields. ¹¹He left the rest of the army under the command of his brother Abishai, who was to attack the Ammonites. ¹²“If the Arameans are too strong for me, then come over and help me,” Joab told his brother. “And if the Ammonites are too strong for you, I will help you. ¹³Be courageous! Let us fight bravely for our people and the cities of our God. May the Lord’s will be done.”

¹⁴When Joab and his troops attacked, the Arameans began to run away. ¹⁵And when the Ammonites saw the Arameans running, they also ran from Abishai and retreated into the city. Then Joab returned to Jerusalem.

¹⁶The Arameans now realized that they were no match for Israel, so they sent messengers and summoned additional Aramean troops from the other side of the Euphrates River. These troops were under the command of Shobach, the commander of Hadadezer’s forces.

¹⁷When David heard what was happening, he mobilized all Israel, crossed the Jordan River, and positioned his troops in battle formation. Then David engaged the Arameans in battle, and they fought against him. ¹⁸But again the Arameans fled from the Israelites.

This time David's forces killed 7,000 charioteers and 40,000 foot soldiers, including Shobach, the commander of their army. ¹⁹When Hadadezer's allies saw that they had been defeated by Israel, they surrendered to David and became his subjects. After that, the Arameans were no longer willing to help the Ammonites.

20

David Captures Rabbah

N the spring of the year, when kings normally go out to war, Joab led the Israelite army in successful attacks against the land of the Ammonites. In the process he laid siege to the city of Rabbah, attacking and destroying it. However, David stayed behind in Jerusalem.

²Then David went to Rabbah and removed the crown from the king's head, and it was placed on his own head. The crown was made of gold and set with gems, and he found that it weighed seventy-five pounds. David took a vast amount of plunder from the city. ³He also made slaves of the people of Rabbah and forced them to labor with saws, iron picks, and iron axes. That is how David dealt with the people of all the Ammonite towns. Then David and all the army returned to Jerusalem.

Battles against Philistine Giants

⁴After this, war broke out with the Philistines at Gezer. As they fought, Sibbecai from Hushah killed Saph, a descendant of the giants, and so the Philistines were subdued.

⁵During another battle with the Philistines, Elhanan son of Jair killed Lahmi, the brother of Goliath of Gath. The handle of Lahmi's spear was as thick as a weaver's beam!

⁶In another battle with the Philistines at Gath, they encountered a huge man with six fingers on each hand and six toes on each foot,

twenty-four in all, who was also a descendant of the giants. ⁷But when he defied and taunted Israel, he was killed by Jonathan, the son of David's brother Shimea.

⁸These Philistines were descendants of the giants of Gath, but David and his warriors killed them.

21

David Takes a Census

SATAN rose up against Israel and caused David to take a census of the people of Israel. ²So David said to Joab and the commanders of the army, "Take a census of all the people of Israel—from Beersheba in the south to Dan in the north—and bring me a report so I may know how many there are."

³But Joab replied, "May the Lord increase the number of his people a hundred times over! But why, my lord the king, do you want to do this? Are they not all your servants? Why must you cause Israel to sin?"

⁴But the king insisted that they take the census, so Joab traveled throughout all Israel to count the people. Then he returned to Jerusalem ⁵and reported the number of people to David. There were 1,100,000 warriors in all Israel who could handle a sword, and 470,000 in Judah. ⁶But Joab did not include the tribes of Levi and Benjamin in the census because he was so distressed at what the king had made him do.

Judgment for David's Sin

⁷God was very displeased with the census, and he punished Israel for it. ⁸Then David said to God, "I have sinned greatly by taking this census. Please forgive my guilt for doing this foolish thing."

⁹Then the Lord spoke to Gad, David's seer. This was the message:

¹⁰*"Go and say to David, 'This is what the Lord says: I will give you*

three choices. Choose one of these punishments, and I will inflict it on you.”

¹¹So Gad came to David and said, “These are the choices the Lord has given you. ¹²You may choose three years of famine, three months of destruction by the sword of your enemies, or three days of severe plague as the angel of the Lord brings devastation throughout the land of Israel. Decide what answer I should give the Lord who sent me.”

¹³“I’m in a desperate situation!” David replied to Gad. “But let me fall into the hands of the Lord, for his mercy is very great. Do not let me fall into human hands.”

¹⁴So the Lord sent a plague upon Israel, and 70,000 people died as a result. ¹⁵And God sent an angel to destroy Jerusalem. But just as the angel was preparing to destroy it, the Lord relented and said to the death angel, “**Stop! That is enough!**” At that moment the angel of the Lord was standing by the threshing floor of Araunah the Jebusite.

¹⁶David looked up and saw the angel of the Lord standing between heaven and earth with his sword drawn, reaching out over Jerusalem. So David and the leaders of Israel put on burlap to show their deep distress and fell face down on the ground. ¹⁷And David said to God, “I am the one who called for the census! I am the one who has sinned and done wrong! But these people are as innocent as sheep—what have they done? O Lord my God, let your anger fall against me and my family, but do not destroy your people.”

David Builds an Altar

¹⁸Then the angel of the Lord told Gad to instruct David to go up and build an altar to the Lord on the threshing floor of Araunah the Jebusite. ¹⁹So David went up to do what the Lord had commanded him through Gad. ²⁰Araunah, who was busy threshing wheat at the time, turned and saw the angel there. His four sons, who were with him, ran away and hid. ²¹When Araunah saw David approaching, he

left his threshing floor and bowed before David with his face to the ground.

²²David said to Araunah, "Let me buy this threshing floor from you at its full price. Then I will build an altar to the Lord there, so that he will stop the plague."

²³"Take it, my lord the king, and use it as you wish," Araunah said to David. "I will give the oxen for the burnt offerings, and the threshing boards for wood to build a fire on the altar, and the wheat for the grain offering. I will give it all to you."

²⁴But King David replied to Araunah, "No, I insist on buying it for the full price. I will not take what is yours and give it to the Lord. I will not present burnt offerings that have cost me nothing!" ²⁵So David gave Araunah 600 pieces of gold in payment for the threshing floor.

²⁶David built an altar there to the Lord and sacrificed burnt offerings and peace offerings. And when David prayed, the Lord answered him by sending fire from heaven to burn up the offering on the altar. ²⁷Then the Lord spoke to the angel, who put the sword back into its sheath.

²⁸When David saw that the Lord had answered his prayer, he offered sacrifices there at Araunah's threshing floor. ²⁹At that time the Tabernacle of the Lord and the altar of burnt offering that Moses had made in the wilderness were located at the place of worship in Gibeon. ³⁰But David was not able to go there to inquire of God, because he was terrified by the drawn sword of the angel of the Lord.

22



THEN David said, "This will be the location for the Temple of the Lord God and the place of the altar for Israel's burnt offerings!"

Preparations for the Temple

²So David gave orders to call together the foreigners living in Israel, and he assigned them the task of preparing finished stone for building the Temple of God. ³David provided large amounts of iron for the nails that would be needed for the doors in the gates and for the clamps, and he gave more bronze than could be weighed. ⁴He also provided innumerable cedar logs, for the men of Tyre and Sidon had brought vast amounts of cedar to David.

⁵David said, “My son Solomon is still young and inexperienced. And since the Temple to be built for the Lord must be a magnificent structure, famous and glorious throughout the world, I will begin making preparations for it now.” So David collected vast amounts of building materials before his death.

⁶Then David sent for his son Solomon and instructed him to build a Temple for the Lord, the God of Israel. ⁷“My son, I wanted to build a Temple to honor the name of the Lord my God,” David told him. ⁸“But the Lord said to me, ‘You have killed many men in the battles you have fought. And since you have shed so much blood in my sight, you will not be the one to build a Temple to honor my name. ⁹But you will have a son who will be a man of peace. I will give him peace with his enemies in all the surrounding lands. His name will be Solomon, and I will give peace and quiet to Israel during his reign. ¹⁰He is the one who will build a Temple to honor my name. He will be my son, and I will be his father. And I will secure the throne of his kingdom over Israel forever.’”

¹¹“Now, my son, may the Lord be with you and give you success as you follow his directions in building the Temple of the Lord your God. ¹²And may the Lord give you wisdom and understanding, that you may obey the Law of the Lord your God as you rule over Israel. ¹³For you will be successful if you carefully obey the decrees and regulations that the Lord gave to Israel through Moses. Be strong and courageous; do not be afraid or lose heart!

¹⁴“I have worked hard to provide materials for building the Temple of the Lord—nearly 4,000 tons of gold, 40,000 tons of silver, and so much iron and bronze that it cannot be weighed. I have also gathered timber and stone for the walls, though you may need to add more. ¹⁵You have a large number of skilled stonemasons and carpenters and craftsmen of every kind. ¹⁶You have expert goldsmiths and silver-smiths and workers of bronze and iron. Now begin the work, and may the Lord be with you!”

¹⁷Then David ordered all the leaders of Israel to assist Solomon in this project. ¹⁸“The Lord your God is with you,” he declared. “He has given you peace with the surrounding nations. He has handed them over to me, and they are now subject to the Lord and his people. ¹⁹Now seek the Lord your God with all your heart and soul. Build the sanctuary of the Lord God so that you can bring the Ark of the Lord’s Covenant and the holy vessels of God into the Temple built to honor the Lord’s name.”

23

Duties of the Levites

WHEN David was an old man, he appointed his son Solomon to be king over Israel. ²David summoned all the leaders of Israel, together with the priests and Levites. ³All the Levites who were thirty years old or older were counted, and the total came to 38,000. ⁴Then David said, “From all the Levites, 24,000 will supervise the work at the Temple of the Lord. Another 6,000 will serve as officials and judges. ⁵Another 4,000 will work as gatekeepers, and 4,000 will praise the Lord with the musical instruments I have made.” ⁶Then David divided the Levites into divisions named after the clans descended from the three sons of Levi—Gershon, Kohath, and Merari.

The Gershonites

⁷The Gershonite family units were defined by their lines of descent from Libni and Shimei, the sons of Gershon. ⁸Three of the descendants of Libni were Jehiel (the family leader), Zetham, and Joel. ⁹These were the leaders of the family of Libni.

Three of the descendants of Shimei were Shelomoth, Haziël, and Haran. ¹⁰Four other descendants of Shimei were Jahath, Ziza, Jeush, and Beriah. ¹¹Jahath was the family leader, and Ziza was next. Jeush and Beriah were counted as a single family because neither had many sons.

The Kohathites

¹²Four of the descendants of Kohath were Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel.

¹³The sons of Amram were Aaron and Moses. Aaron and his descendants were set apart to dedicate the most holy things, to offer sacrifices in the Lord's presence, to serve the Lord, and to pronounce blessings in his name forever.

¹⁴As for Moses, the man of God, his sons were included with the tribe of Levi. ¹⁵The sons of Moses were Gershom and Eliezer.

¹⁶The descendants of Gershom included Shebuel, the family leader. ¹⁷Eliezer had only one son, Rehabiah, the family leader. Rehabiah had numerous descendants.

¹⁸The descendants of Izhar included Shelomith, the family leader.

¹⁹The descendants of Hebron included Jeriah (the family leader), Amariah (the second), Jahaziel (the third), and Jekameam (the fourth).

²⁰The descendants of Uzziel included Micah (the family leader) and Isshiah (the second).

The Merarites

²¹The descendants of Merari included Mahli and Mushi.

The sons of Mahli were Eleazar and Kish. ²²Eleazar died with no sons, only daughters. His daughters married their cousins, the sons of Kish.

²³Three of the descendants of Mushi were Mahli, Eder, and Jerimoth.

²⁴These were the descendants of Levi by clans, the leaders of their family groups, registered carefully by name. Each had to be twenty years old or older to qualify for service in the house of the Lord. ²⁵For David said, "The Lord, the God of Israel, has given us peace, and he will always live in Jerusalem. ²⁶Now the Levites will no longer need to carry the Tabernacle and its furnishings from place to place." ²⁷In accordance with David's final instructions, all the Levites twenty years old or older were registered for service.

²⁸The work of the Levites was to assist the priests, the descendants of Aaron, as they served at the house of the Lord. They also took care of the courtyards and side rooms, helped perform the ceremonies of purification, and served in many other ways in the house of God. ²⁹They were in charge of the sacred bread that was set out on the table, the choice flour for the grain offerings, the wafers made without yeast, the cakes cooked in olive oil, and the other mixed breads. They were also responsible to check all the weights and measures. ³⁰And each morning and evening they stood before the Lord to sing songs of thanks and praise to him. ³¹They assisted with the burnt offerings that were presented to the Lord on Sabbath days, at new moon celebrations, and at all the appointed festivals. The required number of Levites served in the Lord's presence at all times, following all the procedures they had been given.

³²And so, under the supervision of the priests, the Levites watched over the Tabernacle and the Temple and faithfully carried out their duties of service at the house of the Lord.

THIS is how Aaron's descendants, the priests, were divided into groups for service. The sons of Aaron were Nadab, Abihu, Eleazar, and Ithamar. ²But Nadab and Abihu died before their father, and they had no sons. So only Eleazar and Ithamar were left to carry on as priests.

³With the help of Zadok, who was a descendant of Eleazar, and of Ahimelech, who was a descendant of Ithamar, David divided Aaron's descendants into groups according to their various duties. ⁴Eleazar's descendants were divided into sixteen groups and Ithamar's into eight, for there were more family leaders among the descendants of Eleazar.

⁵All tasks were assigned to the various groups by means of sacred lots so that no preference would be shown, for there were many qualified officials serving God in the sanctuary from among the descendants of both Eleazar and Ithamar. ⁶Shemaiah son of Nethanel, a Levite, acted as secretary and wrote down the names and assignments in the presence of the king, the officials, Zadok the priest, Ahimelech son of Abiathar, and the family leaders of the priests and Levites. The descendants of Eleazar and Ithamar took turns casting lots.

⁷The first lot fell to Jehoiarib.

The second lot fell to Jedaiah.

⁸The third lot fell to Harim.

The fourth lot fell to Seorim.

⁹The fifth lot fell to Malkijah.

The sixth lot fell to Mijamin.

¹⁰The seventh lot fell to Hakkoz.

The eighth lot fell to Abijah.

¹¹The ninth lot fell to Jeshua.

The tenth lot fell to Shecaniah.

¹²The eleventh lot fell to Eliashib.

The twelfth lot fell to Jakim.

¹³The thirteenth lot fell to Huppah.

The fourteenth lot fell to Jeshebeab.

¹⁴The fifteenth lot fell to Bilgah.

The sixteenth lot fell to Immer.

¹⁵The seventeenth lot fell to Hezir.

The eighteenth lot fell to Happizzetz.

¹⁶The nineteenth lot fell to Pethahiah.

The twentieth lot fell to Jehezkel.

¹⁷The twenty-first lot fell to Jakin.

The twenty-second lot fell to Gamul.

¹⁸The twenty-third lot fell to Delaiah.

The twenty-fourth lot fell to Maaziah.

¹⁹Each group carried out its appointed duties in the house of the Lord according to the procedures established by their ancestor Aaron in obedience to the commands of the Lord, the God of Israel.

Family Leaders among the Levites

²⁰These were the other family leaders descended from Levi:

From the descendants of Amram, the leader was Shebuel.

From the descendants of Shebuel, the leader was Jehdeiah.

²¹From the descendants of Rehabiah, the leader was Isshiah.

²²From the descendants of Izhar, the leader was Shelomith.

From the descendants of Shelomith, the leader was Jahath.

²³From the descendants of Hebron, Jeriah was the leader, Amariah was second, Jahaziel was third, and Jekameam was fourth.

²⁴From the descendants of Uzziel, the leader was Micah.

From the descendants of Micah, the leader was Shamir, ²⁵along with Isshiah, the brother of Micah.

From the descendants of Isshiah, the leader was Zechariah.

²⁶From the descendants of Merari, the leaders were Mahli and Mushi.

From the descendants of Jaaziah, the leader was Beno.

²⁷From the descendants of Merari through Jaaziah, the leaders were Beno, Shoham, Zaccur, and Ibri.

²⁸From the descendants of Mahli, the leader was Eleazar, though he had no sons.

²⁹From the descendants of Kish, the leader was Jerahmeel.

³⁰From the descendants of Mushi, the leaders were Mahli, Eder, and Jerimoth.

These were the descendants of Levi in their various families. ³¹Like the descendants of Aaron, they were assigned to their duties by means of sacred lots, without regard to age or rank. Lots were drawn in the presence of King David, Zadok, Ahimelech, and the family leaders of the priests and the Levites.

25

Duties of the Musicians

DAVID and the army commanders then appointed men from the families of Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun to proclaim God's messages to the accompaniment of lyres, harps, and cymbals. Here is a list of their names and their work:

²From the sons of Asaph, there were Zaccur, Joseph, Nethaniah, and Asarelah. They worked under the direction of their father, Asaph, who proclaimed God's messages by the king's orders.

³From the sons of Jeduthun, there were Gedaliah, Zeri, Jeshaiiah, Shimei, Hashabiah, and Mattithiah, six in all. They worked under the direction of their father, Jeduthun, who proclaimed God's messages to the accompaniment of the lyre, offering thanks and praise to the Lord.

⁴From the sons of Heman, there were Bukkiah, Mattaniah, Uzziel, Shubael, Jerimoth, Hananiah, Hanani, Eliathah, Giddalti, Romamti-ezer, Joshbekashah, Mallothi, Hothir, and Mahazioth. ⁵All these were the sons of Heman, the king's seer, for God had honored him with fourteen sons and three daughters.

⁶All these men were under the direction of their fathers as they made music at the house of the Lord. Their responsibilities included the playing of cymbals, harps, and lyres at the house of God. Asaph, Jeduthun, and Heman reported directly to the king. ⁷They and their families were all trained in making music before the Lord, and each of them—288 in all—was an accomplished musician. ⁸The musicians were appointed to their term of service by means of sacred lots, without regard to whether they were young or old, teacher or student.

⁹The first lot fell to Joseph of the Asaph clan and twelve of his sons and relatives.

The second lot fell to Gedaliah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹⁰The third lot fell to Zaccur and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹¹The fourth lot fell to Zeri and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹²The fifth lot fell to Nethaniah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹³The sixth lot fell to Bukkiah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹⁴The seventh lot fell to Asarelah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹⁵The eighth lot fell to Jeshaiiah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹⁶The ninth lot fell to Mattaniah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹⁷The tenth lot fell to Shimei and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹⁸The eleventh lot fell to Uzziel and twelve of his sons and relatives.

¹⁹The twelfth lot fell to Hashabiah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

²⁰The thirteenth lot fell to Shubael and twelve of his sons and relatives.

²¹The fourteenth lot fell to Mattithiah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

²²The fifteenth lot fell to Jerimoth and twelve of his sons and relatives.

²³The sixteenth lot fell to Hananiah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

²⁴The seventeenth lot fell to Joshbekashah and twelve of his sons and relatives.

²⁵The eighteenth lot fell to Hanani and twelve of his sons and relatives.

²⁶The nineteenth lot fell to Mallothi and twelve of his sons and relatives.

- ²⁷The twentieth lot fell to Eliathah and twelve of his sons and relatives.
²⁸The twenty-first lot fell to Hothir and twelve of his sons and relatives.
²⁹The twenty-second lot fell to Giddalti and twelve of his sons and relatives.
³⁰The twenty-third lot fell to Mahazioth and twelve of his sons and relatives.
³¹The twenty-fourth lot fell to Romamti-ezer and twelve of his sons and relatives.

26

Duties of the Gatekeepers



THESE are the divisions of the gatekeepers:
From the Korahites, there was Meshelemiah son of Kore, of the family of Abiasaph. ²The sons of Meshelemiah were Zechariah (the oldest), Jedaiel (the second), Zebadiah (the third), Jathniel (the fourth), ³Elam (the fifth), Jehohanan (the sixth), and Eliehoenai (the seventh).

⁴The sons of Obed-edom, also gatekeepers, were Shemaiah (the oldest), Jehozabad (the second), Joah (the third), Sacar (the fourth), Nethanel (the fifth), ⁵Ammiel (the sixth), Issachar (the seventh), and Peullethai (the eighth). God had richly blessed Obed-edom.

⁶Obed-edom's son Shemaiah had sons with great ability who earned positions of great authority in the clan. ⁷Their names were Othni, Rephael, Obed, and Elzabad. Their relatives, Elihu and Semakiah, were also very capable men.

⁸All of these descendants of Obed-edom, including their sons and grandsons—sixty-two of them in all—were very capable men, well qualified for their work.

⁹Meshelemiah's eighteen sons and relatives were also very capable men.

¹⁰Hosah, of the Merari clan, appointed Shimri as the leader among his sons, though he was not the oldest. ¹¹His other sons included Hilkiah (the second), Tebaliah (the third), and Zechariah (the fourth). Hosah's sons and relatives, who served as gatekeepers, numbered thirteen in all.

¹²These divisions of the gatekeepers were named for their family leaders, and like the other Levites, they served at the house of the Lord.

¹³They were assigned by families for guard duty at the various gates, without regard to age or training, for it was all decided by means of sacred lots.

¹⁴The responsibility for the east gate went to Meshelemiah and his group. The north gate was assigned to his son Zechariah, a man of unusual wisdom. ¹⁵The south gate went to Obed-edom, and his sons were put in charge of the storehouse. ¹⁶Shuppim and Hosah were assigned the west gate and the gateway leading up to the Temple. Guard duties were divided evenly. ¹⁷Six Levites were assigned each day to the east gate, four to the north gate, four to the south gate, and two pairs at the storehouse. ¹⁸Six were assigned each day to the west gate, four to the gateway leading up to the Temple, and two to the courtyard.

¹⁹These were the divisions of the gatekeepers from the clans of Korah and Merari.

Treasurers and Other Officials

²⁰Other Levites, led by Ahijah, were in charge of the treasuries of the house of God and the treasuries of the gifts dedicated to the Lord.

²¹From the family of Libni in the clan of Gershon, Jehiel was the leader. ²²The sons of Jehiel, Zetham and his brother Joel, were in charge of the treasuries of the house of the Lord.

²³These are the leaders that descended from Amram, Izhar, Hebron, and Uzziel:

²⁴From the clan of Amram, Shebuel was a descendant of Gershon son of Moses. He was the chief officer of the treasuries. ²⁵His relatives through Eliezer were Rehabiah, Jeshaiiah, Joram, Zicri, and Shelomoth.

²⁶Shelomoth and his relatives were in charge of the treasuries containing the gifts that King David, the family leaders, and the generals and captains and other officers of the army had dedicated to the Lord. ²⁷These men dedicated some of the plunder they had gained in battle to maintain the house of the Lord. ²⁸Shelomoth and his relatives also cared for the gifts dedicated to the Lord by Samuel the seer, Saul son of Kish, Abner son of Ner, and Joab son of Zeruiah. All the other dedicated gifts were in their care, too.

²⁹From the clan of Izhar came Kenaniah. He and his sons were given administrative responsibilities over Israel as officials and judges.

³⁰From the clan of Hebron came Hashabiah. He and his relatives—1,700 capable men—were put in charge of the Israelite lands west of the Jordan River. They were responsible for all matters related to the things of the Lord and the service of the king in that area.

³¹Also from the clan of Hebron came Jeriah, who was the leader of the Hebronites according to the genealogical records. (In the fortieth year of David's reign, a search was made in the records, and capable men from the clan of Hebron were found at Jazer in the land of Gilead.) ³²There were 2,700 capable men among the relatives of Jeriah. King David sent them to the east side of the Jordan River and put them in charge of the tribes of Reuben and Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. They were responsible for all matters related to God and to the king.

Military Commanders and Divisions

THIS is the list of Israelite generals and captains, and their officers, who served the king by supervising the army divisions that were on duty each month of the year. Each division served for one month and had 24,000 troops.

²Jashobeam son of Zabdiel was commander of the first division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the first month. ³He was a descendant of Perez and was in charge of all the army officers for the first month.

⁴Dodai, a descendant of Ahoah, was commander of the second division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the second month. Mikloth was his chief officer.

⁵Benaiah son of Jehoiada the priest was commander of the third division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the third month. ⁶This was the Benaiah who commanded David's elite military group known as the Thirty. His son Ammizabad was his chief officer.

⁷Asahel, the brother of Joab, was commander of the fourth division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the fourth month. Asahel was succeeded by his son Zebadiah.

⁸Shammah the Izrahite was commander of the fifth division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the fifth month.

⁹Ira son of Ikkes from Tekoa was commander of the sixth division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the sixth month.

¹⁰Helez, a descendant of Ephraim from Pelon, was commander of the seventh division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the seventh month.

¹¹Sibbecai, a descendant of Zerah from Hushah, was commander of the eighth division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the eighth month.

- ¹²Abiezer from Anathoth in the territory of Benjamin was commander of the ninth division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the ninth month.
- ¹³Maharai, a descendant of Zerah from Netophah, was commander of the tenth division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the tenth month.
- ¹⁴Benaiah from Pirathon in Ephraim was commander of the eleventh division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the eleventh month.
- ¹⁵Heled, a descendant of Othniel from Netophah, was commander of the twelfth division of 24,000 troops, which was on duty during the twelfth month.

Leaders of the Tribes

¹⁶The following were the tribes of Israel and their leaders:

Tribes.....	Leader
Reuben.....	Eliezer son of Zicri
Simeon.....	Shephatiah son of Maacah
¹⁷ Levi.....	Hashabiah son of Kemuel
Aaron (the priests).....	Zadok
¹⁸ Judah.....	Elihu (a brother of David)
Issachar.....	Omri son of Michael
¹⁹ Zebulun.....	Ishmaiah son of Obadiah
Naphtali.....	Jeremoth son of Azriel
²⁰ Ephraim.....	Hoshea son of Azaziah
Manasseh (west).....	Joel son of Pedaiah
²¹ Manasseh in Gilead (east).....	Iddo son of Zechariah
Benjamin.....	Jaasiel son of Abner
²² Dan.....	Azarel son of Jeroham

These were the leaders of the tribes of Israel.

²³When David took his census, he did not count those who were younger than twenty years of age, because the Lord had promised to make the Israelites as numerous as the stars in heaven. ²⁴Joab son of Zeruiah began the census but never finished it because the anger of God fell on Israel. The total number was never recorded in King David's official records.

Officials of David's Kingdom

²⁵Azmaveth son of Adiel was in charge of the palace treasuries. Jonathan son of Uzziah was in charge of the regional treasuries throughout the towns, villages, and fortresses of Israel.

²⁶Ezri son of Kelub was in charge of the field workers who farmed the king's lands.

²⁷Shimei from Ramah was in charge of the king's vineyards. Zabdi from Shepham was responsible for the grapes and the supplies of wine.

²⁸Baal-hanan from Geder was in charge of the king's olive groves and sycamore-fig trees in the foothills of Judah.

Joash was responsible for the supplies of olive oil.

²⁹Shitrai from Sharon was in charge of the cattle on the Sharon Plain. Shaphat son of Adlai was responsible for the cattle in the valleys.

³⁰Obil the Ishmaelite was in charge of the camels.

Jehdeiah from Meronoth was in charge of the donkeys.

³¹Jaziz the Hagrite was in charge of the king's flocks of sheep and goats.

All these officials were overseers of King David's property.

³²Jonathan, David's uncle, was a wise counselor to the king, a man of great insight, and a scribe. Jehiel the Hacmonite was responsible for teaching the king's sons. ³³Ahithophel was the royal adviser. Hushai the Arkite was the king's friend. ³⁴Ahithophel was succeeded by Jehoiada son of Benaiah and by Abiathar. Joab was commander of the king's army.

David's Instructions to Solomon

DAVID summoned all the officials of Israel to Jerusalem—the leaders of the tribes, the commanders of the army divisions, the other generals and captains, the overseers of the royal property and livestock, the palace officials, the mighty men, and all the other brave warriors in the kingdom. ²David rose to his feet and said: “My brothers and my people! It was my desire to build a Temple where the Ark of the Lord’s Covenant, God’s footstool, could rest permanently. I made the necessary preparations for building it, ³but God said to me, ‘You must not build a Temple to honor my name, for you are a warrior and have shed much blood.’

⁴“Yet the Lord, the God of Israel, has chosen me from among all my father’s family to be king over Israel forever. For he has chosen the tribe of Judah to rule, and from among the families of Judah he chose my father’s family. And from among my father’s sons the Lord was pleased to make me king over all Israel. ⁵And from among my sons—for the Lord has given me many—he chose Solomon to succeed me on the throne of Israel and to rule over the Lord’s kingdom. ⁶He said to me, ‘Your son Solomon will build my Temple and its courtyards, for I have chosen him as my son, and I will be his father. ⁷And if he continues to obey my commands and regulations as he does now, I will make his kingdom last forever.’

⁸“So now, with God as our witness, and in the sight of all Israel—the Lord’s assembly—I give you this charge. Be careful to obey all the commands of the Lord your God, so that you may continue to possess this good land and leave it to your children as a permanent inheritance.

⁹“And Solomon, my son, learn to know the God of your ancestors intimately. Worship and serve him with your whole heart and a willing mind. For the Lord sees every heart and knows every plan and thought. If you seek him, you will find him. But if you forsake him, he will

reject you forever. ¹⁰So take this seriously. The Lord has chosen you to build a Temple as his sanctuary. Be strong, and do the work.”

¹¹Then David gave Solomon the plans for the Temple and its surroundings, including the entry room, the storerooms, the upstairs rooms, the inner rooms, and the inner sanctuary—which was the place of atonement. ¹²David also gave Solomon all the plans he had in mind for the courtyards of the Lord’s Temple, the outside rooms, the treasuries, and the rooms for the gifts dedicated to the Lord. ¹³The king also gave Solomon the instructions concerning the work of the various divisions of priests and Levites in the Temple of the Lord. And he gave specifications for the items in the Temple that were to be used for worship.

¹⁴David gave instructions regarding how much gold and silver should be used to make the items needed for service. ¹⁵He told Solomon the amount of gold needed for the gold lampstands and lamps, and the amount of silver for the silver lampstands and lamps, depending on how each would be used. ¹⁶He designated the amount of gold for the table on which the Bread of the Presence would be placed and the amount of silver for other tables.

¹⁷David also designated the amount of gold for the solid gold meat hooks used to handle the sacrificial meat and for the basins, pitchers, and dishes, as well as the amount of silver for every dish. ¹⁸He designated the amount of refined gold for the altar of incense. Finally, he gave him a plan for the Lord’s “chariot”—the gold cherubim whose wings were stretched out over the Ark of the Lord’s Covenant. ¹⁹“Every part of this plan,” David told Solomon, “was given to me in writing from the hand of the Lord.”

²⁰Then David continued, “Be strong and courageous, and do the work. Don’t be afraid or discouraged, for the Lord God, my God, is with you. He will not fail you or forsake you. He will see to it that all the work related to the Temple of the Lord is finished correctly. ²¹The various divisions of priests and Levites will serve in the Temple of God. Others with skills of every kind will volunteer, and the officials and the entire nation are at your command.”

Gifts for Building the Temple

THEN King David turned to the entire assembly and said, “My son Solomon, whom God has clearly chosen as the next king of Israel, is still young and inexperienced. The work ahead of him is enormous, for the Temple he will build is not for mere mortals—it is for the Lord God himself! ²Using every resource at my command, I have gathered as much as I could for building the Temple of my God. Now there is enough gold, silver, bronze, iron, and wood, as well as great quantities of onyx, other precious stones, costly jewels, and all kinds of fine stone and marble.

³“And now, because of my devotion to the Temple of my God, I am giving all of my own private treasures of gold and silver to help in the construction. This is in addition to the building materials I have already collected for his holy Temple. ⁴I am donating more than 112 tons of gold from Ophir and 262 tons of refined silver to be used for overlaying the walls of the buildings ⁵and for the other gold and silver work to be done by the craftsmen. Now then, who will follow my example and give offerings to the Lord today?”

⁶Then the family leaders, the leaders of the tribes of Israel, the generals and captains of the army, and the king’s administrative officers all gave willingly. ⁷For the construction of the Temple of God, they gave about 188 tons of gold, 10,000 gold coins, 375 tons of silver, 675 tons of bronze, and 3,750 tons of iron. ⁸They also contributed numerous precious stones, which were deposited in the treasury of the house of the Lord under the care of Jehiel, a descendant of Gershon. ⁹The people rejoiced over the offerings, for they had given freely and wholeheartedly to the Lord, and King David was filled with joy.

David's Prayer of Praise

¹⁰Then David praised the Lord in the presence of the whole assembly:

“O Lord, the God of our ancestor Israel, may you be praised forever and ever! ¹¹Yours, O Lord, is the greatness, the power, the glory, the victory, and the majesty. Everything in the heavens and on earth is yours, O Lord, and this is your kingdom. We adore you as the one who is over all things. ¹²Wealth and honor come from you alone, for you rule over everything. Power and might are in your hand, and at your discretion people are made great and given strength.

¹³“O our God, we thank you and praise your glorious name!

¹⁴But who am I, and who are my people, that we could give anything to you? Everything we have has come from you, and we give you only what you first gave us! ¹⁵We are here for only a moment, visitors and strangers in the land as our ancestors were before us. Our days on earth are like a passing shadow, gone so soon without a trace.

¹⁶“O Lord our God, even this material we have gathered to build a Temple to honor your holy name comes from you! It all belongs to you! ¹⁷I know, my God, that you examine our hearts and rejoice when you find integrity there. You know I have done all this with good motives, and I have watched your people offer their gifts willingly and joyously.

¹⁸“O Lord, the God of our ancestors Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, make your people always want to obey you. See to it that their love for you never changes. ¹⁹Give my son Solomon the wholehearted desire to obey all your commands, laws, and decrees, and to do everything necessary to build this Temple, for which I have made these preparations.”

²⁰Then David said to the whole assembly, “Give praise to the Lord your God!” And the entire assembly praised the Lord, the God of their ancestors, and they bowed low and knelt before the Lord and the king.

Solomon Named as King

²¹The next day they brought 1,000 bulls, 1,000 rams, and 1,000 male lambs as burnt offerings to the Lord. They also brought liquid offerings and many other sacrifices on behalf of all Israel. ²²They feasted and drank in the Lord’s presence with great joy that day.

And again they crowned David’s son Solomon as their new king. They anointed him before the Lord as their leader, and they anointed Zadok as priest. ²³So Solomon took the throne of the Lord in place of his father, David, and he succeeded in everything, and all Israel obeyed him. ²⁴All the officials, the warriors, and the sons of King David pledged their loyalty to King Solomon. ²⁵And the Lord exalted Solomon in the sight of all Israel, and he gave Solomon greater royal splendor than any king in Israel before him.

Summary of David’s Reign

²⁶So David son of Jesse reigned over all Israel. ²⁷He reigned over Israel for forty years, seven of them in Hebron and thirty-three in Jerusalem. ²⁸He died at a ripe old age, having enjoyed long life, wealth, and honor. Then his son Solomon ruled in his place.

²⁹All the events of King David’s reign, from beginning to end, are written in The Record of Samuel the Seer, The Record of Nathan the Prophet, and The Record of Gad the Seer. ³⁰These accounts include the mighty deeds of his reign and everything that happened to him and to Israel and to all the surrounding kingdoms.

2 Chronicles

1

Solomon Asks for Wisdom



SOLOMON son of David took firm control of his kingdom, for the Lord his God was with him and made him very powerful. ²Solomon called together all the leaders of Israel—the generals and captains of the army, the judges, and all the political and clan leaders. ³Then he led the entire assembly to the place of worship in Gibeon, for God’s Tabernacle was located there. (This was the Tabernacle that Moses, the Lord’s servant, had made in the wilderness.)

⁴David had already moved the Ark of God from Kiriath-jearim to the tent he had prepared for it in Jerusalem. ⁵But the bronze altar made by Bezalel son of Uri and grandson of Hur was there at Gibeon in front of the Tabernacle of the Lord. So Solomon and the people gathered in front of it to consult the Lord. ⁶There in front of the Tabernacle, Solomon went up to the bronze altar in the Lord’s presence and sacrificed 1,000 burnt offerings on it.

⁷That night God appeared to Solomon and said, “What do you want? Ask, and I will give it to you!”

⁸Solomon replied to God, “You showed great and faithful love to David, my father, and now you have made me king in his place. ⁹O Lord God, please continue to keep your promise to David my father, for you have made me king over a people as numerous as the dust

of the earth! ¹⁰Give me the wisdom and knowledge to lead them properly, for who could possibly govern this great people of yours?”

¹¹God said to Solomon, “Because your greatest desire is to help your people, and you did not ask for wealth, riches, fame, or even the death of your enemies or a long life, but rather you asked for wisdom and knowledge to properly govern my people— ¹²I will certainly give you the wisdom and knowledge you requested. But I will also give you wealth, riches, and fame such as no other king has had before you or will ever have in the future!”

¹³Then Solomon returned to Jerusalem from the Tabernacle at the place of worship in Gibeon, and he reigned over Israel. ¹⁴Solomon built up a huge force of chariots and horses. He had 1,400 chariots and 12,000 horses. He stationed some of them in the chariot cities and some near him in Jerusalem. ¹⁵The king made silver and gold as plentiful in Jerusalem as stone. And valuable cedar timber was as common as the sycamore-fig trees that grow in the foothills of Judah. ¹⁶Solomon’s horses were imported from Egypt and from Cilicia; the king’s traders acquired them from Cilicia at the standard price. ¹⁷At that time chariots from Egypt could be purchased for 600 pieces of silver, and horses for 150 pieces of silver. They were then exported to the kings of the Hittites and the kings of Aram.

2

Preparations for Building the Temple

1 Solomon decided to build a Temple to honor the name of the Lord, and also a royal palace for himself. ²He enlisted a force of 70,000 laborers, 80,000 men to quarry stone in the hill country, and 3,600 foremen.

³Solomon also sent this message to King Hiram at Tyre:

“Send me cedar logs as you did for my father, David, when he was building his palace. ⁴I am about to build a Temple to

honor the name of the Lord my God. It will be a place set apart to burn fragrant incense before him, to display the special sacrificial bread, and to sacrifice burnt offerings each morning and evening, on the Sabbaths, at new moon celebrations, and at the other appointed festivals of the Lord our God. He has commanded Israel to do these things forever.

⁵“This must be a magnificent Temple because our God is greater than all other gods. ⁶But who can really build him a worthy home? Not even the highest heavens can contain him! So who am I to consider building a Temple for him, except as a place to burn sacrifices to him?

⁷“So send me a master craftsman who can work with gold, silver, bronze, and iron, as well as with purple, scarlet, and blue cloth. He must be a skilled engraver who can work with the craftsmen of Judah and Jerusalem who were selected by my father, David.

⁸“Also send me cedar, cypress, and red sandalwood logs from Lebanon, for I know that your men are without equal at cutting timber in Lebanon. I will send my men to help them. ⁹An immense amount of timber will be needed, for the Temple I am going to build will be very large and magnificent. ¹⁰In payment for your woodcutters, I will send 100,000 bushels of crushed wheat, 100,000 bushels of barley, 110,000 gallons of wine, and 110,000 gallons of olive oil.”

¹¹King Hiram sent this letter of reply to Solomon:

“It is because the Lord loves his people that he has made you their king! ¹²Praise the Lord, the God of Israel, who made the heavens and the earth! He has given King David a wise son, gifted with skill and understanding, who will build a Temple for the Lord and a royal palace for himself.

¹³“I am sending you a master craftsman named Hiram-abi, who is extremely talented. ¹⁴His mother is from the tribe of Dan in Israel, and his father is from Tyre. He is skillful at making things from gold, silver, bronze, and iron, and he also works with stone and wood. He can work with purple, blue, and scarlet cloth and fine linen. He is also an engraver and can follow any design given to him. He will work with your craftsmen and those appointed by my lord David, your father.

¹⁵“Send along the wheat, barley, olive oil, and wine that my lord has mentioned. ¹⁶We will cut whatever timber you need from the Lebanon mountains and will float the logs in rafts down the coast of the Mediterranean Sea to Joppa. From there you can transport the logs up to Jerusalem.”

¹⁷Solomon took a census of all foreigners in the land of Israel, like the census his father had taken, and he counted 153,600. ¹⁸He assigned 70,000 of them as common laborers, 80,000 as quarry workers in the hill country, and 3,600 as foremen.

3

Solomon Builds the Temple

o Solomon began to build the Temple of the Lord in Jerusalem on Mount Moriah, where the Lord had appeared to David, his father. The Temple was built on the threshing floor of Araunah the Jebusite, the site that David had selected. ²The construction began in midspring, during the fourth year of Solomon’s reign.

³These are the dimensions Solomon used for the foundation of the Temple of God (using the old standard of measurement). It was 90 feet long and 30 feet wide. ⁴The entry room at the front of the Temple was 30 feet wide, running across the entire width of the Temple, and 30 feet high. He overlaid the inside with pure gold.

⁵He paneled the main room of the Temple with cypress wood, overlaid it with fine gold, and decorated it with carvings of palm trees and chains. ⁶He decorated the walls of the Temple with beautiful jewels and with gold from the land of Parvaim. ⁷He overlaid the beams, thresholds, walls, and doors throughout the Temple with gold, and he carved figures of cherubim on the walls.

⁸He made the Most Holy Place 30 feet wide, corresponding to the width of the Temple, and 30 feet deep. He overlaid its interior with 23 tons of fine gold. ⁹The gold nails that were used weighed 20 ounces each. He also overlaid the walls of the upper rooms with gold.

¹⁰He made two figures shaped like cherubim, overlaid them with gold, and placed them in the Most Holy Place. ¹¹The total wingspan of the two cherubim standing side by side was 30 feet. One wing of the first figure was 7-1/2 feet long, and it touched the Temple wall. The other wing, also 7-1/2 feet long, touched one of the wings of the second figure. ¹²In the same way, the second figure had one wing 7-1/2 feet long that touched the opposite wall. The other wing, also 7-1/2 feet long, touched the wing of the first figure. ¹³So the wingspan of the two cherubim side by side was 30 feet. They stood on their feet and faced out toward the main room of the Temple.

¹⁴Across the entrance of the Most Holy Place he hung a curtain made of fine linen, decorated with blue, purple, and scarlet thread and embroidered with figures of cherubim.

¹⁵For the front of the Temple, he made two pillars that were 27 feet tall, each topped by a capital extending upward another 7-1/2 feet. ¹⁶He made a network of interwoven chains and used them to decorate the tops of the pillars. He also made 100 decorative pomegranates and attached them to the chains. ¹⁷Then he set up the two pillars at the entrance of the Temple, one to the south of the entrance and the other to the north. He named the one on the south Jakin, and the one on the north Boaz.

Furnishings for the Temple

OLOMON also made a bronze altar 30 feet long, 30 feet wide, and 15 feet high. ²Then he cast a great round basin, 15 feet across from rim to rim, called the Sea. It was 7-1/2 feet deep and about 45 feet in circumference. ³It was encircled just below its rim by two rows of figures that resembled oxen. There were about six oxen per foot all the way around, and they were cast as part of the basin.

⁴The Sea was placed on a base of twelve bronze oxen, all facing outward. Three faced north, three faced west, three faced south, and three faced east, and the Sea rested on them. ⁵The walls of the Sea were about three inches thick, and its rim flared out like a cup and resembled a water lily blossom. It could hold about 16,500 gallons of water.

⁶He also made ten smaller basins for washing the utensils for the burnt offerings. He set five on the south side and five on the north. But the priests washed themselves in the Sea.

⁷He then cast ten gold lampstands according to the specifications that had been given, and he put them in the Temple. Five were placed against the south wall, and five were placed against the north wall.

⁸He also built ten tables and placed them in the Temple, five along the south wall and five along the north wall. Then he molded 100 gold basins.

⁹He then built a courtyard for the priests, and also the large outer courtyard. He made doors for the courtyard entrances and overlaid them with bronze. ¹⁰The great bronze basin called the Sea was placed near the southeast corner of the Temple.

¹¹Huram-abi also made the necessary washbasins, shovels, and bowls.

So at last Hiram-abi completed everything King Solomon had assigned him to make for the Temple of God:

¹²the two pillars;

the two bowl-shaped capitals on top of the pillars;
the two networks of interwoven chains that decorated the capitals;
¹³the 400 pomegranates that hung from the chains on the capitals
(two rows of pomegranates for each of the chain networks that
decorated the capitals on top of the pillars);
¹⁴the water carts holding the basins;
¹⁵the Sea and the twelve oxen under it;
¹⁶the ash buckets, the shovels, the meat hooks, and all the related
articles.

Huram-abi made all these things of burnished bronze for the Temple of the Lord, just as King Solomon had directed. ¹⁷The king had them cast in clay molds in the Jordan Valley between Succoth and Zarethan. ¹⁸Solomon used such great quantities of bronze that its weight could not be determined.

¹⁹Solomon also made all the furnishings for the Temple of God:

the gold altar;
the tables for the Bread of the Presence;
²⁰the lampstands and their lamps of solid gold, to burn in front of
the Most Holy Place as prescribed;
²¹the flower decorations, lamps, and tongs—all of the purest gold;
²²the lamp snuffers, bowls, ladles, and incense burners—all of solid
gold;
the doors for the entrances to the Most Holy Place and the main room
of the Temple, overlaid with gold.

5



o Solomon finished all his work on the Temple of the Lord. Then he brought all the gifts his father, David, had dedicated—the silver, the gold, and the various articles—and he stored them in the treasuries of the Temple of God.

The Ark Brought to the Temple

²Solomon then summoned to Jerusalem the elders of Israel and all the heads of tribes—the leaders of the ancestral families of Israel. They were to bring the Ark of the Lord’s Covenant to the Temple from its location in the City of David, also known as Zion. ³So all the men of Israel assembled before the king at the annual Festival of Shelters, which is held in early autumn.

⁴When all the elders of Israel arrived, the Levites picked up the Ark. ⁵The priests and Levites brought up the Ark along with the special tent and all the sacred items that had been in it. ⁶There, before the Ark, King Solomon and the entire community of Israel sacrificed so many sheep, goats, and cattle that no one could keep count!

⁷Then the priests carried the Ark of the Lord’s Covenant into the inner sanctuary of the Temple—the Most Holy Place—and placed it beneath the wings of the cherubim. ⁸The cherubim spread their wings over the Ark, forming a canopy over the Ark and its carrying poles. ⁹These poles were so long that their ends could be seen from the Holy Place, which is in front of the Most Holy Place, but not from the outside. They are still there to this day. ¹⁰Nothing was in the Ark except the two stone tablets that Moses had placed in it at Mount Sinai, where the Lord made a covenant with the people of Israel when they left Egypt.

¹¹Then the priests left the Holy Place. All the priests who were present had purified themselves, whether or not they were on duty that day. ¹²And the Levites who were musicians—Asaph, Heman, Jeduthun, and all their sons and brothers—were dressed in fine linen robes and stood at the east side of the altar playing cymbals, lyres, and harps. They were joined by 120 priests who were playing trumpets. ¹³The trumpeters and singers performed together in unison to praise and give thanks to the Lord. Accompanied by trumpets, cymbals, and other instruments, they raised their voices and praised the Lord with these words:

“He is good!

His faithful love endures forever!”

At that moment a thick cloud filled the Temple of the Lord. ¹⁴The priests could not continue their service because of the cloud, for the glorious presence of the Lord filled the Temple of God.

6

Solomon Praises the Lord

THEN Solomon prayed, “O Lord, you have said that you would live in a thick cloud of darkness. ²Now I have built a glorious Temple for you, a place where you can live forever!”

³Then the king turned around to the entire community of Israel standing before him and gave this blessing: ⁴“Praise the Lord, the God of Israel, who has kept the promise he made to my father, David. For he told my father, ⁵‘From the day I brought my people out of the land of Egypt, I have never chosen a city among any of the tribes of Israel as the place where a Temple should be built to honor my name. Nor have I chosen a king to lead my people Israel. ⁶But now I have chosen Jerusalem as the place for my name to be honored, and I have chosen David to be king over my people Israel.’”

⁷Then Solomon said, “My father, David, wanted to build this Temple to honor the name of the Lord, the God of Israel. ⁸But the Lord told him, ‘You wanted to build the Temple to honor my name. Your intention is good, ⁹but you are not the one to do it. One of your own sons will build the Temple to honor me.’”

¹⁰“And now the Lord has fulfilled the promise he made, for I have become king in my father’s place, and now I sit on the throne of Israel, just as the Lord promised. I have built this Temple to honor the name of the Lord, the God of Israel. ¹¹There I have placed the Ark, which contains the covenant that the Lord made with the people of Israel.”

Solomon's Prayer of Dedication

¹²Then Solomon stood before the altar of the Lord in front of the entire community of Israel, and he lifted his hands in prayer. ¹³Now Solomon had made a bronze platform 7-1/2 feet long, 7-1/2 feet wide, and 4-1/2 feet high and had placed it at the center of the Temple's outer courtyard. He stood on the platform, and then he knelt in front of the entire community of Israel and lifted his hands toward heaven.

¹⁴He prayed,

"O Lord, God of Israel, there is no God like you in all of heaven and earth. You keep your covenant and show unfailing love to all who walk before you in wholehearted devotion.

¹⁵You have kept your promise to your servant David, my father. You made that promise with your own mouth, and with your own hands you have fulfilled it today.

¹⁶"And now, O Lord, God of Israel, carry out the additional promise you made to your servant David, my father. For you said to him, 'If your descendants guard their behavior and faithfully follow my Law as you have done, one of them will always sit on the throne of Israel.' ¹⁷Now, O Lord, God of Israel, fulfill this promise to your servant David.

¹⁸"But will God really live on earth among people? Why, even the highest heavens cannot contain you. How much less this Temple I have built! ¹⁹Nevertheless, listen to my prayer and my plea, O Lord my God. Hear the cry and the prayer that your servant is making to you. ²⁰May you watch over this Temple day and night, this place where you have said you would put your name. May you always hear the prayers I make toward this place. ²¹May you hear the humble and earnest requests from me and your people Israel when we pray toward this place. Yes, hear us from heaven where you live, and when you hear, forgive.

²²“If someone wrongs another person and is required to take an oath of innocence in front of your altar at this Temple, ²³then hear from heaven and judge between your servants—the accuser and the accused. Pay back the guilty as they deserve. Acquit the innocent because of their innocence.

²⁴“If your people Israel are defeated by their enemies because they have sinned against you, and if they turn back and acknowledge your name and pray to you here in this Temple, ²⁵then hear from heaven and forgive the sin of your people Israel and return them to this land you gave to them and to their ancestors.

²⁶“If the skies are shut up and there is no rain because your people have sinned against you, and if they pray toward this Temple and acknowledge your name and turn from their sins because you have punished them, ²⁷then hear from heaven and forgive the sins of your servants, your people Israel. Teach them to follow the right path, and send rain on your land that you have given to your people as their special possession.

²⁸“If there is a famine in the land or a plague or crop disease or attacks of locusts or caterpillars, or if your people’s enemies are in the land besieging their towns—whatever disaster or disease there is— ²⁹and if your people Israel pray about their troubles or sorrow, raising their hands toward this Temple, ³⁰then hear from heaven where you live, and forgive. Give your people what their actions deserve, for you alone know each human heart. ³¹Then they will fear you and walk in your ways as long as they live in the land you gave to our ancestors.

³²“In the future, foreigners who do not belong to your people Israel will hear of you. They will come from distant lands when they hear of your great name and your strong hand and your powerful arm. And when they pray toward this

Temple, ³³then hear from heaven where you live, and grant what they ask of you. In this way, all the people of the earth will come to know and fear you, just as your own people Israel do. They, too, will know that this Temple I have built honors your name.

³⁴“If your people go out where you send them to fight their enemies, and if they pray to you by turning toward this city you have chosen and toward this Temple I have built to honor your name, ³⁵then hear their prayers from heaven and uphold their cause.

³⁶“If they sin against you—and who has never sinned?—you might become angry with them and let their enemies conquer them and take them captive to a foreign land far away or near. ³⁷But in that land of exile, they might turn to you in repentance and pray, ‘We have sinned, done evil, and acted wickedly.’ ³⁸If they turn to you with their whole heart and soul in the land of their captivity and pray toward the land you gave to their ancestors—toward this city you have chosen, and toward this Temple I have built to honor your name— ³⁹then hear their prayers and their petitions from heaven where you live, and uphold their cause. Forgive your people who have sinned against you.

⁴⁰“O my God, may your eyes be open and your ears attentive to all the prayers made to you in this place.

⁴¹“And now arise, O Lord God, and enter your resting place, along with the Ark, the symbol of your power.

May your priests, O Lord God, be clothed with salvation;
may your loyal servants rejoice in your goodness.

⁴²O Lord God, do not reject the king you have anointed.
Remember your unfailing love for your servant David.”

The Dedication of the Temple

WHEN Solomon finished praying, fire flashed down from heaven and burned up the burnt offerings and sacrifices, and the glorious presence of the Lord filled the Temple. ²The priests could not enter the Temple of the Lord because the glorious presence of the Lord filled it. ³When all the people of Israel saw the fire coming down and the glorious presence of the Lord filling the Temple, they fell face down on the ground and worshiped and praised the Lord, saying,

“He is good!

His faithful love endures forever!”

⁴Then the king and all the people offered sacrifices to the Lord. ⁵King Solomon offered a sacrifice of 22,000 cattle and 120,000 sheep and goats. And so the king and all the people dedicated the Temple of God. ⁶The priests took their assigned positions, and so did the Levites who were singing, “His faithful love endures forever!” They accompanied the singing with music from the instruments King David had made for praising the Lord. Across from the Levites, the priests blew the trumpets, while all Israel stood.

⁷Solomon then consecrated the central area of the courtyard in front of the Lord’s Temple. He offered burnt offerings and the fat of peace offerings there, because the bronze altar he had built could not hold all the burnt offerings, grain offerings, and sacrificial fat.

⁸For the next seven days Solomon and all Israel celebrated the Festival of Shelters. A large congregation had gathered from as far away as Lebo-hamath in the north and the Brook of Egypt in the south. ⁹On the eighth day they had a closing ceremony, for they had celebrated the dedication of the altar for seven days and the Festival of Shelters

for seven days. ¹⁰Then at the end of the celebration, Solomon sent the people home. They were all joyful and glad because the Lord had been so good to David and to Solomon and to his people Israel.

The Lord's Response to Solomon

¹¹So Solomon finished the Temple of the Lord, as well as the royal palace. He completed everything he had planned to do in the construction of the Temple and the palace. ¹²Then one night the Lord appeared to Solomon and said,

“I have heard your prayer and have chosen this Temple as the place for making sacrifices. ¹³At times I might shut up the heavens so that no rain falls, or command grasshoppers to devour your crops, or send plagues among you. ¹⁴Then if my people who are called by my name will humble themselves and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, I will hear from heaven and will forgive their sins and restore their land. ¹⁵My eyes will be open and my ears attentive to every prayer made in this place. ¹⁶For I have chosen this Temple and set it apart to be holy—a place where my name will be honored forever. I will always watch over it, for it is dear to my heart.

¹⁷“As for you, if you faithfully follow me as David your father did, obeying all my commands, decrees, and regulations, ¹⁸then I will establish the throne of your dynasty. For I made this covenant with your father, David, when I said, ‘One of your descendants will always rule over Israel.’

¹⁹“But if you or your descendants abandon me and disobey the decrees and commands I have given you, and if you serve and worship other gods, ²⁰then I will uproot the people from this land that I have given them. I will reject this Temple that I have made holy to honor my name. I will make it an object of

mockery and ridicule among the nations. ²¹And though this Temple is impressive now, all who pass by will be appalled. They will ask, ‘Why did the Lord do such terrible things to this land and to this Temple?’

²²“And the answer will be, ‘Because his people abandoned the Lord, the God of their ancestors, who brought them out of Egypt, and they worshiped other gods instead and bowed down to them. That is why he has brought all these disasters on them.’”

8

Solomon’s Many Achievements

 It took Solomon twenty years to build the Lord’s Temple and his own royal palace. At the end of that time, ²Solomon turned his attention to rebuilding the towns that King Hiram had given him, and he settled Israelites in them.

³Solomon also fought against the town of Hamath-zobah and conquered it. ⁴He rebuilt Tadmor in the wilderness and built towns in the region of Hamath as supply centers. ⁵He fortified the towns of Upper Beth-horon and Lower Beth-horon, rebuilding their walls and installing barred gates. ⁶He also rebuilt Baalath and other supply centers and constructed towns where his chariots and horses could be stationed. He built everything he desired in Jerusalem and Lebanon and throughout his entire realm.

⁷There were still some people living in the land who were not Israelites, including the Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites. ⁸These were descendants of the nations whom the people of Israel had not destroyed. So Solomon conscripted them for his labor force, and they serve as forced laborers to this day. ⁹But Solomon did not conscript any of the Israelites for his labor force. Instead, he

assigned them to serve as fighting men, officers in his army, commanders of his chariots, and charioteers. ¹⁰King Solomon appointed 250 of them to supervise the people.

¹¹Solomon moved his wife, Pharaoh's daughter, from the City of David to the new palace he had built for her. He said, "My wife must not live in King David's palace, for the Ark of the Lord has been there, and it is holy ground."

¹²Then Solomon presented burnt offerings to the Lord on the altar he had built for him in front of the entry room of the Temple. ¹³He offered the sacrifices for the Sabbaths, the new moon festivals, and the three annual festivals—the Passover celebration, the Festival of Harvest, and the Festival of Shelters—as Moses had commanded.

¹⁴In assigning the priests to their duties, Solomon followed the regulations of his father, David. He also assigned the Levites to lead the people in praise and to assist the priests in their daily duties. And he assigned the gatekeepers to their gates by their divisions, following the commands of David, the man of God. ¹⁵Solomon did not deviate in any way from David's commands concerning the priests and Levites and the treasuries.

¹⁶So Solomon made sure that all the work related to building the Temple of the Lord was carried out, from the day its foundation was laid to the day of its completion.

¹⁷Later Solomon went to Ezion-geber and Elath, ports along the shore of the Red Sea in the land of Edom. ¹⁸Hiram sent him ships commanded by his own officers and manned by experienced crews of sailors. These ships sailed to Ophir with Solomon's men and brought back to Solomon almost seventeen tons of gold.

9

Visit of the Queen of Sheba



WHEN the queen of Sheba heard of Solomon's fame, she came to Jerusalem to test him with hard questions. She arrived with

a large group of attendants and a great caravan of camels loaded with spices, large quantities of gold, and precious jewels. When she met with Solomon, she talked with him about everything she had on her mind. ²Solomon had answers for all her questions; nothing was too hard for him to explain to her. ³When the queen of Sheba realized how wise Solomon was, and when she saw the palace he had built, ⁴she was overwhelmed. She was also amazed at the food on his tables, the organization of his officials and their splendid clothing, the cup-bearers and their robes, and the burnt offerings Solomon made at the Temple of the Lord.

⁵She exclaimed to the king, "Everything I heard in my country about your achievements and wisdom is true! ⁶I didn't believe what was said until I arrived here and saw it with my own eyes. In fact, I had not heard the half of your great wisdom! It is far beyond what I was told. ⁷How happy your people must be! What a privilege for your officials to stand here day after day, listening to your wisdom! ⁸Praise the Lord your God, who delights in you and has placed you on the throne as king to rule for him. Because God loves Israel and desires this kingdom to last forever, he has made you king over them so you can rule with justice and righteousness."

⁹Then she gave the king a gift of 9,000 pounds of gold, great quantities of spices, and precious jewels. Never before had there been spices as fine as those the queen of Sheba gave to King Solomon.

10(In addition, the crews of Hiram and Solomon brought gold from Ophir, and they also brought red sandalwood and precious jewels. ¹¹The king used the sandalwood to make steps for the Temple of the Lord and the royal palace, and to construct lyres and harps for the musicians. Never before had such beautiful things been seen in Judah.)

¹²King Solomon gave the queen of Sheba whatever she asked for—gifts of greater value than the gifts she had given him. Then she and all her attendants returned to their own land.

Solomon's Wealth and Splendor

¹³Each year Solomon received about 25 tons of gold. ¹⁴This did not include the additional revenue he received from merchants and traders. All the kings of Arabia and the governors of the provinces also brought gold and silver to Solomon.

¹⁵King Solomon made 200 large shields of hammered gold, each weighing more than 15 pounds. ¹⁶He also made 300 smaller shields of hammered gold, each weighing more than 7-1/2 pounds. The king placed these shields in the Palace of the Forest of Lebanon.

¹⁷Then the king made a huge throne, decorated with ivory and overlaid with pure gold. ¹⁸The throne had six steps, with a footstool of gold. There were armrests on both sides of the seat, and the figure of a lion stood on each side of the throne. ¹⁹There were also twelve other lions, one standing on each end of the six steps. No other throne in all the world could be compared with it!

²⁰All of King Solomon's drinking cups were solid gold, as were all the utensils in the Palace of the Forest of Lebanon. They were not made of silver, for silver was considered worthless in Solomon's day!

²¹The king had a fleet of trading ships of Tarshish manned by the sailors sent by Hiram. Once every three years the ships returned, loaded with gold, silver, ivory, apes, and peacocks.

²²So King Solomon became richer and wiser than any other king on earth. ²³Kings from every nation came to consult him and to hear the wisdom God had given him. ²⁴Year after year everyone who visited brought him gifts of silver and gold, clothing, weapons, spices, horses, and mules.

²⁵Solomon had 4,000 stalls for his horses and chariots, and he had 12,000 horses. He stationed some of them in the chariot cities, and some near him in Jerusalem. ²⁶He ruled over all the kings from the Euphrates River in the north to the land of the Philistines and the border of Egypt in the south. ²⁷The king made silver as plentiful in Jerusalem as stone. And valuable cedar timber was as common as the

sycamore-fig trees that grow in the foothills of Judah. ²⁸Solomon's horses were imported from Egypt and many other countries.

Summary of Solomon's Reign

²⁹The rest of the events of Solomon's reign, from beginning to end, are recorded in The Record of Nathan the Prophet, and The Prophecy of Ahijah from Shiloh, and also in The Visions of Iddo the Seer, concerning Jeroboam son of Nebat. ³⁰Solomon ruled in Jerusalem over all Israel for forty years. ³¹When he died, he was buried in the City of David, named for his father. Then his son Rehoboam became the next king.

10

The Northern Tribes Revolt

REHOBOAM went to Shechem, where all Israel had gathered to make him king. ²When Jeroboam son of Nebat heard of this, he returned from Egypt, for he had fled to Egypt to escape from King Solomon. ³The leaders of Israel summoned him, and Jeroboam and all Israel went to speak with Rehoboam. ⁴"Your father was a hard master," they said. "Lighten the harsh labor demands and heavy taxes that your father imposed on us. Then we will be your loyal subjects."

⁵Rehoboam replied, "Come back in three days for my answer." So the people went away.

⁶Then King Rehoboam discussed the matter with the older men who had counseled his father, Solomon. "What is your advice?" he asked. "How should I answer these people?"

⁷The older counselors replied, "If you are good to these people and do your best to please them and give them a favorable answer, they will always be your loyal subjects."

⁸But Rehoboam rejected the advice of the older men and instead asked the opinion of the young men who had grown up with him and

were now his advisers. ⁹“What is your advice?” he asked them. “How should I answer these people who want me to lighten the burdens imposed by my father?”

¹⁰The young men replied, “This is what you should tell those complainers who want a lighter burden: ‘My little finger is thicker than my father’s waist! ¹¹Yes, my father laid heavy burdens on you, but I’m going to make them even heavier! My father beat you with whips, but I will beat you with scorpions!’”

¹²Three days later Jeroboam and all the people returned to hear Rehoboam’s decision, just as the king had ordered. ¹³But Rehoboam spoke harshly to them, for he rejected the advice of the older counselors ¹⁴and followed the counsel of his younger advisers. He told the people, “My father laid heavy burdens on you, but I’m going to make them even heavier! My father beat you with whips, but I will beat you with scorpions!”

¹⁵So the king paid no attention to the people. This turn of events was the will of God, for it fulfilled the Lord’s message to Jeroboam son of Nebat through the prophet Ahijah from Shiloh.

¹⁶When all Israel realized that the king had refused to listen to them, they responded,

“Down with the dynasty of David!

We have no interest in the son of Jesse.

Back to your homes, O Israel!

Look out for your own house, O David!”

So all the people of Israel returned home. ¹⁷But Rehoboam continued to rule over the Israelites who lived in the towns of Judah.

¹⁸King Rehoboam sent Adoniram, who was in charge of forced labor, to restore order, but the people of Israel stoned him to death. When this news reached King Rehoboam, he quickly jumped into his chariot and fled to Jerusalem. ¹⁹And to this day the northern tribes of Israel have refused to be ruled by a descendant of David.

11

Shemaiah's Prophecy

WHEN Rehoboam arrived at Jerusalem, he mobilized the men of Judah and Benjamin—180,000 select troops—to fight against Israel and to restore the kingdom to himself.

²But the Lord said to Shemaiah, the man of God, ³“Say to Rehoboam son of Solomon, king of Judah, and to all the Israelites in Judah and Benjamin: ⁴“This is what the Lord says: Do not fight against your relatives. Go back home, for what has happened is my doing!” So they obeyed the message of the Lord and did not fight against Jeroboam.

Rehoboam Fortifies Judah

⁵Rehoboam remained in Jerusalem and fortified various towns for the defense of Judah. ⁶He built up Bethlehem, Etam, Tekoa, ⁷Beth-zur, Soco, Adullam, ⁸Gath, Mareshah, Ziph, ⁹Adoraim, Lachish, Azekah, ¹⁰Zorah, Aijalon, and Hebron. These became the fortified towns of Judah and Benjamin. ¹¹Rehoboam strengthened their defenses and stationed commanders in them, and he stored supplies of food, olive oil, and wine. ¹²He also put shields and spears in these towns as a further safety measure. So only Judah and Benjamin remained under his control.

¹³But all the priests and Levites living among the northern tribes of Israel sided with Rehoboam. ¹⁴The Levites even abandoned their pasturelands and property and moved to Judah and Jerusalem, because Jeroboam and his sons would not allow them to serve the Lord as priests. ¹⁵Jeroboam appointed his own priests to serve at the pagan shrines, where they worshiped the goat and calf idols he had made. ¹⁶From all the tribes of Israel, those who sincerely wanted to worship the Lord, the God of Israel, followed the Levites to Jerusalem, where they could offer sacrifices to the Lord, the God of their ancestors.

¹⁷This strengthened the kingdom of Judah, and for three years they supported Rehoboam son of Solomon, for during those years they faithfully followed in the footsteps of David and Solomon.

Rehoboam's Family

¹⁸Rehoboam married his cousin Mahalath, the daughter of David's son Jerimoth and of Abihail, the daughter of Eliab son of Jesse. ¹⁹Mahalath had three sons—Jeush, Shemariah, and Zaham.

²⁰Later Rehoboam married another cousin, Maacah, the granddaughter of Absalom. Maacah gave birth to Abijah, Attai, Ziza, and Shelomith. ²¹Rehoboam loved Maacah more than any of his other wives and concubines. In all, he had eighteen wives and sixty concubines, and they gave birth to twenty-eight sons and sixty daughters.

²²Rehoboam appointed Maacah's son Abijah as leader among the princes, making it clear that he would be the next king. ²³Rehoboam also wisely gave responsibilities to his other sons and stationed some of them in the fortified towns throughout the land of Judah and Benjamin. He provided them with generous provisions, and he found many wives for them.

12

Egypt Invades Judah

BUT when Rehoboam was firmly established and strong, he abandoned the Law of the Lord, and all Israel followed him in this sin. ²Because they were unfaithful to the Lord, King Shishak of Egypt came up and attacked Jerusalem in the fifth year of King Rehoboam's reign. ³He came with 1,200 chariots, 60,000 horses, and a countless army of foot soldiers, including Libyans, Sukkites, and Ethiopians. ⁴Shishak conquered Judah's fortified towns and then advanced to attack Jerusalem.

⁵The prophet Shemaiah then met with Rehoboam and Judah's leaders, who had all fled to Jerusalem because of Shishak. Shemaiah told them, "This is what the Lord says: **You have abandoned me, so I am abandoning you to Shishak.**"

⁶Then the leaders of Israel and the king humbled themselves and said, "The Lord is right in doing this to us!"

⁷When the Lord saw their change of heart, he gave this message to Shemaiah: "**Since the people have humbled themselves, I will not completely destroy them and will soon give them some relief. I will not use Shishak to pour out my anger on Jerusalem. ⁸But they will become his subjects, so they will know the difference between serving me and serving earthly rulers.**"

⁹So King Shishak of Egypt came up and attacked Jerusalem. He ransacked the treasuries of the Lord's Temple and the royal palace; he stole everything, including all the gold shields Solomon had made.

¹⁰King Rehoboam later replaced them with bronze shields as substitutes, and he entrusted them to the care of the commanders of the guard who protected the entrance to the royal palace. ¹¹Whenever the king went to the Temple of the Lord, the guards would also take the shields and then return them to the guardroom. ¹²Because Rehoboam humbled himself, the Lord's anger was turned away, and he did not destroy him completely. There were still some good things in the land of Judah.

Summary of Rehoboam's Reign

¹³King Rehoboam firmly established himself in Jerusalem and continued to rule. He was forty-one years old when he became king, and he reigned seventeen years in Jerusalem, the city the Lord had chosen from among all the tribes of Israel as the place to honor his name. Rehoboam's mother was Naamah, a woman from Ammon. ¹⁴But he was an evil king, for he did not seek the Lord with all his heart.

¹⁵The rest of the events of Rehoboam's reign, from beginning to end, are recorded in The Record of Shemaiah the Prophet and The

Record of Iddo the Seer, which are part of the genealogical record. Rehoboam and Jeroboam were continually at war with each other. ¹⁶When Rehoboam died, he was buried in the City of David. Then his son Abijah became the next king.

13

Abijah's War with Jeroboam

ABIJAH began to rule over Judah in the eighteenth year of Jeroboam's reign in Israel. ²He reigned in Jerusalem three years. His mother was Maacah, the daughter of Uriel from Gibeah.

Then war broke out between Abijah and Jeroboam. ³Judah, led by King Abijah, fielded 400,000 select warriors, while Jeroboam mustered 800,000 select troops from Israel.

⁴When the army of Judah arrived in the hill country of Ephraim, Abijah stood on Mount Zemaraim and shouted to Jeroboam and all Israel: "Listen to me! ⁵Don't you realize that the Lord, the God of Israel, made a lasting covenant with David, giving him and his descendants the throne of Israel forever? ⁶Yet Jeroboam son of Nebat, a mere servant of David's son Solomon, rebelled against his master. ⁷Then a whole gang of scoundrels joined him, defying Solomon's son Rehoboam when he was young and inexperienced and could not stand up to them.

⁸"Do you really think you can stand against the kingdom of the Lord that is led by the descendants of David? You may have a vast army, and you have those gold calves that Jeroboam made as your gods. ⁹But you have chased away the priests of the Lord (the descendants of Aaron) and the Levites, and you have appointed your own priests, just like the pagan nations. You let anyone become a priest these days! Whoever comes to be dedicated with a young bull and seven rams can become a priest of these so-called gods of yours!

¹⁰"But as for us, the Lord is our God, and we have not abandoned him. Only the descendants of Aaron serve the Lord as priests, and

the Levites alone may help them in their work. ¹¹They present burnt offerings and fragrant incense to the Lord every morning and evening. They place the Bread of the Presence on the holy table, and they light the gold lampstand every evening. We are following the instructions of the Lord our God, but you have abandoned him. ¹²So you see, God is with us. He is our leader. His priests blow their trumpets and lead us into battle against you. O people of Israel, do not fight against the Lord, the God of your ancestors, for you will not succeed!”

¹³Meanwhile, Jeroboam had secretly sent part of his army around behind the men of Judah to ambush them. ¹⁴When Judah realized that they were being attacked from the front and the rear, they cried out to the Lord for help. Then the priests blew the trumpets, ¹⁵and the men of Judah began to shout. At the sound of their battle cry, God defeated Jeroboam and all Israel and routed them before Abijah and the army of Judah.

¹⁶The Israelite army fled from Judah, and God handed them over to Judah in defeat. ¹⁷Abijah and his army inflicted heavy losses on them; 500,000 of Israel’s select troops were killed that day. ¹⁸So Judah defeated Israel on that occasion because they trusted in the Lord, the God of their ancestors. ¹⁹Abijah and his army pursued Jeroboam’s troops and captured some of his towns, including Bethel, Jeshanah, and Ephron, along with their surrounding villages.

²⁰So Jeroboam of Israel never regained his power during Abijah’s lifetime, and finally the Lord struck him down and he died. ²¹Meanwhile, Abijah of Judah grew more and more powerful. He married fourteen wives and had twenty-two sons and sixteen daughters.

²²The rest of the events of Abijah’s reign, including his words and deeds, are recorded in The Commentary of Iddo the Prophet.

Early Years of Asa's Reign

WHEN Abijah died, he was buried in the City of David. Then his son Asa became the next king. There was peace in the land for ten years. ²Asa did what was pleasing and good in the sight of the Lord his God. ³He removed the foreign altars and the pagan shrines. He smashed the sacred pillars and cut down the Asherah poles. ⁴He commanded the people of Judah to seek the Lord, the God of their ancestors, and to obey his law and his commands. ⁵Asa also removed the pagan shrines, as well as the incense altars from every one of Judah's towns. So Asa's kingdom enjoyed a period of peace. ⁶During those peaceful years, he was able to build up the fortified towns throughout Judah. No one tried to make war against him at this time, for the Lord was giving him rest from his enemies.

⁷Asa told the people of Judah, "Let us build towns and fortify them with walls, towers, gates, and bars. The land is still ours because we sought the Lord our God, and he has given us peace on every side." So they went ahead with these projects and brought them to completion.

⁸King Asa had an army of 300,000 warriors from the tribe of Judah, armed with large shields and spears. He also had an army of 280,000 warriors from the tribe of Benjamin, armed with small shields and bows. Both armies were composed of well-trained fighting men.

⁹Once an Ethiopian named Zerah attacked Judah with an army of 1,000,000 men and 300 chariots. They advanced to the town of Mareshah, ¹⁰so Asa deployed his armies for battle in the valley north of Mareshah. ¹¹Then Asa cried out to the Lord his God, "O Lord, no one but you can help the powerless against the mighty! Help us, O Lord our God, for we trust in you alone. It is in your name that we have come against this vast horde. O Lord, you are our God; do not let mere men prevail against you!"

¹²So the Lord defeated the Ethiopians in the presence of Asa and the army of Judah, and the enemy fled. ¹³Asa and his army pursued them

as far as Gerar, and so many Ethiopians fell that they were unable to rally. They were destroyed by the Lord and his army, and the army of Judah carried off a vast amount of plunder.

¹⁴While they were at Gerar, they attacked all the towns in that area, and terror from the Lord came upon the people there. As a result, a vast amount of plunder was taken from these towns, too. ¹⁵They also attacked the camps of herdsmen and captured many sheep, goats, and camels before finally returning to Jerusalem.

15

Asa's Religious Reforms

THEN the Spirit of God came upon Azariah son of Oded, ²and he went out to meet King Asa as he was returning from the battle. “Listen to me, Asa!” he shouted. “Listen, all you people of Judah and Benjamin! The Lord will stay with you as long as you stay with him! Whenever you seek him, you will find him. But if you abandon him, he will abandon you. ³For a long time Israel was without the true God, without a priest to teach them, and without the Law to instruct them. ⁴But whenever they were in trouble and turned to the Lord, the God of Israel, and sought him out, they found him.

⁵“During those dark times, it was not safe to travel. Problems troubled the people of every land. ⁶Nation fought against nation, and city against city, for God was troubling them with every kind of problem. ⁷But as for you, be strong and courageous, for your work will be rewarded.”

⁸When Asa heard this message from Azariah the prophet, he took courage and removed all the detestable idols from the land of Judah and Benjamin and in the towns he had captured in the hill country of Ephraim. And he repaired the altar of the Lord, which stood in front of the entry room of the Lord's Temple.

⁹Then Asa called together all the people of Judah and Benjamin, along with the people of Ephraim, Manasseh, and Simeon who had settled among them. For many from Israel had moved to Judah during Asa's reign when they saw that the Lord his God was with him. ¹⁰The people gathered at Jerusalem in late spring, during the fifteenth year of Asa's reign.

¹¹On that day they sacrificed to the Lord 700 cattle and 7,000 sheep and goats from the plunder they had taken in the battle. ¹²Then they entered into a covenant to seek the Lord, the God of their ancestors, with all their heart and soul. ¹³They agreed that anyone who refused to seek the Lord, the God of Israel, would be put to death—whether young or old, man or woman. ¹⁴They shouted out their oath of loyalty to the Lord with trumpets blaring and rams' horns sounding. ¹⁵All in Judah were happy about this covenant, for they had entered into it with all their heart. They earnestly sought after God, and they found him. And the Lord gave them rest from their enemies on every side.

¹⁶King Asa even deposed his grandmother Maacah from her position as queen mother because she had made an obscene Asherah pole. He cut down her obscene pole, broke it up, and burned it in the Kidron Valley. ¹⁷Although the pagan shrines were not removed from Israel, Asa's heart remained completely faithful throughout his life. ¹⁸He brought into the Temple of God the silver and gold and the various items that he and his father had dedicated.

¹⁹So there was no more war until the thirty-fifth year of Asa's reign.

16

Final Years of Asa's Reign

IN the thirty-sixth year of Asa's reign, King Baasha of Israel invaded Judah and fortified Ramah in order to prevent anyone from entering or leaving King Asa's territory in Judah.

²Asa responded by removing the silver and gold from the treasuries of the Temple of the Lord and the royal palace. He sent it to King Ben-hadad of Aram, who was ruling in Damascus, along with this message:

³“Let there be a treaty between you and me like the one between your father and my father. See, I am sending you silver and gold. Break your treaty with King Baasha of Israel so that he will leave me alone.”

⁴Ben-hadad agreed to King Asa’s request and sent the commanders of his army to attack the towns of Israel. They conquered the towns of Ijon, Dan, Abel-beth-maacah, and all the store cities in Naphtali. ⁵As soon as Baasha of Israel heard what was happening, he abandoned his project of fortifying Ramah and stopped all work on it. ⁶Then King Asa called out all the men of Judah to carry away the building stones and timbers that Baasha had been using to fortify Ramah. Asa used these materials to fortify the towns of Geba and Mizpah.

⁷At that time Hanani the seer came to King Asa and told him, “Because you have put your trust in the king of Aram instead of in the Lord your God, you missed your chance to destroy the army of the king of Aram. ⁸Don’t you remember what happened to the Ethiopians and Libyans and their vast army, with all of their chariots and charioteers? At that time you relied on the Lord, and he handed them over to you. ⁹The eyes of the Lord search the whole earth in order to strengthen those whose hearts are fully committed to him. What a fool you have been! From now on you will be at war.”

¹⁰Asa became so angry with Hanani for saying this that he threw him into prison and put him in stocks. At that time Asa also began to oppress some of his people.

Summary of Asa’s Reign

¹¹The rest of the events of Asa’s reign, from beginning to end, are recorded in The Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel. ¹²In the thirty-ninth year of his reign, Asa developed a serious foot disease. Yet even

with the severity of his disease, he did not seek the Lord's help but turned only to his physicians. ¹³So he died in the forty-first year of his reign. ¹⁴He was buried in the tomb he had carved out for himself in the City of David. He was laid on a bed perfumed with sweet spices and fragrant ointments, and the people built a huge funeral fire in his honor.

17

Jehoshaphat Rules in Judah

THEN Jehoshaphat, Asa's son, became the next king. He strengthened Judah to stand against any attack from Israel.

²He stationed troops in all the fortified towns of Judah, and he assigned additional garrisons to the land of Judah and to the towns of Ephraim that his father, Asa, had captured.

³The Lord was with Jehoshaphat because he followed the example of his father's early years and did not worship the images of Baal.

⁴He sought his father's God and obeyed his commands instead of following the evil practices of the kingdom of Israel. ⁵So the Lord established Jehoshaphat's control over the kingdom of Judah. All the people of Judah brought gifts to Jehoshaphat, so he became very wealthy and highly esteemed. ⁶He was deeply committed to the ways of the Lord. He removed the pagan shrines and Asherah poles from Judah.

⁷In the third year of his reign Jehoshaphat sent his officials to teach in all the towns of Judah. These officials included Ben-hail, Obadiah, Zechariah, Nethanel, and Micaiah. ⁸He sent Levites along with them, including Shemaiah, Nethaniah, Zebadiah, Asahel, Shemiramoth, Jehonathan, Adonijah, Tobijah, and Tob-adonijah. He also sent out the priests Elishama and Jehoram. ⁹They took copies of the Book of the Law of the Lord and traveled around through all the towns of Judah, teaching the people.

¹⁰Then the fear of the Lord fell over all the surrounding kingdoms so that none of them wanted to declare war on Jehoshaphat. ¹¹Some of the Philistines brought him gifts and silver as tribute, and the Arabs brought 7,700 rams and 7,700 male goats.

¹²So Jehoshaphat became more and more powerful and built fortresses and storage cities throughout Judah. ¹³He stored numerous supplies in Judah's towns and stationed an army of seasoned troops at Jerusalem. ¹⁴His army was enrolled according to ancestral clans.

From Judah there were 300,000 troops organized in units of 1,000, under the command of Adnah. ¹⁵Next in command was Jehohanan, who commanded 280,000 troops. ¹⁶Next was Amasiah son of Zicri, who volunteered for the Lord's service, with 200,000 troops under his command.

¹⁷From Benjamin there were 200,000 troops equipped with bows and shields. They were under the command of Eliada, a veteran soldier. ¹⁸Next in command was Jehozabad, who commanded 180,000 armed men.

¹⁹These were the troops stationed in Jerusalem to serve the king, besides those Jehoshaphat stationed in the fortified towns throughout Judah.

18

Jehoshaphat and Ahab

EHOSHAPHAT enjoyed great riches and high esteem, and he made an alliance with Ahab of Israel by having his son marry Ahab's daughter. ²A few years later he went to Samaria to visit Ahab, who prepared a great banquet for him and his officials. They butchered great numbers of sheep, goats, and cattle for the feast. Then Ahab enticed Jehoshaphat to join forces with him to recover Ramoth-gilead.

³“Will you go with me to Ramoth-gilead?” King Ahab of Israel asked King Jehoshaphat of Judah.

Jehoshaphat replied, “Why, of course! You and I are as one, and my troops are your troops. We will certainly join you in battle.” ⁴Then Jehoshaphat added, “But first let’s find out what the Lord says.”

⁵So the king of Israel summoned the prophets, 400 of them, and asked them, “Should we go to war against Ramoth-gilead, or should I hold back?”

They all replied, “Yes, go right ahead! God will give the king victory.”

⁶But Jehoshaphat asked, “Is there not also a prophet of the Lord here? We should ask him the same question.”

⁷The king of Israel replied to Jehoshaphat, “There is one more man who could consult the Lord for us, but I hate him. He never prophesies anything but trouble for me! His name is Micaiah son of Imlah.”

Jehoshaphat replied, “That’s not the way a king should talk! Let’s hear what he has to say.”

⁸So the king of Israel called one of his officials and said, “Quick! Bring Micaiah son of Imlah.”

Micaiah Prophesies against Ahab

⁹King Ahab of Israel and King Jehoshaphat of Judah, dressed in their royal robes, were sitting on thrones at the threshing floor near the gate of Samaria. All of Ahab’s prophets were prophesying there in front of them. ¹⁰One of them, Zedekiah son of Kenaanah, made some iron horns and proclaimed, “This is what the Lord says: With these horns you will gore the Arameans to death!”

¹¹All the other prophets agreed. “Yes,” they said, “go up to Ramoth-gilead and be victorious, for the Lord will give the king victory!”

¹²Meanwhile, the messenger who went to get Micaiah said to him, “Look, all the prophets are promising victory for the king. Be sure that you agree with them and promise success.”

¹³But Micaiah replied, “As surely as the Lord lives, I will say only what my God says.”

¹⁴When Micaiah arrived before the king, Ahab asked him, “Micaiah, should we go to war against Ramoth-gilead, or should I hold back?”

Micaiah replied sarcastically, “Yes, go up and be victorious, for you will have victory over them!”

¹⁵But the king replied sharply, “How many times must I demand that you speak only the truth to me when you speak for the Lord?”

¹⁶Then Micaiah told him, “In a vision I saw all Israel scattered on the mountains, like sheep without a shepherd. And the Lord said, ‘**Their master has been killed. Send them home in peace.**’”

¹⁷“Didn’t I tell you?” the king of Israel exclaimed to Jehoshaphat. “He never prophesies anything but trouble for me.”

¹⁸Then Micaiah continued, “Listen to what the Lord says! I saw the Lord sitting on his throne with all the armies of heaven around him, on his right and on his left. ¹⁹And the Lord said, ‘**Who can entice King Ahab of Israel to go into battle against Ramoth-gilead so he can be killed?**’

“There were many suggestions, ²⁰and finally a spirit approached the Lord and said, ‘I can do it!’

“**How will you do this?**’ the Lord asked.

²¹“And the spirit replied, ‘I will go out and inspire all of Ahab’s prophets to speak lies.’

“**‘You will succeed,’** said the Lord. **‘Go ahead and do it.’**”

²²“So you see, the Lord has put a lying spirit in the mouths of your prophets. For the Lord has pronounced your doom.”

²³Then Zedekiah son of Kenaanah walked up to Micaiah and slapped him across the face. “Since when did the Spirit of the Lord leave me to speak to you?” he demanded.

²⁴And Micaiah replied, “You will find out soon enough when you are trying to hide in some secret room!”

²⁵“Arrest him!” the king of Israel ordered. “Take him back to Amon, the governor of the city, and to my son Joash. ²⁶Give them this order

from the king: ‘Put this man in prison, and feed him nothing but bread and water until I return safely from the battle!’”

²⁷But Micaiah replied, “If you return safely, it will mean that the Lord has not spoken through me!” Then he added to those standing around, “Everyone mark my words!”

The Death of Ahab

²⁸So King Ahab of Israel and King Jehoshaphat of Judah led their armies against Ramoth-gilead. ²⁹The king of Israel said to Jehoshaphat, “As we go into battle, I will disguise myself so no one will recognize me, but you wear your royal robes.” So the king of Israel disguised himself, and they went into battle.

³⁰Meanwhile, the king of Aram had issued these orders to his chariot commanders: “Attack only the king of Israel! Don’t bother with anyone else.” ³¹So when the Aramean chariot commanders saw Jehoshaphat in his royal robes, they went after him. “There is the king of Israel!” they shouted. But Jehoshaphat called out, and the Lord saved him. God helped him by turning the attackers away from him. ³²As soon as the chariot commanders realized he was not the king of Israel, they stopped chasing him.

³³An Aramean soldier, however, randomly shot an arrow at the Israelite troops and hit the king of Israel between the joints of his armor. “Turn the horses and get me out of here!” Ahab groaned to the driver of the chariot. “I’m badly wounded!”

³⁴The battle raged all that day, and the king of Israel propped himself up in his chariot facing the Arameans. In the evening, just as the sun was setting, he died.

19

Jehoshaphat Appoints Judges

WHEN King Jehoshaphat of Judah arrived safely home in Jerusalem, ²Jehu son of Hanani the seer went out to meet him. “Why should you help the wicked and love those who hate the Lord?” he asked the king. “Because of what you have done, the Lord is very angry with you. ³Even so, there is some good in you, for you have removed the Asherah poles throughout the land, and you have committed yourself to seeking God.”

⁴Jehoshaphat lived in Jerusalem, but he went out among the people, traveling from Beersheba to the hill country of Ephraim, encouraging the people to return to the Lord, the God of their ancestors. ⁵He appointed judges throughout the nation in all the fortified towns, ⁶and he said to them, “Always think carefully before pronouncing judgment. Remember that you do not judge to please people but to please the Lord. He will be with you when you render the verdict in each case. ⁷Fear the Lord and judge with integrity, for the Lord our God does not tolerate perverted justice, partiality, or the taking of bribes.”

⁸In Jerusalem, Jehoshaphat appointed some of the Levites and priests and clan leaders in Israel to serve as judges for cases involving the Lord’s regulations and for civil disputes. ⁹These were his instructions to them: “You must always act in the fear of the Lord, with faithfulness and an undivided heart. ¹⁰Whenever a case comes to you from fellow citizens in an outlying town, whether a murder case or some other violation of God’s laws, commands, decrees, or regulations, you must warn them not to sin against the Lord, so that he will not be angry with you and them. Do this and you will not be guilty.

¹¹“Amariah the high priest will have final say in all cases involving the Lord. Zebadiah son of Ishmael, a leader from the tribe of Judah, will have final say in all civil cases. The Levites will assist you in making

sure that justice is served. Take courage as you fulfill your duties, and may the Lord be with those who do what is right.”

20

War with Surrounding Nations

AFTER this, the armies of the Moabites, Ammonites, and some of the Meunites declared war on Jehoshaphat. ²Messengers came and told Jehoshaphat, “A vast army from Edom is marching against you from beyond the Dead Sea. They are already at Hazazon-tamar.” (This was another name for En-gedi.)

³Jehoshaphat was terrified by this news and begged the Lord for guidance. He also ordered everyone in Judah to begin fasting. ⁴So people from all the towns of Judah came to Jerusalem to seek the Lord’s help.

⁵Jehoshaphat stood before the community of Judah and Jerusalem in front of the new courtyard at the Temple of the Lord. ⁶He prayed, “O Lord, God of our ancestors, you alone are the God who is in heaven. You are ruler of all the kingdoms of the earth. You are powerful and mighty; no one can stand against you! ⁷O our God, did you not drive out those who lived in this land when your people Israel arrived? And did you not give this land forever to the descendants of your friend Abraham? ⁸Your people settled here and built this Temple to honor your name. ⁹They said, ‘Whenever we are faced with any calamity such as war, plague, or famine, we can come to stand in your presence before this Temple where your name is honored. We can cry out to you to save us, and you will hear us and rescue us.’

¹⁰“And now see what the armies of Ammon, Moab, and Mount Seir are doing. You would not let our ancestors invade those nations when Israel left Egypt, so they went around them and did not destroy them. ¹¹Now see how they reward us! For they have come to throw us out of your land, which you gave us as an inheritance. ¹²O our God, won’t you stop them? We are powerless against this mighty army that

is about to attack us. We do not know what to do, but we are looking to you for help.”

¹³As all the men of Judah stood before the Lord with their little ones, wives, and children, ¹⁴the Spirit of the Lord came upon one of the men standing there. His name was Jahaziel son of Zechariah, son of Benaiah, son of Jeiel, son of Mattaniah, a Levite who was a descendant of Asaph.

¹⁵He said, “Listen, all you people of Judah and Jerusalem! Listen, King Jehoshaphat! This is what the Lord says: **Do not be afraid! Don’t be discouraged by this mighty army, for the battle is not yours, but God’s.** ¹⁶Tomorrow, march out against them. You will find them coming up through the ascent of Ziz at the end of the valley that opens into the wilderness of Jeruel. ¹⁷But you will not even need to fight. Take your positions; then stand still and watch the Lord’s victory. He is with you, O people of Judah and Jerusalem. Do not be afraid or discouraged. Go out against them tomorrow, for the Lord is with you!”

¹⁸Then King Jehoshaphat bowed low with his face to the ground. And all the people of Judah and Jerusalem did the same, worshiping the Lord. ¹⁹Then the Levites from the clans of Kohath and Korah stood to praise the Lord, the God of Israel, with a very loud shout.

²⁰Early the next morning the army of Judah went out into the wilderness of Tekoa. On the way Jehoshaphat stopped and said, “Listen to me, all you people of Judah and Jerusalem! Believe in the Lord your God, and you will be able to stand firm. Believe in his prophets, and you will succeed.”

²¹After consulting the people, the king appointed singers to walk ahead of the army, singing to the Lord and praising him for his holy splendor. This is what they sang:

“Give thanks to the Lord;
his faithful love endures forever!”

²²At the very moment they began to sing and give praise, the Lord caused the armies of Ammon, Moab, and Mount Seir to start fighting among themselves. ²³The armies of Moab and Ammon turned against their allies from Mount Seir and killed every one of them. After they had destroyed the army of Seir, they began attacking each other. ²⁴So when the army of Judah arrived at the lookout point in the wilderness, all they saw were dead bodies lying on the ground as far as they could see. Not a single one of the enemy had escaped.

²⁵King Jehoshaphat and his men went out to gather the plunder. They found vast amounts of equipment, clothing, and other valuables—more than they could carry. There was so much plunder that it took them three days just to collect it all! ²⁶On the fourth day they gathered in the Valley of Blessing, which got its name that day because the people praised and thanked the Lord there. It is still called the Valley of Blessing today.

²⁷Then all the men returned to Jerusalem, with Jehoshaphat leading them, overjoyed that the Lord had given them victory over their enemies. ²⁸They marched into Jerusalem to the music of harps, lyres, and trumpets, and they proceeded to the Temple of the Lord.

²⁹When all the surrounding kingdoms heard that the Lord himself had fought against the enemies of Israel, the fear of God came over them. ³⁰So Jehoshaphat's kingdom was at peace, for his God had given him rest on every side.

Summary of Jehoshaphat's Reign

³¹So Jehoshaphat ruled over the land of Judah. He was thirty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem twenty-five years. His mother was Azubah, the daughter of Shilhi.

³²Jehoshaphat was a good king, following the ways of his father, Asa. He did what was pleasing in the Lord's sight. ³³During his reign, however, he failed to remove all the pagan shrines, and the people never fully committed themselves to follow the God of their ancestors.

³⁴The rest of the events of Jehoshaphat's reign, from beginning to end, are recorded in The Record of Jehu Son of Hanani, which is included in *The Book of the Kings of Israel*.

³⁵Some time later King Jehoshaphat of Judah made an alliance with King Ahaziah of Israel, who was very wicked. ³⁶Together they built a fleet of trading ships at the port of Ezion-geber. ³⁷Then Eliezer son of Dodavahu from Mareshah prophesied against Jehoshaphat. He said, "Because you have allied yourself with King Ahaziah, the Lord will destroy your work." So the ships met with disaster and never put out to sea.

21

Jehoram Rules in Judah



WHEN Jehoshaphat died, he was buried with his ancestors in the City of David. Then his son Jehoram became the next king.

²Jehoram's brothers—the other sons of Jehoshaphat—were Azariah, Jehiel, Zechariah, Azariahu, Michael, and Shephatiah; all these were the sons of Jehoshaphat king of Judah. ³Their father had given each of them valuable gifts of silver, gold, and costly items, and also some of Judah's fortified towns. However, he designated Jehoram as the next king because he was the oldest. ⁴But when Jehoram had become solidly established as king, he killed all his brothers and some of the other leaders of Judah.

⁵Jehoram was thirty-two years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem eight years. ⁶But Jehoram followed the example of the kings of Israel and was as wicked as King Ahab, for he had married one of Ahab's daughters. So Jehoram did what was evil in the Lord's sight. ⁷But the Lord did not want to destroy David's dynasty, for he had made a covenant with David and promised that his descendants would continue to rule, shining like a lamp forever.

⁸During Jehoram's reign, the Edomites revolted against Judah and crowned their own king. ⁹So Jehoram went out with his full army

and all his chariots. The Edomites surrounded him and his chariot commanders, but he went out at night and attacked them under cover of darkness. ¹⁰Even so, Edom has been independent from Judah to this day. The town of Libnah also revolted about that same time. All this happened because Jehoram had abandoned the Lord, the God of his ancestors. ¹¹He had built pagan shrines in the hill country of Judah and had led the people of Jerusalem and Judah to give themselves to pagan gods and to go astray.

¹²Then Elijah the prophet wrote Jehoram this letter:

“This is what the Lord, the God of your ancestor David, says: You have not followed the good example of your father, Jehoshaphat, or your grandfather King Asa of Judah. ¹³Instead, you have been as evil as the kings of Israel. You have led the people of Jerusalem and Judah to worship idols, just as King Ahab did in Israel. And you have even killed your own brothers, men who were better than you. ¹⁴So now the Lord is about to strike you, your people, your children, your wives, and all that is yours with a heavy blow. ¹⁵You yourself will suffer with a severe intestinal disease that will get worse each day until your bowels come out.”

¹⁶Then the Lord stirred up the Philistines and the Arabs, who lived near the Ethiopians, to attack Jehoram. ¹⁷They marched against Judah, broke down its defenses, and carried away everything of value in the royal palace, including the king’s sons and his wives. Only his youngest son, Ahaziah, was spared.

¹⁸After all this, the Lord struck Jehoram with an incurable intestinal disease. ¹⁹The disease grew worse and worse, and at the end of two years it caused his bowels to come out, and he died in agony. His people did not build a great funeral fire to honor him as they had done for his ancestors.

²⁰Jehoram was thirty-two years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem eight years. No one was sorry when he died. They buried him in the City of David, but not in the royal cemetery.

Ahaziah Rules in Judah

WHEN the people of Jerusalem made Ahaziah, Jehoram's youngest son, their next king, since the marauding bands who came with the Arabs had killed all the older sons. So Ahaziah son of Jehoram reigned as king of Judah.

²Ahaziah was twenty-two years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem one year. His mother was Athaliah, a granddaughter of King Omri. ³Ahaziah also followed the evil example of King Ahab's family, for his mother encouraged him in doing wrong. ⁴He did what was evil in the Lord's sight, just as Ahab's family had done. They even became his advisers after the death of his father, and they led him to ruin.

⁵Following their evil advice, Ahaziah joined Joram, the son of King Ahab of Israel, in his war against King Hazael of Aram at Ramoth-gilead. When the Arameans wounded Joram in the battle, ⁶he returned to Jezreel to recover from the wounds he had received at Ramoth. Because Joram was wounded, King Ahaziah of Judah went to Jezreel to visit him.

⁷But God had decided that this visit would be Ahaziah's downfall. While he was there, Ahaziah went out with Joram to meet Jehu grandson of Nimshi, whom the Lord had appointed to destroy the dynasty of Ahab.

⁸While Jehu was executing judgment against the family of Ahab, he happened to meet some of Judah's officials and Ahaziah's relatives who were traveling with Ahaziah. So Jehu killed them all. ⁹Then Jehu's men searched for Ahaziah, and they found him hiding in the city of Samaria. They brought him to Jehu, who killed him. Ahaziah was given a decent burial because the people said, "He was the grandson of Jehoshaphat—a man who sought the Lord with all his heart." But none of the surviving members of Ahaziah's family was capable of ruling the kingdom.

Queen Athaliah Rules in Judah

¹⁰When Athaliah, the mother of King Ahaziah of Judah, learned that her son was dead, she began to destroy the rest of Judah's royal family. ¹¹But Ahaziah's sister Jehosheba, the daughter of King Jehoram, took Ahaziah's infant son, Joash, and stole him away from among the rest of the king's children, who were about to be killed. She put Joash and his nurse in a bedroom. In this way, Jehosheba, wife of Jehoiada the priest and sister of Ahaziah, hid the child so that Athaliah could not murder him. ¹²Joash remained hidden in the Temple of God for six years while Athaliah ruled over the land.

23

Revolt against Athaliah

IN the seventh year of Athaliah's reign, Jehoiada the priest decided to act. He summoned his courage and made a pact with five army commanders: Azariah son of Jeroham, Ishmael son of Jehohanan, Azariah son of Obed, Maaseiah son of Adaiah, and Elishaphat son of Zicri. ²These men traveled secretly throughout Judah and summoned the Levites and clan leaders in all the towns to come to Jerusalem. ³They all gathered at the Temple of God, where they made a solemn pact with Joash, the young king.

Jehoiada said to them, "Here is the king's son! The time has come for him to reign! The Lord has promised that a descendant of David will be our king. ⁴This is what you must do. When you priests and Levites come on duty on the Sabbath, a third of you will serve as gatekeepers. ⁵Another third will go over to the royal palace, and the final third will be at the Foundation Gate. Everyone else should stay in the courtyards of the Lord's Temple. ⁶Remember, only the priests and Levites on duty may enter the Temple of the Lord, for they are set apart as holy. The rest of the people must obey the Lord's instructions and stay outside. ⁷You Levites, form a bodyguard around the king

and keep your weapons in hand. Kill anyone who tries to enter the Temple. Stay with the king wherever he goes.”

⁸So the Levites and all the people of Judah did everything as Jehoiada the priest ordered. The commanders took charge of the men reporting for duty that Sabbath, as well as those who were going off duty. Jehoiada the priest did not let anyone go home after their shift ended. ⁹Then Jehoiada supplied the commanders with the spears and the large and small shields that had once belonged to King David and were stored in the Temple of God. ¹⁰He stationed all the people around the king, with their weapons ready. They formed a line from the south side of the Temple around to the north side and all around the altar.

¹¹Then Jehoiada and his sons brought out Joash, the king’s son, placed the crown on his head, and presented him with a copy of God’s laws. They anointed him and proclaimed him king, and everyone shouted, “Long live the king!”

The Death of Athaliah

¹²When Athaliah heard the noise of the people running and the shouts of praise to the king, she hurried to the Lord’s Temple to see what was happening. ¹³When she arrived, she saw the newly crowned king standing in his place of authority by the pillar at the Temple entrance. The commanders and trumpeters were surrounding him, and people from all over the land were rejoicing and blowing trumpets. Singers with musical instruments were leading the people in a great celebration. When Athaliah saw all this, she tore her clothes in despair and shouted, “Treason! Treason!”

¹⁴Then Jehoiada the priest ordered the commanders who were in charge of the troops, “Take her to the soldiers in front of the Temple, and kill anyone who tries to rescue her.” For the priest had said, “She must not be killed in the Temple of the Lord.” ¹⁵So they seized her and led her out to the entrance of the Horse Gate on the palace grounds, and they killed her there.

Jehoiada's Religious Reforms

¹⁶Then Jehoiada made a covenant between himself and the king and the people that they would be the Lord's people. ¹⁷And all the people went over to the temple of Baal and tore it down. They demolished the altars and smashed the idols, and they killed Mattan the priest of Baal in front of the altars.

¹⁸Jehoiada now put the priests and Levites in charge of the Temple of the Lord, following all the directions given by David. He also commanded them to present burnt offerings to the Lord, as prescribed by the Law of Moses, and to sing and rejoice as David had instructed.

¹⁹He also stationed gatekeepers at the gates of the Lord's Temple to keep out those who for any reason were ceremonially unclean.

²⁰Then the commanders, nobles, rulers, and all the people of the land escorted the king from the Temple of the Lord. They went through the upper gate and into the palace, and they seated the king on the royal throne. ²¹So all the people of the land rejoiced, and the city was peaceful because Athaliah had been killed.

24

Joash Repairs the Temple

 JOASH was seven years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem forty years. His mother was Zibiah from Beersheba. ²Joash did what was pleasing in the Lord's sight throughout the lifetime of Jehoiada the priest. ³Jehoiada chose two wives for Joash, and he had sons and daughters.

⁴At one point Joash decided to repair and restore the Temple of the Lord. ⁵He summoned the priests and Levites and gave them these instructions: "Go to all the towns of Judah and collect the required annual offerings, so that we can repair the Temple of your God. Do not delay!" But the Levites did not act immediately.

⁶So the king called for Jehoiada the high priest and asked him, “Why haven’t you demanded that the Levites go out and collect the Temple taxes from the towns of Judah and from Jerusalem? Moses, the servant of the Lord, levied this tax on the community of Israel in order to maintain the Tabernacle of the Covenant.”

⁷Over the years the followers of wicked Athaliah had broken into the Temple of God, and they had used all the dedicated things from the Temple of the Lord to worship the images of Baal.

⁸So now the king ordered a chest to be made and set outside the gate leading to the Temple of the Lord. ⁹Then a proclamation was sent throughout Judah and Jerusalem, telling the people to bring to the Lord the tax that Moses, the servant of God, had required of the Israelites in the wilderness. ¹⁰This pleased all the leaders and the people, and they gladly brought their money and filled the chest with it.

¹¹Whenever the chest became full, the Levites would carry it to the king’s officials. Then the court secretary and an officer of the high priest would come and empty the chest and take it back to the Temple again. This went on day after day, and a large amount of money was collected. ¹²The king and Jehoiada gave the money to the construction supervisors, who hired masons and carpenters to restore the Temple of the Lord. They also hired metalworkers, who made articles of iron and bronze for the Lord’s Temple.

¹³The men in charge of the renovation worked hard and made steady progress. They restored the Temple of God according to its original design and strengthened it. ¹⁴When all the repairs were finished, they brought the remaining money to the king and Jehoiada. It was used to make various articles for the Temple of the Lord—articles for worship services and for burnt offerings, including ladles and other articles made of gold and silver. And the burnt offerings were sacrificed continually in the Temple of the Lord during the lifetime of Jehoiada the priest.

¹⁵Jehoiada lived to a very old age, finally dying at 130. ¹⁶He was buried among the kings in the City of David, because he had done so much good in Israel for God and his Temple.

Jehoiada's Reforms Reversed

¹⁷But after Jehoiada's death, the leaders of Judah came and bowed before King Joash and persuaded him to listen to their advice. ¹⁸They decided to abandon the Temple of the Lord, the God of their ancestors, and they worshiped Asherah poles and idols instead! Because of this sin, divine anger fell on Judah and Jerusalem. ¹⁹Yet the Lord sent prophets to bring them back to him. The prophets warned them, but still the people would not listen.

²⁰Then the Spirit of God came upon Zechariah son of Jehoiada the priest. He stood before the people and said, "This is what God says: **Why do you disobey the Lord's commands and keep yourselves from prospering? You have abandoned the Lord, and now he has abandoned you!**"

²¹Then the leaders plotted to kill Zechariah, and King Joash ordered that they stone him to death in the courtyard of the Lord's Temple. ²²That was how King Joash repaid Jehoiada for his loyalty—by killing his son. Zechariah's last words as he died were, "May the Lord see what they are doing and avenge my death!"

The End of Joash's Reign

²³In the spring of the year the Aramean army marched against Joash. They invaded Judah and Jerusalem and killed all the leaders of the nation. Then they sent all the plunder back to their king in Damascus. ²⁴Although the Arameans attacked with only a small army, the Lord helped them conquer the much larger army of Judah. The people of Judah had abandoned the Lord, the God of their ancestors, so judgment was carried out against Joash.

²⁵The Arameans withdrew, leaving Joash severely wounded. But his own officials plotted to kill him for murdering the son of Jehoiada the priest. They assassinated him as he lay in bed. Then he was buried in the City of David, but not in the royal cemetery. ²⁶The assassins were Jozacar, the son of an Ammonite woman named Shimeath, and Jehozabad, the son of a Moabite woman named Shomer.

²⁷The account of the sons of Joash, the prophecies about him, and the record of his restoration of the Temple of God are written in The Commentary on the Book of the Kings. His son Amaziah became the next king.

25

Amaziah Rules in Judah

MAZIAH was twenty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem twenty-nine years. His mother was Jehoaddin from Jerusalem. ²Amaziah did what was pleasing in the Lord's sight, but not wholeheartedly.

³When Amaziah was well established as king, he executed the officials who had assassinated his father. ⁴However, he did not kill the children of the assassins, for he obeyed the command of the Lord as written by Moses in the Book of the Law: “Parents must not be put to death for the sins of their children, nor children for the sins of their parents. Those deserving to die must be put to death for their own crimes.”

⁵Then Amaziah organized the army, assigning generals and captains for all Judah and Benjamin. He took a census and found that he had an army of 300,000 select troops, twenty years old and older, all trained in the use of spear and shield. ⁶He also paid about 7,500 pounds of silver to hire 100,000 experienced fighting men from Israel.

⁷But a man of God came to him and said, “Your Majesty, do not hire troops from Israel, for the Lord is not with Israel. He will not help those people of Ephraim! ⁸If you let them go with your troops

into battle, you will be defeated by the enemy no matter how well you fight. God will overthrow you, for he has the power to help you or to trip you up.”

⁹Amaziah asked the man of God, “But what about all that silver I paid to hire the army of Israel?”

The man of God replied, “The Lord is able to give you much more than this!” ¹⁰So Amaziah discharged the hired troops and sent them back to Ephraim. This made them very angry with Judah, and they returned home in a great rage.

¹¹Then Amaziah summoned his courage and led his army to the Valley of Salt, where they killed 10,000 Edomite troops from Seir. ¹²They captured another 10,000 and took them to the top of a cliff and threw them off, dashing them to pieces on the rocks below.

¹³Meanwhile, the hired troops that Amaziah had sent home raided several of the towns of Judah between Samaria and Beth-horon. They killed 3,000 people and carried off great quantities of plunder.

¹⁴When King Amaziah returned from slaughtering the Edomites, he brought with him idols taken from the people of Seir. He set them up as his own gods, bowed down in front of them, and offered sacrifices to them! ¹⁵This made the Lord very angry, and he sent a prophet to ask, “Why do you turn to gods who could not even save their own people from you?”

¹⁶But the king interrupted him and said, “Since when have I made you the king’s counselor? Be quiet now before I have you killed!”

So the prophet stopped with this warning: “I know that God has determined to destroy you because you have done this and have refused to accept my counsel.”

¹⁷After consulting with his advisers, King Amaziah of Judah sent this challenge to Israel’s king Jehoash, the son of Jehoahaz and grandson of Jehu: “Come and meet me in battle!”

¹⁸But King Jehoash of Israel replied to King Amaziah of Judah with this story: “Out in the Lebanon mountains, a thistle sent a message to a mighty cedar tree: ‘Give your daughter in marriage to my son.’

But just then a wild animal of Lebanon came by and stepped on the thistle, crushing it!

¹⁹“You are saying, ‘I have defeated Edom,’ and you are very proud of it. But my advice is to stay at home. Why stir up trouble that will only bring disaster on you and the people of Judah?”

²⁰But Amaziah refused to listen, for God was determined to destroy him for turning to the gods of Edom. ²¹So King Jehoash of Israel mobilized his army against King Amaziah of Judah. The two armies drew up their battle lines at Beth-shemesh in Judah. ²²Judah was routed by the army of Israel, and its army scattered and fled for home. ²³King Jehoash of Israel captured Judah’s king, Amaziah son of Joash and grandson of Ahaziah, at Beth-shemesh. Then he brought him to Jerusalem, where he demolished 600 feet of Jerusalem’s wall, from the Ephraim Gate to the Corner Gate. ²⁴He carried off all the gold and silver and all the articles from the Temple of God that had been in the care of Obed-edom. He also seized the treasures of the royal palace, along with hostages, and then returned to Samaria.

²⁵King Amaziah of Judah lived for fifteen years after the death of King Jehoash of Israel. ²⁶The rest of the events in Amaziah’s reign, from beginning to end, are recorded in The Book of *The Kings of Judah and Israel*.

²⁷After Amaziah turned away from the Lord, there was a conspiracy against his life in Jerusalem, and he fled to Lachish. But his enemies sent assassins after him, and they killed him there. ²⁸They brought his body back on a horse, and he was buried with his ancestors in the City of David.

26

Uzziah Rules in Judah



ALL the people of Judah had crowned Amaziah’s sixteen-year-old son, Uzziah, as king in place of his father. ²After his father’s death, Uzziah rebuilt the town of Elath and restored it to Judah.

³Uzziah was sixteen years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem fifty-two years. His mother was Jecoliah from Jerusalem. ⁴He did what was pleasing in the Lord's sight, just as his father, Amaziah, had done. ⁵Uzziah sought God during the days of Zechariah, who taught him to fear God. And as long as the king sought guidance from the Lord, God gave him success.

⁶Uzziah declared war on the Philistines and broke down the walls of Gath, Jabneh, and Ashdod. Then he built new towns in the Ashdod area and in other parts of Philistia. ⁷God helped him in his wars against the Philistines, his battles with the Arabs of Gur, and his wars with the Meunites. ⁸The Meunites paid annual tribute to him, and his fame spread even to Egypt, for he had become very powerful.

⁹Uzziah built fortified towers in Jerusalem at the Corner Gate, at the Valley Gate, and at the angle in the wall. ¹⁰He also constructed forts in the wilderness and dug many water cisterns, because he kept great herds of livestock in the foothills of Judah and on the plains. He was also a man who loved the soil. He had many workers who cared for his farms and vineyards, both on the hillsides and in the fertile valleys.

¹¹Uzziah had an army of well-trained warriors, ready to march into battle, unit by unit. This army had been mustered and organized by Jeiel, the secretary of the army, and his assistant, Maaseiah. They were under the direction of Hananiah, one of the king's officials. ¹²These regiments of mighty warriors were commanded by 2,600 clan leaders. ¹³The army consisted of 307,500 men, all elite troops. They were prepared to assist the king against any enemy.

¹⁴Uzziah provided the entire army with shields, spears, helmets, coats of mail, bows, and sling stones. ¹⁵And he built structures on the walls of Jerusalem, designed by experts to protect those who shot arrows and hurled large stones from the towers and the corners of the wall. His fame spread far and wide, for the Lord gave him marvelous help, and he became very powerful.

Uzziah's Sin and Punishment

¹⁶But when he had become powerful, he also became proud, which led to his downfall. He sinned against the Lord his God by entering the sanctuary of the Lord's Temple and personally burning incense on the incense altar. ¹⁷Azariah the high priest went in after him with eighty other priests of the Lord, all brave men. ¹⁸They confronted King Uzziah and said, "It is not for you, Uzziah, to burn incense to the Lord. That is the work of the priests alone, the descendants of Aaron who are set apart for this work. Get out of the sanctuary, for you have sinned. The Lord God will not honor you for this!"

¹⁹Uzziah, who was holding an incense burner, became furious. But as he was standing there raging at the priests before the incense altar in the Lord's Temple, leprosy suddenly broke out on his forehead. ²⁰When Azariah the high priest and all the other priests saw the leprosy, they rushed him out. And the king himself was eager to get out because the Lord had struck him. ²¹So King Uzziah had leprosy until the day he died. He lived in isolation in a separate house, for he was excluded from the Temple of the Lord. His son Jotham was put in charge of the royal palace, and he governed the people of the land.

²²The rest of the events of Uzziah's reign, from beginning to end, are recorded by the prophet Isaiah son of Amoz. ²³When Uzziah died, he was buried with his ancestors; his grave was in a nearby burial field belonging to the kings, for the people said, "He had leprosy." And his son Jotham became the next king.

27

Jotham Rules in Judah



OTHAM was twenty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem sixteen years. His mother was Jerusha, the daughter of Zadok.

²Jotham did what was pleasing in the Lord's sight. He did everything his father, Uzziah, had done, except that Jotham did not sin by entering the Temple of the Lord. But the people continued in their corrupt ways.

³Jotham rebuilt the upper gate of the Temple of the Lord. He also did extensive rebuilding on the wall at the hill of Ophel. ⁴He built towns in the hill country of Judah and constructed fortresses and towers in the wooded areas. ⁵Jotham went to war against the Ammonites and conquered them. Over the next three years he received from them an annual tribute of 7,500 pounds of silver, 50,000 bushels of wheat, and 50,000 bushels of barley.

⁶King Jotham became powerful because he was careful to live in obedience to the Lord his God.

⁷The rest of the events of Jotham's reign, including all his wars and other activities, are recorded in *The Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah*. ⁸He was twenty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem sixteen years. ⁹When Jotham died, he was buried in the City of David. And his son Ahaz became the next king.

28

Ahaz Rules in Judah



HAZ was twenty years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem sixteen years. He did not do what was pleasing in the sight of the Lord, as his ancestor David had done. ²Instead, he followed the example of the kings of Israel. He cast metal images for the worship of Baal. ³He offered sacrifices in the valley of Ben-Hinnom, even sacrificing his own sons in the fire. In this way, he followed the detestable practices of the pagan nations the Lord had driven from the land ahead of the Israelites. ⁴He offered sacrifices and burned incense at the pagan shrines and on the hills and under every green tree.

⁵Because of all this, the Lord his God allowed the king of Aram to defeat Ahaz and to exile large numbers of his people to Damascus. The armies of the king of Israel also defeated Ahaz and inflicted many casualties on his army. ⁶In a single day Pekah son of Remaliah, Israel's king, killed 120,000 of Judah's troops, all of them experienced warriors, because they had abandoned the Lord, the God of their ancestors. ⁷Then Zicri, a warrior from Ephraim, killed Maaseiah, the king's son; Azrikam, the king's palace commander; and Elkanah, the king's second-in-command. ⁸The armies of Israel captured 200,000 women and children from Judah and seized tremendous amounts of plunder, which they took back to Samaria.

⁹But a prophet of the Lord named Oded was there in Samaria when the army of Israel returned home. He went out to meet them and said, "The Lord, the God of your ancestors, was angry with Judah and let you defeat them. But you have gone too far, killing them without mercy, and all heaven is disturbed. ¹⁰And now you are planning to make slaves of these people from Judah and Jerusalem. What about your own sins against the Lord your God? ¹¹Listen to me and return these prisoners you have taken, for they are your own relatives. Watch out, because now the Lord's fierce anger has been turned against you!"

¹²Then some of the leaders of Israel—Azariah son of Jehohanan, Berekiah son of Meshillemoth, Jehizkiah son of Shallum, and Amasa son of Hadlai—agreed with this and confronted the men returning from battle. ¹³"You must not bring the prisoners here!" they declared. "We cannot afford to add to our sins and guilt. Our guilt is already great, and the Lord's fierce anger is already turned against Israel."

¹⁴So the warriors released the prisoners and handed over the plunder in the sight of the leaders and all the people. ¹⁵Then the four men just mentioned by name came forward and distributed clothes from the plunder to the prisoners who were naked. They provided clothing and sandals to wear, gave them enough food and drink, and dressed their wounds with olive oil. They put those who were weak on donkeys and took all the prisoners back to their own people in Jericho, the city of palms. Then they returned to Samaria.

Ahaz Closes the Temple

¹⁶At that time King Ahaz of Judah asked the king of Assyria for help. ¹⁷The armies of Edom had again invaded Judah and taken captives. ¹⁸And the Philistines had raided towns located in the foothills of Judah and in the Negev of Judah. They had already captured and occupied Beth-shemesh, Aijalon, Gederoth, Soco with its villages, Timnah with its villages, and Gimzo with its villages. ¹⁹The Lord was humbling Judah because of King Ahaz of Judah, for he had encouraged his people to sin and had been utterly unfaithful to the Lord.

²⁰So when King Tiglath-pileser of Assyria arrived, he attacked Ahaz instead of helping him. ²¹Ahaz took valuable items from the Lord's Temple, the royal palace, and from the homes of his officials and gave them to the king of Assyria as tribute. But this did not help him.

²²Even during this time of trouble, King Ahaz continued to reject the Lord. ²³He offered sacrifices to the gods of Damascus who had defeated him, for he said, "Since these gods helped the kings of Aram, they will help me, too, if I sacrifice to them." But instead, they led to his ruin and the ruin of all Judah.

²⁴The king took the various articles from the Temple of God and broke them into pieces. He shut the doors of the Lord's Temple so that no one could worship there, and he set up altars to pagan gods in every corner of Jerusalem. ²⁵He made pagan shrines in all the towns of Judah for offering sacrifices to other gods. In this way, he aroused the anger of the Lord, the God of his ancestors.

²⁶The rest of the events of Ahaz's reign and everything he did, from beginning to end, are recorded in The Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel. ²⁷When Ahaz died, he was buried in Jerusalem but not in the royal cemetery of the kings of Judah. Then his son Hezekiah became the next king.

Hezekiah Rules in Judah



EZEKIAH was twenty-five years old when he became the king of Judah, and he reigned in Jerusalem twenty-nine years. His mother was Abijah, the daughter of Zechariah. ²He did what was pleasing in the Lord's sight, just as his ancestor David had done.

Hezekiah Reopens the Temple

³In the very first month of the first year of his reign, Hezekiah reopened the doors of the Temple of the Lord and repaired them. ⁴He summoned the priests and Levites to meet him at the courtyard east of the Temple. ⁵He said to them, "Listen to me, you Levites! Purify yourselves, and purify the Temple of the Lord, the God of your ancestors. Remove all the defiled things from the sanctuary. ⁶Our ancestors were unfaithful and did what was evil in the sight of the Lord our God. They abandoned the Lord and his dwelling place; they turned their backs on him. ⁷They also shut the doors to the Temple's entry room, and they snuffed out the lamps. They stopped burning incense and presenting burnt offerings at the sanctuary of the God of Israel.

⁸"That is why the Lord's anger has fallen upon Judah and Jerusalem. He has made them an object of dread, horror, and ridicule, as you can see with your own eyes. ⁹Because of this, our fathers have been killed in battle, and our sons and daughters and wives have been captured. ¹⁰But now I will make a covenant with the Lord, the God of Israel, so that his fierce anger will turn away from us. ¹¹My sons, do not neglect your duties any longer! The Lord has chosen you to stand in his presence, to minister to him, and to lead the people in worship and present offerings to him."

¹²Then these Levites got right to work:

From the clan of Kohath: Mahath son of Amasai and Joel son of Azariah.

From the clan of Merari: Kish son of Abdi and Azariah son of Jehallelel.

From the clan of Gershon: Joah son of Zimmah and Eden son of Joah.

¹³From the family of Elizaphan: Shimri and Jeiel.

From the family of Asaph: Zechariah and Mattaniah.

¹⁴From the family of Heman: Jehiel and Shimei.

From the family of Jeduthun: Shemaiah and Uzziel.

¹⁵These men called together their fellow Levites, and they all purified themselves. Then they began to cleanse the Temple of the Lord, just as the king had commanded. They were careful to follow all the Lord's instructions in their work. ¹⁶The priests went into the sanctuary of the Temple of the Lord to cleanse it, and they took out to the Temple courtyard all the defiled things they found. From there the Levites carted it all out to the Kidron Valley.

¹⁷They began the work in early spring, on the first day of the new year, and in eight days they had reached the entry room of the Lord's Temple. Then they purified the Temple of the Lord itself, which took another eight days. So the entire task was completed in sixteen days.

The Temple Rededication

¹⁸Then the Levites went to King Hezekiah and gave him this report: "We have cleansed the entire Temple of the Lord, the altar of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table of the Bread of the Presence with all its utensils. ¹⁹We have also recovered all the items discarded by King Ahaz when he was unfaithful and closed the Temple. They are now in front of the altar of the Lord, purified and ready for use."

²⁰Early the next morning King Hezekiah gathered the city officials and went to the Temple of the Lord. ²¹They brought seven bulls, seven rams, and seven male lambs as a burnt offering, together with

seven male goats as a sin offering for the kingdom, for the Temple, and for Judah. The king commanded the priests, who were descendants of Aaron, to sacrifice the animals on the altar of the Lord.

²²So they killed the bulls, and the priests took the blood and sprinkled it on the altar. Next they killed the rams and sprinkled their blood on the altar. And finally, they did the same with the male lambs.

²³The male goats for the sin offering were then brought before the king and the assembly of people, who laid their hands on them. ²⁴The priests then killed the goats as a sin offering and sprinkled their blood on the altar to make atonement for the sins of all Israel. The king had specifically commanded that this burnt offering and sin offering should be made for all Israel.

²⁵King Hezekiah then stationed the Levites at the Temple of the Lord with cymbals, lyres, and harps. He obeyed all the commands that the Lord had given to King David through Gad, the king's seer, and the prophet Nathan. ²⁶The Levites then took their positions around the Temple with the instruments of David, and the priests took their positions with the trumpets.

²⁷Then Hezekiah ordered that the burnt offering be placed on the altar. As the burnt offering was presented, songs of praise to the Lord were begun, accompanied by the trumpets and other instruments of David, the former king of Israel. ²⁸The entire assembly worshiped the Lord as the singers sang and the trumpets blew, until all the burnt offerings were finished. ²⁹Then the king and everyone with him bowed down in worship. ³⁰King Hezekiah and the officials ordered the Levites to praise the Lord with the psalms written by David and by Asaph the seer. So they offered joyous praise and bowed down in worship.

³¹Then Hezekiah declared, "Now that you have consecrated yourselves to the Lord, bring your sacrifices and thanksgiving offerings to the Temple of the Lord." So the people brought their sacrifices and thanksgiving offerings, and all whose hearts were willing brought burnt offerings, too. ³²The people brought to the Lord 70 bulls, 100

rams, and 200 male lambs for burnt offerings. ³³They also brought 600 cattle and 3,000 sheep and goats as sacred offerings.

³⁴But there were too few priests to prepare all the burnt offerings. So their relatives the Levites helped them until the work was finished and more priests had been purified, for the Levites had been more conscientious about purifying themselves than the priests had been.

³⁵There was an abundance of burnt offerings, along with the usual liquid offerings, and a great deal of fat from the many peace offerings.

So the Temple of the Lord was restored to service. ³⁶And Hezekiah and all the people rejoiced because of what God had done for the people, for everything had been accomplished so quickly.

30

Preparations for Passover

KING Hezekiah now sent word to all Israel and Judah, and he wrote letters of invitation to the people of Ephraim and Manasseh. He asked everyone to come to the Temple of the Lord at Jerusalem to celebrate the Passover of the Lord, the God of Israel.

²The king, his officials, and all the community of Jerusalem decided to celebrate Passover a month later than usual. ³They were unable to celebrate it at the prescribed time because not enough priests could be purified by then, and the people had not yet assembled at Jerusalem.

⁴This plan for keeping the Passover seemed right to the king and all the people. ⁵So they sent a proclamation throughout all Israel, from Beersheba in the south to Dan in the north, inviting everyone to come to Jerusalem to celebrate the Passover of the Lord, the God of Israel. The people had not been celebrating it in great numbers as required in the Law.

⁶At the king's command, runners were sent throughout Israel and Judah. They carried letters that said:

“O people of Israel, return to the Lord, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, so that he will return to the few of us who

have survived the conquest of the Assyrian kings. ⁷Do not be like your ancestors and relatives who abandoned the Lord, the God of their ancestors, and became an object of derision, as you yourselves can see. ⁸Do not be stubborn, as they were, but submit yourselves to the Lord. Come to his Temple, which he has set apart as holy forever. Worship the Lord your God so that his fierce anger will turn away from you.

⁹“For if you return to the Lord, your relatives and your children will be treated mercifully by their captors, and they will be able to return to this land. For the Lord your God is gracious and merciful. If you return to him, he will not continue to turn his face from you.”

Celebration of Passover

¹⁰The runners went from town to town throughout Ephraim and Manasseh and as far as the territory of Zebulun. But most of the people just laughed at the runners and made fun of them. ¹¹However, some people from Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humbled themselves and went to Jerusalem.

¹²At the same time, God’s hand was on the people in the land of Judah, giving them all one heart to obey the orders of the king and his officials, who were following the word of the Lord. ¹³So a huge crowd assembled at Jerusalem in midspring to celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread. ¹⁴They set to work and removed the pagan altars from Jerusalem. They took away all the incense altars and threw them into the Kidron Valley.

¹⁵On the fourteenth day of the second month, one month later than usual, the people slaughtered the Passover lamb. This shamed the priests and Levites, so they purified themselves and brought burnt offerings to the Temple of the Lord. ¹⁶Then they took their places at the Temple as prescribed in the Law of Moses, the man of God. The Levites brought the sacrificial blood to the priests, who then sprinkled it on the altar.

¹⁷Since many of the people had not purified themselves, the Levites had to slaughter their Passover lamb for them, to set them apart for the Lord. ¹⁸Most of those who came from Ephraim, Manasseh, Issachar, and Zebulun had not purified themselves. But King Hezekiah prayed for them, and they were allowed to eat the Passover meal anyway, even though this was contrary to the requirements of the Law. For Hezekiah said, “May the Lord, who is good, pardon those ¹⁹who decide to follow the Lord, the God of their ancestors, even though they are not properly cleansed for the ceremony.” ²⁰And the Lord listened to Hezekiah’s prayer and healed the people.

²¹So the people of Israel who were present in Jerusalem joyously celebrated the Festival of Unleavened Bread for seven days. Each day the Levites and priests sang to the Lord, accompanied by loud instruments. ²²Hezekiah encouraged all the Levites regarding the skill they displayed as they served the Lord. The celebration continued for seven days. Peace offerings were sacrificed, and the people gave thanks to the Lord, the God of their ancestors.

²³The entire assembly then decided to continue the festival another seven days, so they celebrated joyfully for another week. ²⁴King Hezekiah gave the people 1,000 bulls and 7,000 sheep and goats for offerings, and the officials donated 1,000 bulls and 10,000 sheep and goats. Meanwhile, many more priests purified themselves.

²⁵The entire assembly of Judah rejoiced, including the priests, the Levites, all who came from the land of Israel, the foreigners who came to the festival, and all those who lived in Judah. ²⁶There was great joy in the city, for Jerusalem had not seen a celebration like this one since the days of Solomon, King David’s son. ²⁷Then the priests and Levites stood and blessed the people, and God heard their prayer from his holy dwelling in heaven.

31

Hezekiah’s Religious Reforms



WHEN the festival ended, the Israelites who attended went to all the towns of Judah, Benjamin, Ephraim, and Manasseh, and they smashed all the sacred pillars, cut down the Asherah poles, and removed the pagan shrines and altars. After this, the Israelites returned to their own towns and homes.

²Hezekiah then organized the priests and Levites into divisions to offer the burnt offerings and peace offerings, and to worship and give thanks and praise to the Lord at the gates of the Temple. ³The king also made a personal contribution of animals for the daily morning and evening burnt offerings, the weekly Sabbath festivals, the monthly new moon festivals, and the annual festivals as prescribed in the Law of the Lord. ⁴In addition, he required the people in Jerusalem to bring a portion of their goods to the priests and Levites, so they could devote themselves fully to the Law of the Lord.

⁵When the people of Israel heard these requirements, they responded generously by bringing the first share of their grain, new wine, olive oil, honey, and all the produce of their fields. They brought a large quantity—a tithe of all they produced. ⁶The people who had moved to Judah from Israel, and the people of Judah themselves, brought in the tithes of their cattle, sheep, and goats and a tithe of the things that had been dedicated to the Lord their God, and they piled them up in great heaps. ⁷They began piling them up in late spring, and the heaps continued to grow until early autumn. ⁸When Hezekiah and his officials came and saw these huge piles, they thanked the Lord and his people Israel!

⁹“Where did all this come from?” Hezekiah asked the priests and Levites.

¹⁰And Azariah the high priest, from the family of Zadok, replied, “Since the people began bringing their gifts to the Lord’s Temple, we have had enough to eat and plenty to spare. The Lord has blessed his people, and all this is left over.”

¹¹Hezekiah ordered that storerooms be prepared in the Temple of the Lord. When this was done, ¹²the people faithfully brought all the gifts, tithes, and other items dedicated for use in the Temple.

Conaniah the Levite was put in charge, assisted by his brother Shimei. ¹³The supervisors under them were Jehiel, Azaziah, Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth, Jozabad, Eliel, Ismakiah, Mahath, and Benaiah. These appointments were made by King Hezekiah and Azariah, the chief official in the Temple of God.

¹⁴Kore son of Imnah the Levite, who was the gatekeeper at the East Gate, was put in charge of distributing the voluntary offerings given to God, the gifts, and the things that had been dedicated to the Lord. ¹⁵His faithful assistants were Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah. They distributed the gifts among the families of priests in their towns by their divisions, dividing the gifts fairly among old and young alike. ¹⁶They distributed the gifts to all males three years old or older, regardless of their place in the genealogical records. The distribution went to all who would come to the Lord's Temple to perform their daily duties according to their divisions. ¹⁷They distributed gifts to the priests who were listed by their families in the genealogical records, and to the Levites twenty years old or older who were listed according to their jobs and their divisions. ¹⁸Food allotments were also given to the families of all those listed in the genealogical records, including their little babies, wives, sons, and daughters. For they had all been faithful in purifying themselves.

¹⁹As for the priests, the descendants of Aaron, who were living in the open villages around the towns, men were appointed by name to distribute portions to every male among the priests and to all the Levites listed in the genealogical records.

²⁰In this way, King Hezekiah handled the distribution throughout all Judah, doing what was pleasing and good in the sight of the Lord his God. ²¹In all that he did in the service of the Temple of God and in his efforts to follow God's laws and commands, Hezekiah sought his God wholeheartedly. As a result, he was very successful.

Assyria Invades Judah



AFTER Hezekiah had faithfully carried out this work, King Sennacherib of Assyria invaded Judah. He laid siege to the fortified towns, giving orders for his army to break through their walls. ²When Hezekiah realized that Sennacherib also intended to attack Jerusalem, ³he consulted with his officials and military advisers, and they decided to stop the flow of the springs outside the city. ⁴They organized a huge work crew to stop the flow of the springs, cutting off the brook that ran through the fields. For they said, “Why should the kings of Assyria come here and find plenty of water?”

⁵Then Hezekiah worked hard at repairing all the broken sections of the wall, erecting towers, and constructing a second wall outside the first. He also reinforced the supporting terraces in the City of David and manufactured large numbers of weapons and shields. ⁶He appointed military officers over the people and assembled them before him in the square at the city gate. Then Hezekiah encouraged them by saying: ⁷“Be strong and courageous! Don’t be afraid or discouraged because of the king of Assyria or his mighty army, for there is a power far greater on our side! ⁸He may have a great army, but they are merely men. We have the Lord our God to help us and to fight our battles for us!” Hezekiah’s words greatly encouraged the people.

Sennacherib Threatens Jerusalem

⁹While King Sennacherib of Assyria was still besieging the town of Lachish, he sent his officers to Jerusalem with this message for Hezekiah and all the people in the city:

¹⁰“This is what King Sennacherib of Assyria says: What are you trusting in that makes you think you can survive my siege of Jerusalem? ¹¹Hezekiah has said, ‘The Lord our God

will rescue us from the king of Assyria.’ Surely Hezekiah is misleading you, sentencing you to death by famine and thirst!

¹²Don’t you realize that Hezekiah is the very person who destroyed all the Lord’s shrines and altars? He commanded Judah and Jerusalem to worship only at the altar at the Temple and to offer sacrifices on it alone.

¹³“Surely you must realize what I and the other kings of Assyria before me have done to all the people of the earth! Were any of the gods of those nations able to rescue their people from my power? ¹⁴Which of their gods was able to rescue its people from the destructive power of my predecessors? What makes you think your God can rescue you from me? ¹⁵Don’t let Hezekiah deceive you! Don’t let him fool you like this! I say it again—no god of any nation or kingdom has ever yet been able to rescue his people from me or my ancestors. How much less will your God rescue you from my power!”

¹⁶And Sennacherib’s officers further mocked the Lord God and his servant Hezekiah, heaping insult upon insult. ¹⁷The king also sent letters scorning the Lord, the God of Israel. He wrote, “Just as the gods of all the other nations failed to rescue their people from my power, so the God of Hezekiah will also fail.” ¹⁸The Assyrian officials who brought the letters shouted this in Hebrew to the people gathered on the walls of the city, trying to terrify them so it would be easier to capture the city. ¹⁹These officers talked about the God of Jerusalem as though he were one of the pagan gods, made by human hands.

²⁰Then King Hezekiah and the prophet Isaiah son of Amoz cried out in prayer to God in heaven. ²¹And the Lord sent an angel who destroyed the Assyrian army with all its commanders and officers. So Sennacherib was forced to return home in disgrace to his own land. And when he entered the temple of his god, some of his own sons killed him there with a sword.

²²That is how the Lord rescued Hezekiah and the people of Jerusalem from King Sennacherib of Assyria and from all the others

who threatened them. So there was peace throughout the land. ²³From then on King Hezekiah became highly respected among all the surrounding nations, and many gifts for the Lord arrived at Jerusalem, with valuable presents for King Hezekiah, too.

Hezekiah's Sickness and Recovery

²⁴About that time Hezekiah became deathly ill. He prayed to the Lord, who healed him and gave him a miraculous sign. ²⁵But Hezekiah did not respond appropriately to the kindness shown him, and he became proud. So the Lord's anger came against him and against Judah and Jerusalem. ²⁶Then Hezekiah humbled himself and repented of his pride, as did the people of Jerusalem. So the Lord's anger did not fall on them during Hezekiah's lifetime.

²⁷Hezekiah was very wealthy and highly honored. He built special treasury buildings for his silver, gold, precious stones, and spices, and for his shields and other valuable items. ²⁸He also constructed many storehouses for his grain, new wine, and olive oil; and he made many stalls for his cattle and pens for his flocks of sheep and goats. ²⁹He built many towns and acquired vast flocks and herds, for God had given him great wealth. ³⁰He blocked up the upper spring of Gihon and brought the water down through a tunnel to the west side of the City of David. And so he succeeded in everything he did.

³¹However, when ambassadors arrived from Babylon to ask about the remarkable events that had taken place in the land, God withdrew from Hezekiah in order to test him and to see what was really in his heart.

Summary of Hezekiah's Reign

³²The rest of the events in Hezekiah's reign and his acts of devotion are recorded in The Vision of the Prophet Isaiah Son of Amoz, which is included in The Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel. ³³When Hezekiah died, he was buried in the upper area of the royal cemetery,

and all Judah and Jerusalem honored him at his death. And his son Manasseh became the next king.

33

Manasseh Rules in Judah



MANASSEH was twelve years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem fifty-five years. ²He did what was evil in the Lord's sight, following the detestable practices of the pagan nations that the Lord had driven from the land ahead of the Israelites. ³He rebuilt the pagan shrines his father, Hezekiah, had broken down. He constructed altars for the images of Baal and set up Asherah poles. He also bowed before all the powers of the heavens and worshiped them.

⁴He built pagan altars in the Temple of the Lord, the place where the Lord had said, "**My name will remain in Jerusalem forever.**" ⁵He built these altars for all the powers of the heavens in both courtyards of the Lord's Temple. ⁶Manasseh also sacrificed his own sons in the fire in the valley of Ben-Hinnom. He practiced sorcery, divination, and witchcraft, and he consulted with mediums and psychics. He did much that was evil in the Lord's sight, arousing his anger.

⁷Manasseh even took a carved idol he had made and set it up in God's Temple, the very place where God had told David and his son Solomon: "**My name will be honored forever in this Temple and in Jerusalem—the city I have chosen from among all the tribes of Israel.**" ⁸**If the Israelites will be careful to obey my commands—all the laws, decrees, and regulations given through Moses—I will not send them into exile from this land that I set aside for your ancestors.**" ⁹But Manasseh led the people of Judah and Jerusalem to do even more evil than the pagan nations that the Lord had destroyed when the people of Israel entered the land.

¹⁰The Lord spoke to Manasseh and his people, but they ignored all his warnings. ¹¹So the Lord sent the commanders of the Assyrian

armies, and they took Manasseh prisoner. They put a ring through his nose, bound him in bronze chains, and led him away to Babylon. ¹²But while in deep distress, Manasseh sought the Lord his God and sincerely humbled himself before the God of his ancestors. ¹³And when he prayed, the Lord listened to him and was moved by his request. So the Lord brought Manasseh back to Jerusalem and to his kingdom. Then Manasseh finally realized that the Lord alone is God!

¹⁴After this Manasseh rebuilt the outer wall of the City of David, from west of the Gihon Spring in the Kidron Valley to the Fish Gate, and continuing around the hill of Ophel. He built the wall very high. And he stationed his military officers in all of the fortified towns of Judah. ¹⁵Manasseh also removed the foreign gods and the idol from the Lord's Temple. He tore down all the altars he had built on the hill where the Temple stood and all the altars that were in Jerusalem, and he dumped them outside the city. ¹⁶Then he restored the altar of the Lord and sacrificed peace offerings and thanksgiving offerings on it. He also encouraged the people of Judah to worship the Lord, the God of Israel. ¹⁷However, the people still sacrificed at the pagan shrines, though only to the Lord their God.

¹⁸The rest of the events of Manasseh's reign, his prayer to God, and the words the seers spoke to him in the name of the Lord, the God of Israel, are recorded in The Book of the Kings of Israel. ¹⁹Manasseh's prayer, the account of the way God answered him, and an account of all his sins and unfaithfulness are recorded in The Record of the Seers. It includes a list of the locations where he built pagan shrines and set up Asherah poles and idols before he humbled himself and repented. ²⁰When Manasseh died, he was buried in his palace. Then his son Amon became the next king.

Amon Rules in Judah

²¹Amon was twenty-two years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem two years. ²²He did what was evil in the Lord's sight, just as his father, Manasseh, had done. He worshiped and

sacrificed to all the idols his father had made. ²³But unlike his father, he did not humble himself before the Lord. Instead, Amon sinned even more.

²⁴Then Amon's own officials conspired against him and assassinated him in his palace. ²⁵But the people of the land killed all those who had conspired against King Amon, and they made his son Josiah the next king.

34

Josiah Rules in Judah



OSIAH was eight years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem thirty-one years. ²He did what was pleasing in the Lord's sight and followed the example of his ancestor David. He did not turn away from doing what was right.

³During the eighth year of his reign, while he was still young, Josiah began to seek the God of his ancestor David. Then in the twelfth year he began to purify Judah and Jerusalem, destroying all the pagan shrines, the Asherah poles, and the carved idols and cast images. ⁴He ordered that the altars of Baal be demolished and that the incense altars which stood above them be broken down. He also made sure that the Asherah poles, the carved idols, and the cast images were smashed and scattered over the graves of those who had sacrificed to them. ⁵He burned the bones of the pagan priests on their own altars, and so he purified Judah and Jerusalem.

⁶He did the same thing in the towns of Manasseh, Ephraim, and Simeon, even as far as Naphtali, and in the regions all around them. ⁷He destroyed the pagan altars and the Asherah poles, and he crushed the idols into dust. He cut down all the incense altars throughout the land of Israel. Finally, he returned to Jerusalem.

⁸In the eighteenth year of his reign, after he had purified the land and the Temple, Josiah appointed Shaphan son of Azaliah, Maaseiah the governor of Jerusalem, and Joah son of Joahaz, the royal historian,

to repair the Temple of the Lord his God. ⁹They gave Hilkiah the high priest the money that had been collected by the Levites who served as gatekeepers at the Temple of God. The gifts were brought by people from Manasseh, Ephraim, and from all the remnant of Israel, as well as from all Judah, Benjamin, and the people of Jerusalem.

¹⁰He entrusted the money to the men assigned to supervise the restoration of the Lord's Temple. Then they paid the workers who did the repairs and renovation of the Temple. ¹¹They hired carpenters and builders, who purchased finished stone for the walls and timber for the rafters and beams. They restored what earlier kings of Judah had allowed to fall into ruin.

¹²The workers served faithfully under the leadership of Jahath and Obadiah, Levites of the Merarite clan, and Zechariah and Meshullam, Levites of the Kohathite clan. Other Levites, all of whom were skilled musicians, ¹³were put in charge of the laborers of the various trades. Still others assisted as secretaries, officials, and gatekeepers.

Hilkiah Discovers God's Law

¹⁴While they were bringing out the money collected at the Lord's Temple, Hilkiah the priest found the Book of the Law of the Lord that was written by Moses. ¹⁵Hilkiah said to Shaphan the court secretary, "I have found the Book of the Law in the Lord's Temple!" Then Hilkiah gave the scroll to Shaphan.

¹⁶Shaphan took the scroll to the king and reported, "Your officials are doing everything they were assigned to do. ¹⁷The money that was collected at the Temple of the Lord has been turned over to the supervisors and workmen." ¹⁸Shaphan also told the king, "Hilkiah the priest has given me a scroll." So Shaphan read it to the king.

¹⁹When the king heard what was written in the Law, he tore his clothes in despair. ²⁰Then he gave these orders to Hilkiah, Ahikam son of Shaphan, Acbor son of Micaiah, Shaphan the court secretary, and Asaiah the king's personal adviser: ²¹"Go to the Temple and speak to the Lord for me and for all the remnant of Israel and Judah.

Inquire about the words written in the scroll that has been found. For the Lord's great anger has been poured out on us because our ancestors have not obeyed the word of the Lord. We have not been doing everything this scroll says we must do."

²²So Hilkiah and the other men went to the New Quarter of Jerusalem to consult with the prophet Huldah. She was the wife of Shallum son of Tikvah, son of Harhas, the keeper of the Temple wardrobe.

²³She said to them, "The Lord, the God of Israel, has spoken! Go back and tell the man who sent you, ²⁴"This is what the Lord says: **I am going to bring disaster on this city and its people. All the curses written in the scroll that was read to the king of Judah will come true. ²⁵For my people have abandoned me and offered sacrifices to pagan gods, and I am very angry with them for everything they have done. My anger will be poured out on this place, and it will not be quenched.'**

²⁶"But go to the king of Judah who sent you to seek the Lord and tell him: 'This is what the Lord, the God of Israel, says concerning the message you have just heard: ²⁷**You were sorry and humbled yourself before God when you heard his words against this city and its people. You humbled yourself and tore your clothing in despair and wept before me in repentance. And I have indeed heard you, says the Lord. ²⁸So I will not send the promised disaster until after you have died and been buried in peace. You yourself will not see the disaster I am going to bring on this city and its people.'**"

So they took her message back to the king.

Josiah's Religious Reforms

²⁹Then the king summoned all the elders of Judah and Jerusalem. ³⁰And the king went up to the Temple of the Lord with all the people of Judah and Jerusalem, along with the priests and the Levites—all the people from the greatest to the least. There the king read to them the entire Book of the Covenant that had been found in the Lord's

Temple. ³¹The king took his place of authority beside the pillar and renewed the covenant in the Lord's presence. He pledged to obey the Lord by keeping all his commands, laws, and decrees with all his heart and soul. He promised to obey all the terms of the covenant that were written in the scroll. ³²And he required everyone in Jerusalem and the people of Benjamin to make a similar pledge. The people of Jerusalem did so, renewing their covenant with God, the God of their ancestors.

³³So Josiah removed all detestable idols from the entire land of Israel and required everyone to worship the Lord their God. And throughout the rest of his lifetime, they did not turn away from the Lord, the God of their ancestors.

35

Josiah Celebrates Passover

THEN Josiah announced that the Passover of the Lord would be celebrated in Jerusalem, and so the Passover lamb was slaughtered on the fourteenth day of the first month. ²Josiah also assigned the priests to their duties and encouraged them in their work at the Temple of the Lord. ³He issued this order to the Levites, who were to teach all Israel and who had been set apart to serve the Lord: "Put the holy Ark in the Temple that was built by Solomon son of David, the king of Israel. You no longer need to carry it back and forth on your shoulders. Now spend your time serving the Lord your God and his people Israel. ⁴Report for duty according to the family divisions of your ancestors, following the directions of King David of Israel and the directions of his son Solomon.

⁵"Then stand in the sanctuary at the place appointed for your family division and help the families assigned to you as they bring their offerings to the Temple. ⁶Slaughter the Passover lambs, purify yourselves, and prepare to help those who come. Follow all the directions that the Lord gave through Moses."

⁷Then Josiah provided 30,000 lambs and young goats for the people's Passover offerings, along with 3,000 cattle, all from the king's own flocks and herds. ⁸The king's officials also made willing contributions to the people, priests, and Levites. Hilkiah, Zechariah, and Jehiel, the administrators of God's Temple, gave the priests 2,600 lambs and young goats and 300 cattle as Passover offerings. ⁹The Levite leaders—Conaniah and his brothers Shemaiah and Nethanel, as well as Hashabiah, Jeiel, and Jozabad—gave 5,000 lambs and young goats and 500 cattle to the Levites for their Passover offerings.

¹⁰When everything was ready for the Passover celebration, the priests and the Levites took their places, organized by their divisions, as the king had commanded. ¹¹The Levites then slaughtered the Passover lambs and presented the blood to the priests, who sprinkled the blood on the altar while the Levites prepared the animals. ¹²They divided the burnt offerings among the people by their family groups, so they could offer them to the Lord as prescribed in the Book of Moses. They did the same with the cattle. ¹³Then they roasted the Passover lambs as prescribed; and they boiled the holy offerings in pots, kettles, and pans, and brought them out quickly so the people could eat them.

¹⁴Afterward the Levites prepared Passover offerings for themselves and for the priests—the descendants of Aaron—because the priests had been busy from morning till night offering the burnt offerings and the fat portions. The Levites took responsibility for all these preparations.

¹⁵The musicians, descendants of Asaph, were in their assigned places, following the commands that had been given by David, Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun, the king's seer. The gatekeepers guarded the gates and did not need to leave their posts of duty, for their Passover offerings were prepared for them by their fellow Levites.

¹⁶The entire ceremony for the Lord's Passover was completed that day. All the burnt offerings were sacrificed on the altar of the Lord, as King Josiah had commanded. ¹⁷All the Israelites present in Jerusalem celebrated Passover and the Festival of Unleavened Bread for seven

days. ¹⁸Never since the time of the prophet Samuel had there been such a Passover. None of the kings of Israel had ever kept a Passover as Josiah did, involving all the priests and Levites, all the people of Jerusalem, and people from all over Judah and Israel. ¹⁹This Passover was celebrated in the eighteenth year of Josiah's reign.

Josiah Dies in Battle

²⁰After Josiah had finished restoring the Temple, King Neco of Egypt led his army up from Egypt to do battle at Carchemish on the Euphrates River, and Josiah and his army marched out to fight him.

²¹But King Neco sent messengers to Josiah with this message:

“What do you want with me, king of Judah? I have no quarrel with you today! I am on my way to fight another nation, and God has told me to hurry! Do not interfere with God, who is with me, or he will destroy you.”

²²But Josiah refused to listen to Neco, to whom God had indeed spoken, and he would not turn back. Instead, he disguised himself and led his army into battle on the plain of Megiddo. ²³But the enemy archers hit King Josiah with their arrows and wounded him. He cried out to his men, “Take me from the battle, for I am badly wounded!”

²⁴So they lifted Josiah out of his chariot and placed him in another chariot. Then they brought him back to Jerusalem, where he died. He was buried there in the royal cemetery. And all Judah and Jerusalem mourned for him. ²⁵The prophet Jeremiah composed funeral songs for Josiah, and to this day choirs still sing these sad songs about his death. These songs of sorrow have become a tradition and are recorded in *The Book of Laments*.

²⁶The rest of the events of Josiah's reign and his acts of devotion (carried out according to what was written in the Law of the Lord), ²⁷from beginning to end—all are recorded in *The Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah*.

36

Jehoahaz Rules in Judah

THEN the people of the land took Josiah's son Jehoahaz and made him the next king in Jerusalem.

²Jehoahaz was twenty-three years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem three months.

³Then he was deposed by the king of Egypt, who demanded that Judah pay 7,500 pounds of silver and 75 pounds of gold as tribute.

Jehoiakim Rules in Judah

⁴The king of Egypt then installed Eliakim, the brother of Jehoahaz, as the next king of Judah and Jerusalem, and he changed Eliakim's name to Jehoiakim. Then Neco took Jehoahaz to Egypt as a prisoner.

⁵Jehoiakim was twenty-five years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem eleven years. He did what was evil in the sight of the Lord his God.

⁶Then King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon came to Jerusalem and captured it, and he bound Jehoiakim in bronze chains and led him away to Babylon. ⁷Nebuchadnezzar also took some of the treasures from the Temple of the Lord, and he placed them in his palace in Babylon.

⁸The rest of the events in Jehoiakim's reign, including all the evil things he did and everything found against him, are recorded in The Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah. Then his son Jehoiachin became the next king.

Jehoiachin Rules in Judah

⁹Jehoiachin was eighteen years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem three months and ten days. Jehoiachin did what was evil in the Lord's sight.

¹⁰In the spring of the year King Nebuchadnezzar took Jehoiachin to Babylon. Many treasures from the Temple of the Lord were also taken to Babylon at that time. And Nebuchadnezzar installed Jehoiachin's uncle, Zedekiah, as the next king in Judah and Jerusalem.

Zedekiah Rules in Judah

¹¹Zedekiah was twenty-one years old when he became king, and he reigned in Jerusalem eleven years. ¹²But Zedekiah did what was evil in the sight of the Lord his God, and he refused to humble himself when the prophet Jeremiah spoke to him directly from the Lord. ¹³He also rebelled against King Nebuchadnezzar, even though he had taken an oath of loyalty in God's name. Zedekiah was a hard and stubborn man, refusing to turn to the Lord, the God of Israel.

¹⁴Likewise, all the leaders of the priests and the people became more and more unfaithful. They followed all the pagan practices of the surrounding nations, desecrating the Temple of the Lord that had been consecrated in Jerusalem.

¹⁵The Lord, the God of their ancestors, repeatedly sent his prophets to warn them, for he had compassion on his people and his Temple. ¹⁶But the people mocked these messengers of God and despised their words. They scoffed at the prophets until the Lord's anger could no longer be restrained and nothing could be done.

The Fall of Jerusalem

¹⁷So the Lord brought the king of Babylon against them. The Babylonians killed Judah's young men, even chasing after them into the Temple. They had no pity on the people, killing both young men and young women, the old and the infirm. God handed all of them over to Nebuchadnezzar. ¹⁸The king took home to Babylon all the articles, large and small, used in the Temple of God, and the treasures from both the Lord's Temple and from the palace of the king and his officials. ¹⁹Then his army burned the Temple of God, tore down the

walls of Jerusalem, burned all the palaces, and completely destroyed everything of value. ²⁰The few who survived were taken as exiles to Babylon, and they became servants to the king and his sons until the kingdom of Persia came to power.

²¹So the message of the Lord spoken through Jeremiah was fulfilled. The land finally enjoyed its Sabbath rest, lying desolate until the seventy years were fulfilled, just as the prophet had said.

Cyrus Allows the Exiles to Return

²²In the first year of King Cyrus of Persia, the Lord fulfilled the prophecy he had given through Jeremiah. He stirred the heart of Cyrus to put this proclamation in writing and to send it throughout his kingdom:

²³“This is what King Cyrus of Persia says:

“The Lord, the God of heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth. He has appointed me to build him a Temple at Jerusalem, which is in Judah. Any of you who are his people may go there for this task. And may the Lord your God be with you!”